- This morning, we begin our journey through yet another book of the Bible, and, if you have been here very long, you know the beginning of any new book, letter, or epistle is my favorite part. Mainly because I love history but also because without the introduction or background of the letter or book, you have no context.
    - And without context - you can't properly apply the scriptures.
- Context is key, and without it you run an extremely high risk of losing the meaning and substance of what God is conveying. Another way to say it is, without context you lose the maximization of the life-changing and mind-transforming power that lay within the pages of God's Holy Manuscript.
    - Remember, Context - Context – Context. Without it, you may end up wandering down a path that leads you to an unhealthy view of who God is, and how He operates. And certainly, this is the case for many of the modern-day 21st century churches and pastors.
- Now having said that, there may be no other book of the New Testament that more clearly articulates what I am trying to say about context than 2 Corinthians.
    - And why? Well because 2 Corinthians is difficult to read and study, especially if you don't have the contextual background to the letter.
    - The famed British Biblical Scholar C.K. Barnett said that 2 Corinthians "was surely the most difficult book in the New Testament" – he meant it was the most difficult to interpret.
        - Which means if you simply picked it up and read it, without studying its background and history, you would most likely end up frustrated and confused, which would then lead you to put it down and possibly never look at it again. And obviously, that's not what we want.
        - And so, for that reason, it's important we understand the background to any Book or letter we read in scripture. So, that is where we will begin this morning – with a background introduction.
- By now you should know, Paul wrote both 1st and 2nd Corinthians. But he didn't write them consecutively. He wrote 1 Corinthians first - but then wrote 2 Corinthians somewhere between his writings of 1 Corinthians and Romans, which is significant for reasons we will discuss later.
    - Unlike 1 Corinthians and Romans though, 2 Corinthians is very different. Whereas 1 Corinthians and Romans are in their own way systematic and orderly, 2 Corinthians (at least on the surface) is not.
    - Matter a fact, it will prove to be uneven and digressive, which has led some scholars to suggest that 2 Corinthians was really a just a collection of letters put together later as a single letter.
    - This morning, as we journey through the introduction of this letter, we are going to discover the why, as in "Why was Paul's 2 letter to the Corinthians a more difficult read than any of his other letters?"
- But before we delve too deep into that topic, let me start by saying the pages of this letter contain a story about people, church people or Christians to be exact. And what we are going to discover about these people is that they are no different than the Church People or Christians of today, at least as it relates to their behavior.

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- Christians today honestly act no differently than they did in Paul's day, and we will see that all too clear in our studies. This fact clues us in on something. It clues in on a simple, but guaranteed truth about people.
- And that is, people are people, and it makes no difference what year, century, or decade they lived in. At our core all humans, (even those we consider the best of humans) are selfish, self-centered, self -loving, and self-serving.
- And Paul, as well as many other writers of the scriptures, highlight this very fact over and over again, it's just a truth of humanity. And it's the one thing you can count on with people.
- Paul explains it this way in Romans 3:9-10, when he says:

Romans 3:9 What then? Are we better *than they?* Not at all; for we have already charged that both Jews and Greeks are all under sin;
Romans 3:10 as it is written: "THERE IS NO RIGHTEOUS PERSON, NOT EVEN ONE;

- Isaiah describes us another way in Isaiah 64:6:

Isaiah 64:6 For all of us have become like one who is unclean, and all our righteous deeds are like a filthy garment; And all of us wither like a leaf.

- Now, you may be sitting here this morning and saying to yourself yea, yea, yea – I get it – we all know this. Get on with it preacher. And if that is the case you need to hold up a minute, because understanding who we truly are (our standing if you will) "In the sight of a Holy and Righteous God" is extremely important.
  - Because if you don't truly understand your position before God, you can never move forward in your Spiritual Growth and Maturity. You see, if you strip sin down to its lowest common denominator, you will discover that whatever problem or struggle you may have, whatever burden you have been called to bear; All sins find at their root - at their core - an issue the Bible calls pride - which by the way is the opposite of humility.
  - The only way a Christian can overcome sin is by increasing humility. That is the panacea for sin – humility. And so, if that's the case then the question is, 'How do I obtain or gain more humility?'
    - You obtain it when you understand who you are in the sight of a Holy and Righteous God. That you are a slave of God - a bond servant. You obtain it when you realize that you are as sorry as the next person - (no matter who they may be).
    - But here's the deal. You cannot intellectually arrive at this conclusion on your own. It is simply not humanly possible. It requires divine revelation which can only be obtained by God, through His Holy Word.
- When God's word begins to take hold of your life it's then, and only then, that your Christian life begins to take shape – and it's then, and only then, you become a powerful tool or instrument that God uses for His Glory.

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- God’s process of bringing you into a place of humility can only take place when you understand your position before God, and that only happens when you hear directly from Him. That’s when you begin to grow Spiritually.
- After Salvation comes Spiritual Growth. That’s what we want, because without it, it’s impossible for believers to become pleasing vessels before God. And, if we don’t please God, we will never feel content or at peace, which is an obvious precursor to your happiness. Yes, you may be saved, but if you never mature you will never truly be fulfilled in your Christian Life. That’s what’s at stake here:
  - Humility - Brokenness - Submissiveness - Obedience
  - These are the key essential ingredients to your Spiritual Growth.
- But once again, how does that process work? It’s all in God’s word. You pray, you study God’s words daily, you sit under a pastor who teaches God’s word, and it begins to transform your life. And then, once that happens, God puts you in the game, uses you in His work inside His creation.

- Now, what does all this have to do with today’s teaching? Well, Paul’s 2nd letter to the Corinthians is going give us a picture of what happens when Christian people inside God's church aren’t humble, and they don’t mature. And, as you will soon see, it’s somewhat disturbing.
  - Now, before we get into the letter itself, I want to do a little deep dive into the history behind this church, its founder and its location.
- First let’s talk about the church itself. This church was established by Paul, in or around AD 50, towards the end of his second missionary journey. Once he established it, Paul then moved on to Ephesus - which was a city on the west coast of Turkey, some 180 miles away by sea.
- Remember, Paul was an Apostle, appointed by Jesus Christ, and He was by all accounts the greatest writer of the New Testament. He was also one of the, if not the, greatest evangelist to ever live, which tells us why he wrote much of the NT.
  - If you think about it, it only makes sense that the man who directly or indirectly established many of the churches in that area and during that time, that he would also be the greatest writer of the NT.
  - And so, as the founder, or inspirer of those churches, Paul felt responsible for them. And, the leaders of those churches, guys like Timothy, looked to him for leadership, guidance and direction, which, once again, tells us why Paul ended up writing much of the NT. Because he was always dealing with church people, primarily their behavior and the issues their behavior caused.
    - Don’t forget, Paul lived in the very beginning of the establishment of the church. This was a time when the church was new, and fresh, which led people to begin developing opinions. Opinions on how the church should operate, as well as opinions on what was right for the church and what was wrong for the church. They also developed theories on what should and should not be allowed inside the body of Christ.
    - Their mistakes are what helped established the NT writings, because they had no NT to guide them. Most of Paul’s letters were letters written to encourage, exhort, admonish, and correct the churches’ behavior. From those letters, we

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too get our instructions, so keep that in mind the next time you read your NT Bible.

- That's just a little background on the letter 2 Corinthians. But what about the location? Paul established this church in Corinth, hence the name Corinthians. It has been said that the church at Corinth – of all the churches Paul established – might best resemble the church of today. Its population is believed to be roughly 100-600 thousand people, although the exact population isn't known.
    - That area has been compared to many of our modern-day cities. One writer described it as a cross between New York, Los Angeles, and Las Vegas. So, that kind of gives you an idea of what type of area we are dealing with here.
    - This church sat on what is known as the Isthmus of Corinth. which was just a narrow strip of land that connected Northern Greece and the Southern Peloponnesus. Corinth was considered a crossroad of the ancient world. It was a land bridge with two coastal ports. The city port connected the Mediterranean Sea in the west with the Aegean Sea in the east.
        - It was known for its commerce, specifically its sailors, and with the sailors came lots of Pagan worship, which, of course led to it becoming a very sinful place. Matter of fact, it became a center for Pagan worship and established The Pagan Temple of "Aphrodite". The temple itself was guarded by prostitutes. Not sure how that worked, but that's the way it was. Now this obviously meant that men loved to visit this temple.
    - Paul showed up in Corinth around AD 50, which was approximately 20 years after Christ's death. Upon his arrival he went to the Jews first. He went to the Jewish synagogues to start a church.
        - But, as usual he was rejected, so he went next door to the synagogue and started his own church.
- After establishing the church, he leaves and heads to Ephesus, where he continues with the work of the ministry. Later in 54 AD he hears some disturbing news about this church. He hears there are divisions and strife breaking out. Shocker I know, which takes us back to the beginning of today's message:
    - People - People - People
        - The problems always begin with the people. Now, having said all this, we could give these people a little break, because after all, the Corinthian church had no NT to guide it. Only the Old Testament.
        - So, with no guidance, they do what most people do. They invent their own guidance. Right, isn't that how it works?
- It reminds me of a recent discussion I had with a good friend – it was a discussion about Baptism. He told me that his church teaches that you must be Baptized in Jesus name. That if you were Baptized in Titles – the Father, Son and Holy Ghost – then your baptism was of no effect.
    - Our discussion went on for quite some time, and at the end of it we ended up right back where we started, which was essentially nowhere. You see, his misunderstanding of Jesus' Name Baptism came from a misunderstanding of Salvation. Specifically, how Salvation works.

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- If you understand how Salvation works (Soteriology), then you will never be confused on the topic of being baptized in the name of Jesus versus the Name of the Father, Son & Holy Ghost. This is why understanding the “Whole Council of God” Is Foundational and Key.
- If you lack the foundation, then you are totally susceptible to false doctrines and false teachings. Which happens to be one of the biggest problems Paul faces in the Church in Corinth. And for that matter, it ends up being one of the key issues he deals with in just about every church he established or had influence in establishing. It also continues to plague the church today, which is why our government has over 4000 registered denominations on the books.

- As I said, Paul is an Apostle, a true Apostle. And as with any true Apostle, they are always appointed directly by God. They were also given supernatural powers by God, which means if someone tells you they are an apostle today (as some claim to be), then tell them you want to see their Apostolic powers.
  - Paul writes 1 Corinthians as a letter of correction to this church, but unfortunately it doesn’t seem to completely solve the issue, which then leads to him making a trip back to the Church. He does so to straighten out the mess. This trip takes place somewhere around 58 AD.
    - It’s worthy to note that Paul wrote Romans during his second visit to Corinth. Romans, unlike Paul’s other letters, was a letter built around theology and doctrine, and it was probably inspired by seeing the mess going on in Corinth.
    - It certainly was a mess, and the first step in correcting it was writing a letter, and that letter is where we get 1 Corinthians. This letter was well thought out and had at its core a purpose. It was designed to teach these church members how to live a Godly Church life.
  - 1 Corinthians has been called the NT principal letter for Pastoral application of theology in everyday life. It demonstrates how important theology is to the proper conduct of Christian life, particularly in the life of the gathering. Whereas Romans was written to preeminently define Christian theology. So, there is a little background on the place where the church in Corinth resided, and a little background on 1 Corinthians.
- But what about 2 Corinthians? Well, that’s a different story. 2 Corinthians is different than 1 Corinthians in many ways. First, as I stated earlier, there is very little organization in this letter. Very little system if you will, which has caused some scholars to believe that it is actually a collection (or blend) of some things of several of Paul’s letters to Corinth. This will become clear as we delve into a review of some history there.
  - Second Corinthians is not the second letter written by Paul to the Corinthians. First Corinthians is not the first letter written by Paul to the Corinthians. They just happen to be the two letters that made it into the cannon of scripture – as intended by God.
  - Some time after Paul left Corinth, he wrote a letter to the Corinthian church, a letter which apparently perished but is mentioned in 1 Cor. 5:9. There are some scholars who believe portions of that letter appear in 2 Corinthians, and we will take this up when we get to 2 Cor. 6. Namely the last of 2 Cor. 6 through the first part of 2 Cor. 7. It’s viewed as some part of that initial letter Paul wrote.

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- That letter had been misunderstood, which gave rise to some remarks in 1 Cor. 5, you may recall, Paul mentions it there, to clear up some misconceptions. Now bear in mind, don't let me confuse you with chapter references. Chapter references were not added to the Bible until the 13th Century, and the verses were not added until the 16th Century.

- Now, the occasions of 1 Corinthians, you may recall, the household of [Chloe], brought Paul news of all kinds of cliques and problems in the church, which gave rise to the 1 Corinthians letter. It was a response to that visit that Paul writes what we know as 1 Corinthians, which is clearly the 2nd letter.
  - But then Paul receives word again that things had gone from bad to worse.
  - Paul felt it was necessary to leave his work at Ephesus and pay a hurried visit to Corinth, to set things right. Scholars call this visit the painful visit. When Paul writes about this visit he references coming again in sorrow, indicating that his first visit had been unpleasant, and it failed to clear up the situation and Paul left very disturbed.
    - How do we know this? We look elsewhere in the Bible. This second visit is implied in some of the passages in 2 Corinthians, because we will find there, he is making illusions to a 3rd visit he is planning to undertake, because his 2nd visit is past (It doesn't come up in Chapters 12 & 13 of 2 Cor.)
  - Multiple visits just goes to show how hard it is for people to "get it". It was hard for Paul. It was hard for Jesus. After Jesus fed people and healed people, they were always after just one more thing. And that tells us we have to lean on His understanding, and trust in God.
- So Paul makes his initial visit, writes a letter but that first one is lost. After receiving word a second letter is written – what we call 1 Corinthians. That letter doesn't establish what Paul is trying to accomplish so prompts the second visit. That second visit (the painful visit) prompts Paul to write a third letter which scholars called the severe letter. It was very severe in tone, and it cost him a lot to write it - (because it's alluded to in 2 Cor. 2) Had it not been successful, it is conceivable there might have been a final rupture between Paul and the church he founded.
  - This letter seems to be lost but many scholars believe it is Chapters 10-13 of 2 Corinthians. That's why I am mentioning it because these fragments are viewed as being assembled in what we have come to know as 2 Corinthians.
    - Now this severe letter that I referred to is taken by Titus, who is to return by a Macedonian Troas. Paul is so anxious about its possible effect because it's such a drastic letter, and he was impatient to talk to Titus, so he traveled north from Ephesus to Macedonian. Titus met him, and to Paul's relief and joy the Corinthians punished the ringleader of the opposition that's involved and repented of their sins.
- So, Paul was joyed over Titus's report, and he wrote a 4th letter, and that's the letter we know as 2 Corinthians. If you tell your friends we are studying 4 Corinthians this morning, they might think you have gone bonkers.
  - All this is to show why it's important to capture the background and context before diving into a book. With that introduction, let's read the opening.

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2 Cor. 1:1 **Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God, and Timothy *our* brother,**
To the church of God which is at Corinth with all the saints who are throughout Achaia:

- Paul opens with his typical salutation, in Pauline style. He lets his audience know he is "an Apostle of Jesus Christ by the will of God". Here Paul is establishing his credibility. He is an apostle directly appointed by God. All done by the will of God. Paul's appointment, our appointment, is by the will of God. Just like we are all saved by God's sovereign decree.
    - When we understand this, we understand that God chose us. We may have answered the call, but we didn't make the phone ring. The modern church, subconsciously has this backwards. And when we think we did something to obtain salvation, then it becomes about you. It's never about you.
        - John 3:16 says God so loved the world (Greek = cosmos), His creation. We are just a part of it. Our position before God is to serve Him, in the capacity He has called us. He saved us with a purpose – so what are we doing with that purpose?

Romans 8:28 **And we know that God causes all things to work together for good to those who love God, to those who are called according to *His* purpose.**

- Going back to the second half of the first verse, Achaia was the name of the district of which Corinth was the Chief Church. But it's interesting, as you notice the style, it also highlights something we all tend to forget. These letters, while very directed, were also generally used as encyclicals. That is they were hand copied and passed around to the churches - a very treasured thing.
    - As this takes place over and over again, those letters end with up "errors" or "variants". You may find atheists like to take this idea and run with it. But the majority of those errors are simply grammatical – commas, colons etc. The overall variance do not change God's word – Jesus and His crucifixion does not change, salvation and how we're saved never changes, the death, burial and resurrection never changes.
- So let's close with Paul's words in verse 2:

2 Cor. 1:2 **Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.**

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- This morning, we are going to pick up with our journey through the second book (or 2nd letter) to the Corinthian Church. Having said that, we won't be in 2 Corinthians today - but does that surprise you?
- As I began preparing this past week, God led me to another book of the Bible, which gives us more introductory into the church at Corinth. Now, I know you may be thinking, my goodness more introduction, didn't we do that when we started the book a couple weeks ago?
    - Yes, we did. But this introduction is a little different, for a different reason, and it too is important, because it gives us further insight into the context of the letter. And, as you know by now, context is the key when reading any ancient writing of antiquity. But it's especially important if you truly want to understand who God is and how He operates.
- Now, if you missed the first teaching, which was all introduction, I highly recommend you go to our website and listen to it. I promise it will serve you well as we take this journey through what is Paul's second published letter to the Corinthians.
    - There's a bit of irony to 2 Corinthians and it shows up in the name itself - Second Corinthians. Because as we discovered in the introductory teaching, the letter isn't actually the second letter Paul wrote to the Corinthians. It's not even the third. Matter of fact, most Biblical Historians agree it is probably Paul's fourth letter, and maybe even the fifth letter.
        - But it's called 2 Corinthians because it's the second letter that Paul wrote to the Corinthians that God allowed to be placed inside the cannon of scripture. Which means we don't need to worry about which letter it is, because if God wanted the other letters to be included in the cannon of scripture, then we can rest assured they would be there.
- As I said, I want to give you just a little more insight into Paul's inaugural journey into this town known as Corinth. What we've discovered so far is that starting a church in this town was very difficult, especially in the beginning, where even the Apostle Paul found himself down, depressed, and disheartened at times as he desperately tried to get this church up and running.
    - You see, establishing a church period is tough, but establishing one in this town was extremely tough, because Corinth was unlike any other town Paul had visited. It was a seaport town with lots of sailors. And, as a result, Corinth had widely been considered the sin city of its day. It was a rough place.
        - And so, for that reason alone, it made it extremely difficult for Paul to get anything going.
- Before moving forward this morning I want to give you just a little more background; a little more insight into what Paul was dealing with when he first arrived in Corinth. Specifically, I want us to see how it is that a man of Paul's calling could experience what he experienced.
    - Not only with the people he encountered in that town (which was expected), but more importantly, how he had to deal with the hand God dealt him. And, for us to do that, we will need to travel into another book of the Bible. A book that Paul didn't write - the Book of Acts - which was written by Luke the Physician.
    - The background to Lukes's writing goes like this; Paul has just finished his work in

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Athens, Greece, and now it's time for him to move on to the next town. That town is the town of Corinth.

- Let's review what Luke said in Acts 18:1-5

Acts 18:1 After these things he left Athens and went to Corinth.
Acts 18:2 And he found a Jew named Aquila, a native of Pontus, having recently come from Italy with his wife Priscilla, because Claudius had commanded all the Jews to leave Rome. He came to them,
Acts 18:3 and because he was of the same trade, he stayed with them and they were working, for by trade they were tent makers.
Acts 18:4 And he was reasoning in the synagogue every Sabbath and trying to persuade Jews and Greeks.
Acts 18:5 But when Silas and Timothy came down from Macedonia, Paul began devoting himself completely to the word, solemnly testifying to the Jews that Jesus was the Christ.

So, as I said, the scene is this: Paul arrives in Corinth (Which by the way will be the last European city to ever grace Paul's presence). Paul arrives in Corinth, and he runs into a married couple by the name of Aquilla and Priscilla. Apparently, these two had been pushed out of Rome because of a dispute that arose between the non-believing Jews and the believing Jews in the city.

And so, Claudius the Emperor of Rome decided to settle the dispute by forcing all Jews - both believing and non-believing - out of the city. This is how Aquila and Priscilla ended up in Corinth. While they were there they met up with Paul.

Verse 3 says that Paul was in the same trade as Aquila and Priscilla. What was their trade? They were in the tent-making business, which means they were also in the same guild (which was much like the union of today). And we know this to be the case from Roman historical records.

Because this is how it worked in the Roman Empire. If you wanted to work, you had to be part of a guild. And so, with Aquila and Priscilla being Jewish (as was Paul) and with them being tent makers (as was Paul), Paul decides to stay with them, which makes sense - right?

Now, what's interesting is the scripture says in v4 that Paul had been reasoning with Jews and the Greeks in synagogues every sabbath, trying to persuade them. But the question is, what was he reasoning and persuading them about?

That Jesus was the fulfilment of the Old Testament scriptures. That He was the Messiah, the one they had been waiting for, and that they needed to accept Him as Lord and Savior. That was a tough message to deliver, but Paul delivered it anyway.

The problem was, things weren't going so well, which left Paul in a somewhat unfamiliar place. Up until this point, Paul had been successful everywhere he went. But now, no one is responding, and that's left him in somewhat of a quandary, in a disheartened and depressed state. Which is interesting when you think about it.

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God is the one who called Paul to Corinth. And Paul answered that call in the affirmative. But despite his best efforts, his message appears to be falling on deaf ears. So, what gives? Did he misunderstand God? Was he not doing something correctly?

Here's what you need to know about God. First, rarely (and I do mean rarely) do we see what God is doing in the moment. We might think we know, but we rarely do. Second, if we do happen to figure it out, maybe just a little bit, it's generally from the benefit of having hindsight.

And even then, many times, we still don't know. But, if we aren't careful that statement can leave us confused, can't it? I mean think about it, if we don't know what God wants us to do, then how in the world can we begin to reconcile decisions we may need to make in our own lives?

Well, honestly, it really all boils down to knowing God more intimately. Intimately, meaning, you know how He operates and therefore you have a better sense of what to do. But how do we do that? We do that by knowing His word.

You see, inside Paul's story is your story. Meaning, the way God operated with Paul is no different than the way he operates with you. He's the same today as He was then, which means you can find peace in knowing God is always doing something. Many times, you simply will not know what He is doing!

Now this is a hard concept for us to deal with at times, because we are human, and we want the answers. Unfortunately, when we don't get the answer, Christians many times will create one themselves or sometimes tend to over-Spiritualize things.

Many times, Christians, when trying to make decisions, look for signs; a cloud by day or pillar of fire by night, or a burning bush to guide them. But for us, today, that's not how God works.

He left us His word to guide us, and honestly, with God many of the decisions we are faced with aren't really that hard. Yes, we should pray, and seek God's wisdom. Ultimately, some of the things we face are just common sense.

Example: I don't have to look for a sign or even pray about helping someone. If I know God's word, then I know God has already told me to help people. Another example: I don't have to pray about loving those who aren't loveable. I don't have to pray about taking care of someone's needs, those who need assistance.

Many of the decisions we face in life don't have to be over spiritualized. In fact, many times the answers are staring us in the face. But what about more complicated decisions, such as a job or career change. What then?

Once again it all boils down to understanding God's word. Remember, your job is simply a way for you to feed and clothe you and your family. It's the instrument God has given you to survive and take care of your basic needs. When you understand it from God's standpoint then it gets a whole lot simpler.

You see, the question isn't what job fulfills me the most, but rather, what job will give me the ability and the opportunity to glorify God the most. Help me to be a greater asset for the Kingdom. It's not how I can make the most money, or get better benefits, or even a better retirement. At the center of all decisions lies the question, 'How can I better serve God in

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whatever I do?'

It's always about God. And, if you start with that basis, you will always end up in the right place. But what if I make the wrong decision? Well, guess what? God will make the most of it, even in a wrong decision, maybe even more in a wrong decision. God will bring Glory to himself, especially in the way you react to a bad situation.

You see, it all boils down to obedience, and no one is better at making lemonade out of lemons than God Himself!

But what about relationships? This question comes up all the time. Should I date this person or that person? Should I marry this person or that person? Once again, is that person going to help you glorify God, or are they going to pull you further away from God. Is this person asking you to do things that defy God's word? Are they trying to be an example of obeying God's word? This is tough I know.

But that is the perspective. Who does God want me to be with so I can become stronger and bring Glory to his name? A very different approach here. The world's approach is about our happiness - our compatibility - our common interest. God's approach is about Him.

And you never want to be unequally yoked with someone. "A hawk and dove don't light on the same line". "Light and darkness don't share the same space". In every decision we make we should make it through the lens of God's Glory!

And so, speaking of God's Glory, back to Paul. Here he is in Corinth having no success at all to speak of. And then something happens:

Well let's see what happens in Acts 18:6-11

Acts 18:6 But when they resisted and blasphemed, he shook out his garments and said to them, "Your blood be on your own heads! I am clean. From now on I will go to the Gentiles."

Acts 18:7 Then he left there and went to the house of a man named Titius Justus, a worshiper of God, whose house was next to the synagogue.

Acts 18:8 Crispus, the leader of the synagogue, believed in the Lord with all his household, and many of the Corinthians when they heard were believing and being baptized.

Acts 18:9 And the Lord said to Paul in the night by a vision, "Do not be afraid any longer, but go on speaking and do not be silent.

Acts 18:10 for I am with you, and no man will attack you in order to harm you, for I have many people in this city."

Acts 18:11 And he settled there a year and six months, teaching the word of God among them.

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So right when things seem bleak God shows up, and "the fruit" producing begins. Now, why did I jump into Acts this morning before moving into 2 Corinthians itself? First, for more context, but secondly, as I began studying and preparing for the message this week, I felt God leading me back to Acts to show you something very important about God.

Look at V.6

Acts 18:6 But when they resisted and blasphemed, he shook out his garments and said to them, "Your blood be on your own heads! I am clean. From now on I will go to the Gentiles."

Paul is working hard here to be obedient, fulfilling the work of ministry. He's doing what God called him to do.

But the result up is up to God. They resisted and blasphemed. And what did Paul do? Luke says, he shook out his garments and said to them "Your blood be on your own heads! I am clean. From now on I will go to the Gentiles."

In other words, he moved on, and why? Because we are not responsible for the results. We are to be obedient, and God will handle the rest. Here's an example from the pages of scripture, how that when you intimately know how God operates you can keep from being frustrated.

Look at Paul's situation. He's frustrated. He's doing what God called him to do. He's being obedient. He's entered a terrible city, one that caused him to fear and tremble. He's intimidated. And yet he presses on anyway. And nothing happens. Not only do they not respond, they resist and blaspheme what he is saying.

Now how does that apply to us? Well, have you ever tried to help someone who reaches out to you for help, and the first thing you do is invite them to church and they don't show up?

So, you invite them again and nothing - yet they continue to complain about their situation - you try and share Christ with them - but to no avail - and the cycle continues. Maybe they are in a destructive relationship. You tell them to get out, but nothing. You are kind to them. You love on them, you help them, you invest in them, and you simply see no improvement and no fruit whatsoever.

Well, guess what. Rest assured that God is doing something. You may not be able to see it, but God is doing something. And we are not responsible for the results. We simply put our

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hand to the plow and God provides the harvest. And sometimes we get to see the harvest, and sometimes we don't. Either way we must be content with it.

But in Paul's case, when he's at his lowest point, something does happen.

Look at v8

Acts 18:8 Crispus, the leader of the synagogue, believed in the Lord with all his household, and many of the Corinthians when they heard were believing and being baptized.

And so, God showed up. Paul couldn't see, but God was doing something the entire time. God hadn't abandoned him. On the contrary, even in the way He sent Aquila and Priscilla, he was giving Paul progressive encouragement. Even though Paul might not have seen it that way in the moment

Remember, Paul was all alone in this city and God knew that.

But just as the writer of Hebrews said in Hebrews 13:5. "God will never leave us nor forsake us," God is true to His word. That was true for Paul, and it is true for you and me.

So hold on. Hold on.

And then to drive this point home even further, let's look one more time at Acts 18:9-10.

Acts 18:9 And the Lord said to Paul in the night by a vision, "Do not be afraid any longer, but go on speaking and do not be silent;

Acts 18:10 for I am with you, and no man will attack you in order to harm you, for I have many people in this city."

These are very powerful verses for at least two reasons. First - they further confirm what I was telling you a few moments ago. God is always doing something inside His creation - many times we can't see it. But, when all effort and hope seem to be lost and Paul begins questioning his decision of going to Corinth in the first place, his Gospel messages penetrate the heart of a leader of the synagogue and he and his household are saved.

God puts an exclamation point on this moment. Not just anyone is saved. The leader of the Jewish synagogue is saved.

Next, for further encouragement, God sends Paul a vision at night and says, "Do not be afraid any longer, but go on speaking and do not be silent." So, obviously Paul was afraid, which once again gives us further confirmation of how he felt at this moment.

The Apostle Paul was afraid. Pretty insightful don't you think! If he was afraid, and it is okay

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if we are afraid at times, I would say so, and God knows He's afraid. Just like He knows when we are afraid - right?

And that leads us to verses 10&11, and these will be my closing verses of the day. Verse 10 may be one of my favorite verses in all of scripture. Listen to what it says and see if you can figure why this verse might be one my most favorite verses.

Acts 18:10 for I am with you, and no man will attack you in order to harm you, for I have many people in this city."

Listen to what Luke wrote here. For I am with you (that's for you and me as well). He is with us. Then he says, "no man will attack you in order to harm you." So, obviously Paul fears being attacked. Pretty comforting. But you know what's more comforting than that? The end of the verse. And here it is.

For I have many people in this city.

What does the end of the verse tell us? That God has already paved the way for Paul to walk. That He has people out there for Paul. They don't know it yet, and Paul doesn't know who they are, but God does because He has already prepared the path. Before they know it and before Paul knows who they are. How encouraging must that be!

And what does that tell us once again? It tells us God is Sovereign over His creation. That's what it tells us. It tells us God is already at work inside His creation long before we ever arrive. It tells us He knows the plans He has for us. And it tells us He's got us!

By the way, it also tells us that He's doing what He is doing, with or without us.

This is a complete paradigm shift from traditional church thinking. Our whole life we have been told that God needs us to do what He wants to do in someone's life. But the reality is God wants us to participate, but He doesn't have to have us.

It also tells us that there is work to be done. Based on the people's responses to Paul in verse 6, many people won't listen. Some will reject and blaspheme God, and when that happens, based on verse 6, we just simply move on.

And why? Because in verse 10, "I have many people in this city." Another way to say it is we

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have work to do. Our job is to influence as many people for the Kingdom as we can, not to set up shop for a few people. Not investing everything we have into a select few.

God has people in this city and our job is to get to as many of them as we can, and when we get to them then what do we do? We do what Paul did in v11:

Acts 18:11 And he settled there a year and six months, teaching the word of God among them.

We teach them the Word of God. And why? Because God's Word is what saves. And God's Word is what Sanctifies - matures – and makes disciples. Mature disciples bring more people into the Kingdom.

It's cyclical. This is how it works folks. No magic tricks, no thrills, no frills. Just stick with the program and God will do the rest.

I'll close with this, just a highlight on a previous question I posed a few minutes ago. How do I know what decisions to make in my life? You must know God more intimately, which gives you insight into how He operates. And how do you know how He operates? You see it in His word, which is exactly what we did here today!

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- This morning, we return to our study of 2 Corinthians. We are two teachings in but are just now today getting into the text of 2 Corinthians. The reason for this is always the same: Context - Context – Context.
  - To receive maximum impact in our lives, (which is what we want, right?), if we want to grow and mature spiritually at a maximum level, we must stay in context when studying God's Holy Manuscript.
  - And so, it's for that reason that I taught back-to-back teachings which gave us a deep dive look into the context and the setting of Paul's writings. Now, in case you missed the first two teachings, remember you can visit our website and catch back up.
  - So, with the introductory teachings behind us, let's delve in to 2 Corinthians this morning and see what God has for us.
- During the first teaching a few weeks ago, I read through verses 1-3, but I want back up and touch on them again really quick, as a segway if you will into the next set of verses.

2 Cor. 1:1 Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God,
and *our* brother Timothy,
To the church of God which is at Corinth with all the saints who are throughout Achaia:

- So, before we begin this morning, remember that Paul wrote 1 Corinthians as a letter of correction to this church in trying to correct some of their bad behavior. Unfortunately, that letter didn't seem to completely solve the issues. Not only does it not seem to resolve the issues, but Paul also gets word that the situation has actually gone from bad to worse.
  - Paul is told that there are some in the church who question who he is. Specifically, his Apostolic Authority. And evidently, as we will discover in Chapter 7 all these problems, "this stir" of questioning Paul's authority, originates with one individual.
  - Which is interesting. One person - one individual stirring things up - causing trouble. And why? Because at its core, it's all about that individual. Their self-interest, their agenda, their thoughts, and their opinion. Regardless of what they may say, it's always about them. It's not about the greater good of the body of Christ - the church.
    - Remember this situation the next time you find yourself being drawn into a vortex of murmuring. When a person or certain group of people start speaking privately among themselves, as if there's some secret that no one else knows about, it always starts the same way. They start complaining under their breath in an effort to gain support, seeking out anyone who might listen.
    - Just remember 2 Corinthians, because that's what Paul is dealing with here. If you notice someone doing this, do your part to snuff it out. And, do you know the best method for snuffing out murmuring? Don't respond to it and don't participate in it.
- Paul writes 2 Corinthians making another attempt at straighten things out in this church, and this time, he speaks specifically to the issue of his calling and his Apostolic

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Authority. He begins with an opening Salutation & Greeting, in what we will call typical Paul fashion.

- Right out the gate he begins by establishing that he is an Apostle of Christ Jesus by the Will of God (no higher calling than this). A simple statement here. He says:
- I am an Apostle, established by none other than Jesus Christ himself - by His will. And then He says, 'To the Church at Corinth, with all the saints throughout Achaia'. Remember, Achaia is the region and Corinth is the capital of that region.
  - This letter was written to Corinth, but it could also be distributed to other churches in that region. It is believed there may have been one or two more churches in that region.
  - We will call this a soft opening of sorts, as Paul re-establishes who he is and where his authority was derived. And then he says in verse 2:

2 Cor. 1:2 **Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.**

- "Grace to you" is an interesting phrase and one worth noting. In our opening introductory teaching, we touched on this phrase, but I would just like to back up and highlight it one more time.
  - God's Grace is His Unmerited Favor, and it works in several ways in scripture. The primary way is it offers us Salvation, which we don't deserve. This is what Paul means when He says, "For by Grace you are saved" in Ephesians 2:8-9.
    - It is because of God's Grace, His Unmerited Favor, that you even had the opportunity to be saved. The word Grace here, in Paul's opening Salutation, is not used in the same context as the word Grace he used in Ephesians 2:8-9.
  - Paul is using it in a different sense. This is not the Grace that saves. This is the Grace that sustains, and that's different. This is important to note. God's grace serves in many facets; the most important being salvation. But, next in line, is sustaining. But it goes deeper than that.
    - You see if you are a believer, meaning you have come to the realization you are a sinner, and you have confessed that fact, and you have recognized that the cure for your sin problem is Jesus, specifically, His saving work of the Cross of Calvary.
    - Meaning, if you have accepted His work on the cross as being true and a solution for your sin problem. That very revelation, just the revelation itself in your life, is a result of God's Grace.
- Let me be clear here for just a second. Your eyes being opened to the fact that you are a sinner was the first step of God's Grace being evident in your life. And why? Because according to the scriptures, you, under your own volition, will never come to that realization on your own. Let's look at a few scriptures as proof of what I am saying.

Eph. 2:1 **And you were dead in your offenses and sins.**

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- Dead being the key word here. If you were dead, then you were not what by definition? Alive. But let's don't stop there, lets dig further. Moving on, verses 2-5

Eph. 2:2 in which you previously walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power of the air, of the spirit that is now working in the sons of disobedience.
Eph. 2:3 Among them we too all previously lived in the lusts of our flesh, indulging the desires of the flesh and of the mind, and were by nature children of wrath, just as the rest.
Eph. 2:4 But God, being rich in mercy, because of His great love with which He loved us,
Eph. 2:5 even when we were dead in our wrongdoings, made us alive together with Christ (by grace you have been saved),

- Then we have Romans 3

Rom. 3:10 as it is written, "THERE IS NONE RIGHTEOUS, NOT EVEN ONE;
Rom. 3:11 THERE IS NONE WHO UNDERSTANDS, THERE IS NONE WHO SEEKS FOR GOD;

- There are many more scriptures we could use to drive this point home but remember - you didn't find Jesus. He wasn't hiding. He found you and it was because of God's Grace - His unmerited favor on your life - that you even realized you were who you were. Another way to say it is the fact that you even realized you were in jeopardy in the first place, which then afforded you the opportunity to accept Him as Lord and Savior.
    - But as I previously stated, "Grace" as it relates to Salvation is not the aspect of Grace that Paul is speaking of here. The Grace that Paul is speaking of here is different, and we'll discover that and deal with it, and talk more about it throughout this letter. For now, just remember, it takes Grace to be saved and it takes Grace to be sustained as we walk throughout this life.
        - And this is important guys, because if you are a believer you can stand on this promise. When things get rough, when you get down, when you are ostracized or talked about or deeply burdened in some way. Remember, it's God's sustaining Grace that ensures us that we are never alone.
    - Paul is experiencing it here. And it's because of it that you can know that you will always stand, because God will make you stand. You will sustain because God's Grace will cause you to sustain.
    - Romans 14:4 says it this way:

Rom. 14:4 Who are you to judge the servant of another? To his own master he stands or falls; and he will stand, for the Lord is able to make him stand.

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- I will tell you something else as it relates to God sustaining. It has an interesting aspect to it, and that is, God can't really begin to use us until we get to that point where it's only by His Grace we are being sustained.
    - Follow what I am saying here. God can't utilize us, and the level we can be used by Him, until we come to the realization that its only by His Grace we are sustained.
        - Meaning, we must come to the end of ourselves, and abandon the thinking that somehow, we are in control, that we are doing something or accomplishing something, in and through our own power.
        - Because I assure you, that is never the case. If you are a child of God, your accomplishments, however great or small are all due to His Sustaining Grace. Whether you know that or not.
    - Paul's words in Romans ring true for me, primarily because I started out in business for myself when I was 15 years old. I had no clue what I was doing, but that didn't matter at that point in my life. I was "IOF" - Ignorance on Fire.
- This past week I was calculating just how long (my wife) Daffney and I have been self-employed; in roughly six more months we will have officially been in business for roughly 35 years. It's hard to believe.
    - Throughout my career (if you call it that), my journey if you will, I failed many times. More times than I succeeded. And it has been a long and arduous journey to say the least. Daffney can attest to that. What she can also attest to, is that throughout this journey, there were many, many times when we thought we were done. When we thought for sure this business was about to collapse.
    - I would often seek the advice of friends, other businesspeople, and often these friends would tell me to quit. They would often speculate as to why we were failing. Saying things like, 'our problems were all a result of me not fulfilling my calling. And, honestly, at times that seemed to make sense. But the reality was, that wasn't true at all.
    - You see God was doing something with both Daffney and me. He was building our resolve, our character, and our stress tolerance among other things, all for His Glory. Building us for the work of ministry. The business being His instrument for our development. Not for the purpose of making money, but so that we could become the husband and wife, the Pastor and wife, that he wanted us to become, so that we would grow up and bring Glory to His name.
        - So that we would become useful instruments of His Ministry. So that we would learn what it meant to become bondservants of Jesus Christ. So that we would learn what it meant to lean on Him, and not our own understanding.
    - You see, along the way we would find ourselves down, depressed, and burdened beyond belief. Eventually we would become weak and feel like giving up. I would begin internally viewing myself as a failure, thinking to myself, how could I be so dumb?
        - And then, just when I thought it was all over, God's sustainable Grace would come along and take over. My faith never wavered, but in my flesh, I would become weak. It was then in those moments that the Grace that Sustains would take over, undergirding me, and lift me up, forcing us to stand. All because He made it happen.

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        - He made us stand on numerous occasions. I had smart businesspeople, some Christian, some not, tell me 'You won't be in business for more than "X" more days or months.'
        - But when all hope seemed to be lost, God would show up. Sometimes it would be in the form of new business, but many times it was in the form of Wisdom. He would give me one more piece of the puzzle, a piece that I wasn't seeing. A piece that would make things little better (financially speaking).
    - Regardless of what it was, it was His Grace that sustained us through it all. And that's the aspect of Grace that Paul is writing about here, and that's going to become more evident as we journey through this letter.
- Before moving on, let me digress on this topic by leaving you with what the writer of Hebrews said in Chapter 4:16 - this will kind of give you the why behind God's Sustaining Grace.

Hebrews 4:16 Therefore let's approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace for help at the time of *our* need.

- That sums up why Paul opened with Grace be to you. Next, He says, and "Peace from God". Once again, just like God's Grace, Gods' peace has different aspects to it as well.
- I want you to notice the phrase here, "Peace from God", which is different than the "Peace of God". So, what's the difference? As I said a few moments ago, just like Grace has different aspects, so does Peace.
    - There is a "Peace from God" - as mentioned here in 2 Corinthians. But there is a "Peace of God" that shows up in Romans, and it too relates to salvation. Let me read it to you - Romans 5:1-2:

Rom. 5:1 Therefore, having been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ,
Rom. 5:2 through whom we also have obtained our introduction by faith into this grace in which we stand; and we celebrate in hope of the glory of God

- This peace - the "Peace of God" - is a natural byproduct of Salvation. It's a peace best described using the analogy of jeopardy. Have you ever been in jeopardy, scared or fearful, maybe worried in a tremendous way – overburdened? The Bible also calls it "Heavy Ladened".
    - Maybe you feared for your life, or you fear an outcome, much like awaiting a sentencing in a court hearing. Maybe best described as having a weight on your shoulders. I want you to think back to that time. And then think back to when what you feared the most, didn't happen.
    - Or the outcome wasn't as bad as you thought it would be. Immediately your fear turned to relief, or better said, it turned to a calm - in reality it's a "Peace". That feeling best describes the Peace of God. It shows up many times when someone is dying. During their last days and hours, they say, "I'm okay - I'm at Peace with God".

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- If you're a believer, that peace is a peace that you should carry with you everywhere you go. Paul also refers to it as the "Blessed Hope", because you see, it's through that Peace that we find our reconciliation, i.e. victory over sin.
    - But remember, Paul isn't writing this letter to unbelievers, he's writing it to the Church at Corinth. So, he assumes it's being read by believers, which clues us in on why he uses the phrase "Peace from God" rather than "Peace of God".
    - Let me read it again:

2 Cor. 1:2 **Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.**

- So, what about this Peace from God? It's as if Paul is delivering a word not only from himself, but from God as well.
    - So, this Peace is not the Peace of God, which relates to salvation, and if that's not the case, then what kind of peace is it? Well, when you pair peace with the word Grace, it takes on a totally different meaning.
    - Peace is a benefit of Grace. Matter of fact, when you find Peace in scripture you will almost always find it paired with Grace. Which tells us something. The sense is this - Grace to you. Meaning may God and the Lord give you an abundance of undeserved gifts, and may you receive peace because of that Grace. And without one you can't have the other.
        - Just know that the Peace of God and the Peace from God are different. One is derived from Salvation and the other is derived from knowing you have God's sustaining Grace. Knowing God is in control and has got you no matter the situation, good, bad or indifferent, will begin to really resonate and make more sense, become more meaningful as we journey through 2 Corinthians.
    - Moving on, next we pick up with verses 3-4, where Paul will shift his focuses from his salutation and greeting to that of thankfulness and comfort. Just like Grace and Peace. Thankfulness and comfort are not just thankfulness and comfort in the traditional sense. This is different, and they are topics we should all be interested in. Here's what he says:

2 Cor. 1:3 **Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of mercies and God of all comfort,**
2 Cor. 1:4 **who comforts us in all our affliction so that we will be able to comfort those who are in any affliction with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God.**

- Paul starts out by using the words "blessed be". It's the same as saying he is thankful. "Blessed be" means thankful. He's giving thanks. Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ. He starts out this way, because he wants to set the tone, to establish the value of the experiences he's about to recount. Experiences he has had, and there is going to be a surprise in those experiences as he gives thanks for some very strange things.

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- Next, we have the word comfort, and it's going to show up all throughout this epistle. As a matter of fact, it's going to occur 18 times as a verb (an action), and 11 times as a noun in various forms.
- The word comfort, as we use the term, comes from two words in Latin; *Con* - which means "together", and *Fortis* - meaning strong. When we think of the word comfort, we tend to think of it in an emotional sense, as in comforting someone. It's the equivalent in our mind to consoling. But that's not the word Paul is using here.
- The word comfort here means to strengthen. To strengthen them. The Greek word is *Parakleesis* (Pars -Klee -sis), which means "called alongside to help". We should recognize that word right away because it shows up in the Greek term that refers to "The comforter" The Holy Spirit.
  - You may recall, Jesus said himself that another comforter I will send to you. "Who will disannul your orphanage". Powerful statement that Jesus made here. Imagine if you were an orphan, abandoned from birth, and someone came along and disannulled you as an orphan. Literally reversed it. Took you from being an orphan, abandoned and alone, to comforting you in a way that you no longer felt you were an orphan.
  - That's a different type of comfort than we are used too, isn't it? But that's the comfort of God. And Paul says, He is the God of all comfort (not some but all). The sense of this comfort is to comfort in a way that we come alongside and assume someone's burden. Not just, I will pray for you, no, you get in the boat of pain with them. Your comforting is almost a physical sense.

- I saw an example of this type of comfort through a tragic story of the death of my niece. Four years ago this March, I was in Washington DC at a conference. My team and I were there a couple of days. And one night, around 9-10pm, Daffney called my phone.
  - She said, "You need to call your sister". Carmen (our niece) had been shot. In that very moment, I remember feeling a sense of jeopardy, fear, disbelief, and shock all wrapped up in one. I also remember feeling helpless. There I was stuck in Washington.
  - And to make matters worse, we had no idea how bad it was. I called my sister and stayed on the phone with her all the way to the emergency room. I desperately tried to "comfort" her. In the counseling sense to give her hope, saying stuff like, it will be okay, and she is probably fine.
  - I remember her desperately asking me to pray (and I did). I just remember thinking, there is no way I can help. There is no way to give her true comfort. No matter how hard I tried, there were no words that I spoke that could give her any relief. As I said, I felt helpless.
  - I was on the phone with her as she arrived at the emergency room, only for her to hear the news that her daughter didn't make it. My heart was beating out of my chest. My fear turned to panic. My anxiety and stress went through the roof. But there was absolutely nothing I could do for her.
  - I managed to get a flight out the next morning, and what was interesting was, a few of my staff members were with me. They, too, were trying to give me comfort. But unfortunately, they found themselves in the same place I was the night before in trying to console my sister: There was nothing they could say.

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- I flew home the next morning, arrived at the airport, got in my vehicle, and drove to my mother's house. When I arrived, I found my sister lying in the bed crying beyond belief. It was unlike any cry I had ever heard. I don't know how to describe it really, other than it was cry of desperation.

- It was painful to watch, and once again I felt helpless. There were simply no words that could bring any level of comfort to my sister that day. None whatsoever. But something interesting did happen that day. Something that I did not realize until I started this study of comfort this week.
  - My brother-in-law, my sister's husband, who by the way was not her husband at the time. As a matter of fact, they weren't even dating at that point. They had previously dated but had broken up. He was there that day.
  - And when I peeked into the room to check on her, she was curled up in the fetal position on the bed sobbing and crying, and right beside her in the floor, there he was, her former boyfriend with his hand on her side. He was sobbing and crying right along with her, almost as bad as she was.
  - At that time, I didn't think much of it, other than how awesome it was that he was there with her. But this past week all that changed as I studied 2 Corinthians. Guys, that's the type of comfort that Paul is describing here in His opening Salutation.
  - It's not just consoling, or words of encouragement. This is the type of comfort that my now brother-in-law gave my sister that day. And it can only come when one person assumes the burden of another.
- You know, if you opened your Bible to 2 Corinthians 1 today, and just read it, you would read right past Paul's greeting and opening. No way you would have given a second thought to these words: Grace & Peace & Comfort.
  - This gives you a sense of just how rich God's word is, and it tells you why we must slowly and methodically dissect and ingest every word. It's so powerful.
  - Now, you may be sitting here this morning wondering how in the world could I give, or show someone, that type of comfort. Seems impossible. Remember, God never gave us the problem or the command without giving us the path or solution to that problem or command.
- So, guess what, you will have to come back next week as God through the Apostle Paul shows us exactly how this is made possible.

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- Last week, after a two-week introduction into 2 Corinthians, we finally made our way into the actual Book or letter itself. Of course, we didn't make it very far, only made it through four verses. But who cares. It's all about quality not quantity.
    - So, this morning, as a segway into this week's teaching, I want us to back up and re-read those verses one more time for context. Listen closely to what the Apostle Paul has to say:

2 Cor. 1:3 **Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of mercies and God of all comfort,**
2 Cor. 1:4 **who comforts us in all our affliction so that we will be able to comfort those who are in any affliction with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God.**

- Right out of the gate, Paul lets this church (and by extension you and I) know that their God and our God is the God of "all" comfort, who comforts us in all our affliction. And He does so that we will be able to comfort those who find themselves in any affliction. Specifically, with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God. Very interesting concept here and one we will explore in depth this morning.
    - Now, I want you to follow Paul's logic here. The God who comforts us, who brings about comfort in "all" our afflictions, equips us to comfort others in the same way He (being God) comforts us.
    - At the end of last week's teaching, I told you that if you came back this week, you were going to learn just exactly how this process happens. How it could be that you and I as humans, and more specifically believers, could possibly comfort others in the same way God comforts us. Seems impossible, doesn't it? Not really, when you see how God does it.
- Now, before delving too deep into this concept this morning, I want to back up and revisit this word comfort one more time. Because as I stated last week, this word "comfort" is going to show up all throughout this Epistle. As a matter of fact, it will occur 18 times as a verb (an action) and 11 times as a noun in various forms, so, it's significant to Paul's writings.
    - The word comfort, as we use the term, comes from two words in the Latin - the word *Con* - which means "together" and *Fortis* - which means "strong". Most of the time when we think of the word comfort, we tend to think of it in an emotional sense, as in comforting someone or consoling someone with our words.
    - But as I previously stated, that's not the definition of the word Paul is using here. The word comfort here actually means to strengthen someone. To strengthen them. The Greek word is *Parakleesis* (Pars-Klee -sis), which means "called alongside to help". It means when you hurt, I hurt, and when you're down, I'm down.
        - And this definition or meaning lines up perfectly with the entire testimony of scripture, not just what Paul wrote. I want to read from James 2:14-17 as further proof of what I am saying. James 2:14-17 is going to speak about our faith in relation to our works. Another way to say it would be, our words lining up with our actions.

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- See if you can follow the progression of logic here as we read what James wrote:

James 2:14 What use is it, my brothers *and sisters,* if someone says he has faith, but he has no works? Can that faith save him?
James 2:15 If a brother or sister is without clothing and in need of daily food,
James 2:16 and one of you says to them, "Go in peace, be warmed and be filled," yet you do not give them what is necessary for *their* body, what use is that?
James 2:17 In the same way, faith also, if it has no works, is dead, *being* by itself.

- Now the concept here is a simple one, but it's been over-complicated throughout the years. Any veteran Christian should know that works do not save us. James says faith without works is dead.
  - In other words, doing a work, or works, is not going to save you, but if you are saved you should be doing works. Another way to say it is, if you are saved, you should be bearing fruit in your life. It's the equivalent of someone saying one thing but doing another.
  - If you are saved, fruit should be manifest in your life. Pretty simple to understand, and the same applies to Paul's definition of comfort. Meaning, it works on the same premises. Comforting someone is not just saying, "I'll pray for you" or "We will pray for you".
    - It's literally coming along side someone and strengthening them. Just like your faith, it must carry with it an element of action. So must the Biblical process of comforting someone.
    - But how? With words. But not in the way we think of it. So, if it's words, but not in the way we think of it, then what is it? You'll soon see, there is a supernatural design that is opposite to what we've been classically taught.
- First, it requires an investment of time into that individual, which is tough, especially in the world we live in. Whether you realize it or not, time is the most valuable thing you possess, and it supersedes any other type of wealth or possession you may have.
  - It's also limited, and what's interesting is, regardless of socio-economic class, we all get the same amount of it. And so, what you do with your time matters. If you are a believer, what should you be doing with most of your time? The work of ministry!
    - I didn't say going to Church. I said the work of ministry, which is "Something you do as you go", not "something you go do". That means it's what you do when you're working and moving about in your everyday life. That's where real ministry takes place. Very little ministry takes place at church.
- Anyway, back to this valuable possession we call time. As I said, it's so valuable because we are so busy, busier than we have ever been. But what's interesting is we aren't really getting any more accomplished than we ever did. Primarily because of what I call the "Fill in the Gap Law".
  - Now, if you have never heard of this law, that's alright, because I made it up. The Fill in the Gap Law says, "When my life becomes more efficient, through the reduction

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of time, through technology or a quicker system or process, when my time is freed up, I just fill it in with something else".

- I can prove what I am saying. Does anyone order their groceries online? What a wonderful time saver. You order them and then go pick them up in the parking lot. They bring them to you. Does it save time? It's supposed to. Let's say for this exercise it does.
- Can you tell me what you did with that extra time? Probably not. No one can. And why? Because you "Filled in The Gap" with something else. Time is our most valuable possession, and how we manage it (as it relates to ministry) matters. You get the point.

- Last week, when speaking of comforting someone, I used my brother-in-law as an example of what this type of comfort looked like in an individual, and I won't re-tell the story. But if you haven't heard it, I encourage you to go back and listen to last week's teaching.
  - Because, through my niece's death, my sister's friend at the time (now her husband) comforted her in the same way Paul wrote about comfort in 2 Corinthians. So, this concept of comfort is a heavy one. It's weighty, because as I said, it's a coming along side and strengthening of the individual. And it requires your time.
  - But the question remains, how do we accomplish this? And furthermore, is it even possible for us to do this as humans? If it is, can we possibly do it in the same way God does it for us?
    - Also, are we supposed to take on everyone's burdens? Are we supposed to come along side everyone we meet and strengthen them? If you are concerned about this, you can take a deep breath, because the answer is No.
    - Even if we wanted to, there is no way you and I could come alongside everyone we meet and strengthen them.
  - But what about the ones we do feel led to come alongside? Is it possible to comfort them the way God comforts us? I would tell you in a physical sense the answer is no. Meaning, there is no way to take on someone's burdens, someone's pain to the point that you feel the same way they feel. That's simply not possible.
  - And why? Because the stakes are not the same for you as they are for them. I kind of relate it to playing poker with your own money versus someone else's. If I were a good poker player, which means I won more than I lost, and you came to me one day and said, "Hey Greg, I know you are a good poker player, and you win more than you lose. I would like to give you all my money".
    - "Everything my wife and I have saved for a lifetime, and I want you to play poker with it and try and double it for us. If you do that, I will give you a percentage of what you win for us". The question is, would it be possible for me to mentally approach that game of poker the same way I would approach it using my own money?
  - The answer is no. Psychologically it's simply not possible. The same holds true when it comes to taking on someone else's burden. But that's not what God is asking us to do. He is asking us to come alongside and comfort people by strengthening them, in the same way that God comforts us.

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- But once again, this begs the question how does that work? Meaning, how does God comfort us? We have many examples in scripture of God comforting someone, but this morning I want to focus on that process, and not simply the result.
    - Specifically, the process that God puts us through so that we are equipped to bring comfort to others. And to do this, I want to use the Greatest Commentary on the Bible, which is none other than The Bible itself.
    - And we will start out with Philippians 4. Listen to what Paul says:

Phil. 4:6 Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and pleading with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God.
Phil. 4:7 And the peace of God, which surpasses all comprehension, will guard your hearts and minds in Christ Jesus.

- So, God's directive to us is not to be anxious about anything. But the problem is that's easier said than done, isn't it? So just exactly how does that work? If I am anxious and worried or stressed, how do I simply not be those things?
    - You could say, "well just do it", but this isn't Nike, and so that doesn't work. We can't simply say the words, "I am now not anxious", and there it is. You are now not anxious. Obviously, that doesn't work, and lucky for us that's not what God meant.
    - The key to not being anxious shows up in the rest of the verse, where it says, but, in everything by prayer, and pleading, with thanksgiving, let your request be made known to God.
- Notice first, it said in everything, which means all things. Anything that makes you worry. And the first step is to be prayerful. Pray. That's step 1. Start out with prayer. And then what's next? Step 2 is with pleading.
    - And the final step is to be thankful. With thanksgiving let your request be made known to God. So, it's Pray, Plead/Pleadings (this is in a legal sense) not a begging sense. In other words, put forth your position in the request. And don't forget to do it in a state of thankfulness. Be thankful in all things (which means even in the bad things). It's then, and only then, that your request be made known to God.
- So, there's the process. This is God's prescription for processing your request and if you do that, what's the result? Verse 7 is the result:

Phil. 4:7 And the peace of God, which surpasses all comprehension, will guard your hearts and minds in Christ Jesus.

- This directive is an objective directive (absolute). Meaning, it's not subjective (open ended). And it's laid out in a very clear cut and precise way. Another way to say it is, if this, then this. So, there's the process for not being anxious.
- But there's another verse I want us to look at for further insight into this fact. It shows up in the Psalms, where the Psalmist says, in what is (probably) the most famous Psalm of all - the 23rd Psalm. In this Psalm God goes out of His way to paint for us a picture of the type of comfort that He has made available to us, and how it's achieved.

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Psalm 23:1 **The LORD is my shepherd; I will not be in need.**

- Let me just pause here for a minute. I love how God gives us this empirical statement. God is our shepherd. If you are saved (accepted Jesus Christ as Lord), He is your Shepherd - and that's a fact. Which means, this truth is a truth that you can count on.
    - And in a world of uncertainty, that means something. It's extremely important you understand this, because if He is our Shepherd then we are what? "His Sheep". If you are a believer, you're a sheep.
        - So, if believers are sheep, then what are non-believers? "Goats". That's the Bible's description of a non-believer. And that does not mean "The greatest of all time". So, if you are a believer, you are a sheep. And as a sheep, you have the attributes and qualities, and you operate and live in the environment of sheep.
        - Meaning, you have enemies and predators, namely the enemy of God, Satan and his demons, and they are out to get you. So, you are under constant threat, just like a sheep.
    - This is important, and if you understand this fact and relate your life to that of a sheep, then you understand that the Shepherd takes care of His sheep. Which is why God says through the Psalmist; You will not be in need, because He's always taking care of you.
- Now as I said, understanding this concept is very important. Think about it like sheep grazing in the field. As they graze, they know there are predators among them, and yet they have comfort knowing the Shepherd is watching over them.
    - Simply knowing they are protected, no matter what, allows them to eat in peace. That is the sense here. Believers are sheep, and God is our Shepherd, and it's for that reason we can rest easy, knowing He has got us!
        - Next, the Psalmist says:

Psalm 23:2 **He lets** (or the Hebrew says - "makes" - which is a better word in my opinion)
He makes me lie down in green pastures.
He leads me beside quiet waters.
Psalm 23:3 **He restores my soul;**
He guides (Hebrew says - "Leads") **me in the paths of righteousness.**

- By the way, when someone is righteous in scripture what are they? They are saved, because they've been made clean by the blood of Jesus Christ. That's how we are made righteous.
- Now, there are two important aspects I want us to note about verses 2 & 3, and both are important, but one is even more important. First, we have the word "He":
    - He makes
    - He leads
    - He restores

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- He guides
  - Who's doing it? He is. God is in charge. He is doing it. Which means, you and I aren't doing it (Really important for us to understand). We are not in control. The second aspect (and the more important of the two), is the phrase "For the sake of His name."
  - "For whose name's sake"? For His. God does all that He does for a specific reason, and not for the reason most of us have been taught. We have been taught that God does all that He does because He loves us. But that's not true.
  - He does love us, but that's not why He does what He does. He does it for His name's sake. Not yours and not mine. For His name's Sake!
- These are important words for us to understand. But why? Because wouldn't you rather have God do something for His benefit rather than yours? Think about it, what means more, His benefit, or ours?

- Now this concept might rub us the wrong way at first, because it might make us feel as if the Lord is selfish, or self-centered, or self-absorbed. And if you think that, or feel that, you would be wrong. I'll tell you why.
  - At the end of the day, if it benefits Him, it automatically benefits you, right? Which one would give you more confidence, Him doing something for you, or Him doing something for Him? Something that you know automatically benefits you.
- Another way to say it is, in the "hierarchy" of creation, who's more important, you or Him? "The Creator" or "The Created"? You get the point. You see, because He is watching over us, for His namesake, we can have the utmost confidence knowing that we are taken care of! And if that's the case, then the natural byproduct of this reality (in your mind and heart) is what? Comfort and peace!
  - And so, that's how it works. Now moving on to verse 4 - the Psalmist says:

Psalm 23:4 **Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death…**

- Once again, let me pause for just a second, and I'm not going to make too big a deal about this. But I do want to point something out. Something I think is interesting with the Psalmist word progression.
  - Notice that He (God) does all the good stuff and "I" when left up to me, I end up in the bad stuff. In other words, He makes me, He leads me, He guides me, and then, He restores me, but I walk through the valley of the shadow of death.
  - You can kind of get the sense that the Psalmist is saying here, "I walked into trouble. I went the wrong direction. I walked into something I shouldn't have. But God was with me, and He guides me through it. He restores me.
  - This theory is confirmed in the second half of the verse when he says,

…"I fear no evil, for You are with me; Your rod and Your staff, they comfort me.

- In other words, I got myself into a mess, but you brought me through it, and because I

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know that you are there, that you are in control, that you protect and guide me.

- And you do so, both with your rod and a staff. The rod was used by the Shepherd to beat off attacking animals, and the staff (the walking stick) kept the sheep away from physical dangers. God uses both these instruments (as our Shepherd) to guide us and to ward off our enemies. The word comfort here is once again used as a verb, which means God is active in your life, guiding you and protecting you, and if you understand this, both in your heart and mind, that brings you the comfort of God.
- Next, in verse 5:

Psalm 23:5 **You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies;**
You have anointed my head with oil, My cup overflows.
Psalm 23:6 **Certainly goodness and faithfulness (mercy in the Hebrew) will follow me all the days of my life, and my dwelling *will be* in the house of the LORD forever.**

- By now you should understand one thing. God is in control - period! Even in "the valley of the shadow of death (i.e., the worst of times of your life)". And because you can count on this very fact you will be Comforted. Let me give you a real-life analogy that might drive this point home a little more.
  - In life there are people you can depend on and there are people you cannot depend on and unfortunately this is the truth of life. Daffney and I have found this to be true, especially in our business. There are people we can give important things to and rest easy knowing it's handled, and there are those who we cannot give important things to, because we know they won't get it done.
  - When I hand something off to someone I trust to handle it, I no longer worry about it anymore because I know they will handle it. And in a world of uncertainty, those people are a Godsend. Now, before getting too far into this topic let me be clear on something.
    - This is not an all-or-nothing proposition as it relates to people. Meaning, all non-dependable "per se" people are not necessarily non-dependable in all categories. I'll use myself as a real-life example.
    - If my wife asks me to stop at the store and pick something up, she almost always must worry about it getting done because she knows I will forget it. Which makes her worry, and rightly so, because my track record isn't very good when it comes to stopping off at the store, because I always forget.
    - As a result, she must constantly remind me, and follow up, which leaves her feeling uneasy and unsure, and honestly causes her to worry even more. It makes her worry so much that she probably says to herself, forget it, I'll just do it myself.
    - But having said that, that's not the way I am in all categories. For example, when it comes to protecting our family, in that category she can lay her head down at night and know that I will always protect her and the kids. And because she knows this, she sleeps easily at night. She doesn't worry or stress over being protected. You get the point.

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- When it comes to God, that feeling of dependability and security should always be present in your life because He is rock solid in all categories. Now the question is, do you feel that way about Him? Are you comforted when things are uncertain, while you're in the storm or the "Valley of the Shadow of death"?
    - If not, there is a reason for that; it's because you haven't gotten to know Him in a deeply intimate way. But how do we get intimate with Him? By studying and ingesting His Memoirs. Through His word. It is always through His word.
    - When you've studied His word for an extended period of time, it will begin to become truth, and once it becomes a truth in our life, when we believe His word (which by the way - is simply God in word form), that's when you begin to develop the "Comfort" of God, and along with it comes "A peace that passes all understanding".
- So, if we are sheep, and He is our Shephard, then by knowing Him more intimately that's how we are comforted. So, if you don't feel comforted, delve into His Word.
    - Back to 2 Corinthians. Let me re-read verse 4 one more time for context and I promise we are closing in on the end.

2 Cor. 1:4 **who comforts us in all our affliction so that we will be able to comfort those who are in any affliction with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God.**

- God comforts us, and for that reason we should comfort others in the same way He comforts us. But, once again, how do we do it? I mean, seriously. As I stated earlier, is it even possible for me to comfort someone in the way God comforts me? The answer is Yes.
    - Paul wouldn't have mentioned it the way he did if it wasn't possible. God said we were comforted so we could comfort others with the same comfort He gave us. So, how does that work? Not in the way you might think.
- By now, we understand that the comfort Paul is referring to is not just consoling, it's coming along side and strengthening. But how is that even possible really? Remember, when we are comforted by God, it's through our minds. When it registers in our minds that He is who He says he is, "That He is our Savior, and that He died for us, gave His life for us", and ultimately, that He suffered for us so that we could one day be with Him in Heaven.
    - But how could we invoke that type of confidence in someone to the point that they felt comforted? As I said, the answer is not what you might expect. So, what is it?
    - It's found in verses 5-7:

2 Cor. 1:5 **For just as the sufferings of Christ are ours in abundance, so also our comfort is abundant through Christ.**
2 Cor. 1:6 **But if we are afflicted, it is for your comfort and salvation; or if we are comforted, it is for your comfort, which is effective in the patient enduring of the same sufferings which we also suffer;**

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2 Cor. 1:7 and our hope for you is firmly grounded, knowing that as you are partners in our sufferings, so also you are in our comfort.

- Guys, in these verses we get the answer to two of our questions:
  - 1) How "we" comfort others in the same way God comforts us, and
  - 2) How we know which people we are best suited to comfort, to invest in (given our limited time).
    - In these verses God gives us the answer to both questions. And the prescription comes through a combination of two words - "Suffering and Comfort". One is necessary for the other to take place.
- Look at what Paul says, "Just as the sufferings of Christ are ours in abundance, so also our comfort is abundant through Christ". Paul is speaking of himself and his fellow workers in the faith, men like Timothy, Titus, and other Apostles, disciples, and church leaders. Men who suffered for Christ, and men who counted it as an honor to do so.
  - But why? Because through suffering we draw closer to Him. Suffering never comes by accident (just so you know), because God is always in control. Suffering is by God's design. And as I said, it does two things:
    - First, it builds your spiritual immune system, because accompanying any suffering is an applied question. Do you trust Him? According to the testimony of scripture, suffering is the prerequisite for God's comfort. And it's through suffering that you learn to trust God.
- This morning are you suffering or are you hurting? Are you going through something? Whatever it is you are going through in your life, whatever it is that has brought pain and suffering to your life, at the core of your suffering is an underlying question. One that God is asking. Do you trust him?
  - And if you don't completely trust Him in the moment, it's okay. Because eventually, with the benefit of hindsight, you will. We will always suffer, because it's through suffering that we learn to trust God. It's the ole "Footprints in the Sand" analogy.
- But there's a second thing that Suffering does. It equips us to "Comfort" others. It's simple. "Your suffering created your Credentials". Earned you the right to comfort someone.
  - Many years ago, I came to work one day, and my bookkeeper was nowhere to be found. I called her and finally got her on the phone. She was distraught, and really in a malaise, a haze, a fog. She wasn't speaking clearly.
  - She told me she couldn't come to work because she had just received news that her son, who was in college at the time, committed suicide the previous afternoon. I was immediately shocked, but obviously not near as shocked as she was.
  - When she shared the news, I remember scrambling, trying to think of the words to say. But try as I may, there were no words I could say. I felt totally ill equipped for that conversation. There was nothing I could say that would bring her comfort.
  - Eventually, she resigned her job with us. She said the stress was just too much. Throughout the years I lost touch with her. A few years later, I caught up with her and asked her how she was doing. She was noticeably doing much better. She

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began telling me about this support group she had joined. It was a group of people who had a similar tragedy in their life.

- They had lost a child or loved one to suicide. She told me how they all would get together and take trips; go hiking and camping and Horseback riding. They were able to connect with one another on a level that only a person who had lost a loved one to suicide could connect.
- You see, through the suffering of another person, she found comfort, solace, and peace. Through their suffering she began the healing process. This is exactly what Paul is writing about here.

- How do you strengthen someone? You suffer. How do you bring the “comfort” of God into someone’s life? Through the recounting of your own suffering. And the type of suffering you go through matters, because it’s through that suffering that you know whom you are best suited to comfort.

- This gives us the answer to whom we are to focus our individual efforts on. Whom we should invest in. Remember, as a believer you are a minister, and as a minister you are to participate in the work of ministry, and it’s through your “Sorrows that you earn your Credentials”.
  - You lost a child - minister to those who have lost children. You lost a spouse - minister to those who have lost spouses. You’ve been fired from a job - minister to those who have just been fired from a job. You’re broke - minister to someone who is broke. You have been divorced, minister to those who have been divorced.
- Just remember, there can never be comfort without suffering, and it’s through your suffering that you earn the right to minister to those in similar need.

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- This morning, we pick back up with the study of 2 Corinthians. Last week we finished up with Chapter 1 verses 4-7. In those verses Paul gave us a deep dive into the Biblical concept of comfort paired with suffering. We learned that these two are mutually inclusive of one another.
    - In other words, one proceeds the other. Specifically, we learned that it is through suffering that we are equipped to bring comfort to those who are suffering. If I have been deathly sick, I am now equipped to minister to those who are currently deathly sick.
    - If I have lost a spouse, I am now equipped to minister to those who have just lost a spouse (in a way that others who have not lost a spouse could never minister to someone). If I lost a child, broke, fired etc. You get the point.
- The circumstances from which I have suffered have equipped me to minister to others in the same circumstance. Now quick, before diving into today's scriptures, let's back up and re-read 2 Corinthians 1:3-7 one more time for context.

2 Cor. 1:3 **Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of mercies and God of all comfort,**
2 Cor. 1:4 **who comforts us in all our affliction so that we will be able to comfort those who are in any affliction with the comfort with which we ourselves are comforted by God.**
2 Cor. 1:5 **For just as the sufferings of Christ are ours in abundance, so also our comfort is abundant through Christ.**
2 Cor. 1:6 **But if we are afflicted, it is for your comfort and salvation; or if we are comforted, it is for your comfort, which is effective in the patient enduring of the same sufferings which we also suffer;**
2 Cor. 1:7 **and our hope for you is firmly grounded, knowing that as you are partners in our sufferings, so also you are in our comfort.**

- I want you to remember the circumstances in which Paul wrote this letter.
    - The sequence looked like this:
        - 1) Paul made his first visit to Corinth after establishing the church.
        - 2) He then wrote a letter after that visit, but that letter was lost.
        - 3) Paul then received a letter from the house of Pauly (A person who attended that church), and in this letter he is told that things aren't going well.
        - 4) This prompts Paul to write another letter, the letter we know to be 1 Corinthians.
        - 5) But evidently that letter doesn't accomplish what Paul wants it to accomplish, which then prompts him to return for a 2nd visit. Scholars call this visit the "painful visit" - which then prompts Paul to write again.
        - 6) A 3rd letter, which scholars call the "severe letter". It's called the severe letter because it was very severe in tone and it cost him a lot to write it (mentally), and we know this to be the case, because it's alluded to in 2 Corinthians 2. It's

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considered “severe” because had the letter not been successful, it is conceivable there might have been a final rupture between Paul and the church that he founded.

- That letter seems to be lost as well, but many scholars believe it’s captured inside Chapters 10-13 of 2 Corinthians. We don’t know this to be the case for sure, but that’s what has been speculated. Having said that, whether it is or isn’t, is neither here nor there.

- What matters, and what we do need to understand, is that Paul started this church, and they have some serious problems, and he is desperately trying to hold them together. His method of doing so comes from the letter we are studying here today.
  - Think about that for a moment. We live in the digital age - phones, emails, direct messenger. And, even more than that we have planes and cars, which means we can travel a long distance in a short time.
  - Remember, Paul is writing this letter from Ephesus, which is roughly some 894 miles away if you drove it today. So, just imagine walking that far. This is an important fact to understand, because it means he can’t just hop on a plane and head down there.
  - Also, imagine how he must have felt when he received the bad news about this church. How worried and stressed he would have been. I’m sure he began immediately trying to figure out how he could rectify their situation. The only way he could do it, given his circumstances, was to write them a letter.
    - And the letter couldn’t just be any letter, because everything hinged on it, which required him to really think about what he was saying. That letter is the letter you and I are studying here today. I’m trying to give you a sense of what’s at *stake* here.
- Think about it in your own terms. You ever started a business, a church, or even taken over a group or organization of some sort? Maybe it was becoming the head of, or in charge of, the PTA, or the Little League, or Girl Scouts, or some women’s or men’s group at the church?
  - If so, more than likely you experienced some sort of conflict within the group, and you probably worked hard trying to bring everyone together; trying to get them all on the same page. I have found myself in this situation many times, and every time it required people to put down their personal bias, and agenda, and focus on the common good or purpose of the organization.
    - And it’s tough to do when you are able to talk directly to the individuals in the group. Just imagine trying to do it long distance through a letter.
    - Based on my experience, that would almost be impossible, but that’s what Paul is doing here, which means every word he writes and the way he writes it matters. He’s got one shot at making them think, pause, and process the whole situation, which is why he says this in verses 6-7:

2 Cor. 1:6 **But if we are afflicted, it is for your comfort and salvation; or if we are comforted, it is for your comfort, which is effective in the patient enduring of the same sufferings which we also suffer;**
2 Cor. 1:7 **and our hope for you is firmly grounded, knowing that as you are**

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partners in our sufferings, so also you are in our comfort.

- He's trying to establish trust through common ground, which then will help reestablish his authority. From there he then moves on to a statement that he often uses, which shows up in verse 8, where he says:
  - For we do not want you to be unaware (the Greek says ignorant). Another way to say it is, you need to know what's going on here. I don't want you to be kept in the dark. So,

2 Cor. 1:8 **For we do not want you to be unaware, brothers *and sisters,* of our affliction which occurred in Asia, that we were burdened excessively, beyond our strength, so that we despaired even of life.**

- There is a lot to unpack here in verse 8. First, remember, Paul is God's man and so are the men who are with him. God has called them out, set these men aside for the laying of the foundation of the Church. Our Church body finds its roots with these men.
- But I want you to notice something. They don't get the luxury of avoiding affliction, and not only are they not afforded the opportunity of avoiding affliction, but their affliction is also far beyond their strength to bear it. Paul said they were burdened excessively beyond their strength.
  - I want you to look at what's happening to what is arguably the Greatest Apostle who ever lived, (at least in my opinion), not to mention he's the greatest writer of the New Testament. Look at what God allows him and the others to go through. They are burdened so badly that it's more than they can bear.
    - So much so, that Paul says they despaired life. When you read it in the Greek, it means they despaired life to the point of finding it difficult to go on living. In other words, they wanted to die.
- Paul's words tell us something. They paint for us a picture, and the picture is this. For Paul and his friends, life on earth was never comfortable. And by the way, that is the consistent testimony of scripture for all of God's people, which means the same holds true for us. Which is tough for us to understand, but it's still true.
  - But what's even more difficult for us to understand is why God allows it to be this way. Paul tells us why. So that you and I can become a fully developed useful tool for the work of ministry, and our suffering is what causes or forces this process to happen.
- One of my favorite quotes comes from Benjamin Franklin is "Pain instructs". The Bible says, "Pain Equips". I want you to think about what I am saying here. God's method for the work of ministry to become manifest in your life comes through the training, of which suffering brings.
  - What that tells us is that we need to be ready and expect suffering to come our way. There is no other way around it, and just like Paul, no believer is exempt. Having said that, they did have an advantage over us when it came to suffering. It was much easier for them to accept suffering than it is for us.

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- That's because of the environment they were raised in versus the one we were raised in. Also, they had an advantage because of the way they were taught versus the way we have been taught.
  - You see, at no point during those people's lives did they ever actually believe life was supposed to be good, because it wasn't. Life for someone living in that day was hard, so hard times were nothing new for them.
  - But for us on the other hand, we have no clue. We've been taught and believe that we should never be inconvenienced in any way, that life should be smooth. Especially in America, everything we do is set up around making things smoother, more efficient, quicker, and more convenient. Which is an issue, a big issue for several reasons.

- Number 1 - it's a big issue because if we believe we shouldn't be inconvenienced, and yet suffering or being inconvenienced is God's method for equipping us for the work of the ministry, then you have an automatic built-in paradigm problem.
  - Your mindset is completely wrong, which leaves you confused, stressed, and depressed, saying, "Why me". Many times, when we say, "why me", our Christian brothers and sisters will say, "I'm sorry you're going through this or that, and I don't why it's happening, but I'm sure it's for a reason".
  - Folks, it is for a reason, and here it is in Paul's own words. You are inconvenienced. I use the word inconvenience because, for most of us (not all of us), but for most of us, in comparison to what Paul experienced, it's inconvenienced at best.
    - We are inconvenienced for our development, our molding process, all so that we can be equipped for the work of the ministry.
    - But wait a minute preacher. You're the one who does the work of ministry. No, no, you are as responsible for doing the work of the ministry as I am. But unfortunately, once again, much like everything else in society, even the church (speaking loosely of the institution itself - the staff, the programs, the building), it has become bent toward serving those within its four walls.
  - Believers often say, "You know, we haven't been to church in a while, so we need to go to church". That language is totally incorrect. You are the church. You are simply going to an assembly (gathering) with other believers. You're not going to church.
    - The church was not designed to be like going to the movie. It was designed to be a place where we as believers come together, support one another, assume each other's burdens, serve each other, lift each other up through fellowship, and become stronger through the teaching of God's Word.
    - All so that, as we go throughout our week, we can do the work of ministry and effect change for the Kingdom inside a dark and dying world. Your job as a believer is to do the work of ministry as you go throughout your day. Gathering as an assembly simply helps you do that job better.
- And so that begs the question, how are you doing with the job God's called you to do? Obviously, that's a rhetorical question, but it's something we should all ask ourselves. How are you doing? Honestly, if you aren't doing too good, it is probably because of your mindset and your paradigm.
  - And the church (the institution itself) has evolved us into this paradigm. They didn't

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do it on purpose, but it happened, and for that reason, we don't look on ourselves as ministers. We look at ourselves as the ones being ministered to.

- You know what's interesting about that thought process? Whether you look at yourself as a minister or not (which you are), the world looks at you that way. Think about it, why do you think non-believers clam up every time you tell them you're a Christian? It's because they view you in the same light as a minister, and they automatically hold you to the same standard.
- And so, once again, how are you doing with what God expects you to do? God's method for our development comes by way of suffering. Now we know why he allows it to enter our lives. And in keeping with that theme, Paul moves into his next set of statements.
- Where he says this in verses 9-11:

2 Cor. 1:9 **Indeed, *we had* the sentence of death within ourselves so that we would not trust in ourselves, but in God who raises the dead,**
2 Cor. 1:10 **who rescued us from so great a *danger of* death, and will rescue *us,* He on whom we have set our hope. And He will yet deliver us,**
2 Cor. 1:11 ***if* you also join in helping us through your prayers, so that thanks may be given by many persons in our behalf for the favor *granted* to us through *the prayers of* many.**

- What Paul is trying to do through his words is make a connection with these people, relate to them, humanize who he is, explain how he and the others have suffered on their behalf, for their comfort.
  - Now, through his words there is an implied question.
  - Remember, this church is facing two problems:
    - 1) They have allowed false teaching to creep into the church.
    - 2) There is some individual that is causing dissension.
  - He is doing so by questioning who Paul is, along with Paul's Apostolic Authority. And that's a serious battle for Paul, because that man (the one causing the dissension, whoever he is), the one causing the problem, he lives among them, and Paul does not.
- So, part of the benefit of Paul mentioning his suffering is to leave them with an implied question, something he wants them to think about, and that is, "you know that we have suffered for your sake to the point of death. We've shared in the burdens of Christ, and therefore we are one with you".
  - So, the question is, has this man (the one who is causing all the problems) done the same? Has he been afflicted beyond what he could bear, or is he simply going about his day causing dissension? Obviously, the implied answer is no. He has not.
  - And not only is he not bearing burdens beyond what He can bare, he's creating more burden for the church and for Paul, the founder of the church. This man has questioned who Paul is, and now, Paul is asking them to think about it. He's asking

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them to logically think about the entirety of the situation.

- I think Paul's statement in Verse 9 is very interesting, because in his statement he speaks of a fact, one that you and I must embrace as believers.

2 Cor. 1:9 **Indeed, *we had* the sentence of death within ourselves so that we would not trust in ourselves, but in God who raises the dead.**

- I want to start out by focusing on the words "we had". At first it sounded as if they had it, but now they don't. The truth is, when you study the original Greek words "we had", specifically the part of speech, along with the definition, you will find that first it's a verb and second, its definition means "to have, hold".
  - The usage in the Greek says I have, hold, possess, which means they are carrying it with them. Inside them. But, carrying what? A sentence of death. And guess what, we carry the exact same thing.
- Now, at first glance you might say that's terrible or depressing or unfair. But if you understand it, the way Paul is saying it here, it's liberating and empowering, because look at what Paul says next:

2 Cor. 1:9 **Indeed, *we had* the sentence of death within ourselves so that we would not trust in ourselves, but in God who raises the dead.**

- The key words here are "so that". In other words, they carry with them this understanding of this sentence of death, which means, they know they are going to die physically but not spiritually.
  - And why did He place that feeling with them? We get the answer in the last half of the verse "so that they would not trust in themselves, but in God who raises the dead". They know they are going to die physically, but they trust in the God who raises the dead.
    - Paraphrasing it for you; if you understand, you carry with you a sentence of death, that means you accept death as a reality, but a temporary one, because you also understand that God is going to raise you into your new heavenly body, that you will be living with Him in eternity forever.
    - When that understanding truly sinks in, which can only come through the faith He gave you, it will cause you to trust Him with the here and now. Next, Paul drives this point home when he says this in verse 10:

2 Cor. 1:10 **who rescued us from so great a *danger of* death, and will rescue *us,* He on whom we have set our hope. And He will yet deliver us,**

- If you are a believer this morning, you can rest easy knowing God has rescued you from the danger of death. And not only has He rescued you, but Paul also says He will rescue you. Meaning, He will continue to rescue you, but only if you do what? Nothing. It's done.

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- Remember, Paul is writing this letter to believers, so it assumes the people who are reading it are Saved. Which means, for those who are saved He has rescued you, and will continue rescuing you until the day of your death. Which is why Paul said, “He on whom we have set our hope. And He will yet deliver us”.
- God has saved you and no matter what happens, even though you carry the sentence of death, you can set your hope on Him, knowing that one day you will be resurrected into newness of life.
  - So, guess what this means for you and I sitting here today? If you understand this, if you understand that for however many days you have left on this earth, no matter how hard it gets, that God has got you.
  - If you can embrace this concept then you can live out your remaining days, trusting and knowing that the God who saved you, is also the God that sustains you, and that your suffering wasn’t for naught. In other words, it had and has real purpose and meaning.
  - And finally, Paul closes this section with verse 11 where he says:

2 Cor. 1:11 *if* you also join in helping us through your prayers, so that thanks may be given by many persons in our behalf for the favor *granted* to us through *the prayers of* many.

- He asked them to join in with them in with a prayer of thanksgiving, so that through many, they could thank God for the “favor” they have been shown. The word favor is an English translation. The Greek word is “Grace”.
  - Now, if you’re really tracking with me through this text of scripture this morning, at this point you might be a little confused. I mean, Paul just said in verse 8 he didn’t want the brothers to be unprepared. They were so burdened and afflicted that they wanted to die. So, immediately that prompts a question in my mind. Just exactly what “Favor” or “Grace” is he talking about here?
    - He tells everyone to pray and praise God and give thanks to God for the Favor and Grace they have been shown. What is He talking about? I mean seriously, this church, the one he faithfully started, is falling apart. It doesn’t seem to me things are going too well, so what is he telling everyone to be thankful for? What favor is he talking about?
    - I have a few Christian friends in my life that use this word from time to time. Mainly when something good happens in their life. I have often heard them say, God showed me favor.”
    - In other words, they received something positive in their life, maybe monetary, might be a house or a car - something temporal, and their theory is, God gave me this because I am a believer and therefore, this is His favor bestowed in my life.
  - The question is, based on what we just studied, does that line up with the context of favor in a Biblical sense? It doesn’t, does it? The favor Paul is talking about here, is God’s Grace in his life as it relates to eternity.
  - Verse 11 - May many give thanks to God, for the Grace He has bestowed upon us

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- The question is, Grace for what? To obtain the answer you must keep Paul's words in the context of what he has been talking about. This Favor or Grace in the Greek must relate to Paul's previous words, where he said he was thankful for something. So, what could it be?
    - First of all, let me say God's ultimate show of Grace in our life comes is by way of Salvation.
    - Ephesians 2:8-9 says it this way:

Eph. 2:8 **For by grace you have been saved through faith; and this *is* not of yourselves, *it is* the gift of God;**
Eph. 2:9 **not a result of works, so that no one may boast.**

- Grace is God's unmerited favor in your life. And as I said, its primary function relates to Salvation and Eternity. God's Grace/Favor was offered to you, even though you were unworthy of such an offer.
    - But Favor/Grace doesn't always relate to salvation directly. It also shows up in other ways in our life as well, and Paul is highlighting one of those ways here in verse 9 when he says:

Eph. 2:9 **Indeed, *we had* the sentence of death within ourselves so that we would not trust in ourselves, but in God who raises the dead,**

- You see, Paul realized that because the sentence of death was a reality in their lives, that too was a form of God's Grace. In other words, because they were saved, along with the fact that God had given them the faith to understand what that meant.
    - Which was that they would die physically but never die spiritually. Because they were given that reality by God, that fact forced them to trust in God and not in themselves. This was a form of God's Grace. Interesting, isn't it?
- From our perspective, and certainly from the prosperity movement's perspective, we, or they wouldn't call this Grace. Paul has been burdened to the point of death, bringing him to a place which is more than he can bear, and he carries with him a sentence of death. He says to this church, join with him and give God thanks for the *favor* He has shown us.
    - That seems strange, doesn't it? It does if your mind is set on the temporal (on the here and now), but it doesn't if your mind is focused on eternity. And that's where Paul and his fellow "sufferers of the faith" are.
        - Also, it's worth noting that when Paul asks *if* you also join in helping us through your prayers. The words "Join in helping" is the translation of a Greek word used only here in the New Testament: *synypourgounton*. It consists of three words meaning with, under, and work. It paints a picture of laborers bowed down under some heavy burden that they are working hard together to lift.
        - That gives you a better sense of what he is saying here, and once again, it keeps with the theme of his letter, which is that he is in the same boat they are. They

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are together. God's "Favor/Grace" in scripture isn't tied to the here and now, to stuff or temporal items. It's tied to eternity, along with anything that makes eternity a reality in our lives while we still live here on earth.

- Now let me say this before we close and move on this morning. There are three Christian views to the Biblical words "Favor and or Grace", and two of them are on opposite ends of the extreme. One falls in the middle. The one that falls in the middle is the actual correct Biblical use of these words and is where we need to fall.
  - Let me talk about all three quick this morning. This first view shows up with the prosperity movement. It sees all things that are temporal and good (stuff) as a show of God's Grace & Favor. This person often holds to the view that says, all things that are positive and good in our life come from God, and all things negative - sickness, death, financial problems, whatever it may be - come from the Enemy/Satan. And this is actually true, but not in the sense that they use it.
    - They mean it in an earthly sense not a spiritual sense. They take their view from scriptures like James 1:17, and then bend it to fit their narrative.
    - Listen to what James 1:17 says:

James 1:17 Every good thing given, and every perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of lights, with whom there is no variation or shifting shadow.

- Now, if you just read that verse by itself it would seem to suggest that all good things come from God. Which then forces us to assume that if all good things come from above, then the inverse of this would say all bad things come from below. And, yes, this is true. But not in the way the prosperity person might think.
  - The key to understanding this verse lies in the definition of "Good thing" and "Perfect Gift", and to better understand what God is saying here in James you must back up and read the entire section in context.
  - Which begins at the beginning of Chapter 1, and it is all about the Testing of your Faith. In the interest of time, we will back up to verse 12 and read it all the way through verse 18. And from there you will understand what this "Good Thing" is, along with what the "Bad Thing" is.

James 1:12 Blessed is a man who perseveres under trial; for once he has been approved, he will receive the crown of life which *the Lord* has promised to those who love Him.
James 1:13 No one is to say when he is tempted, "I am being tempted by God"; for God cannot be tempted by evil, and He Himself does not tempt anyone.
James 1:14 But each one is tempted when he is carried away and enticed by his own lust.
James 1:15 Then when lust has conceived, it gives birth to sin; and sin, when it has run its course, brings forth death.
James 1:16 Do not be deceived, my beloved brothers *and sisters.*

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James 1:17 Every good thing given and every perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of lights, with whom there is no variation or shifting shadow.
James 1:18 In the exercise of His will He gave us birth by the word of truth, so that we would be a kind of first fruits among His creatures.

- So, this “Good Thing” and “Perfect Gift” comes by way of what? Through the exercising of “His Will” by “The Word of Truth”, which tells us that this “Good thing” has nothing to do with anything this world gives us - it’s not wealth or money can buy!
    - But the prosperity movement has tied all Good Things to meaning earthly things, and that’s simply not the case. Now, let me say this, at its inception, this prosperity thought process started out with the best of intentions (as most good things do).
        - It started out as a good thing, but soon slowly evolved into what it is today, which is very Spiritually Unhealthy. This is the way it always happens when humans get their hands on something. Good often turns to excess which then evolves into bad.
- I would like to talk more about the origin of this movement, but before I do, I want to talk about its counterpart, because its counterpart actually precipitated the prosperity movement. The counterpart view comes from the other end of the spectrum, and it says that suffering and or hardship is proof you are saved.
    - That if you aren’t suffering A LOT - you aren’t Christian. That suffering is the primary sign you are a Christian. This may not be a view you’re familiar with, but it’s real, and it existed way before the prosperity movement ever came about.
    - A person who holds to this view (in an extreme way) is called a Masochist, and the practice of this view is Masochism. The reality is this person takes suffering and turns it into a “demigod”.
        - In extreme cases, this individual says when temporal and or earthly good things happen to a Christian person, it must have come from the enemy. Their Spiritual Satisfaction is derived from suffering. The sense is, If I’m suffering, I am Spiritual.
- And just like the prosperity movement, this too is wrong and Spiritually Unhealthy. But why? I mean, isn’t this what Paul is saying here in 2 Corinthians? The answer is no - he’s not. That’s not what he’s saying.
    - Which leads me to the third and correct Biblical view of suffering, and that is, Sin causes us to suffer, and suffering is part of a fallen world. But God takes that suffering and turns it to good, for His Glory. He uses it as a tool to equip you for ministry.
    - If you suffer, it is not so that you can say, ‘Woe is me, I am suffering’. Look everyone, I am suffering because the enemy is after me, and therefore this lets you know I am Christian. Everyone suffers, even unbelievers. Suffering is a part of life.
        - And yes, the enemy is after you. And yes, God often allows suffering to take place in the life of the Christian. But it’s so that He can point you away from the temporal and back to the eternal. As I said, we will suffer, it’s the reality of living in a fallen world.

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        - But the suffering in and of itself is not the point. The point is what comes from the suffering, which is your Spiritual Development. God uses it to equip you for the work of ministry.
- And that brings me to my final point of the day. If good things happen to me, should I feel bad? No, of course not. Use it to God's Glory but be careful in sending a message to the world that says, 'Look at this good thing that happened, it's because God is showing favor towards me because I am a Christian'.
    - That's what the prosperity movement tries to convey. The problem with that message is if earthly "Good Things" show to the world the "Favor" of God in your life, then what does the world think when "Bad Things" happen to a Christian? Good things and Bad things happening are a part of life. They are a part of the world we live in. It's okay when Good Things happen but use them to God's Glory!
    - If God allowed a good thing to happen to you, then ask yourself the question, 'How can I glorify Him with it?' You get the point, and to keep this all in perspective, remember, it's all about Him, all the time! And it's never about what we can obtain on this earth.

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- Last week, we finished our teaching with verse 11, and now we move into the second half of the chapter. The half that some of your Bibles may have entitled, “Paul’s Integrity”.
  - And why is it titled Paul’s Integrity? Because Paul is desperately trying to defend who he is to this Corinthian Church (the one he founded). Remember, there is a person in this church (we don’t know who he is), who is exerting a lot of energy trying to discredit Paul, specifically his Apostolic Authority.
  - Saying that he is no different than anyone else, that he has no special authority, and so in the next 12 verses we are going to journey headlong into Paul defending who he is.
- Now, before we do, remember, leading up to these verses he’s already let the church know that he, along with the others, are one with them, and that they have suffered for the cause of Jesus Christ. And, more than that, they suffered greatly, excessively, to the point beyond which they could physically bare it, “To the point of death”.
  - And, they not only did it for Christ (for the sake of the Gospel), but also did it for them, for this church. He explained it this way in verses 6&7:

2 Cor. 1:6 **But if we are afflicted, it is for your comfort and salvation; or if we are comforted, it is for your comfort, which is effective in the patient enduring of the same sufferings which we also suffer;**
2 Cor. 1:7 **And our hope for you is firmly grounded, knowing that as you are sharers of our sufferings, so also you are sharers of our comfort.**

- So, the message is this, we are one, together in this battle, and you should never forget it. By the way the same still holds true today. As believers, you and I as brothers and sisters, united in Christ, are all one, and we are called to suffer together in this life.
  - Which means when you hurt, I hurt, and when you feel comfort, I feel comfort. We are one. And so, the structure of the letter begins with an opening Salutation, which included Paul letting them know he was an Apostle of Jesus Christ (appointed) by the will of God.
  - Then, he moved into reminding them of who God is. He is the one who comforts us all. Then, he lets them know that he and the others are with them through suffering and through comfort, we are one together. He establishes who he is, and how they are one with this church.
    - And now he moves to defending His integrity, and that’s where we pick up next:

2 Cor. 1:12 **For our proud confidence is this: the testimony of our conscience, that in holiness and godly sincerity, not in fleshly wisdom but in the grace of God, we have conducted ourselves in the world, and especially toward you.**
2 Cor. 1:13 **For we write nothing else to you than what you read and understand, and I hope you will understand until the end;**
2 Cor. 1:14 **just as you also partially did understand us, that we are your reason to be proud as you also are ours, on the day of our Lord Jesus.**

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- Let's pause here for just a minute to paraphrase what Paul is saying. He says our proud confidence (the Greek says - the boasting) is this: the testimony of our conscience, that in holiness and godly sincerity. In today's terms we might say, "The Lord as my witness". That's the sense here!
    - Have you ever heard someone say that, or have you ever said it yourself? If you have, what you are really saying is, "I am telling you the truth" or "As God is my witness". When we use that phrase it's the same thing as them saying, "My conscience testifies to this, through the Holy Spirit as my witness".
        - Now obviously, I was not sitting there the day Paul, or his understudy transcribed this letter, therefore I can't say for sure what he meant, but you kind of get the sense of weightiness or anxiety within their words.
        - Meaning, we don't generally say, "The Lord as my witness" unless we are desperately trying to get someone to believe us, right? And so, for that reason, along with the background of the letter, this gives me good reason to believe that what I am telling you is the truth.
- Next, Paul says in verse 13-14:

2 Cor. 1:13 **For we write nothing else to you than what you read and understand, and I hope you will understand until the end;**
2 Cor. 1:14 **just as you also partially did understand us, that we are your reason to be proud as you also are ours, on the day of our Lord Jesus.**

- He says, for we write nothing less to you than just what you read and understand. I love Paul's choice of words here, mainly because I say the same thing myself, but in a different way.
    - When Paul says, "For we write nothing else", what he is saying is, "What I am telling you, is exactly the way it is". Nothing more and nothing less. Another way to say it might be you can take it for face value. And why?
    - Because I have no bias, no hidden agenda, therefore it is exactly what I say it is. Then he says, "Just as you partially did understand us". Now these words are important for us to understand, and for a reason that's much deeper than you may realize. And so, what is that reason?
        - It's that through Paul's words we are reaffirmed about what we learned in the introduction of this letter. Which was that Paul's previous letters didn't seem to correct their behavior. Not totally. Which is what led him to write this letter.
        - This letter was written as a last-ditch effort, trying to fully straighten out this church's behavior. That's why he says you "partially understood", because obviously, they didn't "fully understand". And that's important for the validation of our understanding of the context of the letter.
    - Next, he says, "We are your reason to be proud as you also are ours."
- Last week I talked about how it was that Paul was trying to humanize or make a connection with the people in this church, which is strange given the fact he founded it, but regardless, once again, we see it here one more time.

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- That is the whole reason he is saying, “We are your reason to be proud as you also are ours”. It’s for the promotion of unity through understanding, which is essential and is key to the success of the church.
- This trait, unity, is still an essential key to the church’s success today. It’s also an essential key for any group or organization to succeed, which tells us that the leader’s primary purpose is to get the group in alignment. Because, once alignment takes hold, you achieve Synergy, and Synergy is where the magic happens.
  - Until the church is unified, until we are all in alignment, we will never be maximized in God’s will for us here on earth. But, let me expound just a minute of this concept of Unity, because, from a Biblical standpoint, it doesn’t mean we all get along, or that we never disagree.
  - On the contrary. It means if we all focus on Christ, (i.e. His word), and the instruction that comes from His Word, unity will be a natural byproduct of what we focus on as a group.

- Maybe a better example would be this; pick a dot on the map. You and I may disagree on the best mode of transportation, or route to get there, but if we remain focused on the goal, which is the destination, then the details (whether we take a train, plane, or automobile) will become a moot point.
  - But what does it require for unification to take place? First, it takes a clear understanding of the destination, or we might say the mission. And to understand the mission, you must understand the purpose or the why as we might call it. More specifically, the why to the what. Everyone must understand why we are doing what we do.
    - Before the beginning of the service this morning we handed everyone a piece of paper with a question that asked, “Why are you here today?” I haven’t looked at them yet, so if you wrote your name on it, don’t worry it is anonymous.
    - But for a fun exercise, and to prove my point, I wanted to ask everyone this question. I know it sounds elementary, but if you think about it, does it really? Now this is a simple and straightforward question, right? Wouldn’t you agree? And the answer itself should be straightforward as well. And maybe it is, but let’s see if that’s the case.
  - You see, if we as a group are confused about why we are here, then there is no way for us to maximize our effectiveness for the Kingdom of God. The answer to that question should not be obscure, unknown, or vague, because the answer comes from God’s Word.
  - But, if you are not being taught God’s Word correctly, or you don’t know how to study it for yourself correctly, then more than likely your answer might be obscure or vague, or unknown, and if that’s the case then ultimately, your belief will be drawn from what you think, or feel, or what you’ve been told, rather than what God said it is.
    - And if you think about it, this is really concerning, because if we can’t agree on this foundational and fundamental question, then we’re all in trouble. But guess what? Thankfully for all of us sitting here today there is an answer, and it lies in the pages of God’s Holy Manuscript and it’s not obscure or vague.
    - Matter a fact, it’s the opposite of obscure. It’s pointed and direct, and it’s

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available right at your fingertips. You see from God's Word we receive it all. Our conviction, which leads to Salvation. And after Salvation that same conviction is what then leads to your Sanctification or your "Spiritual Maturity".

- Through God's instructions we learn it all. We learn what's Holy and acceptable to Him, how we should act and react. What we should do and what we shouldn't do. What we should fear and what we shouldn't fear. Ultimately, we learn that God is Sovereign and in control of His creation.

- Which means, anything and everything that we will ever face or contend with, the answers are right at our fingertips through the Power of the Scriptures. And so, when the church comes into alignment with God's Word, meaning we all together understand the correct answers, that's (as I said) where the magic happens.
  - That's when the church (you and I) become an unstoppable force for the Kingdom. And that's why unity is so important.
  - We pick up next in 2 Corinthians.

2 Cor. 1:15 In this confidence I intended at first to come to you, so that you might twice receive a blessing;
2 Cor. 1:16 that is, to pass your way into Macedonia, and again from Macedonia to come to you, and by you to be helped on my journey to Judea.
2 Cor. 1:17 Therefore, I was not vacillating when I intended to do this, was I? Or what I decide, do I decide according to the flesh, so that with me there will be yes, yes and no, no *at the same time?*

- Let's take it from the top as they say, starting with verse 15. Immediately Paul goes into a defense of something he had previously told this church he would do. Which was what? He previously told them he would come visit them, but he hasn't. And, evidently, he has now gotten word that they were upset because he hasn't done what he told them he would do. He hasn't kept his word.
  - Which helped to "fuel the fire" of the person in this church who was trying to undermine Paul's authority in the first place. Now, the question is when and where did he tell them he was coming, and did he lie to them? For the answer let's got to 1 Corinthians 16:2-9 and find out what he said.

1 Cor. 16:1 Now concerning the collection for the saints, as I directed the churches of Galatia, so you are to do as well.
1 Cor. 16:2 On the first day of every week, each of you is to put aside and save as he may prosper, so that no collections *need to* be made when I come.
1 Cor. 16:3 When I arrive, whomever you approve, I will send them with letters to take your gift to Jerusalem;
1 Cor. 16:4 and if it is appropriate for me to go also, they will go with me.
1 Cor. 16:5 But I will come to you after I go through Macedonia; for I am going through Macedonia,
1 Cor. 16:6 and perhaps I will stay with you or even spend the winter, so that you

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may send me on my way wherever I go.
1 Cor. 16:7 **For I do not want to see you now *just* in passing; for I hope to remain with you for some time, if the Lord permits.**
1 Cor. 16:8 **But I will remain in Ephesus until Pentecost;**
1 Cor. 16:9 **for a wide door for effective *service* has opened to me, and there are many adversaries.**

- Obviously, there is an entire message wound up in these verses, but that would require me to spend the rest of the service teaching on these verses.
  - In these verses Paul told them that he would come back soon and stay with them. And he made it clear that he didn't want to come just for a quick visit. No, he wanted to wait so he could come and stay with them for a while, possibly all the way through winter. As I said, I don't want to exegete all these verses, but I do want to touch on a few things really quick.
- First, I want to highlight the New Testament requirement for giving versus the Old Testament requirement for giving or tithing. In the Old Testament the requirement was 10%, and that lines up with what most of us have been taught our entire lives, that we were to give 10% of whatever we made. But now, in New Testament the mandate has changed. Look at Verse 2.

1 Cor. 16:2 **On the first day of every week, each of you is to put aside and save as he may prosper, so that no collections *need to* be made when I come.**

- Other than when I taught 1 Corinthians, this will be the first time in the history of our church that I have ever taught anything on giving or tithing. And why? Because your tithe and giving is none of my business. That's why we have two treasurers in this church. They are the only ones that know what people give. They also reconcile the giving and approve whatever we give.
  - I have zero clue what people give and don't want to know. It's between you and God. But having said that, you are commanded to give, and if you feel 10% is good, then so be it. But Paul tells this Corinthian church to give as you have been prospered, he didn't say give 10%.
  - But there's a catch to all of this, and one you may not be aware of, and it lies in the words "and save as he may prosper". I think the best way to demonstrate what Paul means is through the story of the widow's mite, which shows up in Mark 12:41-44.

Mark 12:41 **And *Jesus* sat down opposite the treasury,**
and *began* watching how the people were putting money into the treasury; and many rich people were putting in large amounts.
Mark 12:42 **And a poor widow came and put in two lepta (lep-tuh) coins,**
which amount to a quadrans. (quad-rans)
Mark 12:43 **Calling His disciples to Him, He said to them, "Truly I say to you,**
this poor widow put in more than all the contributors to the treasury;

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Mark 12:44 for they all put in out of their surplus, but she, out of her poverty, put in all she owned, all she had to live on."

- In First Corinthians Paul says, "they were to save as they had been prospered, or save as they had been blessed," and then of course they would give what they saved to the church. But in the story of the widow's mite, this seems to conflict with what Paul said, and it's definitely in conflict with what many churches teach today.
    - But honestly you can't totally blame the church for its confusion. Because based on what 1 Corinthians 16:2-8 says in our English translation, it seems to clearly teach a concept that supports we are to give out of our abundance, but then in verse 43-44 Mark says:

Mark 12:43 Calling His disciples to Him, He said to them, "Truly I say to you, this poor widow put in more than all the contributors to the treasury;
Mark 12:44 for they all put in out of their surplus, but she, out of her poverty, put in all she owned, all she had to live on."

- There is something powerful happening here, and that is, Paul said, give as you have prospered. Mark reinforces this principle by telling us these rich people did exactly that. But then we have the widow, who didn't do that, yet she is the one Jesus seems to be praising.
    - So, what's this all about? Is the Bible in conflict? If it is, we all need to go home. But if it's not, we need to know why. So, what's the answer? The prosperity Paul is speaking of isn't necessarily financial. It can be, and it is in the situation he's speaking about, but it's not always.
    - You see at the end of the day, the widow gave all that she had, not from her abundance financially, but from her heart, even though she was broke. She had been prospered in other ways. You too have also been prospered in ways other than financial. You just might not realize it, but it's true.
- If you're saved you've prospered, and honestly you could stop right there, but we will go on. You feel the sunshine yesterday - you've prospered. You live in America - you've prospered. Your kids are healthy - you've prospered. You've got a job - you've prospered. You have a roof over your head, food to eat – prospered. Your family still together – prospered. Mama doing well - Papa doing well – prospered. And the list goes on and on.
    - Prosperity shows up in many forms. It's anything that God has done for you. But honestly, you know what's the most prosperous thing God has done for you. He gave you access to "The peace that passes all understanding". The peace that only God can bring. That is true prosperity.
    - Now, why is this understanding of prosperity important? Because, if you think your giving is linked to your financial prosperity, you will automatically look in your bank account and say, well, I haven't been blessed financially, so I guess I don't have much to give.
        - But as I said, it's not always financial. It could be financial, but if it were financial and you used your bank account balance as a gauge of that blessing, that

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probably wouldn't work, because what if you can't manage money? You've been blessed financially, but you're not a good steward of it.

- Remember, your giving should be a direct reflection of how thankful you are for all that God's done for you in all areas of your life. But Pastor, how do I determine what to give? Your conscience. Let the conviction of your heart be your guide.
    - As I said, I don't talk about money, and we don't take up an offering here. We have a box in the back, and you can put your tithe in it. But just because we don't take up an offering doesn't mean that I don't care about the giving. I care, but not in a sense of how much we receive. I care because it's a sign of "Spiritual Maturity" in the believer.
    - And there it is again. Everything always goes back to maturity. Giving, like everything, is a matter of understanding which requires "Spiritual Maturity". By the way, no preacher should ever feel pressure to preach on giving. If the giving is down, then my only advice is to double down on the teaching of God's word to the people and let God convict them and mature them.
    - If I ever get to a place where I must ask people for money from the pulpit, then I'm done because we've lost the battle. Giving is a requirement from God, and it's between you and Him as it relates to how much you give. And, just a side bar, it's not dependent on whether you agree with the Pastor, Elders, Deacons, or whomever inside the church.
- People who give only based on agreeing with the leadership of the church should never give in the first place, because they don't understand why they are to give. So, if that's your *thought process,* to give based on you agreeing with the church leadership, I would say keep it, you're just wasting your tithe.
    - Instead, go study and find out why you should tithe, then give. It's a matter of obedience.
    - Because you guys have been faithful in giving here at our church, we have been able to do some amazing things for people in this community, which is one thing God calls us to do, to reach outside these walls and help people and other organizations. Which brings me to one final point.
- Notice how in verse 3 of 1 Corinthians 16, there was a reason for the collection of money - to give to the poorer church.

1 Cor. 16:3 When I arrive, whomever you approve, I will send them with letters to take your gift to Jerusalem;

- Paul said collect the gifts, the money, and I will send it with whomever you approve to take letters and your gifts to Jerusalem. Paul didn't keep the money, and he didn't say let me give you a blessing based on your giving, or that our ministry needs a jet, an outreach center, or another building. No, Paul said, take up an offering so he can send it to the poorer Church in Jerusalem.
    - So, we now know from 1 Corinthians 16 that Paul said he would come see them, but he was unable to do so. And here in 2 Corinthians 1:15-17, we see him defending this previous statement where he says this:

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2 Cor. 1:15 In this confidence I intended at first to come to you, so that you might twice receive a blessing;
2 Cor. 1:16 that is, to pass your way into Macedonia, and again from Macedonia to come to you, and by you to be helped on my journey to Judea.
2 Cor. 1:17 Therefore, I was not vacillating when I intended to do this, was I? Or what I decide, do I decide according to the flesh, so that with me there will be yes, yes and no, no *at the same time?*

- In verse 17, Paul says, "I was not vacillating when I intended to do this, was I? Or what I decide, do I decide according to the flesh so that with me there will be yes, yes, and no, no at the same time?" Paraphrasing here, do you think, when I told you I was coming that I did not intend to do so? Is that what you think?
    - That I was saying one thing with my mouth, (from my flesh), and another from the Spirit, so that there will be yes, yes, and no, no at the same time? Do you think I was talking out of both sides of my mouth? Seriously, do you guys really think this is the case?
    - This reminds me of a principle or a law. One that, (once again), I made up. But it's true. When judging someone based on one event or one situation, always consider the consistency of their life.
- In other words, if someone has made decisions their entire life, that are consistent, but then they decide the opposite of who they are in general. Give them the benefit of the doubt before judging them and apply a little Grace. Many times in my life I have had people get mad at me over something I knew nothing about. They often jump to conclusions without ever consulting with me first.
    - Once I find out about it, I always go directly to them and ask, "Do you really think I would do whatever it is they are mad about"? Almost always they say, "No, not really, I guess I should have talked to you first".
        - That's what Paul is saying here. "Come on people, do you really think that I would tell you I would come, but never intended to do so?" Now you see why the header in my NASB Bible at the beginning of this section says, Paul's Integrity. Moving on, let's finish the Chapter with Verses 18-24.

2 Cor. 1:18 But as God is faithful, our word to you is not yes and no.
2 Cor. 1:19 For the Son of God, Christ Jesus, who was preached among you by us—by me and Silvanus and Timothy—was not yes and no but has been yes in Him.
2 Cor. 1:20 For as many as the promises of God are, in Him they are yes; therefore, through Him also is our Amen to the glory of God through us.
2 Cor. 1:21 Now He who establishes us with you in Christ and anointed us is God,
2 Cor. 1:22 who also sealed us and gave *us* the Spirit in our hearts as a pledge.
2 Cor. 1:23 But I call God as witness to my soul, that *it was* to spare you *that* I did not come again to Corinth.
2 Cor. 1:24 Not that we domineer over your faith, but we are workers with you for your joy; for in your faith, you are standing firm.

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- Beginning with v.18 &19, Paul says, as God is faithful, so is our word, and just like Silvanus and Timothy did not vacillate, neither have I. What he is doing here is connecting himself back to reliable sources that they trust. He's saying, just like God, Silvanus and Timothy are faithful. So am I.
    - Another way to say it is, if you believe Silvanus and Timothy and the others, you should believe me, because they were trained by me and they are accountable to me. And so, he's saying, let's be clear, I am not talking out of both sides of my mouth, and I am not ambiguous with my words, nor do I vacillate when I talk. I also do not make frivolous promises, with fickle intention.
        - But wait a minute. Paul did tell him he was coming, and he didn't do it, so, isn't he kind of talking out of both sides of his mouth? I mean, honestly, he didn't keep his word - Right? No, not right. Let's look at 1 Corinthians 16:7 one more time for the truth. What did he say?

1 Cor. 16:7 **For I do not want to see you now *just* in passing; for I hope to remain with you for some time, if the Lord permits.**

- The key to all of this lies in the words "If the Lord permits". Guess what? Obviously, the Lord did not permit it. Growing up in the South, in Tennessee, I would often hear older people say something that I never really thought about until I studied Paul's words here in verse 7.
    - Back then, when someone would tell you they were going to do something, or that they were coming to see you, they would often say it like this, "I will see you then, Lord willing." Often, they would also add a little something extra to the end of the Lord willing part. They would say, Lord willing and the "Creek don't rise."
    - What they were saying was, "I will be there if the Lord permits" and "The Creek don't rise." Now, this "add on" at the end of Lord willing was obviously a cultural Southern saying, which meant 'and as long as nothing else prevents me from coming'.
- The point is, many times when we tell someone we are going to do something, it doesn't always work out. But that doesn't mean that person is immediately discredited as it relates to everything they say for the rest of their life.
    - Once again, if an individual has been consistent in their life as it relates to their actions, then give them some Grace and don't jump to conclusions. Let me also make one final point. If you are a rigid and hard person, meaning, you always draw a hard line with folks, then be prepared for others to draw a hard line with you.
    - Pretty simple concept. If you are unable to give people Grace, then don't expect any Grace to be given out to you. Or another way to say it is, "If you live by the sword, then you will die by the sword."
- Moving on to verses 20-24:

2 Cor. 1:20 **For as many as the promises of God are, in Him they are yes; therefore, through Him also is our Amen to the glory of God through us.**
2 Cor. 1:21 **Now He who establishes us with you in Christ and anointed us is God,**

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2 Cor. 1:22 who also sealed us and gave *us* the Spirit in our hearts as a pledge.
2 Cor. 1:23 But I call God as witness to my soul, that *it was* to spare you *that* I did not come again to Corinth.
2 Cor. 1:24 Not that we domineer over your faith, but we are workers with you for your joy; for in your faith, you are standing firm.

- In verses 20-24, Paul is driving home his point, which is sad when you stop to think about it for a moment. Here is the Apostle Paul who must defend who he is. I began the introduction of 2 Corinthians by telling you that Paul is dealing with a church full of people, and those people are no different than the people today.
    - And, as usual, at the core of most problems are people. It was that way with this church and it's that way with the church today. One person in this church is causing most of these problems. One person is trying to discredit Paul, which requires Paul to make a defense for who He is. It's crazy when you think about it.
- So, in verses 20-24, Paul continues his defense, beginning with v.20-22 and paraphrasing a little, he says as true as the promises of God are in Him, they are yes. Therefore, through Him also is our Amen to the glory of God through us, who sealed us and gave us the Spirit in our hearts as a pledge.
    - Another way to say it is, God said yes through His promises, and we agree with Him by saying Amen. Now, before moving right past this, I'm going to talk a little bit more about it because it's important we really understand what he's saying here. He's talking about the preaching of God.
- The Paul of the Bible is very straightforward. God made mankind in his own image, that we might love Him and enjoy Him. But mankind chose to rebel, and disobey God, therefore he was driven from the Garden. That loss also included not only alienation from God, but also included physical death.
    - And there, of course in the Garden he made a promise, and that promise was that He would redeem man through the seed of the woman and restore paradise and so forth. The focus of mankind throughout the centuries has been built on that hope, and the incarnation of Jesus Christ is a pivotal event in history. It's the fulfillment of that commitment made in the Garden of Eden, and onward.
        - So, Christ himself is the yes of all God's promises, and we agree with God when we accept Jesus as Lord. And so once again, Paul is establishing common ground with these folks through the Gospel of Jesus Christ. In other words, he's saying people, we are all on the same team.
- And then finally in verses 23-24, he says:

2 Cor. 1:23 But I call God as witness to my soul, that *it was* to spare you *that* I did not come again to Corinth.
2 Cor. 1:24 Not that we domineer over your faith, but we are workers with you for your joy; for in your faith, you are standing firm

- Paul closes the defense of His Integrity section by saying, paraphrasing once again, as

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God is my witness, God prevented me from coming, to spare you (for your benefit). That's why I did not come to you. In other words, I told you I would come, but God prevented me from coming for your own benefit.

- This tells us something. Sometimes, things don't happen because God is protecting you. Remember that. God is Sovereign and the thing that someone did or did not do. That thing that aggravated you about the individual may have been for your own protection, and just like this church didn't know why Paul didn't come, you too may not know why God didn't allow something to happen.
- When things don't work out, just say to yourself, well, I guess God had another plan. I promise you it's better to live this way. It will bring you great peace in time of high stress. And then finally, and we will close here, Paul says:

2 Cor. 1:24 Not that we domineer over your faith, but we are workers with you for your joy; for in your faith, you are standing firm.

- Basically he's saying, we are not lording over your faith. We are coworkers. We are one with you. It's the same theme repeated in a different way. Trust me, we are one with God and we are one with you, therefore, if you are going to listen to someone, listen to me. Don't listen to this person causing all this trouble inside the church.

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- Welcome back to our study of 2 Corinthians, where after completing Chapter 1 we are now ready to move into Chapter 2, and at this point we should begin to pick up some speed, given the nature and the flow of Paul's writings.
    - Last week we ended Chapter 1 with Paul explaining why it was he hadn't come to see them yet. In 1 Corinthians 16, he told them that he didn't want to come see them at that moment. Instead, he wanted to wait and come when he could stay with them for a while. He stated that maybe he would come at the start of winter and stay with them the entire time.
    - But, as we discovered, that didn't happen, and his lack in keeping that commitment helped fuel the fire of one individual in the church, a "nay-sayer", a man who had garnered strength within in this church. He gathered a few select people for his crusade against Paul, where he, along with others, began saying,
        - Paul wasn't special, he was no different than anyone else. He had no Apostolic Authority, and therefore, they shouldn't listen to him.
        - But as we learned last week, Paul wasn't a liar, he simply couldn't come because of the great influence he was having in another town. And so, Paul, to defend his integrity, let the church at Corinth know why it was that he couldn't come to them. And then he ends the Chapter by saying this in verses 23-24:

But I call God as witness to my soul, that *it was* to spare you *that* I did not come again to Corinth.
2 Cor. 1:24 **Not that we domineer over your faith, but we are workers with you for your joy; for in your faith, you are standing firm.**

- I won't rehash these verses, but I do want us to notice something, something that I didn't point out last week. Paul makes it clear that He is not God, that he and the others are simply workers with them, for their joy. The key words to remember are this, and they show up in the last words of verse 24, where it says, "For in your faith you are standing firm."
    - Paul was saying, I am not the one you should be looking up to. You can't find your strength in me. Your faith must be firmly grounded in Jesus Christ, because it's in that faith you will stand firm.
    - I understand what Paul is saying here, because in the earlier years as a Christian I personally experienced a strong connection to a man who was my Pastor at the time. A man whom I found my strength.
        - Now, what's interesting is, while I was connected to him, I thought I was strong (spiritually speaking), but unfortunately, I found out one Sunday night that I really wasn't that strong at all. This all took place when He resigned and took another church in another part of the state.
        - In that moment, whatever strength I thought I had was not real, because when it was challenged, put to the test, what I discovered was that my faith was weak. Because you see the substance of who I was, was grounded in the wrong place. It was in a man, and not my faith.
- Now, having said that, I wasn't alone. I know lots of people who had the same

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experience, and since that time, I have known many people who experienced the same thing in other churches. And why? Because their faith was grounded in the wrong object. And obviously this is a problem, but it happens all the time.

- Some new “Charismatic Preacher” with new ideas, with a new creative way of doing church comes to town, and so it begins. It always starts out the same way. Everything begins hopping, moving, and shaking, until one day it doesn’t.
- I could spend all day talking about the many churches that this has happened to, and some in very recent history, but I would rather talk about the why, such as why this is so dangerous, and more than that, how to protect against it, because it is a serious issue within our Christian faith.
  - The man leaves, dies, moves, or has a moral failure and the church falls apart. On an individual level you could say, so goes the man or woman, so goes their faith. This is why Paul says what he says at the end of v. 24. He wants them to know he is sorry he hasn’t come to them yet.
  - But “In your faith, you are standing firm”. The message from God is this, “Look up, and fix your eyes on me, the author and finisher of your faith”. Because it’s in your faith that you will stand strong!
- And this makes sense. But honestly, on a granular level, what exactly does that mean? I can best answer that by telling you what it doesn’t mean. It doesn’t mean because I am saved, I am automatically going to stand firm! That’s not what it means, because I was saved when I went through what I went through.
- But when my Pastor left, I personally fell apart! And so, if that’s the case, and it was for me, then what did that say about my faith? It said my strength wasn’t in my faith, which tells us something, and that when we are Spiritually Mature it will be evident in our life, by way of our faith.

- Let me also say this, in troubled times the strength of your faith will be revealed. Another way to say it is, in times of trouble, that’s when your faith will be most evident, or less evident, (depending on how you look at it). And so, this is why Paul ended verse 24 the way he did.
  - He was saying, even if I don’t come, you still must grow and gain spiritual strength on your own. And how do we do that? By gaining a more intimate knowledge of who God is, and how He operates.
  - Which can only come through the study and ingestion of His Word. And not just quickly reading it, you must study it. Study it in a way that you are preparing to teach it to someone else. I know I drive this point home all the time, but it’s the truth. Your faith gains its strength when you know God in an intimate way.
  - Specifically, when the knowledge of who He is becomes part of your DNA, when it resonates inside your heart and soul. When you know that He is your provider, your protector.
  - And here are some Hebrew descriptors of who God is, lesser used names of God:

- ***Adir*— "Strong One".**

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- *Adon Olam* — "Master of the World".
- *Avinu Malkeinu* — "Our Father, our King".
- *Boreh* — "the Creator".
- *Ehiyeh sh'Ehiyeh* — "I Am That I Am": a modern Hebrew version of "Ehyeh asher Ehyeh".
- *Elohei Avraham*, Elohei Yitzchak ve Elohei Ya`aqov — "God of Abraham, God of Isaac, God of Jacob".
- *El ha-Gibbor* — "God the hero" or "God the strong one"
- *Emet* — "Truth".
- *E'in Sof* — "endless, infinite", Kabbalistic name of God.
- *Ro'eh Yisra'el* — "Shepherd of Israel".
- *Ha-Kaddosh, Baruch Hu* — "The Holy One, Blessed be He".
- *Kaddosh Israel* — "Holy One of Israel".
- *Melech ha-Melachim* — "The King of Kings" or Melech
- Malchei ha-Melachim "King of Kings of Kings", to express superiority to the earthly rulers title.
- *Makom* or *Hamakom* — literally "the place", meaning "The Omnipresent"; see Tzimtzum.
- *Magen Avraham* — "Shield of Abraham".
- *YHWH-Yireh* (Yahweh-Yireh) — "The Lord will provide" (Genesis 22:13, 14).
- *YHWH-Rapha" — "The Lord that healeth" (Exodus 15:26).*

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- ***YHWH-Niss"i (Yahweh-Nissi) — "The Lord our Banner" (Exodus 17:8-15).***
- ***YHWH-Shalom*** **— "The Lord our Peace" (Judges 6:24)**
- ***YHWH-Ra-ah*** **— "The Lord my Shepherd" (Psalms 23:1).**
- ***YHWH-Tsidkenu*** **— "The Lord our Righteousness" (Jeremiah 23:6).**
- ***YHWH-Shammah*** **— "The Lord is present" (Ezekiel 48:35).**
- ***Tzur Israel*** **— "Rock of Israel".**
- ***Ha Shem*** **— "The Name"**
- You get the point; your faith becomes strong when it truly resonates in your heart who He is!
    - Moving on, Paul now moves into 2 Corinthians 2, where some scholars have entitled this next section Reaffirm Your Love (verses 1-17).

2 Cor. 2:1 **But I decided this for my own sake, that I would not come to you in sorrow again.**
2 Cor. 2:2 **For if I cause you sorrow, who then *will be* the one making me glad but the one who is made sorrowful by me?**
2 Cor. 2:3 **This is the very thing I wrote you, so that when I came, I would not have sorrow from those who ought to make me rejoice; having confidence in you all that my joy was *the joy* of you all.**
2 Cor. 2:4 **For out of much affliction and anguish of heart I wrote to you with many tears; not so that you would be made sorrowful, but that you might know the love which I have especially for you.**
2 Cor. 2:5 **But if anyone has caused sorrow, he has caused sorrow not for me, but in some degree—not to say too much—for all of you.**
2 Cor. 2:6 **Sufficient for such a person is this punishment, which *was imposed* by the majority,**
2 Cor. 2:7 **so that on the other hand, you should rather forgive and comfort *him,* otherwise such a person might be overwhelmed by excessive sorrow.**
2 Cor. 2:8 **Therefore I urge you to reaffirm *your* love for him.**
2 Cor. 2:9 **For to this end I also wrote, so that I might put you to the test, whether you are obedient in all things.**
2 Cor. 2:10 **But one whom you forgive anything, I also *forgive;* for indeed what I**

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have forgiven, if I have forgiven anything, *I did so* for your sakes in the presence of Christ,
2 Cor. 2:11 **so that no advantage would be taken of us by Satan, for we are not ignorant of his schemes.**
2 Cor. 2:12 **Now when I came to Troas for the gospel of Christ and when a door was opened for me in the Lord,**
2 Cor. 2:13 **I had no rest for my spirit, not finding Titus my brother; but saying goodbye to them, I went on to Macedonia.**
2 Cor. 2:14 **But thanks be to God, who always leads us in triumph in Christ, and through us reveals the fragrance of the knowledge of Him in every place.**
2 Cor. 2:15 **For we are a fragrance of Christ to God among those who are being saved and among those who are perishing:**
2 Cor. 2:16 **to the one an aroma from death to death, to the other an aroma from life to life. And who is adequate for these things?**
2 Cor. 2:17 **For we are not like the many, peddling the word of God, but as from sincerity, but as from God, we speak in Christ in the sight of God.**

- Now, before we break all this down, I want you to remember, scholars pretty much agree that 2 Corinthians is a collection of several letters. Possibly this one, along with two other letters that were lost. Which means, it can be hard to follow because it's pieced together. It's considered an Amalgam, which means "mixture or blend".
    - So, remember that as we push through, and I will try to keep it straight for you. In verse 1 Paul starts out by saying,

2 Cor. 2:1 **But I decided this for my own sake, that I would not come to you in sorrow again.**

- In this verse Paul addresses something by saying, "I decided for my own sake, that I would not come to you in sorrow again". Remember, previously, Paul made a trip to this church, but left saddened because of what he saw. That trip prompted Paul to write a letter, a letter known as the "Severe letter". But remember, that letter was lost, we don't have it.
    - Paul's opening words here in Chapter 2 are referencing how he decided not to come for his own sake, because he did not want to return in sorrow again. Meaning, one of the reasons he didn't show up was because he thought he was going to have to scold them again, and he wasn't excited about doing that.
    - We gain insight into this fact back in 1 Corinthians, where this church was having a problem with a sinner in the fellowship, a man who was engaged in open incest with his stepmother, and how that Paul counseled the church through his letter, telling them to excommunicate this man for his own benefit.
        - Paul's hope was that, by kicking him out of the fellowship, he might straighten up and fly right. Well guess what, apparently, the church listened and did what he told them to do, and it worked, because the guy did repent. Paul is going to

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rejoice over that fact, that they listened and acted, but he is also going to point out how that he, and them now, have the task of forgiving this man.

- And we are going to see that clearly throughout the next few chapters, as Paul opens his heart and gives us some real insight into who he is as a Pastor as well as his passion for the ministry.

- Moving on, verse 2:

2 Cor. 2:2 For if I cause you sorrow, who then *will be* the one making me glad but the one who is made sorrowful by me?

- Paul is saying, because he had previously written them a very harsh or severe letter, (which he had Titus deliver to them), he wanted to wait before he came, to see how the church responded to the letter. The sense here is that he was very apprehensive, because if the letter failed to create its intended purpose.
  - Fortunately, for Paul though, it did meet its intended purpose, and he was so joyed by their response that he wrote this letter, the one we are reading now.

2 Cor. 2:3 This is the very thing I wrote you, so that when I came, I would not have sorrow from those who ought to make me rejoice; having confidence in you all that my joy was *the joy* of you all.

- As I said earlier, in these verses, we really begin to see Paul's heart as a Pastor. Here, he says, he preferred to come, like now in a sense, (and just a side bar), there is some strong belief that he did visit them right after this letter was delivered. No hard evidence of this fact, but suggested evidence that he did.
  - And if he did, he did so just so he could rejoice with them, all because they had taken steps to correct the very thing he had counseled them on.
- Moving on, in verse 4.

2 Cor. 2:4 For out of much affliction and anguish of heart I wrote to you with many tears; not so that you would be made sorrowful, but that you might know the love which I have especially for you.

- In this verse, you can feel Paul's pain as he reflects on not only his letter of 1 Corinthians, but also the severe letter that he previously wrote. You can also tell that when they stumble, when they have problems, that Paul grieves over them. Because as I said, he's got a Pastor's heart.
  - Now, what most of us may not stop to think about, is when someone falls inside the fellowship, not only does it grieve the Pastor, but it also grieves who? The Lord Jesus Christ.
  - It's a shock perhaps to realize that Jesus Christ's sufferings didn't end on the cross 2000 years ago. He still suffers, and He suffers because of you and I. Personally, I

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don't think Satan can do anything to make Christ suffer. That's just my hypothesis. But I do know who can cause Him to suffer, and that is us. Let me give you an example of what I am talking about.

- Let's take a look at Zechariah Chapter 13. Verse 6 is one of these interesting little verses that you stumble across in the Old Testament that sort of leaps out at you, and here's what it says:

Zech. 13:6 And *one* shall say unto him, What *are* these wounds in thine hands? Then he shall answer, *Those* with which I was wounded *in* the house of my friends.

- As we read this verse, we quickly recognize it to be Messianic, because it's obviously alluding to Jesus, due to the mentioning of the wounds in His hands. This also lines up with other passages in the Old Testament as well, such as Psalm 22 and others, which speak of His hands and feet being pierced.
  - Now when you read this it might not seem to make sense to you, because it says, "And one shall answer what are these wounds in thy hands. Then He shall answer, those with which, I was wounded in the house of my friends."
  - So, what does it mean when it says, I was wounded in the house of my friends? Who are these friends, and more important than that, what kind of friends are they that they would do such a thing? You wouldn't think they were very good ones, would you?
  - As we begin imagining who these people might be, we immediately think of the Roman Soldiers, the ones who pierced His hands. But I can't imagine a handful of Roman soldiers driving spikes into some 12-by-12's or whatever they were, on a hill in Judea, and think to myself that these are the ones being called the house of his friends.
    - That doesn't seem to fit, does it? So, who are these so-called friends? As I was thinking about it, I suddenly realized that this is apparently an illusion to another occasion in the scriptures. You may recall that on Easter Sunday they say Christ arose.
    - After the morning events, we find Jesus joining two disciples on the way to a place called Emmaus. And, after that little seven-mile walk/Bible study, Jesus breaks bread with them and then disappears because he's got a date back in Jerusalem, in the upper room that night.
  - You may remember, in this scene, the upper room was closed when suddenly Jesus appears and reveals Himself as the resurrected Lord to the disciples. On that evening, there was one person that was absent (May have been more than one, but one that comes to mind), and it's a very noteworthy person. A man named Thomas.
  - Now, we don't know for sure, but we can only imagine the enthusiasm in the room that evening, especially as they told Thomas what they saw. You could hear them saying, "Man Thomas, you should have been at our Bible study last night. You're never going to guess who showed up."
    - You could see Thomas sitting there, patiently waiting to respond, enduring their

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enthusiasm, and then suddenly he says, “Unless I can put my fingers in His nail prints, and my hands in His side, I won’t believe.”

- And I can understand Thomas’ reaction. I mean he was human, and probably a little jealous. I know I would have been. But the Lord doesn’t leave Thomas out, and sure enough, Thomas is with them once again when the Lord appears.

- And here is what it says in John 20:27-29:

John 20:27 **Then He *said to Thomas, “Place your finger here, and see My hands; and take your hand and put it into My side; and do not continue in disbelief but *be* a believer.”**
John 20:28 **Thomas answered and said to Him, “My Lord and my God!”**
John 20:29 **Jesus *said to him, “Because you have seen Me, have you *now* believed? Blessed *are* they who did not see, and *yet* believed.”**

- You know when we read this account in the New Testament, we probably fail to get the full impact of what’s happening here, because it was from that episode, plus an apparent characteristic of Thomas’ personality, that Thomas gets the nickname, “Doubting Thomas”. You know it’s often said when comparing the New Testament to the Old Testament, that the Old Testament conceals, and the New Testament reveals!
  - And here’s an example of exactly that, when you read Zechariah13:6, written some eight centuries before Christ was even born. When Zech says:

Zech. 13:6 **And *someone* will say to him, ‘What are these wounds between your arms?’ Then he will say, ‘*Those* with which I was wounded at the house of my friends.’**

- The answer to who the “the house of His friends are” shows up here in the New Testament. It wasn’t the Roman spikes that wounded him. It was Thomas’ unbelief. That’s a sobering thought, when you think about it. When you and I stumble, even through our doubts, (and we all do from time to time), when we do this, Christ suffers.
  - That is hard for us to understand, and maybe even harder for us to fully grasp, but that’s the reality and we need to come to terms with it.
- So, back to 2 Corinthians 2:5-8:

2 Cor. 2:5 **But if anyone has caused sorrow, he has caused sorrow not for me, but in some degree—not to say too much—for all of you.**
2 Cor. 2:6 **Sufficient for such a person is this punishment, which *was imposed* by the majority,**
2 Cor. 2:7 **so that on the other hand, you should rather forgive and comfort *him,* otherwise such a person might be overwhelmed by excessive sorrow.**
2 Cor. 2:8 **Therefore I urge you to reaffirm *your* love for him.**

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- In this section of verses, Paul is referencing the restoration of the sinning saint. He is alluding back to this guy who was mentioned in 1 Corinthians, the one who had been excommunicated. And as I said earlier, he apparently has repented for what he has done, and now Paul is pointing out and saying that the next step is to "forgive him".
    - That's what Paul is pleading for here. You know, the Body of Christ has often been known as the only group that shoots its wounded. If a man or woman stumbles or falls, and then repents, we are to forgive them, and come alongside them, and help with their restoration process. Not lock them in a room (metaphorically speaking) and throw away the key.
    - All of us as Christians make mistakes. We all stumble and fall. And by the way, just in case you're wondering, I don't know of anyone in Heaven that will have lived a life free of sin. None other than the Lord Himself. Heaven is a home for repentant sinners, and that is what Paul is dealing with here.
        - Here is a guy who had gross sin, and Paul himself called it to their attention. So, they dealt with it, they excommunicated him, and it had its desired effect. The excommunication was a form of discipline, and it caused the man to repent and return to the fellowship, and now Paul is asking them to forgive him. Which is what we all must do when someone repents.
        - You know what Paul is really implying is, if we don't forgive the repentant Christian, then we are just as bad as the person who committed the sin the first place. Essentially, repentance and forgiveness are two sides of the same coin. You see, it's important that we understand how essential forgiveness is in our Christian Walk. That it's the medicine that heals broken hearts.
- Moving on, V.9-11

2 Cor. 2:9 **For to this end I also wrote, so that I might put you to the test, whether you are obedient in all things.**
2 Cor. 2:10 **But one whom you forgive anything, I also *forgive;* for indeed what I have forgiven, if I have forgiven anything, *I did so* for your sakes in the presence of Christ,**
2 Cor. 2:11 **so that no advantage would be taken of us by Satan, for we are not ignorant of his schemes. (the KJV says "his devices")**

- Now, let me ask you a question. If I were to give you a written quiz right now, and ask you to make a list of all of Satan's schemes or devices, what would you write down? Now let me say this, don't confuse any of Satan's schemes or devices with anything obvious. Satan's most dangerous devices are much more complex than the obvious ones, the ones we all think about.
    - As a matter of fact, I would say his most dangerous devices aren't obvious at all, which is why Paul says here don't be ignorant about them. So, let's talk about them for just a moment.
        - There are two mistakes we make about Satan, and the first is not realizing that he exists. More specifically, that he is not who the Bible says he is, which is what

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- a lying, active, vigorous, adversary of your welfare. Meaning that we don't recognize that he is a force, but rather just some sort of euphemism for some abstract thing.

- Let be clear here today, Satan is a person with incredible resources who is hostile to your interest. That's who he is. I find it funny how we feel very comfortable talking about Christ as our personal Lord and Savior, but we get uncomfortable talking about Satan in the personal sense.
    - "As a Personal Satan." It sounds weird to say it that way, but it's true. You see, when we don't recognize him as being alive and well and working among us, we often find ourselves (maybe not consciously, but subconsciously) denying his existence.
    - It's interesting how we don't seem to have balance when it comes to Satan. One camp doesn't give him enough credit (by denying his existence), and the other camp (the ones who do believe he is who the Bible says he is), they give him too much credit.
        - There is a very famous book, a good book in fact, that has an unfortunate title. It's called "Between Christ and Satan". This book is not a bad book, but the title is very misleading, because it implies that Satan and Christ are adversaries, in the equality sense, which is obviously nonsense, because Christ created all things.
- As I said, when it comes to Satan, we often can't seem to garner a balanced theology. We either ignore or deny him on the one hand, or we see him behind every tree on the other. Interesting problem, and so what do we do?
    - Well, we need to recognize his reality, but we also need to recognize our resources in Christ, so we are not timid about it. Back to Satan's schemes or devices. What are some of his devices?
- Well, at the top of the list are "Deceit and Deception". The gain, the warfare, and the battle ground lies between "truth" and "deceit & deception". Remember, the strongest skillset that Satan possesses is that of counterfeiting. I could literally spend an entire day showing you from the pages of scripture where Satan subtly tries to change God's plans through deception by twisting Gods own words.
    - It started with Eve in the Garden and moved to the temptation of Jesus Himself in the desert. And then, as I said earlier, there's his work of counterfeiting. Copying what God is doing. Trying to create the illusion of God's work to confuse God's people.
    - We see it in Revelation, in the end times, where the False Prophet, the Anti-Christ, and Satan all give the illusion of The Father, Son, and The Holy Ghost. The biggest mistake we make as Christians is thinking we can see what Satan is doing, and therefore avoid him. Satan never shows up in our lives in the ways we imagine he will. The scriptures warn of this in Genesis 3, where the NASB Bible says:

Gen. 3:1 Now the serpent was more cunning than any animal of the field which the LORD God had made. And he said to the woman, "Has God really said, 'You shall not eat from any tree of the garden'?"

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- A definition given by the NAS Exhaustive Concordance says, “crafty, shrewd, sensible”. Interesting how the concordance chose the word “sensible”, because I really think that best describes how Satan operates.
    - If it seems sensible then it must be okay. This is the ultimate danger for the believer. Rationale, Logic, and Pragmatism. They can be our worst enemy, thinking we know something, but it’s not what we think it is. Another one of Satan’s devices, and it’s a close cousin to deception, is “deviation”.
    - It’s amazing how many heresies throughout history start by being ½ a degree off the mark. A slight over-emphasis of the truth, but not in balance. The concept is that of flying an airplane.
        - If it’s just one degree off at any distance, it will take you to the middle of nowhere. It’s amazing how theology can develop the same way. You can take some particularly true doctrine, and then over emphasise it, just a little at the expense of others, and the first thing you know you’ve got a major heresy on your hands.
- The word is “Balance”, and how do you protect yourself against losing it? How do you protect yourself from a theology that hangs itself on one little check verse in some particular book. The answer is “The Whole Counsel of God”.
    - You need to have a personal reading and studying program that takes you from Genesis 1:1 to Revelation 22. And when you finish that, start over. You see, when you have all the pieces, they balance each other. It’s fine when you have a specialty interest in a particular topic.
        - I have done that many times myself. You get interested in a particular topic. You begin digging, do a little homework, and before you know it you know a lot about subject X, no problem with that, as long as you also balance that with “The Whole Counsel of God”. It’s the only protection you have.
- Many of you know that I often listen to Biblical debates. Sometimes I listen to debates between Christians and Atheists. I love to hear the Atheist logic and rationale. Now, you might think that I would listen to these so that I can smile and think of all the ways that I know that I am right, and they are wrong.
    - But the truth is, that’s not why I listen to them at all. I listen to them for educational reasons. I love listening to the other side, not just being closed minded and saying to myself, “Well, I am right, and they are wrong”.
        - It’s through listening to the other side’s point of view that I am challenged. I want to be able to defend my position, and I can best do that when I know the enemy’s schemes. I don’t want to be just another Zealot Christian who has no real knowledge or proof. I don’t want my only rebuttal to be, me saying, “Well, that’s what I believe”.
        - You see, when you make that kind of shallow statement to the Atheist, you just prove their point, because what you are essentially saying is, I believe what I believe because someone told me to believe it.
    - By studying the opposing view, you will become emboldened and strong in your defense. That’s why I study the enemies’ schemes. And let me say this, the other side has some pretty strong arguments. They will use the Word of God against you to prove their arguments.

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- Now, as I close this morning, I want to highlight another of Satan's devices. Ones that you probably never thought of, because as I said, the most dangerous ones are not the obvious ones.
    - The device is Unforgiveness. Unforgiveness is one of the most powerful tools Satan has, and one of the deadliest types of unforgiveness are the justified ones. I'm talking about when someone hurts you, or wrongs you, where you are clearly justified in having that attitude.
        - This is very detrimental to your Christian Walk, even though you may not know it. And why? Because they are the ones that you are least likely to forgive, and yet they are the most important for you to forgive.
        - If you are going to be a vessel for God's love, forgiveness is powerful, powerful medicine for hurting people. But unforgiveness is one of Satan's major strongholds in the life of a believer.
- Next week I am going to highlight a few more of Satan's hidden but deadly devices, and just to give you a hint, think about Self-vindication, which is any type of self-focus of whatever kind, including vanity.
    - Then there's Prejudice. Boy does Satan use prejudice, and it doesn't have to be in the overt racial, ethnic kind. It can be the subtle kind. What school did you graduate from? What neighborhood did you come from?
    - Next is our emotions. Our natural emotions can be one of Satan's devices. Any time my flesh is excited, God is not in it. Anything that comes from a place of pride, God's not in it.
    - Finally Confusion. Any time you see confusion, who is not the author of it? God is not the author of confusion.

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- This morning, we pick back up with our study of 2 Corinthians. Last week we spent most of the lesson discussing the schemes and devices of the enemy. We also talked about how the Bible described our enemy (our adversary) as a Subtle and Crafty being, one that walks around like a roaring lion seeking whom he may devour.
- He is subtle and crafty, yet powerful and evasive. There are not many enemies that can be described in this manner. We also discovered that the most powerful schemes of our adversary, (the ones most likely to cause the believer to fail) were the ones we don't even think about.
    - The non-obvious ones such as:
        - Unforgiveness - More specifically, justified unforgiveness.
        - Deceit and Deception - Satan is the great counterfeiter.
        - Our Logic - Rationale and Pragmatism. Our "worldly wisdom".
        - Deviation - Slight deviation from the truth of God that we run with.
        - Ignorance - Paul himself said, "I would not have you ignorant brethren."
        - Confusion - Maybe the most powerful scheme the enemy has.
        - And finally – Pride. But not just pride in the traditional sense, as in arrogance. This type of pride is hidden, and it masquerades itself inside our individual strengths. In other words, each of us possesses individual strengths, but inside our strengths lies our greatest weakness.
            - And if we aren't careful, and I mean very careful, that weakness will rear its head in the form of hidden pride.
- Last week we used Peter as a great Biblical example of that concept. Peter was bold, but that boldness caused him to jump when he should have been still. And the example we used was when he was with Jesus in the Garden of Gethsemane. You may remember the story.
    - When the Roman Soldiers approached Jesus, Peter jumped up, grabbed a sword, and cut one of the Roman Soldiers ears off. And what did Jesus say to him?
    - We read it in Matthew 26:52-54:

Matt. 26:52 Then Jesus said to him, "Put your sword back into its place; for all those who take up the sword will perish by the sword.
Matt. 26:53 Or do you think that I cannot appeal to My Father, and He will at once put at My disposal more than twelve legions of angels?
Matt. 26:54 How then would the Scriptures be fulfilled, *which say* that it must happen this way?"

- In Matthew's gospel, we see Peter operating in his strength - his boldness, but we also see how his boldness became his weakness. A weakness that reared its head and was getting in the way of God's will. And the same can hold true for you and me if we aren't careful.
    - I'll give you another modern-day example, and it starts by asking a question. Are you

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organized, are you systematic, are you administratively driven? Do you see things from a black and white standpoint? What a great strength that is. It's so powerful, yet as powerful as it is, it can become an even greater weakness, especially if that strength becomes a reason to mistreat people, bad-mouth people, or run over people.

- That strength becomes a weakness if it leads you to say, 'What are you, incompetent? Just get out of the way and let me handle it for you. You're obviously not smart enough or organized enough to do this or that.' That's just one small example of what I am talking about.

- We must always remember, inside our strength lies our greatest weakness, and that weakness usually rears its head in the form of "Hidden Pride" - "Justified Pride". Pride that makes sense from a worldly perspective. Pride that gets reinforced by those around you, when some in your camp says, 'I don't blame you. I would have said this or that and would have done the exact same thing. That person needs to learn a lesson, or they made their bed, now they need to lie in it'.
  - Those are not the words of a humble person. They are the words of a prideful individual, they are words that excite the flesh, and anything that excites our flesh is not of God, (even if it's justified).
  - We must always keep ourselves in check, especially within our strengths. The only way to do that is to ask ourselves a fundamental question. When we say things, or act out from our position of strength, are we doing it from a place of pride or love?
    - Love is the key! If love isn't present, then pride is. And just to be sure we understand what love looks like, let's listen to how Paul himself described it in 1 Corinthians 13:4-7:

1 Cor. 13:4 Love is patient, love is kind, it is not jealous; love does not brag, it is not arrogant.
1 Cor. 13:5 It does not act disgracefully, it does not seek its own *benefit;* it is not provoked, does not keep an account of a wrong *suffered,*
1 Cor. 13:6 it does not rejoice in unrighteousness, but rejoices with the truth;
1 Cor. 13:7 it keeps every confidence, it believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things.

- What an amazing description of Love, and if your strengths work in opposition to these descriptors, you can know you are working from a place of pride, rather than that of love, and if that's the case, it is not of God! Moving on, and back to teaching.
- Let's pick back up with 2 Corinthians 2:12-17:

2 Cor. 2:12 Now when I came to Troas for the gospel of Christ and when a door was opened for me in the Lord,
2 Cor. 2:13 I had no rest for my spirit, not finding Titus my brother; but saying goodbye to them, I went on to Macedonia.
2 Cor. 2:14 But thanks be to God, who always leads us in triumph in Christ, and

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through us reveals the fragrance of the knowledge of Him in every place.
2 Cor. 2:15 **For we are a fragrance of Christ to God among those who are being saved and among those who are perishing:**
2 Cor. 2:16 **to the one an aroma from death to death, to the other an aroma from life to life. And who is adequate for these things?**
2 Cor. 2:17 **For we are not like the many, peddling the word of God, but as from sincerity, but as from God, we speak in Christ in the sight of God.**

- Paul begins in verse 12 by explaining about when he came to Troas (which today is the place we call Turkey). When he came to Troas preaching the Gospel of Jesus Christ, a door was opened for him. What he means is, people were answering the call unto salvation.
    - Which is one of the reasons he hadn't come to see them yet. He wanted to come, but God had different plans. Next, he says in verse 13 that he had no rest for his spirit. We would say he was anxious, worried, and concerned. Something was bothering him. But what was bothering him? He tells us in the same sentence when he says, "Not finding Titus my brother".
- Paul was expecting to meet up with Titus, but why did that make him anxious or worried? Because remember, Paul had previously visited Corinth, and that visit was called the "painful visit". Painful because of what he saw.
    - After that visit, Paul wrote a letter to the church, called the "severe letter". It was a very harsh letter, and he wrote it to correct this church's behavior. He sent that letter with Titus back to the Corinthian church, and he was anxiously waiting to see how the church responded to it.
    - If the letter wasn't received well, Paul knew his relationship with that church may be severed forever. So, he hoped he would meet up with Titus in Troas, and find out how the church reacted to what he wrote, but when he arrived, Titus wasn't there, which is what caused him to say that, "he had no rest for his spirit not finding my brother Titus", but immediately after that, it says, "he said goodbye to them, and went on to Macedonia"
- So, God used Paul in Troas for the spread of the Gospel, and then once he bid them farewell, he headed off to Macedonia where he did meet up with Titus, and because we have the benefit of other passages of scripture, we know that while in Macedonia he met up with Titus and received wonderful news. News that the church had indeed read his letter and reacted to it in a positive way.
    - Which prompted Paul to change his worry and concern into relief and joy, and that's why Paul says, "but thanks be to God". In one breathe, he says, "I had no rest for my spirit", and then in the very next breathe he says but thanks be to God.
    - Basically, we could say Paul was going from a low, low, to a high, high within two verses. Obviously, he's on an emotional rollercoaster of sorts. From there he moves in to verse 14, and from verse 14 through Chapter 7:4, we now enter what is the longest coherent (unified and reasoned) section of 2 Corinthians. It is arguably the centerpiece of the entire letter.
        - Chapter 2:14 through Chapter 7:4 is what we call a lengthy digression on Paul's

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part, caused by the contrast between the agitation of mind, which he just described, and his present sense of relief and rejoicing.

- In other words, one thought leads on to another in an outpouring of "spiritual wealth", which is unsurpassed in any other of his epistles. So, let's move into verse 14, where he says,

2 Cor. 2:14 But thanks be to God, who always leads us in triumph in Christ, and through us reveals the fragrance of the knowledge of Him in every place.

- I really love how Paul phrases this verse. He says, 'but thanks be to God, who always (not sometimes) but always leads us in triumph in Christ'. Now, one verse that may pop into your mind when reading verse 14 is Romans 8:28, where it says:

Romans 8:28 And we know that God causes all things to work together for good to those who love God, to those who are called according to *His* purpose.

- Notice it says all things work together for good to those who love God, to those who are called according to His purpose. This may leave us asking ourselves a question, which is, does Romans 8:28 only apply to believers? In other words, do good things only work together for good for those whom He called? Only for the believers?
  - Because I have seen some pretty great things happen for people who have no interest in God. Even those who are atheist and go out of their way to denounce God. And this is certainly true from the world standpoint, but the key to understanding Romans 8:28 lies in the definition of what good is in the eyes of God.
- What does it mean when it says, "And we know God causes all things to work together for good, for those who love God, and for those who are called according to his purpose?" What are these good things in the eyes of God?
  - They are the things that further His will and bring Him glory. They are not earthly things, but Heavenly. They are not temporal, but permanent in Glory. Which means, when something bad (as we consider it bad) happens, you can find solace and peace knowing there will be good coming from it.
    - You may not be able to see it. You may never see it on this side of Heaven, but you can find peace knowing God is doing something with that tragedy.
- A few weeks back I was talking to my sister about the death of my niece, and my sister told me that sometime after the death of her 18-year-old daughter, that God spoke to her in her spirit and told her, "I trusted you with this tragedy". What a powerful word. Coming from a broken heart. So powerful, honestly it makes me want to cry when I think about it.
  - God spoke to my sister through the spirit that lives inside her, and told her, "I trusted you with this tragedy". In other words, because of your Spiritual Resolve and your Spiritual Strength, I have chosen you to endure this tragedy. What a concept.
  - You see, because we live in a fallen world, we know tragedy is a part of life. But we also know that God uses tragedy to bring Glory. So, the only question is, can He trust

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you with tragedy? Are you Spiritually Mature enough for him to use you as his instrument?

- Now, you may be sitting here this morning thinking to yourself, if Spiritual Maturity means I get to endure tragedy, then "no thanks", let someone else do it. That makes sense from a purely worldly standpoint, but not from God's standpoint.
  - As I said, tragedy is a part of life, and it's not "if" tragedy is going to happen, but "when" tragedy is going to happen. Which means it doesn't matter if you are Spiritually Mature or not, tragedy is going to happen to you.
    - The only difference is, will He use you for His Glory through that experience. Because if he does, you will experience what is just a little glimpse of Heaven here on earth! And you will experience that by experiencing His peace, "Which is a peace that surpasses all understanding".
    - That's the peace my sister has today, and it comes from her knowing that her daughter's death wasn't for naught, that God has used and continues to use it in a mighty way.
- The only question is do you want to sit on the sideline when tragedy strikes, saying to yourself, "Woe is me, why did this or that happen, and I'm so depressed, and I don't want to get out of bed or leave the house", or, do you garner the strength of God by knowing and understanding that God is doing something for His Glory through whatever tragedy you may be experiencing.
  - If the answer is B, and I hope it is, then you must become Spiritually Mature. And when you do, Romans 8:28 will mean something to you, because only the mature man or woman can read that verse and even begin to process or understand what it means when it says:

Romans 8:28 **And we know that God causes all things to work together for good (that means even my nieces death) to those who love God, (which BTW 100%, describes my sister) to those who are called (once again, that describes my sister, because God called her) according to *His* purpose.**

- And what was His purpose? To draw men to himself for His Glory. And sure enough, God has used my sister, as well as others who were connected to my niece, to help others and to point many people back towards the Cross even today. All "For His Good, For His Purposes and For His Glory". Moving on, and back to teaching. Paul says one more time in verse 14:

2 Cor. 2:14 **But thanks be to God, who always leads us in triumph in Christ, and through us reveals the fragrance of the knowledge of Him in every place.**

- Real quick I want to touch on something here, something that more than likely was going through Paul's mind at this point, and that was the direct connection between our Conquering Christ and what was a Roman Victory or Triumph.
  - Remember, Paul was a Roman by birth, but he was also Jewish as well as a

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Christian, and he was also well educated. When Paul talks about the triumph in Christ, and then ties it together with a fragrance to God, what he's doing is contrasting the irresistible advance of the gospel, as well as temporary setbacks of his life, to that of a Roman General who had experienced a Roman Triumph or Victory.

- I want you to listen to William Barclay's description of what a Roman triumph looks like, and then compare it to what Paul was saying. Barclay said this, as it related to Paul's writings here in verse 14:
  - In Paul's mind there is the picture of a Roman Triumph and that of Christ as a universal conqueror. The highest honor which could be given to a Victorious Roman General was that of a Triumph. But before he could declare it, he must first satisfy certain conditions.
    - First - He must have been the actual commander-in-chief in the field.
    - Second - The campaign must be finished. The region must have been completely pacified, and the victorious troops brought home.
    - Thirdly - At least five thousand enemy combatants must have fallen in one engagement.
    - Fourth - There must have been a positive extension of the Roman territory gained, and not merely a disaster retrieved, or an attack repelled. And,
    - Fifth - the victory must have been won over a foreign foe and not in a civil war.
  - If those conditions were met, then and only then could there be an actual Triumph declared, at which point the Victorious General could march by procession through the streets of Rome to the Capitol. That procession would proceed as follows:
    - First came the state officials and the senate. Then the trumpeters. Then there were carried the spoils taken from the conquered land. Just like when Titus conquered Jerusalem, and the seven-branched candlestick, the golden table of the showbread and the golden trumpets were taken from the temple and carried through the streets of Rome.
    - Next, there came pictures of the conquered land and models of conquered citadels and ships, followed by the "white bull" for sacrifice, which they made. Then there walked the wretched captives, the enemy princes, leaders, and generals in chains. Those who would be flung into prison and in all probability almost immediately executed.
    - Then came the lictors [minor judicial officials] bearing their rods, followed by the musicians with their lyres. Then came the priests swinging their censers with the sweet-smelling incense burning in them.
    - And then there came the general himself. He stood in a chariot drawn by four horses. He was clad in a purple tunic embroidered with golden palm leaves, and over it a purple toga marked out with golden stars.
    - In his hand he held an ivory scepter with the Roman eagle at the top of it, and over his head a slave held the crown of Jupiter. After him there rode his family, and finally came the army wearing all its decorations and shouting their cry of triumph.

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- As the procession moved through the streets, all decorated and garlanded, amid the shouting, cheering crowds, it was a tremendous day, a day which might happen only once in a lifetime. That was the picture that was in Paul's mind when he wrote verse 14.
  - He sees the conquering Christ marching in triumph throughout the world, and himself in that conquering train. And it is a triumph that Paul is certain nothing can stop. Also, in that procession there were the priests swinging the incense-filled censers.
  - To the general and to the victors the perfume from the censers would be the perfume of joy and triumph and life. But to the wretched captives who walked so short a distance ahead it was the perfume of death, for it stood for the past defeat and their coming execution.
  - So, Paul thinks of himself and his fellow apostles as preaching the gospel of the triumphant Christ, and to those who will accept it, it is the perfume of life, as it was to the victors. But to those who refuse it, it is the perfume of death as it was to the vanquished.
- Of one thing Paul was certain, not all the world could defeat Christ. He lived not in pessimistic fear, but in the glorious optimism which knew the unconquerable majesty of Christ.
  - During a triumph, sweet spices were thrown about or burnt in the streets. The fact of the triumph, or approach of the triumphal procession, was made known by these odors far and wide, so God diffuses by our means.
  - We are the materials of His triumph, the sweet odor of the knowledge of Christ. The metaphor is at the same time triumphant and anti-triumphant.
  - It's as if God leads His servants as prisoners of war in a victory parade, as God Himself spreads the knowledge of Christ everywhere through them. Whereas, in such victory processions the prisoners would be dejected and embittered, from this captive's lips comes only thanksgiving to God, his captor.
- Here Paul reinstates the "power-in-weakness" theme (cf. 1:3-11) that pervades the letter. Barclays words give this verse a different meaning, don't they?
- Moving on, verses 15&16:

2 Cor. 2:15 For we are a fragrance of Christ to God among those who are being saved and among those who are perishing:
2 Cor. 2:16 to the one an aroma from death to death, to the other an aroma from life to life. And who is adequate for these things?

- Quoting Barclay once more, in these verses Paul is comparing the Apostles to the fragrance of the incense. Those who preach the gospel how they are pleasing to God ("a fragrance of Christ to God") regardless of the response of those who hear it.
  - "From death to death" he says, (v. 16) probably means from the death of Christ that the apostles preached in the gospel, to the eternal death of those who reject it.
  - "From life to life" (v. 16) probably means from the resurrection of Christ that they

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preached in the gospel, to the eternal life of those who believe. The role of the heralder of Christ is a high calling, and no one is sufficient in himself, or herself, for this task.

- We all need the Grace of God to accomplish this! Barclay says it this way, "Christ undertook a battle not rightly his; and we share in a triumph not rightly ours." The day of Christ's triumph is what Paul was envisioning. Specifically, His return to the earth at His Second Coming.

- Once again, what a powerful description of these verses. Moving on, in verse 17 we end Chapter 2, with Paul saying:

2 Cor. 2:17 For we are not like the many, peddling the word of God, but as from sincerity, but as from God, we speak in Christ in the sight of God.

- Peddling the Word of God. This was a cut at the false teachers who had found their way into the Corinthian Church. At this time, combatting false teaching was one of Paul's biggest tasks, because it riddled most, if not all, of the churches Paul helped established.
  - These false teachers used the Word of God to push their agenda and take control, which ultimately led to them making money. And the weaker Christians listened to their teaching, because in their minds, it all seemed to make sense and since it seemed logical, then it must be correct.
- Today, I would say more than ever, God's Word is being peddled at an ever-increasing rate. And by the way, this is exactly what Timothy said would happen in the "End Times".
- Listen to what he said in 2 Timothy 4:3-4:

2 Tim. 4:3 For *the* time will come when they will not tolerate sound doctrine; but *wanting* to have their ears tickled, they will accumulate for themselves teachers in accordance with their own desires,
2 Tim. 4:4 and they will turn their ears away from the truth and will turn aside to myths.

- It was bad in Paul's day, but it's even worse in ours, because most of the false teachers in Paul's day were teaching a blend of Judaism and Christianity. And you can kind of see why that was the case.
  - Before Christianity, Judaism was God's Rule of law. It was God's requirement and path unto Salvation. So, it is easy to see how that when Christ came and abolished that law, the people struggled to make the transition.
  - But today, in our day, one of the primary teachings that endangers Christianity is that of the Prosperity Movement, and just like the false teachers in Paul's day, this movement, at its root, has as its primary motivation an agenda of control that revolves around a prosperity of not only the Leaders in the church, but a false prosperity preached to the people that there is prosperity available for everyone, even though the prosperity seems to only end up with a select few at the top.

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- But how did this happen? How did it take root? It happened through one of four of the most effective schemes or devices of the enemy. First was that of ignorance, specifically the believer's ignorance as it relates to the scriptures.
    - Which is then paired with deviation, just a slight deviation of God's Word, slightly taken out of context, then enters our Logic, our Reason, our Rationale, and our Pragmatism. And let's not forget our feelings that are primarily derived from the world's wisdom.
    - And of course, all this has led to confusion, which as I said, is a powerful scheme or device of the enemy. Because, you see, if the Christian begins to question what they are seeing, then confusion sets in. Once that takes hold, it will usually end up with the believer becoming completely averse to anything church related.
    - The result will be them quitting church altogether, which is the goal of the enemy in the first place. This process is simple to understand. It starts with a simple statement like, God loves us, therefore, He wants us to prosper.
- Fairly simple and certainly non-confrontational, right? And both are true, but His prosperity has nothing to do with this life. Hence, a slight deviation from the truth. This movement has become so powerful that it has metastasized - spread in many different directions.
    - From the milder, less noticeable versions, which show up in the mainstream churches, to the more extreme and more noticeable versions inside the larger charismatic denominations, with the TV evangelists living lavish lifestyles.
    - The more extreme cases are obviously easier to spot. Having said that, the less noticeable milder versions of prosperity are just as concerning. In these churches prosperity is an undercurrent of sorts, it's assumed, but not really vocalized, but it's still being taught. Which leaves the believer confused.
    - This is as big of a problem as the more extreme in-your-face versions, because if we believe that God is concerned about our earthly prosperity in any shape, form, or fashion, even in some minor undertone format, it is, as I said, a problem.
        - Because when things don't work out, when prosperity doesn't befall an individual believer, or heaven forbid, the opposite happens, and that individual ends up questioning everything they believe. And many times, that believer not only quits church, but they go on a campaign to debunk Christianity altogether.
- So, let me be clear. God's word being peddled is not reserved for just the extreme denominations. It holds true for mainstream conservative denominations as well (such as the Southern Baptist, of which I was saved and surrendered in the ministry to preach under). And whom I love.
    - Right now, there are many former conservative Christian people who have started online social media groups, that have as their focus and purpose a move to debunk Christianity. They have established podcasts and online video followings, which have as their header:
        - Why I left the church
        - Why Christianity is a scam
        - How I was freed from the bonds of Christianity

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- I watched a video where one woman talked about how she was part of the praise and worship team. How she was depressed because she really didn't believe what she was singing. How that, if God was an awesome God, and He was supposed to take care of her, then why was she so depressed. And why was life not happening in the way the songs said it would happen. So she left.
    - The sad part is, she has a ton of people following her. She talks about what she calls "the church behind the scenes". How fake everyone is. All of this finds its roots in Ignorance and Confusion. She doesn't understand who God is or how He operates.
    - Go through the scriptures, and find someone who is living their "best life now". Go find someone we would deem is "living a prosperous life". For them it was nothing but hard times, except the "blessed hope". And the same is true for us.
- So how do we prevent going down this path of confusion which leads to disappointment. We need to, everyday, pray and study for ourselves (as the Bereans), so that we can grow up and mature.
- Because if not, you too can easily fall prey to this scheme and device of the enemy. And so, for that reason, we must never allow someone to peddle God's word. That was Paul's message then, and it remains true today.

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- This morning, turn with me if you will to 2 Corinthians and follow along as we venture into the 3rd Chapter of Paul's Epistle.
  - Last week we began our teaching with Paul making a shift from Chapter 2:13 into verse 14. With that shift, Paul began what will be the longest coherent (unified and reasoned) section in all of 2 Corinthians.
  - Paul's narrative begins with verse 14 of Chapter 2 and continues all the way through verse 4 of Chapter 7. This section will also represent what is arguably the centerpiece of the entire letter. As a matter of fact, scholar's call it a lengthy digression on Paul's part, caused by a contrast inside Paul's own mind.
    - A contrast between an ongoing battle of anxious worry mixed with joy. Specifically, worry and joy over his present sense of relief, and rejoicing over hearing how the church at Corinth responded to the severe letter he wrote to them.
- As we move forward in Paul's writings, we will see how one thought will lead to another in an outpouring of spiritual wealth, unsurpassed in any of his other epistles. And as I said, this will all be brought about by Paul's recollection of his happy reunion, where he met up with Titus in Macedonia, paired with the good news that his friend brought to him from Corinth.
  - As we ended Chapter 2 this past week, we did so with Paul writing the following in 2 Corinthians 2:17:

2 Cor. 2:17 For we are not like the many, peddling the word of God, but as from sincerity, but as from God, we speak of Christ in the sight of God.

- Remember, one of Paul's goal's in writing this letter was to re-establish his authority within this church, along with who he was, which was a man called by the will of God. To do that, he had to win back his integrity among these people, along with reestablishing his Apostolic Authority in the minds of this church.
  - In verse 17 Paul said something that rings true even today, and that was, that he and the other Apostles were not men who "peddled the word of God". The KJV version says,

2 Cor. 2:17 (KJV) For we are not as many, which corrupt the word of God: but as of sincerity, but as of God, in the sight of God speak we in Christ.

- Whereas the NASB says "peddling". The Greek says peddling as well, but both words carry the same meaning. In the Greek - *kapēleúō* - it means properly, to act as an unscrupulous merchant, i.e. "a huckster" who profits by "peddling the Word of God" for personal gain. *Kapēleúō* ("peddler") is only used in 2 Cor 2:17, and it specifically speaks of people "marketing the ministry" (the Word of God) for fast gain.
  - In those days, "peddling the word of God" was done in a very different manner than it is today. But having said that, peddling is peddling no matter how you do it. The problem with today's peddling lies in the degree of danger involved.

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- Christians today are in graver danger of being deceived by false teaching than the Christians were in Paul's day. And why? Primarily because most of the false teaching in Paul's day revolved around the Jews (some which were saved - we call them *Messianic Jews*).
  - You see, the Messianic Jews of Paul's day were desperately trying to hang on to the Law, and their cultural customs. Therefore, they came up with a hybrid version of Christianity. A version that blended Christianity and Judaism, but obviously there was no such thing,
  - Then you had the non-Christ professing Jews. They were trying to get the believing Jews to abandon Jesus altogether. These two groups made up what were most of the false teachers present in that day. But having said that, there were others. Ancient Greek Mysticism ran rampant along with many other Pagan religions.
  - And yes, both were bad, and both had the power to cause the believer to stumble. But for the church of today, we face an entirely different type of false teaching. One that takes peddling the word of God to a whole new level, and different level.
- One that finds its roots in pragmatism and logic, paired with "easy belief-ism", married with this concept of prosperity. One that says that somehow, God wants us to prosper here on earth. Now, I won't re-hash all this, but as I said last week, God does want us to prosper.

- But His prosperity is spiritual not temporal. His prosperity revolves around the peace you receive when you live for Him. More specifically, when you bring Him Glory in everything you do. You see, when you understand God's concept of prosperity, and you begin to think in this manner, and live this way, you can tap into a comfort and a peace only available through "The Spirit of God". A comfort and peace that God has reserved for his Children.
  - And by the way, it's better than any material possession you could ever obtain on this earth.
- Now, with that thought and concept fresh on your mind, let's delve into Chapter 3, where Paul continues to defend who he and the other Apostles are.
  - The NASB calls this section, 'Ministers of a New Covenant'.

2 Cor. 3:1 **Are we beginning to commend ourselves again? Or do we need, as some, letters of commendation to you or from you?**
2 Cor. 3:2 **You are our letter, written in our hearts, known and read by all people,**
2 Cor. 3:3 **revealing yourselves, that you are a letter of Christ, delivered by us, written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God, not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts.**
2 Cor. 3:4 **Such *is the* confidence we have toward God through Christ.**

- Paul starts verse 1 by saying, "Are we beginning to commend ourselves again? Or do we need some letters of commendation to you or from you? In this verse you get a real sense of the frustration in Paul's writings. I would call it a hint of sarcasm mixed with

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aggravation.

- Paul is saying, 'People do we need to start over? Do we need to prove ourselves to you again, or send you letters of commendation? Commendation meaning, do we need to gather letters from other churches, proving who we are, so that you guys will believe in us again?
  - Remember guys, Paul started this church, which is why he is fighting so hard with his words. As I said, he is trying to re-establish his authority. And what a ridiculous thing for him to have to do. Think about it, the Apostle Paul established this church by himself. He put leaders in place, set them on the right path, then leaves and heads to the next area to do the same thing. Now he must start all over re-establishing himself.
  - All because there are those in this fellowship who have sowed doubt in the minds of these believers, specifically about the validity of who Paul is. You can kind of see why his writings seem sarcastic. Mine would be too.

- I find it interesting how easy it is for us (as humans) to wander and get off track. How easy it is to mess things up with our thoughts and ideas. What easy pickings we are for the enemy. Honestly, if you leave most of us alone for more than a week, we will begin wandering off course, which tells us something.
  - It tells us that we must recognize this fundamental weakness that lies inside each one of us. In other words, we must admit to ourselves that we all are susceptible to wander. To slowly drift off track. And therefore, it's imperative we heed what 1 Peter tells us, and that is that we must be sober, alert, and vigilant.
    - All because "the enemy prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking who he may devour". And how does he do it? Through our minds, and our psyche. And so, if we know this to be the case, that we are all prone to wander, we must all agree that it's incumbent of each of us to protect ourselves against this very thing that lives within us.
  - But how do we protect ourselves from this "wandering disease"? By adhering to the spiritual disciplines set forth by God, through His Word. It's through His Word that we find our protection, our defense against our wandering minds. And what are the protections found in God's Word? Well, first of all we must adhere to Paul's words found in Romans 12:1-2:

Romans 12:1 Therefore I urge you, brothers *and sisters,* by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a living and holy sacrifice, acceptable to God, *which is* your spiritual service of worship.
Romans 12:2 And do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may prove what the will of God is, that which is good and acceptable and perfect.

- Look at what it says one more time. Romans 12:2 - Do not be conformed. Another way to say it is "resist". Don't allow the world to creep in on you. More importantly, be aware that the world is always working to creep in on you. And I am not just talking about bad

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things, as we would consider it bad.

- The world has a way of creeping in on you and distracting you when you don't even realize it. Even when it's not bad things. Meaning, in things you may passionately believe in, but things that are not particularly bad. Something like a conservative political stance or something financial or cultural.
- Whatever it is, if you aren't careful, those things, even if they are not 'per se' bad things, have a way of pressing in on you, consuming your time and making you busy and preoccupied. As I said, it may be a certain political stance or cause that you believe in.
  - If you aren't careful, you will find yourself spending more time on that than you do in God's Word. Maybe it's health. That's a good thing, but it can still be worldly, especially if it fills up your time and prevents you from "renewing your mind" through God's Word. Then it's not a good thing. You get the point. God's requirements and disciplines are first. Everything else comes second.

- Next, we have a Biblical Defense Mechanism against wandering. Hebrews 10:23-25:

Hebrews 10:23 Let's hold firmly to the confession of our hope without wavering, for He who promised is faithful;
Hebrews 10:24 and let's consider how to encourage one another in love and good deeds,
Hebrews 10:25 not abandoning our own meeting together, as is the habit of some people, but encouraging *one another;* and all the more as you see the day drawing near.

- Your second line of defense for your wandering mind is to stay close to the flock, to God's people, and do not forsake the assembling of your Christian brothers and sisters. It's simple. The deterioration of the Christian's life always begins the same way; by skipping church.
  - Going to church is one of the most important disciplines that a Christian must embrace. If we don't, we will begin to wander, and when the wandering begins everything in your Christian Life slowly begins to deteriorate. Life; Marriage; Finances; Health; Relationships, etc. Just fill in the blanks. Whatever it is will begin to deteriorate.
    - You see, gaining spiritual stability in your life is the only way to defend against wandering. Now let me lament for a minute. I am no one's judge, first because God told me specifically that is not my job, and second of all because I don't need anyone judging me.
- But, let me say, I am blown away at how clueless we are at recognizing the enemy's schemes, especially the scheme of robbing us of our time, and then how that translates into a deficiency of prayer, study time, and church attendance in our life, which are three primary defense mechanisms against our spiritual deterioration.
  - Church and church attendance in the 21st Century are on the decline, which was accelerated and reinforced by the pandemic. Christians are forsaking the assembling of the believers at an alarming rate, and the result is 'wanderings'.

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- It's simple. Don't pray, don't study, and don't attend church, and you will wander. There is no way around it and there is no replacement for it.
  - I had a guy tell me a couple weeks ago that he and his first wife used to attend church on a regular basis. But they got away from church and eventually grew apart and divorced. I thought to myself, he now knows what to do to stay married to his second wife. But I was wrong and evidently that wasn't the case.
  - Because when I asked him where they currently attended church, he said we don't. For me, my church takes place when I get up on Sunday mornings and ride my bike some 150 miles. That's when I feel closer to God, he said.

- I want you to remember that anything, including your thoughts, insights, emotions, or revelations; anything that is contrary to "The Word of God", isn't from God. It makes no difference how you feel. God never causes us to feel a way that is contrary to His Word!
  - His words are clear on forsaking the assembly of the believers. I am sure you have got the point by now. Paul says in verse 1, paraphrasing here, do we need to begin all over again by commending ourselves, or do we need to bring you letters of commendation?
    - And then in verses 2-4:

2 Cor. 3:2 **You are our letter, written in our hearts, known and read by all people,**
2 Cor. 3:3 **revealing yourselves, that you are a letter of Christ, delivered by us, written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God, not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts.**
2 Cor. 3:4 **Such *is the* confidence we have toward God through Christ.**

- Simply put, Paul says you are our letter, our proof of Christ, who He is, and what He has done. You are our letter, written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God. What Paul is saying, is our service is God working through us, rather than our independent service of Him.
  - Paul was contrasting God-confidence with self-confidence. Dr. Thomas Constable says, "Christianity is not the natural life lived on a higher plane. It is a divine life manifested in the energy of the Holy Spirit."
  - In other words, Paul said if you doubt us, look around. How do you think you got where you are? Was it on your own? Did this church establish itself? Did you do it? Did we do it? No, God did it. It was by and through the work of God.
    - You know what is interesting is, we all go through moments of doubt in our lives, where we question things in life. Is God with me, or is His hand on my situation? Did I make the right decision? Maybe, sometimes, we even doubt our faith. In those moments, if you pause and think about what Paul is saying here, you will find great comfort in your own moments of doubt.
- Paul is saying, stop and look around you. Examine where you were, and where you used to be. If you do, you will see how God's hand is firmly on your situation. As a matter of fact, your enlightenment, and your salvation, is living proof of this very fact.
  - In other words, there is no way you would have come as far as you have without

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Him, and He didn't bring you this far to abandon you. You are the living proof of all that He is: His Hand, His Presence, and His Divine Sovereignty. It is everywhere, all you must do is pause and look around. Do not doubt, even in times when He doesn't seem to be near. Because of His Word, you can gain confidence knowing that He is with you, and as Paul tells us in Philippians 1:6:

Phil. 1:6 ***For I am*** **confident of this very thing, that He who began a good work among you (Greek says in you) will complete it by the day of Christ Jesus.**

- So, when you're down, distressed, worried, or depressed, pause for a moment, look around, and think about all that God has done for you. Be thankful and give Him praise. For this, as Paul says in verse 4, "For this is the confidence you have toward God through Christ".
  - In other words, if you want a level set in your life, if you want to quit wandering in the desert, simply reflect on all the many blessings He has bestowed upon your life, specifically, where you are and where you could be if it weren't for those blessings. Make sense?
- Let's continue in the chapter:

2 Cor. 3:5 **Not that we are adequate in ourselves *so as* to consider anything as *having come* from ourselves, but our adequacy is from God,**
2 Cor. 3:6 **who also made us adequate *as* servants of a new covenant, not of the letter but of the Spirit; for the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life.**
2 Cor. 3:7 **But if the ministry of death, engraved in letters on stones, came with glory so that the sons of Israel could not look intently at the face of Moses because of the glory of his face, fading *as* it was,**
2 Cor. 3:8 **how will the ministry of the Spirit fail to be *even* more with glory?**
2 Cor. 3:9 **For if the ministry of condemnation has glory, much more does the ministry of righteousness excel in glory.**
2 Cor. 3:10 **For indeed what had glory in this case has no glory, because of the glory that surpasses *it.***
2 Cor. 3:11 **For if that which fades away *was* with glory, much more that which remains *is* in glory.**

- What Paul is saying or doing in these verses is contrasting the difference between the Mosaic Law and The Spirit of God. Or the difference between man's effort and God's effort. Specifically, the difference between what man must do to be right with God (The Law).
  - What the Spirit can do through you to make you right with God, through your yielding and obedience to the Spirit of God. In other words, if man wants to be made right with God by following the Law, under his own effort, then good luck because

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he will never obtain it.

- As you should all know by now, prior to Jesus, God gave the Jews the Law of Moses. A law that gave them direction. A law that established boundaries and rules for them to live by. Another way to say it is a law that kept them on track. They could depend on it and find great comfort in it.
    - Just like all of us find great comfort in knowing where we are going and what we are supposed to do, whether it be in our job or in our life. And let's be honest, there is great comfort in knowing the parameters or rules by which we should live, and that is exactly what the Law represented to the Jews.
    - It was their 'Rule Book', saying do this or do that and you will be right with God. Sounds great, but the problem was no one could keep the rules. And so, that begs the question, why did God create the rules in the first place? Why issue a set of rules and guidelines if He knew they couldn't keep them?
    - To show them exactly what it would take for them to be right with God and to enter Heaven. Perfection was the standard. But still, why show them what it would take to be right with God? Why show them perfection? Why did they need to know that?
        - So that once that revelation set in, that they were unable to do the impossible, it would set them up to receive their Messiah. Meaning, if you lived under the law, and tried desperately to achieve it, but you failed every day, never even coming close to reaching the level required to become righteous in the sight of God, then when God provided an alternative solution through a Messiah, one that would make a once and for all ultimate sacrifice on their behalf, all so that they could be free from the burden of guilt, brought about by the sin that lived inside of them.
    - When that Messiah arrived, you would think they would jump at the new and improved solution that God provided. All they had to do was accept Him and accept the work He would perform on their behalf. If they did that, then they would be made right with God, without them needing to keep the rules perfectly ever again.
    - You would think they would rejoice and immediately do away with the Old Covenant and the Law, and immediately accept in its place the New Covenant (through Jesus Christ). I mean, one is hard and burdensome and heavy and weighty, the other easy and light. One brings relief, the other stress!
        - But that wasn't the case. Man in his own wisdom struggled. His emotions, his mind, his feelings always gravitated back towards what he knew, what he felt comfortable with, what he could see and touch, the tangible for the non-tangible.
        - The church and the people would say, I hear you Paul, I hear you Peter, Titus, John, Apollos. I know I can feel it tugging at me like gravity. I know I should trust in Jesus. But I just can't do it, I need more. Something of substance, more concrete. Something more visible, even though I know I can't achieve it. I find comfort in it.
- You see, in verses 5-11, Paul is trying to show them, and by extension us, something here today. And that is, 'trust in the Spirit of God'. When you don't know what to do, trust the Spirit of God, which is made manifest through the Word of God.
    - This church lost its way. The church of today has lost its way. They wandered off

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track, and the church of today has wandered off track, and it all began with them questioning if Paul and the other Apostles were who they proclaimed to be?

- And that sort of thing always begins the same way, by listening to the nay sayers. Those who would say, 'look at the hard evidence'. It's easy to see. Paul promised to come visit you, but he never came. He didn't keep his word. He's not an Apostle. He has no Apostolic Authority. Trust in what you can see. I mean after all; would an Apostle not keep His word?
- Here's the application for us sitting here today. Listen closely. You cannot trust what you can see and feel. You can only trust what God wrote. One more time, you cannot trust in what you can see and feel, you can only trust in what God wrote.
  - Another way to say it is, when things seem to be one way, to make sense, you cannot trust it. The only thing you can trust is what God promised. What He spoke through the men he chose to speak it through. And so, what does that mean?
  - It means your knowledge, your intellect, your logic, your feelings, your good advice; either advice you receive or advice you give, is of no value if it's not grounded in God's word. And why? Because God's Word is God in Word Form, and it's in God's Word we find the truth! For He is truth.
  - John 17:15-17 says it this way:

John 17:15 **I am not asking You to take them out of the world, but to keep them away from the evil one.**
John 17:16 **They are not of the world, just as I am not of the world.**
John 17:17 **Sanctify them in the truth; Your word is truth.**

- Summing it all up, Paul is telling them to listen to God through the Spirit of God. They must put away what they can feel and touch, and in its place stop and look around and see all that God has done.
  - They are confused because they are trying to make a decision in the flesh. They are trying to lean into the law. What they can feel and touch. Paul is saying, listen to the Spirit who speaks through God's Men and through His Word.
  - The same still holds true for you and I today. Every day, we encounter decisions that we must make, and almost always, we try and process those decisions in our flesh, by and through the tangible information made available to us through our environment and through our experiences.
    - This gives way to us applying deductive reasoning using our intellect. When we do this, we are just like those Jews in the church of Corinth, reaching back to the Law and grabbing on to what makes sense. This is not the way you and I are to make decisions, that is the way the world makes decisions.
- Remember, God does not move us contrary to His Word, so how imperative is it for you to know His Word? Pretty imperative isn't it.
  - The lesson for us here today is what does God say? Then do it.
  - He said, do not forsake the assembling of the believers. He didn't say if you feel

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closer to God by being outdoors then that is good enough. God said we are to rightly divide the word of truth. He didn't say let someone else tell you what you believe.

- God said love thy neighbor as thyself, He didn't say unless you don't like them, or they get on your nerves, or they encroach on your boundary line. God said I have forgiven you, therefore you are to forgive others. He didn't say unless they don't deserve forgiveness.
  - Paul is trying to get them to make decisions based on the Spirt of God, not on the emotions and intellect of man. And the same is true for us!

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- Welcome back as we continue our journey through 2 Corinthians. Two weeks ago, we ended our lesson by studying the words Paul wrote, beginning with Chapter 3 verse 5 and continuing through verse 11.
    - In those verses, we could clearly feel Paul's frustration with this Church. His heightened sense of stress, if you will, as he desperately tries to get this church back on track with this letter. Remember, there was no internet or US Postal service in those days, so the only way a letter could be delivered was through a messenger or someone designated to deliver the letter.
        - And as we have previously discussed, Paul is writing this letter (as he does with all his epistles/letters) in an effort to correct their poor behavior. Like many churches, even in our day, they had gotten off track. And since Paul is the one who established this church in the first place, he obviously feels an even stronger obligation to right the ship.
- And so, in 2 Corinthians, up through Chapter 3, he continues to state his case and make a defense for himself. A defense for who he is and why they should heed his words and listen to him, rather than these false teachers who have made their way into the church.
    - Because (as he has already stated), he is not writing from his own wisdom or intellect, but rather by and through 'The Spirit of God'. You see, this church is confused, and the church of today is confused as well, and that's hard to believe about that church. I mean, how could this church or any church be so confused about the differences between right and wrong?
    - But, regardless of it being hard to believe, it happens. And why? Because they don't know God's word. And if you don't know Gods word, then you have no basis in which to measure God's standard, and, as previously stated, this not only happened to this church, but it's happening to the Church of the 21st Century at an even more alarming rate.
        - And the only defense we have against allowing false teaching to slip into our minds, and the minds of our children, is to know God's word. When it's remembered and absorbed, it will begin to resonate with the Spirit of God that lives inside of us. That is the only chance we have of staying on track.
        - When faced with tough decisions, all we must do is ask ourselves a question, "what does God's word say about the situation?" That's it. That's the only question. If we could ever figure that out, we could reduce the stress in our lives ten-fold.
- So, with that said, this church is trying to process what Paul is writing in this letter. After reading the letter, they must then begin to let it resonate with the Spirit that lives inside them. That is the only way they can come to the right conclusion. And what is the specific dilemma they were facing?
    - It was, and is, do they listen to the people around them, those familiar people living in and around them every day, those people who are trying to tell them that Paul and the other disciples are not called by God, that they aren't trustworthy? Or do they listen to Paul, based on what the Spirit of God says to them?
    - Like I said, it's absurd to think about, really. Someone questioned the Apostle Paul's validity, but that's what's happening. That is the current 'State of the Union' for this group of believers. But what was it specifically they were questioning?

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        - Well, among other things, it was mainly the debate over whether they should continue living under the Old Covenant, the Law of Moses (The Rules), versus living under the New Covenant of Jesus Christ, which comes by way of Grace yielding to 'The Spirit of God'.
    - Another way to say it was, should they continue to live by what they could 'Feel and Touch' versus living by 'The Spirit of God', or, one might say, living by the tangible versus the intangible.
- Now before moving on this morning, I want to pose a question to you. What does it mean when we say that someone lives by 'The Law, the Rules, by Feel and Touch' versus 'Living by the Spirit'?
    - Living by the Law means living by the Law or rules that God delivered through Moses. Specifically, the Law and rules given to the children of Israel prior to the arrival of Jesus. And by the way, if you choose to live that way it's not too bad, there are only 613 Laws to follow, so have at it.
    - Or you could choose the easier route, which is Living by the Spirit, which comes by way of accepting Jesus as your Lord and Savior by accepting His Sacrifice on the Cross at Calvary. But honestly, how does a believer live by the Spirit?
        - This phrase, 'Live by the Spirit', sounds very spiritual, doesn't it? I mean, when faced with a decision, if someone says to you, "hey, don't react harshly", or, "don't make a rash decision but rather, think about what you are doing and let the Spirit guide you". That sounds great, doesn't it? But what does it mean? And furthermore, how does a believer do such a thing?
- Let me explain this concept by giving you the inverse of what deciding in 'The Spirit' looks like. If you aren't sure what deciding in 'The Spirit' looks like, then let's talk about what doing the opposite looks like. And what is the opposite of the Spirit? It's the Flesh.
    - It combines the world around you and making decision based on your intellect, logic. You know this makes sense, so that is what I'll do. But that is not how God operates. We are called to live by His Word and line everything up against it.
        - But if you can learn to identify what making decisions in the flesh looks like, then you can at least, at a minimum, know what not to do. Right?
        - If I can recognize in myself what making non-spiritual decisions looks like, then at least I can identify it, and when I feel it coming on, I can pause and try to do the opposite. Now, before I do too much of a deep dive into this topic, let me say this. The less spiritually mature you are, the less likely you are to decide in 'The Spirit'. Which makes sense, right?
- The less in tune with God you are, the less likely you are to make a Godly decision or react in the way that God wants you to react. And so, once again, spiritual maturity is the key, and without it you will always struggle in critical spiritual decisions.
    - Now, a good 'fail safe' against reacting in the wrong way is to learn to recognize the triggers of the flesh. One of the most common triggers of the flesh is reacting too quickly. The number one defense against this common mistake is to pause before responding or reacting, but to do that you must know when you're making a reaction in the flesh.
    - And the best way to know it is by asking yourself a question, which is, does this

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excite my flesh? Meaning, does it cause a sense of indignation, justice, or retaliation to rise inside of me.

- Indignation, a sense of justice and retaliation, always finds its roots in this thing the Bible calls 'Pride'. Pride always causes our adrenaline to increase, our blood pressure to rise. And of course, this always happens when we least expect it. Someone says something that offends us, or rubs us the wrong way, and immediately, for most Christians, the first thing that happens is the flesh gets excited. Which results in what?
  - Anger. That feeling almost always emerges from the flesh, and for the most part nothing good ever comes from it. Because anything we say or do in the moment will almost always be the wrong thing to say or do. And so, what should we do?
  - First, we must identify what we really hope to accomplish in the situation. Which is what? We want to Glorify God in all we do. We want to say and do what God wants us to say and do. Which means we cannot react in the flesh. So, how do we prevent ourselves from doing that?
    - We must pause. Pause and wait. But for how long? For as long as it takes to lower your blood pressure, and clear your head, and ask God to guide you. And let me just say this about this process, it usually is not a very quick process. It takes time. In some cases, it may take days or even weeks. Sometimes the Spirit may impress upon you to remain silent forever. And why? Because silence may be the very best way to Glorify God.
    - That can be very hard to do, but that may be the true reality when making decisions in the Spirit. Many times, God is doing something outside your control and even outside your knowledge. And if that's the case, then obviously, that doesn't require us to do anything.
    - We just need to pray and get out of the way, and we must be okay with that, because God's Word never gives us the right to lash out and bring justice to our own situation. As a matter of fact, Paul addressed this issue directly in Colossians 3:12-17 when he said this:

Col. 3:12 So, as those who have been chosen of God, holy and beloved, put on a heart of compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, *and* patience;
Col. 3:13 bearing with one another, and forgiving each other, whoever has a complaint against anyone; just as the Lord forgave you, so *must* you *do* also.
Col. 3:14 In addition to all these things *put on* love, which is the perfect bond of unity.
Col. 3:15 Let the peace of Christ, to which you were indeed called in one body, rule in your hearts; and be thankful.
Col. 3:16 Let the word of Christ *richly dwell* within you, with all wisdom teaching and admonishing one another with psalms, hymns, *and* spiritual songs, singing with thankfulness in your hearts to God.
Col. 3:17 Whatever you do in word or deed, *do* everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks through Him to God the Father.

- Paul kind of sums it up for us here when he says, if you are a believer and someone

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wrongs you, you are to put on a heart of compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, and patience. These are attributes of the Spirit.

- And then in verse 13 he says, 'bear with one another'. In other words, *'give each other a break'.* And then we are to 'Forgive each other". And why? Because the Lord forgave you. He forgave you for all that you've done, and therefore, he says, 'so must you do also'.

- Now before moving into today's teaching, I want to back up and re-read 2 Corinthians 3:1-11 as a segway into our next set of verses. This is what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 3:1 **Are we beginning to commend ourselves again? Or do we need, as some, letters of commendation to you or from you?**
2 Cor. 3:2 **You are our letter, written in our hearts, known and read by all people,**

- I want to pause here for just a second and highlight something I feel eludes most Christians today.
  - If you are a believer, according to Paul, 'You' are the tangible, visible, outward manifestation of Christ to the world. That's what Paul means when he says, 'You are our letter, written in our hearts, known and read by all people'.
    - I want you to let that sink in for a minute. As believers, we are the outward manifestation of Christ to the world. This means for a lot of people; you may be the only Jesus they ever see. The question is, how you do feel you are doing with that responsibility? It's a sobering thought when you think about it, but it's the truth.
  - As believers the world is watching, and we need to think about that, especially when it comes to reacting out of the flesh.
- Moving on, verse 3-11:

2 Cor. 3:3 **revealing yourselves, that you are a letter of Christ, delivered by us, written not with ink but with the Spirit of the living God, not on tablets of stone but on tablets of human hearts.**
2 Cor. 3:4 **Such *is the* confidence we have toward God through Christ.**
2 Cor. 3:5 **Not that we are adequate in ourselves *so as* to consider anything as *having come* from ourselves, but our adequacy is from God,**
2 Cor. 3:6 **who also made us adequate *as* servants of a new covenant, not of the letter but of the Spirit; for the letter kills, but the Spirit gives life.**
2 Cor. 3:7 **But if the ministry of death, engraved in letters on stones, came with glory so that the sons of Israel could not look intently at the face of Moses because of the glory of his face, fading *as* it was,**
2 Cor. 3:8 **how will the ministry of the Spirit fail to be *even* more with glory?**
2 Cor. 3:9 **For if the ministry of condemnation has glory, much more does the ministry of righteousness excel in glory.**

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2 Cor. 3:10 For indeed what had glory in this case has no glory, because of the glory that surpasses *it.*
2 Cor. 3:11 For if that which fades away *was* with glory, much more that which remains *is* in glory.

- Let me just paraphrase what Paul is doing and saying here. Remember, he is trying to get these Converted Jews to lean on Jesus rather than the customs and traditions of the Law. He's trying to get them to learn to live by faith, by the Spirit, not by the flesh. And he is saying, 'The Law gave a set of rules that a Jew had to live by, but it was a ministry of death'. Because no one could keep it perfectly, and without keeping it perfectly, no one could enter heaven.
    - But God knew that, and therefore he made a new way, a New Covenant through Jesus. And so what he was telling this church was, forget the Law, the Rule Keeping, and believe me when I tell you there is a better way, and that better way is Jesus.
- Moving on, 2 Corinthians 3:12-18 he says this:

2 Cor. 3:12 Therefore, having such a hope, we use great boldness in *our* speech,
2 Cor. 3:13 and *we are* not like Moses, *who* used to put a veil over his face so that the sons of Israel would not stare at the end of what was fading away.
2 Cor. 3:14 But their minds were hardened; for until this very day at the reading of the old covenant the same veil remains unlifted, because it is removed in Christ.
2 Cor. 3:15 But to this day whenever Moses is read, a veil lies over their hearts;
2 Cor. 3:16 but whenever *someone* turns to the Lord, the veil is taken away.
2 Cor. 3:17 Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, *there* is freedom.
2 Cor. 3:18 But we all, with unveiled faces, looking as in a mirror at the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from glory to glory, just as from the Lord, the Spirit.

- There is a lot to unpack here, so let's get started beginning with Verse 12. Paul says they had such hope, that they used great boldness in their speech. What does that mean? Well, first, the words hope and boldness and courageous are used together all throughout scripture to describe the confidence we are to display when standing firm in our faith.
    - And when these words are combined, they tell us something, and that is, if we are saved, we should be bold about it. Not arrogant, not haughty, not walking around with an air, but confident in our 'Blessed Hope'. Our 'Hope of Salvation'. That is the confidence we have knowing that we know we are saved.
    - Knowing that God sent His only Son Jesus Christ to be a once-and-for-all sacrifice for the sins of the world, so that one day when we die, we can know confidently we will be with God and our loved ones who are saved in Heaven. The writer of Hebrews

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describes it this way in Hebrews 4:16:

Hebrews 4:16 Therefore let's approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace for help at the time of *our* need.

- Very simple concept, yet one that most Christians will never fully embrace. And why, well because they have not matured enough to come to the reality of who God really is and what He has done for us.
  - That reality has not fully taken hold in our life. It hasn't truly set in. Once it does, you will act differently. You will think differently. Because you have confidence, a confidence that you know God and that He knows you. Confidence that you know if you passed away today, you would spend eternity in Heaven.
    - When you reach that level of confidence it creates a boldness inside of you, and that boldness manifests itself to the outside world in action and in speech.
- If you are sitting here this morning and you're thinking to yourself, I don't really have that kind of boldness. I mean, I believe. I repented. I've been baptized. I have accepted Jesus as Lord and Savior. But I can't really say that I am so confident of the work of Jesus in my life that it has made me become bold. Certainly not bold enough that the world around me would see and feel it.
  - If this is your reality, and it is for many Christians, I don't want you to stress about it, and I certainly don't want you to question your salvation. Because Salvation, the process of becoming a Christian, and Sanctification, the process of spiritually maturing, are two totally different things.
  - Salvation is the moment in which God reaches down and pricks your heart, (convicts you), which causes you to realize you are in jeopardy. It's in that moment you feel a sense of anxiety or stress (conviction), because you feel a sense of jeopardy from not knowing what will happen to you when you die.
    - It's in that moment, when God opens a door for the individual, and when that individual accepts God's solution for their problem, which is Jesus Christ. Specifically asking God to forgive them (They repent and turn from the person they once where).
    - When that person repents and affirms that repentance and acceptance of Jesus through the outward symbol of Salvation to the world (through Baptism), the Bible says they will be saved. But that's just the beginning. Now you must mature. Move from Milk to Meat (as Hebrews describes it). That process is called Sanctification.
  - Sanctification is when a believer grows and matures by becoming more like Jesus. When you begin to mature you gain confidence, and that confidence emboldens you. That's where boldness comes from. So, if you don't feel bold, there is a reason, but it doesn't mean you are not saved.
    - It means you haven't matured spiritually to the point of having enough confidence in your Salvation and who God is. You haven't developed an intimate relationship with Him, which only comes by way of correctly Studying His Word. Now, I realize this seems like a whole lot of explanation for just one

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word. But it's important. Because I speak with men and women all the time who say, 'I am just not sure if I am saved'.

- Which would be a real hindrance to becoming confident and bold in your faith. That would be the opposite of becoming bold in your faith. I mean, if you just aren't sure you are saved, then it would be impossible to be confident and bold in what God has done for you, wouldn't it?

- Guys, God never wanted any of His children to lack *boldness,* but the only way you can become emboldened in your faith is to know God's Word, because His Word is Him. To become confident in your salvation, it's imperative you sit under a Pastor Teacher (a man called to teach the scriptures) and follow it up with your own study.
  - Not just reading the Bible, but the correct study of the Manuscript. When you do that, that's when your Salvation will be confirmed and that's where the Sanctification process will begin. And it's for this reason and this reason alone that Paul says he has such hope in Christ Jesus and that he speaks with Great Boldness.
  - It means he is so confident about who God is and Who he is in Christ Jesus that it causes him to stand tall when speaking.
- Moving on to verse 13, and this is where we will close this morning. Paul says:

2 Cor. 3:13 and *we are* not like Moses, *who* used to put a veil over his face so that the sons of Israel would not stare at the end of what was fading away.

- What does all this mean? Before explaining what he is saying let me make sure you understand the context. Paul is trying to explain to this church why they don't need to follow the Law anymore.
  - And so, for us to understand what he is saying, we must first start out by understanding who the people are he is referring to. From there we must understand the situation these people are in. And we do that by asking questions, like, who was Moses and what was his job?
    - Moses was the man God choose to deliver the Law (His Law - the rules) to the Children of Israel/the Jewish People. Those rules established the standard the Jews were to live by if they wanted to be made right or righteous before God.
- Next, who were the sons of Israel? They are the Children of Israel. Sons doesn't just mean males. It describes the entire group. And who were the Children of Israel? The Jews. God's chosen people. And where did they come from? God created them through Abraham. Prior to Abraham there were no Jews.
  - God called a man named Abraham out of a place called 'The Ur of the Chaldeans', and then told Abraham to take his wife (Sarah) and leave his homeland and go to a land in which He would show him. He also told him that He would make or create many nations through Him. And Abraham obeyed and God did what he said he would do.
    - Through Abraham, God created this group of people we know to be the Jews, which is God's chosen race of people. The people He chose to carry out a plan. They also eventually become known as the Israelites. But that's not all. There's

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more. From Abraham also came another group of people.

- And who were they? The Muslims, which is where we get the origin of Islam. But wait a minute. Aren't the Muslims bitter enemies of the *Jews*? And isn't that why there is so much war in the Middle East and wasn't that the root cause of 9-11?
  - Yes and no. It wasn't the direct reason for 9-11, but it was the underlying root cause. The Muslims hate the Jews and would like nothing more than to see them eradicated from planet earth, which is why they are always trying to push them out of Israel and take over.
- And so that's the way it is. God said it would be that way from the very beginning all the way until the end. But why? Because Abraham and Abraham's wife Sarah disobeyed God.
  - You see, God promised Abraham and Sarah a child one day, even though Sarah was barren (unable to have children). But Sarah became impatient and began to doubt God and she began to worry that she was getting too old to have kids. She thought to herself, maybe God has forgotten about us.
    - So, she decided to take matters into her own hands, and she conjured up a great idea. Instead of waiting on God, she decided to allow Abraham to lay with her hand maid Hagar. Hagar became a surrogate for Abraham and Sarah. And it worked. Sure enough, Hagar became pregnant and bore a child named Ishmael.
    - Galatians 4:29 says this about Ishmael, we're told he was a child born out of the flesh:

Galatians 4:29 **But as at that time the *son* who was born according to the flesh persecuted the one *who was born* according to the Spirit, so it is even now.**

- So, Ishmael was the child born of the Flesh. All because Abraham and Sarah took matters into their own hands and jumped ahead of God and tried to 'solve their problem' themselves.
  - Which turned out to be a bad idea, because eventually God did come through on His promise (as he always does), and Abraham and Sarah did have a child (even in her old age), and that child's name was Isaac. Isaac was the promised child, the child born of the Spirit.
    - And so now we have a problem. Two children. One child, Ishmael, born out of the flesh (not of God), and one child, Isaac, born of the Spirit (God's promised child). So, what now? Well, look one more time at what Paul said again in Galatians 4:29 about these two groups of people.

Galatians 4:29 **But as at that time the *son* who was born according to the flesh persecuted the one *who was born* according to the Spirit, so it is even now.**

- The people who came from Ishmael (The Muslims) would war against Isaac's people

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(The Jews). And sure enough, that is exactly what we have still today. The Muslims and the religion of Islam, those who descended from Ishamel, are bitter enemies of the people who came from Isaac (The Jews). And they will never be at peace.

- They will war against one another until Jesus returns. And why? Because of Abraham and Sarah's disobedience. So, back to the text. Who was Moses? God's chosen man whom He chose to deliver The Law, His Rules, to His chosen people - the Jews/the Nation of Israel - The Israelites. To the children of Israel. The Jewish people.
  - A Law that was impossible to keep because it contained 613 rules. No one could keep that many rules, and God knew that. That is why He sent Jesus. He became a once and for all 'Sacrifice' for all sins. He replaced the Law.

- But for the newly converted Jews, those who converted over to Christianity (By the way - we call those Messianic Jews), for them, they struggled with this concept because for 2000 years they lived under the Law. So, even though they were saved and converted over to Christianity, they kept gravitating back to the rules, and they are the ones Paul is writing to here in 2 Corinthians.
  - He was trying to explain to them why they no longer must follow the Law of Moses. He is doing this to refute the false teaching that was easing its way into this church. This false teaching made its way into this church through a group of Jews who had not been converted over to Christianity. And we call these people Judaizers.
    - They were staunch Orthodox Jews who were trying to unconvert these believers, and they were having some success by sowing seeds of doubt in the minds of these folks. They were telling the church that they could accept Jesus, but they still had to follow the rules. And this was a problem, because it undermined everything Jesus came and died for.
- And so, when we read verse 13, what we are reading is Paul trying to logically reason with this church in effort to get them to drop that line of thinking. But what does he mean when he says, in verse 13:

2 Cor. 3:13 and *we are* not like Moses, *who* used to put a veil over his face so that the sons of Israel would not stare at the end of what was fading away.

- The word boldness in Hebrew here means barefacedness. Paul could be barefaced (without a veil) in his confidence, because of the permanent character of the covenant under which he ministered.
  - Moses, in contrast, could not. He ministered with a literal veil over his face much of the time.
    - You can read about that in Exodus 34:29-35.
  - He removed the veil when he spoke with the people (Exodus 34:33), and when he spoke with God in the tabernacle. But he wore it at other times, evidently to teach the Israelites their unworthiness to behold God's Glory.
- Paul used this difference in ministry to illustrate the superior nature of the New Covenant under Jesus Christ. For these newly converted Jews the Law was familiar, it

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was comfortable, and they loved to lean on it.

- And even though we aren't Jews, don't we do the same when we feel comfortable with something? It could be a custom or tradition or routine. That is what Paul is contending with here, essentially, he is trying to get them to lean on Jesus and the Spirit of God and abandon the things they were comfortable with.

- If you struggle, look around. If you don't know if you believe at the level you should, look around. Look at creation. It is easy to see there is intelligent design going on. Our God is holding it all together.
  - And to refute those doubts, get out your Bible, ingest His Word.

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- So, this morning we will journey back in time to Paul's second Letter to the Corinthians. As we discovered in the introduction of the letter, 2 Corinthians is believed to be 4th Corinthians, but 1st Corinthians and 2nd Corinthians are the only two letters we have.
    - We know this to be the case because the other two letters are referenced in Paul's writings, but as I said, we don't have them. But why? Well, lucky for you I have a real deep theological answer. God didn't intend for those letters to be a part of the Cannon of Scripture.
    - And why? I have no clue, that's just the way it is. And so there you have it. We only have two of Paul's letters written to the Corinthian church and they are entitled First and Second Corinthians. And just remember, they are not chronological. They are simply the only two of the four letters we have.
- When we last left off, we were right in the middle of Paul continuing to put forth a defense for why this church and these believers should not be listening to the false teachers (primarily the Judaizers), who had been pushing a heretical teaching that said, yes, you can believe in Jesus, but you must also follow and live by 'The Law of Moses'.
    - Essentially, you must still stick to the rules. And as I stated a couple of weeks ago, for all of those who found, or still find comfort in the rules, then you're in luck if you can pull it off. If you can keep the rules perfectly, then you can indeed earn your way to heaven. But that's a tall order, seeing how there are over 600 rules you must follow.
        - Paul's message to these folks is clear. And by the way, the same message holds true today. Jesus died so that you and I could be made clean, without trying in our own power to make it happen. Righteousness, meaning clean, holy, and blameless before a perfect and Holy God.
        - Jesus was and is our once and for all sacrifice, and our acceptance of His work, coupled with our repentance and baptism, is all that God requires for us to enter Heaven's Gate.
- Now I want to pause here for a moment, and just touch on something. As we have discovered throughout our study of scripture, we know we do not have to keep the rules of the Old Covenant Law (the rules) to clean ourselves up. We are covered by the blood, and we live under grace.
    - But if you think that's it. That somehow, you simply repeat a prayer, ask Jesus to save you, and then you can go on living however you want, you are way off course.
    - And furthermore, if you are okay with that concept, not convicted about the way you might be living, in whatever capacity, specifically living a Non-God-Glorifying life, then you might want to check yourself. Because if you are saved you will be convicted if you are doing something or living in a way that is contrary to God's Law, to His expectation of your life.
        - This is addressed specifically in James 2:14-17:

James 2:14 What use is it, my brothers *and sisters,* if someone says he has faith, but he has no works? Can that faith save him?
James 2:15 If a brother or sister is without clothing and in need of daily food,
James 2:16 and one of you says to them, "Go in peace, be warmed and be filled,"

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yet you do not give them what is necessary for *their* body, what use is that?
James 2:17 **In the same way, faith also, if it has no works, is dead, *being* by itself.**

- I'm bringing this up because if we are not careful, we move from a place of legalism (rule following) to a place of anything goes by saying, 'we're good, we are covered by His blood, and we live by Grace'.
  - I have had people say this to me before, 'yes, I did this or that, but you know, praise God I am under Grace'. If that's your thought process, I can assure you that is the wrong thought process. Instead, our attitude should be, yes, I did this or that and I am ashamed and broken and convicted. I have repented and am desperately trying to change.
  - Grace is not a license to do whatever we want to do. It simply removes the burden of all the rules following, coupled with the requirements of the sacrificial system. And so, as it relates to Salvation, and God's New Covenant solution through Jesus Christ, the only question is, do you understand Salvation through Jesus, and have you made that decision?
- So, Paul makes his defense for the New Covenant of Jesus, which comes by way of Grace versus The Rules under the Old Covenant Law of Moses, and he continues that same theme moving forward in 2 Corinthians 3:12-18, so follow with me as we break down these verses:

2 Cor. 3:12 **Therefore, having such a hope, we use great boldness in *our* speech,**
2 Cor. 3:13 **and *we are* not like Moses, *who* used to put a veil over his face so that the sons of Israel would not stare at the end of what was fading away.**
2 Cor. 3:14 **But their minds were hardened; for until this very day at the reading of the old covenant the same veil remains unlifted, because it is removed in Christ.**
2 Cor. 3:15 **But to this day whenever Moses is read, a veil lies over their hearts;**
2 Cor. 3:16 **but whenever *someone* turns to the Lord, the veil is taken away.**
2 Cor. 3:17 **Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, *there* is freedom.**
2 Cor. 3:18 **But we all, with unveiled faces, looking as in a mirror at the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from glory to glory, just as from the Lord, the Spirit.**

- There is a whole lot being said in these verses. So, let me unpack it this morning. First, Paul begins verse 12 with the word 'therefore', and as we've discovered in the past, whenever we see the word therefore, we must ask ourselves, what's is there for?
  - This word is referencing back to what he just said in the previous verses. He just told this church why the New Covenant through Jesus Christ was far superior to the Old Covenant and The Law through Moses.
  - And he begins this verse by making a statement that should ring true for every

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Christian. And that is, because we have the hope of Salvation, of Heaven, the Blessed Hope as Paul calls it elsewhere in scripture, we should be bold in our speech when speaking about what God has done for us.

- Meaning, we shouldn't be mousy, or shy, or reserved. We should be bold but not arrogant. Not prideful or haughty or holier than thou, but bold and confident in our faith. So bold and so confident that we can't wait to share the Good News with others about Jesus Christ.
- And I've got to be honest with you folks. In a world that is so prosperous, yet so poor, our message should resonate loudly with those around us. Because even though people are doing so well (financially speaking), they are still dying inside.
- Day after day, I run into these people. People that appear to be doing fine on the outside, but privately they are hurting and suffering. Which means, your boldness, if displayed correctly (which is in conjunction with the Holy Spirit in humbleness), will resonate and reach people at an alarming rate. And I am not just talking about lost people. I am talking about Church people as well.

- This morning, I want to give you just a little bit of insight into exactly what I am talking about as it relates to the church of today. Specifically, its position in time before God. Now, what do I mean when I say, its position in time before God?
  - The church was established on the day of Pentecost, reflected in the 2nd Chapter of the Book of Acts, and from that day moving forward, it found itself operating in different ways, with a different purpose throughout history. Meaning, as society evolved and changed, the church changed with it.
  - More specifically, it took on a different persona or reacted differently to the world around it. Many theologians believe that the Church was depicted (at different intervals of time), by and through John's seven letters written to the Seven churches in the Book of Revelation in Chapters 2 & 3. (See slide in video)
    - So the 7 letters to the 7 churches, from Ephesus to Laodicea, also see a progression in time. Starting with the Apostolic church, then the persecuted church. The Roman Empire church then the Roman Catholic Church and the Reformation church (when the Protestants broke off from Catholicism). Then we moved to the Missionary church which was all about seeing people saved through missions.
    - In the end times we have the Apostate church. Apostasy means "fallen away". There are a lot of interesting descriptions of this church.
- The church began at Pentecost and throughout history it evolved and changed and served a purpose according to God's divine plan. And so, when we read John's letters, we can clearly see certain characteristics of that church at that point in the history of mankind.
  - Which is why I say the letters represent the 'Church' throughout history. Which should leave us asking a question, and that is, which church in John's seven letters best fits the church of today? That would be the church of Laodicea.
  - When you study this church and its characteristics, you can definitively know that there has never been a church throughout the history of the church that more closely mirrors Laodicea than the one that exists in our day. We're talking about the

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body of believers, not the buildings.

- Let me turn to Revelation, read and explain the descriptors of this church, and see if this appears to be the case. Now before reading this, I would like to point something out. John wrote these 7 letters to the 7 Churches that resided in Asia Minor, or what is modern-day Turkey.
  - And in those letters, five of the churches received a commendation, an opening statement about what they have done right, followed by correction, what they needed to improve on. But two of the churches, which happen to be 'Sardis and Laodicea', received no commendation, only correction. Because they hadn't done anything right.
  - Laodicea is the seventh and final church that John writes to, and as I said it receives no commendation, no pat on the back. It simply receives rebuke and correction. I want you to listen to what John writes about this church:

Revelation 3:14 "To the angel of the church in Laodicea write. The Amen, the faithful and true Witness, the Origin of the creation of God, says this:
Revelation 3:15 'I know your deeds, that you are neither cold nor hot; I wish that you were cold or hot.
Revelation 3:16 So because you are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold, I will vomit you out of My mouth.
Revelation 3:17 Because you say, "I am rich, and have become wealthy, and have no need of anything," and you do not know that you are wretched, miserable, poor, blind, and naked,
Revelation 3:18 I advise you to buy from Me gold refined by fire so that you may become rich, and white garments so that you may clothe yourself and the shame of your nakedness will not be revealed; and eye salve to apply to your eyes so that you may see.
Revelation 3:19 Those whom I love, I rebuke and discipline; therefore be zealous and repent.
Revelation 3:20 Behold, I stand at the door and knock; if anyone hears My voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and will dine with him, and he with Me.
Revelation 3:21 The one who overcomes, I will grant to him to sit with Me on My throne, as I also overcame and sat with My Father on His throne.
Revelation 3:22 The one who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches.'"

- We could spend two or three weeks unpacking just these eight verses. But we are in 2 Corinthians, so I don't want to do that. But let me say, this description of this church fits perfectly with the church of today and let me explain why. Look at John's description of this church.
  - They are neither hot nor cold, but lukewarm, which causes God to vomit them out of His mouth. They say they are 'rich' and have become wealthy and have no need of anything. But they do not realize they are wretched, miserable, poor, blind, and

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naked.

- And God says to them, “I advise you to buy from me gold refined by fire so that you may become rich, and white garments, so that you may clothe yourself and the shame of your nakedness will not be revealed; and then this is key, they need eye salve to apply to their eyes so that they may see.

- Now, paraphrasing for you, I want to work backwards first. This church is full of people. We know this to be the case when we do a deeper dive into the history of this church. It is indeed full of people, but these church people are much different than any other church people in any of the other letters. And what’s the difference? They are not saved. But how do we know that? We know it from verse 18, where he says:

Revelation 3:18 **I advise you to buy from Me gold refined by fire so that you may become rich, and white garments so that you may clothe yourself and the shame of your nakedness will not be revealed; and eye salve to apply to your eyes so that you may see.**

- Buying gold refined by fire means purchasing something that is pure. But what is it that John is specifically referencing? Well, we get the answer midway through the verse, they are purchasing ‘white garments’, which is always a reference to Righteousness or Salvation in Scripture.
  - We also get another clue to their Spiritual State when John says, become rich. In other words, you are not rich, which is not a reference to finances. It’s a reference to Salvation.
    - God has no use for money and that’s not the context of the verse. We get even more confirmation of this at the end of the verse, when he says, ‘you need eye salve to apply to your eyes so that you may see’.
    - Once again, this is a clear reference to Salvation, which tells us something. It tells us that the previous references of them being neither hot nor cold but lukewarm, is a direct reflection of their Spiritual State. Their salvation.
    - Hot means someone is saved, and Cold means they are not. And Lukewarm means that they are what? Well, many preachers throughout history have said it means these people are backslidden, but that’s not the case, because there is no such thing as it pertains to Salvation. You are either saved or you’re not. There is no in-between. It’s like pregnancy. You are either pregnant or you are not. Same is true for salvation. You are either saved or you are not.
  - But wait a minute, because I don’t know if I agree with you Pastor. I know plenty of people (including myself) who have fallen off or backslidden spiritually at different times in their lives. I don’t disagree with that statement, but at no time did they lose their salvation.
  - But what could it mean when someone says they have backslidden? It could mean that are at a spiritual low in their walk with God. But salvation is an event, sanctification is a process.
- These verses give us descriptors of what salvation looks like and what it doesn’t look like. Hot is a picture of salvation and cold is a picture of someone who is not saved (No

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Salvation). So, what is lukewarm, kind of saved? No such thing.

- Look at the other language John uses to further confirm he is speaking about salvation. You need to be refined. You need white garments, you are blind, you think you are rich (a reference to salvation) but you are not. These descriptors all paint a picture of unbelief. Those without salvation.
  - And so, John is clearly painting a picture of what salvation looks like versus what it doesn't look like, and if that's the case, then what's Lukewarm? It represents those who think they are saved, but they are not. But why? What causes this? There is something that causes this, but what is it? Wealth. The world's wealth, money, stuff, prosperity.
  - Look at verse 17:

Revelation 3:17 **Because you say, "I am rich, and have become wealthy, and have no need of anything," and you do not know that you are wretched, miserable, poor, blind, and naked,**

- Wealth creates self-reliance. What a powerful statement. Wealth creates self-reliance. But why? Because when we prosper, we have no need for God. And once again, why? Because we seemingly have no problems. But what else creates self-reliance? Knowledge, specifically false knowledge. The wisdom of the world, which is foolishness to God.
  - Paul tells us this in 1 Corinthians 3:18-19:

1 Cor. 3:18 ***Take care that*** **no one deceives himself. If anyone among you thinks that he is wise in this age, he must become foolish, so that he may become wise.**
1 Cor. 3:19 **For the wisdom of this world is foolishness in the sight of God. For it is written: "*He is* THE ONE WHO CATCHES THE WISE BY THEIR CRAFTINESS";**

- At no other time in history has the church been so wealthy (I didn't say the world, I said the church). Also, at no other time has the church been so seemingly wise. Wise because we live in the information age. Once again, notice I said, 'The Church'. I am not talking about corrupt churches of the past that stole people's money.
  - I am talking about the believers themselves, which make up the 'True Church'. At no other time in Church history have the people who make up the church been so financially prosperous and seemingly wise and would say we don't need God. Today more than ever, people are doing extremely well, saying to themselves we are rich and have need of nothing.
  - But the fact of the matter is, they are dying inside, and I run into it every day. Let me digress on this point by leaving you with the following thoughts:
    - Number 1: if the church of Laodicea is a picture of the end-times church, and I believe it is, then that means our churches are full of lost people.

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        - Number 2: The greatest opportunity for evangelism is inside the walls of the buildings we call the church.
        - Number 3: It also means although people appear to be doing good on the outside, they are not.
- And so, what are we to do? Well, first, we must get to the core root of the problem if we ever hope to improve it. And we do that by asking ourselves why is the church in such a poor spiritual state? Specifically, how in the world could churches be full of people who are not saved.
    - I mean, isn't that the purpose of the church, to get people saved? Yes, it is, but no it's not. You see, we don't save anyone. That's the problem. The church has gotten good at counterfeiting the work of the Holy Spirit. Creating emotional, amped-up church services that lead people into an emotional experience.
    - But the question is, is that how people are saved? No. So how are they saved? Romans 10:17 tells us:

Romans 10:17 Faith comes by hearing and hearing by the word of Christ.

- But what is the word of Christ? The scriptures. God convicts people through His word. Not through great and wonderful human stories or motivational messages.
    - Which means, we as a church must return to teaching the scriptures if we want people to be truly convicted, and consequently saved. God gave us the prescription for Salvation. Faith comes by hearing and hearing by the Word of Christ.
        - Get rid of all the bells and whistles and return to solid foundational, unaltered Bible teaching, because that's what saves people. And once salvation sets in, it's then, and only then, that we as a body of believers, the true Church, will become bold and confident, living out what we know to be the truth. And so, there it is, there's the answer to the problem facing today's church.
        - Pressing on let's close. Verses 13-17. Let me read them once more time as a refresher.

2 Cor. 3:13 and *we are* not like Moses, *who* used to put a veil over his face so that the sons of Israel would not stare at the end of what was fading away.
2 Cor. 3:14 But their minds were hardened; for until this very day at the reading of the old covenant the same veil remains unlifted, because it is removed in Christ.
2 Cor. 3:15 But to this day whenever Moses is read, a veil lies over their hearts;
2 Cor. 3:16 but whenever *someone* turns to the Lord, the veil is taken away.
2 Cor. 3:17 Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, *there* is freedom.

- Paul says, we are not like Moses, who would put a veil over his face so that the sons of

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Israel would not stare at the end of what was fading away. As I said a couple of weeks ago, many times when Moses would speak to the Children of Israel (The Jews - Gods Chosen People), he would cover His face.

- In verse one, Paul said we are to be bold. The word boldness here in Hebrew means barefacedness. Paul was saying that he could be barefaced (without a veil) in his confidence because of the permanent character of the covenant under which he ministered.
- Moses on the other hand, in contrast, could not. He ministered with a literal veil over his face much of the time. That's what Exodus 34:29-35 tells us. The only time he would remove it was to speak to the people, the children of Israel (Exodus 34:33), and when he spoke with God in the tabernacle.
  - But he wore it at other times, evidently to teach the Israelites their unworthiness to behold God's glory.

- Paul used this difference in ministry to illustrate the superior nature of the New Covenant under Jesus Christ, to that of the old nature of the Old Covenant under Moses. Next, in verse 14, Paul says, that their minds were hardened, for until this very day at the reading of the Old Covenant the same veil remains unlifted, because it is removed in Christ.
  - Even today Jews do not believe in Jesus Christ, and still adhere to the Old Covenant - their eyes are closed. And until they cry out, which will happen at the end of Tribulation, they are under this hardening. This veil cannot be lifted until they accept Jesus Christ.
  - And then to further confirm what Paul is saying, he says this in verse 15-17:

2 Cor. 3:15 But to this day whenever Moses is read, a veil lies over their hearts.

- Meaning, if they try and adhere to the Old Covenant and the Law of Moses, a veil lies over their heart. Which is another way of saying they are blind and can't see the truth. But, having said that, verse 16 says:

2 Cor. 3:16 but whenever *someone* turns to the Lord, the veil is taken away.

- Whenever someone turns to God the veil is removed. Meaning, once they turn to God, then, and only then, are they given eyes to see and ears to hear. And then finally he says in verse 17:

2 Cor. 3:17 Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, *there* is freedom.

- Freedom, what an interesting word that Paul uses here. Paraphrasing, he's saying, if you have the Spirit of the Lord living inside of you, you are free. You have freedom. Real freedom. But freedom from what? Bondage and slavery - to sin! The thing that separates you from God.

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    - This morning, the question is, do you have freedom? Are you free indeed? Or do you walk around feeling bound up, enslaved, with a sense of jeopardy about your future? You see, when you know that you know you are good, meaning, when you know that God has got you, that you're one of His, and that He's got your family, your loved ones, there is no better sense of Freedom.
    - My prayer for all of you here today is that each one of you has that feeling that you walk in, in a place of freedom. Meaning, you carry with you a sense of peace wherever you go, because there is no better joy or peace on earth.
- Guys, a few months back I received a bad diagnosis. That journey all started with a Primary Care Physician, which led to a CT scan, which then led to an ENT who then sent me for an MRI. From there, the ENT sent me to Vanderbilt, where I met with a Neurosurgeon, to discuss cutting me from one side of my head to the other. I had a bone cyst (fancy way of saying tutor) behind my frontal sinuses above my left eye. I was told it was growing inward and was touching my brain and causing edema (swelling) to the brain.
    - When I first received the news from the ENT, he tried to candy coat it, but I wouldn't let him do it. I could tell by his face that he was worried about what he saw.
    - I remember going out to my truck and thinking to myself, well, I need to make sure my wife and the kids don't have to deal with business messes if something happens to me. Honestly, it was really my first time facing immortality. I didn't realize it at the moment, but later, as I reflected on it, at that moment, when I received the news from the ENT, at no point did I remember feeling scared.
        - Instead I had a peace which surpassed all understanding. I had a boldness in my faith, because of the blessed hope of knowing that my life is temporary and being with God is forever.
- Let's close with 2 Corinthians 5:6-8:

2 Cor. 5:6 Therefore, being always of good courage, and knowing that while we are at home in the body we are absent from the Lord—
2 Cor. 5:7 for we walk by faith, not by sight—
2 Cor. 5:8 but we are of good courage and prefer rather to be absent from the body and to be at home with the Lord.

- So what that means is when I breathe my last breath here on earth, I will breathe my first breath there in Heaven with my Savior.

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- This morning turn with me if you will to the 4th Chapter of the book of 2 Corinthians. We will continue our journey through Paul's letter, which some might call a letter of 'desperation', a letter born out of stress and anxiety. Stress and anxiety over how this church was being swayed by false teaching, ancient mysticism, and a host of other things.
    - Last week, we ended our teaching with Verse 18, where Paul wrote the following, and I will just read it for context, and here's what Paul wrote in verses 16-18:

2 Cor. 3:16 **but whenever *someone* turns to the Lord, the veil is taken away.**
2 Cor. 3:17 **Now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, is freedom.**
2 Cor. 3:18 **But we all, with unveiled face, beholding as in a mirror the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from glory to glory, just as from the Lord, the Spirit.**

- Paul says, now the Lord is the Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom. This is a simple statement at its core, and if someone heard this, it should prompt a question in the mind of the individual. And that question would be:
    - If 'The Spirit of The Lord' brings freedom, then how do I get the Spirit of the Lord and what kind of freedom are we talking about?
        - The answer is, when a person turns to God, turns to Christ Jesus, and accepts the 'free' gift of Salvation, and repents (asks for forgiveness), and asks God into their heart, they will be saved.
        - That salvation, or just knowing they are saved, brings freedom. A freedom that no man has ever known. But, why? Why does it bring such freedom? Because it is a fact that 100% of people die. Every individual on planet earth dies 100% of the time.
- Depending on our individual situation and our phase of life, we wake up at some point with fear of the unknown, and Paul says, once we turn to the Lord, the veil is taken away. Meaning, once we realize our position in life, when immortality sets in, at that point, fear of the unknown becomes a reality, and we realize our plight and turn to God

John 1:9 **If we confess our sins, He is faithful and righteous, so that He will forgive us our sins and cleanse us from all unrighteousness.**

- And attached to that forgiveness is freedom, which brings about Peace. That's really all it is, an eternal peace that comes from knowing you're saved, that there is more after this life.
    - This past week I lost a dear friend to cancer. He was a very confident man, a funny man, an intelligent man. He was my kind of guy. He was 72 years old and was given a death sentence diagnosis last year sometime.
    - A few weeks ago, he was doing quite well, but this past week he took a turn for the worse. I went to his home this past Tuesday and spent a little time with him. The

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best way I believe I could describe him was he lived life to the fullest.

- I never met a man with more stories, and that's saying something coming from me. But anyway, as I sat there and prayed with him and laughed with him, he said to me repeatedly, 'I'm ready. God has given me a good life and I am ready'.
- You see, because he knew Jesus he had a peace. Was he nervous? Yes. But he wasn't scared or fearful. He was looking forward to Heaven and seeing his mother. He was at peace. That is the freedom that Paul is talking about, and it's the freedom available to every one of us sitting here today.

- Those were Paul's words at the end of verse 17, and those words still hold truth for anyone who will call upon the name of the Lord.

- Moving on, Chapter 4:1-6. The translators entitle this chapter 'Paul's Apostolic Ministry'.

2 Cor. 4:1 Therefore, since we have this ministry, as we received mercy, we do not lose heart,
2 Cor. 4:2 but we have renounced the things hidden because of shame, not walking in trickery nor distorting the word of God, but by the open proclamation of the truth commending ourselves to every person's conscience in the sight of God.
2 Cor. 4:3 And even if our gospel is veiled, it is veiled to those who are perishing,
2 Cor. 4:4 in whose case the god of this world has blinded the minds of the unbelieving so that they will not see the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.
2 Cor. 4:5 For we do not preach ourselves, but Christ Jesus as Lord, and ourselves as your bond-servants on account of Jesus.
2 Cor. 4:6 For God, who said, "Light shall shine out of darkness," is the One who has shone in our hearts to give the Light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Christ.

- There is so much being said in these verses, and a lot to break down; some of which brings about controversy within the Church. But, before getting to the controversy, let's start with verses 1&2, and deal with those verses first.
  - Paul begins by using the word "therefore" again, and when we see that word, we ask ourselves, what's the therefore there for? It's there based off his previous statements in the previous chapter, where he says we have freedom because we are saved. Because we have the Spirit of the Lord living inside us.
  - Then the next thing, therefore, 'since we have this ministry'. In other words, since we know this, and since we have received this mercy, we do not lose heart.
- Guys, this is so important. If we are believers, we should never lose heart. Never get down about our life situations. Instead, because we are saved, when life hits us in the face we should reflect on this very fact, and 'never lose heart'.
  - Now that sounds simple, but is that the way it always is? I would ask, is that the way it ever is for you? Yes – No – Maybe. Paul says they don't lose heart because they

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have received salvation, and by extension, the exact same thing is true for us as well. But what if that's not the case. What if we do lose heart, then what do we do?

- Well first let me clarify what Paul is talking about before dealing with this issue. And I can't do that unless I ask myself the question, what does Paul mean when he says, 'they don't lose heart'?

- To get to the bottom of his statement we must ask ourselves, what is this 'losing heart' thing tied to? It's tied to the topic of Salvation, because that's what he just got through writing about. The Spirit of The Lord – Freedom.
  - So, with that thought in mind, losing heart must be related to their faith or mission or calling from God. Paul says, because we have this ministry and because we received mercy (salvation), we do not lose heart.
  - That does not exclude us from worry, but we stay the course, press on in the face of adversity, because we know God is in control.

2 Cor. 4:2 **but we have renounced the things hidden because of shame, not walking in trickery nor distorting the word of God, but by the open proclamation of the truth commending ourselves to every person's conscience in the sight of God.**

- Now this can be a little confusing. The first thing to ask is, what are these things hidden (renounced because of shame) and why? We find the answer in the context - with Paul responding to his critics trying to undermine his efforts, he continues on in his self-defence. Paul was ashamed of the things he had done and who he was prior to Christ. He has repented and now stands firmly on the pure truth of God's Word.
  - Paul is saying the lives of those in the Corinthian church are witness to the gospel of Jesus Christ. God uses their witness to grab the attention of the unbelieving world, to prick their conscience. What is different about them?
  - The church needs to hear that as believers, our lives are a living testimony. It doesn't require words. God can use our lives to convict others, draw people to Himself. And that's important to hear because its a different version of witnessing we may have been brought up under.
  - Most of us have been taught to go tell people about Jesus - the Great Commission. But as I've previously taught you, that's not the case.

Matthew 28:19 **Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit,**
Matthew 28:20 **teaching them to observe all that I commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age."**

- The key to the Great Commission lies in how we make disciples. But let's first clarify what a disciple is.
  - A disciple is a follower of Jesus Christ, they were His understudies if you will. And

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that's gotta be someone who is saved. So is it even possible for us to "make them"?

- Disciples are made when people are saved, and that can only take place when they are taught the word of God. And then, God, not us, convicts someone from His Holy Manuscript.
  - It's not by giving our testimony, or a convincing argument. This prescribed (and outdated) method of the church is not what scripture is asking us.
  - Let me remind you of a statement by Dr. Chuck Missler: "Remember the Berean way". For the Bereans were considered to be the most studious of people - they didn't just take someone's word for it. They would study the scriptures daily to find that these things might be true.
- Can we think of a part of scripture in where someone becomes a disciple of Jesus Christ through the listening to another's testimony? I can't. The Apostle Paul had the greatest testimony anyone's ever had, yet he never used it as a means of leading someone to salvation. In Acts, we can read Paul's encounter with the Philippian jailer and how he lead that man and his family to Christ.

Romans 10:17 **So faith *comes* from hearing, and hearing by the word of Christ.**

- If we want to see people saved, we must teach them the scriptures. And if we want spiritual maturity for them and us, we have to teach (and study) the scriptures.

This is further reinforced in Matthew 28:20.

Matthew 28:20 teaching them to observe all that I commanded you; and lo, I am with you always, even to the end of the age."

- So does this mean we never give somebody our testimony? Of course not, no. But we don't do it as a means of convincing someone to salvation but rather for encouragement. As a means of thankfulness for all God has done.
  - Our testimony should be viewed like that of an altar in the Old Testament - as a marker of where God has brought us. People pass by and see it.
  - Paul is saying our lives our actions, who we are, is what God uses to draw men to Himself. Not words. Words are easy, actions are hard and come by way of time and study and spiritual maturity.
    - So our actions matter a lot, because people are watching!
- We move next into these controversial verses 3-4. If you gloss over them you might miss the controversy. I feel it is important to teach you exactly what Paul is saying, and I think it's important for me to point out the apparent conflict. And why? Well, for two reasons.
  - First, so that you are prepared to give a defense of the scriptures. There are many people out there, Bible nay sayers, who live to point out what they believe are inconsistencies in the scriptures. We need to be prepared to answer their objections.
  - The second reason is to understand what Paul is saying, especially as it relates to the doctrine of salvation - soteriology. It matters, because it influences how you approach another person with the Gospel of Jesus Christ and how you view your responsibility in the process - and that result is not on you.

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- And so, with that thought in mind, let's re-read verse 16:

2 Cor. 3:16 **but whenever *someone* turns to the Lord, the veil is taken away.**

- This statement is a 100 % true statement. If someone turns to the Lord and asks the Lord to forgive them (they repent), He will save them, and that holds true 100% of the time.

2 Cor. 4:3 **And even if our gospel is veiled, it is veiled to those who are perishing,**
2 Cor. 4:4 **in whose case the god of this world has blinded the minds of the unbelieving so that they might not see the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.**

- In Chapter 3 we are told that as soon as someone believes this veil is taken away. Then in Chapter 4 we are told the gospel is veiled to those who are perishing. So on the one hand, anyone who turns to God will be saved. But on the other hand, there seems to be a group of people who are in a state of perishing - with no hope. This is where conflict can be envisioned.
- How could some people never have an opportunity to turn to the Lord? This statement has been the topic of many a theological debate, boiled down to two camps of people.
  - Armenians, who believe all people are given the opportunity to be saved and therefore it is up to us to provide them that opportunity. There's a sense of stress and anxiety that "it's on us". That idea has fuelled the evangelical church movement which does whatever it can to draw people in - church services turn into rock concerts.
    - Originally, the intention was pure but then over time it began to waver. They failed to recognise how someone is actually saved. It wasn't until the mid-20th century that preachers moved away from bible teaching, introduced the altar call (which has no base in scripture) and saw an increase of numbers. But sound doctrinal teaching gave way to emotional storytelling, topical messages.
    - This leads to megachurches. Audience members enjoying the service, but not remembering the message or what bible was taught.
  - Now opposite the Armenian view is Calvinism which says God has predestined some for salvation and others to be left out. This view has lead some to become lazy as it relates to evangelism. "If God already knows who will be saved, what's the point in wasting our time trying to reach people?"
    - This group of people tend to become scripture hounds. They may thirst for knowledge but they lose empathy.
- I can tell you with 100% certainty that we do not know who is going to be saved. But God does - he knows the beginning from the end.
  - But we are commanded to go and make disciples - we know how after this morning. We go not because we can influence the results but because we are bond-servants to the God Most High. And slaves don't get rights or opinions! We simply obey the master.

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- So what about these “conflicting” views? They are both 100% true! God is sovereign and knows all thing, and man has responsibility. And all those who turn to the Lord will be saved. God knows who will be saved and who will perish (some who will never turn to the Lord).
- God is the one who corrects the heart. Romans 3 tells us no man seeks God.
    - God has to lift the veil and open the eyes. Then man has to respond, but will he? The Armenians say there is no guarantee man will respond. The Calvinists say, no doubt he or she will respond because God will cause them to respond.
- Let’s digress for a moment and talk about God’s sovereignty. We might think we are in control, but God started this thing on time and will end it on time. He knew us before he formed us in our mother’s womb. He has appointed our time to day. And yet man has responsibility.
    - How do we reconcile it? It’s a futile effort. Instead we need to focus on obedience, and to serve the Lord without question. Who are we to question the Creator of the universe?
    - Pauls echoes this sentiment in Romans 9:20-21.

Romans 9:20 **On the contrary, who are you, O man, who answers back to God? The thing molded will not say to the molder, “Why did you make me like this,” will it?**
Romans 9:21 **Or does not the potter have a right over the clay, to make from the same lump one vessel for honorable use and another for common use?**

- Remember there is no conflict in God’s word, only the lack of understanding Who God is. We have to study long enough, let His word penetrate our hearts and minds, to get a complete understanding of the whole counsel of scripture.
- If the plain sense makes common sense, seek no other sense. If it doesn’t make sense, study some more!

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This morning, we return to our journey through 2 Corinthians. When we last left off, we did so by breaking down and studying 2 Corinthians 4:1-6, and since we took a week off for Mother's Day, I want to back up and re-read and re-study these verses just a little more in-depth.

The last time we were together I just lightly brushed over what were some controversial verses. Therefore, I want to dig in a little deeper on them this morning, so let's get going on these verses right out of the gate.

Here's what Paul wrote:

1 Therefore, since we have this ministry, as we received mercy, we do not lose heart,

2 but we have renounced the things hidden because of shame, not walking in trickery nor distorting the word of God, but by the open proclamation of the truth commending ourselves to every person's conscience in the sight of God.

3 And even if our gospel is veiled, it is veiled to those who are perishing,

4 in whose case the god of this world has blinded the minds of the unbelieving so that they will not see the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.

5 For we do not preach ourselves, but Christ Jesus as Lord, and ourselves as your bondservants on account of Jesus.

6 For God, who said, "Light shall shine out of darkness," is the One who has shone in our hearts to give the Light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Christ.

Last time we were together I finished our teaching by focusing specifically on verses 3-6. As I said earlier, those verses have been considered controversial verses throughout the years. I will point out, however, that these verses are just a few verses in a long line of verses that highlight and say the exact same thing throughout many other places in scripture.

In other words, this is not the only place in scripture where this type of language is used. In fact, verses 3 & 6 highlight what is an overarching theme of scripture, and that is, God is totally Sovereign and in control of all things. Meaning, God is the creator, and as the creator He is in control of His creation.

He either A) allows things to happen, or He B) causes things to happen. And it all happens according to His Will and Sovereign Decree. And all for one reason and one reason alone. For His Reasons - For His Plans - For His Purposes, which is ultimately for 'His Glory'.

And mixed up in the middle of what God is doing is a twin truth or reality that lives within God's creation, and that is, God is Sovereign, and man has responsibility for all that. Meaning, God is in control. He's either allowing things to happen or He's causing things to happen.

And yet, man still has culpability or is responsible in all things as well. And I get this can be confusing, and I don't want to upset anyone here today, but the reality is The Sovereign Creator of the Universe doesn't owe us any explanation for anything He does.

Remember, we are doulos (slaves) (bondservants). Paul just called he and the other disciples this very thing in verse 5, when he said:

5 For we do not preach ourselves, but Christ Jesus as Lord, and ourselves as your

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bondservants on account of Jesus.

I think it's interesting how he said, 'we are your bondservants on account of Jesus Christ'. Remember, he is writing this letter to the Church at Corinth, which means he is writing to the people in this church.

So essentially, what he is saying is, we serve you because we are slaves of Jesus Christ, and obviously as bondservants/slaves, we are not offered the luxury of opinions. If you think about it, that makes sense, because are we so arrogant to think that if God explained to us why He does what He does, that we would even understand it?

Think about it. There are things that happen in this world, things that we can see with our own eyes, and we can't explain it. Such as, we can't explain how a hummingbird flies. According to the laws of flight, or aeronautics, a hummingbird shouldn't be able to fly, much less be able to navigate backwards and forwards in mid-air.

Nevertheless, that is exactly what happens, and there are many other things in life we can't explain. But instead of walking around in a state of confusion, we just accept them as a truth, and the same holds true with God. God is Sovereign, and even though He is totally in control of all things, man is still held accountable for his actions.

Now guys, let me say this before moving forward this morning. Inside this understanding of God and His creation, lies one of the most (if not the most) liberating testimonies in all of scripture, and when you understand or fully grasp this concept of God's Sovereignty, which gives you deep insight into the character and full nature of God, nothing will confuse you and nothing can discourage you.

And not only that. Nothing will ever hold you back in your walk with Him.

Having said that, this concept is a tough concept to grasp. But regardless of whether we grasp it or not, it's still the truth. And one of the ways I can best help you come to agreement with it is for you to remember, at the core of this understanding lies a basic truth, a reality of God, of our creator. An actual truth of any creator.

And that is, the creator is never surprised by His creation. That is the truth. At no point has someone like a painter, a carver, a sculptor, a builder; at no time has a person who has created something been shocked by what he created. He or she may have been shocked at how well it turned out, but never shocked at what he or she created.

And that makes sense, doesn't it? I mean, obviously it does. You see, when that sets in as it relates to God, it's (as I said) the most liberating and powerful change that can happen in the life of a Christian. And it will influence you. It will begin to control how you think and react to the world around you. Even though you may not understand it, you will accept it, and why?

Because it simply is what it is. As I said, this reality and truth is so powerful when it sinks in. God allowed it or caused it to happen, and He is never surprised by what takes place. Paul says it this way in Colossians 1:16-17:

16 for by Him all things were created, *both* in the heavens and on earth, visible and invisible, whether thrones, or dominions, or rulers, or authorities—all things have been created through Him and for Him.

17 He is before all things, and in Him all things hold together.

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Just remember that, especially in moments of doubt. God is totally in control, and He's never surprised. Maybe another way to say it is, we never surprise Him because He already knows. But, what about man's responsibility? If God is Sovereign does man truly have responsibility? The answer is yes, but just exactly how does that work?

Now, before delving too deep into this topic this morning, let me say this. There is absolutely no way to harmonize these two truths of scripture. Yet, having said that, they both remain true. And if you try to harmonize them, you will end up destroying one or the other. Meaning, you will end up giving too much credit to one side or the other.

In effort to explain this further, I want to use an excerpt from John McArthur's message entitled, 'Gods Sovereignty versus Man's Responsibility'. I could spend a lot of time recrafting this narrative, but honestly, Dr. McArthur has done such a good job that I will just quote His message.

And we will do this by turning to the Book of Isaiah and then Matthew, which will give us what are probably some of the best examples of these parallel truths in all the scriptures. In the 10th Chapter of Isaiah, God introduces a nation known as Assyria. The Assyria Nation as they are called. He also introduces us to the people of Assyria.

And without going into all the details about these people, just know they were a warring people, a brutal people, very barbaric. And as you can imagine, they were pagan (non-God believing), they were also an idolatrous nation, and they are introduced to us in Isaiah 10 in a very interesting way. Let's read it.

5 Woe to Assyria

Woe to Assyria. This is important because it tells us something. The word 'woe' means a judgement is coming on Assyria. But not just any judgement, it's a judgement from God. 'Woe' is an onomatopoetic Hebrew term. We say, 'woe' in English, but it doesn't carry the weight that it does in the Hebrew. The Hebrew meaning is 'oyeeyaa'. It's kind of a groan.

That's why I say onomatopoetic is a word that sounds exactly like its meaning. It's a word that denotes terrible distress and it signifies destruction and judgement. And so, from God's own words of distress, it's clear God is going to destroy Assyria. He's going to bring divine judgement on this nation.

Next, it says this in the second half of verse 5:

5 Woe to Assyria, the rod of My anger
And the staff in whose hands is My indignation,

God says He is going to judge Assyria, and then He identifies Assyria as the "rod of His anger and the staff of His indignation". In other words, Assyria is a weapon in the hands of God. Meaning, God is picking up Assyria like a weapon and He is using them to unleash His wrath on somebody.

The question is, who is the somebody he is using to unleash his wrath on? Well, verse 6 says,

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6 I send it against a godless nation, And commission it against the people of My fury.

I'll pause here for just a moment. Whomever this nation is, they are evidently a Godless nation. But who is it? Well, upon further research, as we read on in Isaiah, we discover the nation God is unleashing His wrath on is none other than His own people - the Nation of Israel. He's talking about Israel.

Which tells us - that God in His Sovereignty picked up Assyria and sent Assyria as a destroyer against His own people.

Against what is now an apostate idolatrous Israel. A nation that has abandoned God. That's what it means when God says, "I am going to pick up Assyria, the rod of My anger, the staff of My wrath, My indignation, and I'm going to send it against a godless nation, against Israel."

And that's exactly what He did. Assyria was the tool God used to punish His own people, Israel. And by the way, this is a historical fact, the story of the Assyrian invasion of the northern kingdom of Israel took place in 722.

Assyria took the Northern Kingdom of Israel captive, massacred them, and they never returned from captivity. The northern part of the kingdom was divided and disappeared forever, never to be heard from again. Assyria was the weapon God used. But then He goes on to say in the second half of verse 6 He did this "To capture booty, to seize plunder, to trample them down like mud in the streets," and once again, this is a historical recorded fact, this is exactly what happened. Next, we move into verse 7, where we read something interesting about this whole event. Listen to what it says,

7 Yet it does not so intend,

Nor does it plan so in its heart,

But rather it is its purpose to destroy

And to eliminate many nations.

"Yet, it does not so intend, nor does it plan so in its heart." So, God is saying, I'm going to use Assyria as a weapon against my own people, even though this was not and is not what Assyria was choosing to do. Rather, God says He was choosing for them to do.

Simply put, Assyria had no intention of doing this to the Nation of Israel, but it did have as its purpose to destroy and cut off many other nations. We know this to be the case because in verse 9 many of these other nations are listed.

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Remember, as I previously stated, the nation of Assyria is a warring nation. They love to conquer and war against other nations. But, having said that, Assyria has no plan (at this point) to war against Israel. But God has different plans, and without them even planning or intending to do it, God says I'm going to pick them up and use them as My weapon.

Now, before breezing right past this morning, we need to realize just how amazing this is. Assyria has no intention of doing this, but God, literally and sovereignly, picks them up and drives them at Israel. And he does so for what reason? To accomplish His will, which is what? To discipline them and bring them back into a right relationship with Him.

But there's a problem, or an irony if you will, and it began back in Verse 5, where He says. "Woe to Assyria." Woe to Assyria. Why Woe to Assyria, what did they do wrong?

Shouldn't it say woe to Israel? Assyria is the nation that will be destroyed for doing something they didn't choose to do, doing something they didn't plan to do, doing something that was not their intention to do. And yet, God is going to destroy them for doing it.

Assyria had its own plans, which had nothing to do with Israel, but God had different plans. And yet, Assyria will be destroyed for it. That doesn't seem fair, does it? Not from our perspective, but we aren't God, and we aren't the Creator. We are simply the created, and the creator does not say to the created, why did you make me this way?

Better yet, the created doesn't say to the Creator, why did you do anything? Proverbs 16:4 says,

4The LORD has made everything for its own purpose, Even the wicked for the day of evil.

Revelation 4:11 says,

11 "Worthy are You, our Lord and our God, to receive glory and honor and power; for You created all things, and because of Your will they existed, and were created."

These are just a few verses that confirm what I am saying. God is God and we are not. He does what He wants. Moses tells us this in Exodus 33:19, when he says:

19 And He said, "I Myself will make all My goodness pass before you and will proclaim the name of the LORD before you; and I will be gracious to whom I will be gracious and will show compassion to whom I will show compassion."

This is the overarching testimony of scripture, and it makes no difference whether we like it or not. And why? Because God is doing something and we have no clue what it is, and we will see that confirmed in Verse 12 of Isaiah 10. Listen to what he says:

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Isaiah 10:12

“It will be when the Lord has completed all His work on Mount Zion, (representing Israel and Jerusalem), He will say, ‘I will punish the fruit of the arrogant heart of the king of Assyria and the pomp of his haughtiness.’”

And then He goes on to quote what the king of Assyria says about this very thing, which was that he had become proud and arrogant as he launched an attack against Israel. And God says, paraphrasing here, ‘for this reason I’m going to destroy him.’

Then, skipping forward to verse 16, Isaiah tells us further, the following:

Verse 16,

“I’m going to send wasting disease.

Under His glory a fire of kindle is like a burning flame.

17. The light of Israel will become a fire, his Holy One a flame

and it will burn and devour his thorns and briars in a single day.

18. He will destroy the glory of his forest and fruitful garden,

soul, and body as when a sick man wastes away.”

What an amazing dichotomy of God’s Sovereignty. God punishing a nation for what God picked them up and made them do, and then holding them responsible for doing it. And, for us, there’s simply no explanation and no way to harmonize these two truths. But they are still both true.

Full responsibility of pride fell on the King of Assyria, along with the full responsibility for the evil intention and massacre of Israel falling on the Assyrian Nation as well.

Even though they were acting by divine decree, they bore full responsibility for what they did.

This again is an illustration of those parallel realities: human responsibility and divine sovereignty. These two will always run parallel, and they will always have to be understood that way.

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Sinners bear the full weight of responsibility for their acts of defiance against God, even when God is using them to accomplish His purposes. And yet all things are decreed and determined by God as to their end.

Now, I don't want you to leave here today and think to yourself well, maybe that's just the only place that scripture paints a picture of God's Sovereignty and Man's Responsibility. If you think that I assure you that isn't the case. It is all over the pages of scripture.

And if you're interested I can give you many more verses that testify to these two truths, both in the Old Testament and the New Testament, but today's question is, what does all this have to do with 2 Corinthians 4:1-6? Well, let's read it one more time as we close. The only difference this time is, when we read it, we will read it with what I just taught you from Isaiah fresh on your mind.

1 Therefore, since we have this ministry, as we received mercy, we do not lose heart,

2 but we have renounced the things hidden because of shame, not walking in trickery nor distorting the word of God, but by the open proclamation of the truth commending ourselves to every person's conscience in the sight of God.

3 And even if our gospel is veiled, it is veiled to those who are perishing,

4 in whose case the god of this world has blinded the minds of the unbelieving so that they will not see the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.

5 For we do not preach ourselves, but Christ Jesus as Lord, and ourselves as your bondservants on account of Jesus.

6 For God, who said, "Light shall shine out of darkness," is the One who has shone in our hearts to give the Light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Christ.

It is simple. God is in control of all things, and He is doing what He is doing 'All for His Glory' to an appointed end. Which means, He is bringing humanity to a final close. Which means, this creation started on time and will end on time.

It also means your life and my life are on a timer, a countdown, and one day it will all be over. I will leave you with this final word, regardless of how you feel about God, and regardless of what you think is fair or not fair.

If you can ever harness the understanding of the Creator versus the Creation mentality. Specifically, that the creation does not know what the creator is doing, or that the creation (you and I), can't even begin to understand this whole creation thing. But we can know for sure that there is a God.

Because we see there is a creation, and that the Creator (Our God) has a plan, but we are simply His created, which means He has us in the Palm of His Hand. You see, when that understanding becomes who you are, meaning, when it gets inside of your very being, it will give you a Peace like you have never had before.

Paul speaks about this peace in Philippians. It's a Peace that Passes all understanding. It's a Peace that only God can give, and He has reserved it for Himself. The only way you can get that kind of peace is to first trust Him as your Lord and Savior, and then begin to intimately

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know Him, which comes by way of studying and ingesting His word.

And so, with all that said, if you are sitting here today and you don't know him, meaning, you have never made a profession of faith. Put your trust in Him. I want to encourage you to do that, and to see me after the service.

On the other hand, if you have trusted Him, meaning you are saved, but you don't really have that Peace that Passes all understanding, then there are two things you need to know.

First, God's Peace is real, and second, it can only come by way of studying, praying and spending time in His word. And by the way, there is no shortcut to this process. Which means, once again, you must take responsibility in your own walk and spiritual growth.

You do that by making the commitment to give God your First Fruits of the Day. And you must be consistent with it. If you do that, if you study every day, and spend time in prayer, I promise, eventually you will begin to feel it. I assure you it's available.

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- This morning, turn with me if you will back to just one of the four letters that Paul wrote to the Corinthian Church. This letter we are studying is known as 2nd Corinthians. When we last left off, we were deep into Chapter 4 verses 1-6, where Paul told this Corinthian Church that:
    - A - They (Paul and the other disciples) never lost heart in their ministry because of the mercy God had shown them. Which simply meant they understood their plight before God. Meaning, they understood their destiny, highlighted by the understanding that God was in control. That His hand was with them.
    - B - He said that they never walked in shame, nor had they distorted the Word of God, but by the open proclamation of the truth they commended themselves to every person's conscience in the sight of God. Which meant that their lives were proof of the Gospel of Jesus Christ.
        - Another way to say it is, they were who they said they were, which is what you do as a witness. This is the very definition of a witness. Our witness is who we are, how we act and respond. Not what we say. Our lives are our witness, and our lives should give testimony, or proof, to the One we say we serve.
    - This concept has long since been abandoned by the church. So-called Christian men and women conducting themselves in ways that testify opposite of who they say they are in Christ Jesus.
- Today, the church's faith has become weak, diluted and watered down, surface and superficial at best. Something we often wear as a banner (at times), but very rarely does it move or motivate our behavior. And, unfortunately, I get to see it on full display as I deal with it in business every day.
    - Men and woman distorting the reality of who God is, and what He expects from each one of us. Where Christianity once meant something to the individual, and to society, it's now (in most of the cases) a side note.
    - Even in the more devout believer, their faith has become nothing more than a loose affiliation, or somewhat of a life of 'comfort food'. But that is not what God expects from us, and Paul's own words paint for us a picture of the truth as it relates to our life as a witness.
    - Paul's message to the Church at Corinth was clear. We are who we say we are, and you can know that in the way we conduct ourselves. Guess what folks? The same is true for us as well. Our lives should reflect our faith, and so the question is, does it?
- Paul proceeded to write some words in verses 3&4, words that would turn out to be very controversial in the future. Having said that, Paul probably never considered his words to be controversial. But as man always does, we have managed to make something out of nothing, and therefore, his words created controversy for Bible theologians for years to come.
    - And what were those words? If their gospel was veiled (meaning hidden), if it were veiled it was veiled to those who were perishing. And then he said, in verse 4, "In which case the God of this world, had blinded the minds of the unbelieving, so that they will not see the light of the gospel of the Glory of Christ."
    - These words shouldn't have been controversial, because they simply highlight the overarching testimony of scripture, which is, that God is the creator, and we are His creation.

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- And because of that very fact, He moves and does as He wills, or as God Himself told Moses, “That He will have mercy on whom He has mercy.” I won’t rehash all of this, but if you want to hear all about it, then I encourage you to go back and listen to the previous message.
  - Paul said in verse 5, that he nor the other Apostles, preach themselves, but Christ Jesus as Lord, and they as bondservants on account of Jesus. Paraphrasing here, Paul was saying we are 100% sold out for Jesus. We are committed. We are serious.
  - And one of the ways you can know we are true in what we say is demonstrated by the fact that we do not promote ourselves in any way. Another way to say it is, we will never elevate ourselves. In fact, we are so sold out; we are your bondservants on account of Christ Jesus. We are your slaves because of Christ, and we are here to serve you, to help you, by and through Servant Leadership.

- And finally, we ended our teaching with verse 6, where Paul said,

2 Cor. 4:6 For God, who said, “Light shall shine out of darkness,” is the One who has shone in our hearts to give the Light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Christ.

- One more time, Paul is validating who they are by reminding them that God is in control, and that God is the one who causes all things to happen, including Salvation. Which is what he means when he says that He is the one who has caused the light of Jesus to shine in our hearts, and *to give the Light of the Knowledge of the glory of God* in the face of Christ.
  - God is the one. He and He alone is the one who started a work in them, and He and He alone is the one who will be faithful to complete it, which harmonizes perfectly with what Paul wrote in Philippians 1:6 - which said,

Phil 1:6 *For I am* confident of this very thing, that He who began a good work among you will complete it by the day of Christ Jesus.

- And that, my friends, is the truth. God is the one who pricks the heart. He and He alone is the one who will keep you until the end. It all starts with Him, and it ends with Him! But why is Paul telling them all this? Because there were some in the church, one in particular, who began murmuring and saying that Paul might not be who he said he was.
  - This person gained support from others, which is the way it always begins. The murmuring generally begins with one person and gains momentum from there. Now, before moving on this morning, I want to highlight what I believe is one important thing to note about Paul’s defense.
  - And that is, at no point does Paul sight any of his own accomplishments as reason for them to trust him or believe him. Rather, he continually points them back to Jesus. And why is that important? It’s important because only God can change the mind and the heart. We can’t change anything.

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- We can talk 'til we are blue in the face, but ultimately, God will be the One who brings the results. That's simply the way it is. Now moving on this morning, we pick back up in the 4th Chapter of 2 Corinthians, as Paul continues with his defense, or his explanation if you will, of who he and the other Apostles/disciples are.

- Now, before we read these next set of verses, let me just say, what we are about to read is a promise from God. A promise that every believer can count on. It wasn't just for Paul. It's for you and I as well. So, let's read it, and see what this promise is all about:

2 Cor. 4:7 But we have this treasure in earthen containers, so that the extraordinary *greatness* of the power will be of God and not from ourselves;
2 Cor. 4:8 *we are* afflicted in every way, but not crushed; perplexed, but not despairing;
2 Cor. 4:9 persecuted, but not abandoned; struck down, but not destroyed;
2 Cor. 4:10 always carrying around in the body the dying of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our body.
2 Cor. 4:11 For we who live are constantly being handed over to death because of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our mortal flesh.
2 Cor. 4:12 So death works in us, but life in you.

- The word Powerful doesn't even begin to describe what is truly being said in these verses. Beginning with verse 7, Paul says we have this treasure in earthen containers, (the Greek says, 'Earthen Vessels').
  - If you are a believer, you and I, our bodies are containers. They are vessels. And so, if we are truly containers or vessels, then the immediate question is, what are we as containers holding within ourselves?
  - God created us with a purpose in mind, and by Paul's own words he knew we were created to hold something. And so, what is it that we are holding? Paul says it's a treasure. But what's this treasure? Well, if we refer to verse 6, we get the answer. Let's read it again.

2 Cor. 4:6 For God, who said, "Light shall shine out of darkness," is the One who has shone in our hearts to give the Light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Christ.

- So, what is this gift? It's the knowledge and the revelation of Jesus Christ. Which ultimately leads to what? Salvation, which causes the Holy Spirit to take up residence in your body. And, if that's the case (and it is), it means there is something Pure and Holy living inside you.
  - The problem is, it cohabitates with something else, which is what? Your flesh, which is what? The Enemy of God. And these two are constantly warring against one another. If I asked you the question, which one of these would you prefer to be more pronounced in your life, I would think you would say or hope you would say the Holy Spirit, right?

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- And if that's the case, then I would ask you how's that looking these days? Paul was saying that he and the other disciples were so full of God that their very lives exuded it. The feeling is almost like God oozed out of their pores.
  - And the same should be said of us as well, because what produced this effect in Paul is still available for you and I as well. We are no different than Paul or the other disciples. We too can have "all" of God we want. We can have so much of God that without ever even saying a word, when people engage with us, they will feel Him and begin to inquire about Him.

- Moving on, Paul says as believers we are containers, earthly vessels. And as containers we are meant to house or hold a part of God, and that thing that we are to hold, or house is the treasure Paul is speaking about.
  - But for me, that begs the question, wonder why God chose us as vessels, to inhabit His children in this manner?
    - In other words, why did God choose to place inside of you and I His Holy Spirit? I mean, He didn't have to do this, did He? No, He didn't. So why did He do it? Because He was doing something, as always. He was, and is, working His plan. And what is that plan?
  - Paul tells us in the second half of the verse, when he says:

2 Cor. 4:7 **But we have this treasure in earthen containers, so that the extraordinary *greatness* of the power will be of God and not from ourselves;**

- It's simple. God chose to inhabit a believer and to cohabitate with our flesh so that His Glory and the Greatness of His power would be made manifest in us. And then ultimately, His light would be shone into a dark and dying world.
  - Our earthly vessel, our bodies, are part of the method that God uses to inject His Light into this world. In other words, we are the instruments He uses to accomplish His will. And so, once again, how are you doing at being a useful instrument of God?
    - Do you possess the 'Spiritual Law of Attraction'? In other words, are people drawn to you because you exude the characteristics of Jesus? Or would the opposite be true. Instead of drawing people in, do you push people away?
    - The surest way to push people away is to claim to be a Christian, 'a Christ follower', and then to act opposite or display the opposite characteristics of Christ. Another way to say it is, declare your faith to the world yet display no fruits of the Spirit. Which are what?
  - Love - Joy - Forbearance - Kindness - Goodness - Faithfulness - Gentleness and drum roll please, Self-Control. That's a tough one, isn't it? It's tough for everyone. Believers and non-believers. Which, by the way, is why I believe that the toughest characteristic to control in our lives is the one that will bring God the greatest glory.
- Think about it. Do you lose your mind when you get mad, or do you remain calm and prayerful? Are you slow to speak or are you quick to respond in anger? These attributes of Christ are what draw people to Jesus.
  - People expect you to lose your mind, and so when you don't, it causes them to

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pause and inquire. Remember, it's not about you, it's Him shining through you, and this should always be on the forefront of our minds as we move about and live out every day of our lives.

- Verse 8 - 9 says:

2 Cor. 4:8 *we are* afflicted in every way, but not crushed; perplexed, but not despairing;
2 Cor. 4:7 persecuted, but not abandoned; struck down, but not destroyed;

- In these verses lies that promise of God that I was previously talking about. It's a promise that is available to all believers. Just like Paul. Even though we are afflicted in every way, we will not be crushed; perplexed, but not despairing; persecuted, but not abandoned; struck down, but not destroyed.
  - It's simple. God has made it clear, repeatedly. He will never leave us nor forsake us. And just like Paul and the other disciples, this is a promise you and I can count on as well. It makes no difference how bad it gets; He is always with you. And that applies even if you don't feel His presence in that moment.
    - Remember, just because you may not feel it, doesn't mean it isn't true. Feelings are emotions, and I assure you, that in the darkest times of your life, if you pray, study, and seek God, the feeling of God's presence will eventually return. So don't worry about the feeling. Just simply remember the promise.
  - This world is always going to try and beat us down and rob us of joy. Drag us through the mud of life. But God will always make us stand. And why? Because of what we just read in verses 10 -12. Let me read it again.

2 Cor. 4:10 always carrying around in the body the dying of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our body.
2 Cor. 4:11 For we who live are constantly being handed over to death because of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our mortal flesh.
2 Cor. 4:12 So death works in us, but life in you.

- Paul's words here are almost poetic. In these verses he paints for us a picture of just how bad things were for him and the other Apostles/disciples. But he also gives us the why behind the entire process. He says they are always carrying around in their body the dying of Jesus.
  - So that, *AND THIS IS THE KEY*, so that, THE LIFE OF JESUS MAY ALSO BE REVEALED IN THEIR BODY.
  - Paul's words may be a little confusing here, but the concept is an easy one to understand. Let me explain it quick. Once we are saved, the next step after Salvation is Sanctification. This is simply obtaining Spiritual Growth in our lives, which is nothing more than Spiritual Maturity.
    - And why is this the case? Why is this what God requires of you? Because this is the method He uses to accomplish His will, to carry out His plan for mankind.

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We are His instruments, and the only way we can be an effective instrument is through the process of Sanctification. The more we mature, the more God uses us.

- So, if you don't feel like God ever really puts you in the game, it's probably a maturity issue. You need to seek Him daily through His Word and begin your spiritual growth journey. But what does that have to do with verses 10-11-12?
    - What Paul is telling us is, that through their persecution, through their trials, and by their reaction to those trials, they themselves experience just a little bit of what Jesus experienced. Paul also said this very thing in Philippians 3:7-11. Listen to what he said:

Phil. 3:7 But whatever things were gain to me, these things I have counted as loss because of Christ.
Phil. 3:8 More than that, I count all things to be loss in view of the surpassing value of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord, for whom I have suffered the loss of all things, and count them mere rubbish, so that I may gain Christ,
Phil. 3:9 and may be found in Him, not having a righteousness of my own derived from *the* Law, but that which is through faith in Christ, the righteousness which *comes* from God on the basis of faith,
Phil. 3:10 that I may know Him and the power of His resurrection and the fellowship of His sufferings, being conformed to His death;
Phil. 3:11 if somehow I may attain to the resurrection from the dead.

- This process, or concept if you will, is that of 'Suffering for Christ', and through that suffering there is connection to His death. Even though Paul and the others experienced some harsh treatment, including beatings and imprisonment, nothing they ever experienced compared to the suffering Christ experienced on the cross.
    - But, in a small way, through their own sufferings, they made a connection to what Jesus experienced. They handed themselves over to all of this because of their calling, because of their ministry. And for that reason, they connected with Him on an entirely different level.
    - Now, having said that, we too can experience the same thing Paul, and the others did, but to do so, we must put our own sufferings in proper perspective. We must look at our own sufferings to bring Glory to God. And how do we do that? By pointing the outside world back to the cross through our pain.
        - In other words, by letting the world know that God is in control. That He and He alone has a plan, and that we have experienced nothing in comparison to what Jesus endured on our behalf on the Cross of Calvary. Unfortunately, for most Christians, when we suffer, we don't look at things this way.
        - Instead of pointing people back to the cross, we generally ask why me Lord? And I get it. It's natural, but it's not mature, it's not spiritual. As a matter of fact, it's fleshly. We must never forget, our lives are but a vapor, here today - gone tomorrow. It may seem sad, but it's the truth.

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- Once you pass away, there are two truths you can count on. The first is, the people we know, the ones left living, they will think about us for a little bit but then quickly move on. That's not a bad thing, it's just the way it must be. We do the same thing. Life moves on and we move on. That's the first truth.
- The second truth is, once you pass away, you will not care about this earth. If you are a believer, you will not want to come back and you will not be sad. This is a promise. And so, if these are the two truths about our death that we can count on, then all that remains is what we do while we are still living.
  - Not what we do for ourselves or our kids or family, but what we do for the Kingdom of God. You know that place where we are going to be living for eternity. Never forget, you (as a believer) will be rewarded for the work you do for God while you remain on this planet. All this is not for nothing.

- As a believer, the work you do for God while living your life out is the most *gratifying* and fulfilling work you will ever experience while living on this earth. There is nothing like being an instrument of God. Nothing.
  - Outside of being saved, there is no greater feeling than being part of a transformation of someone else's life for God. And if you haven't experienced it, I would suggest you get busy in your maturing process and ask God to use you.
- Moving on, so Paul counts it gain to suffer for God, and that's exactly what he is re-emphasizing in verses 10 -12. One more time listen to it again:

2 Cor. 4:10 always carrying around in the body the dying of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our body.
2 Cor. 4:11 For we who live are constantly being handed over to death because of Jesus, so that the life of Jesus may also be revealed in our mortal flesh.

- And then in verse 12, he summarizes it all by giving us the why behind this whole thing. Listen to what he says:

2 Cor. 4:12 So death works in us, but life in you.

- They experience what they experience so that others may be saved, so that others may experience eternal life.
  - If this were a mathematical equation it would read like this; suffering = transformation, and that transformation is what qualifies you and I for the work of the ministry. Our transformation, through suffering (if we will let it), qualifies us to do the work of the ministry.
  - Our suffering transforms us into a useful instrument of God. This is ultimately what Paul is saying in verse 12 when he says, "So death works in us, but life in you."
- Moving on, and we will close this morning with Verses 13-18, which just further highlights what Paul continues to say. Listen to him one more time:

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2 Cor. 4:13 But having the same spirit of faith, according to what is written: "I BELIEVED, THEREFORE I SPOKE," we also believe, therefore we also speak,
2 Cor. 4:14 knowing that He who raised the Lord Jesus will also raise us with Jesus and will present *us* with you.
2 Cor. 4:15 For all things *are* for your sakes, so that grace, having spread to more and more people, will cause thanksgiving to overflow to the glory of God.

- (The whole purpose of this creation and your existence by the way - To the Glory of God)

2 Cor. 4:16 Therefore we do not lose heart, but though our outer person is decaying, yet our inner *person* is being renewed day by day.
2 Cor. 4:17 For our momentary, light affliction is producing for us an eternal weight of glory far beyond all comparison,
2 Cor. 4:18 while we look not at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen; for the things which are seen are temporal, but the things which are not seen are eternal.

- I am not going to spend a lot of time on these verses this morning, other than to say as you read Paul's words you do see more of the same. He is desperately trying to get a point across, and that is, Christian men and women wake up and smell the roses. This life is passing, and what we do here matters.
    - In Paul's own words he says we are dying on the outside, but he and the other Apostles/Disciples are being renewed daily on the inside. Not for the here and now, but rather for what is to come. The focus here is on the eternal not the temporal.
    - We as a people are so much worse off than any other generation that has ever lived before us, because we are so here and now focused, and that's primarily because we have advanced in our knowledge. Which is not a bad thing, until it begins to make us reliant on ourselves.
        - Advances in technology and medicine have taken us to a place where we think we are going to somehow live forever. Maybe not consciously, but certainly subconsciously. Because we begin to believe ultimately, it's all within us, that we can do anything and that we can accomplish anything.
        - We even tell our kids this lie, and it is a lie by the way. I'm sorry but it is. We can't do anything we want to. And just an FYI to you, this is such a dangerous theory to promote, especially from a Christian standpoint, because it runs counter to what God is trying to teach us through His word.
- You see, one of the most important concepts for us to understand is our dependance and reliance on God. Which means any teaching that says 'We' are the captain of our ship, is 100% counter to the mindset God wants us to have. The truth is, we can't accomplish anything outside of Christ, especially as it relates to working for Christ.
    - Now, my words may seem obvious and simple this morning, and they are. But the reality is, very rarely do believers operate from this basis. They may understand it, but it doesn't control how they act. And this is so important because mindset

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matters. What you think, whether consciously or subconsciously, matters, because it's what ultimately moves and motivates you.

- Now, I'm going to digress on this topic and close, but before I do, I want to do something I have never done before. I want to issue you guys a challenge. This week I want you to take verses 13-18 and do a deep dive into just exactly what Paul is trying to relay to this church, and by extension what he is trying to relay to you and me as well.
    - Next week I'm going to begin the message with these same verses. The difference is I want you to come prepared. Prepared by studying and ingesting these verses ahead of time, so that when I teach it you will receive the maximum Spiritual Impact in your life.
        - We will call this an experiment of sorts. Take these verses and go study. And don't just go to a commentary or your study Bible and read what someone else wrote based on their studies. Before you begin your study, start out with prayer, then read the verses, read them again, read them slowly and think about what you're reading.
- Remember, the Bible is not a novel. It's not to be read for entertainment. It's an instruction manual. So, start out with prayer, then read the verses slowly. Ingest them, meditate on them, let them soak in, make notes, and then, if you feel led, go read some commentary on the verses.
    - Let's try that this week and let's see if the teaching has an entirely different effect on your life.

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- Last week I did something I have never done before. I left you guys with a challenge. I challenged you to pray, study, and meditate on this week's verses. Basically, to prepare for this week's lesson.
    - I wanted you to do a deep dive into just exactly what Paul was trying to convey to the church at Corinth, and then of course, by extension, what he was trying to convey to us as well. So, you were supposed to study this week's verses in-depth for yourself first, start out with prayer, ingest them, meditate on them, let them soak in, make notes, and then and only then, pick up a commentary for reference if you felt led.
    - This was a test of sorts. A test to see if today's teaching might take on a different meaning in your life. If it might have a different spiritual impact on your life. So, before moving forward this morning, I am going to start on the left side of the room and ask you to stand up and tell us how you did with the challenge.
        - Not really. Just kidding. Having said that, if you didn't do it that's okay. We are going to try it again this week. Give you another opportunity, because I promise you, if you begin to do what I am telling you to do you won't believe the impact it will have when you come here and hear me teach it, because it's a really simple concept.
        - If you prepare before I teach you will experience Maximum Spiritual Impact. It's just that simple, there's no way around it.
- So, we open this morning back in 2 Corinthians 4:13-18, where we pick back up with Paul once again where he is in the middle of writing this letter to the church of Corinth.
    - He continues making a defense of who he is, which is an Apostle of Jesus Christ. But more specifically, he is making a defense of his ministry. And so, without further ado, let's read what he wrote:

2 Cor. 4:13 But having the same spirit of faith, according to what is written: "I BELIEVED, THEREFORE I SPOKE," we also believe, therefore we also speak,
2 Cor. 4:14 knowing that He who raised the Lord Jesus will also raise us with Jesus and will present *us* with you.
2 Cor. 4:15 For all things *are* for your sakes, so that grace, having spread to more and more people, will cause thanksgiving to overflow to the glory of God.
2 Cor. 4:16 Therefore we do not lose heart, but though our outer person is decaying, yet our inner *person* is being renewed day by day.
2 Cor. 4:17 For our momentary, light affliction is producing for us an eternal weight of glory far beyond all comparison,
2 Cor. 4:18 while we look not at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen; for the things which are seen are temporal, but the things which are not seen are eternal.

- As I previously stated, Chapter 4 ends with Paul essentially in the same mode he has been in for the last several verses and several chapters. He is continuing his defense as a Christian and an Apostle along with a defense of his ministry, and he starts out verse 13 by quoting from Psalms 116:10.

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- This quote comes from the Greek Septuagint, which is a simply the Hebrew Bible translated into the Greek. Paul says (paraphrasing here), just like the Psalmist, I concur and have believed, and therefore 'I' and 'we' have spoken.
- Now, immediately when we read verses 13 & 14, we come across at least two words that give us some special insight into the state of mind of Paul and the other Apostles. And those words (if we understand them correctly), will also give us guidance and understanding and wisdom into what should be our own state of mind when it comes to God/Jesus and his position in our lives.
  - Those 2 words are believed and knowing. Beginning with the word believed, first, before we begin, let me say this belief isn't just any 'ole' belief. Rather it's a supernatural belief, a belief that finds its origin in God. It's a word that is derived from the Hebrew word *pisteuo*, and it's a verb, an action.
  - The word combines the word *pistis*, or faith, and *peitho*, or persuade, or be persuaded. The sense is your belief as a Christian comes because of your faith, which as we know is a gift from God. It's nothing you have earned or even sought after, which means your belief in Jesus Christ has been influenced or persuaded by the Lord.
  - So, the context of the word is, because God has given them faith, they now believe. And the inverse of that is, without God bestowing His faith on them or us, we will never believe. As previously stated, this belief is an action, and it moves you, directs you, and causes you to act and react differently in your thought process.
- Next, we have the word knowing or knowledge. It is a Greek word *oioa*, and it too is a verb. Its definition is to be aware, behold, consider, perceive. The usage of this word is, I know, remember, or appreciate. It's a grasp of the truth. A comprehension of, or the gateway of, grasping a spiritual truth. A connection or bridging of your spiritual mind to a physical reality. I like to call it the ah-ha moment.
  - It's when something becomes a true reality, so much so that it moves you in both thought and action. In other words, it's when a truth becomes a reality. So much so that you believe it, like anything you can see or physically touch.
  - And once again, as I said earlier, it's a verb, which means it's active and it influences you in everything you do, including your responses to the tragedies of life. Now, these words are very important because they are repeated many times throughout scripture. Paul himself, among others, mentions them repeatedly as well. For example, in Colossians 1:9-10 he says,

Colossians 1:9 For this reason we also, since the day we heard *about it,* have not ceased praying for you and asking that you may be filled with the knowledge of His will in all spiritual wisdom and understanding,
Colossians 1:10 so that you will walk in a manner worthy of the Lord, to please *Him* in all respects, bearing fruit in every good work and increasing in the knowledge of God;

- Then in Ephesians 1:15-19:

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Ephesians 1:15 For this reason I too, having heard of the faith in the Lord Jesus which *exists* among you and your love for all the saints,
Ephesians 1:16 do not cease giving thanks for you, while making mention *of you* in my prayers;
Ephesians 1:17 that the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of glory, may give you a spirit of wisdom and of revelation in the knowledge of Him.
Ephesians 1:18 *I pray that* the eyes of your heart may be enlightened, so that you will know what is the hope of His calling, what are the riches of the glory of His inheritance in the saints,
Ephesians 1:19 and what is the boundless greatness of His power toward us who believe.

- I want you to notice something about these prayers. Notice how these prayers are centered around knowledge and wisdom, not fixing a particular problem. In other words, he doesn't ask for the sick to be healed or for God to fix some specific problem, he simply prays for them to receive knowledge and wisdom.
    - But like belief, it's not just any ole knowledge, it's for their knowledge of God to increase. Which tells us something. Number 1, it tells us that knowledge is truly power, especially as it relates to solving a problem or preventing a problem or causing you to make the correct choices in life (as it relates to God). And why?
        - Because wisdom and knowledge are what gives you the ability to solve a problem, to resolve issues. Which makes my second statement even more important.
    - Number 2, from the testimony of scripture (and in Paul's own words), we know that our knowledge can increase, which means, ultimately our ability to garner more power and strength through our understanding can grow.
        - Which (once again) causes our ability to make better choices and decisions as it relates to God, grow stronger. And even more than that, when our knowledge and understanding of God increases, so does something else, 'Our Peace and Comfort' and our 'Contentment'.
        - Which is all a result of reducing the 'noise' in our life, which comes when we reduce the confusion in our lives. And that makes sense, doesn't it? When your knowledge and understanding of God increases and becomes stronger, then our confusion about life's obstacles becomes less, which then reduces our stress and noise. The result of which is 'Great Comfort and Peace'.
    - And so, the only question is, if knowledge and understanding of God were on a scale of 1-10, how high up the scale do you want to be? And maybe a better question is, how high up the scale are you now?
        - And if you are not where you want to be, then how do you move forward on that scale? The answer is, you must study and ingest God's word in its purest form, because that's what increases your knowledge and wisdom relating to who God is.
- And just exactly how does this spiritual process work? I'm glad you asked. The answer is intimacy with God, which only happens when, once again, you study His Word.

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- Intimacy with God comes from a clear understanding of who He is. It doesn't come from some emotion or feeling of who we think He might be. Because God never operates contrary to what He has already put in His Word.

- Now, before moving on this morning, there's something else I want you to understand about what Paul is saying. He's saying that because of their level of wisdom and understanding of who God is (their knowledge), they have obtained or garnered the ability to endure tremendous persecution.
  - In other words, because they know what they know, and they believe it as strong as they believe anything that they can physically see and touch, it has caused them to endure, because ultimately they know (with God) the best is yet to come and that their lives (even though hardship and persecution are a tool), that God is using to testify to the world that He is who He is.
  - These men's lives are a living testimony, which highlights one more time the fact that our testimony is not what we say, but it is who we are. Our lives are a living testimony, and that's what Paul has been trying to convey to this church throughout this letter, that because of the Faith that God has so graciously bestowed on he and the other Apostles, which has only grown and increased over time as they gained more and more wisdom of who God is. Because of this fact, they can be who God wants them to be.
    - Another way to say it is, because the reality of who God is has become such a rock-solid truth in their hearts and minds, it directs everything they do, even unto death. Which is why I say this isn't any Ole Belief, it's a belief that moves you supernaturally.
    - And let me say, the level of belief they possess is a level of belief we too can possess. It's no different. The only difference in their level of belief and our level of belief is their level of knowledge and wisdom of who God is versus our level of knowledge and wisdom of who God is. It's all directly proportional.

- But I have a question for you. What specifically (knowledge wise), is it that they have a higher level of wisdom and understanding about, or what is it that they know better than we know? Paul clues us in verse 14. Listen to it one more time.

2 Cor. 4:14 knowing that He who raised the Lord Jesus will also raise us with Jesus and will present *us* with you.

- Their level of belief and knowledge and wisdom was directly tied to the resurrection of Jesus Christ. More specifically, that the God who raised the Lord Jesus from the dead would also raise them.
  - This concept and understanding is simple, because Paul and the other disciples knew that the same God that raised Jesus from the dead, would do the same for them. That fact and that reality propelled them forward with zero hesitation or reservation.
    - Think about it. If you knew you were about to die, but you also knew that no matter what, that God was going to raise you to newness of life, and you knew this, or believed this so much that it became a part of who you were (a rock-solid reality in your life). If that were the case, then obviously you would not fear

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death.

- As a matter of fact, not only would you not fear it, but you would also embrace it, and that is the 'state of mind', or mental place or position that Paul and the other Apostles were in. And that is the 'state of mind" or mental place or position we too must strive to achieve.

- And it's unfortunate, but for most Christian men and women they will never taste even a small sample of what this is like. And why? Because they do not spend time with God in prayer or in His Word. And that's the only way it's achieved. There is no other method God has given us to achieve this type of spiritual result.

- Now moving back to the text, re-reading it one more time but highlighting verses 15:

2 Cor. 4:13 But having the same spirit of faith, according to what is written: "I BELIEVED, THEREFORE I SPOKE," we also believe, therefore we also speak,
2 Cor. 4:14 knowing that He who raised the Lord Jesus will also raise us with Jesus and will present *us* with you.
2 Cor. 4:15 For all things *are* for your sakes, so that grace, having spread to more and more people, will cause thanksgiving to overflow to the glory of God.

- Going back to what I said last week, verse 15 highlights what is the purpose of our existence as believers, and that is, it's all about God all the time.

2 Cor. 4:15 For all things *are* for your sakes, so that grace, having spread to more and more people, will cause thanksgiving to overflow to the glory of God.

- To the Glory of God. I won't belabor this point, except to say when you understand (I mean truly understand) this concept, it will forever change your life as a believer. And what's the concept? It's that in everything you do, everything you achieve, and in all that you endure (the hard things you go through), they are all for the 'Glory of God'.

  - And just an FYI to you, this concept can never fully be realized in your life until you begin to deeply understand that 'we are not our own', meaning that God owns us and that we've been bought with a price! Our existence, our very being (If we are a Christian), belongs to God. It is all about God. It's all about Him and His Glory all the time.

  - This is the overarching testimony of scripture, that our purpose and destiny as believers is to bring glory to God. It's that simple, and this is why I say that when we grasp this concept, I mean really grasp it, it will change our life.

    - And why? Because when that reality resonates and becomes real inside your existence, it then will move you, guide you, and direct you in how you think, as well as how you act and react. And why? Because you know that no matter what happens to you on this earth, it's of no real consequence because it's 'all for God's Glory'.

- We know this to be the case, because this is what Paul proceeds to tell us in Verses 16-18:

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2 Cor. 4:16 Therefore we do not lose heart, but though our outer person is decaying, yet our inner *person* is being renewed day by day.
2 Cor. 4:17 For our momentary, light affliction is producing for us an eternal weight of glory far beyond all comparison,
2 Cor. 4:18 while we look not at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen; for the things which are seen are temporal, but the things which are not seen are eternal.

- Paul's words here are so powerful.
  - He says that he and the other Apostles keep going, pressing on, and do not lose heart, even though their outer person is decaying, because they know their inner person is being renewed day by day.
  - Another way to say it is, even though they feel themselves physically getting worse and essentially dying, they are gaining strength inside themselves, specifically in their 'State of Mind', because of some daily renewing process. The question is, what renewing process are they talking about? For further insight into this topic, let's look at what Paul said in Romans 12:1-2, two verses that obviously reference the same topic:

Romans 12:1 Therefore I urge you, brothers *and sisters,* by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a living and holy sacrifice, acceptable to God, *which is* your spiritual service of worship.
Romans 12:2 And do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may prove what the will of God is, that which is good and acceptable and perfect.

- Now let me say, this renewing concept has at least two aspects to it. First of all (and I'll short cut it for you), the renewing of your mind comes by spending time with God, both in the study of His Word accompanied by prayer.
  - But second, you do have a choice in the matter, meaning you can choose to do it or not to do it. Which means if you want to grow with God and begin to know Him more intimately, you must discipline yourself and set aside time every day to spend with Him. That is the only way you can be renewed.
  - And (as you hear me say over and over again) there is no short cut to this process. You can't outsource it to someone else like your mother or grandmother or wife or husband. If you want more of God, and you want to gain a deeper understanding of your purpose on this planet, then it is up to you.
    - You must engage in prayer and study every day, and if you do, then something supernatural will happen. Paul gives us a glimpse into this supernatural thing in verse 17 when he says:

2 Cor. 4:17 For our momentary, light affliction is producing for us an eternal weight of glory far beyond all comparison,

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- So, what is this supernatural thing that we receive when we renew our minds daily? It's perspective. And, once again, not just any ole perspective. It's spiritual perspective. We gain eyes for eternity. Look at what Paul is saying – Because they renew their minds daily, they are able to put all of life's troubles into perspective. Look at what he says:

2 Cor. 4:17 **For our momentary, light affliction is producing for us an eternal weight of glory far beyond all comparison,**

- This may be one of might top 10 favorite verses in all of scripture.

2 Cor. 4:17 **For our momentary, light affliction is producing for us an eternal weight of glory far beyond all comparison,**

- First, to understand the weightiness of what Paul is trying to convey, you must understand just how bad things were for Paul and the other Apostles. These men have been stripped naked, beaten, and thrown into prison on several occasions.
  - And honestly, just me telling you that doesn't really give you the true sense of what they endured on a daily basis. They are truly living a life of extreme hardship, something that most of us here today can't even begin to imagine and something that most of us will never experience.
  - And yet, Paul says it's momentary. But more than that he says it's light. It's a light affliction. I don't know about you, but when I think of something being light, I don't think of beatings falling into that category. But Paul does. And why? Because of what he says in the rest of the verse.
    - Which is what? It's light because of the result of all that they are enduring. In other words, their pain and suffering are doing something, producing something. And what is it that it's producing? An eternal weight of glory far beyond all comparison.
  - Wow. Just imagine if you could look at life's afflictions in this way. And I'm not talking about beatings and imprisonment here, I'm talking about the simple hardships of life. What if you could look at your afflictions as light? Well, you can if you understand what Paul is saying, and that is, in all that you endure it's doing something, which means it has purpose.
- John Piper spoke about this this topic in one of his sermons several years ago. He said, and I quote, "Not only is all your affliction momentary, not only is all your affliction light in comparison to eternity and the glory there, but all of it is totally meaningful."
  - He goes on to say, "Every time something horrific happens, an interviewer will say, 'Meaningless'. And that is what it looks like at least from our perspective. They look at it and they say, "this is meaningless." But it wasn't meaningless. I don't care if it was cancer or criticism. I don't care if it was slander or sickness; it wasn't meaningless. Every millisecond of your misery is producing a glory you will get because of that suffering."
  - And we know this to be true because of what we read here in 2 Corinthians 4:17 - that my light, momentary, lifelong, total affliction is doing something. It's doing

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something. And it's not meaningless.

- But how do we reconcile this in our finite minds? How do we keep this perspective on life? We do it by doing what Paul does. Look at verse 18 as we close:

2 Cor. 4:18 **while we look not at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen; for the things which are seen are temporal, but the things which are not seen are eternal.**

- Focus – Focus. If you want to gain an eternal perspective on this life, it's all about what you focus on. Paul and the other Apostles and disciples were able to garner the perspective they had because of their focus. They understood the things you can see are temporary, but the things unseen are eternal.
  - And that is where they put their focus, and that's how they were able to look at their afflictions as light. Because they knew what they were experiencing here on earth was producing an eternal weight of Glory. One that they would one day realize in Heaven.
    - Focus. It's all about your perspective. According to Paul, if you can see it and touch it, it carries no spiritual value because it's temporary. But if you can't see it, those are the things that are eternal and those are the things you should focus on.
- Next week we move into Chapter 5, where Paul continues with this concept of the temporal/temporary verses the eternal. And so, our focus verses next week will be 2 Corinthians 5:1-10. And this is what he says: The Temporal and Eternal

2 Cor. 5:1 **For we know that if our earthly tent which is our house is torn down, we have a building from God, a house not made by hands, eternal in the heavens.**
2 Cor. 5:2 **For indeed, in this *tent* we groan, longing to be clothed with our dwelling from heaven,**
2 Cor. 5:3 **since in fact after putting it on, we will not be found naked.**
2 Cor. 5:4 **For indeed, we who are in this tent groan, being burdened, because we do not want to be unclothed but to be clothed, so that what is mortal will be swallowed up by life.**
2 Cor. 5:5 **Now He who prepared us for this very *purpose is* God, who gave us the Spirit as a pledge.**
2 Cor. 5:6 **Therefore, being always of good courage, and knowing that while we are at home in the body we are absent from the Lord—**
2 Cor. 5:7 **for we walk by faith, not by sight—**
2 Cor. 5:8 **but we are of good courage and prefer rather to be absent from the body and to be at home with the Lord.**
2 Cor. 5:9 **Therefore we also have as our ambition, whether at home or absent, to be pleasing to Him.**
2 Cor. 5:10 **For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ,**

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so that each one may receive compensation for his deeds *done* through the body, in accordance with what he has done, whether good or bad.

- This week, take these verses, pray over them, study them, meditate on them, and come back next week and let's see what God might do in your life as a result of your preparation!

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- Good morning, guys, welcome back to our journey through the Book, or maybe better said, Paul's 2nd recorded letter to the Corinthian Church – the letter the Bible entitles "2nd Corinthians."
  - When we last left off, I left you with a few focus verses for the week, verses for you to study on your own
  - And those verses showed up in the 5th Chapter of 2 Cor. verses 1-10
    - In my NASB this section of scripture is entitled "The Temporal & Eternal"
    - And this is what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 5:1 For we know that if our earthly tent which is our house is torn down, we have a building from God, a house not made by hands, eternal in the heavens.
2 Cor. 5:2 For indeed, in this *tent* we groan, longing to be clothed with our dwelling from heaven,
2 Cor. 5:3 since in fact after putting it on, we will not be found naked.
2 Cor. 5:4 For indeed, we who are in this tent groan, being burdened, because we do not want to be unclothed but to be clothed, so that what is mortal will be swallowed up by life.
2 Cor. 5:5 Now He who prepared us for this very *purpose is* God, who gave us the Spirit as a pledge.
2 Cor. 5:6 Therefore, being always of good courage, and knowing that while we are at home in the body we are absent from the Lord—
2 Cor. 5:7 for we walk by faith, not by sight—
2 Cor. 5:8 but we are of good courage and prefer rather to be absent from the body and to be at home with the Lord.
2 Cor. 5:9 Therefore we also have as our ambition, whether at home or absent, to be pleasing to Him.
2 Cor. 5:10 For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each one may receive compensation for his deeds *done* through the body, in accordance with what he has done, whether good or bad.

- For context purposes, let me bring us back up to speed, with where Paul is.
  - When we last left off in Chapter 4 we ended our study with Chapter 4:16-18 where Paul made two insightful and "yet" powerful statements.
  - I want to re-read it real quick and highlight what were the two main points, or themes of those verses if you will

2 Cor. 4:16 Therefore we do not lose heart, but though our outer person is decaying, yet our inner *person* is being renewed day by day.
2 Cor. 4:17 For our momentary, light affliction is producing for us an eternal weight of glory far beyond all comparison,
2 Cor. 4:18 while we look not at the things which are seen, but at the things which

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are not seen; for the things which are seen are temporal, but the things which are not seen are eternal.

- As I previously stated, Paul's words (this letter) are addressed to the church at Corinth. A church that he founded and that has begun to drift off track in his absence
  - In fact they have drifted off track so much, that they are now questioning the validity of Paul's calling as an Apostle of Jesus Christ
  - So as a result, Paul writes these words with one theme in mind: to defend who he is, as well as defend the authority or the calling that God has placed on his life
    - Now before moving on this morning, let me say the words Paul wrote here in verse 17 may be some of the most powerful language used in all the scriptures.
    - And the reason for this is, Paul's life and the affliction he experienced wouldn't be considered light by any of us, or by anyone else for that matter
    - Think about it, he had been beaten, stripped naked, shackled, beaten again, shipwrecked and snake bitten. And imprisoned, not once, not twice, but three times.
  - From our vantage point, we wouldn't call his life afflictions "Light or Easy" but Paul does. And why?
- When we read the beginning of verse 17, that these trials and tribulations are momentary and light, and that they are doing something for him – what where they doing?
  - They were producing in them an eternal weight of glory that was far beyond all comparison
- Interesting statement here, they are producing an eternal weight of glory - that far exceeds anything good or bad - that he could ever experience in this life
  - But that begs the question, what in the world is he talking about?
  - He's saying, whatever I experience on this earth, in the here and now, whatever afflictions I may experience as a believer, those afflictions had a purpose and a meaning.
    - And that purpose and meaning finds its center, its origin, its purpose, squarely revolving around the Glory of God.
  - Which means, Paul confidently and boldly knows he and the others will receive an eternal reward which far exceeds anything they (and by extension us), could ever experience here on earth
  - And these things that happen to us – sickness, death, pain, heartache, brokenness – whatever it is, those things are doing something.
    - Which is to take your life and mold it all for "God's Glory"
    - And that was why Paul could make the statement he made
    - Let me also say this, Paul deeply and strongly believed what he said. He believed it with every fiber of his being, and we must do the same.
  - But the question is, how can we arrive at the same place Paul did in his life?

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- How can we mature to this point that we look at life the same way Paul did? Or a better question might be, is it even possible to arrive at this place?
    - I say you can have all of God you want in your life, you simply must become more deeply intimate with Him.
    - And you do that through Study - Prayer - Study - Prayer - Study
        - That's how your belief system and your confidence in God is built. Outside of that it will never happen.
- The true test of our faith comes in times of trial in our lives. It's a really simple test and it begins with a question:
    - When trials and troubles arrive in our life do we A) Immediately abandon our faith, and question God
    - Or B) Do we stay steadfast, and double down on our relationship with Him, pull closer to him
        - Now this may sound like I am painting with a broad stroke here this morning, but it's the truth. You cannot know where you stand in your faith until it is tested.
        - Let me also say, this doesn't mean that when something bad happens that we don't question or worry. It simply means in the end you don't waiver. It means (after the shock is over) you have a level set, you get up and dust yourself off and double down on your relationship with God.
- So Paul, as part of his defense of who he is, uses as his proof his life and his affliction
    - Essentially saying, if I were not an Apostle – if I were not a true believer, a man called by God – then how do you explain my outlook on life, that in spite of all that I have been through I'm still standing firm.
        - This is an example of what a true witness really looks like, it causes people to "lean in - look closer - inquire - become curious"
        - This is how it works: People are watching, observing how we act and react in the face of any type of adversity.
        - They are curious about this faith we say we have, curious how we handle and conduct ourselves in even simple matters of conflict
        - For that is your witness, they are a witnessing everything you say and do!
    - Finally Paul says at the end of Chapter 4 that his attitude and perspective comes from a focus: A focus on the eternal versus the temporal. A focus on the next life, not this one.
- This got me to thinking about the word focus and just how powerful our minds can be. The reality is for most of us we will never tap into even 5% of our ability to focus. Yet focus is key.
    - And focus is a derivative of discipline, which is the main reason we don't focus very well. Most (if not all of us) struggle to stay disciplined, especially as it relates to spiritual matters.
    - Obviously, the greatest example of this being studying your Bible daily, coupled with your prayer life

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        - Do you set aside time for God daily or do you skip it most days?
- A couple weeks ago, I was honored with the opportunity to play golf with one of Major League Baseball all-time greats Mr. Daryl Strawberry. Daryl was a phenom by most accounts; He won 4 World Series (1 with the Mets, and 3 with the Yankees)
    - And let me say, what a wonderful day it was – and what a kind and gracious man he was (a man who loved the Lord).
    - As we spent the day together, I thought to myself, here I am playing golf with a baseball legend. So what questions could I ask him
        - And I don't mean, superficial questions. I mean questions that might give me some real insight into the world of an elite athlete.
    - So as I thought about what questions to ask, I had to really think what it meant to be a professional at anything. I had to try to think about and understand what it meant to be successful at that level. Because most people never truly understand how talented a professional athlete really is.
        - We simply see them on TV and think, how hard could it be.
        - The reality is it's extremely hard
    - You see in order to be deemed a professional at anything there are some intangibles that an individual must posses: It's not just their ability to hit the ball, or to run fast, or to catch, or jump or whatever it is, in whatever sport they may play.
    - It's much more than that. It's the mental. It's their ability to be disciplined and to Focus!
- I asked Daryl, when you stepped into the batter's box in Shea or Yankee stadium, what did you hear? He said "Nothing - I didn't hear anything. I just focused on the pitcher and the ball that was coming out of his hands.
    - I said, I've heard it said a good hitter could see the spin on the ball. He said, I could see the seams on the ball!
        - You want to talk about focus, his eyes and mental state were so focused, he could see the seams turning on the ball
- This type of focus is the type the Apostle Paul had. He knew who he was. He knew who Jesus was – He knew that Jesus saved him, and he knew his calling was to get up everyday and work for the Kingdom
    - And that was all made possible because of his view of this life. Meaning he knew this life was temporal and fleeting, nothing but a vapor - a mist if you will.
- I love the way King Solomon summed up his life in the end. King Solomon was the richest man who ever lived. It's been said he was so wealthy that if you took his wealth and converted it into today's currency he would be worth $2.1 Trillion Dollars
    - And just to put that into perspective:
        - John D Rockefeller was worth $663.4 Billion
        - Henry Ford was worth $199 Billion
        - Cornelius Vanderbilt was worth $185 Billion
        - Jeff Bezos of Amazon $152.8 Billion

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        - Bill Gates $118.1 Billion
        - Warren Buffet $117.3 Billion
    - You get the picture.
- Here's what King Solomon had to say about his life, his wisdom, his wealth and all the pleasures obtained for himself in Ecclesiastes 2:1-11

The Futility of Pleasure and Possessions

**Eccl. 2:1 I said to myself, "Come now, I will test you with pleasure.
So enjoy yourself." And behold, it too was futility.**
**Eccl. 2:2 I said of laughter, "*It is* senseless," and of pleasure, "What does
this accomplish?"**
**Eccl. 2:3 I explored with my mind *how* to refresh my body with wine while
my mind was guiding *me* wisely; and how to seize foolishness, until I could
see what good there is for the sons of mankind to do under heaven for the
few years of their lives.**
**Eccl. 2:4 I enlarged my works: I built houses for myself, I planted vineyards for
myself;**
**Eccl. 2:5 I made gardens and parks for myself, and I planted in them all kinds of
fruit trees;**
**Eccl. 2:6 I made ponds of water for myself from which to irrigate a forest of
growing trees.**
**Eccl. 2:7 I bought male and female slaves, and I had slaves *born* at home. I
also possessed flocks and herds larger than all who preceded me in Jerusalem.**
**Eccl. 2:8 I also amassed for myself silver and gold, and the treasure of kings and
provinces. I provided for myself male and female singers, and the pleasures of
the sons of mankind: many concubines.**
**Eccl. 2:9 Then I became great and increased more than all who preceded me in
Jerusalem. My wisdom also stood by me.**
**Eccl. 2:10 All that my eyes desired, I did not refuse them. I did not restrain my
heart from any pleasure, for my heart was pleased because of all my labor; and
this was my reward for all my labor.**
**Eccl. 2:11 So I considered all my activities which my hands had done and the
labor which I had exerted, and behold, all was futility and striving after wind,
and there was no benefit under the sun.**

- Paraphrasing here, King Solomon said I have had it all, I have seen it all, I have experienced all the pleasures that my heart desired and it was all for naught - for nothing - it was all vanity and striving after the wind
    - Perspective and Focus Guys, that's what it's all about. It's what we must do if we are ever going to be anything other than a Christian in name only, we must put this life in its rightful perspective – which is it's temporary.

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- Moving on, Paul continues with his theme of focusing on the Temporal versus the Eternal

2 Cor. 5:1 For we know that if our earthly tent which is our house is torn down, we have a building from God, a house not made by hands, eternal in the heavens.
2 Cor. 5:2 For indeed, in this *tent* we groan, longing to be clothed with our dwelling from heaven,
2 Cor. 5:3 since in fact after putting it on, we will not be found naked.
2 Cor. 5:4 For indeed, we who are in this tent groan, being burdened, because we do not want to be unclothed but to be clothed, so that what is mortal will be swallowed up by life.
2 Cor. 5:5 Now He who prepared us for this very *purpose is* God, who gave us the Spirit as a pledge.
2 Cor. 5:6 Therefore, being always of good courage, and knowing that while we are at home in the body we are absent from the Lord—
2 Cor. 5:7 for we walk by faith, not by sight—
2 Cor. 5:8 but we are of good courage and prefer rather to be absent from the body and to be at home with the Lord.
2 Cor. 5:9 Therefore we also have as our ambition, whether at home or absent, to be pleasing to Him.
2 Cor. 5:10 For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each one may receive compensation for his deeds *done* through the body, in accordance with what he has done, whether good or bad.

- I sound like a broken record, but one more time, Paul's word are so rich and weighty, the sheer structure and the architecture of what he is saying, is so heavy – very poetic.
  - Beginning with verse 1 he says

2 Cor. 51 For we know that if our earthly tent which is our house is torn down, we have a building from God, a house not made by hands, eternal in the heavens.

- What Paul is saying is, your body is a house. A dwelling place, but the question is a dwelling place for what?
  - For your soul, and God's Holy Spirit if you are a believer.
    - It's a housing for something that will live on forever. Something eternal.
    - And as such, if we truly believe and understand this, we should quit trying to hold onto it.
  - We spend our entire lives in a body, one that we all know is dying, trying to prolong or somehow forgo death – and in the meantime we miss living life.
- I mean if you are a believer living life here that means working now for the later, not working now for now.

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- It means a life lived here is only truly lived to its fullest when we live in it, but live it with eyes for eternity.
  - It's kind of like a 401K – You invest every paycheck for years, to enjoy it later
  - Paul's and the other disciples and Apostles perspective was pure, they saw themselves as simply passing through this world
  - And they knew the here and now was just a proving ground what was to come.
  - And we know this to be the case because of what he says in verse 10 – which we will touch on later
- And so, our body is temporary housing, and it should be viewed this way.

- Next he says,

2 Cor. 5:2 **For indeed, in this *tent* we groan, longing to be clothed with our dwelling from heaven,**
2 Cor. 5:3 **since in fact after putting it on, we will not be found naked.**

- Here we have once again some more of Paul's weighty words. Interesting statement here in verse 2:
  - As they live in this tent, ie… their body, they groan! They groan longing to be clothed with our dwelling from heaven
  - I had to pause here for moment and honestly ask myself a question – Am I groaning to receive my new home, Or would I say, No I'm good.
    - This word "groan" in the Greek is a verb and it means "to groan within oneself"
    - The usage of this word is I groan, expressing grief, anger or desire
  - This term "denotes feeling which is internal and unexpressed"
    - It's as if there is a pressure inside you, exerting forward (like the forward pressure of Childbirth), to feel pressure from what is coming on
  - So what Paul is saying is their belief of what's to come is so strong inside themselves they are literally internally groaning inside themselves. How's that for perspective?
- Now, as I said earlier, I had to pause and ask myself the question – do I ever feel this way?
  - And the answer is, being truthful maybe a little, in times of hardship.
- Which then precipitated the next question, which was can I feel this way? Is it even possible? And the answer is yes, but it requires our minds to leave the temporal (the here and now) and move into the eternal
  - This takes us back to the topic of discipline and focus. We must discipline ourselves daily focus toward God, and how do we do that?
    - Once again we study, we study, we study – and pray and meditate
    - And how often – every chance we get. Certainly daily if not multiple times a day.

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And let me say I know it's tough, I know.

- But when you create that habit it's amazing how much easier it gets
- This groaning that Paul speaks about here, comes by way of Revelation. From God revealing himself to you through His word, the more you become intimate with Him, the more your groaning will increase overtime.

- Now obviously, Paul was in a much different environment than we are. He didn't have the shiny things of life pulling at him.
  - Which meant looking forward to the next life was a lot easier on him. And in that sense, it was much easier for him to focus.
  - But having said that the same level of Spiritual Awaking that Paul experienced, is still available for us today, it's just harder to obtain naturally. We just have to make the commitment.
- Moving on, verse 3 says:

2 Cor. 5:3 **since in fact after putting it on, we will not be found naked.**

- Verse 3 gives us the why to Verse 1, as in why they are groaning inside: It's because they're anxious, because they know that because their bodies are just a temporary dwelling place, they are ready to move on to the permanent. And they know, that when they die they will not be found naked.
  - In other words, they know they will move from one covering to another. From this ole worn out vessel / house to a new resurrected body.
    - "To not be found naked" is just a poetic way of saying they know they are clothed ie. saved and headed to their permanent home. Which is further confirmed in verses 4&5, where Paul says

2 Cor. 5:4 **For indeed, we who are in this tent groan, being burdened, because we do not want to be unclothed but to be clothed, so that what is mortal will be swallowed up by life.**
2 Cor. 5:5 **Now He who prepared us for this very *purpose is* God, who gave us the Spirit as a pledge.**

- We will close here but let me highlight just a couple things in verses 4&5, and that is as believers we are going to be burdened. It's never ending.
  - One thing gets fixed, or repaired, only for the next thing to rear its head.
    - Every week it seems I remove 2 things from my prayer list, only to add 4 more
    - This is the temporal, temporary life we live and it will never change.
  - But what will help you embrace and accept this fact shows up in verse 5 where Paul says,

2 Cor. 5:5 Now He who prepared us for this very *purpose is* God, who gave us the Spirit as

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a pledge.

- Listen to me, if you don't hear anything else this morning, Your God is totally in control of everything. Not only is He in control, He has prepared things for you beforehand. Before you were even born.
    - Jeremiah says it this way in Jer. 1:4-5, when he says

Jer. 1:4 Now the word of the LORD came to me, saying,
Jer. 1:5 "Before I formed you in the womb I knew you,
And before you were born I consecrated you;
I have appointed you as a prophet to the nations."

- Guys, your life has purpose and meaning. And just as Paul tells us in verse 5 has sealed each and every believer with a pledge – a commitment, a down payment (if you will), by placing the Holy Spirit inside of you.
    - And one day, sooner than later (I assure you), the Lord is coming back to retrieve which is rightfully His, which is the Spirit that lives within us.
    - If we can remember that and grasp it just a little bit it will help us keep our focus.

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- This morning turn with me if you will back to the 5th Chapter of 2 Corinthians. When we last left off, Paul was in the middle of explaining how it was that he and the other Apostles were able to look at life the way they looked at it. More specifically, how it was they had such an eternal verses temporal perspective?
    - As we previously discussed last week, their outlook on this life was directly tied to their ability to focus. Focus intently on the promises of God, all the while knowing that this life is indeed temporary at best.
        - Their line of thinking was also coupled by the fact that they clearly understood, everything we experience in this life is not only temporary, but it's light in comparison to what awaits us in Heaven.
        - But more than that, the things we experience in this world (all the trials and tribulations) in the here and now are also doing something to us. It is molding us and shaping us into the Christian that God wants us to be. But that only happens when and if we allow it to do its work.
    - In other words, if we embrace suffering and allow it to do what it's intended to do (which is to mold and shape us into instruments), we will become instruments that God uses for His Glory. And then once your life comes to an end, and all that you experienced in this life (for Christ's sake) is tallied up, grand totaled if you will, or another way to say it is, when all that you did for Christ is banked. Paul says in Chapter 4 that it will accumulate for you, an "Eternal Weight of Glory".
    - Which is an eloquent way of saying accumulate your riches and rewards in Heaven. And for further proof of this concept, let me read what James says in James 1:1-4, a passage that you may be familiar with, but it's always good to hear it again. Listen to what James says under the caption *Testing Your Faith*:

James 1:1 James, a bond-servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ,
To the twelve tribes who are dispersed abroad: Greetings.
James 1:2 Consider it all joy, my brethren, when you encounter various trials,
James 1:3 knowing that the testing of your faith produces endurance.
James 1:4 And let endurance have *its* perfect result, so that you may be perfect and complete, lacking in nothing.

- I won't dwell on this topic this morning, only to say Verse 4 clearly tells us that we (as believers) do have a choice. A choice whether we allow trials and tribulations to mold our lives into instruments of God or to simply fall prey to a victim mindset, a mindset that asks, "Why me"?
    - In other words, when we put the trials of life into their proper perspective, which is they are supernaturally designed for our benefit, forming us into these "Spiritual Instruments "of God. When we do this (believe it or not) they have the ability to empower us, taking us from a mindset of why me to a mindset of why not me, or, God has chosen me to endure all of this for purposes I can't see.
    - We can either see the troubles of life for what they are, or we can push back against them, resist them, question them, and unfortunately, be confused by them. So, we do have a choice in how the various trials of life affect us. That's why James said in

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verse 4, “And let endurance have its perfect result”.

- Let it do its work. And what is its work? To make you perfect and complete, lacking in nothing. Perfect and complete. But how can we be made perfect and complete? And maybe even more than that, how in the world can we get to a place where we are lacking in nothing?

- Well, as we just discovered, evidently it comes by way of trials. Meaning, the natural byproduct of a trial (in the life of a believer) is “Spiritual Development”. So, what that tells us is the trials in our lives (as Christians), can cause us to become perfect & complete, leaving us in a place where we “lack of nothing”.

- But my question is, what specifically does that mean? First, let me explain what it means by telling you what it doesn’t mean. It doesn’t mean that you will become a perfect person who’s lacking in nothing, meaning, you become rich. That’s not what it means.
  - No, this perfection is a perfection that relates to you and your development as a believer. More specifically, to you as it relates to your calling and purpose relating to God. And this developmental process, according to Paul in verse 3, has a direct effect on your endurance. Your endurance to persevere in your faith.
    - And so, Paul knew this to be the case. Not only did he know it, but he also believed it. He believed it so much that it controlled his outlook and perspective on this life, which in turn is what formed the basis from which he spoke and wrote.

- Now the question we must ask ourselves is, can we develop this same perspective? And the answer is yes. Yes, we can, but it will never happen if we don’t develop a more intimate relationship with the Lord. And how do we do that? Through study, prayer, and meditating on His Word. That is the only way we can become more intimate with Him. We must get to know Him better. It’s no different than any other relationship we may have in life.
  - Moving on this morning. Last week I ended the study by reading Chapter 5 verses 1-10, but I was only able to finish teaching through verse 5. So, this morning I want to pick back up where we left off, and begin todays teaching by backing up and re-reading 2 Corinthians 5:1-10, and this is what Paul wrote in:

2 Cor. 5:1 For we know that if our earthly tent which is our house is torn down, we have a building from God, a house not made by hands, eternal in the heavens.
2 Cor. 5:2 For indeed, in this *tent* we groan, longing to be clothed with our dwelling from heaven,
2 Cor. 5:3 since in fact after putting it on, we will not be found naked.
2 Cor. 5:4 For indeed, we who are in this tent groan, being burdened, because we do not want to be unclothed but to be clothed, so that what is mortal will be swallowed up by life.
2 Cor. 5:5 Now He who prepared us for this very *purpose is* God, who gave us the Spirit as a pledge.
2 Cor. 5:6 Therefore, being always of good courage, and knowing that while we are at home in the body we are absent from the Lord—
2 Cor. 5:7 for we walk by faith, not by sight—

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2 Cor. 5:8 but we are of good courage and prefer rather to be absent from the body and to be at home with the Lord.
2 Cor. 5:9 Therefore we also have as our ambition, whether at home or absent, to be pleasing to Him.
2 Cor. 5:10 For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ,
so that each one may receive compensation for his deeds *done* through the body, in accordance with what he has done, whether good or bad.

- As I said, we paused our teaching last week, ending with verse 5, and I won't re-hash all of what we studied last week. But I will say, Paul's purpose in writing verses 1-5 was to show us just how passionate and sincere he was about what he believed.
    - His teaching and concept are simple, and that is our body is a house, a dwelling place that houses our soul along with the Spirit of God. And it's temporary, which is evidenced by the fact that it's dying and decaying.
        - But that's okay, because if you are a believer, there's a new body, a new home you will one day soon inherit, and we know this to be the case because of what he says in Verse 6-9:

2 Cor. 5:6 Therefore, being always of good courage, and knowing that while we are at home in the body we are absent from the Lord—
2 Cor. 5:7 for we walk by faith, not by sight—
2 Cor. 5:8 but we are of good courage and prefer rather to be absent from the body and to be at home with the Lord.
2 Cor. 5:9 Therefore we also have as our ambition, whether at home or absent, to be pleasing to Him.

- Now, before highlighting the obvious teachings that come from these verses, let me say, a few weeks ago I had someone ask me the question, "What do you think happens when we die?" And I said, I know what happens, and they said, "well, what do you believe?" And I said, what Paul says in 2 Corinthians 5:6-9: "To be absent the body is to be present with the Lord."
    - Guys, there are many theories about what happens to us when we die, one of which is called soul sleep. This teaching, or doctrine, says that upon death, the soul of each person, believer and unbeliever alike, "sleeps" until the general resurrection and judgment.
        - Though all people will be raised from the dead, the condition of humans between death and the resurrection is one of unconsciousness. The soul is alive but unconscious, awaiting the time of the end. According to this teaching, when the person dies, they totally cease to exist. Eventually, each soul will be awakened to resurrection, then to judgment.
        - I'm not going to go over all this, this morning, except to tell you a person who tries to make this the case has to stretch and bend the scriptures into all kinds of strange directions, and they must do so in order to even come close to

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making this theory stick.

- I have studied this teaching, and I can tell you nowhere can I find anywhere in the scripture that teaches anything other than when we die, we immediately enter into the presence of the Lord. And that is clearly backed up by what Paul says here. One of the best ways to validate Paul's teaching, by the way, is by understanding eschatology, which is simply the study of the End Times.

- When you study eschatology, you will clearly see what happens when the Lord returns. And by understanding that, you will get further confirmation of what Paul tells us as being the truth. Also, another confirmation of what Paul is saying comes when you study what happened to a person when they died prior to Jesus living and dying (Saints of the Old Testament), specifically where their souls went, which was to a holding place called "Sheol", which we have studied in-depth before.
  - When you study the purpose of Sheol in the Old Testament, that study also further confirms that we immediately enter the presence of the Lord when we die. Anyway, if you're interested in knowing more on this topic, see me after the service and I will give you some stuff to study.
    - So, Paul says, they long to be absent their body so they can be present with the Lord. But he also says even though, for now, they are not with him in that moment, paraphrasing here, he says they will continue to have (as their ambition) a desire to please him. Listen to verse 9 one more time:

2 Cor. 5:9 **Therefore we also have as our ambition, whether at home or absent, to be pleasing to Him.**

- Breaking it down into layman's terms, Paul is saying no matter where we are, we have as our ambition a mind-set, a goal, to be pleasing to God. The Greek definition of the word ambition is 'to love or seek after honor', and the sense or usage of that word is to be zealous, strive eagerly, desire very strongly.
  - And so, they have as their ambition, their motivation if you will, "To be pleasing to God." Another way to say it is, Lord, no matter my plight or situation in this life, whether in prison or pain, we love You and we will serve You, and we want to please You no matter the state we find ourselves in.
  - A pretty simple statement and one we should all remember. No matter what situation we find ourselves in, if we are believers, we should make it our goal, our ambition, to please God. And why? Well, Paul's going to tell you why in verse 10:

2 Cor. 5:10 **For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each one may receive compensation for his deeds *done* through the body, in accordance with what he has done, whether good or bad.**

- When we die, not only will we automatically enter the presence of the Lord, but evidently, we enter His presence by way of His Judgement Seat. Another way to say it is, we enter His presence through His court. Now let me say for the believer, this will not be a judgement for sin, for Christ already paid that price, rather this will be a judgement for

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the purposes of receiving what the Bible calls a compensation. Much like an athlete receiving his reward for running a race.

- But that might be a little confusing to you because Paul says, “For those things done in the body, whether good or bad.” So, that might seem confusing. I mean, if we are receiving rewards, then why are we receiving compensation for things done in the body, for both good and bad?
  - What’s with the bad part of this process? Well, that’s a good question? The Bible teaches that this judgement reconciles everything you have done in your life as it relates to those things you’ve done for God. Not bad as in sin, but bad as in detracting from bringing Glory to God. It’s an accounting exercise of sorts.
- Think of it like this, accounting is a two-entry system. A system of debits and credits. Which means when you do something, it affects something else. Kind of like Issac Newton’s Third Law of Motion, which says, “For every action there is an opposite and equal reaction.”
- That’s how accounting works. If you make a transaction, you automatically create another transaction. It’s a debit and credit system. Debits are listed on one side and credits on the other. When you effect the debit side of the equation you automatically effect the credit side of the equation. If one side increases the other side decreases.
  - Let me give you an example of what I mean. If your rent is due and you write a check for it, your rent is what’s called an Accounts Payable expense, and it’s required to be paid monthly or whatever the terms are of the rent.
- Anyway, when you pay the rent, or any other expense for that matter, you debit the cash out of your bank account, and credit the rent under accounts payable. This creates a balanced system in your books. When you die, God’s judgement system works much the same way.
  - Upon your death, you immediately enter into the presence of the Lord, and as a believer there will be a final accounting of your life. There is reconciliation, But, as I said, not as a lost person or an unbeliever. It’s a reconciliation that takes place as a one of God’s children.
- And what is the purpose of this reconciliation? To give you the compensation you have earned, which was obtained through the life you lived for God while living here on earth. But notice, as I said, there is a reconciliation, which means the good and bad things are balanced out for final payment.

- And that tells us something, and that is that if today I do something that is pleasing to God (the good things), but tomorrow I do something that is not pleasing to God (the Bad things), These two appear to have an offsetting effect. And one more time, as I stated earlier, this reconciliation has nothing to do with Salvation.
  - Rather, it has everything to do with the rewards you will receive in heaven. Now of course, while studying this my mind always goes to, well, are some things weighted heavier than others, as it relates to the good things I do versus the bad things?
    - My answer to you today is, I have no clue, and I don’t think anyone can answer that question either. What we do know though, is that there is a reconciliation process, and this process has to do with the rewards you will receive in heaven, which is directly related to the things you did which were pleasing to God.

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Things for His Glory and for His Kingdom while living here on earth.

- Which tells us that we can A) Subtract from His Glory for His Kingdom, or we can B) Add to or Bring Glory to His Kingdom. Now, as I was thinking about all of this it got me to thinking just a little bit deeper about this topic. Which of course is what I always do. I simply can't leave well enough alone.

- But it got me to thinking about how all this might work, and I came up with a theory, which by the way is not substantiated today by scripture. Therefore, don't leave this morning and say, "Well, brother Greg said…" I didn't say anything. I am simply giving you some insight into a thought I've had, and that is, if there is a judgement after our death, and that judgement is for reconciliation purposes, for the rewards we will receive in Heaven, which, let me say, I am 100% convinced of that fact, that our reconciliation is for the purposes of receiving our rewards in Heaven.
  - And so, if this is the case, then (once again) it's a debit and credit system. We know that to be the case because that's what it says. We will receive compensation for what we did that is good and bad. Then this means we must think about everything we do (as believers) in this life in the format of adding to and taking away.
  - Meaning, I could go out tomorrow and pray for someone, tell them about God's love, which would be pleasing to our Lord, and as such put a credit in my Heavenly Bank Account. But then turn right around and do something that is not pleasing to Him, I don't know, say, flip someone off in traffic, which would then turn around and create a debit.
    - Also, let me say this, we could also do something that would appear to make a deposit into our Heavenly back account, but in reality, make a debit due to the motive of our heart. And, obviously, only you and God knows what is true.
    - Which tells us even though other people may see me do something and say, wow, wasn't that the Christian thing to do or say, if your motives were all self-serving, God knows it and it would create a debit rather than a credit. (Be burned up with fire).
  - You know what would really be interesting, would be for God to send us a current reconciliation of our Heavenly bank account. Wonder how it would look? I've got a sneaky feeling all of us would be shocked. And not in a good way.
  - So, this is the concept. A believer, upon his death, immediately enters the presence of the Lord and then proceeds directly into a judgement, along with a reconciliation for purposes of compensation, to receive our rewards in Heaven.
- By the way, just one more comment on this topic. I had a guy tell me one time, you know, I may not receive many rewards in Heaven, but as long as I get there, I'm good with it. He said, "I might be sweeping the gold dust off the roads, and you might be serving in some higher capacity, but I'm good".
  - He was speaking in jest, but I thought it was an interesting way of looking at our rewards in Heaven. What he was saying is, it doesn't matter what I do in this life, if I am saved, and I get there, who cares.
    - You know, I would hate to know that was my thought process. Because to be honest with you, my next thought after that would be (and this is just me), but my next thought would be, if I am thinking this way, maybe I am not truly saved in the first place. Because, why in the world would I not be concerned with

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pleasing God while living here on earth. Right? I'm not saying I am correct, but that's just me.

- So, you get the picture. Once you die, Paul says we immediately enter the presence of the Lord for the purpose of receiving our compensation for the life we lived, bringing glory to Him.

- One more side note. For further confirmation of what Paul wrote, the writer of Hebrews said this, and Paul didn't write Hebrews, but in Hebrews 9:27:

Hebrews 9:27 And just as it is destined for people to die once, and after this *comes* judgment,

- Other versions of scripture say, "it is appointed man once to die and then the judgement". I'll close here but let me say this. Guys, this life (especially the one we are living in) has a way of grabbing hold of our attention, taking our eyes off what is important.
  - But one day we will die. We don't know when, but we will all die. And once we do there will be a judgement and there will be a reconciliation, and you will care about it. You won't just have an "oh well" attitude about it. So, remember that as we go and represent our Lord and Savior.

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- Welcome back guys, and welcome back to our study of one of Paul's letters to the Corinthians. His second letter to the Corinthians to be exact.
    - Last week, we ended our teaching with a study focusing on what happens when you die, and more specifically, what happens to a believer when they die. We also studied the concept of what Paul called a judgement/compensation after our death. Judgement and compensation for things we've done in the body, whether good or bad.
    - From Paul's own words, we know that to be absent from the body is to be present with the Lord. That is exactly what he told us in verses 6-8. And for reference, let me read it to you one more time.

2 Cor. 5:6 **Therefore, being always of good courage, and knowing that while we are at home in the body we are absent from the Lord—**
2 Cor. 5:7 **for we walk by faith, not by sight—**
2 Cor. 5:8 **but we are of good courage and prefer rather to be absent from the body and to be at home with the Lord.**

- Before moving forward, let me say this is not the only place in scripture that confirms what happens to a believer when they die. There are many other places throughout the Bible we could study on this topic, but I'm not going to go over all of them this morning. Having said that, if you are interested in studying this topic more in-depth, then I can give you more information. Just see me after the service.
    - Anyway, so to be absent the body is to be present with the Lord, and once we die, we also discovered that immediately upon entering the Lord's presence we will receive and enter a judgement for the purposes of receiving a compensation (as Paul calls it). "For things done in the body whether good or bad".
    - What we also learned was that this judgement was not a judgement unto salvation, but rather a judgement that would be more like an award ceremony, where we receive our rewards for all that we had done, whether good or bad, while living on this earth as a believer.
        - In other words, it was a reconciliation for the purposes of compensation. As I said last week, it was much like an accounting exercise. A simple adding up and subtracting for all the things you have done for Christ as a believer. And the final tally (if you will), gives you your rewards. The rewards God had promised we will receive once we enter heaven.
- Once again, this reconciliation is that of adding up all you have done for God (the good), in one column (we will call these the credits), and then adding up all that you have done bad, things against God, in the other column.
    - And the two offset one another, leaving you with the final numbers for the rewards you have earned. And so, we should remember this as we live our Christian lives. Just because we do something good for the Kingdom one day does not mean we are good. We know by Paul's own words the one good thing can be offset by one bad thing.
        - But because we are humans, we tend to forget about the bad stuff we do, and in

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its place focus on all the good we've done. Paul said that won't work on your day of judgement. All things will be tallied up and reconciled. And so, moving on, Paul now makes a shift if you will.

- And to me, it's a pretty abrupt shift. I call it jumping from one thing to the next in a conversation without letting the other person know where you are going. And let me show you what I mean by backing up and re-reading the last few verses of last week's teaching, and then moving forward into this week's teaching. Listen to what Paul says in verses 9-10:

2 Cor. 5:9 **Therefore we also have as our ambition, whether at home or absent, to be pleasing to Him.**
2 Cor. 5:10 **For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each one may receive compensation for his deeds *done* through the body, in accordance with what he has done, whether good or bad.**

- So, Paul is talking about how, whether he is at home (which means the here and now) while living in his earthly body, or, whether he is absent (meaning dead and present with God), he wants to be pleasing to God no matter what his plight or situation is. He is saying it's all about Christ all the time.
- And then in verse 10, he talks about how we all must appear before the judgement seat of Christ and receive our compensation for the deeds done in the body in accordance with what we have done, whether good or bad. And now, he immediately makes a shift in topic, or in focus where he says the following. Listen to what he says in Verses 11-21:

2 Cor. 5:11 **Therefore, knowing the fear of the Lord, we persuade people, but we are well known to God; and I hope that we are also well known in your consciences.**
2 Cor. 5:12 **We are not commending ourselves to you again but *are* giving you an opportunity to be proud of us, so that you will have *an answer* for those who take pride in appearance and not in heart.**
2 Cor. 5:13 **For if we have lost our minds, *it is* for God; if we are of sound mind, *it is* for you.**
2 Cor. 5:14 **For the love of Christ controls us, having concluded this, that one died for all, therefore all died;**
2 Cor. 5:15 **and He died for all, so that those who live would no longer live for themselves, but for Him who died and rose on their behalf.**
2 Cor. 5:16 **Therefore from now on we recognize no one by the flesh; even though we have known Christ by the flesh, yet now we know *Him in this way* no longer.**
2 Cor. 5:17 **Therefore if anyone is in Christ, *this person is* a new creation; the old things passed away; behold, new things have come.**

- This morning, I am going to break these final verses into a few different sections, if you

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will. The first section will begin with Verses 11-12, beginning with what Paul calls the "Fear of the Lord", and more specifically, how that "Fear" does something to them.

- And what does it do? It causes them to make an effort in trying to persuade people for Christ. For the sake of the Gospel. So, let's begin with the concept of the "Fear of the Lord".
    - First of all, what is it? Without doing a theological deep dive, it's a healthy fear of who God is. But it can only really be derived or realized when we see ourselves in the proper light, which is who we really are in the sight of a Holy and Righteous God.
    - Another way to say it is, it's a fear derived from our own internal self-examination or self-awareness, which, by the way, is the most important trait or characteristic a person can possess. For a person to be totally honest with oneself about who they really are. For a Christian, this self-awareness is self-awareness as it relates to God.
        - If you want to get more specific or more granular, it's your inner ability to realize who you are (without the covering of the blood of Jesus Christ). And so, that begs the question, how does God view us (or see us), without the blood of Jesus covering us?
        - Well, we get a little insight when we read from the prophet Isaiah as well as from Moses on an encounter with God. So let me start by reading from the prophet Isaiah 64:6:

Isaiah 64:6 **For all of us have become like one who is unclean, and all our righteous deeds are like a filthy garment; and all of us wither like a leaf, and our wrongdoings, like the wind, take us away.**

- Isaiah paints for us a picture of who the children were in the sight of God. And then, by extension, the same holds true for each of us. And that picture is in direct contrast to God himself. Where God is pure and righteousness and holy, we are not. Moses himself encountered this same experience in what I would call its purest form. Because of God's holiness, Moses was unable to look upon God.
    - Listen to what God told Moses in Exodus 33.

Exodus 33:17 **The LORD said to Moses, "I will also do this thing of which you have spoken; for you have found favor in My sight and I have known you by name."**
Exodus 33:18 **Then *Moses* said, "Please, show me Your glory!"**
Exodus 33:19 **And He said, "I Myself will make all My goodness pass before you and will proclaim the name of the LORD before you; and I will be gracious to whom I will be gracious and will show compassion to whom I will show compassion."**
Exodus 33:20 **He further said, "You cannot see My face, for mankind shall not see Me and live!"**

- So, the concept is simple. God is pure and clean, and we are unclean. And the only way we can be seen as clean in the sight of God is through the covering of God's innocent Son's blood. And, just to put that into perspective, we must understand just how

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unclean we really are.

- We are so unclean that it took the greatest of all sacrifices to clean us up. It took God sending His Son to die a brutal death on the cross of Calvary, in order that He might reconcile us back to Himself. Another way to say it is, the sin of the world was so bad that the only way God could enter into communion with us was to send His perfect sinless Son to die for us!
- That should give us some insight into just how unclean we are. And, if we can understand just how bad we are, and then see ourselves in this light, then, and only then, can we truly realize what the fear of the Lord is.
  - It's a reverence that evokes a fear or respect for just how clean Holy God is, which then brings us to an understanding of who we are and what we truly deserve, which is death. Not eternal life. So, Paul starts out in verse 11 by saying,

2 Cor. 5:11 Therefore, knowing the fear of the Lord, we persuade people, but we are well known to God; and I hope that we are also well known in your consciences.

- And then he says, in the second half of the verse, that they are well known to God (which means they are His chosen children and Apostles), and he hopes that they are well known to them in their conscience as well.
  - Essentially what he is saying is, we are who we say we are, and even if someone inside your fellowship tells you something different, and even if you begin to question what we say, hopefully, when all is said and done, you will know in your heart (your conscience) that we are telling the truth.
  - It's kind of like us saying, "Yes, I know such and such did this or that, but in my heart, I know they are not a bad person", or "I know this is who they truly are".
    - Basically, what Paul is saying is, although I have not been with you in a while, and although someone inside the fellowship is causing you to question my authority, in your heart, and in your conscience, you know better than that. Moving on to verses 12-15:

2 Cor. 5:12 We are not commending ourselves to you again but *are* giving you an opportunity to be proud of us, so that you will have *an answer* for those who take pride in appearance and not in heart.
2 Cor. 5:13 For if we have lost our minds, *it is* for God; if we are of sound mind, *it is* for you.
2 Cor. 5:14 For the love of Christ controls us, having concluded this, that one died for all, therefore all died;
2 Cor. 5:15 and He died for all, so that those who live would no longer live for themselves, but for Him who died and rose on their behalf.

- Verses 12 and 13 give us further insight into what Paul was dealing with. Remember, one

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of the primary reasons for Paul writing this letter was to defend who he and the other Apostles were, along with defending their calling (their ministry). And why? Because there was some person (a man) in the church who started saying Paul and the others were not who they said they were.

- So once again, we see Paul defending himself. And with that background in view, when you read verses 12 and 13, you can see how it all makes sense. Look at what he says. 'We are not commending ourselves to you again'.
  - In other words, we are not promoting ourselves or shining a light on ourselves (lifting ourselves up). He's saying, it's not about us, it's all about God. But then he says, we are giving you an opportunity to be proud of us, so that you will have an answer "For those who take pride in their appearance and not in heart".
- For those who take pride in their appearance and not in heart! What does that mean? It means, those who are putting on airs, or those who appear to be Christian on the outside, but, in reality, are not on the inside.
  - Paraphrasing here, Paul is saying, we are who we say we are, and God knows it, and hopefully you know it in your hearts, and one of the ways you can know this to be the truth is by the fact that we are not commending ourselves or lifting ourselves up, and our lives testify to this very fact!
  - And then he says something that once again gives us insight into what he was dealing with. Verse 13 says:

2 Cor. 5:13 **For if we have lost our minds, *it is* for God; if we are of sound mind, *it is* for you.**

- For if we have lost our minds, it is for God. What this tells us, is someone inside the church at Corinth is saying Paul and those other Apostles have lost their minds. Which is just more talk from someone trying to discredit them.
  - But I love what he says in response of his critics, for if we have lost our minds, it is for God; if we are of sound mind, it is for you. Pretty good comeback. If we have lost our minds, it is for God.
    - Another way to say it is, if we are crazy, we are crazy over God, but if we aren't crazy, if we are of sound mind, it's for you.
  - In other words, if we are of sound mind, and we are who we say we are, then it's for your benefit. And why, well, verse 14 tells us why:

2 Cor. 5:14 **For the love of Christ controls us, having concluded this, that one died for all, therefore all died;**
2 Cor. 5:15 **and He died for all, so that those who live would no longer live for themselves, but for Him who died and rose on their behalf.**

- Paul says, we are controlled, we are moved, and we do what we do not because of what's in it for us, because of the love of Christ. Interesting concept here, and one we should explore and understand. If we truly understand what it means to be loved by

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God, then we should be moved by that very fact.

- Now, the reason I say this is an interesting concept is because for most of us, because of the world we live in, one that says, “It’s all about us”, we are not generally moved by the love God has for us. We are generally moved by what God can do for us.
- If you stop for just a moment and think about why we do what we do, even in our Christian lives, it’s generally not because of what God has done for us. It’s usually because of what He will do for us, which is different.

- One perspective looks back for reference and the other looks forward. One is a reality based on the past, and the other is based on the future. But does this matter? Yes, it does. But why does this matter? It matters because of who’s at the center of the motivation.
  - When reflecting on the past, God is at the center. I move, I act, I see things through the lens of God’s great sacrifice on my behalf, where the other is I move, I act, or react, because of what God will do for me in the future. Which puts me at the center.
  - One is a God-centered perspective and the other is a me-centered perspective. And if ‘we’ are ever at the center, then God is not. And so, for us to be controlled (as Paul calls it) by God, it must come from the reality of what He has done for us, which reflects how much He loves us.
    - And, as I said, that can only be realized when we truly understand the sacrifice He made for us (through the death of His son). What God did for us! And what did He do for us? Well, Paul tells us in the second half of the verse. Having concluded that one died for all, therefore all died.

2 Cor 5:15 **and He died for all, so that those who live would no longer live for themselves, but for Him who died and rose on their behalf.**

- It’s really simple. God sent His son to die for you so that you would never die. So that you would live eternally forever. And that reality should control you, so much so that you no longer live for yourself, but rather you live for Him. The One who came to earth, who lived and died and rose again on your behalf.
  - This is the Good News. The Gospel of Jesus Christ. And this is the only reason we live, move, and find our very being as believers on this earth. The question is, is this your reality? You see, for most of us, we find it difficult to live in this reality, because this world is always pulling at us, like gravity. The shiny things of life are always grabbing our attention. Distracting us from what matters.
    - Paul’s description of how he and the other Apostles live is exactly how we should live. This was not just a manifesto for their lives. It applies to us as well. Which means we must use what Paul says as a way of bringing us back in line when we get off track and lose our way.
    - And we do this by asking ourselves, is the reality of God’s love controlling my behavior? Is it controlling the way I look at life, the way I act and react, the way I look at my future on this planet? Or am I looking more like those at the church of Corinth, who have the appearance of being a Christian?

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- Moving on, in verses 16 & 17, Paul says this next:

2 Cor. 5:16 Therefore from now on we recognize no one by the flesh; even though we have known Christ by the flesh, yet now we know *Him in this way* no longer.
2 Cor. 5:17 Therefore if anyone is in Christ, *this person is* a new creation; the old things passed away; behold, new things have come.

- If you have been a believer for very long, Paul's words are probably not new to you. You've probably heard them your whole life. But, once again, even though you have heard them, do you believe them?
    - He says, if anyone is in Christ (if you are saved), this person is a new creation; the old things passed away; behold, new things have come, and in verse 16, I'm kind of going in reverse here, he says this is evidenced by the fact that they don't look at other believers in their earthly self.
        - Meaning, they don't look at them in fleshly form. They see them in their Godly form (as believers). Because, when a person is saved, they have become a new creation.
- Now, I want to close here this morning, but I am going to do so by asking you a simple yet profound question. Are you a New Creation, and is that evidenced by the fact that the old things of your life have passed away? Or are you riding both sides of the fence; one foot in the world and one foot out?
    - That's a question that is obviously something only you and God can know. It's none of my business or for that matter anyone else's business. It's between you and the Lord. But it's a fact that if you are saved, if you have surrendered your life to Christ, you are a New Creation and the old should be passed away.
    - And by the way, you can look at the old however you want to look at it, but the true definition for the old can be summed up with a simple statement: whatever you did before you were saved, things that were not of God, that were not holy or righteous, that weren't God-honoring; if you are still doing them then you have not put the old things away.
        - And this doesn't mean you're not saved; it simply means you are not living in the reality of what God did for you! Or maybe better said, you are not living in the reality of how much God loves you. Instead, you are still trying to live for you and not for Him.
- Now having said all of this, I would be remise if I didn't tell you, if you are a New Creation in Christ and you are still holding onto those old things, you should be convicted about it. If you're not convicted, that would be a problem.
    - Guys, it's impossible for us to stay on track if we don't grasp the concept of God's love, and that can only come by way of us looking back to what He did for us. A God-centered paradigm. Not looking forward, which is as I said, a me-centered paradigm.

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- Good morning, and welcome back to our journey through 2 Corinthians. When we last left off, we ended our teaching in the 5th Chapter of 2 Corinthians, specifically verses 11-17. In those verses Paul told the church at Corinth that, and I'm paraphrasing here, 'they' (He and the other Apostles) had a 'Fear of the Lord'.
    - It compelled them and motivated them to persuade others for the sake of the Gospel. Meaning, because of their mentality, how they understood who they were (more specifically), who they were in the sight of a Holy and Righteous God. Which was what?
    - Unclean, unholy, and unrighteous. Tainted or stained might be a better way to say it. Damaged goods. Flawed from birth. Because they knew who they were, it was that realization that evoked a fear inside of them about the reality of who God was and is. Which then caused them to do what? Be grateful. Grateful that God knew them and saved them.
- Which is exactly what Paul said in the middle of verse 11, when he said, 'but we are well known by God'. Essentially, Paul and the other Apostles were so cognitive and aware of who God was, and who they were in His sight. Which came by way of them understanding what it took for God to truly know them in an intimate way, which was only through the covering of the most innocent blood, that of God's Son Jesus Christ.
    - That it moved them, motivated them, and compelled them on a whole different level to share Christ with others. Because of this truth, a truth that resonated deep inside their very being, for that reason, they worked to persuade others, which also led Paul to say, the same reality of who they were, (they hoped), would also be known in this church's conscience as well.
        - Meaning, regardless of what the nay sayers might being saying inside their fellowship, Paul hoped that inside this church's heart, his hope was that they would know, deep down inside, that Paul and the other Apostles were who they said they were.
- Remember, part of the reason Paul wrote this letter was to combat the nay sayers; those who were saying that Paul and the others weren't authentic or real in their ministry, which was highlighted by what Paul himself said in verse 13, when he said that if they had lost their minds, it is for God; but if they were of sound mind, it is for them.
    - Obviously, based on Paul's words, someone or some group inside the church was saying they had lost their minds. Why else would Paul make such a statement? And so, we ended last week's teaching by studying verse 17:

2 Cor. 5:17 Therefore if anyone is in Christ, *this person is* a new creation; the old things passed away; behold, new things have come.

- I won't rehash all of what Paul said in verse 17, other than to say if you have been saved, if you have been convicted and answered the call of God with the affirmative and asked Him to forgive you of your sins (repented), the Bible says you are saved and now you are a new creation.
    - A new creation, and the old things are passed away; behold, new things have come. Which means if you have been saved and are still holding onto the old things, which are things you did when you were not saved, then something is wrong!

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- But having said that, let me say, I understand life happens (I get it). Life happens and maybe that's where you are. You are saved, but you are struggling to put the old away. If that's the case, then my advice is simple. Repent. Ask God to forgive you. Start over and get on the right track today; this morning and move forward as the New Creation that you are.
  - Don't worry about what was, or what happened before, simply hit the restart button by repenting, and according to 1 John 1:9, God will forgive you:

1 John 1:9 If we confess our sins, He is faithful and righteous, so that He will forgive us our sins and cleanse us from all unrighteousness.

- That is all you have to do folks. It's really that simple. Repent and begin again. Now, moving on this morning, we will pick back up with the last verses in Chapter 5, and move into Chapter 6. And this is what Paul says in 2 Cor. 5:18-21:

2 Cor. 5:18 Now all *these* things are from God, who reconciled us to Himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation,
2 Cor. 5:19 namely, that God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself, not counting their wrongdoings against them, and He has committed to us the word of reconciliation.
2 Cor. 5:20 Therefore, we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God were making an appeal through us; we beg you on behalf of Christ, be reconciled to God.
2 Cor. 5:21 He made Him who knew no sin *to be* sin in our behalf, so that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.

- Last week I didn't finish Chapter 5, because I wanted to make sure we had enough time to rightly divide these verses, because inside these verses lies a fundamental truth. A fundamental truth that I feel like most Christians never really grasp or comprehend. And this truth is so important. Let me try and explain it to you.
  - But before I do, let me preface it with something to all the atheist out there, and agnostics. Those who say if sin entered the world through Lucifer or Satan, and Lucifer resided in Heaven with God, if he were an angel in Heaven, wouldn't that mean that God allowed all this to happen? The answer is Yes.
    - You see, from the agnostic or atheistic standpoint this makes no sense, and from a purely pragmatic and logical standpoint, they would be correct. God did allow it to happen, and let me say, Satan's fall was no surprise to God.
  - Based on the book of Ezekiel, we know that God had already been planning for Satan's fall well before it happened. We just don't know why. And so, my response to the atheist or any other unbeliever is, so what! God is the Creator, and we are the created, and He can do what He wants to do when He wants to do it.
    - Therefore, what does it matter how it happened? All we need to remember is all that God is and all that Heaven is, coupled with all of God's ways, are not

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revealed to us! Which tells us that just because we don't understand it, it doesn't mean it didn't happen. And it doesn't mean God isn't working a plan, a plan that He hasn't revealed to us. One that we know nothing about.

- At the end of the day, we know from the pages of scriptures that there was a fall. We just don't know the why behind the fall. No one knows, because God didn't explain it to us, and I can't tell you why He didn't explain it. All I can say is He didn't.
  - But what I can also tell you is that God is the creator of the universe, and He didn't have to explain it to us. He owes us no explanation. He is the creator, and we are the created, and the created does not say to the creator, why did you make me this way?
  - And so, if you want to apply logic and pragmatism to any situation, this would be the place to do it! Because honestly, if you struggle with the "creator verses the created concept", I will tell you that you have a "pride issue", and you need to fully grasp the relationship between the creator and His creation.
- The Book of Ecclesiastes the 11th Chapter says it this way:

Eccl. 11:1 Cast your bread on the surface of the waters, for you will find it after many days.
Eccl. 11:2 Divide your portion to seven, or even to eight, for you do not know what misfortune may occur on the earth.
Eccl. 11:3 If the clouds are full, they pour out rain on the earth; and whether a tree falls toward the south or toward the north, wherever the tree falls, there it lies.
Eccl. 11:4 One who watches the wind will not sow and one who looks at the clouds will not harvest.
Eccl. 11:5 Just as you do not know the path of the wind, and how bones *are formed* in the womb of the pregnant woman, so you do not know the activity of God who makes everything.

- The writer of Ecclesiastes really sums it up best. God is the creator, and He allowed the fall to take place, and as a result, sin enter the world. But having said that, God didn't allow a problem to enter mankind without also providing a solution for the problem.
  - And, by the way, the solution or provision He provided for this problem wasn't just any ole solution. He actually remedied the problem by offering or providing the ultimate sacrifice. Now, I want to explore a concept, or a theory that I have, as it relates to this topic.
  - And what is my theory or concept? It is, if God created Satan, and if God allowed him to fall (which He did), and if God created mankind, and (once again) allowed sin to enter into humanity, and He also provided a provision or solution to mankind, then, by the magnitude of His provision or sacrifice we can know the severity of the problem of Sin.
    - In other words, through the magnitude of the solution, we can know just how bad the problem is. Let me say it another way. God allowed Sin to enter into this world, and we know it's terrible. It's a horrible reality.

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- But then, He provided a solution for this problem. The magnitude of that solution highlights just how bad sin truly is. It also highlights the fact that even though God allowed Sin to enter in, He offset that event by providing an even greater solution to that problem. Which tells us that He and He alone is in control of the whole thing, which is backed up by what Paul says next in Verse 18-19 (one more time):

2 Cor. 5:18 Now all *these* things are from God, who reconciled us to Himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation,
2 Cor. 5:19 namely, that God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself, not counting their wrongdoings against them, and He has committed to us the word of reconciliation.

- What Paul's saying in these verses is, yes sin entered into this world, and yes, God allowed it. But He also reconciled us back to Himself, through Christ Jesus, His only begotten Son. And there could have been no greater Sacrifice for God to give us, which tells us something.
  - It tells us that we are all victims of something we have no control over, and God knew that, so He provided a solution to the sin that plagues us. And, once again, the magnitude of that sacrifice lets us know just how bad the "sin" of the world truly is.
    - But back to the deeper question. Why did He allow all this to happen? My answer is NO CLUE. All I can tell you about this is number 1 - It really doesn't matter why. It doesn't because God has His reasons, and you can lay your head down tonight knowing that whatever the reason was, or is; whatever the reason, it has purpose and meaning.
    - Number 2 - Regardless of the reason, He has also provided an offsetting solution for this problem. And number 3 - Maybe we will find out the why one day when we get to Heaven, but honestly, I don't think we are even going to care.
  - And let me highlight one more important theme or thought about theses verses, and that is (once again), the Sovereignty of God is behind all of this. God is in control of everything!
- Look at what I am saying. God is front and center. He is the one allowing sin to enter in and He is the one reconciling man back to Himself. Which tells us something, and that is, contrary to popular belief, man is not the center of the universe. You and I have zero to do with anything.
- Listen to Paul one more time, and I want you to count how many times God is doing something versus man doing something.

2 Cor. 5:18 Now all *these* things are from God (1), who reconciled us to Himself (2) through Christ and gave us (3) the ministry of reconciliation,
2 Cor. 5:19 namely, that God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself (4), not counting their wrongdoings against them (5), and He has committed to us (6) the word of reconciliation.

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- Based on my math, it's God 6 & Man 0 as it relates to who is doing what. Guys, this is so important for us to understand. God is Sovereign and in Control of all things, and He either A) allows things to happen or B) He causes it to happen, and it's all for His ultimate Purpose and Glory. Now moving on, back to the end of Chapter 5 - verses 20-21:

2 Cor. 5:20 **Therefore, we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God were making an appeal through us; we beg you on behalf of Christ, be reconciled to God.**
2 Cor. 5:21 **He made Him who knew no sin *to be* sin in our behalf, so that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.**

- These last two verses tell us a few things. In particular they tell us that Paul and the other Apostles are Ambassadors for Christ, and as Ambassadors, God is making His appeal to other men through them. And therefore, he says, we beg you on behalf of Christ, be reconciled to God.
    - In other words, Paul is saying we are God's living testimony, and God is making an appeal through us to you. By the way, the same holds true for you and me. If you are a believer, God's desire is to make an appeal to others through you. The question is, how's that going? This is what I call a reflective question.
    - Are you working to become an instrument of God, so that He can make an appeal through you to the world, or are you just here, kind of just getting by? Maybe a better question is, do you want God to make an appeal through you to others? Do you want Him to use you as an instrument? Or would you say - I'm good?
        - The hope would be the first rather than the latter, and if that's true, but it's not really happening in your Christian life, then just as Paul urged this church, do something about it!
        - Repent and ask God to begin a new work in you.
- Finally, Paul gives us the why, as in why he is an ambassador for Christ, and it's because He sent Jesus to be sin, even though He knew no sin. All so that we (all of us) might become the righteousness of God in Him.
    - Another way to say it is, so that we might be cleaned up, so that God might have a relationship with us, so that He would be able to commune with us. And once again, that is the Gospel of Jesus Christ.
        - Next, we move into Chapter 6 verses 1-10, where Paul says the following. We are not going to complete the study of all these verses today, but we will get through a few of them.

2 Cor. 6:1 **And working together *with Him,* we also urge you not to receive the grace of God in vain—**
2 Cor. 6:2 **for He says,**
"AT A FAVORABLE TIME I LISTENED TO YOU,
AND ON A DAY OF SALVATION I HELPED YOU."
Behold, now is "A FAVORABLE TIME," behold, now is "A DAY OF SALVATION"—

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2 Cor. 6:3 giving no reason for *taking* offense in anything, so that the ministry will not be discredited,
2 Cor. 6:4 but in everything commending ourselves as servants of God, in much endurance, in afflictions, in hardships, in difficulties,
2 Cor. 6:5 in beatings, in imprisonments, in mob attacks, in labors, in sleeplessness, in hunger,
2 Cor. 6:6 in purity, in knowledge, in patience, in kindness, in the Holy Spirit, in genuine love,
2 Cor. 6:7 in the word of truth, *and* in the power of God; by the weapons of righteousness for the right hand and the left,
2 Cor. 6:8 by glory and dishonor, by evil report and good report; *regarded* as deceivers and yet true;
2 Cor. 6:9 as unknown and *yet* well known, as dying and *yet* behold, we are alive; as punished and *yet* not put to death,
2 Cor. 6:10 as sorrowful yet always rejoicing, as poor yet making many rich, as having nothing and *yet* possessing all things.

- As usual, there is a whole lot being said here, and Paul starts out with a continuation of his defense of who he and the other Apostles are, and he does this by making the statement in verse 1, which is, “And working together with Him”.
    - Once again, Paul is driving home the point that he and the others are Apostles of Jesus Christ. And honestly, it’s ridiculous to think that the greatest writer of the New Testament, the greatest evangelist and Apostle that ever lived, has to defend himself, especially to a church he founded.
        - But he does, and that’s why he says that he is working hand in hand with God. But then in the second half of the verse he says something we all need to think about. He says, “we also urge you not to receive the grace of God in vain “.
- I want to pause here for just a minute, because it’s important we understand just exactly what Paul is saying. What does it mean to receive God’s grace in vain? And more specifically, what Grace is he talking about?
    - Well, first of all, it’s clear from what he says in the next verse that he is speaking specifically about Salvation, which tells us two things:
        - First, it tells us that he is writing this letter to believers (which we knew to be the case since the letter is addressed to the Church at Corinth). But having said that and based on the way this body of believers is acting, there is some question whether or not they were truly saved. But Paul’s statement pretty much clears that up.
        - Secondly, this verse tells us that it is possible for us to become so comfortable and so familiar with the Salvation that God has bestowed upon us, that we take it for granted (in vain); almost treating it as if we are entitled to it in some way. Which is an interesting thought, and it may be one you are familiar with.
- God saved us, and on the day of our Salvation we should have been full of gratitude and appreciation. But over time, that memory may have faded, leaving us in a place of

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apathy. Meaning, leaving us in a place where we slowly lack interest, enthusiasm or concern about the position God has placed us in.

- Another way to say it is, we began taking it for granted, or as Paul says, in vain. Now, I know this seems like a simple statement, but it's important for us to understand what Paul is saying. We should never get to a place in our walk with God that we take God's grace in vain.
- But it happens, and it happens because we are human. This may not seem like a big deal per se, but it's much more consequential than you may think. You see, once you are saved, you cross over and you become a new Creation, just as Paul told us back in Chapter 5.
  - And as a New Creation, you have a responsibility to grow spiritually, become more and more like Christ, for the purposes of becoming a useful instrument of God. And why is this the case? Because this is God's method for reaching other people. God uses you to reach other men, women and children.
- Which means you are a part of the Work of the Ministry. Which means if you are a believer, you are in full-time ministry. It's not just the preachers that are in full-time ministry. That responsibility also falls squarely on every believer's shoulders. The problem is, if you lose your sense of 'gratitude or thankfulness', as it relates to your salvation, you run a 'great risk' of doing more damage for the Kingdom than you do good.
  - And why is that? Because you develop a sort of 'Spiritual Arrogance', which is derived by taking your salvation in vain. Meaning, you become almost arrogant about it, but not in the way we might think of arrogance. It's more like an arrogance that you can't feel or see in yourself, but everyone around you can see it, especially non-believers.
  - And so, Paul's instructions to this church, to these believers, is don't take for granted the salvation that God so graciously gives you. Now, in light of these statements, here's the question we should be asking ourselves.
- Are we going about our lives, taking our salvation for granted, or are we operating from a basis of 'gratitude and thankfulness as it relates to the grace God has given us? You see, this particular spiritual problem is really dangerous. It's much like a disease, because it creeps in on you without you ever really knowing it's there. Leaving you blind to it. But unbelievers can see it.
  - And they correlate our arrogance with that of spiritual arrogance, and unless we are confronted with it, we are in danger of walking around in spiritual ignorance. Doing more damage to the Kingdom than we do good. Leaving the world calling us 'Hypocrites'.

- And so, the million-dollar question we need to be asking ourselves this morning is, what are we doing to prevent this from happening? More specifically, how do we prevent it? How do we stay in a constant state, or at least a consistent state, of thankfulness?
  - We do it through developing and or cultivating our relationship with Him, which comes by way of prayer and the study and ingestion of God's Word on a daily basis. Through prayer we enter a communing process, and through the study of God's Word we get to know Him more intimately.
  - The process is simple. By studying and reading God's memoirs, we draw near to Him

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because His Word is Him in Word form. And so, the only defense we have from becoming arrogant or vain about our salvation is through developing a deeper relationship with Him. Because when we study (and study correctly, I might add), which is what? Studying in context. When we do that, we become humble, and that humility is the only defense we have from becoming vain.

- That is one of the most powerful messages for us to consider this morning. As I always tell you, the world is watching. When we put on the jersey, the banner of Christianity, the world watches and they watch closely. You could say our lives are now under a microscope, and for that reason we can never take God's Grace in vain.
- Think about that as you move about your life this week. Ask yourself the question, have I taken my salvation for granted? And as a result, have I become vain, leaving a bad taste to the unbelieving world around me? Next week our study verses for the week will be 2 Corinthians 6:2-10. So, study ahead this week and see if next week's teaching might be a little more impactful in your life.

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- This morning, we return to the book or the letter of 2 Corinthians. When we last left off, we only made it through verse 1 of Chapter 6. So, as I often do, I want to back up and re-read the previous verse, or verses, as a segway into today's teaching.
    - And here's what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 6:1 **And working together *with Him,* we also urge you not to receive the grace of God in vain.**

- Last time we were together, we talked specifically about what it meant to 'Receive the Grace of God in vain', and without going back over all of what was said, the core of what Paul meant was we should never take for granted the Salvation that God has given us. And we all know this to be the case, but the question is, why? Why does it happen?
    - It happens when our memory fades, when we begin to just go through the motions of church. More specifically, when we fail to do our part; essentially fail to do the work of the ministry. Fail to pray every day, fail to study on our own (And by the way, devotionals will not substitute for your own study of God's word). Devotionals are okay for a fill-in, problem is, devotionals do not contain the power to bring salvation or sanctification into someone's life. Only God's Word can do that.
    - Nothing wrong with reading a devotional, as long as you know the author is a solid bible teacher. But even at that, it's supplemental to your time spent in God's word. And so, when our Spiritual Disciplines begin to wane, when you fail to pray and study correctly on your own, you find yourself in a place where you take your salvation in vain. It's just that simple.
    - You can't make a profession of faith (join the team), and never participate. Christianity is a team sport, and it requires your involvement. And so, Paul says never take the grace of God in vain. And then he says, moving into verse 2:

2 Cor. 6:2 **for He says,**
"AT A FAVORABLE TIME, I LISTENED TO YOU,
AND ON A DAY OF SALVATION, I HELPED YOU."
Behold, now is "A FAVORABLE TIME," behold, now is "A DAY OF SALVATION".

- As with most of what Paul wrote, he wrote with a sense of urgency, especially as it related to salvation, because he knew time was running out.
    - And so, he recites a quote from Isaiah 49:8 in an effort to stress the importance of responding immediately. He says, at a 'favorable time' I listened to you, and on a day of salvation I helped you, and behold, now is 'a favorable time'. Behold, now is 'a day of salvation'.
    - In the context of the prophet Isaiah's quote, God was addressing His servant Isaiah (whom the nations despised). God was making a promise through Isaiah, promising an eventual vindication and urging him to restore his people.
        - The parallel of Paul's quote of Isaiah and the Corinthian Church's ministry is obvious. Rather than squabbling among themselves over Paul, the readers

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needed to get on with the work that God had given them to do. Which then leads Paul to say this in verse 3. And let me say, verse 3 really ties back to verse 1 as it relates to becoming vain in our salvation. This is what he said:

2 Cor. 6:3 giving no reason for *taking* offense in anything, so that the ministry will not be discredited,

- What Paul was saying to this church (and by extension to the church of today) was, be cognitive and aware of your actions. People are watching! Give no reason for anyone to take offense in anything you do, so that the ministry will not be discredited.
  - This concept is a simple one, yet it seems to be one that Christians of today seem to ignore or completely miss altogether, and that is, we can cause people to stumble through our witness. As I have told you many times, our witness is not simply what we say, but how we act.
    - Paul said, never give any cause for others to stumble. That's what he means when he says, 'giving no reason for taking offense in anything'. And why? Because they didn't want their ministry to be discredited.
  - Now obviously, we cannot prevent all criticism of our ministry, because there will always be some who take offense without good reason. But regardless, we should always do everything we can to make sure that we do not give anyone cause for justifiable criticism.
- Let me say, I believe Paul's words are more applicable today. Maybe more than they have ever been. You see, in so many ways, most of which they don't even think about, the church has completely absolved itself of any responsibility of offending the outside world. Meaning, Christians today very rarely think about their actions as it relates to having an effect on the outside world.
  - And what's interesting is, the offensiveness of the Church is often directly related back to what Paul said in verse 1. Which was what?
  - "Taking the grace of God in vain". In other words, when we begin taking God's grace for granted. Which is what? Taking for granted what God has done for you, it automatically causes something to begin to well up inside an individual; a thing called pride.
    - One precipitates the other. Pride is the opposite of humility, and humility is what takes hold when we don't take God's grace for granted. The increasing or decreasing of humility all revolves around your daily discipline of prayer and spending time in God's word. I digress, but you get the point. Moving on.
- Next, Paul gives us some insight into what it's like to be a part of the original prosperity gospel. If you don't know what the prosperity gospel is, it's the gospel that says if you join God's team, if you make a profession of faith, your life will prosper in every way. Mainly, earthly ways, especially financially.
  - Now when I say this is the original prosperity gospel, you guys probably think I am joking. I'm actually not. In these verses you will read about the prosperity gospel, but it's prosperity according to God's word, brought to us through the eyes of Paul. It's still prosperity; just not the way many of today's Churches describe it.

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- Let's see what Paul says about his and the other's lives as Apostles as it relates to their prosperity. We begin with verse 4-9:

2 Cor. 6:4 but in everything commending ourselves as servants of God, (so they are servants of God),

- He says - But in everything commending ourselves as servants of God in much endurance, in afflictions, in hardships, in difficulties,

2 Cor. 6:5 in beatings, in imprisonments, in mob attacks, in labors, in sleeplessness, in hunger,
2 Cor. 6:6 in purity, in knowledge, in patience, in kindness, in the Holy Spirit, in genuine love,
2 Cor. 6:7 in the word of truth, *and* in the power of God; by the weapons of righteousness for the right hand and the left,
2 Cor. 6:8 by glory and dishonor, by evil report and good report; *regarded* as deceivers and yet true;
2 Cor. 6:9 as unknown and *yet* well known, as dying and *yet* behold, we are alive; as punished and *yet* not put to death,
2 Cor. 6:10 as sorrowful yet always rejoicing, as poor yet making many rich, as having nothing and *yet* possessing all things.

- Once again, a whole lot being said here, and a whole lot being relayed to you and me. Paul says, we commend ourselves as servants of God in much.
  - Endurance
  - Afflictions,
  - Hardships,
  - Difficulties,
  - Sleeplessness,
  - And hunger
    - Paul says they commend themselves in much endurance. The word endurance here by the way, is the Greek word hupnmone (hoop-om-on-ay). Its usage would be that of endurance, steadfastness, patiently-waiting for.
  - 5281 *hypomoné* (from 5259 */hypó*, "under" and 3306 */ménō*, "remain, endure") – properly, *remaining under*, endurance; steadfastness, especially as *God enables* the believer to "*remain* (*endure*) *under*" the challenges He allots in life.
- What Paul is saying is that God gives them the strength to endure, to wait, to endure the challenges of life. And because they endure (because no one could endure what they have endured without the strength of God), they stand as proof of, or in line with, God.
  - In other words, because of what we have endured, and the fact that they are still

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standing firm in their faith, still servants of God, this alone is proof that they are who they say they are. And this is interesting when you stop to think about it, especially in light of how the church of today or Christians of today view their faith. Follow me here for just a minute.

- Today, when something good happens to us, most of us say praise the Lord or we are so blessed, but when something bad happens what do we usually say? O no! O my! That's so bad. I'm sorry. Let's pray. Let's ask God to fix it.

- But according to Paul's own words, it's the trials of life that bring the greatest testimony. Not prosperity as the world views prosperity. As believers we still receive prosperity, but it's a different type of prosperity. It's God's prosperity. It's a prosperity that comes from within. From knowing that you are Serving Him, and despite all circumstances, and let me say, I don't know of one place in scripture where something 'good' happens; worldly good; possessions or stuff; and that event or situation is tied directly to a positive testimony or witness for God.
  - Based on what many churches are teaching today, you would think that would be the case, but it's actually the opposite of that, which is not surprising, because with God it's always right the opposite of what we think. God's own word proves that point. For example, in His own words.
  - The First will be last and the last will be first, and the greatest of these on earth will be least of these in Heaven. It's all reversed, and we see it here once again in Paul's writing. They endure because God makes them endure, and all for the sake of the testimony or the witness they project.

- Now in light of this information, I think this should cause us to pause and reflect. Pause and reflect and ask ourselves the question, 'does our life in any way resemble what Paul is trying to convey'? In other words, would the world look at us today and say, 'wow, look at all that you have endured, and in spite of all that they are still standing with God?
  - You see, this is the powerful testimony that Paul and the other Apostles conveyed to the world, and in some respects, it's the most powerful testimony they could convey. The difficulties of life that you and I endure deliver our greatest testimony to the world around us.
    - And so, when we look at Paul's own life and his testimony to this Church, we would say the greater the difficulty, hardship, trial, and pain, the greater the testimony. And just exactly how bad was their hardship, trial, and pain?
  - Well, let's look one more time.
    - Sleeplessness
    - Hunger
    - Beatings
    - Imprisonment
    - Mob Attacks
    - Labor
  - Pretty bad, isn't it? But what's interesting is after Paul describes their hardships and difficulties, he immediately shifts gears and says not only are we servants of God in the bad things, but we also are servants of God in the good things as well. As a

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matter of fact, these bad things have precipitated (given way to) these good things. Look at what he says, starting with verse 4 and moving forward into verse 6 one more time.

2 Cor. 6:4 but in everything commending ourselves as servants of God,
2 Cor. 6:5 in beatings, in imprisonments, in mob attacks, in labors, in sleeplessness, in hunger,

- And then the shift, where he says,

2 Cor. 6:6 in purity, in knowledge, in patience, in kindness, in the Holy Spirit, in genuine love,
2 Cor. 6:7 in the word of truth, *and* in the power of God; by the weapons of righteousness for the right hand and the left,

- Verse 5 gives us what we would consider the bad stuff. All that they have endured. But after mentioning the bad stuff, straight away, he shifts and says this in Verse 6,

2 Cor. 6:6 in purity, in knowledge, in patience, in kindness, in the Holy Spirit, in genuine love,
2 Cor. 6:7 in the word of truth, *and* in the power of God; by the weapons of righteousness for the right hand and the left,

- In other words, in all things we still stand as servants of God. In how we are treated and in how we respond. Even in our purity, our moral standing, our knowledge; specifically, our understanding of God (who He is) (His plans for creation, which includes us and our lives), even in our patience, we are patient because of Him and because of all we have endured.
  - And in our kindness. This kindness reflects a generous and sympathetic disposition, and it manifests itself in good deeds or actions. And then he says, all this is manifest through and by the Holy Spirit. And finally, he mentions two words - genuine love. In genuine love. What is genuine love?
  - It's a love that is not:
    - 505 *anypókritos* (an adjective, derived from alpha-privative 1 */A* "not" and 5271 */hypokrínomai*, "to act as a hypocrite") – properly, *not a phony* ("put on"), it's sincere - and free from hidden agendas (selfish motives) – literally, "without *hypocrisy*" (unfeigned).
  - Another way to say it would be, in all things, whether bad or good, we are true blue and pure servants of God. And, what a message for all Christian men and women listening today. If you are saved, then grow and mature in Him so that you can be more than just a Christian in name only. Grow and mature so that you don't discredit God's ministry.

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- And then finally, Paul says something that might seem insignificant, but it kind of binds all this together, and that is they are genuine in the word of truth, and in the power of God, by the weapons of righteousness for the right hand and the left. A reference to “The word of truth” here is more than likely a reference to truthful speech, or perhaps the message of truth.
    - Meaning, the message they are bringing, which is obviously everything they speak about, but certainly the Gospel of Jesus Christ. In other words, Paul is letting this church know through this letter that when he speaks, he speaks in truth.
    - By the way, you can still sense the frustration in Paul’s words. Of him having to continue his defense of himself and the other Apostles. To get a better understanding of what he is saying, it’s kind of like telling someone the truth, but you sense they don’t believe you. Have you ever had that happen?
        - Well, that would be the sense of what he is saying, and there is nothing more frustrating than speaking truth and the people you are speaking it to act as if they don’t believe you. Which is particularly true in Paul’s case, where he is speaking truth to a church he founded. A church he hasn’t visited for a while, and now he finds himself in the position of having to defend himself. That would be pretty frustrating.
        - Next, after saying they are servants in the word of truth, he mentions the “power of God by the weapons of righteousness for the right hand and the left”. Dr. Thomas Constable describes Paul’s reference to the power of God along with these weapons of righteousness for the right hand and the left in this way. He stated the following:
    - Paul described some of the conditions under which he ministered and some of the methods he used.
        - Weapons may refer to the sword of the Spirit (the Word of God) and the shield of faith (cf. Rom. 6:13; Eph. 6:11-17; 1 Thess. 5:8). The right hand normally attacked with a sword, and the left hand defended with a shield. However, these are weapons of righteousness, which are the spiritual weapons that God supplies.
- Having said that, another possibility, which is not necessarily mutually exclusive, is that weapons of righteousness may refer to the weapons that come from doing right, personal integrity. Righteousness often refers to right conduct in the New Testament. The right hand and the left may then be a figurative expression (merism) for all acts.
    - Matthew Henry suggested that temptations on the right might refer to prosperity, and temptations on the left to adversity.[291]. He said, "We stand in need of the grace of God to arm us against the temptations of honor on the one hand, so as to bear good report without pride, and of dishonor on the other hand, so as to bear reproaches without recrimination."
    - Before moving on, I would like to mention at least two things about verse 7. Number 1 - if you are a believer, you have access to the power of God through the Holy Spirit that lives inside you. This may seem cliché, and the term has been somewhat hijacked by many in the charismatic movement.
        - So often, the term has been used as if there is some ‘superpower’ the Christian can access, and although it is supernatural, it’s not something you summon supernaturally. In other words, it’s not hidden, just waiting for you to learn how

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to access the power. For all you Star Wars fans, it's not like learning how to harness the force.

- The power that God gives us comes through the knowledge and understanding of Him, which then gives way to confidence. A confidence that then gives us a "Peace that Passes all Understanding". And they only way you can access that confidence is by intimately knowing Him. Specifically knowing that He has got you. That He is with you. That no matter what, good or bad, God is working all things to His Glory.

- I love the way the Psalmist says it in the 23rd Psalm

A Psalm of David.

Psalm 23:1 The LORD is my shepherd,
I shall not want.
Psalm 23:2 He makes me lie down in green pastures;
He leads me beside quiet waters.
Psalm 23:3 He restores my soul;
He guides me in the paths of righteousness
For His name's sake.
Psalm 23:4 Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death,
I fear no evil, for You are with me;
Your rod and Your staff, they comfort me.
Psalm 23:5 You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies;
You have anointed my head with oil;
My cup overflows.
Psalm 23:6 Surely goodness and loving kindness will follow me all the days of my life,
And I will dwell in the house of the LORD forever.

- King David eloquently describes what is the true Power of God. These words personify the very essence of what I Paul is trying to convey, and that is, God is totally Sovereign and in control of everything. Which includes your life and all the circumstances surrounding it. There simply cannot be a greater power than the power that comes from knowing. Knowing that the creator of the universe has got you!
  - That applies whether you can see what's happening or not.
    - Now, I am not saying there aren't other intangibles that apply to the power of God, but they all manifest themselves through the knowledge and understanding of who He is and where you stand with Him. And as previously stated, when all this comes full circle in your life, it yields confidence.
- Moving on, Paul finishes this section with verses 8-10, and here is what he said:

2 Cor. 6:8 by glory and dishonor, by evil report and good report; *regarded* as deceivers and yet true;

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2 Cor. 6:9 as unknown yet well-known, as dying yet behold, we live; as punished yet not put to death,
2 Cor. 6:10 as sorrowful yet always rejoicing, as poor yet making many rich, as having nothing yet possessing all things.

- Once again, Paul continues contrasting words and situations and circumstances as it relates to their commitment to God, as servants of the Lord. He says,
  - By Glory and Dishonor
  - By Evil report and Good Report
  - Regarded as deceivers and yet true
  - As unknown yet well-known
  - As dying yet behold, we live as punished yet not put to death
  - As sorrowful yet always rejoicing
  - As poor yet making many rich
  - As having nothing yet possessing all things
- Now, I am going to close here this morning, but before I do I want to clarify part of what Paul is saying. When Paul says by glory and dishonor, or by evil report and good report, he is simply saying, regardless of what's being said and regardless of human opinion, whether good or bad, we stand as servants of God.
  - And we are who we say we are! And no matter our situation, we remain. Which once again, is a great word for us to hear and understand. Our faith should never waiver, or blow in the wind, no matter our plight. We must stand on what we know to be true, and once again, you can't do that unless you are confident.
    - One of my primary jobs as a 'Pastor Teacher' is to help eliminate the confusion in the mind of the believer, and I would tell you that this has never been needed more than it is today for the Church of the 21st century. For the most part, most people who claim to be Christian don't not know what they believe. They just simply are. They're here, and in many cases, their faith is nothing more than a footnote. A 'good idea'.
    - But it has no roots, no depth. The picture that Paul paints here is a picture we must embrace, and the question for the day is, how do we get to this place? To a place in which we say whether rich or poor, good or bad, sickness or good health, death or life, God you are my rock and my refuge. You are my provider.
  - And yea, though I walk through the Valley of the Shadow of Death, I will fear no evil. For thy rod and they staff they comfort me!
  - Knowledge - Knowledge - Understanding - Understanding
- Which leads to confidence, and this all comes by way of knowing God more intimately through His Word. This is the essence of what Paul is relaying in these verses, and his message, and supposed to be our message is, we are servants of God, and we stand no matter our circumstances or situations.
  - Amen.

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- Next week, I will touch a little bit more on these same verses, more specifically as it relates to clearing up Paul's confusing contrast of words, where he says, deceivers and yet true.

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- Alright guys, welcome back this morning and good to see everyone. Last week we finished our teaching by studying 2 Corinthians 6, specifically verses 2-10. And in those verses, we learned a little bit about what I called the original “Prosperity Gospel”, or maybe better entitled - The “Prosperity Gospel according to Paul”.
    - And what was it that we learned about the “Prosperity Gospel” according to Paul? We learned that prosperity, as defined by Paul, is very much right the opposite of what many churches and preachers of today define as the Prosperity Gospel.
    - And why is that? Well, specifically when speaking about prosperity, today’s preachers talk in terms of the here in and now - things we can obtain while living on this planet (especially money).
        - Paul, on the other hand, used different language when describing prosperity, or as he called it, “gain”, when talking about Christ. Listen to just a little bit of what he said in Philippians 3:7-11 about his topic:

Phil 3:7 **But whatever things were gain to me, these things I have counted as loss because of Christ.**
Phil 3:8 **More than that, I count all things to be loss in view of the surpassing value of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord, for whom I have suffered the loss of all things, and count them *mere* rubbish, so that I may gain Christ,**
Phil 3:9 **and may be found in Him, not having a righteousness of my own derived from *the* Law, but that which is through faith in Christ, the righteousness which *comes* from God on the basis of faith,**
Phil 3:10 **that I may know Him and the power of His resurrection and the fellowship of His sufferings, being conformed to His death;**
Phil 3:11 **if somehow I may attain to the resurrection from the dead.**

- Such powerful language is being used here. Paul says, and I am paraphrasing here, “I must lose the temporal, to gain the eternal. Whatever I gain here, I count it as loss in view of the value of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord”.
    - And then in verse 10 he says,

Phil 3:10 **that I may know Him and the power of His resurrection and the fellowship of His sufferings, being conformed to His death;**

- The fellowship of His sufferings. What is that?
    - It’s the concept of our suffering on earth and creates connectivity between us and Jesus and His suffering on the cross. And this is not the only place Paul speaks in these terms, which is why Paul uses words like beatings, imprisonment, hunger, sleeplessness, mob-attacks, and labor, and then turns around and connects those experiences to things such as their personal development and growth as it relates to their relationship with God.
        - Now the question for me as it relates to the Bible’s definition of prosperity

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verses the Church of today's version of prosperity, is how in the world did it get so twisted around? How did it get to a place of such opposite extremes?

- Well, I did a little research on the topic, and I want to share it with you this morning. We will call this segment the evolution of Prosperity Gospel or Prosperity Movement, and I want you to listen closely as I try and chronicle the history and evolution of of this movement. It's going to be a little lengthy, but I hope you get a lot out of it.
    - According to historian Kate Bowler, the prosperity gospel was formed from the intersection of three different ideologies: Pentecostalism, New Thought, and "an American gospel of pragmatism, individualism, and upward mobility".
    - This "American gospel" was best exemplified by Andrew Carnegie's Gospel of Wealth and Russell Conwell's famous sermon "Acres of Diamonds", in which Conwell equated poverty with sin and asserted that anyone could become rich through hard work.
        - This gospel of wealth, however, was an expression of Muscular Christianity and understood success to be the result of personal effort rather than divine intervention.
    - The New Thought movement, which emerged in the 1880s, was responsible for popularizing belief in the power of the mind to achieve prosperity.
    - While initially focused on achieving mental and physical health, New Thought teachers such as Charles Fillmore made material success a major emphasis of the movement.
        - By the 20th century, New Thought concepts had saturated American popular culture, being common features of both self-help literature and popular psychology.
- E. W. Kenyon, a Baptist minister and adherent of the Higher Life movement, is credited with introducing mind-power teachings into early Pentecostalism.
    - In the 1890s, Kenyon attended Emerson College of Oratory where he was exposed to the New Thought movement. Kenyon later became connected with well-known Pentecostal leaders and wrote about supernatural revelation and positive declarations. His writing influenced leaders of the nascent prosperity movement during the post-war American healing revival.
    - Kenyon and later leaders in the prosperity movement have denied that he was influenced by the New Thought movement.
        - Anthropologist Simon Coleman argues that there are "obvious parallels" between Kenyon's teachings and New Thought.
    - Kenyon taught that Christ's substitutionary atonement secured for believers a right to divine healing.
        - This was attained through positive, faith-filled speech; the spoken word of God allowed believers to appropriate the same spiritual power that God used to create the world and attain the provisions promised in Christ's death and resurrection.
        - Prayer was understood to be a binding, legal act. Rather than asking, Kenyon taught believers to demand healing since they were already legally entitled to

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receive it.

- Kenyon's blend of evangelical religion and mind-power beliefs—what he termed "overcoming faith"—resonated with a small but influential segment of the Pentecostal movement.
  - Pentecostals had always been committed to faith healing, and the movement also possessed a strong belief in the power of speech (in particular speaking in tongues and the use of the names of God, especially the name of Jesus).
  - Kenyon's ideas would be reflected in the teachings of Pentecostal evangelists F. F. Bosworth and John G. Lake (who co-led a congregation with New Thought author Albert C. Grier prior to 1915).

- Post 1945 Healing Revivals
  - While Kenyon's teachings on overcoming faith laid the groundwork for the prosperity gospel, the first generation of Pentecostals influenced by him and other figures, such as Bosworth, did not view faith as a means to attain material prosperity.
    - In fact, early Pentecostals tended to view prosperity as a threat to a person's spiritual well-being.
  - By the 1940s and 1950s, however, a recognizable form of the doctrine began to take shape within the Pentecostal movement through the teachings of deliverance and healing evangelists.
    - Combining prosperity teaching with revivalism and faith healing, these evangelists taught "the laws of faith ('ask and ye shall receive') and the laws of divine reciprocity ('give and it will be given back unto you')".
  - Oral Roberts began teaching prosperity theology in 1947.
  - He explained the laws of faith as a "blessing pact" in which God would return donations "seven fold",
    - He promised donors would receive back from unexpected sources the money they donated to him. Roberts offered to return any donation that did not lead to an equivalent unexpected payment.
  - In the 1970s, Roberts characterized his blessing pact teaching as the "seed faith" doctrine: donations were a form of "seed" which would grow in value and be returned to the donor.
    - Roberts began recruiting "partners", wealthy donors who received exclusive conference invitations and ministry access in exchange for support.
- In 1953, faith healer A. A. Allen published *The Secret to Scriptural Financial Success* and promoted merchandise such as "miracle tent shavings" and prayer cloths anointed with "miracle oil".
  - In the late 1950s, Allen increasingly focused on prosperity. He taught that faith could miraculously solve financial problems and claimed to have had a miraculous experience in which God supernaturally changed one-dollar bills into twenty-dollar bills to allow him to pay his debts.
  - Allen also taught a concept called the "word of faith" or the power to speak

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something into being.

- In the 1960s, prosperity became a primary focus in healing revivals.
  - T. L. Osborn began emphasizing prosperity in the 1960s and became known for his often ostentatious displays of personal wealth.
  - During that decade, Roberts and William Branham criticized other prosperity ministries, arguing that their fund-raising tactics unfairly pressured attendees.
    - These tactics were prompted in part by the expense of developing nationwide radio networks and campaign schedules.
  - At the same time, leaders of the Pentecostal Assemblies of God denomination often criticized the focus on prosperity taken by independent healing evangelists.
- Televangelism
  - During the 1960s, prosperity gospel teachers embraced televangelism and came to dominate religious programming in the United States.
  - Oral Roberts was among the first, developing a syndicated weekly program that became the most watched religious show in the United States. By 1968, television had supplanted the tent meeting in his ministry.
    - Reverend Ike, a pastor from New York City, began preaching about prosperity in the late 1960s.
    - He soon had widely aired radio and television programs and became distinguished for his flashy style.
    - His openness about love for material possessions and teachings about the "Science of the Mind" led many evangelists to distance themselves from him.
  - In the 1980s, public attention in the United States was drawn to prosperity theology through the influence of prominent televangelists such as Jim Bakker. Bakker's influence waned, however, after he was implicated in a high-profile scandal. In the aftermath, Trinity Broadcasting Network (TBN) emerged as the dominant force in prosperity televangelism, having brought Robert Tilton and Benny Hinn to prominence.
- Word of Faith
  - Although nearly all of the healing evangelists of the 1940s and 1950s taught that faith could bring financial rewards, a new prosperity-oriented teaching developed in the 1970s that differed from the one taught by Pentecostal evangelists of the 1950s.
    - This "Positive Confession" or "Word of Faith" movement taught that a Christian with faith can speak into existence anything consistent with the will of God.
  - Kenneth Hagin was credited with a key role in the expansion of prosperity theology. He founded the RHEMA Bible Training Center in 1974, and over the next 20 years, the school trained more than 10,000 students in his theology.
    - As is true of other prosperity movements, there is no theological governing body for the Word of Faith movement, and well-known ministries differ on some theological issues, though many ministries are unofficially linked.
    - The teachings of Kenneth Hagin have been described by Candy Gunther Brown of Indiana University as the most "orthodox" form of Word of Faith prosperity

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teaching.

- International growth
  - By the late 2000s, proponents claimed that tens of millions of Christians had accepted prosperity theology.
    - The neo-Pentecostal movement has been characterized in part by an emphasis on prosperity theology, which gained greater acceptance within charismatic Christianity during the late 1990s.
    - In the 2000s, Evangelical-Pentecostal churches teaching prosperity theology saw significant growth in the Global South and Third World countries.
    - According to Philip Jenkins of Pennsylvania State University, poor citizens of impoverished countries often find the doctrine appealing because of their economic powerlessness and the doctrine's emphasis on miracles.
  - One region seeing explosive growth is Western Africa, particularly Nigeria.
  - In the Philippines, the El Shaddai movement, part of the Catholic Charismatic Renewal, has spread prosperity theology outside Protestant Christianity. One South Korean prosperity church, Yoido Full Gospel Church, gained attention in the 1990s by claiming to be the world's largest congregation.
    - A 2006 poll by *Time* reported that 17 percent of Christians in America said they identified with the movement.
- By the 2000s, adherents of prosperity theology in the United States were most common in the Sun Belt.
  - By 2006, three of the four largest congregations in the United States were teaching prosperity theology, and Joel Osteen has been credited with spreading it outside of the Pentecostal and Charismatic movement through his books, which have sold over 4 million copies.
    - Bruce Wilkinson's *The Prayer of Jabez* also sold millions of copies and invited readers to seek prosperity.
  - In 2005, Matthew Ashimolowo, the founder of the largely African Kingsway International Christian Centre in southern England, which preaches a "health and wealth" gospel and collects regular tithes, was ordered by the Charity Commission to repay money he had appropriated for his personal use.
  - In 2017, the organization was under criminal investigation after a leading member was found by a court in 2015 to have operated a Ponzi scheme between 2007 and 2011, losing or spending £8 million of investors' money.
  - In 2007, U.S. Senator Chuck Grassley opened a probe into the finances of six televangelism ministries that promoted prosperity theology: Kenneth Copeland Ministries, Creflo Dollar Ministries, Benny Hinn Ministries, Bishop Eddie Long Ministries, Joyce Meyer Ministries, and Paula White Ministries.
- In January 2011, Grassley concluded his investigation stating that he believed self-regulation by religious organizations was preferable to government action.
  - Only the ministries led by Meyer and Hinn cooperated with Grassley's investigation.
  - The inauguration of Donald Trump as the 45th President of the United

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States featured prayers from two preachers known for advocating prosperity theology.

- Paula White, one of Trump's spiritual advisers, gave the invocation.

- This is just a little background on the movement. But that still begs the question, how does someone develop this type of teaching, especially when the testimony of scripture obviously teaches something right the opposite?
  - The answer to that question is why I do what I do - Context or taking God's word out of context. Let me give you a little more insight into what I am talking about by explaining some of the Theology behind this movement.
  - Proponents of prosperity theology often cite the parable of the talents as back up to their teachings
    - Prosperity theology teaches that Christians are entitled to well-being and, because spiritual and physical realities are seen as one inseparable reality, they interpret well-being as physical health and economic prosperity.
    - Teachers of the doctrine focus on personal empowerment, promoting a positive view of the spirit and body.
    - They maintain that Christians have been given power over creation because they are made in the image of God and teach that positive confession which allows Christians to exercise dominion over their souls and material objects around them.
  - [52] Leaders of the movement view the atonement as providing for the alleviation of sickness, poverty, and spiritual corruption;[53] poverty and illness are cast as curses which can be broken by faith and righteous actions.
- [46] There are, however, some prosperity churches which seek a more moderate or reformed paradigm of prosperity.
  - [12] Kirbyjon Caldwell, pastor of a Methodist mega-church, supports a theology of abundant life, teaching prosperity for the whole human being, which he sees as a path to combating poverty.[9][B]
  - Wealth is interpreted in prosperity theology as a blessing from God, obtained through a spiritual law of positive confession, visualization, and donations.
  - [54] Believers may see this process in almost mechanical terms;[55] Kenneth Copeland, an American author and televangelist, argues that prosperity is governed by laws,[10] while other teachers portray the process formulaically.
    - [53] Journalists David van Biema and Jeff Chu of *Time* have described Word of Faith pastor Creflo Dollar's teachings about prosperity as an inviolable contract between God and humanity.[9]
- The prosperity theology teaching of positive confession stems from its proponents' view of scripture.
  - The Bible is seen as a faith contract between God and believers; God is understood to be faithful and just, so believers must fulfill their end of the contract to receive God's promises.
    - This leads to a belief in positive confession: the doctrine that believers may

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claim whatever they desire from God, simply by speaking it.

- Prosperity theology teaches that the Bible has promised prosperity for believers, so positive confession means that believers are speaking in faith what God has already spoken about them.
- Positive confession is practiced to bring about what is already believed-in; faith itself is a confession, and speaking it brings it into reality.[56]

- The teaching often depends on non-traditional interpretations of Bible verses,[53] the Book of Malachi often being given special attention. While Christians have generally celebrated Malachi for its passages about the Messiah, teachers of prosperity theology usually draw attention to its descriptions of physical wealth.[57] Frequently quoted verses include:
  - Malachi 3:10: "'Bring ye all the tithes into the storehouse, that there may be meat in mine house, and prove me now herewith, saith the Lord of hosts, if I will not open you the windows of heaven, and pour you out a blessing, that there shall not be room enough to receive it.'" (KJV)[9]
  - Matthew 25:14–30: the Parable of the talents[37]
  - John 10:10: "'I am come that they might have life, and that they might have it more abundantly.'" (KJV)[9]
  - Philippians 4:19: "My God shall supply all your need according to his riches in glory by Christ Jesus." (KJV)[53]
  - 3 John 1:2: "Beloved, I wish above all things that thou mayest prosper and be in health, even as thy soul prospereth." (KJV)[5]
- Prosperity theology casts itself as the reclamation of true doctrine and thus part of a path to Christian dominion over secular society.
  - [39] It contends that God's promises of prosperity and victory to Israel in the Old Testament apply to New-Covenant Christians today, and that faith and holy actions release this prosperity.
  - [52] C. Peter Wagner, a leader of the New Apostolic Reformation, has argued that if Christians take dominion over aspects of society, the Earth will experience "peace and prosperity".
  - [58] Some Latin Americans who have embraced prosperity theology argue that Christianity has historically placed an unnecessary focus on suffering.
    - They often view this as a Roman Catholic doctrine that should be discarded and replaced with an emphasis on prosperity.[59]
- Prosperity-theology advocates also argue that biblical promises of blessings awaiting the poor have been unnecessarily spiritualized, and should be understood literally.[60]
  - Prosperity churches place a strong emphasis on the importance of giving. Some services include a teaching-time focused on giving and prosperity, including Biblical references to tithing; and then a sermon on another topic which follows the offering.
  - Prosperity-church leaders often claim that a specific blessing can be exchanged for the money being donated to their ministry; some have been reported to instruct worshipers to hold their donations above their heads during the prayer.[61]

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        - Congregants in prosperity churches are encouraged to speak positive statements about aspects of their lives that they wish to see improved.
        - These statements, known as "positive confessions" (distinct from confessions of sin), are said to miraculously change aspects of people's lives if spoken with faith.
            - [62] Prosperity churches also encourage people to "live without limits"[63] and to cultivate optimism about their lives.
    - [64] T. D. Jakes, pastor of The Potter's House non-denominational mega-church, has argued in favor of prosperity, rejecting what he sees as the demonization of success.
        - He views poverty as a barrier to living a Christian life, suggesting that it is easier to make a positive impact on society when one is affluent.[63]
        - While some prosperity churches have a reputation for manipulating and alienating the poor,[65] many are involved in social programs. Underlying these programs is a theology of empowerment and human flourishing with the goal of releasing people from a "welfare" or "victim" mentality.
- [65] Many prosperity churches hold seminars on financial responsibility. Kate Bowler, an academic who studies prosperity theology, has criticized such seminars, arguing that though they contain some sound advice, the seminars often emphasize the purchase of expensive possessions.
    - [37] Hanna Rosin of *The Atlantic* argues that prosperity theology contributed to the housing bubble that caused the late-2000s financial crisis. She maintains that prosperity churches heavily emphasized home ownership based on reliance on divine financial intervention that led to unwise choices based on actual financial ability.[37]
    - Most churches in the prosperity movement are non-denominational and independent, though some groups have formed networks.
        - [10] Prosperity churches typically reject presbyterian polity (Paul-lity) (or governance) and the idea that a pastor should be accountable to elders; it is common for pastors of prosperity churches to be the highest organizational authority-figure.
        - [66] Critics, including Sarah Posner and Joe Conason, maintain that prosperity teachers cultivate authoritarian organizations. They argue that leaders attempt to control the lives of adherents by claiming divinely-bestowed authority.
        - [67] Jenkins contends that prosperity theology is used as a tool to justify the high salaries of pastors.[68]
- Now, this morning I realize I spent a lot of time speaking about the “Prosperity Movement”, and I did so because I feel it’s important. And why?
    - Because once again, believers are confused, and they don’t know what to believe. The overarching theme of scripture bever says, nor does it promote, “The give to get concept”. And it never teaches that healing is an automatic reality in the life of a believer, or that if we just have enough faith, or we pray in a certain way, then all the bad things of life will be reversed!
    - And how do I know this to be the case? Well, first of all I know this to be the case

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because I study scripture (as a whole and in context). But second, I know it to be the case because of logic and or pragmatism, meaning, I know it to be the case because the truth is, sometimes people are healed when we pray and sometimes, they are not!

- Sometimes people are blessed financially, and sometimes they are not, and when I couple that truth with the truth of God's consistency along with His ultimate purpose for our lives, which is what; that we are part of His plan.
- A plan that begins here on earth and ultimately ends up with us residing with Him in Heaven. A plan that is backed up by the testimony of scripture that says, our lives here on earth are about His Glory! That our lives are not our own. That we have been bought with a price.

- When I apply all of these truths, it's not that hard to come to the correct conclusion about God's prosperity verses man's prosperity.
- Let me also say, applying logic and pragmatism one more time, the fact that we all die and that no one is ever permanently healed is pretty firm evidence that God isn't concerned about the here and now.

- You see, all of this data tells me why I cannot take passages from Matthew, like "the parable of the Talents", or scriptures from Malachi, and twist them into saying something polar opposite of what we know to be true. Not to mention the fact that the prosperity gospel also teaches something polar opposite of what the Bible overwhelmingly teaches.
  - I digress on this point. I just felt it important for us to do a little deep dive into the background on this topic, since obviously it is such a powerful movement in the world today.
    - Moving on. Now at the end of last week's teaching, I said this week I would clarify verse 8, because for some it might seem conflicting or confusing. And to do that, I want to back up and re-read last week's verses an bring us forward in context, and this is where we will close this morning. Beginning with 2 Cor. 6:3-10:

2 Cor. 6:3 giving no cause for offense in anything, so that the ministry will not be discredited,
2 Cor. 6:4 but in everything commending ourselves as servants of God, in much endurance, in afflictions, in hardships, in distresses,
2 Cor. 6:5 in beatings, in imprisonments, in tumults, in labors, in sleeplessness, in hunger,
2 Cor. 6:6 in purity, in knowledge, in patience, in kindness, in the Holy Spirit, in genuine love,
2 Cor. 6:7 in the word of truth, in the power of God; by the weapons of righteousness for the right hand and the left,
2 Cor. 6:8 by glory and dishonor, by evil report and good report; *regarded* as deceivers and yet true;
2 Cor. 6:9 as unknown yet well-known, as dying yet behold, we live; as punished

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yet not put to death,
2 Cor. 6:10 **as sorrowful yet always rejoicing, as poor yet making many rich, as having nothing yet possessing all things.**

- Let me say this before moving on this morning. It's interesting how Paul contrasts words so eloquently when describing he and the other Apostles lives. Specifically, as it relates to how the world views things verses how God views things.
  - It's also interesting how Paul's words confirm exactly what I have been teaching today on this concept of the prosperity movement. Which was what? That whatever we deem as bad from the world's standpoint, is actually opposite with God. Just look at the contrast in Paul's words, beginning with verse 8.
  - By glory and dishonor, by evil report and good report, regarded as deceivers and yet true. Now, before moving forward this morning, these words are the words that I wanted to clear up.
    - When Paul says, "regarded as deceivers and yet true", he's not saying we are regarded as deceivers and it's true. That's not what he is saying at all.
    - But to better understand what he is saying you have to read it in the Greek. The Greek reads this way, it says, "as imposters (not deceivers- as imposters), and yet true". What Paul is saying is, we are imposters as it relates to this world, because we don't belong here. In other words, we are regarded as imposters, because we are.
- Moving on in verse 9:
  - As unknown yet well known. As dying, yet behold we live. As punished yet not put to death. As sorrowful yet always rejoicing. As poor yet making many rich. And, as having nothing yet possessing all things.
  - From the world's standpoint, Paul and the other Apostles are being dishonored. Yet in God's eyes they are honored. The contrasts here tell us one thing, and that is we appear one way (from the world's point of view), but in reality, we are opposite in (God's view).
    - Dr. Thomas Constable of Dallas Theological Seminary says it this way:

"These verses probably give us some indication of the charges that Paul's critics were leveling at him (cf. Rom 3:8; 1 Cor. 4:13).

- Human responses to Paul's preaching evidently varied greatly (v. 8), but God's estimate was positive regardless of the opinions of people.
  - These contrasts may be between human responses, or between the human and the divine responses.
  - Regardless of people's estimates of him, the great apostle continued to fight the good fight of faith (vv. 7, 9).
  - Moreover, regardless of how he appeared to be doing, in reality God was preserving and blessing him (vv. 9-10)."

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- And so, with all this said, we should get a better understanding of God's view verses the world's view. It is always the opposite. And, I'll close with what might be the strongest commentary to this very fact, which shows up in Luke 17:32-33, and this is what Luke says:

Luke 17:32 Remember Lot's wife.
Luke 17:33 Whoever strives to save his life will lose it, and whoever loses *his life* will keep it.

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- Alright guys, turn with me if you will to the sixth Chapter of 2 Corinthians as we pick back up with Paul's second recorded letter to the Corinthian Church.
  - Last week, I paused in our teaching to really highlight what was, and is, a problem with the American church, and not just with the American church, but with the church globally as well.
  - And that problem is a message being taught by many churches called the "Prosperity Gospel" or "Prosperity Message". A message that says, God wants to bless you (in a temporal sense), an earthly sense, with stuff. Especially money.
  - And although it is true that God wants to bless us, His blessings are always eternal, and they are always about His Glory. Simply put, these blessing emerge when our lives bring glory to God here on earth. And by bringing Him glory, we, in turn, receive a real peace and a real contentment that only God can deliver.
    - Now let me say this. From time-to-time God will bless a believer financially. But, once again, if He does, it's all for His glory, for a work that He entrusts us to do, which is always for the work of ministry. Amen - Amen!
- Now moving on this morning, let's pick back up with our teaching in 2 Corinthians, the sixth Chapter. When we last left off, we finished our previous teaching with verses 2-10. In those verses Paul explained how that (and I will paraphrase here), how that he and the other Apostles always stood firm in their faith, even in the face of great hardship.
  - Whether it was beatings, imprisonments, mob attacks; whatever it was they always stood firm in their faith. Never wavering. And that very fact, that they did indeed stand firm in the face of great adversity, was evidence that they were who they said they were.
    - Another way to say it is, their actions lined up with their words. And that my friends, is and will always be, the most powerful testimony a believer can ever display. The question is always the same; are you who you say you are? And not just in the good times, but in the bad times as well.
    - Paul also did something else in these verses, he contrasted words in his writings. Meaning, he took words that were polar opposite of one another and then used them as an example of their stance with God.
    - More specifically, he used them to give us a picture of the universal position of their life in Christ, and how they never wavered. Paul's universal position in life is our universal position in life as well. It can best be described as being riddled with ups and downs, good times and bad. A little bit better at times and then a lot worse. That's life. It's life for all of us, and the key to surviving it lies in your perspective, your paradigm.
  - Paul described it this way in verses 4-10:

2 Cor. 6:4 but in everything commending ourselves as servants of God, in much endurance, in afflictions, in hardships, in difficulties,
2 Cor. 6:5 in beatings, in imprisonments, in mob attacks, in labors, in sleeplessness, in hunger,

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- And then he makes the shift in verse 6 when he says:

2 Cor. 6:6 **in purity, in knowledge, in patience, in kindness, in the Holy Spirit, in genuine love,**
2 Cor. 6:7 **in the word of truth, *and* in the power of God; by the weapons of righteousness for the right hand and the left,**
2 Cor. 6:8 **by glory and dishonor, by evil report and good report; *regarded* as deceivers and yet true;**
2 Cor. 6:9 **as unknown and *yet* well known, as dying and *yet* behold, we are alive; as punished and *yet* not put to death,**
2 Cor. 6:10 **as sorrowful yet always rejoicing, as poor yet making many rich, as having nothing and *yet* possessing all things.**

- I would say that about covers life, it's up and it's down and it's good and then it's bad. The point is, and Paul says it at the beginning of verse 4, "in everything we are to commend ourselves as servants of God". Another way to say it is, no matter my situation, we will serve the Lord.
    - Next, he moves into what will be the final verses of Chapter 6, where he says the following, and let me read it to you:

2 Cor. 6:11 **Our mouth has spoken freely to you, you Corinthians, our heart is opened wide.**
2 Cor. 6:12 **You are not restrained by us, but you are restrained in your own affections. (Self-awareness)**
2 Cor. 6:13 **Now in the same way in exchange—I am speaking as to children—open wide *your hearts to us,* you as well.**
2 Cor. 6:14 **Do not be mismatched with unbelievers; for what do righteousness and lawlessness share together, or what does light have in common with darkness? (a hawk and a dove)**
2 Cor. 6:15 **Or what harmony does Christ have with Belial (bee-lee-el), or what does a believer share with an unbeliever?**
2 Cor. 6:16 **Or what agreement does the temple of God have with idols? For we are the temple of the living God; just as God said,**
"I WILL DWELL AMONG THEM AND WALK AMONG THEM;
AND I WILL BE THEIR GOD, AND THEY SHALL BE MY PEOPLE.
2 Cor. 6:17 **"Therefore, COME OUT FROM THEIR MIDST AND BE SEPARATE," says the Lord. (Your choice)**
"AND DO NOT TOUCH WHAT IS UNCLEAN; And I will welcome you.
2 Cor. 6:18 **"And I will be a father to you, and you shall be sons and daughters to Me,"**
Says the Lord Almighty.

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- So, Paul pauses finishing his defense in verse 10, and then makes a shift by saying:

2 Cor. 6:11 Our mouth has spoken freely to you, you Corinthians, our heart is opened wide.
2 Cor. 6:12 You are not restrained by us, but you are restrained in your own affections.
2 Cor. 6:13 Now in the same way in exchange—I am speaking as to children—open wide your hearts to us as well.

- Pretty simple concept here. Paul says, guys, our mouth has spoken freely to you. That's the translation of my NASB 95. But the Greek says it better. It says, "The mouth of us *has been opened to you."*
    - The sense here, (as I have read it and studied it), is God has spoken through us to you, and what you do with it is up to you. And that is further confirmed in verse 12 when he says, "You are not restrained by us, but you are restrained in your own affections."
        - Now, Paul's words here run a lot deeper than you might think, and in his words lies a powerful lesson for each of us, and that is, you have heard the truth now do something about it.
    - The two words "own affections" in the Greek mean, to be moved by the inward parts (heart, liver, lungs, etc.), the emotions. The usage of the words in the Greek are the inward parts, the heart, affections, seat of feelings.
    - In other words, do not let your emotions override the truth of God's word. There simply cannot be any deeper truth or reality in the life of the believer than that. You know what you are supposed to do but you just aren't willing to do it.
    - Which tells us that God gives us a "say" in the matter, meaning we do get a choice, but the question is, when God speaks what do we do? Do we A) - Close our eyes and ignore what God says because it's going to cause conflict in our lives, or do we B) - Make the right choice regardless of our emotions?
- Now, here's what I will tell you about this particular topic. The level in which you are willing to obey God's word is directly proportional to your happiness on this earth.
    - Now this may sound like an obvious statement, but apparently, it's not too obvious because believers won't do it. Every day, I meet with people who come to me for counseling. It could be dealing with relationships, or substance abuse issues or children. And the answer they are looking for is many times crystal clear.
        - And it starts with a simple question, which is, what does God expect, or what does God's word tell me to do? And almost always those people will say, I know, I know. I just can't seem to do it.
    - Let me say, I personally don't understand that statement. I really don't. Someone might say to me, "Well, it's easy for you to say because you're not in their situation." I would say to that person, "you are misunderstanding what I am talking about."
    - I understand being in a bad situation and struggling to do the right thing. What I don't understand is the statement, "I just can't seem to do it." You can do it. The

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reality is you aren't willing to do it.

- In other words, I can understand someone saying, for me right now the "juice isn't worth the squeeze." Meaning - I am not willing to make the right choice at this current time. Believe it or not, I can accept that, and I mean that sincerely, and the reason I can accept that is because it's the truth.
- You can do it, you're just not willing to do it at this time. The sad thing is though, if you only knew; if you only knew what blessings were waiting for you if you simply listened and obeyed.

- I have often said, if I had a crystal ball, and could show what the future looked like when you stand with Christ (no matter the situation or circumstance). If you could only get glimpse of what God has in store for you, you would never choose to stay where you are.
  - But why don't we do it? Why don't we do what we are supposed to do? In essence, it all boils down to belief and trust. Meaning, you just don't trust God enough to think it's going to be alright, or that somehow, it's going to be better. And so, for that reason, you stay where you are.
  - Now let me say this. This is all a biproduct of spiritual maturity, which as we know is a biproduct of knowing God more intimately. Which is a biproduct of what? Studying and knowing His word more in-depth. It's a simple concept.
    - When you know God more intimately, you then trust Him and believe Him at a whole different level, which then allows you to make sound and solid decisions about everything in your life.
    - But for most believers, the level of maturity required to make sound decisions (while in the fire) will never be a reality. Which, once again, leaves that person in a constant state of turmoil and confusion.
- And so, what am I trying to say? I am trying to say, we as believers must desire and pray about reaching a higher level of spiritual maturity. That's if we ever want to see improvement in our Christian life.
  - We should never live lives that mirror the world around us. Rather, we should live lives that make those in the world around us 'desire to inquire'. To pause and ask themselves, what's different about you? Because that's the purest way that you and I participate in the work of the ministry. That's how God uses us, and puts you in the game, through the testimony of our lives!
    - So, Paul tells them, you have received the truth, so forget about what you've been told by the others around you, and instead, make the right choice and follow what God has said.
- In verse 13, Paul says something else I find interesting. He says, paraphrasing here, we are speaking to you as children. Now, Paul's choice of words here tells us two things. First, (and this is just my opinion), I think his choice of words shows his frustration. Because essentially, he is saying, I'm trying to get my message through to you, (so much so) that I have dumbed it down to the point where even a child can understand it.
  - And then secondly, it obviously shows just how immature they are. Remember, this church is roughly a 10-year-old church at this point, so the fact that he has to speak to them in such a child-like way tells us they are very immature, at least on spiritual matters.

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- Now the question for all of us sitting here today is, are we any better than they are? In other words, if you and I attended that church, at that time, would we be any better at deciphering or making spiritual decisions, or are we any better today at making spiritual decisions?
    - In other words, when tough decisions have to be made, do we:
    - A) Roll with the punches and make decisions by gravitating toward what is comfortable or easy in the moment? Or…
    - B) Pray and refer to God's word, and then make our decisions based on what God would expect.
        - I suspect the overwhelming majority of Christians today would go with A, which is based on my sample size of dealing with Christian brothers and sisters for the last 20-plus years. Moving on, verses 14-18, let me read it once again.

2 Cor. 6:14 Do not be mismatched with unbelievers; for what do righteousness and lawlessness share together, or what does light have in common with darkness? (a hawk and a dove)
2 Cor. 6:15 Or what harmony does Christ have with Belial (Bee-Lee-El),
or what does a believer share with an unbeliever?
2 Cor. 6:16 Or what agreement does the temple of God have with idols? For we are the temple of the living God; just as God said,
"I WILL DWELL AMONG THEM AND WALK AMONG THEM;
AND I WILL BE THEIR GOD, AND THEY SHALL BE MY PEOPLE.
2 Cor. 6:17 "Therefore, COME OUT FROM THEIR MIDST AND BE SEPARATE,"
says the Lord. (Your choice)
"AND DO NOT TOUCH WHAT IS UNCLEAN;
And I will welcome you.
2 Cor. 6:18 "And I will be a father to you,
And you shall be sons and daughters to Me,"
Says the Lord Almighty.

- Paul begins verse 14 by giving a command, or an order. He says, "Do not be mismatched with unbelievers". The word for mismatched in Greek is "unequally yoked together" or "tied together".
    - The sense here is that of uniting together two opposing groups of people. And let me say, there could be no greater opposing two groups than that of the believers and unbelievers. Believers are not supposed to hook up with, unite, or connect with unbelievers.
    - Now wait a minute preacher. How are we going to reach people for the Lord if we don't associate with unbelievers? I didn't say don't associate with them. I said we don't unite with them. The word is yoke. Do you guys know what a yoke is?
        - Think of what a yoke looks like, two oxen connected. These two oxen are not associating with one another, they are married, conjoined together. They are one! This is a lot different than simply associating with someone.

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- Now, before pressing on this morning, I want to highlight something else about Paul's words, and that is, Paul's reference here to unbelievers should give us cause for concern. And why? Because remember, Paul is writing this letter to a church, so evidently this group, - or someone within this church, is obviously being influenced by unbelievers.
  - The question is, how could that happen? Well, there are only two possible answers:
    - Number 1 - this church or these church leaders are taking advice from people outside the walls of the church, or…
    - Number 2 - they are taking advice from people inside the church. People who they think are believers, but they are not. Based on the history of this church, as well as others, I'm going with Number 2.
  - Which is pretty disturbing when you stop to think about it, and it leaves me asking a question; which is, whatever percentage of "non-believing" church people do you think may have attended the Church at Corinth? I'm not sure, but guess what? I assure you it pales in comparison to the percentage of "non-believing" church members attending churches today, and as my daddy would say, "that certainly brings on more talk".
  - Which obviously leads to the question, how could this be the case? Well, without keeping you here all day, all I can tell you is, it's prophetic, and know this to be the case when we study eschatology (The End Times).
- In the last days, the church will be full of people who say they are saved, but in fact, are not. And just for a little proof of this, let me read an excerpt from 2 Timothy 4:1-5:

2 Tim. 4:1 I solemnly exhort *you* in the presence of God and of Christ Jesus, who is to judge the living and the dead, and by His appearing and His kingdom:
2 Tim. 4:2 preach the word; be ready in season *and* out of season; correct, rebuke, *and* exhort, with great patience and instruction.
2 Tim. 4:3 For *the* time will come when they will not tolerate sound doctrine; but *wanting* to have their ears tickled, they will accumulate for themselves teachers in accordance with their own desires,
2 Tim. 4:4 and they will turn their ears away from the truth and will turn aside to myths.
2 Tim. 4:5 But *as for* you, use self-restraint in all things, endure hardship, do the work of an evangelist, fulfill your ministry.

- Paul was the one who wrote Timothy, therefore, it's pretty fitting that we use his own words to confirm what he is trying to convey in 2 Cor. 6:14. How could there be people inside the church who are not believers, but obviously think they are? The answer is the absence of God's word being preached.
  - And why is that? Because God's word is what saves people. And how does that work?
    - When taught in context and rightly divided by a pastor/teacher, it convicts, which then causes reflection in a person, which then causes repentance, which then causes salvation. That's how it works.

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- So, if the word is no longer being taught or studied or championed, then there is no conviction and no reflection and no repentance and no salvation. That's it! And that's why the church ends up with people in it who aren't saved.
    - But why does the church quit teaching the word? Well, they don't completely quit teaching it, but they do, and they don't.
        - They don't completely quit, they just begin bending it and shaping it to fit a theme or narrative - taking it out of context, which then ends up diluting it. Diluting it or watering it down to the point it loses its "seasoning effect", its "convicting effect".
        - That's what happens, and the crazy thing is it's all happening with the purest of intentions, which was for the sake of reaching the lost. Which is so strange when you think about it. You mean in an effort to reach people for Christ, we abandoned the mechanism that actually saves them? The answer is yes.
        - But, as I said, with the purest of intentions. But why? It happened because preachers forgot (or maybe they never knew), whatever the reason, they lost sight of how salvation works. Let me explain.
- Man does not save man. Man has zero to do with man's salvation. It's all God all the time. Man has nothing to do with it, we are simply an instrument God uses in the process of salvation. But at some point in church history, in an effort to reach more people for Christ, preachers began forgetting that. Not consciously but subconsciously, and as a result, the message began turning more toward a "tickling of the ear".
    - Where once, the Bible was the basis for the message, meaning, the Bible was the starting point for the preaching, man began having his own ideas, and that led to the advent of topical preaching.
    - Meaning, instead of God's word being the basis for the message, man started with his own basis, ideas, and philosophies, and then used the Bible as a reference, or foot note, or back up for what he was trying to convey. Let that sink in for minute. Can you see the danger in that?
        - One way takes the Bible (the verses) and teaches from it, and the other way takes a preacher's idea, or topic, and then uses the Bible (almost like a commentary) to back up what he is trying to convey.
        - Next week, I am going to expound on this a little bit more by giving you some real-life examples of what I am trying to say, but for now you should get the picture.
- Now, let me say this, for most of us, we all pretty much grew up sitting under this type of teaching. Which means this might be a little upsetting or disruptive if it's the first time you've heard what I am saying. And so, in an effort to make you feel a little better, I will say a preacher can teach the Bible in a topical format, as long as he keeps it completely in context of what the scripture is trying to convey.
    - The problem is in order to do that the preacher must do a whole lot more work in crafting his message. And I assure you, it is a whole lot easier just to teach it as you come to it. Verses rather than trying to craft a narrative in context, using the scriptures to back up what you are trying to say. Let me digress on this topic by saying this, a man should never come up with a theory or an idea and then try and use the Bible as a "back up" to what he is trying to say or prove.

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- Instead, the Bible should be the starting point or basis for what he is saying. In other words, where you start as it relates to Biblical teaching matters. Pressing on, and I will close by touching real quick on the rest of what Paul said in verses 14–18.
  - He said don't be mismatched (unequally yoked) with unbelievers. And then he says,
  - For what does righteousness have in common with lawlessness?
  - Or what does light have in common with darkness?
  - Or what harmony does Christ have with Belial (Bee-Lee-El)? "Bee - Lee - El" is a word associated with Satan.
  - And then he says, or what agreement does the temple of God have with idols? The comparisons here are pretty simple, and once again, Paul is contrasting words. Words that are polar opposites, and the message to the believer is simple - we should never yoke ourselves together with the world.

- And let me say this to all believers; if you yoke yourself together with things of this world, in whatever facet they may be, and I am not going to go through the litany of things that could be considered worldly, except to say if you are confused about what those things might be, then just ask yourself the question - if the Lord were sitting here with me in this very moment in whatever I'm doing would I feel comfortable doing what I am doing?
  - If the answer is yes, then you're good. If the answer is no, then you're not good. That's your litmus test in case you are confused.
- Anyway, Paul's message to this church is clear; do not be unequally yoked with unbelievers, and certainly don't take their advice or direction in spiritual matters. And obviously, by extension, the same is true for us!
  - Next week I will expound a little bit more on verses 16-18 before moving into Chapter 7, and in those verses, we are going to discover something encouraging, which is "a promise from God".
  - A promise that says, if we do what we are supposed to do then God will respond and do something for us. And so, the inverse of that is, if we don't do what we are supposed to do, then He won't. Pretty simple!

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- Good morning and welcome back to our study of 2 Corinthians. When we last left off, we were in the process of studying, and or breaking down and rightly dividing - God's word of truth.
    - And we were specifically focused on 2 Cor. 6:11-18. And so, as I often do, before moving forward I want to back up and re-read these verses for context this morning and here is what Paul said,

2 Cor. 6:11 **Our mouth has spoken freely to you, you Corinthians, our heart is opened wide.**
2 Cor. 6:12 **You are not restrained by us, but you are restrained in your own affections. (Self-awareness)**
2 Cor. 6:13 **Now in the same way in exchange—I am speaking as to children—open wide *your hearts to us,* you as well.**
2 Cor. 6:14 **Do not be mismatched with unbelievers; for what do righteousness and lawlessness share together, or what does light have in common with darkness? (a hawk and a dove)**
2 Cor. 6:15 **Or what harmony does Christ have with Belial (bee-lee-el), or what does a believer share with an unbeliever?**
2 Cor. 6:16 **Or what agreement does the temple of God have with idols? For we are the temple of the living God; just as God said,**
"I WILL DWELL AMONG THEM AND WALK AMONG THEM;
AND I WILL BE THEIR GOD, AND THEY SHALL BE MY PEOPLE.
2 Cor. 6:17 **"Therefore, COME OUT FROM THEIR MIDST AND BE SEPARATE,"**
says the Lord. (Your choice)
"AND DO NOT TOUCH WHAT IS UNCLEAN;
And I will welcome you.
2 Cor. 6:18 **"And I will be a father to you,**
And you shall be sons and daughters to Me,"
Says the Lord Almighty.

- In the first section of these verses – verses 11-12 – Paul said we have spoken freely to you, and our hearts are opened wide, and you are not restrained by us, but you are restrained in your own affections.
    - What Paul was saying was, we have spoken the truth, we've done all we can do to straighten out your beliefs, your poor behavior and or your theology and the only thing holding you back from getting back on track with God - is you
        - It's - you!
        - You're the problem – btw – this is the way it always is.
- We are the problem – in one way, shape, form, fashion or the other, we (us), you and I are always the problem. Especially as it relates to our spiritual growth, and overall spiritual health and maturity.
    - This message is simple, yet a difficult one for most people to grasp. Do not let your

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emotions override the truth of Gods word!

- Instead obey and do what God requires you to do.

- That was true for the Church at Corinth - and that is true for us as well.

- But what if I don't know what to do? You do know what to do, you're just not doing it – because your emotions are getting in the way. Because we have access to God's word we know what God expects, therefore we know what to do.
  - And so the only thing holding us back is our own affections/emotions.
- Moving on, in the next set of verses – verses 14-16 – Paul says, "Do not be mismatched with unbelievers". The word in the Greek actually says "do not be unequally yoked".
  - The picture being painted here is that of one being tied to together or connected permanently, conjoined with unbelievers. Which is disturbing when you think about it. And why?
    - Because, as we know Paul is writing this letter to the Church of Corinth, a church he founded.
    - Which means when he told this church not to be unequally yoke with unbelievers he was speaking about people inside this fellowship. Which is pretty sobering when you stop to think about it.
- Last week I explained why this happens, why unbelievers end up deeply rooted inside the church. It's all because of the gradual, and slow abandonment of the teaching of God's Word but just exactly how did that happen. Or better yet, why has it happened?
  - It's happened because of Thematic or Topical Teaching preaching approach. A teaching style that was supposed to lend itself to a better understanding of God's Holy Manuscript.
    - And although it did (in a sense), over time the continued dumbing down of the scriptures slowly diluted or watered down the central context the Bible was trying to convey of what we were supposed to learn.
    - Which is ironic because God's word is the mechanism that God uses to save people. And we know this because of verses like Romans 10:17, which tells us that "Faith comes by hearing and hearing by the word of Christ or God".
  - And so once again the reason for this shift from Bible Teaching to Topical or Thematic Teaching was to bring a more "life applicable", or easy to understand message to God's people.
    - And so, that's what happened and it makes sense on the surface. Problem is it's only through God's word that people become convicted and it's through that conviction that people repent and are saved.
  - But why is that? Why is it, that people are convicted from God's word. It's because they are hearing directly from God. Where in the Old Testament, God spoke through the Law and the Prophets.
  - Once Jesus came, all that changed and today He speaks to you and I through His word, specifically through the situations and circumstances fleshed out in His Word.
- The concept is a simple one: When we read and study and meditate on His word God reveals His character to us. This happens when we see how God deals with individuals

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and situations that in turn convicts us about our own lives – and that conviction leads to Salvation.

- And so if Salvation comes directly from my conviction that comes through His word.
- And if my Sanctification (Spiritual Maturity) comes from studying His Word as well, then wouldn't it make sense for me to get as close to God as I can possibly get? Yep.
  - And to do that I need to receive His word in purest possible form. Which means I don't want a man/a preacher/a pastor to come up with some topic or theme or sermon series trying to simplify the message on my behalf. God doesn't need the preachers help delivering His message.

- Now, let me say as previously stated, the shift in teaching from Bible Teaching to Topical or Thematic Preaching was done with the purest of intentions. All in an effort to reach more people for Christ – which was a good thing.
  - And I get it, the Church needs to reach more people and so, let's try something different. Something that might be more moving, something that would really draw them in, get their attention. Leave them saying "Man, I really get a lot out of today's message"
  - Problem is – as previously stated – the only way people are saved is by and through God's word.
- But honestly, this new style did draw more people in. Matter a fact it drew in hundreds and thousands of people and continues to do so.
  - But the truth is, in many cases, the reason more people came or were drawn into the church had less to do with God and more to do with the preacher's charisma, and presentation, and or speaking ability.
    - Or the energized "rock concert" service which created the appearance of growth.
    - Problem was and still is, it was external and not internal growth. Meaning, people came, the church grew. But in many respects it was simply surface and superficial. It had no real substance.
    - People were a mile wide and an inch deep in their walk with God. But it worked, and once this all got going, there was no stopping it or slowing it down.
- Now, last week I told you I was going to expound a little more on this topic of Topical Preaching versus Expository Bible Teaching, and I want to do that by giving you some examples of what I am trying to convey – more specifically the differences in the two especially as it relates to context.
  - And from these examples you will see how the misrepresentation of the context of scripture takes people down the wrong path, especially as it relates to knowing and understanding God.
- Now, the difference in the two types of styles - Topical or Thematic versus Bible Teaching - lies primarily in the difference of exegeting the scriptures versus eisegeting the scriptures.
  - And let me give you the definitions of both - so you can better understand what I am saying:

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    - Exegeting scripture means to expound.Iit starts with the Bible as the basis and context for the message and expounds on what the text says.
        - The Bible Teacher sets the stage, begins the book or letter/epistle by letting us (the hearer) know who the writer was, who he was speaking to, what the setting was (geographical), the time frame that it was written in along with all pertinent historical background etc..
        - This is what it means when we say the preacher or teacher is exegeting the scriptures.
- On the other hand, there is what we call eisegeting the scriptures.
    - This style starts with man's thought, or theory, theme or idea and then uses the Bible as a basis for backing up what he is trying to convey.
    - Generally, the preacher jumps all over the Bible from one verse to another, right to the middle of a book or letter, and uses them to back up his narrative, or agenda.
        - As I said last week, a preacher can do this. He can preach topically or thematically. But they must stay in context, which is hard to do when you're the one trying to tell the Bible what the context is, or what the context should be!
- So, as I said last week I wanted to give you some examples of what I am talking about to give you some perspective of why it's so important to stay in context. and I want to start with John 10:10.
    - John 10:10 is a favorite go-to scripture for the Topical and or Thematic or Charismatic preachers. And here is what John 10:10 says,

John 10:10 **The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full.**

- As I said, this is one of the signature verses of the prosperity gospel. John 10:10 is used to suggest that God loves his followers and wants them to have every good thing.
    - The problem is - interpreting this verse to promise physical gain neglects the depth suggested by its context. And why?
    - Because the preceding verses clearly illustrate the parable of the sheep and their good shepherd, Jesus, who calls them by name.
        - That's what John says - that Jesus sheep know the good shepherd's voice and follow Him.
    - Verse 10 then contrasts Jesus with false shepherds who steal and kill and destroy. The abundance of life suggested here has to do with knowing and being known by Jesus, not material things.
        - The *Tyndale Commentary* explains, "He does not offer them an extension of physical life nor an increase of material possessions, but the possibility, nay the certainty, of a life lived as a higher level of obedience to God's will and reflecting his glory."
- Next, we move to James 4:2

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James 4:2 **You do not have because you do not ask God.**

- This verse is often used to bolster the "name it and claim it" part of the prosperity gospel — if you don't *"have,"* it's because you haven't prayed enough.
    - This interpretation ignores the verse that follows, in which James says, "When you ask, you do not receive, because you ask with wrong motives - which is so that you may spend what you get on your pleasures."
        - Creflo Dollar says this of prayer: "When we pray, believing that we have already received what we are praying, God has no choice but to make our prayers come to pass."
- While prayer (including intercessory prayer) is crucial to the life of a Christian, using it to force God into appeasing the believer's desires also goes against the very prayer Jesus prayed on the eve of his crucifixion: Which said, "Yet not my will, but yours be done" (Luke 22:42)

Mark 10:29-30 **No one who has left home or brothers or sisters or mother or father or children or fields for me and the gospel will fail to receive a hundred times as much in this present age.**

- Prosperity preachers are known for their emphasis on giving, which on its face seems to line up with scripture. However, the motivation they teach — this giving in order to get concept — distorts the biblical tradition.
    - In *God's Will Is Prosperity*, Gloria Copeland writes of this verse, "Give $10 and receive $1,000; give $1,000 and receive $100,000 . . . in short, Mark 10:30 is a very good deal."
    - But of course, that's not what this verse is promising. The reward indicated here is fellowship with hundreds and thousands of other believers.
    - The following verse (10:31) provides further clarity to this fact, when it says: "But many who are first will be last, and the last first."
        - This verse clearly encourages ordinary, obedient discipleship, not personal gain.

Galatians 3:14 **He redeemed us in order that the blessing given to Abraham might come to the Gentiles through Christ Jesus.**

- Once again prosperity preachers apply this verse to their misinterpretation of the Abrahamic covenant found in Genesis, which they read as God promising financial blessings to Abraham's descendants.
    - In *Spreading the Flame*, Edward Pousson writes, "This Abrahamic inheritance is unpacked primarily in terms of material entitlements."
        - Again, an entire portion of the verse is neglected. The Apostle Paul concludes in 3:14 by writing that Jesus sacrificed "so that by faith we might receive the promise of the Spirit."

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- David Jones, author of *Health, Wealth and Happiness*, writes that Paul is reminding the Galatians of the spiritual blessing that is salvation, not that of wealth in this life.

2 Corinthians 8:9 **Though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that you through his poverty might become rich.**

- Prosperity teachers read this verse to suggest that Jesus' sacrificial death affords us temporal wealth.
  - Most Christians agree that when Paul says that Jesus was "rich," he was referring to His status as the Son of God. And His becoming poor was his voluntary act of stepping into humanity — the incarnation.
    - Indeed, Paul was telling early Christians that because of the grace afforded to them, they should empty themselves.
    - The goal was equality, and in verse 15, Paul recalls Exodus 16:18, saying, "as it is written: 'The one who gathered much did not have too much, and the one who gathered little did not have too little.'"

3 John 2 **Dear friend, I pray that you may enjoy good health and that all may go well with you, even as your soul is getting along well.**

- In a prosperity gospel context, this verse is read to claim that physical health is inseparable from spiritual growth — if a believer were truly faithful enough, he would be experiencing bodily blessings.
  - However, 3 John 2 is simply a greeting. It's how John begins his letter to Gaius, similar to how any polite person might begin a letter with well wishes. It was not a promise to Gaius, and certainly is not meant to be taken as a promise that none of God's people will ever fall ill.

Malachi 3:10 **Bring the whole tithe into the storehouse . . . and see if I will not throw open the floodgates of heaven and pour out so much blessing that there will not be room enough to store it.**

- This verse is a powerful fundraising tool for prosperity preachers, manipulating believers into tithing more by saying God will return the favor exponentially.
  - But as D. A. Horton explains, this verse has nothing to do with individual riches; rather, it arises from a particular historical situation for Israel: "The Israelites were robbing God by not giving enough food to the national storehouse that was used to feed the priests of Israel. So, the priests were having to leave their priestly duties and take up farming to survive (see Neh. 13:10-13). God therefore exhorts Israel to test him by giving obediently. If they did, he would reward them as he did in the past."

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Isaiah 53:5 The punishment that brought us peace was on him, and by his wounds we are healed.

- Whereas most Christian scholars see this verse as a prophecy that spiritual wounds (sin) are healed (overcome) by the atoning work of Jesus on the cross, prosperity gospel preachers interpret it to mean that abundant faith will result in physical healing.
    - Kenneth E. Hagin, one of prosperity gospel's founders, writes, "It is the plan of Our Father God, in His great love and in His great mercy, that no believer should ever be sick; that every believer should live his full life span down here on this earth."

Jeremiah 29:11 For I know the plans I have for you,' declares the Lord, 'plans to prosper you and not to harm you, plans to give you hope and a future.'

- This maybe one of the most misunderstood verses by Christians more generally (see "Five Bible Verses You Need to Stop Misusing"), Jeremiah 29:11 is often used to promise good news, suggesting that God works every seemingly bad situation for our benefit in the not-so-distant future.
    - But this verse comes amidst Jeremiah's letter to the exiles in Babylon, and it would be 70 more years before they would return home.
    - The verse is not a promise to Christians today who lose jobs or experience heartbreak of any kind. It was a promise to the Israelites that God, on his own timetable and plan, would restore his people.
        - And so what would the message be for us, or what would the current "Life Application" be for us?
        - That God works on His own timetable, not ours, that would should be patient and know that God is doing something (for His Glory), and not for ours.
- Then finally, I will end with John 14:14.

John 14:14 You may ask me for anything in my name, and I will do it.

- Similar to James 4:2, prosperity preachers misinterpret this verse to suggest that God will answer the prayers of the faithful.
    - But Christians praying for financial wealth should consider the words of Jesus from Matthew 19:24: "It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for someone who is rich to enter the kingdom of God."
    - Jesus speaks the words in John 14:14 as a way of encouraging His disciples to spread the gospel of His kingdom.
        - And once again, if someone is confused about this text of scripture they can become less confused by reading the verses before and after which provides really useful and powerful context. And the preceding verse says:

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John 14:12 **…Whoever believes in me will also do the works that I do…**

John 14:15 **"If you love me, you will keep my commandments"**

- Now you may be setting here this morning and thinking to yourself, well Pastor, you have talked a lot about Prosperity Preachers and the misinterpretation of the scriptures as it relates to finances, wealth, and or health or healing, but I don't really believe that, so I'm good.
  - Well, guess what, you're not good and let me show you what I mean by dealing with a more mainstream or less controversial misinterpretation of scripture.
    - Such as someone saying, "I found Jesus", or they found Jesus or I lead them to Jesus.
  - Christians have used these phrases for years and although for the most part when someone says it it's harmless, because they are just trying to convey what happened to a person when they were saved it's actually an incorrect statement.
    - Matter a fact, it's a completely inaccurate statement because we don't find God or Jesus – that's not how it works.
- First of all, remember God isn't hiding and second, Romans 3:9-11 says,

Romans 3:9 **What then? Are we better *than they?* Not at all; for we have already charged that both Jews and Greeks are all under sin;**
Romans 3:10 **as it is written:**
"THERE IS NO RIGHTEOUS PERSON, NOT EVEN ONE;
Romans 3:11 **THERE IS NO ONE WHO UNDERSTANDS,**
THERE IS NO ONE WHO SEEKS OUT GOD;

- Now why is this important? It is important because what you believe about our role, as it relates to God, is extremely important. And why?
  - Because of the expectation it creates as it relates to an individual. Meaning when you understand who's in control of what, it changes your expectation of the individual!
- Follow me here:
  - If we (the individual) aren't doing the finding as it relates to God. Instead, if it's God whose doing the finding then how does that change the preacher's approach to Preaching and Teaching.
    - Hang in here with me for a minute.
  - If I (The Preacher), believe a person is lost, and they are searching, trying to find God, then isn't it my job to help them be found?
  - And if it's my job to provide them with directions, specifically help them get to their ultimate destination (a destination by the way that they are not even aware of), wouldn't my thoughts of how all this works affect the way I craft my message?

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        - Wouldn't I be tempted to slant my message toward solving their perceived problem?
        - The answer is yes – of course I would.
- Because of this line of thinking, which was derived from a misunderstanding of God's Word, there emerged a style of preaching called "Seeker Sensitive".
    - Problem is, there is no such thing because "Seeker sensitive" assumes someone is seeking, and according to Paul in Romans that isn't the case.
        - Now, could someone be having a hard time in their life and maybe be seeking relief from their situation? Absolutely. It happens everyday.
    - But to say, "They are seeking, or searching for God" is simply not a true statement, and we know this to be the case, because once again Romans 3 tells us exactly that – "No one seeks God".
- Well okay preacher, aren't we supposed to tell people about Jesus?
    - Yes, but not really. You are supposed to live your life in a way that God uses you, your life (who you are), to draw men to Himself.
        - For example, when someone sees you go through a difficult time, when the storm is raging all around you, what do you do?
        - Do you give honor and glory to God – praising Him in that storm.
        - Or do you say, whoa is me?
    - Does your life represent the great and powerful God you say you serve or to the outside world does it appear you only live out your faith in the good times, or when it's convenient.
        - You see your life is supposed to create curiosity in the unbeliever. Make them say is this guy or gal for real? Make them say why does this person have so much peace in such difficult times?
        - And when that happens, it will cause a person to inquire which then gives you the opportunity to tell them about your relationship with Jesus. And it's at that point that you have earned the opportunity to invite them to church.
        - And if they visit (because they are curious), it's then that if the preacher is teaching God's Word that God may choose to open the eyes of that individual and prick their hearts (as Peter called it in Acts).
    - Guys that's how it works, and so our prayer should be everyday:
        - Lord as I go about my life on this earth please grow me and mature me to the point that my life creates curiosity in the unbelieving world around me
        - Which then will earn me the right to tell them about my relationship with you, which then affords me the opportunity to invite them to church
    - Having said all that though, what happens if they come to church and the preacher is preaching on politics or other controversial topics that have nothing to do with God, or His word but rather have everything to do with the Preacher's personal opinion…
    - Well, if the visitor is offended more than likely they will leave and never return.

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That’s generally what happens.

- But if the preacher sticks to teaching God's Holy Manuscript by rightly dividing the Word of Truth then it’s between them and God.
  - It’s not my responsibility as the pastor to convict anyone of anything or lead anyone to God – God does that through His Word.
    - Sometimes God deals with an individual and sometimes God didn’t choose to deal with them in that moment.
  - But at the end of the day it’s not my responsibility to prick someone’s heart, only God can do that, it's my responsibility to teach them the truth.
- And so as I close you should be able to see in this little exercise based on Romans 3, how context matters, a whole lot.
  - It changes how we look at things, where one way of thinking is man focused, the other is God focused.
  - One way can lead to a whole lot of false conversions, which creates a bunch of unbelievers sitting in church – The other leads unto real conviction, true repentance, and ultimately salvation.
  - Amen

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- Good morning and welcome back to our journey through 2 Corinthians. So far, we've managed to make it halfway through Paul's letter and we are roughly some 24 teachings deep. We began our study of this letter on January 7 of this year, and we should be picking up some speed due to the nature of Paul's writings as we move forward. But, having said that, who knows.
    - Anyway, so this morning we pick back up with 2 Corinthians the sixth Chapter, and when we last left off, we finished up with Verses 14-18, where Paul stated the following:

2 Cor. 6:14 Do not be mismatched with unbelievers; for what do righteousness and lawlessness share together, or what does light have in common with darkness? (a hawk and a dove)
2 Cor. 6:15 Or what harmony does Christ have with Belial (Be-Lee-El), or what does a believer share with an unbeliever?
2 Cor. 6:16 Or what agreement does the temple of God have with idols? For we are the temple of the living God; just as God said,
"I WILL DWELL AMONG THEM AND WALK AMONG THEM;
AND I WILL BE THEIR GOD, AND THEY SHALL BE MY PEOPLE.
2 Cor. 6:17 "Therefore, COME OUT FROM THEIR MIDST AND BE SEPARATE,"
says the Lord. (Your choice)
"AND DO NOT TOUCH WHAT IS UNCLEAN;
And I will welcome you.
2 Cor. 6:18 "And I will be a father to you,
And you shall be sons and daughters to Me,"
Says the Lord Almighty.

- Paul tells this body of believers, this Corinthian church, a) - to not do something specific, and b) - If you obey God's direction or command, He will in return do something for you. And what was that?
    - Well, first off, he said, "Do not be mismatched with unbelievers". We touched on this in depth over the last couple of weeks, so I won't rehash it all. But before we move into Chapter 7, let's do a quick "brush up" and just kind of bring back up to the surface some of the highlights.
    - And that begins with us remembering that (once again) Paul is writing this letter to the Corinthian Church, which means there were unbelievers in this church influencing the decisions and thought processes of these believers.
        - Which is unsettling when you stop to think about it. As I said, I won't rehash all of this again, only to say there is a reason God said don't be mismatched to unbelievers. And like I said last week, it didn't say don't associate with unbelievers. It says don't be mismatched, or the Greek words are unequally yoked, tied together.
- But why? Why can't we be yoked together with unbelievers? Because of perspective - perspective! Because of our perspective, or outlook on life, especially as it relates to this life and its effect on the next life to come.

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- You see, we as believers have nothing in common with unbelievers. Much like, say, Alabama fans have nothing in common with Auburn fans. But why? Why is that the case? It's the case because believers and unbelievers look at life through a totally different set of lenses or paradigm or perspective.
- Where believers are supposed to look at everything with "eyes for eternity", unbelievers on the other hand look at everything with eyes for the "here and now". One perspective is eternally focused and the other earthly or temporally focused. And so, for that reason, God commands us not to be joined together with unbelievers.

- Then at the end of verse 16, Paul makes a statement. A statement that gives us some deep insight as it relates to the believer's physical body here on earth. He tells us that our bodies are the temple of the living God, which tells us that if you are saved (a believer) your body houses God's Spirit.
  - Meaning, you are a container or a carrier for God's spirit. Think about that for a minute. If you have asked Jesus into your heart, to forgive you of your sins, to save you, and then followed that up with public profession of baptism, you have living inside of you The Spirit of the Living God, or The Creator of the Universe's Spirit, residing inside your very being.
  - Not sure if that resonates, but it should. As a matter of fact, it should cause us to pause and really think about how that what you say, what you do, how you act and react, matters.
    - And maybe, to get a little more granular in scope, to hit home a little more, when thinking about God's spirit living inside us, what about what we eat or drink or watch or listen to? I mean, if our bodies are a housing for the Spirit of God, shouldn't those things be of concern as well?
    - I'm not going to harp on this with specifics, but once again when pondering this concept, it should make us think.
- Moving on, I made the statement earlier that these verses clearly state that if we do something, then God will in return do something for us. And what is it? Let's read it again, verses 16-18:

2 Cor. 6:16 **Or what agreement does the temple of God have with idols? For we are the temple of the living God; just as God said,**
"I WILL DWELL AMONG THEM AND WALK AMONG THEM;
AND I WILL BE THEIR GOD, AND THEY SHALL BE MY PEOPLE.
2 Cor. 6:17 **"Therefore, COME OUT FROM THEIR MIDST AND BE SEPARATE,"**
says the Lord. (Your choice)
"AND DO NOT TOUCH WHAT IS UNCLEAN;
And I will welcome you.
2 Cor. 6:18 **"And I will be a father to you,**
And you shall be sons and daughters to Me,"
Says the Lord Almighty.

- Throughout the history of Christianity there has been a debate, a debate that has been

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controversial and continues to be controversial, even today; and that is the debate between Calvinism and Arminianism.

- The Calvinist says that God is Sovereign and totally in control of His creation (and obviously this makes sense). But on the other side of this coin is what's called Arminian, which says man is free and has been granted freewill, and therefore, God isn't really controlling anything, but rather man is in control.
  - As I said, this debate has been going on for centuries, and that debate still rages on, even today. And so, we have those who say God is Sovereign and in control, and they are called Calvinists. And those who say man has freewill, and therefore he is in control, they are called Arminian.

- Now having said all this, there is another group out there called Mollinists. A Mollinist says yes, God is sovereign and in control, but man also has freewill. The Mollinist has struggled drawing a hard line with one side or the other, and so they try to harmonize the two by landing in the middle.
  - But the question is, why is this even a thing? Well, because the overarching theme of scripture is that of God's Sovereignty, which, as I said earlier, makes total sense when you stop to think through it.
  - God is the creator, and we are the created, and nothing we do surprises Him. And as we know, God started this whole thing on time, and He will end it on time. The thought that somehow man controls things and it just works out, from a logical standpoint, would be a ludicrous notion.
    - But once again, on the other hand, we do see many places in scripture where God says if we do this then He will do that, which obviously lends itself to the freewill/Arminian point of view. And sure enough, right here in 2 Cor. 6:17-18, we see this very thing. We see a command for us to do something, and then a promise by God to do something as a result of our actions.
- Look at it again,

2 Cor. 6:17 **"Therefore, COME OUT FROM THEIR MIDST AND BE SEPARATE,"**
says the Lord. (Your choice - freeewill)
"AND DO NOT TOUCH WHAT IS UNCLEAN;
And I will welcome you. (God's Promise)
2 Cor. 6:18 **"And I will be a father to you, (God's Promise)**
And you shall be sons and daughters to Me," (The result)
Says the Lord Almighty.

- Now, in keeping with our theme as it relates to teaching scripture, which is what? To stay in context. In order to do that, we need to ask ourselves some questions. The most important of which is, what is Paul talking about, or even more important, who is Paul talking to or who is he talking about?
  - Well, verses 17 & 18 are not actually the words of Paul. They are the words of Isaiah. Paul is simply quoting Isaiah, which tells us that Paul is reminding these folks of what was said in their OT manuscript.

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- And that information is important and should lead us to ask the question, who was Isaiah talking to? And the answer is the Israelites. The Israelites (as they often do) had wandered off track and fell into a place of idol worship inside the city of Babylon.
  - And God called them out and told them to come out from their midst and be separate. He also told them to "Do not touch what is unclean". And then the Lord says, if you will do that I will welcome you, and I will be a Father to you, and you shall be sons and daughters to Me.
  - And so, Paul quotes Isaiah using it as a comparison to the place where the Corinthian Church was at that time, which tells us they must have been in a pretty bad place as it related to God.
- And let me say, the situation the Israelites found themselves in had nothing to do with disagreements as it relates to doctrine. Instead, it had everything to do with pagan idol worship. Which means the situation that the Corinthian Church found themselves in must have been similar in nature. And we know this to be the case when we study 1 Corinthians, along with other historical documents related to the history of this church.

- So, Paul began this church. He helped build it. He left them to go start other churches. He has been gone for some time. And the result was? The Church in Corinth lost its way!
  - And by the way, this is not a foreign concept. It's way more common than you may think. On the contrary, it's a warning, because the same thing is still happening today even in our church age.
  - Churches and denominations all over the world find themselves getting off track and wandering all the time. And why? Well, evidently it starts with being mismatched or unequally yoked with unbelievers, and from there it parlays into all sorts of things.
    - But the good thing for the church and for us individually is, if we will make a choice to come out from among the unbelievers, or from whatever (non-God honoring) activity or situation we find ourselves in, God will forgive us. And He promises He will be our Father, and in return we can return to being His sons and daughters.
- This kind of keeps with the theme of what I said a couple of weeks ago: Choices - Choices - Choices Or Decisions - Decisions - Decisions
  - If you find yourself in a place where your life is currently in a mess, or off track with God in any way, there is but one solution! Repent - that's what God meant when He told the Israelites to come out. His message to the Israelites is still the same message for us today.
  - If we want a fresh start with God, then repent and turn from whatever you are doing wrong and make the right choice and see for yourself what God will do. Because I can assure you, God will keep His promise even when we don't.
- Now, moving on into Chapter 7. My Bible entitles this next section of 2 Corinthians "Paul Reveals His Heart", and here's what it says in Chapter 7:1-4:

2 Cor. 7:1 Therefore, having these promises, beloved, let's cleanse ourselves from

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all defilement of flesh and spirit, perfecting holiness in the fear of God.
2 Cor. 7:2 **Make room for us *in your hearts;* we have wronged no one, we corrupted no one, we have taken advantage of no one.**
2 Cor. 7:3 **I do not speak to condemn *you,* for I have said before that you are in our hearts, to die together and to live together.**
2 Cor. 7:4 **My confidence in you is great; my boasting in your behalf is great. I am filled with comfort; I am overflowing with joy in all our affliction.**

- Beginning with Verse 1, Paul starts with the word therefore, which simply refers us back to what he just said. What he's saying is, because of what I just said; specifically, because you have these promises. What promises?
    - Promises that say, if you will come out of the people you are currently affiliating with, that God will become your father, and you will become His sons and daughters. For this reason, Paul says, beloved, let's cleanse ourselves from all defilement of flesh and spirit.
    - Now at first reading this may seem a little confusing. Meaning, you might say, well I understand cleansing ourselves from the flesh, but the spirit? Paul's words here incorporate what's called the use of Merism; which is simply a rhetorical device (or figure of speech) in which a combination of two contrasting parts of the whole refer back to the whole.
        - In other words, when Paul says let's cleanse ourselves from all defilement of flesh and spirit, he's simply saying, let's cleanse our entire body fully clean. It has nothing to do with the spirit that lives within us being defiled. It's simply a way of describing a complete spiritual detox process.
- Now, I want you to notice something about Paul's statement. When he says let's cleanse ourselves, this tells us something. First of all, it tells us we have a choice. We can do it or not do it. We could give our Arminian free will friends "one point" for this text of scripture, because man's free will comes into play here.
    - But the bigger question is, how do we do it? How do we cleanse ourselves? For those in the Old Testament it was through a sacrifice, but for us it's different. For us it's through repentance, and we know this to be the case because of verses like 1 John 1:9 that say:

1 John 1:9 **If we confess our sins, He is faithful and righteous, so that He will forgive us our sins and cleanse us from all unrighteousness.**

- And so, if that's the case, then all that's left for us to do is to what? To do it! Repent. Once again, choices and decisions. We have a choice. Repent and turn back to the Lord and do the things you should be doing. And by the way, we are to do this regardless of the perceived fallout.
    - In other words, we are to do it regardless of what we fear may happen. Obedience is the key in this process. You may be fearful of the result, but just know that when you honor God, God will honor you.

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- I have been a Christian for 34 years, and on a few specific occasions throughout my life and career, I have been faced with some really tough decisions. And I can tell you from personal experience, if you do what's right by God (the God honoring thing); if you honor God, He will always (not sometimes - but always) honor you.
    - And if you don't believe me, then I would tell you to put Him to the test. The next time you are faced with a tough decision, a decision that is really tough to make, a decision that may cost you your job, a decision that may cost you a relationship, a decision that "no one" may know about, where you can do what satisfies you and your current situation or do what satisfies and honors God.
    - Go ahead and make the right decision, the God-honoring decision, and see what happens regardless of your perceived outcome in the situation. As I said, do what honors God and what He lays on your heart. Throw all caution to the wind and see what happens.
        - Because, if you do, I promise you will be both surprised and empowered. Surprised because what you think will happen, the worst-case scenario, probably won't happen, and, empowered when you see how God shows up.
        - Guys, remember, God knows our situation and the scripture is clear - "He will never leave us nor forsake us", and if you don't understand but one fundamental truth of scripture, understand this one. Our lives as believers have a purpose and a plan, which is to bring God glory.
    - Which means if that's the case, then whatever happens to us regardless of the situation and circumstances, we can know it will work out for our benefit every single time. Amen.
- Now back to verse 1. Paul says something or makes another statement. A statement that we all need to take to heart. Something very, very important. Which is what? Let's read it again,

2 Cor. 7:1 Therefore, having these promises, beloved, let's cleanse ourselves from all defilement of flesh and spirit, perfecting holiness in the fear of God.

- We are to cleanse ourselves. And we know how to do that because of 1 John 1:9. We are to confess and repent. But we are also supposed to do something else. Something that I feel is both fascinating and very pertinent to our walk with Christ, and that is, we are to perfect holiness in the fear of God.
    - And as always, we need to begin our pursuit of this by asking ourselves the question, how do we do this? How do we perfect holiness in the fear of the Lord?
    - Well, first of all, we need to begin by looking at the two words "Perfecting Holiness". Perfecting Holiness denotes an ongoing process. It's the ongoing, never-ending pursuit of Holiness. And it never ends. It's part in parcel, sanctification, which is becoming more like Jesus.
        - It's like the perfect round of Golf. We will never obtain it, but we are still commanded to pursue it. And even though perfect holiness is not obtainable on this side of heaven, we can definitely improve on it.
        - I like to say it like this - If holiness were a scale of say 1-10, and the day before we

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were saved, we were, say, at zero. The day after we were saved, we moved into the 1 slot. From that day forward we are to pursue moving up that scale. And how do we do that?

- Well, first of all, Paul says it begins with a fear of the Lord, which can be a problem for us, especially in a world that speaks out adamantly against fearing anything. This is obviously not a popular concept, causing some to say, I just don't think God wants us to fear Him.
  - Well, if you believe that, you are wrong.
  - I wouldn't say His goal is for us to fear Him. I would say His goal is for us to obey Him. And the motivation to obey many times is derived from fear. God gave us the emotion of fear, because it's through that emotion that we make decisions.
  - Fear is a good thing. It has a way of tempering our behavior, and therefore fearing God is important because it's through our fear and respect of the Lord, that we improve our lives.
    - All throughout the scriptures we see references to this very thing, where "the Fear of the Lord" produces a profitable result in the life of the believer. Proverbs 9:10 says,

Proverbs 9:10 The fear of the LORD is the beginning of wisdom, And the knowledge of the Holy One is understanding.

Hebrews 10:31 It is a terrifying thing to fall into the hands of the living God.

- Moses himself received a revelation on this topic, where he asked to see God and God said in Exodus 33:20 the following,

Exodus 33:20 He further said, "You cannot see My face, for mankind shall not see Me and live!"

- Let's be clear. God is love, but He is also judgement and wrath. He is all that wrapped up into one. Paul says, if we want to begin our pursuit of holiness, it begins by fearing God, which begins when you understand your position before God. When you are self-aware in your standing.
  - And let me just go on record by saying, contrary to popular belief, we are not born good, and we are not good at our core. We are opposite of that. We are unrighteous, unholy, unclean, selfish, and self-serving at our core.
  - And the only way we can improve on those deficiencies in our lives is by becoming more and more self-aware of our position before a Holy and Righteous God.
- My prayer for each of us this morning is two-fold. First of all, if you are in a place in your life where you know you are not doing the right things, not honoring God in a decision or decisions, my prayer is that you would throw caution to the wind, come out, repent, and put God to the test by honoring Him in whatever tough decision you may be facing.

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- It could be work related, relationship related, a decision with a family member or a child. It could be that you want to make the right decision, but you are fearful of the fallout. My prayer is you make the God-honoring choice, no matter what you perceive the consequences might be.

- Second of all, my prayer is for each of us to pursue holiness in ways we have never pursued it before, and for us to do that we must garner a deeper understanding of who God is, which then will evoke a greater fear of the Lord.
  - And of course, the best way to do this is by studying and meditating on His word. One of the strongest natural biproducts of studying God's word is that it produces a healthy fear of Him.
  - Because the more you know Him, the healthier the fear you will have of Him. And this all takes place in the life of the believer when we grasp a deeper and deeper understanding of who God is; just how all-powerful He is, how majestic, how omnipotent, how omnipresent.
- That He is the Creator of the universe; the Alpha and the Omega; the beginning to the end and everything in between. Paul says, the fear of the Lord is the beginning of the pursuit of Holiness, and that's my prayer for us today. All so that we may become a more fully devoted follower of our Lord Jesus Christ.

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- Welcome back guys. This morning, we return to our journey through Paul's second recorded letter to the Corinthian Church. We ended our teaching last week by focusing in on verses 14-18 of Chapter 6 and then finishing up with Chapter 7, verse 1.
    - At the end of Chapter 6, Paul told this church a couple of things. First, he made it crystal clear that we as believers, that our bodies are carriers, housing for the Spirit of the Living God. For the Creator of the Universe.
    - And if that's the case, and we know it is because that's what the Bible tell us, then we should always be aware of this fact and never take it lightly. It's extremely important that we take seriously who it is we say we represent. Which means how we act and react matters.
        - And why? Because you (if you are a believer) just might be the only Jesus anyone ever sees. You see, the scriptures are clear. God's primary method for drawing men to Himself is through your life, through the life of a believer, which (once again) should force us to reflect and ask ourselves the question. Which is what?
        - How are we doing, or how are we handling our responsibility as an ambassador for Christ? And let me say, this is probably not an assessment we should be giving ourselves. Not if we really want to know how we are doing.
    - Rather, we should ask a fellow believer. Or better yet, ask a non-believer, someone who deals with you on a daily basis. They would be the ones who could give us the truest and most accurate grade or score on this matter.
- Guys, I believe this is the most pressing issue facing believers in the 21st century, our behavior. Which by the way is simply a biproduct of spiritual maturity. It's somewhat of a mathematical equation.
    - Your behavior as a Christian man or woman is directly proportional to your walk with the Lord; to the amount of time you spend daily in prayer and in God's Word. The process of spiritual growth and sanctification is simple. The more you get to know Him the more you grow.
    - And the result is, the less likely you are to act or react like the world, and the more you are likely to act and react like Christ Jesus. We should always be asking ourselves that question, how are we doing? How are we doing when it comes to our lives and its power to influence the world around us for the Kingdom?
        - Are we neutral? Not really having any effect. Are we negative, which would cause the opposite effect of drawing men closer to God? Or are we having a positive effect, making a difference for the Kingdom?
- Let me also say one more thing related to this topic. If we do decide to assess ourselves, give ourselves a self-evaluation of sorts on how we are doing for the Kingdom, don't do it using the obvious methods like attending church or helping someone change a flat tire or getting a cat out of a tree.
    - Those are the easiest and most obvious ways to assess ourselves. And if I am being honest, these probably have the least effect on the world around us. If we want to truly give ourselves this Spiritual Self-Evaluation Examination, do it in the hard ways, using our everyday lives as gauges. Evaluate ourselves as we move about in the highways and byways of life when our patience is tested, which by the way, brings out the worst in everyone.

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- It's in those moments when our countenance and behavior speak the loudest to the world around us. Those moments create the truest test. Those are the times that reveal just how mature we are as believers. When we are caught off guard.
- In those times, are you slow to speak and slow to react, or do you jump and blurt out the first thing that comes to mind, saying whatever "excites" your flesh in that moment? As I said, that is the true test!

- Next, Paul ended Chapter 6 by quoting from the Prophet Isaiah, where he wrote the following,

2 Cor. 6:16 **Or what agreement has the temple of God with idols? For we are the temple of the living God; just as God said,**
"I WILL DWELL IN THEM AND WALK AMONG THEM;
AND I WILL BE THEIR GOD, AND THEY SHALL BE MY PEOPLE.
2 Cor. 6:17 **"Therefore, COME OUT FROM THEIR MIDST AND BE SEPARATE," says the Lord.**
"AND DO NOT TOUCH WHAT IS UNCLEAN;
And I will welcome you.
2 Cor. 6:18 **"And I will be a father to you,**
And you shall be sons and daughters to Me,"
Says the Lord Almighty.

- Remember, Paul wrote 2 Corinthians (along with most all his letters) with a few purposes in mind, with his primary objective being that of exhortation, of correcting the church's behavior. And so, when he quotes Isaiah, He does so for two reasons:
  - First, he's referring them back to something that all Jewish people held near and dear to their hearts, and that was and still is, the OT Hebrew Scriptures. The Jewish people were raised on the OT Scriptures, and when it came to the prophets, as well as other stories from the OT, they respected them immensely. And really, that's probably an understatement. They actually revered them.
    - And so, when Paul quotes from the OT, this tells us something; it tells us that he is really trying to drive his point home and grab their attention. It was as if he was saying, "Hey - Hey - Hey - listen to me folks - look up here! Remember what the prophet Isaiah said. Pay attention."
  - That's kind of the concept here. He's trying to drive a heightened awareness to what he is saying by comparing his words back to what the Prophet said. And what did the Prophet say? Good question, and one that takes me to my second point.
    - He wanted them to know that if they made a choice to do something, that God would in turn do something for them. And what was that? Repent and turn. Come out from among the pagans (the non-believers), from those whom they were living with in Babylon.
    - And if they did that, then God would in turn do something for them, which was what? He would be their God and Father, and they would be His sons and daughters. To you and I, this may seem insignificant, but I assure you that's not the case. It wasn't insignificant for them. As a matter of fact, it's not insignificant

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for you and I sitting here today.

- Isaiah's words still hold true for all of us sitting here today. The message and promises of God haven't changed. If we obey God; His statutes - His commands - His expectations - and do what's right by him, He will also be our Father, and we will be His sons and daughters as well.
    - Jesus himself confirms this in Matthew 12:46-50 when he says,

Matt. 12:46 While He was still speaking to the crowds, behold, His mother and brothers were standing outside, seeking to speak to Him.
Matt. 12:47 Someone said to Him, "Behold, your mother and Your brothers are standing outside seeking to speak to You."
Matt. 12:48 But Jesus answered the one who was telling Him and said, "Who is My mother and who are My brothers?"
Matt. 12:49 And stretching out His hand toward His disciples, He said, "Behold My mother and My brothers!
Matt. 12:50 "For whoever does the will of My Father who is in heaven, he is My brother and sister and mother."

- Pretty easy to comprehend. Jesus says those who do the will of my Father, they are my brothers and sisters. Another way to say it is, those who obey and follow my commands, these are my sons and daughters, and obviously this makes sense, right? Not real hard to understand.
    - The question is, are you following the will of the Father? If you are then Amen. If you aren't, then repent and get back into a right relationship with Him. And if you do you can rest on a promise of God, which is; If you honor God, He will honor you. And this isn't just a statement. As I said, it's a promise of God.
        - And it's backed by the credibility and reliability of God's Word, and in a world of uncertainty, that means a lot. But the interesting part is, you actually have a choice in this process. You have a say in the matter. All you have to do is believe it. All you have to do is make the choice and know that God will honor His promises, and that He will be faithful. And this is always the case, even if we are not always faithful!
- And so, Paul, in an effort to grab their attention (one more time), quotes from the Prophet Isaiah, and he tells this church to repent and turn from what you are doing. Return to God. And nothing moves God quicker than repentance. And this is the overarching theme of Scripture. As a matter of fact, Proverbs screams the exact same thing, albeit in a different way. Listen to Proverbs 3:5-8:

Proverbs 3:5 Trust in the LORD with all your heart and do not lean on your own understanding.
Proverbs 3:6 In all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight.
Proverbs 3:7 Do not be wise in your own eyes; Fear the LORD and turn away from

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evil.
Proverbs 3:8 **It will be healing to your body and refreshment to your bones.**

- In these verses we have a powerful set of statements and commands, and they start with us and end with God. Proverbs say trust in the Lord. But how much? Just a little? No, with all your heart. And do not lean on your own understanding.
    - And in all your ways (not some of your ways), in all your ways acknowledge Him. And He will do what? He will make your paths straight. Then the Proverbs says do not be wise in your own eyes. Fear the Lord and turn from evil, and it will be (not might be), it will be healing to your body and refreshing to your bones.
        - The Hebrew manuscript says it this way, “And it will be strength to your bones”. And so, paraphrasing here for a minute, obey the Lord and the Spiritual Health Benefits will be tremendous. And I would tell you to do this regardless of whatever tough decision you may be faced with.
- As I said last week, I challenge you to put this concept to the test, and experience what the Psalmist said in Psalm 34:8-9, which was what?

Psalm 34:8 **O taste and see that the LORD is good;**
How blessed is the man who takes refuge in Him!
Psalm 34:9 **O fear the LORD, you His saints;**
For to those who fear Him there is no want.

- And so, once again, it boils down to the same ole theme: Choices - Choices - Choices
    - It all boils down to choices and decisions. Which means, - when faced with difficult decisions, do the God-honoring thing. Honor Him and He will honor you.
- Moving on. Last week we finished our teaching by studying Chapter 7 verse 1, where once again they (and we) are commanded to do something. And what is it? Well, let’s read it and see. Chapter 7:1-4:

2 Cor. 7:1 **Therefore, having these promises, beloved, let’s cleanse ourselves from all defilement of flesh and spirit, perfecting holiness in the fear of God.**

- Real quick, I want you to remember from last week’s teaching, Paul’s command for them to cleanse themselves from all defilement of flesh and spirit. This incorporates the use of what’s known as Merism, which is simply a rhetorical device (or figure of speech), in which a combination of two contrasting parts of the whole refer to the whole.
    - Which tells us that Paul was not saying cleanse the spirit that lives inside you. He’s simply using this language as a way of saying clean up your entire being, your whole self, all of it. And once again, in this process you do have a choice. You can do it or not do it. But if you choose to do it, you can do so knowing you have the promises of God accompanying your decision.
    - Which was what? That He will be your Father, and you will be His sons and

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daughters! Moving on, next Paul says this in verse 2-4:

2 Cor. 7:2 **Make room for us *in your hearts;* we have wronged no one, we corrupted no one, we have taken advantage of no one.**
2 Cor. 7:3 **I do not speak to condemn *you,* for I have said before that you are in our hearts, to die together and to live together.**
2 Cor. 7:4 **My confidence in you is great; my boasting in your behalf is great. I am filled with comfort; I am overflowing with joy in all our affliction.**

- In these verses, Paul reiterates what he has told us time and time again, which was how that he and the other Apostles are not the enemy. That they can trust what they are saying.
  - He says, "We have not wronged you; we have not corrupted you; we haven't taken advantage of you, we have not condemned you. You guys are in our hearts, and my confidence in you is great. As a matter of fact, I boast about you (brag on you) and I am filled with comfort (when it comes to you). And finally, I'm even overflowing with joy in all our affliction."
  - Last week, I told you that the header in my Bible at the beginning of this section is entitled, "Paul reveals his heart". And now we see why.
    - Even though this church has lost its way, gotten off track, started listening to unbelievers inside their church, Paul still loves them and desperately wants to see them repent and return to the place where they once were.
    - Another way to say it is, he hasn't given up on them. And guess what? His model is our model! If someone you know is off track, where once they appeared to love the Lord with all their heart, soul, and mind; but now finds themselves seemingly far away from God, pray for them and encourage them and love them.
  - Ask God to prick their hearts once again, so that they may return to the place they once were. Because the scriptures are clear, that if they repent and if they return back to God, He will be faithful and just to cleanse them of all unrighteousness. So don't give up on them! Back to the text. In verse 5 Paul writes:

2 Cor. 7:5 **For even when we came into Macedonia our flesh had no rest, but we were afflicted on every side: conflicts on the outside, fears inside.**
2 Cor. 7:6 **But God, who comforts the discouraged, comforted us by the arrival of Titus;**
2 Cor. 7:7 **and not only by his arrival, but also by the comfort with which he was comforted among you, as he reported to us your longing, your mourning, your zeal for me; so that I rejoiced even more.**
2 Cor. 7:8 **For though I caused you sorrow by my letter, I do not regret it; though I did regret it—*for* I see that that letter caused you sorrow, though only for a while—**
2 Cor. 7:9 **I now rejoice, not that you were made sorrowful, but that you were**

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made sorrowful to *the point of* repentance; for you were made sorrowful according to *the will of* God, so that you might not suffer loss in anything through us.
2 Cor. 7:10 **For the sorrow that is according to *the will of* God produces a repentance without regret, *leading* to salvation, but the sorrow of the world produces death.**
2 Cor. 7:11 **For behold what earnestness this very thing, this godly sorrow, has produced in you: what vindication *of yourselves,* what indignation, what fear, what longing, what zeal, what punishment of wrong! In everything you demonstrated yourselves to be innocent in the matter.**
2 Cor. 7:12 **So although I wrote to you, *it was* not for the sake of the offender nor for the sake of the one offended, but that your earnestness in our behalf might be made known to you in the sight of God.**
2 Cor. 7:13 **Because of this, we have been comforted.**
And besides our comfort, we rejoiced even much more for the joy of Titus, because his spirit has been refreshed by you all.
2 Cor. 7:14 **For if I have boasted to him about you regarding anything, I was not put to shame. But as we spoke all things to you in truth, so also our boasting before Titus proved to be *the* truth.**
2 Cor. 7:15 **His affection abounds all the more toward you, as he remembers the obedience of you all, how you received him with fear and trembling.**
2 Cor. 7:16 **I rejoice that in everything I have confidence in you.**

- This is a long section, and one that can't be broken up, because obviously, it creates one continuous statement from Paul. In this section we clearly see why Paul makes a shift in his writings. Where in the previous 6 Chapters he was defending himself and his authority as an Apostle, now his tone has changed.
    - And why? Because he has received good news about the Church's response to his letter.
- Backing up in verses 5&6, Paul says that when he arrived in Macedonia, he and the other Apostles' flesh had no rest. They experienced conflicts on the outside and fears on the inside. Now before breaking this down any further, let me say something.
    - Let the record show that the Apostle Paul, along with the other Apostles, were dealing with some abusive situations. And we know this to be the case from his earlier writings, writings that clearly describe how they were beaten, imprisoned, attacked by mobs, etc. So, when they arrived in Macedonia, they were pretty beat up.
        - And just a side note; you and I are no more immune to these types of abuses than Paul or any of the other Apostles. And this is the truth. Regardless of what popular church culture says, suffering is a part of life and it's certainly a part of the Christian life. The difference for the believer is their outlook. It's our reaction to suffering that makes all the difference in the world.
    - Paul says, "our flesh had no rest." And then he says they were, "afflicted on

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every side: conflicts on the outside, and fears inside." Here, in Paul's own words, we receive another fundamental truth of God's Word; which is what? That the greatest writer of the NT, the greatest of all the Apostles, and the greatest evangelist to ever live, was scared. That he and the other Apostles were fearful and scared.

- And that's okay, because that is how God created us! If He didn't want us to experience fear, He wouldn't have created us with that emotion. But the larger teaching for us here today doesn't lie in the fact that they were scared (although it is encouraging to know they we are not alone). The greater teaching lies their reaction to that fear. That's what we should be interested in.
- And how did they react when faced with persecution, beatings, and imprisonment? Well, let me begin explaining it by first telling you what they didn't do. They didn't Google what to do, they didn't ask the opinion of their unbelieving friends and family, and they didn't seek out wisdom or knowledge from the world around them.

- No, just as Paul writes many times throughout his letters, he sought the Lord's wisdom and knowledge. A wisdom that finds its origin in the will of God! And this is key folks, over and over again, when we see Paul praying for people, his prayer seems to always revolve around the same theme: Lord God, please give them knowledge and wisdom as it relates to Your will.
  - And isn't that interesting because it's so counter to what we've been taught. Very rarely do we read where Paul says, "God please give them this or fix that", rather it's almost always, "Lord, give them knowledge and understanding of your will".
  - Another way to say it might be, "Lord, give them eyes to see and ears to hear". And why is that the case? Because as a believer, regardless of how you may feel, all you really want is what God wants, and all you need is what He provides. Nothing more, nothing less!
    - But unfortunately for us (because we haven't been taught the scriptures properly), many times our prayers find their origins with our wants and our desires, which is usually not in accordance with the will of God!
- Now, this statement may leave you asking the question, well okay preacher, but how do you ever truly know what the will of God is? The answer is, you must know Him more intimately; so much so that the Spirit that lives inside you moves you, touches you, and compels you in one direction or the other.
  - And how do you get to know him more intimately? You pray and study His Word, just as you've heard me say over and over again. You study His memoirs! And as you study, you will get a better understanding of who He is, how He operates, and what He expects. And it's then, and only then, that the answers to your prayers will become clearer.
  - And so, this morning, if you don't leave with anything else, leave with this: our prayers must be directed in a way that leads us to the Will of God in all situations, and we should always ask God to give us eyes to see and ears to hear as it relates to His knowledge and understanding.
    - And the obvious inverse of that is, our prayer should never have anything to do with our wants and desires. Now I realize this is a hard pill to swallow, and many times it is much easier to say than do. But that is the testimony of scripture.

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Paul never prayed, “Lord, keep me from harm, or keep me from any trial and or tribulation”, for that matter.

- Rather he always prayed, “Father, give us knowledge and wisdom and direct us in the way of your will”.
- And so, for Paul and for us, when the world beats us up - hold on! Wait. Because God will show up. Look at verse 6, Paul says,

2 Cor. 7:6 But God, who comforts the discouraged, comforted us by the arrival of Titus;

- But God who comforts the discouraged, comforted us, and how did he do that? Not in the way you might expect. He comforted them by the arrival of Titus.
  - Let me start out by saying, God comforts the discouraged, and many times He does so in the most unusual way. Could be through someone’s words that resonate deeply inside the believer, even though the person speaking those words has no clue how God is using it.
  - It could be through a sign; a bird, a rainbow, a symbol; something that only we and we alone will recognize and connect with. A few weeks ago, I had someone who worked for me pass away, and his daughter was talking out in the parking lot.
    - She was talking and then suddenly she began staring, somewhat in a trance. I immediately turned around to see what she was staring at, and she said, “look, a Redbird. My dad always said when you see a Redbird it’s a sign that the person who just passed away is watching over you.”
    - What’s interesting is that Redbird just set there as if it truly was watching over her. I don’t have any Biblical basis for this, only to say God gives comfort to the discouraged, and that’s exactly what the Lord does here for Paul and the others. And in this situation, He does so by sending Titus to meet them in Macedonia.
  - And when Titus arrives, what does he tell Paul? Well, first, before I tell you what he said, you need to understand the background, the history between Paul and the Church at Corinth.
- You see between Paul’s first letter to the Corinth Church and this letter (2 Corinthians), he wrote another letter called the sever letter. A letter we don’t currently have a copy of, but we know he wrote it because he tells us he did right here in Chapter 7.
  - That letter was a very harsh letter written to correct the poor behavior of this fellowship, and when Paul wrote it, he gave it to Titus to carry to the Church at Corinth, and then to read it to them as well.
  - Based on Paul’s on words, we know he didn’t know how it would be received; it could be bad, or it could be good. And so, he wrote the letter and sent it with Titus. But it’s been sometime, and he hasn’t heard back from him. And so, you could say he has been anxiously awaiting Titus’ response.
    - And then finally he meets up with Titus in Macedonia, and fortunately for Paul, Titus brings him good news. He tells him that the church received Paul’s letter of exhortation, his rebuke, and they repented and turned back to God. And as

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you can see by Paul's own writings, he received great comfort.

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- Welcome back to our study of 2 Corinthians the 7th Chapter. Last week we ended our teaching by finishing up verses 8-12.
  - In those verses we read where Paul shifted the tone of his writings, where He moved from that of a negative or corrective type of writing to more of a positive or encouraging writing.
    - And why was that? Well it was because of the words of Titus, his disciple and protege.
  - If you remember, Paul had previously written a letter to the church of Corinth, a letter known as the "severe letter". And as we have come to learn, it was known as the severe letter due to its harshness and severity of tone.
  - And as it is with most of Paul's writings, he wrote that letter trying to correct the church's behavior. And so once the letter was complete he gave it to Titus, and Titus hand delivered it to the Church of Corinth.
    - Obviously this Had to be the case, since there was no FedEx, UPS, text or email - or any planes, trains and or automobiles.
    - So, Titus walked the letter to the church, which meant Paul had to wait to hear back from him.
  - And sure enough finally, after a very long wait, Paul meets up with Titus in a town known as Macedonia.
    - And when Titus arrives he delivers Paul some good news. He let Paul know that the church had received the letter and they responded accordingly.
    - They repented and changed their behavior.
    - And not only did they repent, they also dealt with the individual inside the church who was causing all the problems.
- It was at that point, that the tone of Paul's writings shifted here in the 7th Chapter of 2 Corinthians from that of a negative tone to that of a positive one.
  - Now, in an effort to bring us back up to speed and to stay in context, I want us to back up re-read Verses 8-12 from last week, and from there we will proceed forward into the last half of Chapter 7 and then progress into Chapter 8. And here is what Paul said:

2 Cor. 7:8 **For though I caused you sorrow by my letter, I do not regret it; though I did regret it—*for* I see that that letter caused you sorrow, though only for a while—**
2 Cor. 7:9 **I now rejoice, not that you were made sorrowful, but that you were made sorrowful to *the point of* repentance; for you were made sorrowful according to *the will of* God, so that you might not suffer loss in anything through us.**
2 Cor. 7:10 **For the sorrow that is according to *the will of* God produces a repentance without regret, *leading* to salvation, but the sorrow of the world produces death.**
2 Cor. 7:11 **For behold what earnestness this very thing, this godly sorrow, has**

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produced in you: what vindication *of yourselves,* what indignation, what fear, what longing, what zeal, what punishment of wrong! In everything you demonstrated yourselves to be innocent in the matter.
2 Cor. 7:12 **So although I wrote to you, *it was* not for the sake of the offender nor for the sake of the one offended, but that your earnestness in our behalf might be made known to you in the sight of God.**

- I won't go back over what all we studied pertaining to these verses, only to say that Paul made it clear; He was sorrowful about what he wrote, how it caused them pain, but not really because the letter accomplished its intended purpose.
  - Which was what? That they repent and dealt with the man inside their fellowship who was causing all the issues.
  - The man who was telling them that Paul wasn't an Apostle, that he didn't have Apostolic powers and therefore they shouldn't listen to him.
    - I won't elaborate too much on this only to say I have been involved in church for many years, and on a few occasions, I have dealt with this same type of person. Someone who is always stirring up trouble inside the fellowship – baseless trouble I might add.
    - And let me be clear, sometimes things must be dealt with from a church leadership standpoint. That's not what I am talking about.
    - I am talking about an individual who stirs up trouble because that's what makes them tick – they love it and they feed off of it.
  - And as I said, I have dealt with this myself a few times. Matter a fact, when we started this church we had an individual doing this very thing week in and week out.
    - He was constantly trying to catch me making a mistake as it related to what I taught. This was extremely taxing and irritating to say the least.
    - Having said that I will say, through much prayer and patience (which is a miracle in and of itself for me to have patience) God handled it.
    - And He also taught me something, which was to be prepared to study and know what I was teaching, to not take it lightly. And that's what I did.
- Anyways, God handled this individual in our church, and let me say that at the core of what this man was all about, it really simply boiled down to pride – this person had an agenda and he was determined to push it through to completion.
  - I later on found out he had done the same thing in other churches by the way, and he also tried to get others on board with him as well. Which is always the case as "Misery loves company". And why? Because that person always needs support, to feed their ego and keep the narrative going.
    - And let me just remind the church, if you don't feed into someone when they try and cause dissension they will eventually either conform or leave. So when someone tries to cause trouble, be the one to stamp it out.
- Next we move into verses 13-16 where Paul writes the following:

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2 Cor. 7:13 Because of this, we have been comforted. And besides our comfort, we rejoiced even much more for the joy of Titus, because his spirit has been refreshed by you all.
2 Cor. 7:14 For if I have boasted to him about you regarding anything, I was not put to shame. But as we spoke all things to you in truth, so also our boasting before Titus proved to be *the* truth.
2 Cor. 7:15 His affection abounds all the more toward you, as he remembers the obedience of you all, how you received him with fear and trembling.
2 Cor. 7:16 I rejoice that in everything I have confidence in you.

- I'll try and paraphrase this section for you real quick: Paul writes that once they received the good news the church repented. He and the other disciples were comforted, and they also received joy because they saw in Titus that his spirit had been refreshed by the church's reaction to Paul's letter.
    - This is another truth of scripture – You and I have in our possession the ability to bring a refreshing into the life of another believer.
        - In other words when someone gets down, we have the ability to lift them up. And we can do that through the way we act and/or react to life's difficulties.
    - Follow me here for just a moment because of how this church reacted to Paul's "Severe Letter", which was to repent and to change their ways, Titus' spirit was refreshed.
        - Another way to say it is he had some of his faith in humanity restored. Their reaction gave him hope and gave him strength to carry on.
        - This also happens when we share our hardships and struggles with other believers as well, especially in times of their own personal trial and tribulation.
    - You see, when we recall, reflect and testify to the goodness of God – specifically as it relates to "His Mercy and Grace", how he brought us through whatever it was – that testimony always has a way of lifting people up.
        - And so, just remember that because part of the church's responsibility – Part of your responsibility as a believer – is to lift up your brothers and sisters and to refresh each other's spirit.
        - And as I said, one of the best ways to do that is through our own testimony – by recounting what God has done for us, and/or what he did for another brother or sister – the gift of our testimony is a gift we should always bestow on another individual.
        - So remember that and be sure to share it and don't hold it in!
- Next, finishing with verse 14-16, Paul says he boasted about them, that he had confidence in them. Essentially what he was saying was, I knew you would do the right thing and that's what I told Titus.
    - And so the sense here is that he told Titus that they would repent, and when they did he was relieved, all because what he said would happen, happened.
    - Many times, we too can find this same type of relief or solace when we tell

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someone that God will not leave them nor forsake them (even though they themselves may not be able to see that in the moment), but then sure enough God shows up and does exactly what we said he would do.

- I find this especially true when someone is going through a very difficult time. Maybe something that I've never gone through. Let me say in those times the best thing to say is either A) Nothing at all or B) Simply say "I can't imagine what you are going through"
- In those times, it's best to refrain from trying to connect with their pain as if you understand their situation or circumstance.
- When we do this it almost always comes off manufactured, fake and/or disingenuous. And that's almost always the case even if you aren't trying to be fake or disingenuous. Even if you are trying to be sincere!

- Instead of trying to make a connection, just simply say "I can't imagine what you are going through, can I pray with you?" And then when you pray ask God to give them peace – a peace that will eventually lead to understanding.
  - You can also say, "I don't know where all this is going, but I do know that God is still on his throne and that He loves you. And that He is doing something even in this tragedy, and in time He will reveal the purpose behind all of this."
- And for us when He reveals it that's when we can rejoice and find confidence in the Lord. That's when you can use that situation as a testimony to lift someone else up and refresh their spirit. That's the sense of what Paul is saying here.

- Moving on into Chapter 8 my NASB entitles this next section "Generosity Commended". I want you to listen to what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 8:1 Now, brothers *and sisters,* we make known to you the grace of God which has been given in the churches of Macedonia,
2 Cor. 8:2 that in a great ordeal of affliction their abundance of joy and their deep poverty overflowed in the wealth of their liberality.
2 Cor. 8:3 For I testify that according to their ability, and beyond their ability, *they gave* voluntarily,
2 Cor. 8:4 begging us with much urging for the favor of participation in the support of the saints,
2 Cor. 8:5 and *this,* not as we had expected, but they first gave themselves to the Lord and to us by the will of God.
2 Cor. 8:6 So we urged Titus that as he had previously made a beginning, so he would also complete in you this gracious work as well.
2 Cor. 8:7 But just as you excel in everything, in faith, speaking, knowledge, and in all earnestness and in the love we inspired in you, *see* that you also excel in this gracious work.
2 Cor. 8:8 I am not saying *this* as a command, but as proving, through the earnestness of others, the sincerity of your love as well.
2 Cor. 8:9 For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though He was rich, yet for your sake He became poor, so that you through His poverty might

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become rich.

- In these verses Paul makes another shift. He moves from boasting about the confidence he had in the church of Corinth, to encouraging them to be like their church brothers and sisters to the north, the churches in Macedonia.
  - He encourages them to emulate these churches in a very specific way, as it pertains to their generosity, to their giving!
  - In these next several verses Paul is going to paint a picture for us, a picture of what I call a foundational truth or principal of God as it relates to giving.
  - Beginning with verses 1-3 Paul says:

2 Cor. 8:1 **Now, brothers *and sisters,* we make known to you the grace of God which has been given in the churches of Macedonia,**
2 Cor. 8:2 **that in a great ordeal of affliction their abundance of joy and their deep poverty overflowed in the wealth of their liberality.**
2 Cor. 8:3 **For I testify that according to their ability, and beyond their ability, *they gave* voluntarily,**

- Let me break this down for you. In verse 1 Paul says “we make known to you the grace of God which has been given in the churches of Macedonia”.
  - And then he ties God’s Grace back to their giving in verses 2&3 when he says, “That in a great ordeal of affliction their abundance of joy and their deep poverty overflowed in the wealth of their liberality”
  - Let me say this before getting started on this topic this morning, first of all we are coming up on our 10-year anniversary in this church.
    - And when we started this church there were a couple of foundational principals that I started with.
    - First of all I said, I would never preach or teach in a topical format. More specifically, I wouldn’t come up with some topic, brought on by a personal agenda, and use the scriptures to back up my point. This is called eisegeting the scriptures – and I wont do that.
    - Instead I committed to always exegete the scriptures, which is a style of teaching or preaching that begins with the Bible as the basis or foundation for the teaching and lets the word of God teach you, or speak to you and tell you what you need to know.
    - And why teach this way? Because one method is riddled with Man’s opinion and the other with God's.
- And so, for 10 years I have taught the Bible – Book by book, Chapter by Chapter, verse by verse – rightly dividing the word of truth.
  - That’s what the Pastor teacher is supposed to do, nothing more nothing less. And so in keeping with this concept of not teaching topically, I certainly wasn’t going to push people to give – I wouldn’t even mention it unless I came across it in the

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teaching.

- Over the past 10 years I don't think we have talked about giving or tithing more than maybe once or twice. And today you can rest easy knowing that just because we have landed on this topic here in 2 Corinthians I am not going to wear you out about it and make up for the lack of teaching on this topic over the last 10 years.
  - Instead, I am going to do what I always do and that is teach you about this topic.
  - Now what is interesting is this topic has come up a lot over the past several weeks. And for a few reasons, but obviously because of our potential move into a new facility, my position on this topic is still the same as it has always been.

- I believe the lack of what appears to be Spiritual Maturity revolving around this topic of giving has less to do with immaturity and more to do with a conflict with God's Word.
  - Let me try and explain. Yes it is true that giving is a test of the heart, of faith and trust in the Lord.
  - But God's word is very clear on debt.

Proverbs 22:7 **The rich rules over the poor,**
And the borrower *becomes* the lender's slave.

Romans 13:8 **Owe nothing to anyone except to love one another; for he who loves his neighbor has fulfilled *the* law.**

- God said, the borrower is slave to the lender, that we are to owe no man nothing but to love him. And yet, the church makes a decision to take out a loan and place itself deep in debt, sometimes for millions of dollars.
  - And so I believe the conflict that arises from a giving campaign, has less to do with a lack of Spiritual Maturity, and more to do with a conflict brought on by working opposite of God's Word.
  - Now, I am sure I will get lots of fan mail if this message reaches Pastors and church leaders around the world. But let me remind you, "I am not making the news - I'm simply reporting it".
    - Also let me say, this is just me, but I am not sure why a church with 300, 400, 500 and upwards of a 1000 people couldn't just raise the money without going into debt.
    - Follow me here, if God says don't be in debt and yet the church feels like they need to build a building for the purposes of doing more work for the kingdom, then couldn't God provide the financial resources needed, through the people, to build the facilities?
    - I would say He could. The difference really lies in our patience and our trust in Him.
  - If you want to really know if God wants you to build a new church facility or add on to an existing one, just gather the people together, and pray and ask God to provide the money through the people.

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        - If you can't raise the money on the front end, then guess what, that's probably a pretty good sign you aren't suppose build it.
        - For a real life confirmation of this, I have a good friend who moved to Tullahoma a few years ago. And when he moved here and joined a local fellowship, the church he joined, started a building campaign.
        - And I remember him being bothered by it. He told me that when he lived in another part of the state the church he grew up in decided to build a new facility, but instead of going into debt the church decided to do what I call a "reverse giving" program. Reverse in the sense that it went against traditional thinking.
        - His church decided to ask people to pray and commit to giving toward a new building, but they wouldn't go into debt – people would pray and give up front, and once they raised the money, when they reached their goal, then they would build.
    - I can't remember all the details except to say it was roughly 20 years ago, and they weren't a super large church, but they raised roughly 2 million dollars without borrowing a dime.
    - What a novel concept! Just pray and ask God to provide the harvest much like a farmer praying for rain!
- Anyways, this topic of giving is a touchy one, and as I said it has come up a lot over the last several weeks. But I do believe I have done our fellowship a disservice in a sense as it relates to giving – I have kind of suppressed the issue, and in suppressing it I have denied people the ability to understand the principals behind Giving.
    - Specifically, why does God require us to give, or tithe? Is it because He is broke and He needs your money, or is there a deeper Spiritual Truth at play?
        - Does it have more to do with you and less to do with him?
        - Let me start out by saying, nowhere in scripture is the concept of giving to get, ever taught.
    - But the scriptures do paint a picture where when someone gives, the result is they receive.
    - Some might say, well Pastor isn't that the same thing? The answer is no – because many times what the individual receives in return isn't financial.
        - That's what we see here in 2 Corinthians with Paul's writings. Let's look at it again:

2 Cor. 8:1 **Now, brothers *and sisters,* we make known to you the grace of God which has been given in the churches of Macedonia,**
2 Cor. 8:2 **that in a great ordeal of affliction their abundance of joy and their deep poverty overflowed in the wealth of their liberality.**
2 Cor. 8:3 **For I testify that according to their ability, and beyond their ability, *they gave* voluntarily,**

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- In verse 2, we clearly see three things at play here:
  - First, this church is poor (deep poverty). Which is not poor like we think of poor, they were poor in the sense of starvation poor. And yet, they gave liberally.
    - It doesn't say how much they gave, just liberally (sacrificially). The sense is that they gave more than they should.
    - And the result was what? They had an abundance of joy. Not money – Joy.
  - And I can tell you that there is something supernatural going on here, because from the world's point of view, they shouldn't be deeply poor and filled with an abundance of joy at the same time.
- Well there is a "Spiritual Principal or Law" in play here, and it has nothing to do with money but everything to do with obedience.
  - The joy we receive from giving revolves around obedience. It's not the giving that brings the joy (although that can be the case), it's the act of obeying God, pleasing Him.
    - Which makes sense when you line that concept up against scripture. Listen to what 1 Samuel 15:22 says about this very thing:

1 Samuel 15:22 **Samuel said,**
"Has the LORD as much delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices
As in obeying the voice of the LORD?
Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice,
***And* to heed than the fat of rams.**

- Here we see the principal of obedience explained in detail: it's not about the sacrifice itself, it's about the obedience. And obedience is a faith, a trust and a heart issue.
  - Do we really think God needs our money? It's already His, and so obviously money and possessions mean nothing to God.
    - Yes money is part of our financial echo system – by definition money is simply a medium of exchange. Meaning it's just an instrument we use to exchange goods and services, least of which is for food and shelter.
  - Money is also cyclical by design, meaning it was never meant to be hoarded up.
    - On the contrary, it was meant to be used as an instrument. Primarily as an instrument of blessing to others!
- Let me close with this, over the next week or so I am going to teach you this concept of giving and tithing but not in the way you might think.
- And certainly not for the purposes of giving to get or for the purposes of going into debt for the kingdom.
  - But rather for the purposes of showing how God views giving, and more specifically, how giving relates to your contentment and joy on this planet as you live out all the remaining days of your life
    - Amen – Amen !

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- Good morning, guys and welcome back to our study of 2 Corinthians. Last week we finished Chapter 7, where we read (what was) a shift in the tone of Paul's writings, a shift from that of (what one might call) a negative tone to that of a positive one. That shift was brought on by the report Paul received from Titus.
    - Remember, Titus was a protégé and disciple of Paul, and Paul chose him to deliver a letter, a previous letter that he wrote to the church at Corinth, a letter known as the "severe letter".
    - Scholars called it the severe letter due to its perceived severity or harshness of tone. If you remember, Paul wrote this letter as a letter of correction, in an effort to correct this church's behavior. And yes, this church and even churches today misbehave. I think a better word than misbehave would be they were losing their way, getting off track, losing focus.
        - And so, Paul wrote this letter in a last-ditch effort, trying to bring them back into focus, into alignment. And then as we learned, Titus hand-delivered the letter to this fellowship in Corinth.
- But here's a question for you? What would cause a church to wander, to get off track in the first place? Honestly, it usually happens when someone inside the fellowship begins to think or hypothesize. Think or hypothesize about what they think might be a good idea, or what they think might be a better way to do ministry, or, even worse, when they think they know what God meant (a different interpretation).
    - And as I said, this is always brought about when our mind begins to ponder or think or hypothesize. And once those thoughts take hold, it's at that point we begin to drift and wander. We lose our focus on "The Northern Star".
        - I use the Northern Star as a reference point because it is a point in the sky that never moves. Well, it moves a little, but in a circle. The Northern Star is a focal point, and it creates a visual destination, and as long we stay focused on it and continue to walk toward it, we will never lose our way.
    - Now, this concept or idea (if you will), applies to just about everything in life, business, career, health, marriage, family, etc. And what's interesting is, it's a really easy concept to understand, yet a very difficult one to maintain for a long period of time. But why? Why is it hard to maintain?
        - Because we are human, and even the most focused of individuals tend to wander.
        - The best illustration of this Northern Star concept comes when we imagine walking outside at night and you see the Northern Star in the sky.
- The Northern Star is this stationary, immovable object. And because it never moves, you can depend on it, which means you can trust it and you can focus on it and know as you walk toward it you will never lose your way. That eventually you will end up at your destination.
    - And so, as I said, this is a simple concept to understand. But if that's the case, then why, (if this is the case), do people lose their way so easily? It's because as you walk, the ground you are walking on is moving. Follow me here.
    - The Northern Star is stationary. Yet the earth is not. The earth moves, which means the moment you take your eyes off the Northern Star, you begin to drift ever so

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slightly in a different direction, because you lose your focal point.

- Now from a real-life application standpoint, what is our Northern Star (if we are Christians)? It's Jesus and His teachings - His word. And so, if that's the case, then how do we as believers, and then by extension the church, how do we get off track? Through abandonment! By abandoning the disciplines and directions of our Lord and Savior.
    - Generally speaking, it's usually the shiny things of life that start the process. It could be a new set of friends, ones who may not be believers. It could be a new house, a new hobby, a new passion or interest of some sort, it could be sports. Whatever it is, it always starts out innocent in seemingly minor and or minuscule ways, but then gains strength, slowly growing into something bigger.
- Now, as I studied this concept of wandering or straying off track, my mind immediately went to the Book of James. Listen to what James had to say about his very thing:

James 1:15 Then when lust has conceived, it gives birth to sin; and when sin is accomplished, it brings forth death.
James 1:16 Do not be deceived, my beloved brethren.
James 1:17 Every good thing given and every perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of lights, with whom there is no variation or shifting shadow.
James 1:18 In the exercise of His will He brought us forth by the word of truth, so that we would be a kind of first fruits among His creatures.

- I won't belabor this point, other than to say, James says - "when lust is conceived" - which by the way, starts with the eyes (1 John 2:15), which then gives way to a thought of the mind, and when lust is conceived, it gives birth. Birth to what? Sin! And then sin leads to what? Death.
    - And let me just say this. This isn't just talking about people who aren't saved, or those who died in unbelief and therefore will not inherit eternal life. No, this death can take place as you live and breathe on this earth. Is your marriage falling apart? Go back to the beginning.
    - Remember when it was at its best? Was God in the picture? Were you living your life to please him, or where were you living your life to please you?
        - It's always, at least for believers, that things were great until they weren't, and the 'until they weren't' part of that equation has a direct correlation to the abandonment of commands, which includes the forsaking of his people (the assembly - the church).
        - And it all starts with the eyes, then evolves into a thought, and then when fully conceived, gives way to sin, and then sin to death. It may not be actual death, but death of marriage or career or relationship or whatever. Now, based on our analysis of how this happens, you might think preventing this wandering from happening would be easy, right?
    - I mean, just stay focused. Don't take your eyes off the Northern Star. But the reality is, it's extremely difficult to do, because as I said, once again, we are human, and according to scientific research, the average human can only focus for roughly 15-20

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minutes. Not sure what that means for me, but anyway. You get the point.

- Now this fact, when you think about it it's somewhat discouraging, because as Christians we have to focus for a real long time. “A lifetime”. Right, we must focus for life. Paul gives us a sense of this very thing and his own struggles all throughout his writings. One example of which shows up in Philippians 3:14, when he says,

Philippians 3:14 I press on toward the goal for the prize of the upward call of God in Christ Jesus.

- Even in the Old Testament we hear the same thing. Joshua 1:9 says,

Joshua 1:9 “Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous! Do not tremble or be dismayed, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go.”

- And these are just a couple of places (among many) with that same thing over and over and over again. And so, this is important for us to realize, because knowledge is power, and when we understand that the only way we stand a chance, that our marriage stands a chance, that our children stand a chance, is to stay focused.
  - All we need to do is double down and do it, and never compromise. Discipline and dedication to the Northern Star is what is required to stay on track. But dedication and discipline to what? Well, for one answer let’s look at what Paul wrote in the book of Acts when he said the following:

Acts 2:41 So then, those who had received his word were baptized; and that day there were added about three thousand souls.
Acts 2:42 They were continually devoting themselves to the apostles’ teaching and to fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to prayer.

- The most important words in all these verses (at least as it relates to our study today) are the words “continually devoting”. The Greek combination of these words is (pros-kar-ter-eh'-o). It’s a verb and it means:
  - 4342 */proskarteréō* means "to continue to do something with intense effort, with the possible implication of despite difficulty – 'to devote oneself to, to keep on, to persist in'" (*L & N*, 1, 68.68).]
  - So, what is it that they were doing? They were devoting themselves. First to the Apostle’s teaching, second to fellowship, and third & fourth to the breaking of bread and to prayer. There is your recipe for staying on track and never losing your focus:
    - Study of God’s Word
    - Fellowship
    - Breaking of Bread, which is just another form of fellowship.
    - Prayer

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- And guess what, that is not what the church at Corinth was doing, and the result was they lost their way because some individual joined their church and began to think, and the result was he helped ease them off track.
- And so, Paul wrote them a letter, the severe letter, all in a last-ditch effort to get them back on track. And what was the result? It worked. They repented. It worked and Titus, just now here in 2 Corinthians 7, has reported this very thing. Which is what caused Paul to make a shift or change in the tone of his writing.
- And from there Paul also does something else. And what does he do? He not only shifts the tone of his writings, but he also shifts the topic of his writing. And here's what we read last week, moving on to Chapter 8. My NASB entitles this next section, 'Generosity Commended' - and I want you to listen to what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 8:1 **Now, brothers *and sisters,* we make known to you the grace of God which has been given in the churches of Macedonia,**
2 Cor. 8:2 **that in a great ordeal of affliction their abundance of joy and their deep poverty overflowed in the wealth of their liberality.**
2 Cor. 8:3 **For I testify that according to their ability, and beyond their ability, *they gave* voluntarily,**
2 Cor. 8:4 **begging us with much urging for the favor of participation in the support of the saints,**
2 Cor. 8:5 **and *this,* not as we had expected, but they first gave themselves to the Lord and to us by the will of God.**
2 Cor. 8:6 **So we urged Titus that as he had previously made a beginning, so he would also complete in you this gracious work as well.**
2 Cor. 8:7 **But just as you excel in everything, in faith, speaking, knowledge, and in all earnestness and in the love we inspired in you, *see* that you also excel in this gracious work.**
2 Cor. 8:8 **I am not saying *this* as a command, but as proving, through the earnestness of others, the sincerity of your love as well.**
2 Cor. 8:9 **For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though He was rich, yet for your sake He became poor, so that you through His poverty might become rich.**

- Last week I told you guys about how it was that I don't preach topically. I teach through the Bible - book by book, word by word, verse by verse, and chapter by chapter. Which means I only teach you what comes up in the text of scripture. In the 10-year existence of this church, I have probably only touched lightly on the topic of giving maybe once or twice, and even then, it was brief.
  - But as I said last week, with the new opportunity of moving locations, which by the way, just came about roughly three weeks ago. With that opportunity presenting itself, the topic of giving has come up quite a bit (and not just from me).
  - Many have been concerned, and rightly so, for obvious reasons, because in this new facility we will have some expenses. But still nothing major, because we won't be

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going into debt for this building, which we can thank God for.

- What's interesting is, if you didn't know better, you would think I somehow timed last week and this week's lessons in conjunction with the consideration of this facility. But we know that's not the case, because A) Well, I don't plan that far ahead for anything, and B) I'm really not that smart, and C) As everyone knows, we teach through the Bible.

- Therefore, since we started 2 Corinthians in January, it would have been really hard to have planned the teachings in conjunction with a building that wouldn't come on the market until some nine months later. And so that leaves only one answer, which is it was God's Sovereign decree. He planned it that way.
  - Anyway, so last week I told you I want to teach about giving from a Biblical standpoint, and along with that I want to debunk some of the myths surrounding this controversial topic.
  - Now, before we begin, let me start out by saying I have a deep-rooted disdain for preachers and churches who push giving or tithing as a means of receiving. And why? Because I assure you, that teaching is not a teaching of scripture. Having said that, there are times when you will receive a financial blessing after giving.
  - But I submit to you, the giving itself was not the reason you received the blessing. It was your obedience to God's word which brought the blessing. I will also tell you, if God so chooses to return a financial blessing back to you, it's not so you can buy more stuff. It's so you can bring more honor and glory to Him! Another way to say it is, if God trusts you with finances He will bless you in that area of your life, all so that you can return those blessings back to the Kingdom. And that is the testimony of scripture.
    - And just to back up what I am saying as it relates to giving verses obedience, specifically which one is the most important, I want to back up and re-read what I read you last week regarding this topic. One more time, 1 Samuel 15:22 says this,

1 Samuel 15:22 **Samuel said,**
"Has the LORD as much delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices
As in obeying the voice of the LORD?
Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice,
***And* to heed than the fat of rams.**

- Here in 1 Samuel, we clearly see that our obedience is what God is after. It's not about the sacrifice itself, it's about obedience. And just remember, obedience is a faith, a trust, and a heart issue.
  - And honestly, when you stop to think about it that makes sense, because do we really think God needs our money? Seriously, it's already His. It's not ours, we are simply tending to it for a time, and then it moves on to someone else. In reality, we don't actually own anything.
    - We think we do, but we don't. We are just sharecroppers at best, someone who lives on the land, tends to it, makes a living off it, but doesn't actually own it.

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Because as I said, eventually it transfers to someone else. Money is simply a tool, a means for our survival, it's temporary, and we are to use it as we wait for the Lord's return to our permanent home.

- Now, let me say one more thing before we move on this morning. Giving is nothing more than a form of sacrifice, and just like other sacrifices in the Old Testament, it's a requirement. And it's important to remember, one sacrifice does not offset another. Meaning, if you sacrifice in one way, say with your time, that doesn't offset the requirement of your tithe sacrifice.
    - Let me explain what I mean. In the Old Testament there were five main types of sacrifices. Three were voluntary and two were mandatory. The Burnt offering, the Grain offering, and the Peace offering were all voluntary.
    - Time doesn't permit this morning, but next week we are going to touch on why there were voluntary sacrifices versus mandatory, along with the purpose and benefits of both, because it's important, and you're going to want to hear it - I promise.
    - And so, the first three were voluntary and the final two were mandatory, and those mandatory sacrifices were the Sin offering and the Trespass offering. And each one of these sacrifices had a specific purpose, and as I said earlier, one didn't offset the other.
        - And the same is true for your tithe to your local church. This is important because sometimes I will hear people say, " Well, I don't give, but I give of my time", or "I don't tithe but I donated XYZ to some charity organization", or "I gave some of my old clothes to goodwill, or I cleaned out my pantry and gave some food to whatever organization takes food.
        - If that's your thinking, you would be incorrect because that's not how it works.
- Now, as I said at the onset of our teaching, I don't just want to teach you about giving from a Biblical perspective, I also want to debunk some myths about this subject as well. And let me start with a couple of misunderstandings on this topic.
    - One, I am required to give 10%. That is not the case. That is an Old Testament teaching. The New Testament teaching says we are to give as we've been blessed, which is interesting in and of itself.
        - Personally, I like the 10% requirement. That way I don't have to think about it. But in the New Testament God changed it, which means you do have to think about it. This type of giving requires you to listen to your heart and examine all the ways you've been blessed, and then give based on that conviction.
        - That's a little bit tougher than just simply giving 10%, don't you think? (I'll touch on this next week as well).
    - The second myth I would like to debunk is, if I give to another organization other than my church then that fulfills my tithe requirement to my local fellowship. Just like the first myth, this also would not be the case.
        - Now this may step on some toes, but let me remind you once again, I'm not making the news I am simply reporting, and I will always back up what I am saying from the pages of scripture. Also let me say, just from a purely pragmatic and logical standpoint, does that make sense?
- Please hear my heart on this, because I am not being smart. If tithing to the local church

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that you attend is a requirement, then God must have had a reason that he wanted us to do it, right? And if that's the case, then how could we give to another organization and think that would fulfill the requirement of tithing to our local fellowship?

- In other words, if there is a reason God asks you to support the church you attend, then how could giving somewhere else fulfill that same need? It couldn't! Easy now preacher. Guys, one more time, giving is between you and God. It has zero to do with me. I don't know what people give and never will.
- But, if we really want to understand giving and the tithe principal, then we must start out with the why, as in why God commanded us to give to our local fellowship in the first place? And why was it? Well, there are at least two reasons.
  - First - Because God said so, and it's a test of your obedience/faith and trust in Him. And then second, because He wants us as believers to support the church we attend.
  - But why? Well, it's actually not for the reasons you may think or for the reasons you may have been taught. For most of us, we've been taught that we should support our ministers and take care of facilities and various programs.
  - And although, yes, this is correct to a point, this concept has been abused and has really lost its way. For example, nowhere in scripture does it say, or for that matter, do we see a Pastor who was paid to work at the church and that was his only occupation.

- Now some might say hold on preacher, nowhere in the scriptures were there a lot of things. There were no church buses, gyms, church league softball teams, organs, pianos, or air conditioning. But I don't hear you complaining about those items. This is true but hear my heart one more time.
  - I'm not complaining about a pastor or music guy, or youth guy being paid. I'm not. I'm simply telling you there were no pastors in the New Testament scriptures who received their full compensation from the church.
    - As a matter of fact, the concept of a fully compensated staff is a fairly new concept, relatively speaking, at least as it relates to the history of mankind. This actually only became a thing in the last, what, 50 to 60 years (at least as a common or standard practice).
  - I will say this though, there's has been a lot of good come from men and women who were paid full-time ministers. But having said that, I'm not a fan of it. And why? Because it changed the entire dynamic of church and let me explain what I mean.
- The biblical structure (organization chart) of the Church is this: you have Elders, older men who lead the church from an administrative standpoint, then you have Deacons, younger men who attend to the needs of the people in the fellowship, the widows as well as other needs.
  - And you have a Pastor/Teacher, who is also an Elder, but who is gifted to teach. The Bible tells us the church is to be run by a plurality of Elders, meaning more than one. And then of course, last but certainly not least, we have the women. They are to serve and teach and lead and guide the younger women.
  - This is the Biblical structure of the Church, and what you will find when you study this structure, which shows up in the Pastoral Epistles - 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy. and

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Titus; what you will find is that the Pastor is not the CEO, nor is he the one who does everything.

- The Church of the Bible is a church full of people who all work, which means if the work and responsibilities are all delegated out, then you don't need one or two or three people receiving an exorbitant pay. Pay, by the way, that sometimes exceeds the pay of the average church member.
    - And why? Because the ministers aren't doing all the work. Everyone is involved. But guess what? That's exactly opposite of what the church has evolved into today, and that dynamic is not good for two reasons:
        - One, it robs you (the believer and member) of the opportunity and responsibility of contributing to the fellowship, participating in the work of the ministry. And two, it puts an unrealistic expectation on the Pastor/Teacher, which is why so many of these guys are quitting ministry. They can't handle it.
        - Also, let me say the majority of ministries happen on the highways and the byways of life as we go about our day. It's not in church, at least as it relates to the outside world. And so, for the Pastor to be out among the people is extremely important.
    - But that is not necessarily the case anymore because man had a better way, and as we know, we are smarter than God, so we helped Him out and fixed it, and the result is churches are dying and Christians are weak because they never mature, and they never really get in the game.
    - All because we set our churches up much like going to the movies. You buy your ticket/you pay your tithe, and you attend and wait to be entertained. And let me say this, no one elected me the foremost authority on this topic, I am simply a man and a Pastor/Teacher who has observed this church thing for almost 30 years, and then said to myself, what's the deal?
        - Something's not right. And then, because it bothered me, I went and studied it for myself to find that these things might be true. You know, like what the Bereans did in the Book of Acts.
- And let me say one more thing before we close. For all those people who say, well you're just saying that because you're not full-time in a church. To you I say, "O contraire mon frere". You would be incorrect! Let me be clear, if that was what God called me to do, that's where I would be.
    - I remember one time several years ago, someone said to me, "I heard you are a preacher."
    - I said, "that is correct". They said, "so you are bi-vocational"? I said, "I am". And they said, "ahh, that's good". The sense was, ahh isn't that cute. You get to act like a real preacher. I said, "yeah, I'm bi-vocational, just like Paul, Peter, Stephen, Barnabas, Appolos, John, and drum roll please – JESUS."
        - They all had jobs, including Jesus. There was no such thing as a paid preacher who strictly worked at the local fellowship in the New Testament. There was in the Old Testament, and they were called Priests. And not priests as in the Catholic priests we have today.
- And so, what am I trying to say? Am I saying preachers shouldn't be paid? Nope, not

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saying that at all, but your tithe and God's money was not meant to just pay for preachers or ministers, or for that matter, keeping up extravagant facilities.

- Well then preacher, what was it for? You will have to come back next week to find out. And I promise, if you do, I promise we are going to talk about giving from a Biblical Perspective. Today, I just felt the need to set the stage. And so, let me just close with this.
  - If you struggle with giving. You look at your bill's week in and week out and you say to yourself, well I can pay the light bill, or I can give to the church, do not give out of guilt. Give out of obedience and know God will take care of your every need.
- Remember, I am not speaking to you as a preacher who gets paid. I am speaking to you as a man who has seen the absolute worst of financial times, harder financial times than most people will ever see.
- And if I feel so compelled, maybe I'll tell you a few stories next week. Stories that I assure you will blow your mind. Stories that highlight how God showed up in our lives, financially speaking, when it appeared we were done.

- Let me just tell you that I have been so far down financially speaking, that those closest to me didn't know what to tell me. As a matter of fact, many times people treated me like Job. They said, what have you done to God, because obviously based on your financial condition you have done something.
  - People have said to me (people who loved me by the way), they said God must be punishing you for not doing ministry full-time, which is actually funny when you think about it because there is no such thing as a part-time pastor. They are all full time.
    - But anyway, those are some of the comments I received during my hardest financial times, and honestly, at times I thought to myself, maybe they are correct. But I stand here before you today with the benefit of hindsight to tell you that wasn't the case. God was doing something, preparing me, molding me into what I am now.
    - I will also tell you, once again with the benefit of hindsight, at no time did Daffeny and I ever waver on our giving. There were few times when I thought to myself, oh this is tough. Should I hold out? But we didn't, and we are going to explore all of this over the next several weeks.
- And so, I want to encourage you to be here, because even though we didn't delve into the scriptures on this topic this morning, I am going to get to it and teach about giving from a place that you may have never seen before, and next week will be different. I promise.

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- Alright folks, good morning and welcome back on this beautiful October 1st morning and praise the Lord for the relief from the heat.
    - Last week, we somewhat (kind of, sort of, but not really) delved into the 8th Chapter of the book or letter of 2 Corinthians. I say somewhat because I spent most of the lesson setting up what would be the biblical teaching on giving.
    - Along with that I wanted to debunk a few myths around this topic while also debunking a few myths about the church as well. The reason for this was simple. Once you understand the purpose of the church, specifically the reason God created it, once you understand that it will help clear up a lot of the controversy around the concept of tithing. And shortly, you will see what I am talking about.
        - Anyway, so as I said, our teaching last week turned out to be a little controversial, and the result of that was I received a few phone calls from some "concerned citizens", or maybe we should call them some "concerned believers" regarding some of the things I said.
        - Which is okay. I love mixing it up. It's healthy and I love the fact someone actually listened and then cared enough to call. Having said that, when I asked these "concerned believers" what they believed about what I said, some said not sure, I'll have to study it and get back with you. Some said, I don't know, while others said, well, I'm going to wait to respond and see what you say next week.
        - Well, if that's your response you're in luck, because today is next week and (we made it) and you're going to find out why I said what I said.
- Before we do that though, I will say the responses I received highlight (what I feel) is a bigger and more systemic issue, which is you need to know the why behind why it is you believe what you believe. You see, all believers should adhere to the concept of what Dr. Chuck Missler calls the "Berean Way". And what is the Berean Way?
    - Well let's read about it in Acts 17:10-11:

Acts 17:10 The brothers immediately sent Paul and Silas away by night to Berea, and when they arrived, they went into the synagogue of the Jews.
Acts 17:11 Now these people were more noble-minded than those in Thessalonica, for they received the word with great eagerness, examining the Scriptures daily *to see* whether these things were so.

- So, the Bible says those in Berea were more noble-minded (meaning of higher stature), at least as it relates to their thinking. And why? Because "they received the word with great eagerness (the Greek says - with great readiness), examining the scriptures daily to see whether these things were so."
    - So, what exactly does that mean? It means these folks didn't just take someone's word for it. As a matter of fact, they didn't even take Paul's word for it. Instead, they examined the scriptures daily to find out if what they were being told was in fact the "truth".
    - It was real simple, these folks wanted to know did God say it or did man say it? Which is interesting because that's the whole reason Paul is writing 2 Corinthians in

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the first place. Remember, these folks have gotten off track because they listened to some man, a non-believer, who eased his way into their fellowship and started all this trouble.

- He did so by telling people that Paul wasn't really a true Apostle, that he didn't have Apostolic authority, that he lied to them. And so, rather than listening to Paul and ultimately God's word, they began listening to this man, which then took them down the wrong path. And, by the way, this is still happening today.

- And so, the question is, why? Why are people so susceptible to being led off track? Because people simply don't know what it is they believe. But why is that? Because they aren't being fed. Fed what? Sheep food. And what's sheep food for the believer? It's God's word, which should be administered in healthy doses by the Pastor/Teacher.
  - As a matter of fact, this is the primary job of the Pastor, and this was even highlighted by Jesus Himself when He told Peter this very thing in John 21:15-17:

John 21:15 So when they had finished breakfast, Jesus said to Simon Peter, "Simon, *son* of John, do you love Me more than these?" He said to Him, "Yes, Lord; You know that I love You." He said to him, "Tend (feed) my lambs."
John 21:16 He said to him again a second time, "Simon, *son* of John, do you love Me?" He said to Him, "Yes, Lord; You know that I love You." He said to him, "Shepherd my sheep."
John 21:17 He said to him the third time, "Simon, *son* of John, do you love Me?" Peter was grieved because He said to him the third time, "Do you love Me?" And he said to Him, "Lord, You know all things; You know that I love You." Jesus said to him, "Tend (feed) my sheep.

- And so, Jesus himself says to Peter, if you love me then you will do something. And what was it? FEED/SHEPHARD my sheep. The meaning of the word feed here in the Greek literally means to feed (graze), pasture, just like grazing sheep in a pasture. And so, the fact that the Pastor isn't feeding the sheep is one reason people don't know what they believe.
  - But the other is they aren't studying for themselves so they can "see if these things might be true." This is an issue, and as I said, it's systemic inside the church and it's one that needs to be resolved, because people are confused, and it shouldn't be this way. God left us His word so that we wouldn't be confused, but it's up to us to dig in and receive clarity through the Holy Spirit, and through seeing the consistency of how God operates through the pages of His own memoirs.
  - But how do I know this problem is as bad as I say it is? Because I talk to people all the time about all sorts of Biblical topics. That's how I know. Which, as I said, was highlighted by the conversations I had this past week surrounding last week's teaching.
    - One more thing, just an FYI. Not all the discussions I had this week were with people from our church. Some were with friends and listeners, but still the central theme of our discussions revolved around why do you believe what you believe?

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        - And the overwhelming response that I received from folks when I asked them this question was, well, I can't necessarily give you scriptures to back up what I believe but that's what I have been taught my whole life, and I highly doubt my Pastor would have lied, or for that matter, I highly doubt our entire denomination got it wrong.
    - Pretty scary statement when you stop to think about it, isn't it, and it's one a believer should never make. Remember, when it comes to anything I teach, I always want to remind you, don't take my word for it, instead follow the "Berean Way" - study for yourself and find that these things might be true.
    - That's exactly what I did some 20 years ago. I began studying for myself, all because a Pastor told me something that I discovered was not true. One day, when I asked this man a question relating to baptism, instead of answering my questions from the basis of scripture, he gave me denominational rule.
        - Which, as I discovered, turned out not to line up with the Bible. It was actually right the opposite of what the scriptures taught. Which then led me to question everything. It also led me to say, well, if he was wrong on that issue then what else might he be wrong about?
    - And so, I began to study, and I was shocked with what I discovered. The more I dug in and questioned, the more I found what I call denominational preference, or plain old tradition. Tradition turned out to be more important than what the Bible taught, which obviously was an issue.
- Now having said that, let me also say all of these denominational preferences started out the same way, with good intent. But unfortunately, many of them ended up in the same place. Which was where? In no-man's land. And in some cases, not all cases, but in some, It actually turned into Hersey. And what is Heresy? It is a teaching that teaches or twists what God's word says, and in its place blends or meshes it into what the church or denomination prefers it to say.
    - So, my word to you is, believer beware because many of the current church's practices and traditions of today are not grounded in truth of scripture. Now in keeping with the spirit of the "Berean Way", let me say, I said something last week that was incorrect (I know that's a shock but it's true).
    - And so, for that reason, I want to speak a retraction (if that's even a thing). And what was it that I said that was wrong? Well, before I tell you let me say, first of all, it didn't have anything to do with the obvious statements I made last week.
        - Statements like giving 10% is not a requirement, that 10% is an Old Testament teaching not a New Testament teaching, or that nowhere in scripture do we see the "give to get" concept being taught. It wasn't one of those out-front obvious statements I made.
    - Also, let me say one more thing, no one brought this mistake to my attention. I caught it myself when I went back through and listened to the teaching. And so, what was it? What was the mistake?
    - It centered around something I said when I quoted Acts 2:41-42. Before I quoted Acts last week, I said let's see what Paul said. The problem is, Paul didn't write Acts. Who wrote Acts? Luke, so that was my mistake. I mentioned Paul as the writer because Paul is mentioned in that particular section of Acts.

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        - And so anyway, I'm proving my own point. I even have to check myself "to see if these things might be true."
- Moving on, so last time we were together I made a few statements, some of which turned out to be a little controversial. And as I said last week, I will always back up what I say with scripture. I also said if you want to hear my proof (from the basis of scripture) then you will have to come back next week, which is this week.
    - This week is here, and before I address those statements, I would like to back up and re-read the opening verses of Chapter 8 for context purposes. And here's what Paul wrote "Great Generosity"

2 Cor. 8:1 **Now, brethren, we *wish to* make known to you the grace of God which has been given in the churches of Macedonia,**
2 Cor. 8:2 **that in a great ordeal of affliction their abundance of joy and their deep poverty overflowed in the wealth of their liberality.**
2 Cor. 8:3 **For I testify that according to their ability, and beyond their ability, *they gave* of their own accord,**
2 Cor. 8:4 **begging us with much urging for the favor of participation in the support of the saints,**
2 Cor. 8:5 **and *this,* not as we had expected, but they first gave themselves to the Lord and to us by the will of God.**
2 Cor. 8:6 **So we urged Titus that as he had previously made a beginning, so he would also complete in you this gracious work as well.**
2 Cor. 8:7 **But just as you abound in everything, in faith and utterance and knowledge and in all earnestness and in the love we inspired in you, *see* that you abound in this gracious work also.**
2 Cor. 8:8 **I am not speaking *this* as a command, but as proving through the earnestness of others the sincerity of your love also.**
2 Cor. 8:9 **For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though He was rich, yet for your sake He became poor, so that you through His poverty might become rich.**

- As I said, the somewhat controversial statements that I made last week came on the heels of the topic of 'giving'. And as I stated last week, in the 10-year history of this church I don't think I have ever really taught much on the topic of giving. And why? Because I teach book by book, verse by verse, and chapter by chapter, and the topic never came up.
    - But here we are, and in an effort to set the foundation for this section of teaching, I mentioned a few things which were true.
    - First of all, I said the Bible never teaches a concept of 'giving to get', or 'giving to receive'. An extreme example of this being, 'give $10 and you will receive $20' type of thing. I don't think anyone here today subscribes to this line of teaching per se.
    - But I will tell you this is a very prominent teaching inside the church of today, and it is false. As a matter of fact, it is heresy. Remember, as we discussed last week, your

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giving is an obedience issue. God doesn't need your money. He's not broke. But He does ask you to examine your heart and give based on how you have been blessed. And this is the case for at least two reasons:

- 1 – It shows sacrifice and obedience on your part, not to mention it shows the faith and trust you have in Him as well. Also, your giving is what, 2 – supports the fellowship. Now, based on these statements, that led me to say supporting your fellowship is part of God's plan.
- But that doesn't mean the preacher or ministers should receive the bulk of the proceeds given to the church. Let me say this one more time. I'm not against the preacher or ministers being paid, but I do feel since the advent of the preacher receiving his sole compensation from the church, which has constituted what we call a full-time preacher (which is humorous because all preachers are full-time, or at least should be).

  - This full-time preacher concept has caused a lot of issues, specifically as it relates to the rest of the body working and doing their part inside the fellowship. One of the byproducts of this movement is that most folks have simply sat down, and therefore have become spiritually stagnant.
    - And as I have previously stated, this happens because the people feel as if the preacher is the one being paid so he should do the work. Which means, in part, the body doesn't have to work. And once again my friends, that is not the testimony of scripture.

- The Preacher/Pastor/ Teacher is an elder gifted to teach. He has a job - study and shepherd and feed the sheep. He shouldn't be focused or involved in all the other church stuff. And let me say, the Pastor is just one piece of the puzzle. Collectively, the body is to work together and minister to each other first. Take care of each other's needs first and then once they are healthy, the natural biproduct of spiritual health will be to reach outside the walls of the church and have an influence on others.
  - But the church of today has got this backwards. Oh, really preacher? Yes really, and let me prove it to you, and to do that let's go back to where it all began. And where did it all begin? On the day of Pentecost. That was when the church was first formed.

Acts 2:43 Everyone kept feeling a sense of awe; and many wonders and signs were taking place through the apostles.
Acts 2:44 And all the believers were together and had all things in common;
Acts 2:45 and they would sell their property and possessions and share them with all, to the extent that anyone had need.
Acts 2:46 Day by day continuing with one mind in the temple, and breaking bread from house to house, they were taking their meals together with gladness and sincerity of heart,
Acts 2:47 praising God and having favor with all the people. And the Lord was adding to their number day by day those who were being saved.

- Now, you may recognize these verses, but the question is do you recognize what's really

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being identified in these verses? First of all, look really closely at who the subject of these verses is. It's not unbelievers – it's believers.

- Guys, just a side note. The Church was never supposed to look to the world for support. We are to take care of our own. Remember that we should never look to the government or any other outside organization for support. That is the responsibility of our local fellowship.
  - I remember a few years ago having a conversation with a lady whose husband abandoned her. She stayed at home and raised their children. And so, when her husband left, she and her children struggled mightily. The crazy thing is, she was part of a big church. So why didn't the church help her? Why didn't they take care of one of their own?
  - Because we have been programed to look outside the church and spend the church's monies trying to reach the world. Folks this is wrong. We meet the needs of the church first! I digress, but to prove my point, look at how verse 43 starts out. It starts out with 'everyone'.
- This 'everyone' is referring to those who believed, and if you will back up and read the text, you will see that what I am saying is true. So, 'everyone' is believers, and this same theme continues all the way through to verse 47. Look at it, the 'everyone' in verse 43 is speaking to all the believers. Highlighted again in verse 44, when it says they had all things in common.
  - And then in verse 45 it says they would sell their property and possessions, and share them with all, and they would do so, "to the extent that anyone had need." What's happening here is crystal clear. They are taking care of one another, not the outside world.

- Next, moving on to verse 46, it says day by day they continued in one mind. They were also breaking bread – eating together. And then, here is the kicker. They were praising God and finding favor with all the people. This phrase, finding favor with all the people, is a reference to God's people, not the world.
  - But wait preacher, what about outreach? What about sharing the gospel, or what about seeing people saved? What about it? One more time, outreach is a natural biproduct of spiritual health, and it works opposite of what we have seen and been taught in the Church of the 20th and 21st century. Look at verse 47 one more time,

Acts 2:47 praising God and having favor with all the people. And the Lord was adding to their number day by day those who were being saved.

- Who was adding to their fellowship? The Lord was adding to their numbers day by day those who were being saved. It appears that as the fellowship takes care of the needs of one another, and as they praise God, God adds to their fellowship!
  - What? Here's how it works folks. When we are healthy (spiritually speaking) God uses us to draw men to Himself. When we are not healthy, we are sidelined and when we try and skip what it takes to become healthy, and go ahead and commence with "outreach", we do more damage than we do good.
  - And why, because we are trying within ourselves to reproduce the work of the Holy

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Spirit by forcing the end result. And that's the reason we do more harm than good, because we haven't paid the price required for spiritual maturity. And by the way, the world knows this is the case. They see it in our behavior, and when they see it, our behavior actually creates the opposite effect of reaching people for Christ. It pushes them away.

- So, based on the testimony of scripture, we must take care of one another first. Support one another in every way. Not just financial but in all ways, and once we have taken care of one another, and we become mature and healthy, then God will use our lives to reach outside the church walls.

- Now, I realize this might rub you the wrong way and I could spend the rest of the service proving my point to you from the basis of scripture, but I have to move on because I have a few other topics we need to touch on this morning. Having said that, if you are still struggling with this then I encourage you to take a closer look at the church and its structure inside God's holy manuscript and study for yourself so that you can "find that these things might be true".

Moving on, let's conclude our teaching today by talking about the "tithe", And specifically whether or not it is the mandate or requirement of scripture in the New Testament. I told you last week that 10% is not a requirement, but am I correct, or did I just make that up? Let's dig in and see if what I say is true or not?

First of all, let's look at the word tithe; what is it and what does it mean? The word tithe is a Hebrew word that means tenth, and the tithe appears in the Old Testament. Let me be clear, tithing is an Old Testament concept. The tithe was a requirement of the Law, in which the Israelites were to give 10 percent of the crops they grew as well as the livestock they raised to the tabernacle/temple (Leviticus 27:30; Numbers 18:26; Deuteronomy 14:24; 2 Chronicles 31:5).

If you want to get down to the truth of the matter, the Old Testament law actually required multiple tithes, one for the Levites, one for the use of the temple and the feasts, and one for the poor of the land, which would have pushed the total to around 23.3 percent.

Some have understood the Old Testament tithe as a method of taxation to provide for the needs of the priests and Levites in the sacrificial system.

Having said that, after the death of Jesus Christ the Law was fulfilled, and nowhere in the New Testament do we see a command, or even recommendation, for the Christian to submit to a legalistic tithing system. Also, nowhere in the New Testament do we see a designation for a percentage of an individual's income to be set aside as a tithe.

The only thing we see written or mentioned about this topic in the New Testament is that our gifts should be "in keeping with income" (1 Corinthians 16:2). Or, as the NASB says it, we are to give as we have been prospered or blessed.

1 Cor. 16:1-4

1 Now concerning the collection for the saints, as I directed the churches of Galatia, so do you also.

2 On the first day of every week each one of you is to put aside and save, as he may prosper, so that no collections be made when I come.

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3 When I arrive, whomever you may approve, I will send them with letters to carry your gift to Jerusalem;

4 and if it is fitting for me to go also, they will go with me.

Notice Paul didn't collect gifts for himself, he collected them for the poor church in Jerusalem, specifically for the believers in that church to once again help take care of their needs.

Anyway, so some in the Christian church have taken the 10 % figure from the Old Testament tithe and applied it as a "recommended minimum" for Christians in their giving. But that is not a New Testament teaching. Having said that, although no tithe is demanded of the Christian, the New Testament talks about the importance and the benefits of giving.

Once again, we are to give as we are able. Sometimes that means giving more than 10 %, sometimes that may mean giving less. It all depends on the ability of the Christian and the needs of the body of Christ. Once again, we are to take care of each other first.

James tells us that every Christian should diligently pray and seek God's wisdom on this matter, and remembering that above all, offerings should be given with pure motives and an attitude of worship to God and service to the body of Christ.

Paul also says this in 2 Corinthians 9:7 about this topic. "Each man should give what he has decided in his heart to give, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver."

Now, last week I also said I wanted to debunk another myth around giving, and that was, if you give elsewhere, outside your fellowship, can that replace the responsibility you have in giving to your local fellowship/church? I say no, but why?

Well, we just studied how we are to take care of the needs of the body first, then move to the outside world. So, if you give somewhere else outside your fellowship, then how can you help fulfill both the needs of your church and the needs of some other ministry? You can't, but there's nothing keeping you from doing both.

Guys, let me just say this on this topic. If God lays it on your heart to give to someone else, or to give to another ministry, do it, but never look at it as a trade-off. Don't look at it like negotiating with your kids. You know, don't say okay Lord I will give to this other ministry or fulfill this other person's need, but it's one or the other, I can't give to the church and give to this other ministry. So, God you choose, but we can't do both.

That is not how it works. Guys, I wish I could take my experience as it relates to giving and superimpose it into the life of every believer. I wish I could play the movie of my life relating to this topic, specifically for those who struggle with the concept of giving. If I could, I promise you would never worry or even check up on giving again.

I can honestly say this, the more Daffney and I have given throughout the years, the more God has given back to us, which by the way, He expects us to give back again. It's cyclical, and the more we have given the more he has blessed us!

And never forget, everything belongs to God. It's not ours. As I said last week, we are simply "Spiritual Sharecroppers", tending to what God has entrusted us with until either A) He returns, or B) we die. Either way, we can't take it with us.

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Let me say a couple more things on this topic. As I have plainly stated in the past, giving to get is not a thing in God's dichotomy. It's not a teaching of scripture. But when you give, God always returns what you give in one shape, form, fashion, or the other. Sometimes it is financial, and at other times it is through peace, joy, and true contentment.

Whatever it is, I can assure you, you will be blessed through your commitment and sacrifice of giving. Next week we will touch a little more on this topic and then move on.

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- Welcome back guys and turn with me if you will to the 8th Chapter of the Book of 2 Corinthians.
    - We took a pause over the last two weeks in order to debunk some misunderstandings about the church, but more specifically about the topic of “tithing” or “giving”. And we did this by backing up (as always) and asking the question “why”.
    - When you study scripture and you don’t understand something, many times the best way to arrive at the answer is to start by asking why? And this would certainly be the case when trying to figure out why God created the Church, because when you discover the why of the Church, as it relates to its intent and purpose, you will then understand why God requires us to give.
        - You see, God created the church, the body, the ecclesia, and He gifted it to us, and through it He provided us (the believer) the means by which to take care of each other, build each other up, support each other (which also includes financial support at times), and then last but not least, He created the church for our edification.
        - To mature us, grow us spiritually, all through the teaching of God’s Word, which would then be administered through a Pastor/Teacher, a man who was gifted to teach God’s Holy Manuscript. A man who (according to Timothy) “*coincidentally”* would be an overseer or elder in the church as well.
        - And so, He created this magnificent institution, and it becomes our family, and honestly, when it’s right, there is nothing better in the life of the believer. And so, what’s its ultimate purpose or reason? Another way to say it is, what’s the church’s goal?
- Its goal is to support and equip the saints for the work of ministry, so that as we live our lives inside this dark and dying world, we will make an impact for the Kingdom. So, with all that said, the church:
    - Provides a support system for believers - for one another - and as I said last week - it takes care of its own first (which includes financial at times).
    - It also matures the believer though teaching an absorption of God’s Word.
    - And all for the purpose of the believer’s spiritual strength, so that he or she can enter the world and become a proxy or facilitator, or an extension of God, themselves.
        - And when this is right, or when it takes hold in the life of a Christian, the result is an unbeliever will come to know God, because it’s all facilitated through God’s children. And then once that happens, that newly saved person begins that same process and the entire thing starts all over again. Which means it’s cyclical.
        - And so that’s one of the primary reasons we give, to support our church, which in return supports us. But that isn’t the only reason we give, we also give because when we do it’s a form of sacrifice, which is simply a test of our faith, obedience, and appreciation. Appreciation for all that God has done for us.
- Now before moving forward this morning, I want to point something out, and that is the most awesome feeling in the world is to give when you don’t have it to give, because it’s

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such a leap of faith and it requires courage, because you're scared and afraid.

- It's an awesome feeling because it's such a sacrifice. It brings such gratification. But what makes it even more amazing is the feeling you get when you see God show up and take care of your needs in what will always be the most unimaginable of ways, which let me say has happened for Daffeny and myself many, many times.
  - Just remember this, God never leaves His children hanging. He always provides, because He knows what we need before we need it, and He is always prepared to meet our needs. And remember, you can really never appreciate His Grace until you experience it firsthand.

- Now, as we move forward this morning, I am going to back up and re-read once again 2 Corinthians 8:1-9. I know we have read it two or three times over the last several weeks so be patient with me here, because this week we are going to do what we do, which is to rightly divide God's word of truth. I haven't been doing that over the past few weeks, so I want to do that before we move forward.
  - And I want to share something with you as I have reread these verses this week. I noticed something, something that for a lack of better words, sent cold chills up and down my spine. And when I show it to you, hopefully the same will happen for you as well. Let me read it to you one more time, and here's what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 8:1 Now, brethren, we *wish to* make known to you the grace of God which has been given in the churches of Macedonia,
2 Cor. 8:2 that in a great ordeal of affliction their abundance of joy and their deep poverty overflowed in the wealth of their liberality.
2 Cor. 8:3 For I testify that according to their ability, and beyond their ability, *they gave* of their own accord,
2 Cor. 8:4 begging us with much urging for the favor of participation in the support of the saints,
2 Cor. 8:5 and *this,* not as we had expected, but they first gave themselves to the Lord and to us by the will of God.
2 Cor. 8:6 So we urged Titus that as he had previously made a beginning, so he would also complete in you this gracious work as well.
2 Cor. 8:7 But just as you abound in everything, in faith and utterance and knowledge and in all earnestness and in the love we inspired in you, *see* that you abound in this gracious work also.
2 Cor. 8:8 I am not speaking *this* as a command, but as proving through the earnestness of others the sincerity of your love also.
2 Cor. 8:9 For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though He was rich, yet for your sake He became poor, so that you through His poverty might become rich.

- Guys, I know I say this all the time, but I really can't help it. These verses are some of the richest, most educational and insightful verses in all of scripture, at least as it relates to giving. They are also very insightful as it relates to understanding the attitude that we

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should all have when it comes to tithing or giving.

- And let me expound on what I mean here for just a moment, because this is so powerful and liberating. Let's start with verse 1, where Paul begins by letting the people of Corinth in on what I would call "a little secret". He says,

2 Cor. 8:1 Now, brethren, we *wish to* make known to you the grace of God which has been given in the churches of Macedonia,

- Okay, let's pause here for just a minute. Paul says, now, brethren. He was speaking to the church and by extension that includes you and I as well. Now brethren, he says, we wish to make known to you the grace of God which has been given in the churches of Macedonia.
  - So, here's the interpretation along with the real-life application. He says, "Let me tell you about the Grace that God has given to the churches in Macedonia". Now at first read, this may seem insignificant, but I assure you it's not.
  - It would be like me saying to you, "Hey Mark, Scott, Richard, Stacy, or hey Dave, let me tell you about the amazing work and gift that God has bestowed on the brothers and sisters over at First Baptist Church, or over at the First United Methodist or The United Pentecostal Church. A gift that is so amazing and a gift that is also available to you.
    - That's the sense here. Paul is saying, guys let me tell you about the grace, the "unmerited favor", that God has shown to the churches of Macedonia. It is truly unreal, and God wants to give it to you as well.
    - Another way to say it might be, paraphrasing, guys, God is doing amazing things in these churches, and we want you to get in on the deal as well. That's what he is trying to convey here. So, we got that, now let's move on to verse 2.

2 Cor. 8:2 that in a great ordeal of affliction their abundance of joy and their deep poverty overflowed in the wealth of their liberality.

- Paul says that in a great deal of affliction, in the middle of all of their trial and tribulation, something has happened to them and there is a reason it's happened.
  - And so, what's happened? They are experiencing an abundance of joy, which by the way makes no sense at all. As a matter a fact it seems impossible and totally backwards. I mean how could they be under "a great deal of affliction" and at the same time be experiencing such an "abundance of joy"? Something doesn't make sense, and so what is the deal?
  - Well, whatever it is, I can guarantee you it's supernatural, because obviously these two things don't go together. And oh yeah, one more thing, not only are they experiencing a great deal of affliction, but they are also broke.
    - But not just any ole' broke (as in the way we think of someone being broke). No, they are experiencing deep poverty, which is much different than just being broke. This is a whole different level of broke. As a matter a fact, when you study

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these two words in the Greek, deep and poverty, and then tie them together, you get a real sense of just how bad things were for these churches, because deep in the Greek means depth, as in deep water, met: fullness, immensity, and extreme degree, profundities, deep-laid plans.

- And then the word poverty in the Greek means beggary and destitution. So, combining these two words together, we get the real picture, which is a depth of extreme poverty that hinges on that of begging and destitution. And so, you get it, it's real bad for these people.
- And yet, at the same time they are experiencing an abundance of joy. And when you combine those two words, abundance and joy, you get the opposite end of the extreme. Which is what? To experience above-normal gladness and joy.

- But the question is why, or an even better question might be How? How could it be? What in the world is going on? What could be causing these two opposite extremes and emotions to take place at the same time? It's hard to believe when you stop to think about it, Because I don't think this would be our reaction.
- So, what gives? What is causing this? Well, it shows up in the last part of verse 2, let me read it again.

2 Cor. 8:2 **that in a great ordeal of affliction their abundance of joy and their deep poverty (overflowed in the wealth of their liberality).**

- The key phrase in this verse lies in the words "overflowed in the wealth of their liberality." The Greek actually gives us a better sense of what's really being said here, so let me read it to you.
  - "Of the deep poverty of them abounded into the riches the generosity of them"
    - Paraphrasing, because of how generous they were, God offset their great deal of affliction and poverty with an abundance of joy. If this was a mathematical equation you would say it this way, the more they gave the more their joy increased.
    - Even though they were experiencing a great deal of affliction, and even though they were living in deep poverty (So poor, and destitute they were to the point of begging).
  - In spite of all that, they overflowed with an abundance of joy because they gave. Guys, this is amazing, and it begs the question, how in the world could this be? I mean, how did they give when they were broke? The answer is - it was supernatural.
  - They gave what they had even though they didn't have it to give, and God obviously continued to replace it. Which is interesting because when you think about it, God knows they are broke, that they don't have any money. Yet He told them to give anyway. Which tells you something.
- It tells you He had a plan to cover them and to bless them financially all over again. That's the way it had to be if He wanted to keep it all going! Right?
  - By the way, it didn't say how much they gave because giving is not about the quantity of the sacrifice, it' all about the quality of the sacrifice. Which couldn't be

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highlighted any better than in the story of the "Widow's mite". Let me read it as backup context and commentary to what Paul is saying here today in 2 Corinthians.

- And to do that we will go read Luke's words in Luke 21:1-4. You can also read it in Mark 12, but we will read from Luke, and here's what it says:

Luke 21:1 Now He looked up and saw the wealthy putting their gifts into the *temple* treasury.
Luke 21:2 And He saw a poor widow putting in two lepta coins.
Luke 21:3 And He said, "Truly I say to you, this poor widow put in more than all *of them;*
Luke 21:4 for they all contributed to the offering from their surplus; but she, from her poverty, put in all that she had to live on."

- Now, in this story we see the New Testament teaching on giving being lived out, and that is, giving is not about the quantity it's about the quality of the sacrifice. Listen to me one more time. Giving is not about the amount, it's about the magnitude of the sacrifice. Which as I said lines up with what I taught you last week as it pertains to the concept of giving in the New Testament.
  - In the Old Testament, 10% was the standard (well kind of, sort of), but that's not the standard in the New Testament. The New Testament teaches we are to give as we have been blessed or prospered.
  - Which means if I work at McDonalds, and make $10 per hour, and I give $2 of that to God, but I really can't afford that (at least on paper), but I give it anyway because I have examined my life and have determined that I have been blessed, and prospered to that degree, and I do this when all I really could afford was 50 cents.
    - Then based on Paul's observation, as well as Luke and Mark, something supernatural will take place in my life. Not when I give out of my surplus, but when I give based on how I have been blessed. And that's why the New Testament teaches giving in a much different way than the Old Testament.
- You see after Jesus, the dispensation changed. It was no longer about the rules I followed but about my commitment and obedience and gratitude toward God for the ultimate sacrifice He made on my behalf through His only begotten Son, Jesus Christ.
  - You see, prior to Jesus, God's sacrifice for us was minimal. Minimal in that it could not deliver us to heaven. But after Jesus it was maximized, and now, through the death of His Son, we are all afforded the opportunity to enter Heaven's Gate.
    - In other words, His commitment to you as a believer was the greatest, because He gave it all! As a matter of fact, there could have been no greater sacrifice that He could have given us, which then begs the question, what's the sacrifice that we will give Him in return? Will we dig deep and go beyond? Go deep and beyond what we think we can afford? Or will we give from our surplus, which, according to Jesus, isn't really a sacrifice at all.
- Now this concept is so important to understand, because as I said, it's not about *the amount.* It's about the pain of the sacrifice. It's about the trepidation of the sacrifice, the insecurity of the sacrifice.

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- You know, I always find it humorous when I hear someone talk about another person who is very wealthy, and they say, “You know, he is rich but he’s generous. He gives large sums of money away to all kinds of organizations or foundations”.
- When someone says that I always think about the widow’s mite. She gave the least according to Jesus, but she gave the most because she gave all she had. But for those who had a lot, yes, they gave a lot, but not in comparison to what they had. They didn’t give much at all because they gave from their surplus.
  - This means, someone may give 5% and another give 30%, but the 5% be looked upon (by God) as the one being the more excellent or better sacrifice, all because *it’s proportional* to what they had. And this, once again, lines up with the next verse, verse 3, which says:

2 Cor. 8:3 **For I testify that according to their ability, and beyond their ability, *they gave* of their own accord,**

- That according to their ability, and (here’s the key), beyond their ability, they gave of their own accord. Three things to note here really quick. First of all, notice they gave according to their ability, which would be from their surplus (no matter how large or small it was).
  - But then, they gave beyond their ability from what they didn’t have, and they did so of their own accord. Meaning, no one pushed them or prompted them to do so. No preacher or Apostle pushed them into it or talked them into it. It was all based on their own self - examination of how they had been blessed, coupled with their outlook and perspective on ministry.
  - Follow me here for just a moment, because I told you at the beginning of today’s lesson there was something that gave me cold chills when I studied it again this week. Well, here it is - verses 4-5. Listen one more time,

2 Cor. 8: **begging us with much urging for the favor of participation in the support of the saints,**
2 Cor. 8: **and *this,* not as we had expected, but they first gave themselves to the Lord and to us by the will of God.**

- Paul said, even though they were experiencing a great deal of affliction, coupled with the fact that they were deeply poor, they were broke - bad broke. They were begging them, urging them for the favor of participation! Another way to say it is, they were begging them for the opportunity to participate in supporting the saints (to participate in the work of the ministry).
  - Folks, this is where the natural meets the supernatural, and before I explain what I mean, I would like to point out who it is that they are begging to support. Is it the outside world? No, it’s the saints. And the saints are who? Just Paul and the other disciples. It’s speaking of taking care of all their brothers and sisters. Taking care of one another.
  - But what about this supernatural move of God, where the natural meets the

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supernatural? What causes this to happen? Or a better way to say it is, what activates it? It happened when they blindly trusted God. When they trusted God so much that they threw caution to the wind and gave beyond what they could afford.

- And, once again, not because someone prompted them to do so. That is what is causing this unexplainable abundance of joy to come over them in the midst of such affliction, and I will submit to you that this all happens as a result of their understanding and attitude, paired of course with their action.

- That's what has brought about this "supernatural abundance of joy". Paraphrasing once again, Paul is saying, these folks are looking for an opportunity to minister through their giving. As a matter of fact, Paul says they are begging to participate.
  - And this gives us a different perspective, one that most of us would never even consider if we were in the same boat. These words paint for us such an insightful picture, "for the favor of participation in supporting the saints". You want to talk about perspective, outlook, and attitude? This is it.
  - The sense you get here is this, hey Paul, would you please allow us the opportunity to participate in supporting the saints. Another way to say it would be, hey, I know we are broke, but we have scraped together a little bit of money. Can we please find favor in your eyes so that we too might get in the game?
- You almost get the feeling they are saying, here's all we have, can we please participate in what God's doing, even if it's just with this small amount? You can almost hear them saying, here Paul, will this help?
- I said this gave me cold chills, and that was the case because when you process and think about their situation, and then look at how God blesses them with an abundance of joy in the midst of such turmoil, when you put it all together, you realize it's the strength of their faith and trust in God that's making all this happen.

- God is blessing them because they trust Him. And so, the lesson is clear. If you want to see God move - trust Him. And I am not just talking about financially, I'm talking about in all areas of your life. If your child has strayed - Trust Him. If your marriage is falling apart - Trust Him. If the doctor says it doesn't look good - Trust Him. If you are let go at your job - Trust Him.
  - And I get it. You might say, "Well that's easier said than done. Preacher." I would agree. But do it anyway if you want to see God move supernaturally. Know that nothing moves Him more than when we trust Him with blind faith, which is when trusting Him requires us to throw caution to the wind in the face of insurmountable odds. When it makes no sense. When we are certain it will not work out in our favor.
    - This is what's happening with the churches in Macedonia. They are experiencing great hardship, and they are dead broke. Yet all they want to do is give away all that they have. But there's even more to it than that. Look at verses 5 and 6:

2 Cor. 8:5 and *this,* not as we had expected, but they first gave themselves to the Lord and to us by the will of God.

- Paul is saying, these people were so poor that we never expected them to give the way they gave. But having said that, they didn't give to us first. They first gave themselves to

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the Lord. The sense here is they made themselves available. Their minds were right. Essentially, they were ready, willing, and able to do whatever God required.

- Once again, we get a snapshot picture of their heart, or their attitude, which was what? “Lord we are ready for whatever it is that you would have us do.” That by the way is the first step in pleasing God. You must get your mind right, and if you do that the rest will follow, and that’s exactly what these churches had done. Next in verse 6, Paul writes:

2 Cor. 8:6 **So we urged Titus that as he had previously made a beginning, so he would also complete in you this gracious work as well.**

- In his earlier journey to Corinth, Titus had asked the church to be prepared with an offering when he or Paul returned. This offering was not for the benefit of Paul or Titus, but rather for the benefit of the poor church in Jerusalem. And so, Paul reminds the church at Corinth to remember the work that Titus had previously begun in them, and how he wanted them to experience what the churches of Macedonia had experienced.
  - Which was what? They received God’s grace through a great abundance of joy, brought on by their giving. A giving that was above and beyond what they normally might have given. Essentially, Paul was saying they should test God with their giving - stretch the limits and see what happens.
    - Finally, and we will close with verses 7-9, Paul says:

2 Cor. 8:7 **But just as you abound in everything, in faith and utterance and knowledge and in all earnestness and in the love we inspired in you, *see* that you abound in this gracious work also.**
2 Cor. 8:8 **I am not speaking *this* as a command, but as proving through the earnestness of others the sincerity of your love also.**

- Real simple and straightforward words are being spoken here and let me explain them to you. Paul writes to the church at Corinth, you have done well, you have abounded in everything, in faith and utterance (which is speech), and knowledge, and in all earnestness, and in the love we inspired in you. See that you abound in this gracious work also.
  - I will paraphrase it for you, guys, you have done great in all things, and I am proud of you. But make sure you don’t miss out on this one thing, which is what? To receive the same blessing that God has shown to the churches of Macedonia because of their deep sacrificial giving.
  - In other words, you have done good but don’t miss out on this one thing, which is the opportunity to see God show up because you stretched the limits of your giving. He’s saying guys there is something there, something that we’ve witnessed, and we don’t want you to miss out on it.
    - And then he says, we are not speaking this as a command, which means it is not a command. It’s up to you. And let me say, that is exactly the way giving must be. If someone pushes you to give; the church, a fellow believer or whomever,

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don't do it.

- Do it because you want to put into practice what the churches in Macedonia were doing. Do it because you want to experience the blessing of the Grace that God has bestowed on those churches, not because someone guilts you into it.
  - And lastly, remember, the blessing that comes from deep and uninhibited sacrifice is something that activates God's grace and blessing. And why? Well, because of our final verse of the day. Look at what it says:

2 Cor. 8:9 **For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though He was rich, yet for your sake He became poor, so that you through His poverty might become rich.**

- Verse 9 is speaking specifically to one thing and one thing alone. And what is it? It's the magnitude of the sacrifice that God made on our behalf. And so, the concept is this to the best of our ability is we should strive to match His sacrifice in our own life. It sounds impossible I know. But it's not.
  - God doesn't expect us to give our only begotten Son, He expects us to sacrifice to the deepest level that we can. He expects us to test Him and push our own personal limits beyond what we think we can sacrifice.
  - Once again, this is back to the widow's mite. She gave little in comparison to those who gave a lot, yet she gave more than they did. And why? Because she gave from what she did not have, whereas those who gave a lot gave out of their surplus. It's all about percentages of proportionality.
    - That's what Paul is asking the church of Corinth to consider, and that's what we are being asked to consider as well. It's not a command, it's a challenge. And when we obey in this area of our life, I assure you something supernatural will happen!

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- Good morning, guys and welcome back to our journey through 2 Corinthians.
  - Last week we finished verses 1-9, which (in my opinion) turned out to be maybe some of the most insightful verses in all of scripture, at least as it relates to giving. I would also say they have been some of the most insightful verses that I have ever taught.
    - If you weren't here, I would encourage you to go back to our website and listen to last week's teaching, because Paul's story behind the story was really powerful. So, this morning let's move on and pick back up with one of four letters that Paul wrote to the Corinthian church, and that is 2 Corinthians.
    - And we will begin our journey by backing up to Chapter 8 and re-reading the end of last week's verses for context, and here's what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 8:7 **But just as you abound in everything, in faith and utterance and knowledge and in all earnestness and in the love we inspired in you, *see* that you abound in this gracious work also.**
2 Cor. 8:8 **I am not speaking *this* as a command, but as proving through the earnestness of others the sincerity of your love also.**
2 Cor. 8:9 **For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though He was rich, yet for your sake He became poor, so that you through His poverty might become rich.**

- One more time, I realize we have read these verses several times over the last few weeks, and I won't rehash them other than to highlight a couple things. First, remember Paul is urging the church at Corinth to give with the same fervor and zeal that the churches in Macedonia have given.
  - And they were doing this despite the fact they were experiencing deep poverty. Which means they didn't have anything to give, yet they gave anyway. And they gave for reasons that most Christians never even think about. And what was that? They gave so that they themselves could participate in the work of ministry.
  - Meaning, they didn't give out of tradition or obligation. They gave with intent. As a matter of fact, they went as far as to ask Paul for the "favor" of giving, so they too could support saints.
    - You see, as I said last week, it was all about the heart, or you would say the intent of their giving. That's what made all the difference in the world. And don't forget the scripture never says how much they gave. We have no clue because it wasn't about the amount. It was about the magnitude of the sacrifice, which Paul contrasts with the sacrifice God gave to us through His sacrifice - Jesus Christ.
    - And that takes me to my second point, which shows up in verse 9 when he says:

2 Cor. 8:9 **For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though He was rich, yet for your sake He became poor, so that you through His poverty might become rich.**

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- Now, when we think of the power of God's word, this verse says it all. It says, "Though He was rich, yet for your sake He became poor". Now, the reference to rich and poor here is not speaking about money, but rather it's speaking to the fact that He lowered Himself into His creation (the thing He created), and then allowed His creation to put Him death, to crucify Him, and all for the sake of the ones He created.
  - The corollary here would be like you giving up your life for your children. This is just one way I can imagine us being able to comprehend what Christ did for us. But there is also another way for us to look at it, and that would be for us to think about the reality of what was actually happening.
  - You see, we are God's children - "Adopted Children" - grafted into His family, and because sin entered the world and contaminated us, caused us to become stained and damaged goods, God stepped in and provided a solution to clean us up, and He did so by redeeming us back to Himself. The only way to do that was through a blood sacrifice, through death.
    - It couldn't just be any ole sacrifice, it had to be a suitable sacrifice, one that would allow you and I to enter into Heaven's gates, and the only sacrifice that would suffice was that of the Son. But not just any Son, it was God's only begotten Son, which we would all agree would be by all accounts the ultimate sacrifice. But why?
    - Why such a sacrifice? That's the question. And really, the best way to answer that question is to understand the magnitude of sin; what it did to humanity. No other sacrifice would work, and so, simply put, there was no other way.
  - And what's interesting is Jesus Himself, the One being sacrificed, knew this to be the case, which was highlighted by His own words when He said this in Matthew 26:39:

Matt. 26:39 **And He went a little beyond *them,* and fell on His face and prayed, saying, "My Father, if it is possible, let this cup pass from Me; yet not as I will, but as You *will.*"**

- And then skipping forward in the same chapter, Jesus said this in verses 51-54:

Matt. 26:51 **And behold, one of those who were with Jesus (speaking of Peter) reached and drew his sword, and struck the slave of the high priest and cut off his ear.**
Matt. 26:52 **Then Jesus *said to him, "Put your sword back into its place; for all those who take up the sword will perish by the sword.**
Matt. 26:52 **Or do you think that I cannot appeal to My Father, and He will at once put at My disposal more than twelve legions of angels?**
Matt. 26:54 **How then would the Scriptures be fulfilled, *which say* that it must happen this way?"**

- I won't get into all of what we just read this morning, because obviously there's a lot to unpack with Jesus's words. My point is, there was no other way, no other suitable

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sacrifice, that could provide a covering for the sin of man.

- Nothing but for God to send a perfect, spotless, and innocent lamb to stand in as the ultimate sacrifice because of what sin did to the world. And to put this act of God into its rightful and proper perspective, think about it like this.
  - Imagine you had one biological child. But you also had several adopted children. And then imagine all those adopted children were in grave danger of being destroyed or killed by some enemy or predator of some sort, and the only way to save them would be for you to make a choice or decision, a choice or decision to sacrifice your one and only biological child.
  - What would you do? Would you do it? Obviously, no one would want to think about such a thing but that's what God did for you and me when He sent His only Son to earth to be killed at the hands of the creation that He created.
- And so, this is what Paul is saying when he says, Jesus became poor (spiritually speaking- like one of us) so that we, through His sacrificial death, might become rich. That is the sense here, and that is corollary between what those in Macedonia did through their giving and what Christ did for us on the Cross of Calvary.
- And when you think about it that way, that means their sacrifice was immense. Once again, not because of how much they gave, but due to the magnitude of what they gave. They gave of what they had, and they gave of what they didn't have, and for that reason something supernatural was activated in their lives. Which was what?
  - They received God's grace in the form of an abundance of joy, all in a really dark time of humanity I might add. Which means they received peace in the midst of the storm. A peace like no man could ever imagine, which is what led Paul to include this account in his letter.
  - He wanted the Church at Corinth to get in on what God was doing. And by the way, this same still holds true today. This was not something special and set aside for just those in Macedonia. When we too sacrifice all that we have, and then go a little bit further, it activates something supernatural in the life of the believer.
- And the primary thing that it activates is abundance of joy that comes by way of knowing Jesus in a deeper way, which, when that takes place brings you more and more peace. I won't harp on this too much longer, but I will say, sacrifice comes in many forms and fashions, it's not just financial. I'll digress on this point. You should understand what I mean by now.

- Moving on, picking up with verse 10, where Paul continues to urge the Church at Corinth to get it on what God is doing with the Churches at Macedonia. Follow me here. Let's read verses 10-15, and then back up and break down each verse one by one. Verses 10-15, here's what he wrote:

2 Cor. 8:10 I give *my* opinion in this matter, for this is to your advantage, who were the first to begin a year ago not only to do *this,* but also to desire *to do it.*
2 Cor. 8:11 But now finish doing it also, so that just as *there was* the willingness to desire it, so *there may be* also the completion of it by your ability.
2 Cor. 8:12 For if the willingness is present, it is acceptable according to what *a*

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person **has, not according to what he does not have.**
2 Cor. 8:13 **For *this* is not for the relief of others *and* for your hardship, but by way of equality—**
2 Cor. 8:14 **at this present time your abundance *will serve as assistance* for their need, so that their abundance also may serve as *assistance* for your need, so that there may be equality;**
2 Cor. 8:15 **as it is written: "THE ONE WHO *HAD GATHERED* MUCH DID NOT HAVE TOO MUCH, AND THE ONE WHO *HAD GATHERED* LITTLE DID NOT HAVE TOO LITTLE."**

- Man, oh man, here we go again. Such weighty and powerful words. Let's begin with verse 10, where Paul says:

2 Cor. 8:10 **I give *my* opinion in this matter, for this is to your advantage, who were the first to begin a year ago not only to do *this,* but also to desire *to do it.***

- Paul begins by saying, I give my opinion on this matter. First of all, I want you to take note of what he didn't say. He didn't say do this or do that. In other words, he didn't command them to do something. He simply said, let me give my opinion. Another way to say it might be, in my opinion, or the way I see it.
    - So, he says, in my opinion, this is to your advantage. What's to their advantage? To do what the Churches of Macedonia are doing. For them to give, not just from their ability, but beyond their ability, beyond what they had. And then he says, who were the first to begin a year ago not only to do this, but also to desire to do it.
- Now the end of verse 10 ties directly into verses 11 & 12, so let me address the first part of what I just quoted. He says, who were the first to begin a year ago. Paraphrasing here, he is saying you guys started gathering money for the poorer churches a year ago, and so I urge you to complete it.
    - We know from the study of scripture that the Church at Corinth did in fact begin gathering monies at least one year prior to the Churches in Macedonia. They were gathering up money and awaiting Paul's return, at which time- they would give him the offering and he would then carry the gift to the poorer church in Jerusalem.
    - And so that kind of gives you the background to his statement. He was saying finish what you started and do it in the same way the Churches of Macedonia did it. And then from there he says not only would I ask you to finish it, I also ask you to desire to do it.
        - Which is so interesting, and it ties into verses 11&12, which I'll re-read for context, all in an effort to tie it all together. One more time, verses 10-12:

2 Cor. 8:10 **I give *my* opinion in this matter, for this is to your advantage, who were the first to begin a year ago not only to do *this,* but also to desire *to do it.***
2 Cor. 8:11 **But now finish doing it also, so that just as *there was* the willingness to desire it, so *there may be* also the completion of it by your ability.**

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2 Cor. 8:12 For if the willingness is present, it is acceptable according to what *a person* has, not according to what he does not have.

- You know, Paul's words have often been compared to poetry, and that's really the truth. Just look at how he writes, but more specifically, look at what he writes. He says in verse 11, "but now finish doing it also, so that just as there was the willingness to desire it, so there may be also the completion of it by your ability".
  - The poetic part of his writings shows up when he says, "so that just as *there was* the willingness to desire it". Think about what he's saying here one more time, "so that just as there was the willingness to desire it".
    - Here's the sense of what he is saying. Hang in here with me for just a moment. He is saying, even if you don't desire it, if you are willing to desire it, that is good enough. God will accept that.
  - One more time, "So that just as there was the willingness to desire it". It would be like a boss, or a teacher, or a judge, or someone in authority over you, saying, "I know you don't want to do it, but would you be willing to desire to do it"?
  - In other words, would you consider or try desiring it, and if you said yes, then that alone would be good enough. Isn't that interesting? It is to me. And, once again, it's another one of those statements from Paul that liberates us. But what do I mean? What do I mean when I say his words liberate us?
    - I mean, because God will accept our willingness to desire something even if we don't desire it. God accepts that; therefore, we are liberated by knowing that we don't have to desire it, meaning we don't have to feel guilty about it. That's where liberation comes in.
    - Another way to say it is, if I am willing to try and desire it, that alone will suffice. But, as always, the question is why? Why in the world would God allow us simply to be willing, rather than actually desiring to do something? Because if we are willing to try, God will do the rest.
- One more time, if we will trust God and take a few steps toward him in faith, He will in turn take that many more steps toward us. Wow. All we have to do is take a few steps toward Him and He will do the rest. Yes, that's what Paul is saying. He is saying if we try, God will handle the desire part. But why? Well, once again, we are back to obedience. When we obey (even when we don't want to), God honors our effort and obedience, and replaces the willingness with desire, and that's why Paul says what he says in the way that he says it.
  - If they were willing to try and obey through their giving, regardless of whether they want to or not, God would put the desire in the heart to continue on, and their willingness to participate is acceptable because it's a sign of obedience, which is highlighted in verse 12 when he says this:

2 Cor. 8:12 For if the willingness is present, it is acceptable according to what *a person* has, not according to what he does not have.

- The overarching theme of Paul's words are this, if they are willing to obey in their giving,

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God will accept their giving as an acceptable sacrifice based on what they have, not what they don't have. Meaning, based not on the amount they gave, but rather the percentage of what they gave as it relates to what they have. You get the point, so let's press on.

2 Cor. 8:13 For *this* is not for the relief of others *and* for your hardship, but by way of equality—
2 Cor. 8:14 at this present time your abundance *will serve as assistance* for their need, so that their abundance also may serve as *assistance* for your need, so that there may be equality;
2 Cor. 8:15 as it is written: "THE ONE WHO *HAD GATHERED* MUCH DID NOT HAVE TOO MUCH, AND THE ONE WHO *HAD GATHERED* LITTLE DID NOT HAVE TOO LITTLE."

- In verse 13, to be honest, Paul's words could be construed as socialism, primarily because of the words "by way of equality". Socialism is a system, and one facet of that system is the redistribution of wealth, and although I am 100% against that concept, mainly because it doesn't work because you can't lift another person out of the depths of poverty by taking from one person who has and giving to another person who does not have. It won't work.
  - Each man must work and save and be frugal with what he has if he wants to rise above his financial situation. So let me be clear on this topic. This is not what Paul is talking about here. Paul is talking about equality in two ways here, one of which does include financial, but not equality as it relates to those who truly don't have. He's not speaking about those who won't work.
  - Let me explain what I mean. You see, it really boils down to what I call true poverty. When I think of these poorer churches' situation, I think of their culture and the environment in which they lived. And this is really hard for us to understand, because employment opportunity for us is everywhere.
    - That was not the case for the majority of the people living in those days. Everyone worked in those days, they had no choice, but the opportunities to make money were limited, so it didn't matter how hard someone worked, they would still be poor.
  - This is very different from today's socialist ideals. Today, socialism says we should redistribute wealth because when we all succeed it makes everything better. The socialist of today says it even makes it better for those who are wealthy. In other words, if I take a portion of what a wealthy person has and give it to a poorer person, then theoretically speaking we will all do better (including the wealthy person).
    - And by the way, this can be true, but the problem is this concept assumes the poorer person, the one who receives a portion of the wealthier person's wealth, is a worker. It also assumes they are frugal.
    - You know, when I think about this Covid and that wasn't a bad idea, in and of itself, especially seeing how people were unable to work. And honestly, it didn't bother me due to the fact that the government is so irresponsible when it comes to the money they receive from taxes.

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- My theory was, instead of blowing it on ridiculous and frivolous items and agendas, which pander to lobbyists, help people! Quit blowing money on research and things that don't matter, and in turn, return a portion of it back to the people who were unemployed and struggling.

- Now having said that, the reason I said I thought about the Covid money as it related to wealth redistribution, and more specifically why wealth redistribution doesn't work, at least in our society, is because statistically speaking there were many people who, when they received their checks, didn't hold on to them, save it or even use it to meet their basic needs, instead they spent it on things like TVs and other non-essential items.
  - This is a fact, and companies like Wal-Mart and Amazon confirmed it with their sales reports. Wal-Mart and Amazon reported a dramatic increase in non-essential item sales, items such as TV's, cell phones, toys, and video game consoles, etc., right after the stimulus checks were released.
  - And let me say, although this was part of the government's plan to keep the economy going, the core purpose of the money was for meeting essential needs, not non-essential. You see, if Covid would have hit in Paul's day and age, and the Roman government would have handed out checks, I assure you the money wouldn't have been spent on non-essential items.
    - And so, just remember this when reading Paul's words, these people weren't poor because they didn't work, they were poor because the wages they earned from working extremely hard weren't enough to sustain their basic needs. Basic needs being food, clothing, housing, etc.
- So having said that, Paul was proposing a system of redistributing wealth. But not for the purposes of equality as it related to prosperity or fairness of wealth, but rather for the purposes of meeting the basic needs of believers in the poorer churches. Which by the way, goes back to what I said a few weeks ago.
  - Specifically, about the purpose of the church, which was that "we take care of our own first". We as a body are to take care of the needs of our fellowship first, and then, and only then, do we look to give outside the church. And one more time, when the church helps another believer in need, it assumes that brother or sister is putting forth effort. They aren't just sitting around doing nothing, expecting the church to take care of them.
    - And this also falls right in line with the testimony of scripture, just in case you are wondering. Redistributing wealth in God's dichotomy assumes those who are receiving the wealth redistribution are working hard and responsibly trying to resolve their situation.
    - This is a Biblical concept and keeps in line with what God's word says. For further insight into this topic, let's look at 2 Thessalonians 3:6-13. Listen to what Paul wrote:

2 Thess. 3:6 Now we command you, brothers *and sisters,* in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, that you keep away from every brother *or sister* who leads a disorderly life and not *one* in accordance with the tradition which you received from us.
2 Thess. 3:7 For you yourselves know how you ought to follow our example,

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because we did not act in an undisciplined way among you,
2 Thess. 3:8 **nor did we eat anyone's bread without paying for it, but with labor and hardship we *kept* working night and day so that we would not be a burden to any of you;**
2 Thess. 3:9 **not because we do not have the right *to this,* but in order to offer ourselves as a role model for you, so that you would follow our example.**
2 Thess. 3:10 **For even when we were with you, we used to give you this order: if anyone is not willing to work, then he is not to eat, either.**
2 Thess. 3:11 **For we hear that some among you are leading an undisciplined life, doing no work at all, but acting like busybodies.**
2 Thess. 3:12 **Now we command and exhort such persons in the Lord Jesus Christ to work peacefully and eat their own bread.**
2 Thess. 3:13 **But as for you, brothers *and sisters,* do not grow weary of doing good.**

- So based on Paul's own words, we clearly see he is not a proponent of socialism, at least in the sense of redistributing wealth from one person to another, if that person is not willing to work. You see, when Paul speaks in terms of wealth equality, yes, he is speaking in terms of moving wealth from one group to the other, but as I said, this concept assumes the other group is working hard; the poorer churches are working hard, they just aren't receiving enough compensation from their work to meet their basic needs.
    - And one more thing in terms of the church and this "act" of wealth redistribution. As I previously stated, it has a few purposes, but ultimately it is all for the purpose of bringing Glory to God. Meaning, when we help lift up our fellow brothers and sisters, the outside world will see it and that in turn becomes a "living testimony" to the power and glory of our God.
    - Which then creates curiosity inside the life of the unbeliever. It causes them to say, what's the deal with those folks? Which then in turn causes them to lean in and look and inquire about this Christianity thing. And of course, curiosity to the unbeliever is just a biproduct of taking care of our own.
        - The primary purpose of wealth redistribution inside the church is to help one another and to help meet the needs of our fellow brothers and sisters (meet the needs of our church family). I'll digress. You should get the point by now, so moving on, I got us sidetracked for a minute, so let's read it again to bring us back on track, verses 13-15:

2 Cor. 8:13 **For *this* is not for the relief of others *and* for your hardship, but by way of equality—**
2 Cor. 8:14 **at this present time your abundance *will serve as assistance* for their need, so that their abundance also may serve as *assistance* for your need, so that there may be equality;**
2 Cor. 8:15 **as it is written: "THE ONE WHO *HAD GATHERED* MUCH DID NOT HAVE TOO MUCH, AND THE ONE WHO *HAD GATHERED* LITTLE DID NOT**

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HAVE TOO LITTLE."

- In verse 14, Paul points out another biproduct of taking care of our own, and that is, it not only helps the one who receives, but it also helps the one who gives. Look at it again,

2 Cor. 8:14 at this present time your abundance *will serve as assistance* for their need, so that their abundance also may serve as *assistance* for your need, so that there may be equality;

- So, we get it how our giving could help a brother or sister in need, but how does that help us? Well, to answer that question, you must return to our teaching that began this whole thing a few weeks ago. Which was what? That the Churches in Macedonia received God's grace through an abundance of joy because they gave, not just from what they had, but from what they didn't have.
- And so, this entire thing is cyclical. They gave and God blessed them with an abundance of joy. That's what Paul means when he says,

2 Cor. 8:14 at this present time your abundance *will serve as assistance* for their need, so that their abundance also may serve as *assistance* for your need, so that there may be equality;

- This concept of equality denotes balance and harmony within the fellowship, and not just financially. Yes, financial is part of it, but not all of it. Follow me here. Paul is saying to the wealthier Corinthian Church, you guys have something the poorer churches need.
  - Which is what? Money, right? But they have something you need, something you can't buy, something intangible. And if it weren't for the poorer churches, who because of their poverty provided for you the opportunity to give, you couldn't receive what it is God wants to give you. And so, what is it?
    - An abundance of joy brought by way of God's Grace. Because they gave!
- Guys, lean in here for just a moment and listen to what I am saying. This is so fascinating. It's as if God purposely set this whole thing up with poorer churches and wealthier churches, all so they would each feed one another. Something that each one of them needed, and neither could receive what they needed without the other, which created equality.
  - You see, the equality Paul is speaking about isn't just a redistribution of wealth, it's also a redistribution of joy. And so, the wealthier churches have money, but if it weren't for the poorer churches being poor, the wealthier churches would have no means of receiving an abundance of joy by using their wealth to help the poorer churches.
- Now I don't know about you, but this literally gives me cold chills people. This is the Sovereignty of God on full display, and it tells us something. And what does it tell us? It tells us that yes, money is something, but it isn't everything. It tells us that money fulfills some of our needs, but not all of them.

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    - It tells us that money is nothing more than a tool, an instrument that is to be used to support the work of ministry, which includes supporting those in need. But it's also a tool for the giver to receive something they may not have, which is to experience God's Grace at a whole different level though an abundance of joy!
        - Amen
- Now, I'm going to pause here this morning and leave verse 15 for next week. But let me say this, think about what all this means. This stuff is so rich and life-changing, and all we have to do is connect with it, and then of course let it guide our lives. So, my prayer this morning is that you go throughout the rest of your week and consider all that Paul is teaching us in these verses, because inside God's word, inside God's Holy Manuscript, is the power to literally transform your life.

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- Good morning, guys, and welcome back. This morning, we pick back up with our journey through 2 Corinthians. If you've been here over the last several weeks, you might be thinking to yourself, more like good morning and welcome back to our study of 2 Corinthians 8.
    - And I get it, because I believe we are in our sixth study of this chapter, and we still have a few more verses to go before we finish. Anyway, it really doesn't matter because, as I always say, we aren't running a race, are we? No, I didn't think we were.
    - We are in search of the truth, which is a result of quality over quantity or substance and accuracy over speed. And so, with that in mind, remember we are essentially on a mining expedition. Meaning, we want to mine every ounce of spiritual gold we can out of every page of God's Holy Manuscript.
    - And in order to do that, we must take our time, moving methodically, examining every word in detail, allowing God to speak to our heart, revealing His character to us through the Holy Spirit that lives inside every believer. And we do that in the deepest of ways when we follow Paul's command in 2 Timothy 2:15, which said what? What did he say? Well, it depends on who you ask.
        - If you ask Richard Bancroft (Archbishop of Canterbury), the man who oversaw 47 scholars and clergyman as they translated the New Testament from the *Textus Receptus* (Received Text), which was a series of Greek text, along with the Old Testament translation, which was translated from the Masoretic Hebrew Text.
        - If you want to know what Archbishop Bancroft of Canterbury thinks, then you would go to the translation of the Bible he helped oversee, which was what translation? The King James Version of the Bible. If you read it, Paul says this as it relates to the handling of God's word in 2 Timothy 2:15.

2 Tim. 2:15 (KJV) **Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth.**

- Or, if you read that same verse in the NASB, it would say:

2 Tim. 2:15 (NASB) **Be diligent to present yourself approved to God as a worker who does not need to be ashamed, accurately handling the word of truth.**

- The Greek word translated as "rightly dividing" is *orthotomounta* — (Ortho - tow -mayo), *ortho* means "right or proper," and *tomounta* means "to cut." Which tell us that the best way success is defined when handling God's word is by the way it cuts the individual listening to it or studying it; specifically meaning the way it cuts properly and correctly.
    - The imagery here is that of a farmer. A farmer who is plowing a field. More specifically, how that farmer would seek to cut straight furrows in the ground in order that he might plant the rows in a straight line.

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- This method began with the farmer focusing on a point on the other side of the field (a focal point), so as to ensure the line cut in the dirt was indeed straight. This same method, if you will, applies to a good student of scripture. The student must remain focused on the goal or outcome and be diligent to handle the Word of God properly.
  - Which is why rightly dividing the word of truth is compared to that of "cutting a straight line." And that's what we do here, and that's why it takes time to navigate and traverse through the scriptures correctly. And honestly, as you always hear me say, who cares anyway. It should always be about the quality and purity of God's word, because that's what changes lives, not the quantity. You get the point, so moving on.

- Last week, we ended our teaching by mining some serious spiritual gold out of verses 13-14, and we left verse 15 as a way of kicking back off this week's teaching. And so, as we always do, let's back up and re-read those verses for context before we move forward. And here's what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 8:13 **For *this* is not for the relief of others *and* for your hardship, but by way of equality—**
2 Cor. 8:14 **at this present time your abundance *will serve as assistance* for their need, so that their abundance also may serve as *assistance* for your need, so that there may be equality;**
2 Cor. 8:15 **as it is written: "THE ONE WHO *HAD GATHERED* MUCH DID NOT HAVE TOO MUCH, AND THE ONE WHO *HAD GATHERED* LITTLE DID NOT HAVE TOO LITTLE."**

- Now, because we have rightly divided the word of truth, we know that Paul was writing this section of 2 Corinthians focused specifically on giving. But not just giving as we think of giving. The giving that Paul references here was a type of giving that brought about a supernatural move of God.
  - It was a giving that provided something, both to the giver and to the one receiving the gift. And what was it? Well first, let's deal with what the one receiving the gift, what he or she got out of the deal. On the surface I think it's pretty obvious. They received exactly what you would think they would receive. Which was what? Money. For what purpose? To take care of their needs.
    - Paul was encouraging the wealthier Church in Corinth to give at the same level that the poorer churches in Macedonia gave. And what level did they give? Paul said they gave from what they had (their ability), and they also gave from what they didn't have (beyond their ability). And why did they do this?
    - Well, because as we learned in verse 4, they wanted to get in the game. They wanted to participate in what God was doing. Listen to verse 4 one more time:

2 Cor. 8:4 **begging us with much urging for the favor of participation in the support of the saints.**

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- The Churches in Macedonia were literally begging Paul for the opportunity to give. All with an intent and purpose in mind, which was what? So they too could participate in the work of ministry, and that was manifested in the form of supporting the saints.
    - And who were the saints? The believers, the church, you and me. We are saints. And what's a Saint? Anyone who is saved. And so basically, at the end of the day, the Churches in Macedonia wanted to support their poorer brothers and sisters, those less fortunate, in other areas of the country.
    - So, getting back to my original statement. We know how those who received, received the benefit of the money, and that money provided for their basic needs. But what about the giver? Those who gave, what did they get in return? Well, let's back up and read verse two for the answer.

2 Cor. 8:2 **that in a great ordeal of affliction their abundance of joy and their deep poverty overflowed in the wealth of their liberality.**

- We spent a lot of time on this topic over the last few weeks, so I am not going to rehash it all. But it's worth noting one more time, those who gave received an abundance of joy because of what they gave. Not how much they gave, but rather how much they sacrificed. How much they gave in relation to what they had.
    - As I have said, it's a percentage thing, and Paul saw the results of their giving first-hand. And for that reason, he was writing to encourage the Church at Corinth to do the same, which is what then led Paul to write verses 13-14:

2 Cor. 8:13 **For *this* is not for the relief of others *and* for your hardship, but by way of equality—**
2 Cor. 8:14 **at this present time your abundance *will serve as assistance* for their need, so that their abundance also may serve as *assistance* for your need, so that there may be equality.**

- As I said last week, this concept of equality denotes balance. Much like scales. They have something you need, and you have something they need, and the equation looks something like this. Money given = an abundance of joy = equality. And it was all made possible by way of sacrifice.
    - Just remember that when you give, especially when you question how much to give. It's all about the sacrifice of the gift, not the amount. Pressing on, we ended our teaching last week with verse 14, and I didn't finish verse 15, so let's do that now before moving on. And here is what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 8:15 as it is written: "THE ONE WHO *HAD GATHERED* MUCH DID NOT HAVE TOO MUCH, AND THE ONE WHO *HAD GATHERED* LITTLE DID NOT HAVE TOO LITTLE."

- Let me remind you, when you see quotes in the New Testament, followed by capitalized

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letters, the quote will be a reference back to the Old Testament. And so, if that's the case, then the only question is where do these words show up in the Old Testament?

- But more importantly, why is Paul quoting these specific words (and how does it relate to what Paul is trying to convey)? Well, that's a good question, and one that you will soon discover will reveal yet another spiritual nugget, at least as it pertains to God's character. But more specifically as it relates to a picture of a promise to His children. A promise that still holds true today. A promise that includes you and me.

- Now to begin the process of understanding what Paul wrote, we will need to journey back to Exodus 16:18, and that's where we will find the verses that Paul is referencing. And so, let's begin our journey by asking ourselves who wrote Exodus. Moses did.
  - Now, to further this process along, and before we read verse 18, let's back up a couple of verses for context and begin from there, with verses 16 & 17:

2 Cor. 8:16 **This is what the LORD has commanded: 'Everyone gather as much as he will eat; you shall take an omer apiece according to the number of people each of you has in his tent.'"**
2 Cor. 8:17 **The sons of Israel did so, and *some* gathered much and *some* little.**
2 Cor. 8:18 **When they measured it by the omer, the one who had gathered much did not have too much, and the one who had gathered little did not have too little; everyone gathered as much as he would eat.**

- So once again the question is why did Paul quote Exodus 16:18 while he was writing 2 Corinthians to the Church at Corinth? Because he was trying to drive home a point, and to do that he wanted to use the most reliable source he could find, which for a Jewish person would have been what? The Old Testament.
  - You see, the Hebrew Bible was everything to the Jewish people, and so referencing it brought validation and accreditation to Paul's words. And so, what was the point he was trying to make? Well, to know the point you must first know the setting and or context of the setting, which would begin where?
  - It would begin by asking yourself the question, where were the Israelites at this point in Exodus? Hint: The name of the Book kind of gives it away. Exodus - it means what? "Mass departure of people."
    - And who were the people that had departed and where did they depart from? It was the Israelites, and they departed or were freed from Egypt, from slavery. And who led them out? Moses. And where are they now? In the wilderness, which by the way, when the scripture says wilderness, most of the time it doesn't represent wilderness (at least in the way we think of wilderness).
    - Wilderness usually denotes woods, and although there are woods in the Middle East, this wilderness is generally the desert (rocks, etc.). And so, the Israelites are in the wilderness, and they are struggling a little bit (which is an understatement). They are actually struggling a lot. And what are they struggling with?
  - They were struggling with trusting God. Trusting Him as it related to taking care of their basic needs, especially food. Which is understandable when you realize where

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they were. I mean after all, they are in the desert and there is no food in sight, which I would say would obviously exacerbate their trust issues.

- And this story, by the way, is no different for us. When we can't see a way, we automatically struggle trusting God. And why? Because we are human. We want to trust God but it's hard when we can't see a way. But remember, in those times all we have to do is reflect back on what Heb. 13:5 says, which is what?

- It's another promise from God "that He would never leave us nor forsakes us", and as we know, His promises never fail. Which means you count on them. And this story in Exodus 16 highlights that very fact. And so, what's the deal? What's Paul's point?
  - By referencing back to Exodus, Paul is letting this church know that God always takes care of His children, just as He did for the Jews after the Exodus in the desert. But honestly, there is more to it than that. Yes, that's the message, but what about the message behind the message?
  - Let me show you what I mean. Yes, God provided, but wait, there's more. Let's dig deeper. Moses said although some of the Israelites gathered much manna and some gathered little for various reasons, regardless of who gathered what, they all had their needs met.
    - Which is deep, because it highlights God's Sovereignty through His provision. We have no clue exactly how God worked it all out, because the Old Testament doesn't tell us. But at the end of the day, some gathered little (not enough), while others gathered a lot (more than enough). And when they had all finished eating, they looked around and regardless of who gathered what, they were all fed.
    - You see, Paul wanted the Corinthians (and by extension, you and me) to understand this concept. He wanted them, (and as I said, you and me) to see God's principal at work in the lives of their ancestors. But why? Why did he choose this verse specifically?
  - Well, as I studied commentary on this topic, most if not all of the commentary on these verses expounded on what I call the surface message of the text. Remember, when it comes to God's word there are usually multiple messages within the text, which is what makes God's word so fascinating.
  - And so, having said that, what was the surface message? It was that God would provide for His children no matter who had gathered the most or the least, meaning no matter who had little and who had a lot, that God is our provider (Jehovah Jireh), and He always provides no matter our situation or circumstance.
- Paul wanted them to see the true character of God. He also wanted them to see how they would also become God's agents in maintaining sufficiency for all. And although these surface messages are very powerful in and of themselves, for me what was more exciting was the message behind the message, and in order to see that you must stay in context with Paul's writings. And what was the context of Paul's writings?
  - Well, it started in verse 1 with Paul referencing the Churches in Macedonia. Specifically, how they gave from what they had (their ability) and how they gave more than they had (beyond their ability). And then, how that because of this type of sacrificial giving, God blessed them for their sacrifice and turned around and did something supernatural in their lives. And what was it?

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        - Here it is. He gave all those big givers lots of stuff (big houses, Ferraris, jets & Rolex watches). No, that wasn't it. As a matter of fact, they didn't receive anything made with human hands. Instead, He gave them an abundance of joy, which might not seem like much.
    - But let me ask you, what do you think would be more valuable right now in your life, an abundance of joy brought to you through peace and happiness and contentment, which gives you a real sense of true satisfaction in your life, or more stuff?
        - Let me ask you a question. Can you think back to a time when you were really happy and content, at peace? Well, that's not the kind of joy Paul is referencing here. Let me be clear here, this isn't just any old abundance of joy that we are dealing with.
        - No, I would submit to you this type of happiness and contentment isn't like any you may have ever experienced because it's a peace and happiness that comes from God. Which means it's happiness and contentment 2.0, which I assure you is far more valuable than stuff.
- And so, Paul made a reference to Exodus 16 because he wanted the Church at Corinth to understand what was up for grabs as it related to their sacrificial giving, so they too could experience what those Churches in Macedonia had experienced. But how does Paul's point specifically tie back into the Exodus story? And more importantly, how does it apply to us?
    - Well, here it is. When you give beyond your ability, sacrificially, and remember it's not about the amount you give, it's about the sacrifice of your gift. When you give sacrificially you never have to worry about there being enough. Meaning you will never have to worry about running out.
    - Because, just like the manna that fell from heaven in the desert night, it was always just enough. Never too much and never too little. And even though some gathered much, and others gathered little, they were all provided for equally. And yet, nobody could figure out how and why, because it was a supernatural work of God.
- Now, I want to preface all this by reminding you of our teaching from a few weeks ago, which was that the purpose of the church first and foremost was and still is to take care of each other. Not in extravagant ways, but by meeting our basic needs. We are to take care of our own first, and if we do that well then guess what? The government doesn't have to.
    - Which is why I said it is not the government's responsibility to take care of believers. It's the church's job. You may not know it, but God originated the Welfare System.
        - It was His concept, and not welfare in the way we think of welfare. We tend to look at the word 'welfare' in a negative light. But it's not, at least not in God's dichotomy. You see God designed a system in which those who had much would give to the church, and then, in turn, the church would provide for those who had little.
    - And once again, when I say little, I'm speaking about little as it pertains to their basic needs being met. Which means the church has its own built-in and mandated welfare system. Which makes sense when you think about it, especially as it relates to a believer's position in this world.

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        - Which is what? We are to remain separated from the world and anything it has to offer. And so, if that is the case, well then, we shouldn't ask the world to take care of us, right? And by the way, one more time, just so we are crystal clear, when I say basic needs, sometimes I think we kind of think this means starvation, and certainly food meets the criteria of a basic need, but there are many other needs that need to be met inside the church.
    - Many needs such as medical or needs such as a single mom who can't afford childcare or maintenance on someone's home, and the list goes on and on. I won't belabor the point, but just fill in the blank with whatever it is.
- Now having said that, I do want to point something out. Something I think is interesting. I want you to notice that Paul is not asking this church to take up an offering for him or the other disciples and Apostles. And this intrigued me, made me wonder, ask the question, did Paul ever ask the churches he worked with for money for himself or other disciples?
    - The answer is nope, he did not. I couldn't find any place in scripture where Paul takes up an offering for himself or for the other Apostles. On the contrary, he is always collecting money for the poorer churches. As a matter of fact, Paul actually denounces taking money from the church.
    - And he does so for a very interesting reason. Let's read about 1 Cor. 9:15-18. Here's what the NASB version has to say on this topic:

1 Cor. 9:15 But I have used none of these things. And I have not written these things so that it will be done so in my case; for it would be better for me to die than *that.* No one shall make my boast an empty one!
1 Cor. 9:16 For if I preach the gospel, I have nothing to boast *about,* for I am under compulsion; for woe to me if I do not preach the gospel.
1 Cor. 9:17 For if I do this voluntarily, I have a reward; but if against my will, I have been entrusted with a commission *nonetheless.*
1 Cor. 9:18 What, then, is my reward? *That, when I preach the gospel, I may offer the gospel without charge, so as not to make full use of my right in the gospel.*

- Paul said, I do not want to charge for the gospel message. Paraphrasing, I don't want to take a dime for the work I am called to do. And why? Because I do not want to dilute or lose any of the effectiveness or impact that my preaching may have. Isn't that interesting?
    - I guess many of the 'prosperity guys' missed that memo, and in keeping with this theme, if we back up to verse 16, Paul said, I preach the gospel because that is what God has called me to do. That's what he means when he says I am under compulsion, and therefore woe to me if I do not preach the gospel.
    - He said, paraphrasing once again, woe to me, not only am I under compulsion, but I do it also for free without charge because I have no choice, and if I choose to take pay, then guess what, I lose my reward.
        - Then in verse 18 he says,

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1 Cor. 9:18 **What, then, is my reward?** ***That, when I preach the gospel, I may offer the gospel without charge, so as not to make full use of my right in the gospel.***

- So, Paul makes it really clear. If I take money for doing what God called me to do, then I lose my reward and my message, the message of the gospel, may lose its maximum impact. Now, I wonder why this is the case.
  - Well for at least two reasons. One is Biblical and the other, well, is my personal opinion (which is not what we are supposed to do when teaching scripture, which is listen to my opinion), but I believe I am right, and I know that's a shocker, but just humor me here for a minute.
  - I believe when the man delivering the message is paid, I believe it lessens his impact because of a change in the relationship between the one giving money and the one delivering the message. But why is that the case? Because of the expectation of the giver. Maybe not consciously, but certainly subconsciously.
    - Money always changes the expectation. I'll give you a quick example of what I mean and then I'll digress. Let's say we are friends, and you call me up and say, "Hey Pastor Greg, can you come over to my house and paint my living room and I'll pay you?"
    - And I say yes, and I go to your house, and I paint your living room. Because you are paying me, you are going to scrutinize my work; not give me as much grace and mercy. But on the other hand, if I say no thanks, I don't want any pay, I'll do it for free.
  - When I finish the job, you will be less likely to scrutinize, but more likely to be thankful for the help. All because you didn't pay for it. Money always changes the expectation, and that's why Paul didn't take money.
  - Instead, he said when you take up an offering, we will give to those in need. Once again, I know this flies all in the face of church tradition. But once again, I'm not making the news, I am just reporting it.
- Now, in the past when speaking on this topic, I've had people say to me, well preacher, if the preacher is working a job then who is going to visit the people in the church? Those who are sick, etc. Ah - wonder who? Who might need to go do some visiting? How about you.
  - This is just one more reason for the preacher to forego pay. Because when the preacher receives his primary compensation from the church, the church automatically (the people) assumes everything is his responsibility, which then ends up burning him out. Leading to the number one reason so many preachers end up quitting the ministry, and they also many times end up in divorce as well.
  - Which is insane when you think about it. The preacher ends up divorced, all because he spent more time tending to the needs of the church than he did to his own family. Do you think God designed it this way? I think not.
    - And just one more thing I would like to say before moving on while I'm on my soap box. What a shame it is that the believer doesn't get to participate in the work of ministry, all because in their mind they gave money to the church, and

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therefore, they subconsciously don't feel as if they need to go visit someone. What a blessing they are missing out on.

- Anyway, Paul didn't get paid. But wait. I am confused. How did he survive? You ready for this? He had a job. He had a job. And what did he do? He built tents. He was a tent maker. So, are you saying he shouldn't have received any compensation from the churches? Nope, I am not saying that at all.
    - I'm saying he felt that if he took pay, it would take away his reward and it would lessen his effectiveness in ministry. Another way to say it is, he worked free of charge so that he could maximize his impact in the ministry, and therefore he worked, and he had a job, and I'll leave it at that.
        - But back to the topic at hand, which was what? What was Paul's point in this passage; the deeper point he wanted to make? Well, it's pretty clear. If a person gives sacrificially, which, as Paul says, is beyond their ability, they can rest easy knowing that God will always meet their needs by Paul's own reference back to the Exodus story.
    - If a believer does this, he or she will never even notice it's gone, because God will equal it all out in the end. And one more thing before I leave this teaching. If a believer gives to this church, you have my word that it will never be wasted on anything frivolous or unnecessary.
        - Things like extravagant salaries for staff or a Cadillac for the preacher or for say 'non- essential' facilities. Instead, it will be used to take care of our own first, and then from there, our gifts will move outside the walls of the church.
    - Let me also assure you, all decisions relating to giving in this church will be made by the elders, who will do so by beginning from a place of prayer.
- Now, this morning I want to do something as we close, and that is I want to read the final verses of this chapter as a segway into next week's teaching. I would like for you to take these verses this week and see if you can mine your own spiritual nuggets out of Paul's words.

2 Cor. 8:16 **But thanks be to God who puts the same earnestness on your behalf in the heart of Titus.**
2 Cor. 8:17 **For he not only accepted our appeal, but being himself very earnest, he has gone to you of his own accord.**
2 Cor. 8:18 **We have sent along with him the brother whose fame in *the things of* the gospel *has spread* through all the churches;**
2 Cor. 8:19 **and not only *that,* but he has also been appointed by the churches to travel with us in this gracious work, which is being administered by us for the glory of the Lord Himself, and *to show* our readiness,**
2 Cor. 8:20 **taking precaution so that no one will discredit us in our administration of this generous gift;**
2 Cor. 8:21 **for we have regard for what is honorable, not only in the sight of the Lord, but also in the sight of *other* people.**
2 Cor. 8:22 **We have sent with them our brother, whom we have often tested and**

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found diligent in many things, but now even more diligent because of *his* great confidence in you.
2 Cor. 8:23 **As for Titus, *he is* my partner and fellow worker among you; as for our brothers, *they are* messengers of the churches, a glory to Christ.**
2 Cor. 8:24 **Therefore, openly before the churches, show them the proof of your love and of our reason for boasting about you.**

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- Good morning, guys and welcome back to this October 29th fall morning. Turn with me if you will back to the letter or book of 2 Corinthians.
  - Over these past several weeks we have really uncovered some deep spiritual truths of God. Truths that could only be revealed by and through God's method of rightly dividing His Holy Manuscript.
  - For most of us, including myself some 20 years ago, would have simply read these verses and glossed right over them. And, if we did that, we would have missed the supernatural power that lies inside God's Word. But we didn't miss it because we took our time to mine the information, time to pull out and bring to the surface all those ah-ha moments. You know, those moments that cause the light bulbs to kick on.
    - And over these past weeks we've had several of those moments, and will receive more, as long as I stay committed. Committed to the way I pray and study. Now I say all that because I want to encourage you, the saint, the believer, the child of God, to do the same.
    - Because it's not just for the preacher. God has made those moments available to every believer. All we have to do is commit, and you too will receive power, power that will manifest itself in your life through a conduit, which is the Holy Spirit.
  - Last week I left you with some focus verses, verses I wanted you to study or at least read this week on your own. And so, that's where we are going to pick back up this morning. Here's what Paul wrote at the end of Chapter 8.

2 Cor. 8:16 **But thanks be to God who puts the same earnestness in your behalf in the heart of Titus.**
2 Cor. 8:17 **For he not only accepted our appeal, but being himself very earnest, he has gone to you of his own accord.**
2 Cor. 8:18 **We have sent along with him the brother whose fame in *the things of* the gospel *has spread* through all the churches;**
2 Cor. 8:19 **and not only *that,* but he has also been appointed by the churches to travel with us in this gracious work, which is being administered by us for the glory of the Lord Himself, and *to show* our readiness,**
2 Cor. 8:20 **taking precaution so that no one will discredit us in our administration of this generous gift;**
2 Cor. 8:21 **for we have regard for what is honorable, not only in the sight of the Lord, but also in the sight of *other* people.**
2 Cor. 8:22 **We have sent with them our brother, whom we have often tested and found diligent in many things, but now even more diligent because of *his* great confidence in you.**
2 Cor. 8:23 **As for Titus, *he is* my partner and fellow worker among you; as for our brothers, *they are* messengers of the churches, a glory to Christ.**
2 Cor. 8:24 **Therefore, openly before the churches, show them the proof of your love and of our reason for boasting about you.**

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- If you have been with us at all over the last several weeks, you know Chapter 8 is all about giving. But really, it's all about sacrifice. As a matter of fact, my NASB (New American Standard Bible) entitled this section 'Great Generosity'.
    - What we have discovered throughout our teaching of Chapter 8 is that Paul's message isn't just about giving in the way we have traditionally been taught about giving. On the contrary, it's about giving in the way God set up, a supernaturally designed giving. Specifically, how giving is not about the amount, but the sacrifice.
        - And how that, when we sacrifice, the benefits are not just for the one receiving but also for the one who gives. As a matter of fact, Paul spoke in terms of how, when we give it creates equality, but not equality in terms of wealth redistribution/socialism or communism, but equality in the sense that the giver needs something that they cannot access without having someone to give to.
        - And the receiver needs something that they cannot receive without the giver giving it to them. In other words, when the two (the giver and the receiver) come together, equality takes place. And what is it the giver receives? According to Paul it was an abundance of joy. And what does the receiver receive? It was the money to help take care of their basic needs.
        - And so, with that thought front and center of our minds, Paul continues this same theme all the way through the end of Chapter 8. Listen to verses 16-17 one more time:

2 Cor. 8:16 **But thanks be to God who puts the same earnestness on your behalf in the heart of Titus.**
2 Cor. 8:17 **For he not only accepted our appeal, but being himself very earnest, he has gone to you of his own accord.**

- Now, I want to point out something before we move forward. Something that might throw you for a loop if you slow down long enough to think about it. Notice what Paul says in verses 16&17. He says,

2 Cor. 8:16 **Thanks be to God who puts the same earnestness in your behalf, in the heart of Titus**
2 Cor. 8:17 **For he not only accepted our appeal, but being himself very earnest, he has gone to you of his own accord.**

- The key statement to pick up on in verse 16 is thanks be to God, who puts. The words, 'who puts' tell us something. They tell us that the earnestness that Titus feels for the church at Corinth as it relates to the offering they are taking up for the church in Jerusalem. That earnestness was given to him by none other than God Himself.
    - Which means he didn't manifest it of his own accord, nor was he compelled by anyone else. God laid it on his heart, and from there he simply followed in obedience. Now, having said that, notice verse 17 does however say that not only did he accept our appeal (meaning Paul and the other disciples), but he also says that Titus himself, being very earnest, has gone to you of his own accord.

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- In other words, Paul is saying we did try to compel him, but God had already done a work in his heart, and he did this long before we even said a word. And for you and me, this is very important because that's how it works.
  - We don't have to compel anyone to do or give or sacrifice or anything else for that matter, we simply point out the need and if it's in line with God's will, that need will be met by God. This is the consistent testimony of scripture. God is always working preemptively in the heart of the individual believer to meet whatever need must be met.

- This is such an important Biblical Concept for us to understand, because honestly, it takes all the anxiety and stress out of life. Think about it, if you know and understand that God is already at work meeting your needs before you even know you have a need, isn't that pretty liberating?
  - But how do we know this is the case? I mean, after all, that's not exactly what verse 16&17 said. Well, for further insight on this, I want you to listen to what Jesus said about this topic in Matthew 6:7-8, when He spoke to the disciples about how it was that they should and should not be praying. Listen to what he said:

Matt. 6:7 **"And when you are praying, do not use thoughtless repetition as the Gentiles do, for they think that they will be heard because of their many words.** Matt. 6:8 **So do not be like them; for your Father knows what you need before you ask Him.**

- Matthew quotes Jesus, and says God knows what you need before you need it. Which means if He knows what you need before you need it, then He is already working behind the scenes to meet that need, and He does that by placing earnestness and compulsion in someone's heart. Earnestness and Compulsion for that individual to step up and meet whatever need must be met.
  - Which means God doesn't need us playing Holy Spirit in the lives of another believer. Nothing wrong with making the need known, but then we must wait, and we can be sure that God will compel someone to step up. That's the way it works.
    - And let me say one more thing about Titus as it relates to his earnestness about collecting this offering for the poorer church in Jerusalem. You see, the Corinthians might think that the zeal of Titus as it relates to the relief-fund, that his zeal might simply be a zeal for the benefit of the poorer church in Jerusalem.
    - But in reality, it was a zeal on behalf of the Corinthians. You see, Titus wanted the church in Corinth to get in on the grace that God bestowed on the churches of Macedonia, which showed up when they sacrificed at a certain level. And what level did they sacrifice? They sacrificed what they had (referenced by Paul as their ability), and from what they didn't have (also referenced by Paul as being beyond their ability).
- It was that type of sacrifice that activated a supernatural move of God in the lives of those people in the churches of Macedonia, and Paul and Titus wanted the church at Corinth to get in on what God was doing. And what was He doing? When they gave sacrificially it activated God's grace, which yielded an abundance of joy.

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- And so, the message was simple, and that was if the Church of Corinth wanted to experience what the other churches experienced, then all they would have to do was make the same type of sacrifices. But if they didn't, they themselves would be the chief losers.
- Now, the interesting thing about all this is God Himself is the one really doing all the work. Look at it. He placed earnestness in Titus' heart, which means all we have to do is be obedient. It's the same message over and over again. All God requires is our obedience and willingness to act, and He will do the rest.
  - Next, moving on, Paul kind of shifts gears on us a little bit when he says this in verses 18-24:

2 Cor. 8:18 We have sent along with him the brother whose fame in *the things of* the gospel *has spread* through all the churches;
2 Cor. 8:19 and not only *that,* but he has also been appointed by the churches to travel with us in this gracious work, which is being administered by us for the glory of the Lord Himself, and *to show* our readiness,
2 Cor. 8:20 taking precaution so that no one will discredit us in our administration of this generous gift;
2 Cor. 8:21 for we have regard for what is honorable, not only in the sight of the Lord, but also in the sight of *other* people.
2 Cor. 8:22 We have sent with them our brother, whom we have often tested and found diligent in many things, but now even more diligent because of *his* great confidence in you.
2 Cor. 8:23 As for Titus, *he is* my partner and fellow worker among you; as for our brothers, *they are* messengers of the churches, a glory to Christ.
2 Cor. 8:24 Therefore, openly before the churches, show them the proof of your love and of our reason for boasting about you.

- Paul says we are sending another person along with Titus, a famous person (at least as it relates to the work he has done pertaining to the Gospel of Jesus Christ). So evidently word of this man's work has spread throughout the churches.
  - Having said that, we don't know who this brother is because He didn't see fit to tell us in His word. But many scholars have speculated on who it might be. Some have said Luke and any number of men who had assisted Paul in work. Whomever it was, the Churches of Macedonia, Asia Minor, and Galatia had chosen this man as a courier, and they all knew him well.
    - And more importantly, he had won their respect, and to be honest with you it really doesn't matter who it is, because the point Paul is trying to make has nothing to do with the man's name or his notoriety. And so, what is Paul's point, because that's all you and I need to be concerned with.
  - It was that Paul was very conscious of his need to carefully guard this generous gift and to protect the people handling it. Meaning primary concern was that of being above reproach and for him to stay as far away from any charge of financial

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mismanagement as he could.

- And why? Well, he tells us why, so that he wouldn't be discredited. You see, simply doing what was right wasn't enough for Paul. He wanted to make sure that everyone knew that what he did was above board and honest.

- It's interesting how Paul had learned to anticipate the suspicions or accusations of those who viewed his ministry critically, and then to take the necessary precautions in dealing with financial matters. Obviously.
  - Cicero, the Roman philosopher, said (*De officiis* 2.21.75) "but the main thing in all public administration and public service is to avoid even the slightest suspicion of avarice' (ava -res)", which is extreme greed for wealth or material gain. Obviously, there were some observers of Paul's ministry who wondered if Paul might be using other people's money for his own advantage.
    - Which makes sense, right? You could hear them saying things like, he is probably skimming a certain percentage of this large gift off the top as a commission of sort. And so, to guard against any misunderstanding, Paul had originally thought that he would not accompany the delegates, those who carried the money to Jerusalem (1 Cor. 16:3-4; cf. 2 Cor. 1:16; Rom. 15:25).
  - He had also insisted that the churches, rather than he himself, appoint the delegates (1 Cor. 16:3), and that two delegates accompany Titus to Corinth before he arrived (vv. 18-19, 22-23). What he was doing was trying to apply the wisdom of Proverbs 3:3-4, which says:

Proverbs 3:3 Do not let kindness and truth leave you; Bind them around your neck,
Write them on the tablet of your heart.
Proverbs 3:4 So you will find favor and a good reputation in the sight of God and man.

- Then skipping down in Proverbs 3:20-21 it says:

Proverbs 3:20 By His knowledge the ocean depths were burst open, and the clouds drip with dew.
Proverbs 3:21 My son, *see that* they do not escape from your sight;
comply with sound wisdom and discretion.

- You know guys, this is so important for all of us to understand (especially pastors).
  - We must apply Paul's wise caution, especially in a day and age when so many professed servants of the Lord have proved deceitful. We cannot afford to be naive or careless in these matters, but rather do things that are honorable in the sight of all people.
  - I've been in and around ministry for over 30 years, and the stories abound about the mishandling of ministry funds everywhere. Now when we hear about a mishandling of funds inside the church, we generally think about the preacher being the one who did it. But the truth is, it's not always the preacher dipping his hand into the cookie

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jar.

- For example, I've heard from pastors who told me they would preach at a church and the church would take up an offering for them. And then at the end of the night when they gave it to him, he would be surprised how the amount of the offering would sometimes end up at an even amount, or how some would privately tell him about a specific amount they gave, maybe to be allotted toward a specific initiative the preacher or his ministry were doing.
- But then, when counted, the entire offering didn't total that amount. So not only have some preachers been caught in different types of money schemes, so have other church leaders, and Paul wants to stay as far away from that as he can. And of course, so do we. That's why we have men like Titus and Paul who are appointed to handle the finances for this church.

- Pressing on, next we move into Chapter 9. I know that's hard to believe, but it's true.

- Having said that, even though we are moving forward, the topic of giving still remains. As a matter of fact, my NASB Bible entitles this next section "God Gives the Most". Yep, just when you thought it was safe to come back to church because the dang giving messages were over, here we are again.
  - Listen to what Paul says in 2 Cor. 9:1-5. And before we read this section, I want to make a bold statement. One that may get me in trouble, and that is, in this section we are going to read Paul's words and then receive his surface message. But the message behind the surface message may shock you, because we are going to see Paul do something that I don't think we should do. What?
  - One more time. In this section I believe we are going to read about a deeper spiritual truth, something that I do not think we should do, especially in light of our early teaching, which said God knows what we need before we need it, and therefore He is already working beforehand to meet our needs.
    - So, wonder what it is? Well, let's read it and find out.

2 Cor. 9:1 For it is superfluous (suh-pur-floo-uhs, which means over and above; more than enough)
For it was superfluous for me to write to you about this ministry to the saints;
2 Cor. 9:2 for I know your willingness, of which I boast about you to the Macedonians, *namely,* that Achaia has been prepared since last year, and your zeal has stirred up most of them.
2 Cor. 9:3 But I have sent the brothers, in order that our boasting about you may not prove empty in this case, so that, as I was saying, you will be prepared;
2 Cor. 9:4 otherwise, if *any* Macedonians come with me and find you unprepared, we—not to mention you—would be put to shame by this confidence.
2 Cor. 9:5 So I considered it necessary to urge the brothers that they go on ahead to you and arrange in advance your previously promised generous gift, that the same would be ready as a generous gift, and not as *one grudgingly given due to* greediness.

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- Before we begin breaking down this section, let me remind you, when the cannon of scripture was originally put together it wasn't broken into chapters or verses. Chapter breaks weren't placed in the Bible until roughly about the 12th century, and verses weren't introduced until the 15th Century.
    - So, when we read the Bible, remember we aren't reading it in its original formatting, which can sometimes lead to confusion, primarily because when we think of the Bible we tend to think of it like any other book, where a chapter changes the topic. That's not the case with the Bible. It was written continuously and reads somewhat (but not exactly) like a run-on sentence.
        - The writers wrote continuous with no thought of topic change in mind, which is obvious when we begin reading Chapter 9, because Paul is still writing about the same thing, which was urging the church in Corinth to continue taking up the offering they had promised one year earlier. The one they were gathering for the poorer churches in Jerusalem.
    - So, as I said, in this section we see Paul once again pressing in on the Corinthian Church for them to remember the promise they made related to the offering they were gathering for the poorer church in Jerusalem.
- Now let me say this, this offering evidently was a very important one, and we know it was because Paul and the other disciples were taking some of it. They weren't taking any of it, Paul is simply passionate about the wealthier Corinthian Church giving 'beyond the ability', because they had it and the poorer Church of Jerusalem really needed it.
    - It doesn't actually say the Church in Jerusalem really needed it, but we do know this to be the case, because it's mentioned in other places in scripture (especially as it relates to how poor they were). All you have to do to get the sense of urgency of this offering is read and then re-read this section a few times and you clearly see how Paul really wants the Church at Corinth to give sacrificially, like maybe, they have never given before.
        - That's why he is writing about it so much. Honestly, he is almost in selling mode. Trying to take control of the situation, which is evident by how hard he is pushing. Now let me break it down for you so I can show you what I mean.
- Number 1: In Chapter 8, Paul really begins emphasizing how the churches of Macedonia were (by and through God's Grace) blessed because of their sacrificial giving.
    - And then, number 2: He wants to assure them their gift is being handled correctly. As a matter of fact, he is going to great lengths to show them how their gift will be protected by reminding them there will be two men taking the gift.
        - And we also know from other teachings in scripture that when a church gave, many times they would appoint a person from their fellowship to accompany the men, those who were taking the gift to whomever it was going to. To accompany them on the journey of delivering the gift.
    - And then, finally, Number 3: He kind of guilts them a little bit in verses 3-5 when he says to them, "I have been boasting about you", and then, I'll paraphrase here for a minute, he says, you know I have been boasting about you so don't let me down. That's what he means when he says, in order that our boasting about you may not prove empty in this case, so that, as I was saying, you will be prepared.

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- And then on top of all that, he states, and if any of the Macedonians come with me and find you unprepared, we, not to mention you, would be put to shame by this confidence.
- In other words, make sure your gift is a sacrificial gift (beyond your ability), because it sure would be embarrassing for the churches of Macedonia to see you do something less. And then, just in case they don't get it, he says this in verse 5:

2 Cor. 9:5 **So I considered it necessary to urge the brothers that they go on ahead to you and arrange in advance your previously promised generous gift, that the same would be ready as a generous gift, and not as *one grudgingly given due to* greediness.**

- Basically, I am going to send these men on ahead to you. Just make sure you are prepared with the gift you promised.
  - Now I started out this section by saying that I believe Paul is doing something we shouldn't do. And so, what is it? Well, it pertains to the amount of pressure and guilt he is putting on these people. You see, God knows what we need before we need it and He's already working to meet that need.
    - Which means, God knows the poorer church in Jerusalem is in desperate need of financial support (it's His church), and so He has already prepared beforehand the means of their support, which includes where it will come from, which is from the wealthier Church of Corinth.
    - And, because I know from the testimony of scripture that God will take care of the situation. And let me say, Paul also knows this. Because I know God will take care of this situation, I don't believe we should press in on people. But if that's the case, then why does Paul continue to drive this point in the ground?
- Meaning, why does he continue to drive his point home from different angles by saying things like, now you know that the churches of Macedonia have been blessed immensely by God's Grace because of their sacrificial giving and you don't want to miss out on it. And I have boasted about you to the churches of Macedonia, and I hope you are still preparing your offering.
  - I am sending some men to help you, to make sure you do what you said you are going to do. And oh, by the way, wouldn't it be embarrassing if someone from the churches of Macedonia showed up and you weren't prepared after I bragged on you? Why does he do this? Because he is human. Because he is no different than you and me.
  - Think about it. Can't you hear yourself in Paul's own words? Especially when you really need something or want something, or you are trying to obtain something through someone else. Maybe you're trying to purchase something or trying to obtain something; a job, a piece of land, a house, a car, a scholarship.
    - Whatever it is, we do the same thing. We put forth our best case and then many times drive it home. And we do that with more and more reasons why. Why that person should favor us over someone else when it comes to getting what we

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want.

- But the question is, is that the way it should be? No, and I will tell you why. Because when we do this, we step out of faith and into the flesh. When we do this, 'we' essentially take over by removing God from the equation. By subconsciously saying to ourselves, "Okay God, I can handle it from here".
  - And we don't have to do this. It's futile and it never changes the end result. God is going to do what God is going to do. I have often run into this in my own life, especially as it relates to business. Primarily when trying to land a job. As a matter of fact, it happened this past week.

- I've been meeting with a church in another state who had a fire in their sanctuary in July. We were recommended by a consultant to do the work, and I have met with the Pastor and a few other members of his church on at least three occasions. Each time I stated the reasons why they should use us, over and over again, trying to make the case why we are the best company for the job.
  - And by the way, we are the best company for the job, but that's neither here nor there. My point is, this past week when I met with this church I felt somewhat like Paul, trying to sell them on our services. And honestly, I could feel myself stepping out of faith a little bit into my flesh by easing over into the sales side of things.
    - I could feel it in my spirit, and so once I recognized it, I immediately backed off and said to the Pastor and his wife, Hey guys, it's up to you. Let me know. If God wants me to do this job, then it will happen. If not, it's okay with me.
- Now let me say this, this is another one of those liberating feelings that can only be manifested by and through our faith. The problem is, even though we may know this, many times when we find ourselves in these situations, we still revert back to the flesh. And this will always be the case by the way until we mature. Mature spiritually. And how do we do that?
  - We do it by getting to know God in a more intimate way. And how do we get to know God in a more intimate way? We study His word. We get to know Him by ingesting and rightly dividing His word in context. Essentially, we read and study His memoirs, and then slowly, over time, we become more confident in who God is and how He operates.
  - That is the only way we mature, and it's only then that we will begin to do what Paul taught us in 2 Cor. 5:6-7, which was what? Let's re-read it and see.

2 Cor. 5:6 **Therefore, being always of good courage, and knowing that while we are at home in the body we are absent from the Lord—**
2 Cor. 5:7 **for we walk by faith, not by sight—**

- Remember, walking by faith and not by sight isn't just some bumper sticker saying. It's real, but it's not an automatic reality in the life of a believer. We must mature spiritually if we truly want to experience this phenomenon.
  - Now, you may be sitting here this morning and saying to yourself, who does Pastor Greg think he is? How dare he try and correct the Apostle Paul. And if you think that, well then you would be correct, kind of, sort of, but not really. I am not really

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correcting him. I am simply stating that in his zeal to help the poorer church of Jerusalem, he is working overtime to drive home his point.

- But in the end, God is going to do what He is going to do, and Paul's exuberance isn't going to change a thing. Now this brings on more talk when you think about it. Because am I not saying we should never fight for what we believe in? Nope - not at all.

- I am saying we should always put forth our best foot, or best case, and we should always prepare and make our best presentation. But, when we cross over the line (and we know where that line is), when we move from faith into flesh, that's when we must back off. And if you are a believer, only you know where that line is.
- I know where it is, because I always lead from a place of peace into a place of stress or anxiety. And when I start feeling stressed about the situation, I know it's at that point I am moving from the Spirit into the flesh. And honestly, I think that's the best way for all of us to know the difference.

- But back to my original statement. Is Paul doing something wrong? Well, it depends. Is he working from the flesh or the spirit? I say that God included this scenario in the cannon of scripture to teach us a lesson, even though Paul himself wouldn't have known this to be the case.
  - And those lessons are going to close out today. The first lesson is what we just learned, which is we must trust God because He knows what we need before we need it, and we don't have to stress. Simply trust Him.
  - But then at the same time, as we learn the lessons Paul puts forth, the ones for example we have learned over the past several weeks. The ones about sacrificial giving, which happens when we sacrifice 'above and beyond our ability', which is what I call the surface message.
    - There is also the deeper message. As we have learned with the Bible, there is the message (the one you are reading), and then there is the message behind the message. The one you don't read. The surface message itself is usually clear, but the message behind the message isn't always that way.
    - This morning, the deeper message of God is that (regardless of our passion), God is always going to do what He is going to do. And so don't stress.
  - And so, do I think Paul is wrong? I think Paul is pushing hard, but I also know that inside his push are deep spiritual truths being taught. So no, I don't think Paul is wrong, because God is teaching us something through his writing, through what he is doing.
- I realize this may sound like I am talking out of both sides of my mouth, but I assure you this is not the case. Paul is doing what he is doing, and while doing it we are also learning about God's character. How He operates.
  - For example, how our sacrificial giving activates God's Grace by bringing us a supernatural work by way of "an abundance of joy". But in the same token, we are also being shown a picture of pressure and stress brought about by Paul's zeal, which teaches us another lesson about waiting on God and trusting God for the result.
  - Remember, as I always say, God and His word is like a kaleidoscope. It's blue but

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green, but maybe blue green. There are so many facets to His Word, which is what makes the Bible unlike any other ancient document of antiquity.

- So, this morning, take it for what it is and remember, God knows what we need before we need it, and if we are supposed to have it, whatever it is, He will provide it. As a matter of fact, He's already working to provide it.

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- So last time we were together we finally made it into 2 Corinthians 9:1-5, where the topic of giving continued to be front and center. This topic started in Chapter 8 and has continued on into Chapter 9.
    - Having said that, even though giving was and is the topic at hand (at least on the surface), the reality is, giving is just a biproduct of a deeper systemic issue. And that issue is what?
    - Obedience stemming from a lack of understanding of who God is and what blessings He bestows upon the giver, especially when the giver gives sacrificially. And then of course there is dedication, discipline, and even integrity. These adjectives kind of sum up what's going on with Paul and his writings to the Corinthian Church as a whole.
        - And Chapter 8 is really just a continuation of that theme as it relates to the topic of giving. And so, to bring us back up to speed (after being off a week), I would like to summarize where we are.
- You see, the Church at Corinth had made a commitment to take up an offering for the poorer church in Jerusalem, and they made that commitment roughly one year prior to Paul writing this letter. And so, Paul is writing, reminding them of that commitment. Giving them a heads up of sorts, a heads up that Titus and a couple of other men are coming back through to collect that offering.
    - And as a result, Paul does something in His writing that I said was wrong, something that I said we shouldn't really do, which by the way was met with a little push back. And what was it?
        - Well, he writes the letter letting the church know they are coming to collect the offering, and there is no problem with that. But then He expends a lot of energy driving his point home. Honestly, he really wears them out. He puts a lot of pressure on them using varying examples of why they should follow through with what they said they would do.
- Now, why did I say Paul shouldn't have done that? Because it doesn't help, and it doesn't actually work. You see, this church knows full well the commitment they made, and at the end of the day God knows it as well, and ultimately, He is the one in control of the result or outcome.
    - Now, this type of talk (as I said) has been met with some raised eyebrows throughout the years, and this morning I want to spend the majority of our time explaining why I said what I said and why this is such a controversial statement.
    - And so, without further a due, why is what I said so controversial? Why does this type of talk seem to upset people so much? Why, when I say Paul shouldn't be dunning these people for money, why did I say it and why does it cause somewhat of a stir? I'll begin with why it causes such stir.
        - It primarily causes a stir because it creates a type of internal conflict inside the life of a believer. Meaning, when we stop to think about it, it makes us wonder and ask ourselves a question. Where should my effort stop and where does God's begin? In other words, where is the dividing line between man's responsibility verses God's sovereignty?
- The answer is there is no such dividing line. God is sovereign and that is it. Oh my, now preacher I believe God is Sovereign, but I am sorry, you can't tell me that man has no

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responsibility. I didn't say man has no responsibility. He does. I'm saying if you think God's will hinges on your actions, you would be wrong.

- What? You mean to tell me that God is going to do what God is going to do regardless of the effort I put forth? Yes, that's exactly what I mean. Well, that just doesn't make sense to me. I mean after all, there are many commands in the scripture that specifically tell us to do things.
- What about all the verses in the Bible telling the Jews to do something? Verses that say, if they do whatever it is that God tells them to do then He will do something for them, something positive. Or what about the inverse of that, where God warns them, tells them that if they don't do something He will do something negative or allow something disastrous to happen to them? What about those verses?
- What about them? They are true and they are real, and when the people didn't do what God told them to do then guess what (based on the testimony of scripture)? Something bad happened. Well okay, then what's your rebuttal to that fact?
  - I could spend all day proving to you from the pages of scripture why man's responsibility does not trump God's will, but I think the best way to explain it is by simply leaning on the pragmatic or logical side of things. And to do that, all you have to do is ask yourself the question, can I or any other human being stop 'The Will' of God?
  - The answer is obviously no. You and I cannot stop what God is doing, or for that matter what He is going to do. But that begs the question, if that's the case then why does God command us to do things like pray, or tell us to seek, or tell us to ask Him for something, etc.?

- Why does God command us to pray if what He desires is going to happen anyway? As a matter of fact, why be obedient at all? If this is a question lingering in your mind then you're in luck, because I have the answer. And the answer is, because God told you to do it because He is the creator and we are His creation, and He is using His creation to accomplish His will.
  - But remember, you and I are simply one 'spec' inside His creation. We are a vapor as King Solmon put it. And how absurd is it, or for that matter, how arrogant is it for us to think that God needs us to complete His will.
    - You do realize that He owns and possesses a whole bunch of us. Which means if we aren't willing to be obedient then He will either, (A)-force us to do it (just as He did with Jonah), or (B)-move on to someone else.
  - You see, this is so important for us to understand, and it really just boils down to psychology. Yes, psychology applies even when studying and applying scripture. Honestly, psychology matters in just about every aspect of life. When I say psychology, I mean psychology as it relates to how you view God and His word, or the way you think He views you. Your position before Him. It really matters and let me show you what I mean.
    - If you view God in a way that says God somehow needs us, meaning (sub consciously) in your mind you think God needs us to accomplish His something. That somehow if we aren't available, then what He desires wouldn't be accomplished, or that how you react to conviction, that in some way your reaction will control the outcome.

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        - If that's what you think, then that type of thinking will cause you to become a believer who does things for the wrong reason. It will actually drive your behavior in an unhealthy way. Meaning, you will be driven out of guilt or some type of sense of responsibility, rather than being driven for the Biblical reason. Which is what? Obedience born out of a love for God.
- When you hold to this view, it's a view that says, "God has chosen me for a task, and He has given me the opportunity to participate in the work of ministry. In a work that He is already doing in and around me."
    - If you think that way, then your approach to whatever God convicts you to do is very different. Think about it for minute. In the first scenario you are busy, and you are stressed from the life you are living, but then you feel convicted about doing something. Maybe it's giving money to someone or taking an interest in someone's life when you don't really want to.
    - Or maybe it's telling someone about your church, and you don't really have time, but you do it anyway out of guilt or maybe a thought that says, if I don't do this, then whatever it is God is trying to do will not be accomplished, and therefore I will be held responsible.
        - That would be a traditional view of our response, maybe not consciously but defiantly subconsciously. Primarily because that's what we have been taught. You can hear other believers or preachers saying things like, if you don't do it who will do it, or if you don't do it then that person may starve or may never hear the Gospel.
    - And so, for that reason, you do whatever it is. But you see, if you do that, then we are doing it for the wrong reason. And not just the wrong reason (as in doing it with a poor attitude or doing it begrudgingly) but doing it for the wrong reason because you have a fundamental misunderstanding of who God is, and ultimately who's in control of the outcome.
    - And believe it or not, the way you view obedience matters to God. At one point in my life, I told people about Jesus because I feared if I didn't, they wouldn't be saved. Today I tell people about Jesus because God told me too. Because I am a slave (a Dullosis) of the God most high.
        - I am a servant, which is liberating by the way because it means I can tell people about Jesus or invite them to church without fear of awkwardness or rejection. And if they don't listen or if they aren't interested, I don't sweat it because I am not in control of the outcome.
- You see in this scenario when God lays it on your heart to do something, even though you are still living a stressed-filled life, you feel honored that God chose you. That He gave you an opportunity to participate. And you know in your mind that in the end, that if you aren't obedient, He will move on to a believer who will be obedient. And that person will be the one who will receive the blessing.
    - This is an example of why psychology is important in matters relating to God and God's Word. God isn't commanding you to do something because He desperately needs you to do it, He is commanding you to do something because of what He is prepared to do through you, and for you. Jeremiah 29:11 says it this way,

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Jeremiah 9:11 For I know the plans that I have for you,' declares the LORD, 'plans for prosperity and not for disaster, to give you a future and a hope.

- "For I know the plans that I have for you", is the key to this verse. God already knows the plans He has for you, and those benefits are available to you if you are obedient. These words were spoken through the prophet Jeremiah to the people of Israel. God had spoken many words to these people throughout the years, and sometimes they listened and other times they did not.
    - The reason I say that the key to this verse is, "For I know the plans I have for you", is because God has a plan for you, but you have to work to stay in that plan. The Bible calls it being in the "Will of God".
        - In other words, the reason we obey is not so that God's will might be accomplished, we obey because we are His children and we want to please Our Father who is in Heaven so that we can receive what God is prepared to give us, which by the way isn't necessarily money and it's certainly not more stuff.
        - Who knows what it may be. It may be what the churches in Macedonia received when they obediently gave in a sacrificial manner, which was an 'abundance of joy'. It really doesn't matter what it is, because whatever it is, I assure you, you will want it.
- Now, throughout the centuries there has been a great debate over this concept or topic, one that has raged on and never seems to die. As a matter of fact, it continues to rage on even today. And that is the debate between God's sovereignty and man's responsibility. Between the freewill of man verses God's Providential Hand.
    - This topic has gained much notoriety throughout the years, so much so that both sides have given each other names. For the sovereignty side they have been given the name 'Calvinist.' named after John Calvin, one of the Great Reformers of the 15th century.
    - Calvin has been credited with really pushing the sovereignty of God over the freewill of man, but the truth is he was not the first scholar to point out the Sovereignty of God, he just seems to be the one who received the credit for it.
        - Many scholars throughout the centuries have noted that the scriptures paint for us a picture of a Sovereign God who is in total control over His creation. And just in case you are wondering if God is totally sovereign, He is. And this truth is indeed highlighted on just about every page of scripture.
- And so, as John Calvin studied scripture and came to this revelation. He developed '5 Points' that he felt summarized this topic, which eventually became known as the 5 points of Calvinism. The 5 points of Calvinism said:
    - That man was born in total depravity, lost and in separation from God.
    - That election is unconditional, that God elects people unto salvation.
    - That atonement was limited, limited to only the elect.
    - That God's grace is irresistible, meaning no one will resist it.
    - And that the Saints will persevere (Perseverance of the Saints), meaning all those being saved (as Paul called it), they will persevere until the end. Which means you

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cannot lose your salvation.

- Now we don't have time to study all this today, but just know that when you hear someone reference the '5 points' of Calvinism, or call someone a Calvinist, this is what they are referring to. There is also an acronym given to the 5 Points of Calvinism, so that people could remember it.
    - It's called 'TULIP' - Total Depravity – Unconditional Election – Limited Atonement - Irresistible Grace – Perseverance of the Saints. By the way, just a side note, this debate is cyclical. Meaning it dies for a decade or two and then it seems to rear its head again. And what's funny is, when it reappears, the new group of Christians, the ones studying it or the ones discovering it for the first time, they act as if it's a new concept.
        - I'll use the Southern Baptists as a prime example of what I am talking about.
    - Over the past few years, Calvinism has become a topic that has caused a major riff within the Southern Baptist Convention. As a matter of fact, this was a big topic at the SBC Conference a few years ago. They took a vote on this very thing, whether Calvinism has any place in the doctrines of Southern Baptists.
        - I want to read you an article that was written about the SBC Convention a few years back, highlighting this issue.
        - "It is no secret that, over the last thirty years, the presence and influence of Calvinism has grown within the Southern Baptist Convention. While there are those who are concerned over the theological stance and the trend of its growing presence and popularity, some enthusiastically welcome it."
        - Article V, referenced "God's Purpose of Grace," in the *Baptist Faith and Message (BF&M)* states:

Election is the gracious purpose of God, according to which He regenerates, justifies, sanctifies, and glorifies sinners. It is consistent with the free agency of man and comprehends all the means in connection with the end.
It is the glorious display of God's sovereign goodness, and is infinitely wise, holy, and unchangeable. It excludes boasting and promotes humility.
All true believers endure to the end. Those whom God has accepted in Christ, and sanctified by His Spirit, will never fall away from the state of grace, but shall persevere to the end.
Believers may fall into sin through neglect and temptation, whereby they grieve the Spirit, impair their graces and comforts, and bring reproach on the cause of Christ and temporal judgments on themselves; yet they shall be kept by the power of God through faith unto salvation.

- This statement reaches back to the original *BF&M* in 1925 and to the New Hampshire Confession of Faith upon which it was based and accomplishes a significant feat; it accommodates the soteriological convictions of both Calvinists and non-Calvinists within the SBC family.
    - While the tensions and debates regarding Calvinism are ever present in Baptist life,

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they have intensified in recent years. As a result, in the last three years Southern Baptist leaders have hosted two different conferences to address the issue.

- The first, in 2007, was entitled "Building Bridges Conference: Southern Baptists and Calvinism," and was sponsored by Southeastern Baptist Theological Seminary (SEBTS) and Founders Ministries and hosted at Ridgecrest Conference Center by LifeWay Christian Resources. Approximately 550 attendees participated in the three-day conference.
- The second was "The John 3:16 Conference" in 2008, sponsored by Jerry Vines Ministries, and co-sponsored by New Orleans Baptist Theological Seminary, Southwestern Baptist Theological Seminary (SWBTS), Liberty Baptist Theological Seminary, Luther Rice Seminary, and Midwestern Baptist Theological Seminary. It was hosted by First Baptist Church, Woodstock, Georgia, with about 1,000 attendees at the two-day conference.

- Each conference resulted in a book that committed the primary addresses to text and presented them in chapter form. Both books were published by B&H Academic, a division of B&H Publishing Group of LifeWay Christian Resources.

- So, as you can see, this topic can be an issue. Now, on the other side of Calvinism lives what's known as Arminianism, also known as Arminiasts. Where Calvinism advocates unconditional election, the idea that God has elected certain individuals for salvation based solely on His will.
  - In contrast, Arminianism believes in conditional election, which is the idea that God elects individuals based on His foreknowledge of who will freely choose to accept His grace. One group sets up camp solely on the sovereignty and control of God. The other leans heavily on man's will and free choice.
  - Now this morning, the question that might be rolling around in your head might be, well, what am I? Before you answer, I have some good news. There is another position. In recent years, Dr. Michael Brown debated Dr. James White, and in that debate, he introduced a new concept. It was a new concept to me and evidently a new concept to Dr. White, and it's one I find interesting.
    - It is a concept called Molinism. A Molinist says that both sides are correct. That God is sovereign, and man has freewill. And I will say, in a sense this seems to be true. But I will also say, regardless of where someone may fall on these topics, the scripture never paints a picture of God in need of a man.
    - Meaning, that somehow if we aren't obedient God cannot accomplish what He wills to do, and I am sure you can see from a strictly pragmatic point of view how God needing man to accomplish anything wouldn't make sense, because God is the Creator, and we are His Creation.
- And so, there you have it – a lesson on Calvinism/Arminianism and what it means to be a Molinist, and believe it or not, I will digress on this point because I realize this was a long way around just to back up what I said about Paul being wrong. But I felt it was important, because even though what I said may have ruffled a few feathers, the fact is, Paul doesn't have to beg these people for money.
  - He can remind them, yes, absolutely. Maybe even nudge them, no problem. But ultimately, there is no reason to drive them into the ground, because it will not change the outcome. God intends for the poorer church in Jerusalem to be taken

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care of by the wealthier churches, and that's exactly what's going to happen. Period. The End!

- Now, this morning before we conclude I would like to re-read our previous verse from two weeks ago, and then I would like to segway us into next week's focus verses, and as always, I would like for you to study them for yourself before we meet again. And so, here's what Paul said the last time we were together.

2 Cor. 9:1 **For it is superfluous (suh-pur-floo-uhs) (which means over and above; more than enough) For it was superfluous for me to write to you about this ministry to the saints;**
2 Cor. 9:2 **for I know your willingness, of which I boast about you to the Macedonians, *namely,* that Achaia has been prepared since last year, and your zeal has stirred up most of them.**
2 Cor. 9:3 **But I have sent the brothers, in order that our boasting about you may not prove empty in this case, so that, as I was saying, you will be prepared;**
2 Cor. 9:4 **otherwise, if *any* Macedonians come with me and find you unprepared, we—not to mention you—would be put to shame by this confidence.**
2 Cor. 9:5 **So I considered it necessary to urge the brothers that they go on ahead to you and arrange in advance your previously promised generous gift, that the same would be ready as a generous gift, and not as *one grudgingly given due to* greediness.**

- So, one more time, here we see Paul urging the Church at Corinth to fulfill their commitment. He's pressing in on them just as he has done in Chapter 8, and in this next section he continues with this same type of writing, but he takes a different approach. Let's see what it is.

2 Cor. 9:6 **Now *I say* this: the one who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and the one who sows generously will also reap generously.**
2 Cor. 9:7 **Each one *must do* just as he has decided in his heart, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver.**
2 Cor. 9:8 **And God is able to make all grace overflow to you, so that, always having all sufficiency in everything, you may have an abundance for every good deed;**
2 Cor. 9:9 **as it is written:**
"HE SCATTERED ABROAD, HE GAVE TO THE POOR,
HIS RIGHTEOUSNESS ENDURES FOREVER."
2 Cor. 9:10 **Now He who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food will supply and multiply your seed for sowing and increase the harvest of your righteousness;**
2 Cor. 9:11 **you will be enriched in everything for all liberality, which through us is producing thanksgiving to God.**

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2 Cor. 9:12 For the ministry of this service is not only fully supplying the needs of the saints, but is also overflowing through many thanksgivings to God.
2 Cor. 9:13 Because of the proof given by this ministry, they will glorify God for *your* obedience to your confession of the gospel of Christ and for the liberality of your contribution to them and to all,
2 Cor. 9:14 while they also, by prayer on your behalf, yearn for you because of the surpassing grace of God in you.
2 Cor. 9:15 Thanks be to God for His indescribable gift!

- I want you to take verses 6-15 and study them this week and see if you recognize the shift in his approach.

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- Alright guys, welcome back. So, this morning if you have your Bible with you, turn to 2 Corinthians the 9th chapter. Over the last couple of teachings I've made a statement. One that raised an eyebrow or two, and one that I want to clear up before we move forward this morning. The statement I made pertained to Paul's persistence about giving, specifically as it related to the Church of Corinth's giving verses that of the Churches of Macedonia.
    - The topic of giving began in Chapter 8 and has continued on, even into today's teaching. Now what I said over the last few weeks was, Paul is doing something that we should not do. And what was it that he did?
    - He reminded the church at Corinth of their commitment to take up an offering for the poorer church of Jerusalem. A commitment they had made roughly one year earlier. He let them know that he was sending Titus along with a couple of more men to retrieve that gift, and there is absolutely nothing wrong with that.
        - But after he let them know that Titus and the others would be coming, he really began wearing them out over their promise. And he did so by giving them example after example of why they should follow through on their commitment.
        - And honestly, it wasn't until somewhere around the end of Chapter 8 and on into Chapter 9 that it dawned on me that he was moving from a place of trusting God and into a place of what I call 'helping God out' in an effort to give some extra oomph to the situation. Meaning, he really wanted the gift from the Church at Corinth to be a good one, and so in his writings he continued to emphasize their gift over and over and over again.
    - And as I said, that isn't something we should do, because God is in control. God intends for the Church at Corinth to give, and they will give every dime they are supposed to give, and not a penny more or a penny less.
- Now when I say Paul shouldn't have hounded these people for money, it doesn't mean the scripture is wrong. It means what Paul was doing was wrong, and there are many, many stories in scripture where God's man did something wrong, from Abraham to David to Peter and Paul.
    - So, when I say Paul should have done this or that, I am not saying the scriptures are wrong. I am saying what they did was wrong. Once again, let me be clear. I believe 100% in the inherency of scripture, that the scriptures are without error.
        - And by the way, the topic of Biblical inerrency is one of the most highly debated topics around. But for me there is no debate. God's Word is inspired and without error and without conflict, which means if you run across something in scripture that appears to conflict or be in error, you can rest assured that it is not.
        - But if you do, then you must adhere to the old saying, one that my mentor and close friend Stephen Armstrong used to say, and that is, when plain sense makes common sense, we seek no other sense. When it doesn't, we must dig deeper.
    - Let me say, there have been times when I have run across apparent conflicts in God's Holy Manuscript, but there has never been a time when, after I dug deeper into the background of the book or studied the original translation, that I didn't find the answer to the conflict.
- Now some have said, well, you want to believe there is no conflict, therefore you made

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sure you were able to explain it away. And if someone says that to me, well, I will tell them they don't know me very well and they need to talk to my mother and some of my closest and long-standing friends.

- Because they will tell you I am not a guy that will let well-enough alone, and I am certainly not a 'go with the flow' kind of guy. For me, when something doesn't make sense, whether in life and certainly when it comes to the scriptures, I will not accept some Sunday School answer and quietly be on my way.
- And so, as I said, it makes no difference to me if it's a law, a rule, a job workflow, or a verse of scripture, I must know the why behind everything I do, and it's been that way for me since the day I was born. So, when you hear me teach, you can sleep easy knowing that when I study I pick every last word apart.
  - As a matter of fact, I spend a large portion of my study time studying the Hebrew and the Greek. I drill down into the part of speech of the word, the transliteration of the word, the spelling of the word or words, the phonetic spelling of the word, and then of course the definition and usage, which is, in my opinion, one of the most important parts.
  - I often use a Strongs/Exhaustive Concordance. Sometimes I even use the dictionary. How about that. But not just any dictionary. I use a dictionary written from the 1980s back. Does anyone know why?
- Because the people controlling the meaning of words changed them over time. This was not all bad per se, but when you begin redefining words for the purpose of accommodating social pressures, if that happens you have a problem.
- And so, having said that, if you have a Websters dictionary from the early 80s back, you are pretty safe, but if you use one newer than that it can be tricky. Also, let me say this in case we have some naysayers out there, those who might want to debate what I am saying by saying things like "everyone knows the meaning of words have changed over time, all because the way the word began being used in society changed, therefore there is no harm in that".
  - To those folks I would say, "yes but no".
  - Meaning, yes there are some meanings of words that changed because the meaning of the word in the original King's English changed. Words for example like awful and awesome. The word awful was derived from the word 'awe' which means to "fear, terror, dread, and/or have great reverence".
  - And interesting enough, over time the words awful and awesome became synonymous with the words 'awe-inspiring'. Later on, awful took on a solely negative connotation, which caused the word to take on its modern-day usage, which means extremely bad.
- Awesome, on the other hand, evolved in the opposite way, probably in or around the mid-1900s, where it came to mean extremely good. Nothing necessarily wrong with this unless those words were being used in scripture. Can you see where that would be a bad thing? Because the scriptures never change. They are timeless.

- Anyway, you get my point, and just so you know, when I think of the inherency of God's word, I think of what Paul wrote in 2 Timothy 3:16-17, which said:

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2 Tim. 3:16 All Scripture is inspired by God and beneficial for teaching, for rebuke, for correction, for training in righteousness;
2 Tim. 3:17 so that the man *or woman* of God may be fully capable, equipped for every good work.

- Now when you read the first 4 words of verse 16, it says 'all scripture is inspired'. The word inspired is a Greek word (theopnesutos) (Theo-op'-nyoo-stos) (They-op-news-stews-stus), and the definition is, God-breathed or inspired by God.
  - And so, you can see how just with this one word, that there is a real difference in the meaning of the word. One is God-breathed, and the other is God-inspired. I personally believe there is a huge difference in these meanings.
  - When you say God-breathed, I think of creation. How God breathed it into existence. How He is the Alpha and Omega. The beginning from the end. Where the other word makes me feel (and this is just me), it makes me feel kind of like God did a 'forward', you know like a forward in a book. That he gave some oversight or cursory glance over the writing of the Word.
    - One is absolute and one seems somewhat open-ended. There is another example I use when I talk about translations of the Bible, specifically how important words are. I want to read John 3:17 from my NASB, and then read John 3:17 from the Message Bible.
- My NASB says it this way,

John 3:17 NASB For God did not send the Son into the world to judge the world, but so that the world might be saved through Him.

- Now let's read it from the Message Bible,

John 3:17 MSG God didn't go to all the trouble of sending his Son merely to point an accusing finger, telling the world how bad it was. He came to help, to put the world right again.

- The NASB says "God came, so that the world might be saved", and the Message Bible says, "God came to help". This may not seem like a big difference in the use of words, but I assure you it is.
  - It would be like you drowning in the middle of the ocean, and say I pull up beside you in a boat as you desperately struggle to keep your head above water, and then I say, hey, I see you are drowning. You want me to help you out or save you? Which one would you prefer?
    - So, as you can see, words do matter, and their meanings really matter. And so, with this understanding of how I study scripture in view, let me just say, when I say Paul shouldn't have worn the Church of Corinth out over money, I am not saying that what Paul wrote was wrong. What he wrote was what he wrote.

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        - I am saying that according to Paul's own teachings, dunning these people for money will not increase their giving. And by the way, the same applies for all of us sitting here today. If you give because the preacher or anyone else guilted you into it, you might as well not have given at all.
    - You should always give because God has convicted you to do so. And one more thing, it should never be grope or routine. Rather it should always be with a cheerful heart, out of gladness because you get to participate in what God is doing.
- Now, when I made the statement that Paul shouldn't be wearing these people out over giving, I did that with some background in mind. Background that you may or may not be privy to, and that background will give you some insight into why Paul is so passionate about the welfare of the Church in Jerusalem.
    - And yes, it's easy to say he was passionate because they were poor, but so were the Churches in Macedonia. You know, those churches that Paul just described in Chapter 8 as living in deep poverty. So, lots of churches were poor. Which should leave us asking ourselves, why is he so passionate about the Church of Jerusalem? Anyone know?
    - Well, let me show you why from the pages of scripture. Let's turn to Acts 7:54-60 and then jump into Acts 8:1-3 for the answer. We will start with Acts 7:54-60, where we will read about the stoning of Stephen. And inside this story you will discover why the Church of Jerusalem had such a special place in Paul's heart. Let's read it really quick.

Acts 7:54 Now when they heard this, they were infuriated, and they *began* gnashing their teeth at him.
Acts 7:55 But he, being full of the Holy Spirit, looked intently into heaven and saw the glory of God, and Jesus standing at the right hand of God;
Acts 7:56 and he said, "Behold, I see the heavens opened and the Son of Man standing at the right hand of God."
Acts 7:57 But they shouted with loud voices, and covered their ears and rushed at him with one mind.
Acts 7:58 When they had driven him out of the city, they *began* stoning *him;* and the witnesses laid aside their cloaks at the feet of a young man named Saul.
Acts 7:59 They *went on* stoning Stephen as he called on *the Lord* and said, "Lord Jesus, receive my spirit!"
Acts 7:60 Then he fell on his knees and cried out with a loud voice, "Lord, do not hold this sin against them!" Having said this, he fell asleep.

- Next, we move into Acts Chapter 8:1-3, and here's what we read.

Acts 8:1 Now Saul approved of putting Stephen to death.
And on that day a great persecution began against the church in Jerusalem, and they were all scattered throughout the regions of Judea and Samaria, except for the apostles.

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Acts 8:2 ***Some*** **devout men buried Stephen and mourned loudly for him.**
Acts 8:3 **But Saul began ravaging the church, entering house after house; and he would drag away men and women and put them in prison.**

- So, based on the testimony of Scripture, who was the one who broke up the Church in Jerusalem? Saul, right? Who we now call Paul, which, just an FYI to you; for the record, Saul's name didn't change to Paul. You hear people say that all the time, but that's not the case. His name was Saul, but he was also known as Paul, which is exactly what Acts 13:9 tells us.

Acts 13:9 **But Saul, who was also *known as* Paul, filled with the Holy Spirit, stared at him,**

- So why does he have two names? Because Saul was his Hebrew name, and Paul was His Greek name. Anyway, back to my point. The Church in Jerusalem held a special place in Paul's heart because he is the one that reeked "t-total havoc" on them and broke them up.
  - And no doubt he felt a special kind of responsibility toward them, and therefore, he really wanted to take care of them. Which tells us why he is pushing the Church at Corinth so hard to give sacrificially.
  - Now, with all that said, inside Paul's words lie spiritual truths that are tied back to giving. Which means, even though we shouldn't be dunning people for money, the spiritual blessings that are manifested through sacrificial giving are no less the truth. And that's where we will head next in Paul's writings. Listen to what he says in 2 Cor. 9:6-15:

2 Cor. 9:6 **Now *I say* this: the one who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and the one who sows generously will also reap generously.**
2 Cor. 9:7 **Each one *must do* just as he has decided in his heart, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver.**
2 Cor. 9:8 **And God is able to make all grace overflow to you, so that, always having all sufficiency in everything, you may have an abundance for every good deed;**

- Last week I gave you verses 6-15 as focus verses for this week. But I am going to pause here with verse 8 for just a moment, because we could spend multiple Sunday's teaching on the spiritual truths found in verses 6-8. But before I delve deep into these verses, I would like to point something out, and that is Praise be to God for backing up the statement I made over the past couple of weeks.
  - The one that said we shouldn't be dunning people for money. I'm going to get out of order here for a moment, but I want you to look really quick at verse 7 again:

2 Cor. 9:7 **Each one *must do* just as he has decided in his heart, not**

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reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver.

- Paul, in his own words, says you should never give under compulsion. But the question for me is, is that what the Greek says? No, it says, “each as he purposes in the heart, not out of regret or of necessity; a cheerful giver loves God”. The usage of the word can mean constraint, compulsion; there is need to; force, violence.
  - And so, the sense of the word means to force or compel. And so, even though the word used in the Greek manuscript says necessity, when you study the word, it can be translated to mean compel. Which tells us that if someone gives out of regret or compulsion, their gift is for the wrong reason.
  - And so, the question that lingers in my mind is, will God accept it if we give because someone compelled us, or guilted us? Will God accept that gift? Well, according to the testimony of scripture the answer would be no. And just one example of this shows up in Genesis, all the way back in the very beginning, specifically with the story of Cain and Abel.
    - Do you remember that story? If you don’t remember, I will paraphrase it for you really quick. As most of us know, Cain and Abel were the children of Adam and Eve. Abel was a shepherd and Cain was a farmer.
  - Over time, and by and through the revelation of God, Cain and Abel came to the understanding that in order to please God, they must make sacrifices. They must give sacrificially of what they had, and so for Abel, his gift would come from his herd, and the scripture says he gave of the best portions of the first-born lambs from his flocks.
  - Having said that, Cain on the other hand, according to Genesis 4:4, “He gave of some of his crops”. We aren’t told exactly what “some of his crops” means, we just know that God rejected Cain’s sacrifice while accepting Abel’s. Therefore, we can infer that Cain’s sacrifice wasn’t the best he had to offer.
    - Which tells us something, and that is, giving sacrificially, which is giving in a way that means something to you, meaning, if when you give, you don’t give with a little bit of trepidation, or with a little bit of a heavy heart maybe, as in ‘man oh man I’m going to miss this, or ‘man oh man this hurts a little’, then you are not giving in a sacrificial manner.
  - And what is interesting is, this type of giving is a “mono e mono” type of giving. Meaning, it’s between you and God, because only you and God know what sacrifice really looks like to you. Another way to say it is, only you and God know what causes you to have heart burn. No one else knows.
    - Which means other people may look and see what you have given, and they may think to themselves, wow, look what that person did. But the reality is, and (once again), based on the testimony of scripture, if you see someone give a large gift, their gift may be not even be considered a sacrificial gift by God. It might look sacrificial to you, but you and I have no clue what sacrifice looks like to that individual.
  - You know, throughout my life I have often heard about wealthy people who give a lot of money, and not just to churches but to other charity organizations as well. And I hear people brag about them, how much they have done for the community, or

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about how much they gave to some group.

- And immediately when I hear that, I always think to myself, well, that's awesome, but I wonder if it was a sacrificial gift, or was it just a small portion, or minor overall portion, of their net worth.

- In other words, when they wrote that check did it hurt a little when they gave, or was it a tax write-off, money they weren't going to receive anyway, therefore, they had a choice; they could give it to charity or give it to the government, so they opted to donate it to charity.

- Now it's not always that way, but many times that is the case. And let me tell you how you can know if that's the case or not. If an extremely well-off individual gives, and wants everyone to know what they gave, then most of the time it wasn't a sacrificial gift, it was a tax write-off. Not always, but most of the time.
  - And let me also say, that's okay, because the organization receiving the gift or gifts probably needs the help. And so, you might say, well if that's the case, then who cares why the individual gave. From a world view we don't. I am just saying there is a big difference between giving and sacrificial giving in God's dichotomy.
  - And just a side note. According to scripture, when you give and you let the world know, the blessing you receive comes from this life, not from the one to come. Jesus said it this way in Matthew 6:1-4:

Matthew 6:1 **"Take care not to practice your righteousness in the sight of people, to be noticed by them; otherwise you have no reward with your Father who is in heaven.**
Matthew 6:2 **"So when you give to the poor, do not sound a trumpet before you, as the hypocrites do in the synagogues and on the streets, so that they will be praised by people. Truly I say to you, they have their reward in full.**
Matthew 6:3 **But when you give to the poor, do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing,**
Matthew 6:4 **so that your charitable giving will be in secret; and your Father who sees *what is done* in secret will reward you.**

- Pretty cut and dry, isn't it? Give and let the world know and you will receive all the rewards you are ever going to receive here on earth, but give in secret and your Father in Heaven will reward you. And I assure you, that reward will be far greater than any reward you will receive here and now.
  - Moving on, and we will close with these verses. Going back to verses 6 & 8.

2 Cor. 9:6 **Now *I say* this: the one who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and the one who sows generously will also reap generously.**
2 Cor. 9:7 **Each one *must do* just as he has decided in his heart, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver.**
2 Cor. 9:8 **And God is able to make all grace overflow to you, so that,**

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always having all sufficiency in everything, you may have an abundance for every good deed;

In verse 6, Paul makes a statement that creates a spiritual truth. Honestly, it creates a "Spiritual Law" of sorts. And it's interesting because not only does it apply to believers, but it also seems to apply to the world as well. It's the Law of "Sowing and Reaping".

Paul says, the one who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and the one who sows generously will also reap generously. The Law of Sowing and Reaping is a simple concept really. The concept is based on the fact that money is cyclical. And by the way, money is not the only type of sacrificial giving. There are other types of giving, for example labor or time, but for this exercise we will use money.

So, money is cyclical, and the concept is this; when you give (I didn't say spend), I said give. When you give as a believer with the right motivation, money seems to always find its way back to you. But when it returns, it multiplies. Isn't that interesting. It's really fascinating, especially when you think about investing in your future.

Because this Law tells us that there is no better investment than that of giving. If you want to see your net worth increase, then become a closed-door, private, sacrificial giver. Which, just so you know, is a giver who gives, never expecting anything in return.

Now, as I said earlier, I think what's even more interesting about this Law is how God has also allowed this Law to be available to the world as well.

Throughout my career I have read many stories where wealthy men and women (who were not necessarily believers), even some who were atheist or agnostic, have testified to this whole "Sowing and Reaping" concept. So much so that some high net-worth individuals set out to give away most of their earnings.

Some even have said they vowed to give away 90% of what they made, and they themselves said the more they gave the more they earned, almost as if they couldn't give it away fast enough.

Jeff Bezos, founder of Amazon, falls into this category. He said his goal was to give away the majority of his 124-billion-dollar net worth during his lifetime. *Warren Buffett* understands this concept all too well. So much so that he and Bill Gates' family came up with a concept known as the 'giving pledge', where wealthy people sign up and pledge to give away all their money during their lifetime.

Now, someone might say, well Pastor, the Buffets and Gates are signing that pledge because they are good people and want to help people. I agree. They certainly may be good people, but I assure you early on, they learned about this law, that the more they gave the more seemed to come back to them, and that's what led them to this whole giving pledge thing. In other words, they didn't start out their careers that way. They didn't start out exercising the giving pledge. No, they figured it out over time. Slowly they discovered the more they sowed the more they reaped, which gave them more ability to sow.

I'll digress on this point, but before I do, here's the final thought of the day. Why did God allow this Law (His Law of Sowing and Reaping) to be available to the world around us? Meaning, why didn't He limit it to believers, to His children, to the Church?

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This is just my opinion, which means you can do with it what you want, just don't say that I said it was the truth. My opinion is that even though this world is not of God, that Satan is the ruler of this world, God's Grace still extends to the just and the unjust. And where in the world did I get that opinion from? From Jesus in Matthew 5:43-48, where Jesus said this:

43 "You have heard that it was said, 'YOU SHALL LOVE YOUR NEIGHBOR and hate your enemy.'

44 But I say to you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you,

45 so that you may prove yourselves to be sons of your Father who is in heaven; for He causes His sun to rise on *the* evil and *the* good, and
sends rain on *the* righteous and *the* unrighteous.

46 For if you love those who love you, what reward do you have? Even the tax collectors, do they not do the same?

47 And if you greet only your brothers *and sisters,* what more are you doing *than others?* Even the Gentiles, do they not do the same?

48 Therefore you shall be perfect, as your heavenly Father is perfect.

What Jesus is telling us, is God allows unbelievers to receive blessings simply because they are part of His Sovereign Plan. Essentially, as He blesses believers, the overflow from that will touch unbelievers as well.

I also believe the Law of Sowing and Reaping extends to the unbelieving world for another reason as well, because this is how God set it up, so that all mankind can be taken care of while the earth still exists. This Law of Sowing and Reaping is real, I promise you it's real, and I want to encourage you to study it for yourself.

Maybe even think back to a time when you gave, and low and behold it came back greater than when it left. God put this Law in place so that those who would believe and obey would be the ones that He would use to provide for the needs of others. And in return, they would be the ones who would receive a blessing. And as we have discovered over these past several weeks of teaching, many times, those blessings return back to the giver in the form of an abundance of true joy.

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- Alright guys, welcome back and welcome to our new location, and once again all I can say is thank you Lord. Thank you for the provision you have made with this new facility. It is truly a testimony to where You have brought us.
    - Last week we took a diversion of sorts, and I did something I vary rarely do, and that was I paused from our normal teaching format, which is expositional and verses by verse, and in its place, I did something, as I said, I rarely do, which was I taught a topical message.
    - And even though it was rare, it was good and needed, but having said that, play time is over and we must get back to rightly dividing God's Word of Truth in 2 Corinthians Chapter 9. Now, it's been a few weeks since we were last in this book, and so, as I often do (when we take off a few weeks), I want to do a quick recap or summary, all in an effort to bring you back up to speed with where we were.
    - As we know, 2 Corinthains (as it's called) is actually the 4th letter Paul wrote to this Corinthian church. It's called 2 Corinthians because we only have two of those four letters recorded in the cannon of scripture. We also know 2 Corinthians, just like all of Paul's letters (except for one), was written as a letter of correction.
- Now before moving forward this morning, I want to ask you a quick rhetorical trivia question of sorts, and that is, which one of Paul's letters was not written as a letter of correction? Does anyone know? Romans. Romans is a letter of doctrine. Paul also used Romans as a sort of fundraising letter as well.
    - Anyway, so Paul wrote 2 Corinthians in an effort to correct the church's behavior, but in Chapter 8 he does something. He deviates from correction for a moment and uses that chapter to remind this church of the offering they had previously committed to collect some one year earlier, all for the poorer church in Jerusalem.
    - And while he was on the topic of giving, he took the liberty to teach them, and by extension us, something about this topic. To dive into and explain the spiritual concepts behind giving, along with the blessings that accompany those who obey in giving as well.
    - And so, Paul's dissertation on this somewhat controversial topic of giving begins in Chapter 8 and continues into Chapter 9, and that's where we pick back up today. Now, before moving into today's focus verses, I want to back up and re-read the proceeding verses for context as a segway into today's teaching. Follow with me in 2 Cor. 9:6-8, and here's what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 9:6 **Now *I say* this: the one who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and the one who sows generously will also reap generously.**
2 Cor. 9:7 **Each one *must do* just as he has decided in his heart, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver.**
2 Cor. 9:8 **And God is able to make all grace overflow to you, so that, always having all sufficiency in everything, you may have an abundance for every good deed.**

- The last time we studied these verses, we ended our teaching specifically by focusing on verses 6 & 7, and we touched lightly on verse 8, and as I previously pointed out, verses 6

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& 7 gave us a “Spiritual Truth”, or “Spiritual Law” of sorts. A truth or law that applies not only to believers but to non-believers as well.

- And for further clarification of that statement, I would suggest you go back and listen to our teaching from three weeks ago. So, based on what we learned from Paul’s writings, we know there is this Spiritual Law in place. God’s Spiritual Law. A Law that is simple to understand at its core. A Law that says, “If you sow sparingly, you will reap sparingly”. We call it the “Law of Sowing and Reaping”, or the “Law of Reciprocation”.
- The Law of Sowing and Reaping says, what you put out will come back to you, and when it does it will be multiplied. In other words, when it returns it will return greater than it left. Now if you have been with us very long, you know I am anti any type of promotion of the prosperity movement.
  - Primarily because that movement misrepresents what God’s word says, especially as it relates to the topic of giving, or sowing and reaping, which once again leads to confusion in the life of a believer. And one of the primary callings and purposes of this church (among others), is to help eliminate confusion in the life of the believer.
  - And what better topic to focus on when it comes to eliminating confusion than that of giving, because confusion surrounding this topic is really bad, and it’s led many ‘preachers’ in the prosperity movement to become quite wealthy, leaving those they lead thinking they too will receive more money if they simply give.
- But where did all the confusion surrounding this topic come from? It started by a misinterpretation of 2 Cor. 9:6, which clearly says:

2 Cor. 9:6 **Now *I say* this: the one who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and the one who sows generously will also reap generously.**

- From Paul’s own writings right here in verse 6, where he clearly tells us that if we “sow sparingly” we will “reap sparingly”.
  - So, it would appear that maybe the proponents of the prosperity movement might be correct, right? I mean, just read what it says. But let me ask you a question. Does this seem right to you? Does this seem like something God would have the Apostles and other writers of the Bible promote?
    - No, and I would tell you that if you believe this to be the case, that somehow verse 6 is the end all, be all rule of God’s Reciprocal Law of Giving, then you should immediately clear out your bank account, your 401K, along with any other savings you might have and give it to the church.
    - Because if what verse 6 says is true, then no doubt you will definitely want to get in on the action, right. Take everything you can get your hands on and give it away, because it’s going to come back to you in the form of an increase much greater than it left.
  - Some prosperity teachers even say it will come back to you 10-times greater than it left, and if that’s truly the case, then Wall Street, hedge funds, and private equity investors have got nothing on this retirement plan. So, get busy giving.

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- But my question is, does that make any sense whatsoever? Seriously, from a strictly logical standpoint would that seem to make any sense. Of course not. But how do I know that? I know it because I know God, and I know God because I study His Word, and because I study His Word, I know exactly what He says 'holistically' about the topic of giving.
  - And I can assure you the testimony of scripture does not line up with the 'give to get' concept. Even if you haven't studied the topic of giving in-depth, there is another way you can know that what I am saying is true. All you have to do is use logic, which will be derived from the pages of scripture as well.

- Now, having all that said, the next statement I'm going to make probably isn't going to gain me many fans. Not that I had that many to begin with. But if I did, this next statement might reduce that number. And here it is. The financial outcomes, or for that matter any outcome in the life of a believer, are not about the believer. It's about God. Let me clarify. In God's dichotomy you are not the center of the universe. He is!
  - You and I were not created for self-gratification or self–indulgence, or to (for a lack of examples), become children of God who mimic the way we treat our own children. You know what I am talking about. Where the entire world revolves around them.
    - If we are believers, we have been chosen by God, for God. For His good purposes and for His good deeds. Not for ourselves. We are slaves to the God most high, and this reality immediately lets us know that the 'giving to get' concept won't work because it's not about you. And if it's not about you, then who is it about? It's all about God!
    - Follow me here. And so, this brings me all the way back around to my main point, which is, your giving will only reciprocate when your purposes, your intent, your heart, and your will line up with God's will. With what God wants. It's only then that the Law of Reciprocation will kick in. But how do I know that?
    - Well let's read verses 7 & 8 one more time.

2 Cor. 9:7 **Each one *must do* just as he has decided in his heart, not reluctantly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver.**

- Okay, well maybe that verse really doesn't back up or clarify what I was trying to say. I mean after all, it just says we shouldn't give reluctantly or under compulsion, meaning pushed into giving. And then it says God loves a cheerful giver. So that verse doesn't exactly lend direct credence to what I was saying. But that's not exactly the truth and let me prove it to you.
  - To do that, let's begin by asking ourselves one question. Why would anyone be cheerful about giving their hard-earned money away? Seriously, think about it. The only way that could happen is if, somehow, that person believed they were going to get more of it back in return. Right?
  - I would say in light of verse 6, that would be correct. But if that's the thought process, then those thoughts could only find their basis or foundation in our flesh. I mean think about it. Do you honestly think that anyone could give away their money (to any great degree), and let me say, when speaking of giving here, he is not talking

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about dropping 20 bucks in the offering plate.

- This type of giving isn't just a little bit of money. The giving he is referring to is a deep, sacrificial giving above and beyond your ability (as Paul calls it). So, with that said, do you think someone could do this and do so 'cheerfully', without any anxiety or trepidation, and with no hope or prospect of receiving a return on that investment?
- The answer would be no. And so, if that's the case, then why does scripture say that God loves a cheerful giver? Well, to grasp a better understanding of this you will have to dig deep and get to the meaning of the word cheerful. What does cheerful mean in the Greek? It means joyous, cheerful, not grudging.
- The description of this word describes someone who is cheerfully ready to act because they are already approving, already persuaded, won over, already inclined. And the word is only used here in 2 Corinthians 9:7, where it describes spontaneous and non-reluctant giving.

- So, to sum it all up for you, this giving is a supernatural type of giving, one that God lays on someone's heart in a moment and they give without hesitation. Which means it's not planned and it's not a strategy, like a retirement plan. It's a giving that only reciprocates when God moves on your heart, and then you react out of obedience, and you are excited to do so. Meaning you are cheerful and excited about it.
  - But why should you be excited? Well, I'll tell you why.
  - Because God chose you to participate in the work of ministry, in the work He is doing inside His creation. That's the sense of the word here. Now, just in case anyone may still be experiencing some reluctancy or heartburn about what I just said, I want you to look at verse 8 a little closer, one more time. What does it say?

2 Cor. 9:8 **And God is able to make all grace overflow to you, so that, always having all sufficiency in everything, you may have an abundance for every good deed;**

- A mouthful here. Let me paraphrase it for you, but this time when I do it, let me slowly break it down. Once again:

2 Cor. 9:8 **And God is able to make all grace overflow to you, so that, always having all sufficiency in everything, you may have an abundance for every good deed;**

- So here it is in a nutshell. God is able to make all grace overflow to you, so that when you become sufficient in everything, that sufficiency will build an abundance, which then will give you the ability to perform every good deed. But that brings on more talk, because now my mind goes to what good deeds is he talking about?
  - The key to understanding this entire concept lies in two words – good deeds, and when you understand the meaning of these two words it will give you insight, and the clarity, to answer the question, why it is that the prosperity movement and the

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'giving to give' theory is false.

- Hang with me a minute. So, God causes us to become sufficient in everything, and He does so for the purpose of building abundance, all so that we can perform "every good deed".
  - In other words, when you give without hesitation and without being compelled to do so, with a cheerful heart, this type of giving activates the supernatural, causing God to give you more. That's why verse 6 says,

2 Cor. 9:6 **Now *I say* this: the one who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and the one who sows generously will also reap generously.**

- Which means, when God does a work inside your life as a believer, He does so for the purposes of equipping you to do it all over again. And then He multiplies it, all so that you can give even more. Once again, it's cyclical, as is just about everything with God. Such as the way He grows His church.
  - When you're saved, the next step in your life is that you are supposed to mature. To grow spiritually. Begin the process of Sanctification, which is simply the process of becoming more like Christ.
  - And how does that happen? It happens when you come to know Him more fully. Which comes by way of what? By the ingestion and digestion of God's Word. There is no other way. If you want to mature, you must sit under a Pastor/Teacher/Elder who teaches you the manuscript and then trains you how to study on your own. That is God's method for your Spiritual Growth.
  - And when that happens, when you become a spiritually healthy and mature believer, the natural biproduct of that is you will become 'light' to a dark and dying world. And the biproduct of that is, God will use you to draw men to Himself, and you will invest and invite people to church, and the process starts all over again.
    - It's cyclical. Spiritually healthy Christians are what grow the church, not marketing programs. Anyway, it's the same with giving. When we obey, God moves, and when we obey again God moves even more.
- Now, having said all that, when studying these texts of scripture, my mind immediately jumps to a question. A question that I feel we should all ask ourselves. Which is, what are these good deeds that Paul is referring to here?
  - Are they any old good deeds, such as helping an elderly person across the road, or getting a cat out of the tree? Well, the answer is no. The deeds have nothing to do with 'random acts of kindness', which, let me say there is nothing wrong with. But that's not what He is referencing here. No, these deeds are very specific, and clearly tie back to meeting the financial needs of someone else.
  - Dr. Thomas Constable, of DTS, said it this way. "Such giving need not produce anxiety in the giver, even if he or she is giving away much. God demonstrates His love for cheerful givers by giving them more grace (enablement) and more opportunity. He not only provides them with what is sufficient for their needs, but He gives them more, so that they can give more away. We always need to remember that God is the One from whom everything comes. The word he [Paul] uses here for

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["sufficiency"] is a Greek word *autarkeia* – it's a favorite [*sic*] stoic word. It does not describe the sufficiency of the man who possesses all kinds of things in abundance. It means independence. It describes the state of the man who has not directed life to amassing possessions but to eliminating needs. It describes the man who has taught himself to be content with very little and never to want for anything, the man who has learned to do without things."

- Notice the 'able' in this verse. This should not lead to the conclusion that God can, but He might not (cf. 12:9). But rather, He is more than able and willing. Which lets us know that the righteous person who desires to give to the needs of others will not lack opportunity to do so, because God will make this possible for him or her."
- So, with this understanding of giving in view, you can now know why it is that the prosperity movement and the giving to give concept is false, because what you receive back, by giving more, isn't meant for you. It's meant so that you will have the ability to give it all out again.

- Now, for further confirmation of this truth, let's press on and use (what is) the greatest commentary on the Bible to prove the point further. And what is the greatest commentary on the Bible? It's The Bible. The Bible is the greatest commentary on itself. And why? Because it's 66 books written by 44 authors over thousands of years, and it testifies or confirms itself. Let me show you what I mean. 2 Cor. 9:8 for context and then 9-15:

2 Cor. 9:8 **And God is able to make all grace overflow to you, so that,**
always having all sufficiency in everything, you may have an abundance for every good deed;
2 Cor. 9:9 **as it is written: "HE SCATTERED ABROAD, HE GAVE TO THE POOR, HIS RIGHTEOUSNESS ENDURES FOREVER."**
2 Cor. 9:10 **Now He who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food will supply and multiply your seed for sowing and increase the harvest of your righteousness;**
2 Cor. 9:11 **you will be enriched in everything for all liberality, which through us is producing thanksgiving to God.**
2 Cor. 9:12 **For the ministry of this service is not only fully supplying the needs of the saints, but is also overflowing through many thanksgivings to God.**
2 Cor. 9:13 **Because of the proof given by this ministry, they will**
glorify God for *your* obedience to your confession of the gospel of Christ and for the liberality of your contribution to them and to all,
2 Cor. 9:14 **while they also, by prayer on your behalf, yearn for you because of the surpassing grace of God in you.**
2 Cor. 9:15 **Thanks be to God for His indescribable gift!**

- In verse 9, we get confirmation of what I just said, that the Bible is the greatest commentary on itself. What do I mean? Well, look at what Paul does for further confirmation of what he just said. He quotes from the Old Testament, and we know that,

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because when you see the text of scripture capitalized in quotes, you automatically know this is referencing back to the Old Testament.

- And so, that's what I mean when I say the Bible is the greatest commentary on itself. Paul steps back in time to support what he was saying, as he quotes the Psalmist in Psalm 112:9.
- Psalm 112:9 supports Paul's point that God will provide grace (divine enablement) to givers. In this psalm, the psalmist described the God-fearing person distributing material goods to the poor, and his words read like the epitaph of a philanthropist. It's simple. God will remember the God-fearing person's benevolent acts.
  - And the reference to "righteousness" here in verse 9 is more than likely referring to benevolent acts, as it is in Matt. 6:1, where the title of the section is, 'Charitable Giving to the Poor and Prayer', and it says this:

Matt. 6:1 "Take care not to practice your righteousness in the sight of people, to be noticed by them; otherwise, you have no reward with your Father who is in heaven.

- What that means is, these acts of giving are acts for which God will reward the sacrificial donor with permanent benefits. Another way to say it is, "His righteousness endures forever", and therefore, God will multiply His grace to those who bestow grace on others.
  - That's the concept here folks. And so, what's the take-away from today's message? It is this; when you obey and give sacrificially, which is why God lays it on your heart, He will return it to you in a multiplied form so that you can do it all over again. And when you do that, it will appear that you cannot give it away fast enough. And that's awesome.
  - But what do you get out of it? Well, according to our earlier teaching on this topic going back to Chapter 8, just like the churches of Macedonia, when you give sacrificially, which is not just of your ability but beyond your ability, God will give you something in return - an abundance of joy, which brings about peace, happiness, and true contentment.
    - Which, at the end of the day, is the only real thing of value in this world. Everything else is just hay stubble and will one day be burned up. So, what's the takeaway this morning?
    - Well, above all else, obedience to God is what brings about the joy of the Lord. And so, if things aren't going well for you right now, then I want to challenge you to do something. Look for opportunities to give. To your church, yes, but not just a tithe. Look to go above and beyond. Sacrificially give to get in the game.
  - Do as the churches of Macedonia did and ask God to give you favor. Not favor as in favor for you to buy more stuff, or favor so you can store up treasures in Heaven, but as Paul said back in Chapter 8, for the "favor of participation" in giving to garner so much favor with God that He begins to use you in the work of ministry. For the work He is doing in and around you every day.
- So, as you leave here today, my prayer is that you look for opportunity to support those

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in need in whatever financial opportunity may arise. Because when you do, you unlock the Supernatural Law of ‘Reaping and Sowing’ - The Law of Reciprocation. And once that starts, it brings a joy and contentment into your life that you simply cannot obtain any other way.

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- Welcome back guys and good to see everyone this morning. Well, today is the day. The day we end Paul's teaching on giving (at least for now). Paul began his teaching on this topic in Chapter 8, and I would say we have mined some serious gold out these past several messages.
    - Another way to say it might be, we have made several meals out of this topic. And it's been good, but more than that it's been very educational and transformative. As a matter of fact, I would say it's been the most educational compilation of teachings that I have personally ever taught on this topic.
    - Now, having said that, we aren't quite out of the woods yet. We still have just a little bit more to go before Paul's narrative shifts from giving into his next topic, which will begin promptly in Chapter 10. And, with another chapter behind us, we move closer to finishing yet another Book of the Bible.
        - So, without further a due, turn with me if you will to 2 Cor. 9:9-15, and let's finish the chapter. And to do that, we will back up and read verse 8 for context. Now, before we begin, remember Paul is writing this letter to the church at Corinth, to the people in that church.

2 Cor. 9:8 **And God is able to make all grace overflow to you, so that,**
always having all sufficiency in everything, you may have an abundance for every good deed;
2 Cor. 9:9 **as it is written:**
"HE SCATTERED ABROAD, HE GAVE TO THE POOR,
HIS RIGHTEOUSNESS ENDURES FOREVER."
2 Cor. 9:10 **Now He who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food will supply and multiply your seed for sowing and increase the harvest of your righteousness;**
2 Cor. 9:11 **you will be enriched in everything for all liberality, which through us is producing thanksgiving to God.**
2 Cor. 9:12 **For the ministry of this service is not only fully supplying the needs of the saints, but is also overflowing through many thanksgivings to God.**
2 Cor. 9:13 **Because of the proof given by this ministry, they will**
glorify God for *your* obedience to your confession of the gospel of Christ and for the liberality of your contribution to them and to all,
2 Cor. 9:14 **while they also, by prayer on your behalf, yearn for you because of the surpassing grace of God in you.**
2 Cor. 9:15 **Thanks be to God for His indescribable gift!**

- I want to break these remaining verses down into what would be one theme and two sections. The theme is the same theme we read about all throughout God's Holy Manuscript, and that is God's Sovereignty, which is coupled with His purposes and ultimate control over the process of Sacrificial Giving in the life of the believer, and all for the purposes of His Glory. Look at it again.

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2 Cor. 9:8 **And God is able to make all grace overflow to you, (who is doing the work here? – God is – and why), so that, always having all sufficiency in everything, you may have an abundance for every good deed;**

- And then, Paul backs up what he says by slipping Psalm 112:6 into the mix as he reaches all the way back into the Old Testament as a backup and proof to what he is trying to convey. That's where verses 9 comes in:

2 Cor. 9:9 **as it is written: "HE SCATTERED ABROAD, HE GAVE TO THE POOR, HIS RIGHTEOUSNESS ENDURES FOREVER."**

- So, once again we see clearly that God is the one who scatters. He's the one who gives to the poor, and the result is "His righteousness endures forever".
    - And then verse 10:

2 Cor. 9:10 **Now He who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food will supply and multiply your seed for sowing and increase the harvest of your righteousness;**

- Basically, what we can ascertain from these verses along with the ones prior to these verses, is that when we sow (give sacrificially), which by the way, is defined by Paul as what in Chapter 8? As giving above what someone has; above their ability).
    - When a believer obeys God in the area of finances and giving, God will then return it back to them in a greater fashion, so that, that same person will do it all over again. In other words, in the sowing and reaping concept that Paul just spoke about, the whole reason this Spiritual Law exists in the first place is so that you (if you are a believer), can turn around and help another person in need.
    - Hence, verse 9, where Paul quotes Psalm 112:9, which describes how God provided for the poor. That is the whole point of the sowing and reaping concept. Which means, and let me be clear, it is not to make someone rich.
        - I know I have driven this point home over and over again, but it's really important for us to understand, especially in light of today's church society. One that teaches a give-to-get principal, which is generally masqueraded through a statement we have all heard before, and that is, "You can't out-give God".
        - I've heard that my whole life, and it's true. And I actually have no problem with that statement, other than it assumes, subconsciously, that the purpose of your giving somehow ties back to your wealth. To you obtaining more wealth. But that's not why Paul is teaching this concept. He's teaching it so that they (and by extension you and I), understand the impact their giving, and our giving, will have on the world around them and us by providing for the needs of those less fortunate.
    - And oh, let me say just in case you're wondering if there's something in it for you, or us. There is Abundance of Joy – Peace – Contentment, which is what we learned

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from Chapter 8. But there's more to it than that. And what is it? Well, glad you asked. Look at the second section of these verses.

2 Cor. 9:11 **you will be enriched in everything for all liberality, [The Greek reads – in every way enriching you to all generosity] which through us is producing thanksgiving to God.**
2 Cor. 9:12 **For the ministry of this service is not only fully supplying the needs of the saints, but is also overflowing through many thanksgivings to God.**
2 Cor. 9:13 **Because of the proof given by this ministry, they will glorify God for *your* obedience to your confession of the gospel of Christ and for the liberality of your contribution to them and to all,**
2 Cor. 9:14 **while they also, by prayer on your behalf, yearn for you because of the surpassing grace of God in you.**
2 Cor. 9:15 **Thanks be to God for His indescribable gift!**

- Guys, let me download on you for just a minute. I want to download about something that is really near and dear to my heart and pertains to something that I often say. Your testimony is not what you say, it's who you are, and it manifests itself in your actions (your obedience). "It's not what you say that matters, it's what you do".
    - There is a lot being said in verses 11-15, but what screams the loudest to me when you boil it all down to its lowest common denominator, is the following; when we give to the least of these, when we take care of the poor, provide assistance to those in need, when we do that, you and I will be enriched in everything for all liberality, which means God will bless you financially and our giving will produce more and more thanksgiving back to God, through the people receiving the gift, not to mention the bystanders who may have also witnessed what you did or what the church did, which once again, reaches more people for Christ.
        - And this takes me back to what I've said over and over again, and that is, in God's dichotomy, God does not do what He does but for one reason and one reason alone, and that is to bring Glory to Himself and to redeem mankind back to Himself. We are simply the instrument that He uses to accomplish His will.
        - And that, my friends, is the purpose of the Sowing and Reaping concept. It's real, but not for the purpose of becoming rich. It's for the purpose of giving sacrificially all over again.
    - Moving on, now we jump into Chapter 10, where Paul does indeed shift his narrative. He moves from speaking about giving in Chapters 8 and 9, to that of, well, I would say, correction again. Let's see what he says:

2 Cor. 10:1 **Now I, Paul, myself urge you by the meekness and gentleness of Christ —I who am meek when face to face with you, but bold toward you when absent!**
2 Cor. 10:2 **I ask that when I am present I *need* not be bold with the confidence with which I propose to be courageous against some, who regard us as if we walked according to the flesh.**

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2 Cor. 10:3 **For though we walk in the flesh, we do not war according to the flesh,**
2 Cor. 10:4 **for the weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh, but divinely powerful for the destruction of fortresses.**
2 Cor. 10:5 ***We are*** **destroying speculations and every lofty thing raised up against the knowledge of God, and** ***we are*** **taking every thought captive to the obedience of Christ,**
2 Cor. 10:6 **and we are ready to punish all disobedience, whenever your obedience is complete.**

- I know I say this all the time, so I might as well say it again. Man, there is a whole lot being said here. In verse 1, Paul is doing something, something he had done earlier in this letter, and that was, he was addressing the naysayers. Those in the church who questioned his Apostolic authority.
    - I want you to remember, this was a huge problem Paul was facing, which was odd when you stop to think about it. Paul founded this church, and now he has to re-establish who he is, all because of a few troublemakers who have found their way into this fellowship. And now he has to defend himself.
    - Pretty ridiculous when you stop to think about it, but it was true. You see, since Paul had left, there were new people who began attending the church, who had eased their way into this fellowship, and they began murmuring, telling the church that Paul was not really an Apostle, and therefore, they didn't have to listen to him.
        - And so, as you can imagine, over time that became a big problem, which led him (once again) to address the issue, and he does so by addressing himself with the all-too familiar statement, "I Paul, myself".
    - He addresses them this way because He wants the church to know that it was him who was writing this letter, it was him who was speaking, and that it was him who was making an appeal for them to submit to his Apostolic authority.
- Now, I would be remise if I didn't stop here for just a minute and remind you that those people in that church, the ones causing trouble, are alive and well today. Not them, but people just like them. They are alive and well, and as this fellowship grows, we will encounter them. Here we are in this new facility, and at some point, new people will come.
    - Throughout my ministry I have discovered there are generally two to three types of people who will show up at church. Especially at a new church. The first type is people who haven't ever really attended church, or maybe they have a little, but not very often in their life. They also don't necessarily care for church, and they have a preconceived idea about Jesus and the people who supposedly represent him.
        - My hope and prayer is that when they attend here, they see and feel something different. They felt welcomed and loved all because we noticed them, and we went out of our way to shake their hand and say hello. To say, "good to see you". Warmth will make the biggest impression on these folks, and that warmth will manifest itself because you took time to show you care. They should never leave here and say, well, no one even spoke to us.
    - The second type of people who will attend will be those who have been wandering

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in the ‘church wilderness’ for years. They are simply looking for a home, a place to settle in for them and their family. They haven’t given up yet, but they aren’t far from it. They are giving it one more try , and we are anxiously awaiting their arrival. We understand them because we once were them.

- We, too, have spent time in the church wilderness of the church world, often thinking to ourselves, what is the deal? Why is church so hard and why can’t it ever be right?
- And like I said, on our first day here in this new facility, this place is different. This group of believers is different. I assure you, this preacher is different, and I think we as a body resemble the opening line of one of an old church song, which says, “I am tired and thirsty Lord, send your rain”.
- And then there is the third group. I call them ‘rubberneckers. They will come because they want to see what’s going on. They heard about us. They heard about this whole ‘bible teaching’ thing and they may come and stay for a while. This group is much like the group Paul is dealing with in Corinth.

- They are here and they start fine, but soon they begin murmuring, slowly sowing dissent, stirring up trouble. Subconsciously they slowly begin trying to cut the foundation out from under what God is doing.
- These folks are not hard to identify. You will know who they are by what they say and how they say it. Slowly they will make little comments, complaining under their breath, sowing seeds of doubt about who we are, who I am, and what we are doing. These folks are the folks you as a church body must watch out for.
  - The word is vigilant. You must be a watchman. You can identify them because they will say stuff like, “Now I don’t want gossip, but I heard, or someone said”. They are the secret keepers of the hidden information. You know, the stuff that no one knows. And they feel it’s their responsibility to bring everyone up to speed, inform everyone, quietly inform folks, one by one.
  - They embody the old saying, “It’s still a secret as long as you only tell one person at a time”. These folks are much like cancer. They attach themselves and then slowly grow and gain strength. But here’s the deal, much like cancer grows off sugar, they can only grow when someone lends them an ear.
- That’s what makes them grow, and if you aren’t careful their words will feed your flesh. Another way to say it is, their words will excite your flesh, cause you to lean in ever so closely, just to inquire and to see what the secret might be.

- My prayer is that they will not find a home here. That our church culture will make them feel uncomfortable. That our love will stamp out their dissent. These people are very dangerous, and I’ll tell you why. They’re dangerous because many of them are believers. They are saved, but they are immature, and as such the enemy is using them, and yet they are totally oblivious to that fact. They actually think they are helping, when in fact they are working to erode the very fabric of what God is doing in this fellowship.
  - These people are the ones you need to be wary of. Watch out for them and don’t get sucked into what they are trying to start, because if they get a foothold, that’s where the trouble begins. And honestly, it’s up to you as a body to deal with it. Because if you don’t deal with it privately in the very beginning, when it starts, we will wake up and look around and say, what has happened? How did we get here?

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        - By the way, what's interesting about these people is they are never happy unless something is wrong. They feed off drama. They are self-appointed quality control inspectors. They feel it's up to them to point out everything that's not right.
        - They epitomize the words of a former news commentator I once listened to long ago, and that is, they consider themselves, "Talent on loan from God", and they truly believe pointing out problems is a gift. That somehow, they were put on this planet to help straighten the world out. They are busy bodies, murmurers, and as I previously stated, they are working for the enemy, and yet they are clueless to this fact.
    - And by the way, these people are the same people Paul is contending with in Corinth.
        - People are people, and the same people Paul dealt with are the same people we deal with today. There's no difference, it was just a different time and a different culture. Now as I previously stated, these folks are working for the enemy, they just don't know it. And as I also stated, they may be believers, just immature believers.
    - Which is why Paul says something that we need to recognize and look out for inside our body. And his words of wisdom show up in verses 3-4. Listen to it one more time,

2 Cor. 10:3 **For though we walk in the flesh, we do not war according to the flesh,**
2 Cor. 10:4 **for the weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh, but divinely powerful for the destruction of fortresses.**

- Here's what you need to know. Our battle is not with flesh and blood. The individual or individuals who begin murmuring are not working simply from the flesh. There is a much deeper spiritual component to their actions, and Paul reiterates this point in Ephesians 6:10-13, when he says this:

Ephesians 6:10 **Finally, be strong in the Lord and in the strength of His might.**
Ephesians 6:11 **Put on the full armor of God, so that you will be able to stand firm against the schemes of the devil.**
Ephesians 6:12 **For our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the powers, against the world forces of this darkness, against the spiritual *forces* of wickedness in the heavenly *places.***
Ephesians 6:13 **Therefore, take up the full armor of God, so that you will be able to resist in the evil day, and having done everything, to stand firm.**

- Peter said this same thing but in a different way in 1 Peter 5:6-8:

6 Therefore humble yourselves under the mighty hand of God, that He may exalt you at the proper time,

7 casting all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you.

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8 Be of sober *spirit,* be on the alert. Your adversary, the devil, prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour.

The reality is this. There is spiritual realm in play in this world we live in. One that we cannot see. And that realm is always working behind the scenes trying to destroy the life of a believer. And the only way you and I can wage war against that enemy is by becoming spiritually mature.

That's it. You must mature as a believer if you want to protect your children, your marriage, your life as a whole. And so, when Paul says we walk in the flesh (he's saying, I am human), and the battle I fight is not in the flesh and it cannot be seen. It's invisible because it's spiritual. That's the concept here, and what was true in Paul's day is still true today. Your adversary, your enemy does not stand in front of you, rather he crouches like a roaring lion hiding in the weeds, in the corners and shadows, waiting to pounce. And what's he waiting on?

He's waiting for us to mess up. For you to regress spiritually. For you to forsake the assembling of the believers. To skip church. For you to ease up on your prayer time, on your study of God's Word. For you to give him an opening, give him an opportunity. For you to open the door.

And those who are the most susceptible to his schemes are the immature. Those Christians who have been saved, but really don't know God intimately because they have never matured. Because they haven't spent time with Him, specifically in His Word and in Prayer.

These are the people who will slip into a church and slowly begin sowing the seeds of doubt and dissention. And so, what are we to do about it? Be vigilant and look for the red flags. The red flags that show up in the little things people say, because remember, people will always flip bait, fish a little, before they move in. They will dig and see if you have any interest.

So, recognize it and don't take the bait. That's exactly what Paul says next in verses 5&6. Listen to what he says, and this is where we will close.

5 *We are* destroying speculations and every lofty thing raised up against the knowledge of God, and *we are* taking every thought captive to the obedience of Christ,

6 and we are ready to punish all disobedience, whenever your obedience is complete.

So here is the solution to the murmuring, to those in the church who try to get something going. We should do exactly what Paul says, and the other disciples did. He says they destroyed speculation, and every lofty thing raised up against the knowledge of God. And this is key, they took every thought captive to the obedience of Christ.

We know Paul often speaks in military terms, and that's what he is doing here. His thought is a simple one. Paul is saying when speculation begins to rear its head, especially as it relates to the knowledge of God. Or another way to say it is, when speculation about who God is or who God's man is or about what God is doing; when God is moving and man begins to 'nay say', we shouldn't just let sleeping dogs lie.

Instead, we should grab hold of it and put it under submission to Christ. That's what he means when he says, "we take every thought captive". Paul is painting a picture of being intentional, intentional about stamping out any thought that is contrary to God's Word and

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will.

Meaning, when the wrong thoughts enter your mind, and by the way, if you are a believer, you know what those thoughts are. Meaning, you know if your thoughts are of God or the enemy. And if you don't know, then let me give you a way you can know.

Ask yourself, is this thought bringing Glory to God, or is it exciting my flesh, my pride, my wants and my desires? If you ask yourself that question, then you will know where the thought is coming from.

And when those improper thoughts come streaming in, grab hold of them and bring them under submission to Christ. Let me say, we cannot help it when bad thoughts enter our minds. It happens and it will continue to happen. And we especially can't help it when someone is murmuring in our ear and they begin trying to plant thoughts in our head, but we can recognize it, and grab hold of it and force them to submit to Christ.

Now, before I close let me ask you a question. How in the world do you grab hold of or take captive your thoughts? And more than that, how do you bring them into submission to Christ?

First of all, you must be able to identify which thoughts are of God and which ones are not, and you do that by knowing God, which comes by way of knowing His Word. And then once you recognize those thoughts, you simply isolate them in your mind and ask the Lord to remove them.

You pray about them. You don't let them take hold, and you certainly don't feed them. In essence, what you are doing is using a technique that the manufacturing world uses when trying to fix a problem. It's called the 3 C's: Command – Control – Correct.

You grab hold of the thought by identifying it is not of God. You pray and ask God to bring it into submission. Then you ask God to remove it from your mind. And if you do this, you will correct the situation.

And so, that's what Paul is telling the Corinthian Church to do. And he tells them one more thing. He says this in verse 6:

6 and we are ready to punish all disobedience, whenever your obedience is complete.

This speaks to the heart of church discipline, which is not a popular topic, and I am not going to delve into it this morning. Only to say, Paul is telling this church to deal with the people inside your fellowship who are causing all the problems and confusion, and we will back you up when we arrive.

The inverse of that is, if you don't deal with it, we won't deal with it either. And why? Because we don't run your church. It's your responsibility.

I'll make this statement in closing. If we don't want to be another church statistic, then we as a body must not allow the nay sayers and the murmurings to ever take hold. That's one of the primary keys to church health, and it's up to you to make sure it doesn't happen.

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- Good morning and welcome back guys. This morning, we pick back up in our teaching and study of 2 Corinthians. When we last left off, we ended our teaching with 2 Cor.10:5-6, where Paul moved from the topic of sacrificial giving back to that of admonishment.
    - Meaning, he shifted his narrative from that of giving back to the topic of reprimanding and correcting this church's behavior. As we know, this fellowship has wandered off track, lost their way, and the very first thing Paul has to do in order to correct their thinking is change their perspective, or paradigm.
        - Which, by the way, is the first step to correcting any behavior. It all begins in the mind. You first must change your mentality, (perspective or paradigm), and then you can begin to change your behavior. And this applies to just about any problem you may be facing.
    - If you are struggling with your weight, for example, then read a book on weight loss, giving example success stories with before and after pictures. Once you do that, it will begin to affect your mindset. Where at first you may have been sitting around thinking about changing your diet and going to the gym, and you were dreading it, which by the way, causes you to have zero motivation.
        - But once you pick up a book and begin to read about how to do it and what you can look like in just a short period of time, your mindset will begin to change. And the more you read, the more motivated you become. And as I previously stated, this applies to just about every problem we face.
- We must first change our perspective before we can ever take the initial steps to real change. And believe it or not, many times this mindset change begins with reading or studying something related to the problem you may be experiencing.
    - You see, once you begin feeding your mind with the correct information, it's then and only then that you can begin to move the needle in the right direction. And the same applies to church issues. It all starts with being fed the truth, and that's exactly what Paul is doing here.
    - In verses 5&6, he is painting a picture for this group, showing them how, when stuff begins to enter their mind, when the naysayers begin planting seeds, specifically seeds of doubt against the knowledge of God, when the murmurs and gossipers begin questioning the things of God (you know, silently and in secret, whispering in the corners and shadows), speaking to whomever will listen.
        - Paul says we must identify it for what it is and not entertain it. We should grab hold of it and bring it into obedience of Christ.
        - Another way too say it is, bring it into submission to Christ. That's exactly what Paul is trying to convey here in verse 5 when he says:

2 Cor. 10:5 ***We are*** **destroying speculations and every lofty thing raised up against the knowledge of God, and** ***we are*** **taking every thought captive to the obedience of Christ,**

- But then he goes on to say something else, and it shows up in verse 6, he says:

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2 Cor. 10:6 and we are ready to punish all disobedience, whenever your obedience is complete.

- Verse 6 is pretty straight forward, but I'll put into to layman's terms. Paul is saying, once you have dealt with the people inside your fellowship, the ones who are causing all the issues, once you as church leaders deal with them, punish them, punish them through the church discipline process, which is what?
  - To call them in and deal with them. Tell them to quit doing what they are doing, or they will be asked to leave the fellowship. Paul says once you guys do that, then and only then will we come in and back you up. Now, the question is, wonder why Paul tells them that?
  - It's because the leadership of this church must deal with the naysayers first. And then and only then, after they have done that, he and the other disciples will come in and back them up. But once again, why specifically did he say that?
    - Because if the leadership won't stand up against what's going wrong, then nothing they (the Apostles) can say will help. Because as soon as they leave, things will go right back to the way they were. Now, in studying Paul's words here, there is another point for us to consider, and that is, there is no doubt that Paul is trying to force the church leadership to step up and do what they should have done in the first place.
    - And this just highlights the fact that leadership is always at a premium, and it's always an issue. It was an issue then, and I would say it's an even bigger issue now and leadership in the church is even more critical.
  - The problem we are facing today in our society is that no one is willing to call an ace an ace or a spade a spade. And the church is no different. As a matter of fact, the church has become really good in practicing the 'art of apathy', and when problems arise, we simply say, just let it be.
  - I have seen this firsthand throughout my ministry, specifically when I served as a deacon and an associate pastor, and it always reminded me of the old saying, "In order for injustice to prevail, all it requires is for good men to stand around and do nothing."
- Now having said that, and before I beat up the church leadership of my past (too bad), when church discipline is considered, it must be done prayerfully, from a place of love by elders, which are men who have a lot of T.O.P. – 'Time on the Planet' under their belt, because, obviously, this type of action against someone in the fellowship is a big deal and one that need not be taken lightly.
  - And this highlights what I said last week, which was, it would be better for the body or fellowship itself to stamp out any murmuring before it takes hold. That's the very best scenario and its really how things should be handled.
  - But if that doesn't work, then Paul says it must be dealt with, because the alternative of 'letting it be' won't work. And if issues aren't dealt with, eventually it will serve to cut the very foundation out from under the church. So, Paul has made his point, and I think we all have a clear understanding of what Paul is dealing with. So, let's press on and see what he says next.

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2 Cor. 10:7 You are looking at things as they are outwardly. If anyone is confident in himself that he is Christ's, have him consider this again within himself, that just as he is Christ's, so too are we.
2 Cor. 10:8 For if I boast somewhat more about our authority, which the Lord gave for building you up and not for destroying you, I will not be put to shame,
2 Cor. 10:9 for I do not want to seem as if I would terrify you by my letters.
2 Cor. 10:10 For they say, "His letters are weighty and strong, but his personal presence is unimpressive and his speech contemptible."
2 Cor. 10:11 Have such a person consider this, that what we are in word by letters when absent, such persons *we are* also in deed when present.

- So, based on this section of Paul's writings, we know Paul is speaking about an individual inside the church that is causing trouble, and we are pretty sure that it truly is one person who's behind all of it. What we can also ascertain from Paul's writings is that this individual feels as if he has the same authority Paul and the other disciples have.
    - Which is interesting, because I see the exact same thing happen in church today. There are many people, men and women, who say they are called into the ministry, and maybe they are and maybe they are not. I have no clue. And honestly, it's absolutely none of my business. It's between them and God.
    - Having said that, from time to time I will run into people who say they are called or were called previously into the ministry but are no longer in it. And from time to time, I will be asked about a particular situation with a minister or pastor who has done something wrong, or I will interview someone who completed seminary, received their Master of Divinity or doctorate, worked in ministry for a few years.
        - And then for some reason, they are no longer in ministry. It's in those moments, and in an effort to reconcile their situation in my head, I often ask myself the question, were they truly called into ministry, or did they simply have some emotional experience? One that maybe made them think they were called into ministry.
    - Once again, their calling has zero to do with me, but I often wonder about it in my head. Especially when I interview someone for a job, and I see on their resume where they graduated from seminary. Sometimes I will ask the individual what happened. Why are you not in ministry anymore?
        - And almost always the answer is the same. "Well, I just got burned out", or "I got tired of being beat up by church people," A close pastor friend of mine said, "I was deacon possessed."
    - Which then takes me back to the issues that Paul is dealing with in the church at Corinth. It's church leadership. How they wouldn't step up and deal with someone inside the fellowship causing problems.
- Now, you may be saying to yourself, well you sure sound somewhat judgmental this morning. Let me be clear, I never worry about what others are doing. Primarily because my hands are full of what God has called me to do. But what I can tell you is this, God never calls a person into ministry that he doesn't equip, and He equips them and

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prepares them in every aspect:

- Prepares them for the pressures of the ministry.
- Gives them the heart and temperament for ministry,
- Along with any other skill necessary to survive in their calling

- And if you think about it, this logically makes sense, right? Why would God call a person to something, only to take them there and then drop them off a cliff? The answer is, He wouldn't. And for further proof of this, I will refer you to Romans 11:29, where Paul states the following:

Romans 11:29 **for the gifts and the calling of God are irrevocable.**

- When God gives someone a gift, which by the way we all have one, when God gives someone a gift or calls them to do something, those gifts and callings are irrevocable. Which means they cannot be revoked or changed, and they won't change.
  - And so, if this is the case, then we have a little bit of problem when studying Paul's writings here in Chapter 10, and that is, if Paul is called to be an Apostle, which obviously he is, and at the same time this other gentleman in the fellowship says he's called and has the same authority, then what gives? Who's right and who's wrong?
  - And even more than that, how do you know whose right or wrong? Who does the church listen to? I mean, they are obviously in a tough spot, right? Think about it. Here we have Paul, the man who founded this church, he established it, and then after setting up the leadership in the church he moved on to another area to do the same thing again.
    - But he has been gone for some time, and now he has received word the church is losing its way. Getting off track. Abandoning what Paul taught them, primarily because of this one individual who has made his way into their fellowship. Who's obviously gained their trust, and with that trust firmly in hand, he has slowly began undermining everything Paul established.
    - Telling them things like, Paul has lied to them because he promised to come back and visit them at some point, but he hasn't yet. He's even gone so far as convincing the church that Paul has no more authority than he does. All of which is obviously not true. But who does the church believe?
- Well, Paul gives them some insight into how they know who they can believe. And by the way, this same methodology applies to those of us sitting here today. And what is it? Well, it's really simple. Whose words line up with God's word? And more than that, whose actions line up with God's word? Is it Paul or this other man?
  - And sure enough, this logic is where Paul heads next. Listen to it again:

2 Cor. 10:7 **You are looking at things as they are outwardly. If anyone is confident in himself that he is Christ's, have him consider this again within himself, that just as he is Christ's, so too are we.**
2 Cor. 10:8 **For if I boast somewhat more about our authority, which the**

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Lord gave for building you up and not for destroying you, I will not be put to shame,
2 Cor. 10:9 for I do not want to seem as if I would terrify you by my letters.
2 Cor. 10:10 For they say, "His letters are weighty and strong, but his personal presence is unimpressive and his speech contemptible."
2 Cor. 10:11 Have such a person consider this, that what we are in word by letters when absent, such persons *we are* also in deed when present.

So, here's what's happening. As we know, there's this man inside this church sowing seeds of doubt in the minds of the people about who Paul is and what authority he possesses, and based on Paul's own writings, this gentleman was evidently trying to build his case by telling the people to look at Paul outwardly.

It would be like saying, there is no way this guy is an Apostle. I mean, just look at him. His personal presence is unimpressive, and his speech is contemptible. I mean, seriously, look at him and listen to him speak.

And by the way, this man's statement gives us further proof of what I was saying earlier about God calling a man into ministry. If God calls a man, He doesn't call him because he has some type of rare skill, or impressive stature, or because he is a great speaker. I think we are all smart enough to know that statement would make sense logically speaking.

I mean, obviously, the God of creation doesn't need a man's look or stage presence, or even oratory skills to accomplish His will. All He needs from us is our obedience, along with leadership. Men and woman who are ready, willing, and able to answer God's call on their life. It has always been rare, but it's even rarer today.

And one more thing. Not only does God not call a man based on his looks or oratory skills, but many times also He goes out of His way to call men who are opposite of those descriptors. And just in case you are wondering if this might be the case, just look the Bible's description of Paul. It's not very luxurious.

But with God, it's always this way. He always chooses the most unlikely candidates to accomplish His will. Men like Abraham, Peter, David, and the list goes on and on. God always operates opposite of what we think.

An example of this shows us with Jesus' own words in the parable of the laborer in the vineyard, where our Lord says the first will be last and the last will be first. I'll go even a step further and say the greatest example or proof of God choosing opposite what we would choose lies in God's choosing the Jews as His chosen people.

Of all people on the earth that God could have chosen, He chose them. And trust me when I tell you there is no way anyone else would have picked them to be called God's chosen people. But, once again the question is why? Why does God choose to operate opposite of the way we think and operate?

Because of His Glory. It's always about His Glory. God never wants man to receive credit, because if man receives any credit for the things of God, then God decreases while man increases. And to be honest with you, if man receives any credit, nine times out of 10 he cannot handle it. It's just that simple.

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Credit and accolades always puff up the individual, and once that sets in all types of bad things begin to happen. Plainly put, when pride sets in, it then becomes all about the individual and not about God. Now, when thinking about the way God operates, there is probably no better scripture to highlight what I am saying than 1 Cor. 1:26-31. Listen to what Paul wrote:

26 For consider your calling, brethren, that there were not many wise according to the flesh, not many mighty, not many noble;

27 but God has chosen the foolish things of the world to shame the wise, and God has chosen the weak things of the world to shame the things which are strong,

28 and the base things of the world and the despised God has chosen, the things that are not, so that He may nullify the things that are,

29 so that no man may boast before God.

30 But by His doing you are in Christ Jesus, who became to us wisdom from God, and righteousness and sanctification, and redemption,

31 so that, just as it is written, “LET HIM WHO BOASTS, BOAST IN THE LORD.”

As I said, there is probably no greater commentary on why God chooses people opposite of what we would choose than that of 1 Cor. 1:26-31. And this fact gives us insight into at least two important spiritual principles that are in play as it relates to God, and one of these principals will serve you well as you try to navigate life, especially when it comes to asking yourself the question, how do I know when things are of God verses how do I know when things are of man?

Or, in the case of the church of Corinth, how do we know which man is telling us the truth and which one is not? Is it Paul or this other person?

First of all, let me say, based on 1 Cor. 1:26-31, it’s no surprise that God gives us a glimpse into Paul’s appearance and stature and oratory skills. And it’s absolutely no surprise that God would choose Paul to be (what most scholars consider to be) the greatest writer of the New Testament, greatest evangelist, and the greatest Apostle.

It’s also no surprise, this man who has slipped into this fellowship would use Paul’s personal appearance in an effort to discredit him. If you listen closely, you can hear this man say, come on people, seriously, have you looked at this guy and have you listened to him speak, really? You think this is God’s man?

That’s the sense here, and unfortunately for Paul, he can only defend himself by way of writing a letter, because he is not there with them. So, with all this said, what principal or red flag is in play that helps us know when something is of God or when it is of man?

Before telling you, let me give you a hint. You cannot recognize this red flag unless you know God’s word, because God’s word is what gives you the basis to judge things by. So, the red flag is simple, and it begins with a question; is what this individual or group is saying line up with the character of God - who He is and how He operates?

If it doesn’t, you can know immediately who is working for the Lord and who is working in their own self-interest. You see, it’s all about knowing God, and when you know Him, and

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you know how He operates, it's really easy to identify what or who is of God and who's not.

John the Evangelist gave us a warning, a warning that speaks to the heart of what I am trying to convey here this morning. Listen to what he said in 1 John 4:1:

1 Beloved, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits to see whether they are from God, because many false prophets have gone out into the world.

And so, based on John's own writings, and based on the testimony of scripture, we should never believe everything we hear. Instead, we should test the spirit and see whether it's from God or not. But how do we do that? We do it by lining up what is being said back against God's word.

Believe it or not, it's not that hard. We make it hard because we often mix emotion into the equation. And let me say one more thing. Whenever a man becomes the center of attention, or when man gets credit, or when man shows up larger than life, when he is exalted, looked up to, revered, and in the worst cases worshipped, that is definitely one of the first signs that something is not right.

And certainly, when that sets in inside a church, you can be rest assured pride is not far behind, and once pride takes hold, sets in inside that individual, the next step will result in a fall. That scenario has beseeched many a leader and certainly many a preacher throughout the history of mankind.

Over and over again man is exalted, pride ensues, he loses his humility and before you know it, he's on the front page of the paper. And just a side bar before moving on, even though the scripture makes it clear that God chooses the most unlikely candidates to serve His purposes, that doesn't mean that when you meet an ugly preacher who can't speak well, that he must be God's man. That's not the litmus test.

Once again, how do you know who God's man is? It all boils down to God's word and decrees and do the man's words/actions line up with God's words. Then and only then can you rely on what he is saying. Anything short of that, good looking or unattractive or whatever, it doesn't matter.

Now, as we end our teaching this morning, I want to highlight one more thing. Something you hear me say all the time. Something very important. And that is, one of the primary callings of a Pastor/Teacher is to help eliminate confusion in the life of the believer. Everyone is confused because they don't know what they believe, and the reason for that is their belief system has been developed by what someone has told them, not what they have studied.

Paul's situation with the Church of Corinth is a prime example of this problem. These people are confused because their foundation is weak. All because they don't know what they believe, and therefore they are easily swayed. I want to read a section from Matthew 7 in closing, where Jesus paints for us a picture of what I am trying to convey. Listen to it real quick Matt. 7:24-29:

The Two Foundations

24 "Therefore everyone who hears these words of Mine and acts on them, may be compared to a wise man who built his house on the rock.

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25 “And the rain fell, and the floods came, and the winds blew and slammed against that house; and *yet* it did not fall, for it had been founded on the rock.

26 “Everyone who hears these words of Mine and does not act on them, will be like a foolish man who built his house on the sand.

27 “The rain fell, and the floods came, and the winds blew and slammed against that house; and it fell—and great was its fall.”

28 When Jesus had finished these words, the crowds were amazed at His teaching;

29 for He was teaching them as *one* having authority, and not as their scribes.

In these verses Jesus lays it out for us. Whoever hears His words and does something with those words is compared to a wise man who built his house on the rock. Whereas, the man who hears God’s word and ignores it is like a foolish man, one who is building a house on sand.

I want you to notice something as we close. When Jesus speaks in terms of someone being wise or foolish, He compares them as someone building a house on rock is the one who hears His words and acts on it, or the one who builds a house on sand, hears but does nothing with it.

What Jesus is ultimately talking about is someone’s foundation. Their base. And that base or foundation is God’s word. There is nothing else.

Now, we started out today’s lesson talking about how Paul was trying to change this church’s mindset, their paradigm, which has taken a left turn somewhere along the way because they began listening to the wrong man. And so, what that tells us is their foundation is shaky, and for that reason Paul is trying to back it up by redirecting them back to God’s word.

So once again it all boils down to God’s word; hearing it, knowing it, and doing something with it. And so, if that’s the case, then the only question that remains is, how’s your foundation? Are you studying for yourself to find that these things might be true, or are you relying on the Pastor or some devotional (Lord help us), to tell you what you believe?

This is what’s at the heart of what Paul is dealing with, and if you as an individual believer don’t want to walk around this life in a spiritual malaise of sorts, always confused, you must build your foundation on the Word of God and know for yourself what God says, not what man says.

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- Alright guys, welcome back. Turn with me if you will to 2 Corinthians the 10th Chapter. When we were last together, we finished our teaching by focusing on verses 7-11 in Chapter 10, and in those verses, we read where Paul answered some accusations that had been leveled against him.
  - And of course, as we know, those accusations were leveled by one individual in the church, a person who had slipped into the church sometime after Paul had left. After he moved on to another area to set up another church.
  - In verses 7 & 10, we read where Paul made the following statement as a rebuttal back to those who were questioning him in the Church of Corinth. But more specifically, it was directed back toward this one individual who had begun stirring up all the trouble in the first place. And this is what we read in verses 7 -10:

2 Cor. 10:7 **You are looking at things as they are outwardly. If anyone is confident in himself that he is Christ's, have him consider this again within himself, that just as he is Christ's, so too are we.**
2 Cor. 10:8 **For if I boast somewhat more about our authority, which the Lord gave for building you up and not for destroying you, I will not be put to shame,**
2 Cor. 10:9 **for I do not want to seem as if I would terrify you by my letters.**
2 Cor. 10:10 **For they say, "His letters are weighty and strong, but his personal presence is unimpressive and his speech contemptible."**

- I am not going to rehash these verses again. We already did that last week. But I would like for us to recognize a couple things about verses 9 & 10. Something I feel is worth noting one more time. Let me read it again. Paul says:

2 Cor. 10:9 **for I do not want to seem as if I would terrify you by my letters.**
2 Cor. 10:10 **For they say, "His letters are weighty and strong, but his personal presence is unimpressive and his speech contemptible."**

- First of all, let me say, when Paul writes a letter in an effort to correct behavior, he never sidesteps the truth. He never dances around the issues or is ambiguous about the message he is trying to send. On the contrary. He almost always opens up with a greeting, and in that greeting he establishes who he is and then jumps into the deep end.
  - Meaning, he hits the issues head on. This is what he means when he says, "For they say, His letters are weighty and strong,"
  - Guys, I would like to point out at least two things about Paul's approach. First, the truth will always stand when nothing else will. And this is not my opinion, it's a Biblical truth found in John 8:32 where it says:

John 8:32 **and you will know the truth, and the truth will make you free."**

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- The Greek says, “And the truth will set you free”. The usage of the word, or meaning, is to set free, liberate, release from bondage. Figuratively, to remove the restrictions of sin (darkness), because the words were delivered by God into true spiritual liberty (growth).
    - And this is encouraging, especially if you stop to think about it for just a minute. I mean after all; this statement would seem to give us the answers to all our problems. Right? Just get to the truth and then let everyone know it. And then, walla, everyone will be fixed. Isn’t that how it works?
    - Well, evidently not, because I have seen the truth spoken many times to many people and nothing changed. I want to be clear about something. When John speaks about the truth, he is not speaking about the world’s truth or the world’s wisdom. That’s a form of truth but not absolute truth.
- Honestly, it’s really more of an opinion or perspective based on experience. Absolute truth can only be derived by the creator. And this applies to the creator of anything; a painter, a writer, a sculpturer, a builder, whomever. The truth of any object can only be ascertained by the one who created it, because logically, he or she is the only one who knows why they created whatever it was they created.
    - It’s real simple. The creator is the only one who knows their purposes and plans, therefore, the truth that John spoke is speaking directly to the Word of God, not some truth as man sees it. Which means the truth of God is the instrument that frees God’s created people. And it accomplishes its purpose by causing us to self-reflect, without any fear of bias.
    - Which eliminates the thoughts in our heads that say, well, that person said this or that because it benefited them, or, they said what they said because they think they know me. Follow me here. The truth you read or hear will never meet its intended purposes unless you can hear it without any reservation, which is brought about by presupposition and or thoughts in our minds.
        - Those thoughts or presuppositions that speak to us silently, saying things like, this person has some bias for why it is they are saying what they are saying. And by the way, this is one good reason for seeing a counselor who doesn’t know you, because you can let your guard down with no worry of condemnation.
- Now having said all of this, let me say, when we speak truth to someone there is not an automatic law or rule in play that says that person will hear you and receive it, and apply it, which creates a little confusion in my mind and brings on more talk. Because John says:

John 8:32 **and you will know the truth, and the truth will make you free.”**

- So why can’t we just tell someone the truth straight from God’s Word and that person will automatically begin the process of change? Because for that to happen, God must first open that person’s heart and mind, giving them the ability to hear, see, and receive.
    - Even Jesus Himself dealt with this spiritual realty in Matthew 15, where, after feeding 4000 people with just 7 loaves of bread and a few small fish, and after healing many, many people, after all those miracles, the Pharisees still didn’t believe Jesus was who He appeared to be.

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- So, they decided to put Him to the test to see if He was for real, and we read about this moment in Matthew 16, where he said the following:

Matthew 16:1 The Pharisees and Sadducees came up, and testing Jesus, they asked Him to show them a sign from heaven.

- So, after feeding thousands with just 7 loaves and a few fish and miraculously healing countless people, that wasn't enough. There were still those who simply would not believe. Which tells us something. It tells us that, yes, the truth sets us free, but only when we receive it and then do something with it.
  - And that will not happen unless God opens up a person's pores, giving them eyes to see and ears to hear. Anything short of that, no matter how truthful, will be met with disdain and angst. And so, with all that said, now what? What's a brother or sister to do?
  - Seems a bit discouraging when you stop long enough to think about it. Well, first of all, remember we are not responsible for the outcome, God is. And second of all, when you speak to someone in an effort to correct their behavior, you must do so with the correct intent and with a pure heart.
    - And many times, that may not happen unless you spend a lot of time in prayer before approaching that person. Remember, the result we want is the result God wants. Which is what? "To bring honor and Glory to His name", which means, if the intent of our talk has anything to do with us; our bias, our wants or desires, anything at all, then we should keep it to ourselves.
  - That is our litmus test. When we are not sure when to speak, if our intent glorifies God, then we are on track. If not, let it be, at least until we get our minds right. Which, as I said, means we have the correct intent with a pure heart. Without those two components, we will find very little success in our discussion.
    - Another way to say it is, truth without love cancels itself out, and will many times fall on deaf ears.
- Follow me here. Just because you're right, doesn't mean the person listening will receive what you are saying, which is why I said the best approach in revealing the truth is to be in the right state of mind.
  - Let me explain what I mean a little bit further. Have you ever been reprimanded or scolded or punished by someone who wasn't your parent; someone whom you wouldn't necessarily say loved you?
  - Maybe that person was a teacher or police officer or judge, or maybe it was an employer, or for heaven's sake maybe it was the IRS. Someone who was just doing their job and enforcing the rules. If you can think back to that moment for just a minute, did you feel their direction was coming from a place of love?
    - Probably not. Even if you were in the wrong you still probably felt judged, misunderstood, or simply mistreated, and therefore you struggled accepting or receiving their discipline. My point is this. The goal of revealing truth to an individual is not for us to be right or win the argument. It's so that the situation will improve, both for the individual and for all parties involved.

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        - And for that reason, when we point out truth to fellow brothers or sisters, it should always be grounded in God's Word, packaged with genuine concern and love for that individual. Anything short of that will miss the mark, and we should probably keep it to ourselves.
- Let me say one more thing. Sometimes, even when we do love the person, but we don't feel love toward them in the moment, we actually feel opposite that. We feel anger, frustration, and stress with the situation. The only solution for reversing those feelings can only come by way of prayer and meditation and focus on what God desires for everyone involved.
    - Paul loved the people of the Church of Corinth. I mean, after all, he founded the church. He helped establish the leadership. But here he is, fighting to regain their confidence (which by the way had to be extremely frustrating. And I think we know he is frustrated by what he writes in verse 10, when he says,

2 Cor. 10:10 **For they say, "His letters are weighty and strong,**

- The words weighty and strong are word for word the exact same translation in the Greek. Weighty means heavy and burdensome, and strong means strong & mighty. The usage of these two words combined gives us the sense of this document being grievous and pressing down on a person with oppressive force.
    - Such a grievous burden makes a person unable to function (enjoy free movement). Let me say, the only type of words that can bring with them these types of internal feelings are words of absolute truth. Not your truth, not my truth, but God's truth.
    - Your words might make me mad or angry, but your words will never carry this type of weight or heaviness on my soul unless they are words of absolute truth. And by the way, that is exactly what God's word does to an individual. It disrupts their spirit, especially when you study for yourself.
        - As a matter of fact, one of the ways you can know if you are studying correctly is when you feel oppressed by what you're studying. God's word has a way of shining a light on your life. It has a way of finding your secret hiding places. Bringing your impurities to the surface. Because as you study, you are faced with the reality of who you truly are, which then gives you an opportunity to improve by dealing with those issues.
- I want you to notice I didn't say when you study it brings to light someone else's sin or shortcomings. God's word, when absorbed correctly in context, and rightly divided, will force you to look directly into a mirror, which will then force you to deal with yourself.
    - And that was Paul's goal when he wrote to a church. To get them to reflect. And this is evident by what he said in verse 7, when he said:

2 Cor. 10:7 **You are looking at things as they are outwardly. If anyone is confident in himself that he is Christ's, have him consider this again within himself, that just as he is Christ's, so too are we.**

- Paul is saying, if you are confident in yourself that you are in Christ, then examine

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yourself and you may want to reconsider, because we know for sure we are in Christ. And, paraphrasing here, he' saying the way you are acting is polar opposite of what God expects.

- And this is evident by the fact that this problematic individual in the church is trying to use Paul's appearance as some type of proof that he is really not an Apostle. I mean seriously, does that sounds like something a Godly man would say? No. It sounds exactly like something a worldly man would say.
  - I mean after all, God would never choose a person who looks like Paul and speaks like Paul as His ambassador, would He? And so in response to that, Paul is saying (paraphrasing here), if this person is using my looks as some sort of proof of my calling, that's fine, but (for a lack of better words), I would tell that person to take a hard look at themselves, because if this person thinks they are in Christ, they may want to double check that.

- Moving on, next Paul writes something that says a whole lot but may seem insignificant on the surface. Listen to what he wrote in verse 11:

2 Cor. 10:11 Have such a person consider this, that what we are in word by letters when absent, such persons *we are* also in deed when present.

- Paraphrasing here, who we are in this letter is who we are indeed in everyday life. Once again, here is the definition of a true testimony. Your testimony to the world is not what you say, but who you are. Are we the same in church as we are in the world, or do we play to the crowd?
  - This is so important for us to receive this morning, because the church of our day and age has forgotten this. You see, the gig is up on Christianity. The world isn't buying what we are selling anymore. Believe me when I tell you, when we say we are Christian the world automatically begins watching, and they combine two truths, at least two truths as they see it.
  - One is the fact that you called yourself a Christ follower and the second is, will your life prove out what it is you say you believe in your daily life, or is it just a name tag or bracelet you wear? You know, like one people wore for years. Those WWJD bracelets - What Would Jesus Do?
    - You see, when your words don't line up, the world tosses you into the same bucket as the rest of the Christians, those who say one thing and do another, and they classify us as hypocrites. Remember once again, the world is watching. You may not realize it, but they are. And Christians are losing ground in the day and age that we live in.

- Pressing on. Paul's next statement is so insightful and so powerful; an applicable to all of us sitting here today, so listen to what he says in verse 12:

2 Cor. 10:12 For we are not bold to class or compare ourselves with some of those who commend themselves; but when they measure themselves by themselves and compare themselves with themselves, they are without understanding.

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- Now, as we study, it's easy to lose track as to why Paul is writing this letter, so I want you to keep your focus. Remember, Paul is defending himself, so when he writes, he's writing with his defense in mind.
    - He says something very insightful to the Church in Corinth. Something we should all be cognitive of. He says when they measure themselves, they do so by measuring themselves to themselves. And then for clarification, he says not only do they measure themselves by themselves, but they also compare themselves with themselves, which is basically the same thing but further clarified.
    - This statement, my friends, is one we should all remember as we live out the rest of our lives. When looking at ourselves for the purpose of self-evaluation, we shouldn't measure ourselves by others around us. We can do that, but it has no life-improving effect.
        - And why doesn't it have any life-improving or changing effect? Because I can always find someone that I feel I'm doing better than at the moment. Someone whom I could say, well, I'm not so bad. Look at him or her.
        - As I said, you can do that, but it carries no life-changing value. As a matter of fact, it's a complete waste of time. Instead, our standard barrier should be who? Jesus, right? If we want to compare ourselves to someone, then compare ourselves to Jesus. Do that and the exercise will be over really quick.
- Pressing on, and we will close with verses 13-18:

2 Cor. 10:13 But we will not boast beyond *our* measure, but within the measure of the sphere which God apportioned to us as a measure, to reach even as far as you.
2 Cor. 10:14 For we are not overextending ourselves, as if we did not reach to you, for we were the first to come even as far as you in the gospel of Christ;
2 Cor. 10:15 not boasting beyond *our* measure, *that is,* in other men's labors, but with the hope that as your faith grows, we will be, within our sphere, enlarged even more by you,
2 Cor. 10:16 so as to preach the gospel even to the regions beyond you, *and* not to boast in what has been accomplished in the sphere of another.
2 Cor. 10:17 But HE WHO BOASTS IS TO BOAST IN THE LORD.
2 Cor. 10:18 For it is not he who commends himself that is approved, but he whom the Lord commends.

- Paul uses the word boast here a lot. As a matter of fact, he uses the word 29 times in 2 Corinthians and only 26 times throughout the rest of his letters combined. So evidently, boasting has been brought up as an issue by this rouge individual in the church who is working very hard to disqualify Paul and the other disciples by trying to point out how it is that he thinks Paul and the others are boastful.
    - That they have exceeded their limits of ministry, saying they have no right to minister in Corinth, which makes zero sense, obviously. But that's what this man is saying, so Paul addresses his critic by saying, no, what he is saying is not true and here's why. And then, no, that's not true either and here's why.

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- Which is so ridiculous that Paul has to defend himself. But, while he is defending himself, he says something, something that is so important for you and me to grasp and understand, and it shows up in verses 17&18:

2 Cor. 10:17 But HE WHO BOASTS IS TO BOAST IN THE LORD.
2 Cor. 10:18 For it is not he who commends himself that is approved, but he whom the Lord commends.

- One of the biggest issues facing mankind is the lack of humility, and in its place the presence of pride. Many times, when good things happen to us, or we accomplish something great, we just can't refrain from giving ourselves a pat on the back. Which is exacerbated when others reinforce that feeling by giving us a pat on the back as well.
  - I want us to understand something here this morning before we close. The testimony of scripture is crystal clear. As believers, Christian men and women, when something good happens to us or for us, we are to give all credit back to God. We receive zero credit.
    - It is so tempting to brag on ourselves, either consciously or subconsciously. To give ourselves way more credit than we truly deserve. Throughout my career as a businessman, I often think about what James Taylor says. "I've seen fire and I've seen rain." A lot more rain than fire by the way.
- Having said that, we have been blessed, and I have had some pretty miraculous things happen in my favor. But when I look back at them and really think about how all of it came together, I am faced with the reality that it was all God. That I am really not as smart as I thought I was, and for sure I am not that lucky.
  - So many times, if one little thing had happened differently, everything would have gone the other way. Sometimes the timing was impeccable. Meaning, if I had not been standing where I was standing at that exact moment, or if I hadn't met someone or went to a place that I didn't want to go, the thing that happened in my favor would have never happened. Which just reinforces what Paul is saying in verse 17, which says,

2 Cor. 10:17 But HE WHO BOASTS IS TO BOAST IN THE LORD.

- In other words, guys, God is in control of our lives. He causes the sun to rise and to fall. He makes the seasons change. He controls our entire environmental ecosystem, and He certainly controls what happens in the lives of His children. And why? Because He is working His plan.
  - And believe it or not, this applies in hardship as well. God is always doing something; good, bad, or indifferent, and our lives are not our own. The Bible says you and I have been bought with a price, which means, once you are saved, you are His. You are a slave. A Dulios, in the Greek. You're a servant of the King!
  - Which means when something good happens, when success comes your way, when you just happen to meet someone at the right time who helps further your career, or whatever positive thing happens in your life, don't pat yourself on the back.

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Remember, when good things happen, this is your opportunity to give credit to the one you say you serve.

- And as always, never forget the world is watching, so recognize it for what it is. It's God's provisions and blessings in your life, and therefore, pause and think, and point people away from you and back to the cross. And Give God all the Glory!

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- Welcome back guys and I hope you are staying warm. If you're not, just snuggle with the person next to you. If you don't know them, just tell them to go with it, it will all be over soon.
    - Anyway, back to our study of 2 Corinthians. We ended our teaching last week by finishing Chapter 10, where Paul took the liberty of over 18 verses to describe himself to this church. In reality, what Paul was doing was the same thing he had been doing for the entire letter.
    - He is defending himself against this one individual who has slipped into the church and began nay-saying, murmuring, and downplaying who Paul is – his role as an Apostle and his authority. And of course, Paul is working to discredit this individual, because this man is saying that he too is an Apostle, and therefore they should listen to him instead of Paul.
- Now, if we were able to back out to 100,000 feet and look down on this letter, the central theme revolves around Paul defending himself, which includes him trying to reestablish his position in the eyes of this church in Corinth (the one that he founded and established by the way).
    - And so, just when you thought that Paul had just about exhausted every effort through his writings to accomplish his goal, we move into Chapter 11, where sure enough, he continues on. This section is entitled 'Paul defends His Apostleship'.
    - Now, before you roll your eyes or say lordy, lordy please help us, I will tell you we only have two chapters left in this letter, and neither one of those chapters continues the theme of Paul defending himself.
- Now, before we jump into Chapter 11 this morning, I want you to remember, when we study scripture, there is the message we read, and many times there are several we don't read.
    - This is an important concept for us to remember, especially when you study a section of scripture, and it appears to go on and on and on with the same message. Remember, each word of God's Holy Manuscript has purpose and meaning, and it's 100% applicable to our everyday life.
    - Which means when we study scripture, even though it may appear to be driving the same point home, in reality there really is no redundancy to God's Word. Yes, the surface message may be the same, but the deeper message always changes. And that's because (generally speaking) the situation and circumstances change.
    - Which then gives us a different angle or way to look at the situation, the result being, we can apply it differently in our own life.
        - And Chapter 11 is going to give you a really good example of what I am saying. As I said, the chapter is entitled, 'Paul Defends His Apostleship'. But there is much more to these writings than Paul just defending himself. Follow me and let me show you what I mean.
    - 2 Corinthians 11:1-6, and here's what Paul wrote:

Paul Defends His Apostleship

2 Cor. 11:1 **I wish that you would bear with me in a little foolishness; but indeed you are bearing with me.**

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- Let me stop right here for a minute, because I find this to be an odd statement. Listen to it again:

2 Cor. 11:1 I wish that you would bear with me in a little foolishness; but indeed you are bearing with me.

- What in the world is he saying? Well, first of all, remember, we must remain in context with this verse, and in order to do that we need to back up and read the end of Chapter 10, so we can get the feel for why he is writing these words. Let's do that real quick.

2 Cor. 10:12 For we are not bold to class or compare ourselves with some of those who commend themselves; but when they measure themselves by themselves and compare themselves with themselves, they are without understanding.
2 Cor. 10:13 But we will not boast beyond *our* measure, but within the measure of the sphere which God apportioned to us as a measure, to reach even as far as you.
2 Cor. 10:14 For we are not overextending ourselves, as if we did not reach to you, for we were the first to come even as far as you in the gospel of Christ;
2 Cor. 10:15 not boasting beyond *our* measure, *that is,* in other men's labors, but with the hope that as your faith grows, we will be, within our sphere, enlarged even more by you,
2 Cor. 10:16 so as to preach the gospel even to the regions beyond you, *and* not to boast in what has been accomplished in the sphere of another.
2 Cor. 10:17 But HE WHO BOASTS IS TO BOAST IN THE LORD.
2 Cor. 10:18 For it is not he who commends himself that is approved, but he whom the Lord commends.

- In this last section of Chapter 10, Paul explains how that he and the other disciples, how they (paraphrasing here), how it is, in all that they are, in all that they do, they cannot do more or achieve any more than God has given them to achieve or do. And, he says they do not commend themselves by measuring themselves back against what others have achieved.
  - On the contrary. Their achievements can only be validated through God Himself.
  - And, he says, in everything we do, all glory be to God. What Paul is doing is simply pointing out the differences in his words and testimony verses this man's words and testimony. And through that, he is defending his position as an Apostle by comparing his ministry to that of this one individual in the church.
    - Basically, he says we know who we are, and we know who we serve, and we know our calling. And my favorite part of this entire section lies in verse 12, where he says,

2 Cor. 10:12 For we are not bold to class or compare ourselves with some of those

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who commend themselves; but when they measure themselves by themselves and compare themselves with themselves, they are without understanding.

- In other words, when a person evaluates themselves, especially on a spiritual basis, their standard or measuring stick should never be another person, especially someone whom they deem is doing worse than them. And why? Well, the goal of self-evaluation is what? Personal improvement. And when you measure yourself by someone whom you feel is doing worse than you, you don't accomplish anything.
    - All you do is confirm in your own mind that you're okay, which is counterintuitive to the entire process. And by the way, just in case you are wondering, none of us are truly okay, especially when comparing ourselves to the true standard, which is a standard of perfection.
    - And the only human who ever met that standard was Jesus. He is our standard. And so, based on that standard, we are not okay. Next, Paul says (paraphrasing again), if you guys. the Church at Corinth, if you guys don't know who to believe, which is crazy by the way, but whatever, if you guys don't know who to believe then just look at who we are comparing ourselves to, verses who this man is comparing himself too,
        - If you do that, you will get a pretty good indication of who's on track and who's not. And so, there's the context of the end of Chapter 10, and then leads Paul to write this verse 1 of Chapter 11:

2 Cor. 11:1 **I wish that you would bear with me in a little foolishness; but indeed, you are bearing with me.**

- Still doesn't really make sense. So, let's read a little further into verse 2, and see if we can clear it up.

2 Cor. 11:2 **For I am jealous for you with a godly jealousy; for I betrothed you to one husband, so that to Christ I might present you *as* a pure virgin.**

- Let me pause and read both verses together.

2 Cor. 11:1 **I wish that you would bear with me in a little foolishness; but indeed, you are bearing with me.**
2 Cor. 11:2 **For I am jealous for you with a godly jealousy; for I betrothed you to one husband, so that to Christ I might present you *as* a pure virgin.**

- When he says, "I wish that you would bear with me in a little foolishness", what he is saying is, this entire thing is ridiculous. It's foolish that I'm even having to do this, but I am.
    - And just a side bar. Some writers refer to 11:1-12:13 as Paul's "Fool's Speech"

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because of the recurring foolishness terminology in this passage, because of that fact that he had to make this defense in the first place. Next, he says:

2 Cor. 11:2 For I am jealous for you with a godly jealousy; for I betrothed you to one husband, so that to Christ I might present you *as* a pure virgin.

- I am jealous for you with a Godly jealously. What is Godly jealousy? Dr. Thomas Constable said this about Paul's statement.
  - "God had jealously guarded His people Israel from the deceitfulness of deceivers who sought to draw their affections away from Him (cf. Hos. 2:19-20; 4:12; 6:4; 11:8).
- Paul felt the same concern for the Corinthians. His jealousy was in that sense Godly (God-like).
  - And proof of this lies in what he said in verse 2, when he pictured himself as the father of a virgin bride (cf. 1 Cor. 4:15; 2 Cor. 12:14).
  - How his desire was to keep his daughter, the Corinthian church, pure until she would consummate her marriage to Christ (cf. 4:14; Eph. 5:27; 1 John 3:2-3).[394]
    - This will take place at the Rapture. Another view is that Paul was thinking of himself as the groomsman or bridegroom's friend who, traditionally, presented the bride to the groom in the Jewish wedding ceremony.[395]
    - Human jealousy is a vice, but to share divine jealousy is a virtue. It is the motive and object of the jealousy that is all-important.
  - There is a place for a spiritual father's passionate concern for the exclusive and pure devotion to Christ of his spiritual children, and also a place for anger at potential violators of that purity (11:29)."[396]
- Next – Paul goes on to say:

2 Cor. 11:3 But I am afraid that, as the serpent deceived Eve by his craftiness, your minds will be led astray from the simplicity and purity *of devotion* to Christ.
2 Cor. 11:4 For if one comes and preaches another Jesus whom we have not preached, or you receive a different spirit which you have not received, or a different gospel which you have not accepted, you bear *this* beautifully.
2 Cor. 11:5 For I consider myself not in the least inferior to the most eminent apostles.
2 Cor. 11:6 But even if I am unskilled in speech, yet I am not *so* in knowledge; in fact, in every way we have made *this* evident to you in all things.

- Verses 3-6 give us a minimum of six to seven powerful observations. And right out of the gate, I want you to notice something. Something that might seem inconsequential at first glance, but it's not.
  - You see, inside Paul's own writings we get a glimpse into his humanity, and it all begins in verse 3 with the words 'I am afraid'. I am afraid. Guess what folks? Paul

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was afraid. Guess what else? There has never been an individual born on planet earth who taught and preached and believed more in the complete Sovereignty of God than the Apostle Paul.

- Which means there has never been anyone more convinced that God was in total control of all things than Paul. Yet he was afraid, but afraid of what? Afraid that after all the hard work he had put into establishing the Church at Corinth, that the church would somehow permanently lose its way.
  - And the example he used was that of Eve being deceived by Satan in the garden. Now, if you have attended church for very long, or even if you haven't, I would say most all of us are probably familiar with the story of Adam and Eve and the fall of mankind.
  - The takeaway from that story is not just the fact that Eve disobeyed God, but rather how it was that she came to that conclusion. How she decided it was a good idea to completely ignore God's command. And why did she disobey God? Because the enemy was crafty.

- Now, if you study the word crafty in the Greek you will discover there is much more to this word than meets the eye. In my opinion, the word crafty really isn't the best descriptor of Satan's character. It really doesn't do it justice. The word crafty (to me) somewhat denotes sneaky or simple.
  - But as I said that word just doesn't pay proper respect to the enemy's intelligence level. You see, the enemy isn't just crafty. No, when you study the word in the Greek it's much more powerful than that. The real sense of the word means he was clever, shrewd, skillful, and cunning.
  - The enemy wasn't just a worthy adversary. No, far from it. The enemy was smarter than she was. One of the definitions I read in the Greek said, figuratively; crafty behavior, unscrupulous cunning that stops at nothing to achieve a selfish goal. And certainly, that definition better describes the enemy that you and I face on a daily basis.
- Now, when facing any enemy, it is always imperative that we do research on our opponent, so we can know who it is we are up against. And in the spirit of research, 1 Peter 5:8 gives what I would call a much better insight into what we are facing when he says this:

1 Peter 5:8 Be of sober *spirit,* be on the alert. Your adversary, the devil, prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour.

- Have you ever seen a video of a Lion stalking its prey? If you haven't, I suggest you watch one, because that's exactly how the enemy works. He is slow and methodical. He eases in and his craftiness does not present itself in obvious ways. Remember, he is smarter than you are, therefore, his preferred method is not the direct approach.
  - As I said, he eases in, pulls up a chair next to you, and he does this in familiar ways. It's familiar because generally we are the ones who invite him in, specifically through the things we allow to enter our lives. The things we read, we watch, listen to, including the things we tolerate and participate in.

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- And what's interesting is, many, many times our enemy is not part of some of the things we do, but rather he uses those things as a portal into our souls, specifically by way of our eyes and ears. Much like a Trojan horse. And that is exactly what Paul is afraid of for this church, that they have allowed a seemingly harmless individual to enter their fellowship, and over time he's begun dropping little hints questioning who Paul is.
- And, according to verse 3, the result could be that they will be led astray from the simplicity and purity of serving Christ. And just so you know, when Paul mentions 'the simplicity and purity of serving Christ', he is describing how that serving Christ is not hard. There is nothing super spiritual about it.
  - It simply boils down to two things. First, knowing what God expects, which can only come by way of His Word, and second, putting into practice what you have learned – obedience.

- Guys, just so you know, the enemy in Paul's day is the same enemy prowling around in our day. Which means what happened to Eve and the church at Corinth will happen to you as well if you are not grounded in your faith. In your relationship with God.
  - If we as believers don't work to build up and feed the spirit that lives within us, the enemy will eat us alive. And when that happens, he will also attack our children. Remember, Satan is a lot of things, but he is never intrusive. He is crafty, subtle, clever, and sly. But even more than that, he's so dangerous because he is comfortable and familiar.
  - Meaning, he meets us where we are and finds his way into our lives through the things we participate in, such as through the things we read, see, and hear.
- Pressing on one more time, in Verse 4 Paul says:

2 Cor. 11:4 For if one comes and preaches another Jesus whom we have not preached, or you receive a different spirit which you have not received, or a different gospel which you have not accepted, you bear *this* beautifully.

- What Paul is saying is, this one individual in this church is preaching a different Jesus than the One we are preaching, which brings a different spirit and a different gospel. And then he says, you bear this beautifully. What he means is, you seem to be okay with someone bringing you a different gospel. It's a sarcastic overtone, meaning they seem just fine with this false teacher bringing this false gospel.
  - And then finally, Paul gives us insight into his humanity one more time when he says this in verses 5&6:

2 Cor. 11:5 For I consider myself not in the least inferior to the most eminent apostles.
2 Cor. 11:6 But even if I am unskilled in speech, yet I am not *so* in knowledge; in fact, in every way we have made *this* evident to you in all things.

- Remember, Paul's Apostleship is being called into question here, and evidently, based

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on Paul's own writings he was either being compared to other Apostles or he was being compared to the false Apostles. That's why he says, "For I consider myself not in the least inferior to the most eminent Apostles."

- When Paul says, 'but even if I am unskilled in speech', I would say he was comparing himself to the false teachers, the ones who came with cleverness of speech. Those false teachers who were very good speakers. That's what Paul is fighting against here, men who present well, who garner the attention of the people with their presence and their words.
  - And yet here is ole' Paul. Not much to look at. Not very eloquent or poised in his oratory presentation. But despite all of that, he says something, something that is the key to everything. Something that makes all the difference in the world. Something that you and I must strive to do if we want to live a life that is pleasing to God, and it shows up midway through verse 6, and this is where we are going to close this morning:

2 Cor. 11:6 But even if I am unskilled in speech, (and here it is) yet I am not *so* in knowledge; in fact, in every way we have made *this* evident to you in all things.

- Paul is saying, I may not be a professionally trained speaker or orator, but I can assure you of one thing, this is not the case when it comes to my knowledge of God. Paul echoes this same sentiment in 1 Corinthians 2:1-8, when he says this:

1 Cor. 2:1 And when I came to you, brethren, I did not come with superiority of speech or of wisdom, proclaiming to you the testimony of God.
1 Cor. 2:2 For I determined to know nothing among you except Jesus Christ, and Him crucified.
1 Cor. 2:3 I was with you in weakness and in fear and in much trembling,
1 Cor. 2:4 and my message and my preaching were not in persuasive words of wisdom, but in demonstration of the Spirit and of power,
1 Cor. 2:5 so that your faith would not rest on the wisdom of men, but on the power of God.
1 Cor. 2:6 Yet we do speak wisdom among those who are mature; a wisdom, however, not of this age nor of the rulers of this age, who are passing away;
1 Cor. 2:7 but we speak God's wisdom in a mystery, the hidden *wisdom* which God predestined before the ages to our glory;
1 Cor. 2:8 *the wisdom* which none of the rulers of this age has understood; for if they had understood it they would not have crucified the Lord of glory;

- Paul says, I did not come to you with superiority of speech or superiority of wisdom (he's refencing the world's wisdom here), and we know this to be the case because he goes on to contrast the world's wisdom verses the wisdom that comes from God, and how that through the Spirit of God they have received the wisdom God predestined them to have. "Before the ages to our glory," as he described it. He calls it "hidden wisdom".

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    - Guys, inside God's Holy Manuscript (this thing we call the "Bible") lies a 'hidden wisdom', and it's a wisdom that is only available to believers. Which means as a believer, when you study God's Word correctly, which is in context and rightly divided (rightly divided meaning to tear it apart and break it down).
    - When you do that, God reveals things to you. And not just anything. He reveals Himself in His purest form, which then shines a mirror back in your face, which then forces you to self-evaluate. It puts back pressure on you to become more like Christ and less like the world, which in return matures you and then causes your life to become a witness.
        - It's this 'hidden wisdom' that we are searching for, and it only comes by and through the pages of God's Word. It's that hidden wisdom that will change your life. This hidden wisdom as Paul calls it, is simply the message within the message.
- You see, an unbeliever can read the scriptures, but it really doesn't mean a whole lot. And why? Because he is reading someone else's mail. He or she is reading something that wasn't written to them, therefore when they read it, they will say the same thing the religious rulers said back in Jesus' day. And what did they say? They said, who is this man who speaks as one with authority? They were confused about what he was saying, because His words were never meant for them.
    - Guys, my heartfelt desire is for you to take hold of your spiritual maturity. For you to grow as a believer. For you to become salt and light in a dark and dying world. For God to use you whether you know it or not. If you are a believer, this is your goal. For God to use you.
    - Simply put, there is no greater joy this side of heaven than the feeling you get when God uses you for His glory. And that can only happen when you grow and mature into a Christian worthy of being used. And God's method for your growth comes by way of the 'hidden mysteries' of God, which will not be revealed to you unless you spend time with Him in the study of His Word. But you can't do that unless you know how to study.
        - As you have heard me say many times, God's Word was never meant to be read like a novel. His Word is Him in Word form, which means we don't read it, we study it, and when we study it, we do so using certain rules. Those rules are called Hermeneutics.
- My goal for each one of you is to study daily and weekly for yourself. But in order to do that, you need to know how to do it.

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- Good morning, guys and welcome back. It's good to see everyone after missing last week due to snow. This morning, we are going to pick back up with our study of 2 Corinthians as we move ever so close to closing out this letter or book.
    - When we last left off, we finished our teaching by studying 2 Corinthians 11:1-6, which left us with roughly two-thirds of the chapter left to finish. In Chapter 11 Paul is still in the mode of working diligently defending his position and authority as an Apostle of Jesus Christ.
        - And of course, as we have learned, Paul wrote 2 Corinthians because the church had lost its way. It had gotten sidelined or sidetracked. All because of one man. One individual who had permeated or eased his way into this Corinthian Church, and this man put in a lot of work, worked hard, to undermine everything Paul established.
        - And so, in an effort to refute or rebut everything this man said, Paul wrote 2 Corinthians, which, let me say, seems a little unfair. I mean, Paul seems somewhat at a disadvantage, doesn't he? He doesn't seem engaged in a fair fight, per se.
    - What I mean is, this man, the one trying to undermine Paul's work, well, he is present with the Corinthian Church. He is entrenched with this fellowship. Whereas Paul on the other hand is far away when he receives the news that his beloved Corithian Church has wandered and drifted away from what he had taught them.
- Instead, in its place, they have begun adopting all sorts of Pagan practices - Asian mysticism, Greek philosophies and such. And so, all Paul can do is write a letter. Can you imagine? Can you imagine trying to write a letter to a body of believers in an effort to dispel someone who had gained a foothold inside this fellowship? Pretty tough, wouldn't you say?
    - I would say so. No doubt Paul was disheartened as he wrote each and every word. You know he had to be thinking, should I say it this way or present it that way? He probably thought, what if they take what I wrote the wrong way? And once again, that would be normal because he is human.
        - But you know what? He's not actually at a disadvantage. He has an advantage over this man. But that begs the question, just exactly what kind of advantage does he have? It's God's Sovereign and Providential hand, the hand that guides, governs, and protects all His children.
- Now, let me take a minute to expound on what I just said just a little bit more, because if you are a believer, you need to know that Paul's advantage is your advantage. And so, before we move forward with today's teaching, let me challenge you for just a minute.
    - I want you to think about how disheartened Paul must have truly been. I mean, seriously.
    - He established this church, and it wasn't an easy start up by the way. As a matter of fact, he struggled mightily to get anyone to listen or attend his fellowship in the beginning. And we know this to be the case because that's what Acts 18 tells us. Let me flip over and read it for you really quick.

Acts 18:1 **After these things he left Athens and went to Corinth.**

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Acts 18:2 **And he found a Jew named Aquila, a native of Pontus, having recently come from Italy with his wife Priscilla, because Claudius had commanded all the Jews to leave Rome. He came to them,**
Acts 18:3 **and because he was of the same trade, he stayed with them and they were working, for by trade they were tentmakers.**
Acts 18:4 **And he was reasoning in the synagogue every Sabbath and trying to persuade Jews and Greeks.**
Acts 18:5 **But when Silas and Timothy came down from Macedonia,**
Paul *began* devoting himself completely to the word, solemnly testifying to the Jews that Jesus was the Christ.
Acts 18:6 **But when they resisted and blasphemed, he shook out his garments and said to them, "Your blood *be* on your own heads! I am clean. From now on I will go to the Gentiles."**
Acts 18:7 **Then he left there and went to the house of a man named Titius Justus, a worshiper of God, whose house was next to the synagogue.**
Acts 18:8 **Crispus, the leader of the synagogue, believed in the Lord with all his household, and many of the Corinthians when they heard were believing and being baptized.**
Acts 18:9 **And the Lord said to Paul in the night by a vision, "Do not be afraid *any longer,* but go on speaking and do not be silent;**
Acts 18:10 **for I am with you, and no man will attack you in order to harm you, for I have many people in this city."**
Acts 18:11 **And he settled *there* a year and six months, teaching the word of God among them.**

- In this passage we read where Paul was struggling to get anyone to respond. That's exactly what verse 4 highlights when it said:

Acts 18:4 **And he was reasoning in the synagogue every Sabbath and trying to persuade Jews and Greeks.**

- Now I don't want you to blow right by this, because there is a lesson for us to learn when we study Paul's situation. You see, Paul is trying really hard to persuade people to believe in our Lord Jesus Christ. But evidently, it's falling on deaf ears. Verse 4 says he was reasoning with them, which means he was using logic and pragmatism, and rationale, trying to explain who Jesus was and why they should follow Him.
    - In verse 4, it also says he was trying to persuade them. The sense here is that he's pressing in on these people. Leaning in. Working hard trying to convince people to believe. But it's not working. And just a side note; we know from 1 Corinthians 2:3 that when Paul arrived in Corinth, he did so with much fear and trembling.
    - Basically, he was afraid of going to Corinth because it was a rough town, which is further highlighted by what the Lord told him in verse 10 when he said:

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Acts 18:10 **for I am with you, and no man will attack you in order to harm you, for I have many people in this city."**

- But, regardless of his fear, Paul goes anyway. But why? Why does he go? Because he was called to go there. God meant for him to establish a church in that God-forsaken city known as Corinth. But if that's the case then why is he afraid? And really, more than that, why isn't he having any success? Why isn't God blessing his ministry by giving him a few converts?
    - Well, first of all, he was afraid because he was human. He knew the reputation of Corinth, that it was a rough seaport town, so he's afraid because of this town's history. But why didn't God give him any converts? Because He didn't want to. Because it wasn't time.
        - And Paul's entire situation was supernaturally orchestrated by God with multiple purposes in mind. Purposes such as hardship, which is one instrument that God uses to change, bend, and shape us. Which forces us to lean on Him, specifically, to lean on His understanding and not our own.
        - And so, with all this said, what does Paul's situation tell us? It tells us that God intended for Paul to struggle. But why? For his own good. For his growth. And sure enough, as Paul experiences hardship, God does teach him a few things, such as timing. God's timing, and what it means to wait on the Lord and His timing.
        - And when we study Paul's hardship, we learn a few more things. For example, we learn about Paul and his character, his frailties, his weakness, his humanity, and his response to adversity.
    - But we also learn a lot about God as well, specifically about His character and how He operates. Which then gives us the ability to apply what we learned to our own lives.
- And so, if that's the case, then what can we learn from Paul's situation here in Corinth? Well, first of all, we learn that even though we may be called to do something, to go somewhere, to speak to someone, to share Christ with someone, to make a career move because God wants us to work somewhere else, because He has something He is going to do with us.
    - Or maybe to give money to something or someone, even though we are not really sure how much to give or even why we are giving. We just know we are compelled to do so, regardless of what we do or do not know. What we can learn from Paul's situation is that we are not responsible for the outcome or result. We are simply to find peace and rest in the comfort of God's command and calling.
    - We also learn that many times we are just a piece of a much larger plan, and we see this principal being taught by Paul himself in 1 Cor. 3:5-9, where Paul was trying to (once again) straighten out some of the poor thinking that was plaguing the Church at Corinth. And what was it that Paul was dealing with in 1 Cor. 3:5-9?
- Well, evidently some people were bragging about who had baptized them. They were literally arguing and debating and taking pride over who had led them to Christ, saying things like, well I was baptized by Apollos, and someone else would say well I was baptized by Paul.

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- Essentially, they were arguing over whose baptism or salvation was greater. And in response to that nonsense, Paul said the following:

1 Cor. 3:5 **What then is Apollos? And what is Paul? Servants through whom you believed, even as the Lord gave *opportunity* to each one.**
1 Cor. 3:6 **I planted, Apollos watered, but God was causing the growth.**
1 Cor. 3:7 **So then neither the one who plants nor the one who waters is anything, but God who causes the growth.**
1 Cor. 3:8 **Now he who plants and he who waters are one; but each will receive his own reward according to his own labor.**
1 Cor. 3:9 **For we are God's fellow workers; you are God's field, God's building.**

- So, based on Paul's own testimony, we are clearly not responsible for the growth or result. God is. Which is great, because it takes all the stress out of the situation, right? Because it doesn't depend on you. It's not about your oratory presentation or how convincing you are. All we have to do is listen and respond. Be obedient, because it's all about God all the time.
  - But what else do we learn when we study Paul's situation? There are several lessons, but how about this. God will never leave you nor forsake you, which (once again), is highlighted by verse 10, where Paul wrote this:

Acts 18:10 **for I am with you, and no man will attack you in order to harm you, for I have many people in this city."**

- What this tells us is, regardless of our current circumstances, with God it's all about the long game. Just like investing money. And so, if you know this to be the case, then once again you don't have to stress or worry, even when things are really bad. Just pray and ask God to carry you through the storm. To make you stand and persevere. To give you that Philippians Peace "which is a peace that passes all understanding".
  - And so, when you take all of this into account, it creates what I call Paul's strategic advantage. But it's not only Paul's strategic advantage. As I stated earlier, it's the same advantage you have. It's a peace that comes to you by way of knowing that God is in control.
  - Meaning, regardless of this man who has taken a foothold in this church, Paul can rest easy knowing that God will prevail. And Paul knows this is the case but still he is human. He knows whatever God wants to happen will happen, and if it doesn't work out the way Paul hopes or the way we hope, it really makes ZERO difference.
    - You see, as believers, all we want out of this life is what God wants. If you can ever wrap your mind around that concept, it is the most liberating feeling in the world. Let me give you a small example of what I am talking about.
- This past week I received a call about a job. A massive job. And when I received the call, I got really excited, because it would be the largest job in our company's 20-year history. The man who called me said, "Don't get your hopes up, but I believe I may be able to

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bring you in on this job". I said okay.Then I said, well, if it's the Lords will, we will get it. If not, well, we don't want it. A couple of days later I called the man to ask him what was up with the job, and he said, man I am sorry. They had another contractor. To which I replied, no worries, I guess the Lord didn't want us to have it.

- The guy I was speaking to is a believer. But based on his reaction, I still think he was somewhat surprised by my attitude. Guys, this was a huge job for our company. As I said, bigger than any job our company has ever done probably by 10X, but God didn't want us to have it. Why? I have no clue.
- But, because of my perspective on God and His provision for our company and my life, I was at PEACE with it. You see, all I want is what God wants us to have. That's all. And let me say, I am not perfect when it comes to this type of thinking, but I am getting better.
  - Guys, believe it or not, this type of thinking is what gives us a huge strategic advantage over the troubles of life. That is Paul's advantage and that is our advantage. I think Paul best summed it up in Philippians 1:21, when he said:

Phil. 1:21 **For to me, to live is Christ and to die is gain.**

- What he was saying was, I am going to press on with what God has called me to do, regardless of my situation or circumstances. No matter if I face imprisonment or death, whatever my plight, I will press forward. And if I live then so be it, I will live for Christ. And if I die, well great, I get to go be with the Father in heaven. And so, it's a win either way.
  - That mindset is our strategic advantage. It's a mindset that settles your mind, your spirit, your soul, and your very being. It allows you to say, God, your will be done and not mine. And it's in that mindset that you will discover the greatest advantage of all, which is PEACE.
- Now, having said all this, when you study Paul's writings here in 2 Corinthians, you kind of get the feeling that maybe Paul has left that mindset for just a moment as he desperately tries to write and convince these people that they have embraced the wrong path.
  - You get the sense that Paul is taking over. As in, God stand back I've got this. But there is no need for that, because God's Will will be done. Now with this perspective lingering in your mind, turn with me if you will to 2 Cor. 11:7-11. I am going back up to Verse 6 and read it together with Verses 7-11 for context, and here is what Paul said:

2 Cor. 11:6 **But even if I am unskilled in speech, yet I am not *so* in knowledge; in fact, in every way we have made *this* evident to you in all things.**
2 Cor. 11:7 **Or did I commit a sin in humbling myself so that you might be exalted, because I preached the gospel of God to you without charge?**
2 Cor. 11:8 **I robbed other churches by taking wages *from them* to serve you;**
2 Cor. 11:9 **and when I was present with you and was in need, I was not a burden to anyone; for when the brethren came from Macedonia they fully supplied my need, and in everything I kept myself from being a burden to you, and will**

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continue to do so.
2 Cor. 11:10 **As the truth of Christ is in me, this boasting of mine will not be stopped in the regions of Achaia.**
2 Cor. 11:11 **Why? Because I do not love you? God knows *I do!***

- I'm going to paraphrase this entire section for you. Before we begin, remember, Paul is trying to regain his rightful position in the eyes of this church, and he uses as proof of who he is the fact that he hasn't asked them for any type of financial support. In other words, he is saying, one way you can know I am a true Apostle is because I am not asking you for anything, not even financial support!
    - As a matter of fact, I have robbed other churches (which by the way isn't true. Paul is being sarcastic in that statement, using hyperbole). Anyway, Paul says I am who I say I am. In contrast to this other individual, I minister to you free of charge. I have never asked for a penny and will continue to operate this way. And that should serve as some sort of proof that I am who I say I am.
        - Once again, I feel like Paul is pressing in (in his flesh) as he tries to defend himself and his position. And this is just one example of several examples we have read in 2 Corinthains where Paul is pressing in on them with his words. Trying to convince his readers.
- Now, as my daddy would say, this really brings on more talk, or at least it causes me to pause and ask a question, which is, when do we stop pressing in? When do we know that WE are taking over the situation? That WE are beginning to abandon our dependance on God, and in its place beginning to rely on ourselves?
    - I mean, if we could identify that, wouldn't that be a huge help in life? Sure, it would be. Well, luckily for you I have the answer. The answer as to how you know when you are beginning to take over in a situation and leaving God behind. And by the way, this is a super spiritual answer. Are you ready for it?
    - How do you know when you are taking over and leaving God behind? How do you know when you are saying to God, Lord, just sit back I got this? The answer is you know. How's that for a super spiritual answer? You know!
        - You see, we all know. Knowing is not the problem. The problem is pausing long enough to recognize it. That's the problem. But how do we know? Two words – stress & anxiety. If a situation begins to feel like a burden, full of stress and anxiety, like you are trying to cram a square peg in a round hole, that's when you know it's not of God.
    - But wait a minute. How do you know this is truly the case? I know it because when God's involved it's not burdensome. It's not heavy or stressful or weighty. It just happens naturally. But how do I know that? Well, first of all I use logic (some might say common sense).
        - If God purposes something to happen, logically, it's going to happen. Maybe not the way we want it to, but in the end, it will happen the way He wants it to.
- But that's not my strongest proof. There is another way you can know that what I am saying is true. Study God's Memoirs – His Word.
    - Listen to Jesus' own words in Matt. 11:28-30:

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Matt. 11:25 At that time Jesus said, "I praise You, Father, Lord of heaven and earth, that You have hidden these things from *the* wise and intelligent and have revealed them to infants.
Matt. 11:26 "Yes, Father, for this way was well-pleasing in Your sight.
Matt. 11:27 "All things have been handed over to Me by My Father; and no one knows the Son except the Father; nor does anyone know the Father except the Son, and anyone to whom the Son wills to reveal *Him.*
Matt. 11:28 "Come to Me, all who are weary and heavy-laden, and I will give you rest.
Matt. 11:29 "Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and YOU WILL FIND REST FOR YOUR SOULS.
Matt. 11:30 "For My yoke is easy and My burden is light."

- And there you have it.

Matt. 11:28 "Come to Me, all who are weary and heavy-laden, and I will give you rest.
Matt. 11:29 "Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and YOU WILL FIND REST FOR YOUR SOULS.
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- The picture here is a simple one. With God your burdens will become easy. Not easy in the sense of what you may be going through. That's not what it means. But easy as it relates to PEACE, and PEACE as we know is the opposite of turmoil, stress, and anxiety. This concept isn't hard to understand.
    - It simply means that when the storms of life are raging, when you're right in the middle of it all, you have PEACE. And I don't care what you may be going through, if you have PEACE, you can withstand it. That's the key, and that's the strategic advantage that Paul has available to him.
    - And by extension that's the same advantage available to us today. The only question is, will you harness it? Will you pause and recognize it? Recognize when you are leaving God's provision, and in its place replacing it with your own wants and desires. Will you double down when it's not seemingly going your way? Will you press in hard for what you want, or will you let God handle it?
        - Regardless of what you may or may not think, this mindset, when fully embraced, is what will allow you to win the battle before the battle ever begins. The only question is, will you pause and take time to identify it, or, as I said, will you press in; all in an effort to get what you want?
        - And by the way, just an FYI to you. If God so chooses to allow you to get what you want most of the time, you will discover you should have left it alone. That God only allowed you to have it to teach you something. And that something is generally not going to be a positive experience. It's generally a very painful one, so just let it be.

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- And so, what did we learn today? We learned that God's hand is always with us. That He is totally in control, which gives you and I a strategic advantage, because it takes the 'what ifs' out of life. The 'I should have done this or that' out of life. Which then of course takes the stress and worry out of life!

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- This morning, we are going to pick back up with 2 Corinthians the 11th chapter, where last week our focus section of verses was Chapter 11:7-11. In that section of scripture, we gained a little more insight into Paul's personality, and more specifically his humanity, which was interesting to read about.
    - And so, I would like to bring it back up one more time for context as we move forward into today's teaching. And of course, as I so often do, I want to back up a re-read that section as a segway into today's teaching. So, follow with me if you will, 2 Cor. 11: 7-11, and here's what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 11:7 **Or did I commit a sin in humbling myself so that you might be exalted, because I preached the gospel of God to you without charge?**
2 Cor. 11:8 **I robbed other churches by taking wages *from them* to serve you;**
2 Cor. 11:9 **and when I was present with you and was in need, I was not a burden to anyone; for when the brethren came from Macedonia they fully supplied my need, and in everything I kept myself from being a burden to you, and will continue to do so.**
2 Cor. 11:10 **As the truth of Christ is in me, this boasting of mine will not be stopped in the regions of Achaia.**
2 Cor. 11:11 **Why? Because I do not love you? God knows *I do!***

- Last week as I paraphrased this entire section for you, I didn't want you to forget that Paul was writing 2 Corinthians in an effort to regain his rightful position in the eyes of this church. A church he founded and one that had begun falling to the wayside. Losing their focus.
    - And in its place begun listening to some man who was working overtime trying to discredit Paul's position and his calling in ministry. As I thought about this situation, it reminded me of something that happened to me when I was just 21 years old.
    - Daffney and I were deeply involved in a church here in town, and our Pastor, the man I was saved under, he made a decision to resign and take another church in another part of the state. And so, as all churches do when the Pastor leaves, they formed a search committee and began looking for his replacement.
    - Eventually they found a man, and that man became our new Pastor. Within a few weeks of our new Pastor assuming his new position, he latched on to me (primarily because I had surrendered to the ministry), and I guess he wanted to guide and coach me. Guide and coach me on how 'real ministry' was done,
    - You see, our new Pastor had come from a much larger church where he was an associate pastor, and his goal was for us to become as big as the church he had come from, which, let me say wasn't necessarily a bad thing, at least on the surface. But the problem was his method of getting everyone on board with his vision wasn't the greatest.
        - You see, our old Pastor had done an amazing job, and this new Pastor was filling some pretty big shoes to say the least. And instead of celebrating where the church currently was, and from where it had come, this new pastor decided to throw off on, or downplay, our former Pastor.

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        - He would say things to me like, “Well Greg, you know the old Pastor was at the end of his rope. He had nothing left in the tank, nothing more that he could do and that’s why he left. But I’m here now, and because I know how big churches work, we’re going to take this thing to the next level. A level by the way, that the old Pastor couldn’t take you guys to.”
        - I specifically remember him telling me, the first thing we have to do is go after people with money, because if we don’t have money we can’t grow the church. Which of course totally lines up with scripture, where God says the first you need to do in order to grow the church is go after people with money. Pretty sure that’s not what it says.
        - But anyway, now ironically enough, our old Pastor took a church that had been on a 20-year decline and God used him to lead those people, and eventually they grew to roughly 2800 in Sunday School, which is neither here nor there other than to say, the new Pastor was obviously wrong about our previous Pastor’s ability to take us to the next level.
- My point is, one of the glaring signs of a weak leader is when they throw off on their predecessor. If an individual ever assumes a position replacing someone else, and that man or woman’s ‘go-to move’ is to run their predecessor into the ground, whomever they are leading is in trouble.
    - And why? Because it shows weakness in that person. A strong leader will focus on what he or she can do and not worry about what the other person did or did not do. Many years ago, I hired a consultant to help me in business. A great man, especially in the areas of leadership, and he gave me a quote the other day. A quote that I think is fitting for what I am trying to convey this morning.
    - It's not scriptural per se, but it’s still fitting. He read me a quote by Eleanor Rosevelt. It said, “Great minds discuss ideas; average minds discuss events; small minds discuss people”. And this is a true statement.
    - I say it a little differently though. Small minds discuss people and problems, and great minds discuss solutions.
        - This is what Paul is dealing with in writing to the church at Corinth. Just like the Pastor who tried to downplay my former Pastor, this gentleman is doing the same thing. He is running Paul in the ground. But I wonder why do people do that? Because they are insecure. Because they can’t solve the problem.
        - And so, if you can’t solve it, then why not default to talking about the problem. That’s exactly what small-minded people do, they talk about it and talk about it and talk about it, over and over and over again.
- It’s really simple. Great leaders spend the majority of their time solving problems rather than talking about them. And so, Paul is in a fight for this church, his ministry and his Apostleship, and this gentleman is doing his dead-level best to convince this Corinthian fellowship that he’s really not that special. Talking about his appearance and his speaking ability.
    - And then using that as proof that he is not an Apostle, because you know God would never call an unattractive person into the ministry, especially one that couldn’t speak well. No way. God wouldn’t do that. But that’s exactly what God does, and as we’ve learned, with God everything is reverse of what we think or do.

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- And why is that the case? Because God will never allow any man to receive the credit for the work that He is doing inside His creation. Which is why God Himself chooses who will and who won't carry out and accomplish His will. And this (God's method of choosing) is on full display all throughout the scriptures.
- But regardless of all that, Paul is still in a fight to regain the confidence of this fellowship, and in verses 7-11 of Chapter 11, he (as I stated earlier) shows us his humanity as he begins using hyperbole and sarcasm in his writings. Just listen to verses 10-11 one more time:

2 Cor. 11:10 As the truth of Christ is in me, this boasting of mine will not be stopped in the regions of Achaia.
2 Cor. 11:11 Why? Because I do not love you? God knows *I do!*

- In other words, Paul is saying why do you think that I have done what I have done for you, why? Because I don't love you? Of course not. On the contrary. That's why I do what I do, and I do it for free. As a matter of fact, I even have taken funds from other churches just so I didn't have to burden you, which has allowed me to work for you and to never ask you for anything.
  - This is all pretty sad really when you stop to think about it, but it is what it is, and Paul has to deal with it. And guess what, if he has to deal with stuff like this then so do we. We are not exempt; we are simply an extension of Paul along with all the other great men and women of the Bible.
  - Moving on, let's pick back up with Chapter 11:12-15:

2 Cor. 11:12 But what I am doing I will continue to do, so that I may cut off opportunity from those who desire an opportunity to be regarded just as we are in the matter about which they are boasting.
2 Cor. 11:13 For such men are false apostles, deceitful workers, disguising themselves as apostles of Christ.
2 Cor. 11:14 No wonder, for even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light.
2 Cor. 11:15 Therefore it is not surprising if his servants also disguise themselves as servants of righteousness, whose end will be according to their deeds.

- Hmmm, so speaking of Paul's humanity, how about those words? This is interesting, because up until this point Paul has been fairly cordial and somewhat easy with his words. But not here in verses 12-15. He doesn't hold back. As a matter of fact, I would say he moves in for the kill.
  - Now this set of verses got me to thinking, which sometimes isn't good. It got me to thinking about why now? Why is he just now calling this man out? Why didn't he begin this whole thing by hammering this gentleman? Why didn't he say, "Listen here folks, God called me to Corinth. I established your church. I helped ground it and move it forward. How dare you question me. Have you forgotten who I am?
  - I would say that's probably what most people would have done, wouldn't you? But

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he doesn't, instead, he spends 11 Chapters addressing the issue (and not just this issue), but it's the primary issue for sure. He spends most of the letter addressing this issue, but waits until the end before he crosses over, tips the scales, calling an ace an ace or a spade a spade.

- And so, it just made me wonder why? Why now? Well, first of all, let me say, he's human. I can certainly align with that. And with that thought in mind, let me digress for just a minute. Have you ever had to have a hard conversation with someone, and you knew the person you would be talking to probably wasn't going to receive it very well?
- In those situations what do we usually do? You ease into the water, right? Tippy toe around the issues a little, start out by garnering some synergy on the matter, try to find common ground, or unite on some aspect of the issue at hand. And so, you begin the conversation in a very amicable way, but after a while, when you realize you are getting nowhere, many times you begin to give up, and before you know it, you just decide to call it what it is.

- I feel like that is some of what's happening here. Now, let me also say that is not what the scripture tells us here in 2 Cor. 11. It doesn't say that, so don't walk out of here and go tell someone that Pastor Greg said this or that. This is simply conjecture based on the study of this letter for over a year.
- Having said that, I don't think you can study 2 Corinthians and not arrive at a similar conclusion. I'm pretty sure we would all agree that Paul is very frustrated, even though that's not what it says. It is just me speculating, but I certainly don't think it's a far stretch.

- Now, just for a minute let's examine what he says one more time, because (as I said earlier), he says something in verse 12 that I find interesting, when he says,

2 Cor. 11:12 **But what I am doing I will continue to do, so that I may cut off opportunity from those who desire an opportunity to be regarded just as we are in the matter about which they are boasting.**

- Paraphrasing here, he's saying I am doing what I am doing and will continue to do what I do, so that I may cut off opportunity from those who desire an opportunity to be regarded in the matter about which they are boasting.
  - Now, believe it or not, this isn't just Paul spouting off at the mouth trying to throw shots at this man. There is actually more to it than that, and the substance behind his statement actually applies to all of us sitting here today. And so, what might that be? Well, as always, I am glad you asked.
    - Before explaining what I mean, let me make a statement, a statement that may give you a hint as to what I am about to say. Here's the statement. Apostles were men who were directly appointed by Jesus or God Himself, which means whoever this man was, he was not an Apostle.
    - But how does that apply to those of us sitting here today? Well, it's not just applicable to us, it applies to all Christians. You see, as you and I sit here today, there are men and women who call themselves Apostles. Even in our day and age. There are also churches who say they have Apostolic powers. Powers like

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healing and raising folks from the dead.

- And they say these powers also give them a little something extra when it comes to matters of prayer, but if it's true that Apostles can only be men who were appointed directly by God or Jesus themselves, then Houston we have a problem, because anyone who says they are an Apostle today is obviously lying and must be confused, or maybe worse, they may be a False Prophet.

- Now, I have a question for you. Who was the only Apostle not to be appointed directly by Jesus Himself while he lived on earth? Paul. Remember, Paul was struck down on the road to Damascus and God called him out and blinded him for three days. So, when Paul says:

2 Cor. 11:12 But what I am doing I will continue to do, so that I may cut off opportunity from those who desire an opportunity to be regarded just as we are in the matter about which they are boasting.

- He knows this man is not an Apostle, even though he is boasting about being one, which then leads Paul to say that he will continue doing what he is doing, because what he does proves who he and the others are, which are true disciples of Jesus Christ. Whereas this man, on the other hand, well, he doesn't possess the ability to do what Paul and the others do because he is not a true Apostle.
  - Next, in verse 12, Paul then moves in for the kill, sort of speaking, when he says:

2 Cor. 11:13 For such men are false apostles, deceitful workers, disguising themselves as apostles of Christ.
2 Cor. 11:14 No wonder, for even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light.
2 Cor. 11:15 Therefore it is not surprising if his servants also disguise themselves as servants of righteousness, whose end will be according to their deeds.

- Guys, Paul's words should make you stand up and take notice, because what he did was tell us that this man is indeed a false prophet, which is no surprise. But then he says he was a deceitful worker, disguising himself as an Apostle of Christ. Paul's words are obviously disturbing, because imagine a person infiltrating a church and disguising himself as an Apostle or Godly man. And the church buying into it. That's pretty scary.
  - But what Paul says in verses 14-15 is even scarier, when he says, no wonder, for even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light, and therefore, it's no surprise that his servants also disguise themselves as servants of righteousness, whose end will be according to their deeds.
    - Here's a word for you. If you didn't know it, Satan and his servants disguise themselves as angels of light and servants of righteousness. Which means, right now, today, there are men and women who walk among us, inside our churches, who are involved in ministry, who have disguised themselves and are actively working for the enemy.
    - And because they are in disguise, and not just any disguise (I might add), they

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are disguised as Angels of Light, as Servants of Righteousness. Which means they are really hard to detect, or maybe not. They are for some Christians and maybe not so much for others.

- The question is could you detect them? Do you know how to detect them? Better yet, do you want to know how to detect them? Yes – no – can I buy a vowel? The only way you can detect them is by listening very closely to what they say, and more than that, watching what they do and then lining that back up against the word of God.
- Remember, a hawk and a dove don't lite on the same line, and light and darkness don't inhabit the same space. So, knowing God, which comes by way of knowing His word, is the primary way you can detect this person.
  - But there is another way. You can also detect them through discernment, which, by definition is 'the ability to judge well'. But that's not a given, because even that is based on some level of how educated you are when it comes to the character of God. Which once again comes by way of studying your Bible.

- Now, having said that, I will say, many times women are better equipped on identifying these people. Better than men because they have a keener sense of discernment. Which means men should listen to their wives. But back to the question. How do we know who these spies of the enemy are?
  - As I said, just listen to them, watch them, observe them. Because as good as they are at counterfeiting the work of the Holy Spirit, at the end of the day they will always reveal their true colors. They can't stay true to their disguise forever.
- Next, Paul begins closing out this chapter by showing us a little more of his frustration and humanity through the use of sarcasm one more time. I am going to read this next section, and just lightly touch on it as we close. And next week we will break it apart as we move into Chapter 12. Here's what Paul wrote,

2 Cor. 11:16 Again I say, let no one think me foolish; but if *you do,* receive me even as foolish, so that I also may boast a little.
2 Cor. 11:17 What I am saying, I am not saying as the Lord would, but as in foolishness, in this confidence of boasting.
2 Cor. 11:18 Since many boast according to the flesh, I will boast also.
2 Cor. 11:19 For you, being *so* wise, tolerate the foolish gladly.
2 Cor. 11:20 For you tolerate it if anyone enslaves you, anyone devours you, anyone takes advantage of you, anyone exalts himself, anyone hits you in the face.
2 Cor. 11:21 To *my* shame I *must* say that we have been weak *by comparison.*
But in whatever respect anyone *else* is bold—I speak in foolishness—I am just as bold myself.
2 Cor. 11:22 Are they Hebrews? So am I. Are they Israelites? So am I. Are they descendants of Abraham? So am I.
2 Cor. 11:23 Are they servants of Christ?—I speak as if insane—I more so; in far more labors, in far more imprisonments, beaten times without number, often in danger of death.

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2 Cor. 11:24 **Five times I received from the Jews thirty-nine *lashes.***
2 Cor. 11:25 **Three times I was beaten with rods, once I was stoned, three times I was shipwrecked, a night and a day I have spent in the deep.**
2 Cor. 11:26 ***I have been* on frequent journeys, in dangers from rivers, dangers from robbers, dangers from *my* countrymen, dangers from the Gentiles, dangers in the city, dangers in the wilderness, dangers on the sea, dangers among false brethren;**
2 Cor. 11:27 ***I have been* in labor and hardship, through many sleepless nights, in hunger and thirst, often without food, in cold and exposure.**

- And then his next statement is interesting, where he says this in verse 28:

2 Cor. 11:28 **Apart from *such* external things, there is the daily pressure on me *of* concern for all the churches.**
2 Cor. 11:29 **Who is weak without my being weak? Who is led into sin without my intense concern?**
2 Cor. 11:30 **If I have to boast, I will boast of what pertains to my weakness.**
2 Cor. 11:31 **The God and Father of the Lord Jesus, He who is blessed forever, knows that I am not lying.**
2 Cor. 11:32 **In Damascus the ethnarch (Eth-knock) under Aretas (Aaa-rea-tas) the king was guarding the city of the Damascenes (da'-muh-seen) in order to seize me,**
2 Cor. 11:33 **and I was let down in a basket through a window in the wall and *so* escaped his hands.**

- As I said, we will close with this section, and we will break it down next week. Having said that, I want to encourage everyone to study this section of scripture for yourself and see what you come up with. But before we close today, let me say, if this last section of scripture left us wondering if Paul was frustrated, this section kind of closes the door on doubting that theory, because obviously he is really put out.
    - Notice once again, he uses sarcasm to show his frustration when he says:

2 Cor. 11:16 **Again I say, let no one think me foolish; but if *you do,* receive me even as foolish, so that I also may boast a little.**
2 Cor. 11:17 **What I am saying, I am not saying as the Lord would, but as in foolishness, in this confidence of boasting.**
2 Cor. 11:18 **Since many boast according to the flesh, I will boast also.**
2 Cor. 11:19 **For you, being *so* wise, tolerate the foolish gladly.**

- Essentially, what he is saying is, evidently you guys (speaking of the church at Corinth), evidently you guys respond well to foolishness. You respond well to boasting, especially

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as it relates to things that don't matter. Things of the flesh, which is opposite of things of the Lord.

- So, since that's the case, let me boast a little from my flesh as well. And I love where he goes next. He says, and bear with me I am going to paraphrase and freewheel here for just a minute. He says, far be it from me to compare my resume to this gentleman's. I mean seriously, how could I possibly compare my experiences to what all this man had experienced.
- Please forgive my foolishness for not boasting in my flesh. Meaning, this church obviously valued foolishness over Godliness, especially when it came to proving who Paul was. Paul said forgive me for not doing the same, because obviously what I experienced in the flesh is nothing compared to him. I mean, I was just beaten multiple times. Too many times to name, imprisoned…

2 Cor. 11:24 Five times I received from the Jews thirty-nine *lashes.*
2 Cor. 11:25 Three times I was beaten with rods, once I was stoned, three times I was shipwrecked, a night and a day I have spent in the deep.
2 Cor. 11:26 *I have been* on frequent journeys, in dangers from rivers, dangers from robbers, dangers from *my* countrymen, dangers from the Gentiles, dangers in the city, dangers in the wilderness, dangers on the sea, dangers among false brethren;
2 Cor. 11:27 *I have been* in labor and hardship, through many sleepless nights, in hunger and thirst, often without food, in cold and exposure.

- And so, as I said, we see Paul's humanity on full display here. He was just a man, and as a man he got frustrated with the church. But what's most interesting is when he said, I experienced all these horrific things as a result of my calling as an Apostle of Jesus Christ. And on top of all that, he says in verse 28:

2 Cor. 11:28 Apart from *such* external things, there is the daily pressure on me *of* concern for all the churches.

- Paul was saying, and on top of all that, on top of all that I have endured, I also have to worry (on a daily basis I might add), I also have to worry about all the churches I started that may be led astray.
  - And so, what's the biggest take away from today's lesson? I think there are several, but for me it lies in verses 14-15, where he says:

2 Cor. 11:14 No wonder, for even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light.
2 Cor. 11:15 Therefore it is not surprising if his servants also disguise themselves as servants of righteousness, whose end will be according to their deeds.

- Remember this, folks, everything you hear, everything you're taught, and everything you

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read outside of the Bible itself must be questioned. Questioned and lined back up against the Word of God.

- Because Satan is the great counterfeiter, and he disguises himself and his demons as Angels of Light and Servants of Righteousness, and unless you know God, who He truly is, His character, if you're not careful you can easily be led astray. I'll leave you with a scripture that I think best speaks to what I am trying to say, and it's in 1 John 4:1:

1 John 4:1 Beloved, do not believe every spirit, but test the spirits to see whether they are from God, because many false prophets have gone out into the world.

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- Good morning, guys, and welcome back to our study of Paul's second recorded letter to the Corinthian Church. We are nearing the end of the letter, with just two more chapters to go, and for the last several weeks we have been knee-deep following Paul through his writings.
  - And honestly, watching Paul as he has kind of come to an end (of sorts), an end specifically as it relates to defending his position and authority as an Apostle. Defending himself against this individual, this man, or men at this point, who have made their way into the church and have garnered the attention and respect (evidently) of this fellowship.
  - I say he's at his end because of how his writing has shifted. He's moved from explaining who he is from a place of fact and logic, backed with proof based on his life, to now almost saying if you can't beat them, join them. And to further explain what I mean, let's back up and re-read last week's focus verses for context.
    - Here's what Paul wrote in 2 Cor. 11:16-33. This is a bit lengthy compared to our normal reading, but it's important to read it this way because there is really no break. Just listen to what he wrote:

2 Cor. 11:16 Again I say, let no one think me foolish; but if *you do,* receive me even as foolish, so that I also may boast a little.
2 Cor. 11:17 What I am saying, I am not saying as the Lord would, but as in foolishness, in this confidence of boasting.
2 Cor. 11:18 Since many boast according to the flesh, I will boast also.
2 Cor. 11:19 For you, being *so* wise, tolerate the foolish gladly.
2 Cor. 11:20 For you tolerate it if anyone enslaves you, anyone devours you, anyone takes advantage of you, anyone exalts himself, anyone hits you in the face.
2 Cor. 11:21 To *my* shame I *must* say that we have been weak *by comparison.*
But in whatever respect anyone *else* is bold—I speak in foolishness—I am just as bold myself.
2 Cor. 11:22 Are they Hebrews? So am I. Are they Israelites? So am I. Are they descendants of Abraham? So am I.
2 Cor. 11:23 Are they servants of Christ?—I speak as if insane—I more so; in far more labors, in far more imprisonments, beaten times without number, often in danger of death.
2 Cor. 11:24 Five times I received from the Jews thirty-nine *lashes.*
2 Cor. 11:25 Three times I was beaten with rods, once I was stoned, three times I was shipwrecked, a night and a day I have spent in the deep.
2 Cor. 11:26 *I have been* on frequent journeys, in dangers from rivers, dangers from robbers, dangers from *my* countrymen, dangers from the Gentiles, dangers in the city, dangers in the wilderness, dangers on the sea, dangers among false brethren;
2 Cor. 11:27 *I have been* in labor and hardship, through many sleepless nights, in hunger and thirst, often without food, in cold and exposure.

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- Now, let me pause here for a moment and explain what Paul is saying or what he is writing about here. No doubt he is frustrated, and I am going to go off script for just a minute. He's saying to this church, obviously what you people value has nothing to do with the things of the Spirit.
    - That's what he means when he mentions boasting by the way. Boasting is an act of pride, which is a derivative of the flesh. And so, what he's trying to say is, hey guys, you are listening to this man, or men, but what he, or they are boasting about are things of the flesh, and they have nothing to do with the spirit, and they certainly don't validate this man, or men, as Apostles.
- Now let me say, we don't know everything this man or men have been telling this church, but we do get a little hint or insight into the substance of what they are saying when we back up and re-read Chapter 10:10 and then Chapter 10:17-18. Listen to it one more time:

2 Cor. 10:10 **For they say, "His letters are weighty and strong, but his personal presence is unimpressive and his speech contemptible."**

- Then in verses 17-18 of Chapter 10 he says,

2 Cor. 10:17 **But HE WHO BOASTS IS TO BOAST IN THE LORD.**
2 Cor. 10:18 **For it is not he who commends himself that is approved, but he whom the Lord commends.**

- And then of course, we have what we just read in verse 18, which said:

2 Cor. 10:18 **Since many boast according to the flesh, I will boast also.**

- So, if you study Chapters 10 and 11, you will clearly see that what I am saying is the case. Paul is fighting back, trying desperately to re-gain the confidence of this church. And it's apparent that the thing they (the Church of Corinth) value the most is things of the flesh and not of the spirit.
    - Paul makes a shift in his defense, and says, paraphrasing here, if what you value the most is appearance and someone's speaking ability, things they consider to be their strengths, but are really nothing more than strengths in the flesh. If that's what you value the most, then by all means let's compare notes. Let's compare experiences.
        - And that's what Paul does, but in a very different way. Let me show you what I mean, because I find what Paul does absolutely fascinating (speaking of his approach to boasting in the flesh). And what does he do? Well, he lists most of the hardships he has experienced in ministry, which by all accounts, most people wouldn't consider strengths, but weaknesses.
    - Follow me here for a moment. This man, as previously stated, these men are boasting about things of the flesh and not of the spirit, and so when Paul decides to meet them where they are (to compare his experiences in the flesh with theirs), he

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lists (as I said) his hardships, which would appear to be weaknesses of the flesh and not strengths.

- Kind of odd don't you think? I mean, these men boast in the flesh of their strength, their appearance, their speaking ability, etc. And Paul's way of 'joining in on their boasting' is to compare their strengths to his hardships. Listen to it one more time:

2 Cor. 10:18 **Since many boast according to the flesh, I will boast also.**
2 Cor. 10:19 **For you, being *so* wise, tolerate the foolish gladly.**

- So let me stop here. Real quick, Paul says, the things this man, or men, are using as their defense as Apostles (remember, they are saying they are Apostles as well), so, the things they are using as proof are fleshly things, not Spiritual things. And then in verse 19 he says:

2 Cor. 10:19 **For you, being *so* wise, tolerate the foolish gladly.**

- In other words, you guys are obviously really smart, and yet you tolerate the foolish gladly. And then he says in verses 20-21:

2 Cor. 11:20 **For you tolerate it if anyone enslaves you, anyone devours you, anyone takes advantage of you, anyone exalts himself, anyone hits you in the face.**
2 Cor. 11:21 **To *my* shame I *must* say that we have been weak *by comparison.***
But in whatever respect anyone *else* is bold—I speak in foolishness—I am just as bold myself.

- Paul is saying, you guys tolerate foolishness so much so that you will allow someone to enslave you, devour you, take advantage of you, from those who exalt themselves. As a matter of fact, even if they hit you in the face you will put up with it.
  - Now, we don't know for sure if these men were actually hitting them in the face, and I wouldn't think this would be the case. As a matter of fact, I think after studying it a little more closely I would say a better interpretation would be that this man or men are not hitting them in the face, literally, but rather spiritually speaking. It's a figure of speech.
    - And then from there, he proceeds to drop the hammer where he writes the following in verse 22-27:

2 Cor. 11:22 **Are they Hebrews? So am I. Are they Israelites? So am I. Are they descendants of Abraham? So am I.**
2 Cor. 11:23 **Are they servants of Christ?—I speak as if insane—I more so; in far more labors, in far more imprisonments, beaten times without number, often**

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in danger of death.
2 Cor. 11:24 **Five times I received from the Jews thirty-nine *lashes.***
2 Cor. 11:25 **Three times I was beaten with rods, once I was stoned, three times I was shipwrecked, a night and a day I have spent in the deep.**
2 Cor. 11:26 ***I have been* on frequent journeys, in dangers from rivers, dangers from robbers, dangers from *my* countrymen, dangers from the Gentiles, dangers in the city, dangers in the wilderness, dangers on the sea, dangers among false brethren;**
2 Cor. 11:27 ***I have been* in labor and hardship, through many sleepless nights, in hunger and thirst, often without food, in cold and exposure.**

- So, if it's strength in the flesh you trust and value, (the outward experiences), then how about considering all that I have endured in the flesh. And then his next statement is interesting, where he says this in verse 28:

2 Cor. 11:28 **Apart from *such* external things, there is the daily pressure on me *of* concern for all the churches.**
2 Cor. 11:29 **Who is weak without my being weak? Who is led into sin without my intense concern?**
2 Cor. 11:30 **If I have to boast, I will boast of what pertains to my weakness.**
2 Cor. 11:31 **The God and Father of the Lord Jesus, He who is blessed forever, knows that I am not lying.**
2 Cor. 11:32 **In Damascus the ethnarch (Eth-knock) under Aretas (Aaa-rea-tas) the king was guarding the city of the Damascenes (da'-muh-seen) in order to seize me,**
2 Cor. 11:33 **and I was let down in a basket through a window in the wall and *so* escaped his hands.**

- There is a lot we could study pertaining to verses 32-33, but it's really more of the same. So just know this. Paul is contrasting his experiences in the flesh (his weakness) to that of their strengths, and verses 31-32 are just a continuation of another bad experience that he had, and I think you can see that by the mentioning of being lowered by basket through a window in a wall to escape the 'Eth-knock', which was just a name for a governor of a province or people.
    - So, Paul uses his weakness in the flesh as proof of his Apostleship and compares it to their strength in the flesh. And so, what does that tell us? It tells us that the things that God values in our lives has absolutely zero to do with our strengths in the flesh.
        - Can you speak well? Are you attractive? Are you smart by academic standards? Are you bold or wise in the ways of the world? Are you doing well, financially speaking? Do you have a lot of possessions? Do you have strong opinions?
    - These are the things that the world values, yet God places zero value on them. But if that's the case, then what does God value? Ah, I am glad you asked. How about Humility, Brokenness, Sincerity, Love, Kindness, Long-suffering, Compassion, and

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Selflessness. Put others first and yourself last.

- And just in case we are confused about this, Paul confirms it by giving us a list in Galatians 5:16-25. Let me read it to you:

Gal. 5:16 **But I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not carry out the desire of the flesh.**
Gal. 5:17 **For the flesh sets its desire against the Spirit, and the Spirit against the flesh; for these are in opposition to one another, so that you may not do the things that you please.**
Gal. 5:18 **But if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the Law.**
Gal. 5:19 **Now the deeds of the flesh are evident, which are: immorality, impurity, sensuality,**
Gal. 5:20 **idolatry, sorcery, enmities, strife, jealousy, outbursts of anger, disputes, dissensions, factions,**
Gal. 5:21 **envying, drunkenness, carousing, and things like these, of which I forewarn you, just as I have forewarned you, that those who practice such things will not inherit the kingdom of God.**
Gal. 5:22 **But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness,**
Gal. 5:23 **gentleness, self-control; against such things there is no law.**
Gal. 5:24 **Now those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires.**
Gal. 5:25 **If we live by the Spirit, let us also walk by the Spirit.**
Gal. 5:26 **Let us not become boastful, challenging one another, envying one another.**

- So here is a list. Not an exhaustive list, but a list of some of the characteristics of the flesh verses the spirit. You see, inside every believer lives two entities. One is the flesh and the other the spirit. And these two entities wage war against one another every day of our life, which by the way creates internal conflict.
  - And so, it begs the question, how does one obtain victory over the other? The battle is won through the eyes and ears. Matthew 6:22-23 says this about the eyes:

Matt. 6:22 **“The eye is the lamp of the body; so then, if your eye is clear, your whole body will be full of light.**
Matt. 6:23 **But if your eye is bad, your whole body will be full of darkness. So if the light that is in you is darkness, how great is the darkness!**

- Then Matthew 13:15 says:

Matt. 6:15 **FOR THE HEART OF THIS PEOPLE HAS BECOME DULL,**

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WITH THEIR EARS THEY SCARCELY HEAR,
AND THEY HAVE CLOSED THEIR EYES,
OTHERWISE THEY WOULD SEE WITH THEIR EYES,
HEAR WITH THEIR EARS,
AND UNDERSTAND WITH THEIR HEART AND RETURN,
AND I WOULD HEAL THEM.'

- This concept of the eyes and ears is an important one, because the eyes and ears are the portals to the soul. They provide connectivity to the flesh and spirit, which is what fights the spiritual battle inside every believer. The "Flesh verses the Spirit".
    - And what you consistently see and hear either feeds the flesh or the spirit. Remember this, no matter what you may be struggling with in your life, whatever it is, if you want to obtain victory over it then delve into God's Word. Study alongside an elder or pastor teacher or a Bible teacher. Learn how to study, and when you do that, you will have done what Paul said to do in verse 16, which was to walk by Spirit.
    - And then, Paul says if we do that, we will not carry out the desires of the flesh.
- But that leads to another question, which is, how much study is enough? How much time must I spend in study, in prayer, in church (around God's people), if my desire is for the Spirit to become the predominate influence in my life?
    - It depends. It's a percentages game. Meaning, it depends on what percentage of your life is controlled by your flesh verses your spirit. Is your flesh controlling 90% of your life? Then you had better lock in for a long winter nap, because it will require you to spend the majority of your free time, and part of your not-so-free time in study, and prayer, and in church.
    - Which is why people who find themselves overwhelmed by the flesh, with sins they cannot get under control, that is why they usually need time away, with a complete focus on the 'Things of God'. But how much time? A long time. Short stints won't work, because as soon as this person gets a little traction spiritually speaking, the enemy swoops in, generally through their environment, and sucks them back in. Which makes it nearly impossible for them to break free.
        - My sister was a prime example of this. At one point early on in her life she was all caught up in the drug world. And many times, I would try and help her break free from that lifestyle, but ultimately, she would end up right back with the same crowd. We all knew where she was going to end up if something didn't change.
        - And sure enough, eventually she was arrested and sentenced to 60 months in a federal prison. When she was being sentenced in federal court, I remember the judging saying to her, "I am going to do something that I hope saves your life. I am going to give you 60 months in a federal correction facility.
        - By the way, if you've ever wondered what a federal correction facility is, it's a prison. We just changed the name to make it more palatable. But I assure you the people serving a sentence wouldn't say the name change made it better. But anyway, that's what the judge said.

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- And I remember thinking, how is that going to help her? That's not going to do anything but make her worse. And I was wrong. You see, it took her going to prison and being pulled out of her environment, to break her habits and change the trajectory of her life. But honestly, it took more than that.
  - You see, while she was in there a church ministered to her and she was saved. And with nowhere to go, she began focusing day in and day out on the things of God. That was the key. Can you imagine being incarcerated, and you have no responsibility to speak of and so you just begin studying your Bible.
  - Personally, I think it sounds pretty awesome. No responsibility, just do what your told, mind your business, and spend the majority of your day with God. I know that sounds crazy, but can you imagine what kind of spiritual transformation would take place in your life? This might be an idea for a new business.
  - We create a retreat, and not just for people with drug or alcohol problems, but for everyday folks. Where you could go and stay for a few months and all you do every day is spend time in prayer and the study of God's Word.
- Have you heard of Emmaus Walk? That's exactly what they do. It's a three-day spiritual cleanse of sorts, and everyone who I have known that has attended came out transformed. Anyway, just a thought. And so, back to the story of my sister.
  - After roughly 50 months of being incarcerated and feeding her spirit constantly day in and day out, God became the predominate force in her life. And it was then and only then that she was ready to enter back into society and face the world. And today I am proud to say not only is she a productive member of society, but she is also a director at the Blue Monarch, an organization that helps women who are in the same place that she was.
  - So many years ago, you see, she broke free. But it took a break from her environment. And more than that, it took replacing the things of the flesh with the things of God for her to begin being led by the Spirit.

- Now having said that, I want to be careful with this statement because there is a spiritual law in place. A law that applies to all of us, especially when it comes to working towards allowing the Spirit to take hold of your life. And that is, once you feed the spirit, and it begins suppressing your flesh, you cannot quit feeding it. Not if you expect to maintain whatever spiritual level you have obtained.
  - Spiritual growth is not like the game show 'Who wants to be a Millionaire'. You know, where once you obtain a certain level (spiritual level) in your life, that somehow, you're locked in from that point forward. That's not how it works. On the contrary. You must work on it every day and it never goes away, and the minute you neglect your time with God you begin to regress.
- Now, before moving on this morning, let me say something about this passage in Galatians. I want you to notice that you personally do have a say in whether you are being led by the spirit or the flesh. Look at the words Paul uses in verse 16:
  - "But I say, walk by the Spirit." Notice it's a command. A command for you to do something. And if you do, Paul says you will not carry out the desire of the flesh.
  - Having said that, let me say something about those who struggle mightily with certain sins in their life, verses, say, others who do not. We all struggle mightily with

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sin. The difference between them and us is that their sin is out of control, at least as the world sees it. Another way to say it is, their sin is dominating their life in such a way that the authorities have to get involved.

- But our sin is no different, it's just ours is less seen, a little more under control (maybe). But it is still there and it's still an issue. A good friend of mine used to have a saying. He would say, "don't judge me because I sin differently than you do". And the reason I bring this up, is just because someone struggles with a certain sin, such as drugs or alcohol, doesn't mean they need to spend more time with God than you do.
- The sin in your life may be just as dominant as someone who is struggling with substance abuse. The difference is, your sin may not get you arrested, or maybe you are doing a great job at keeping it hidden, or out of sight of society. And so, let's not be fooled by the enemy into thinking we don't have a problem.

- Because we do, and we, too, need to prioritize our time with the Lord. That's if we want to see the Spirit that lives inside of us take precedent over our flesh. Because remember, there is no such thing as a sin that isn't an issue. It's all a problem.
- As a matter of fact, for those of us who are able to manage our sin a little bit better than others, we are (in many respects) in graver danger of a fall than say, those who are incarcerated. And why? Because we think we are okay. We subconsciously think to ourselves, yeah, our sin is a problem, but not that big of an issue.
  - And the result of that type of thinking leads us to spend less time with God because we don't necessarily think we need it, because, you know, we aren't as bad as "those people".
  - If you want to improve every aspect of your life, the formula is the same. Spend time with the Lord in the study of His Word. Spend time in prayer with Him. Commune with Him and spend time with your brothers and sisters, God's people. The Church.

- Moving on, I am going to close this morning by seg-waying us into Chapter 12, and as always, I would like you to study these verses for yourself this week. And here is what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 12:1 Boasting is necessary, though it is not beneficial; but I will go on to visions and revelations of the Lord.
2 Cor. 12:2 I know a man in Christ, who fourteen years ago—whether in the body I do not know, or out of the body I do not know, God knows—such a man was caught up to the third heaven.
2 Cor. 12:3 And I know how such a man—whether in the body or apart from the body I do not know, God knows—
2 Cor. 12:4 was caught up into Paradise and heard inexpressible words, which a man is not permitted to speak.
2 Cor. 12:5 In behalf of such a man I will boast; but in my own behalf I will not boast, except regarding *my* weaknesses.
2 Cor. 12:6 For if I do wish to boast I will not be foolish, for I will be speaking the truth; but I refrain *from this,* so that no one will credit me with more than he

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sees *in* me or hears from me.

- If you have been with us from the beginning of 2 Corinthians, you heard me say that theologians have debated throughout the years over the construction of 2 Corinthians. Many have said it is a tough letter to teach. Others have said they believe the letter was pieced together from the other two letters that Paul wrote to the Corinthians. Letters that we do not have recorded in the Cannon of Scripture.
    - 2 Corinthians has been called an 'amalgam' (amal-gum), which is just a mixture or blend of letters. As we move into Chapter 12, you can kind of see what they are talking about. Paul is still on the same topic of boasting, at least in the first verse, but then he makes a shift in verse 2, to a story about a man who some 14 years earlier, whether in the body I do not know, or out of the body I do not know, God knows, such a man was caught up to the third heaven.
    - And then he says,

2 Cor. 12:3 **And I know how such a man—whether in the body or apart from the body I do not know, God knows—**
2 Cor. 12:4 **was caught up into Paradise and heard inexpressible words, which a man is not permitted to speak.**
2 Cor. 12:5 **In behalf of such a man I will boast; but in my own behalf I will not boast, except regarding *my* weaknesses.**
2 Cor. 12:6 **For if I do wish to boast I will not be foolish, for I will be speaking the truth; but I refrain *from this,* so that no one will credit me with more than he sees *in* me or hears from me.**

- So, what's this all about? In Chapter 11 Paul was talking about boasting. Their boasting verses his boasting, and he boasts as a counterbalance to these troublemakers in the church. And now, he is speaking about some man. And apparently, he may have been in the body or out of the body. But Paul says, "I don't know. But God knows".
    - And then he says, I know such a man and he was caught up into Paradise and he heard inexpressible words, words that a man in not permitted to speak. He says, on behalf of such a man I will boast; but on my own behalf I will not boast, except regarding my weakness.

2 Cor. 12:6 **For if I do wish to boast I will not be foolish, for I will be speaking the truth; but I refrain *from this,* so that no one will credit me with more than he sees *in* me or hears from me.**

- So, what's this all about? Who is this man? What is third heaven? And what is the place called Paradise? Do you know what he is talking about? And if you don't, can you figure it out on your own?
    - I want to encourage you to really study this week and see if you can answer these questions before we return next week, because it's some interesting stuff.

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- Okay guys, welcome back. It's good to see everyone this morning. Before we begin, I just want to let each and every one of you to know that you guys are a blessing to Daffney and myself, and I really appreciate you guys allowing me the opportunity to teach you the Bible.
    - It's truly been both a blessing and an honor over these past 10 years, and every Sunday we both look forward to seeing all of you. So, thank you for being a part of this fellowship.
- Now, with all that said, as everyone knows we are in 2 Corinthians the 12th Chapter, and when we last left off, I left you with some homework to do. I wanted everyone to read and study 2 Cor. 12:1-6; a section of scripture that my NASB translation entitles 'Paul's Vision'.
    - You may remember from last week's teaching how we highlighted the fact that Paul made an abrupt shift in his writing. Where? In Chapter 11. He was addressing some men inside the church who were working diligently to downplay Paul's authority. Specifically, his position and authority as an Apostle of Jesus Christ.
    - This one man or men, who were at this point telling the Church at Corinth not to listen to Paul, that they, too, were Apostles and that Paul had no more authority than they did. They went as far as to cut Paul down when they said in 2 Cor. 10:10-11:

2 Cor. 10:10 For they say, "His letters are weighty and strong, but his personal presence is unimpressive and his speech contemptible."
2 Cor. 10:11 Let such a person consider this, that what we are in word by letters when absent, such persons *we are* also in deed when present.

- In other words, they were saying in layman's terms (these men were saying to the church), Come on guys, seriously, look at Paul. Paraphrasing here, do you really think God would pick this man to be an Apostle? After hearing those words, Paul compared what they said to that of boasting in the flesh, and his response to that was,
    - "You people (speaking of the church), you people value things that have no spiritual value, things you can see, things in the flesh, and so if that's the way it's going to be, well then, if I can't beat 'em, I guess I'll join em, so let me boast a little in the flesh".
        - And from there, Paul went on a rant of sorts, explaining in Chapter 11:22-27, how, as an Apostle he had experienced horrific abuse as an Apostle of Jesus Christ. It was as if Paul was saying, since we are boasting in the flesh, then let's compare notes.
        - I have they been imprisoned. I have received from the Jews 39 lashes five times. I have been beaten with rods. I have (they have) put ourselves in danger in various ways.
        - Experienced extreme labor and hardships, sleeplessness, hunger, extreme thirst, no food, exposed to the cold. And with that trip down memory lane, I would say if Paul was trying to prove a point, he pretty much trumped anything they were boasting about, at least as it related to their sacrifice for Jesus Christ.
    - And then, as we moved into Chapter 12, Paul continued with the same theme, but

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he shifted the topic. He somewhat abruptly shifted his tactic, further proving his point at the end of verse 1 into verse 2, and this is what we read:

2 Cor. 12:1 Boasting is necessary, though it is not beneficial; but I will go on to visions and revelations of the Lord.
2 Cor. 12:2 I know a man in Christ, who fourteen years ago—whether in the body I do not know, or out of the body I do not know, God knows—such a man was caught up to the third heaven.
2 Cor. 12:3 And I know how such a man—whether in the body or apart from the body I do not know, God knows—
2 Cor. 12:4 was caught up into Paradise and heard inexpressible words, which a man is not permitted to speak.
2 Cor. 12:5 In behalf of such a man I will boast; but in my own behalf I will not boast, except regarding *my* weaknesses.
2 Cor. 12:6 For if I do wish to boast I will not be foolish, for I will be speaking the truth; but I refrain *from this,* so that no one will credit me with more than he sees *in* me or hears from me.

- Now, I left you with some homework to do last week. I wanted you to study for yourself and see if you could identify who this man was; this man that Paul references in verse 2. I also wanted to see if you could identify what this 'third heaven' business was all about, along with the reference to Paradise. And then, how does all of it tie back to the topic of boasting.
    - So let me dig in a little bit and see if my explanation of this person and these places lines up with what you studied. Beginning with the man. Paul said, one more time:

2 Cor. 12:2 I know a man in Christ, who fourteen years ago—whether in the body I do not know, or out of the body I do not know, God knows—such a man was caught up to the third heaven.
2 Cor. 12:3 And I know how such a man—whether in the body or apart from the body I do not know, God knows—
2 Cor. 12:4 was caught up into Paradise and heard inexpressible words, which a man is not permitted to speak.

- Last week I told you how important it is that you read and re-read the text over and over again. And let me say, that statement gives you just a little preview. An intro into what I am going to be teaching you this coming Wednesday night when we begin our class, "How to study your Bible in a way that you are preparing to teach someone else what you've learned.
    - Which, just an FYI to you, is the way you should study scripture. The Bible was never to be read like you read a novel. We are to marinate in it, absorb it, and to do that in the most effective way with the greatest possible maximum impact.

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- So, Paul is speaking of a man he knows in Christ, who 14 years earlier, he says, “Whether in the body I do not know, or out of the body I do not know, God knows such a man was caught up to the third heaven.
    - So, who is this man? Well, before I give you the answer, which I am sure you have already discovered on your own, especially if you have access to this new thing called the ‘inter web’, which is turning out to be a pretty big deal in case you didn’t know. So, if you looked up the answer it would be really easy to figure out.
    - Especially if you read a commentary on the topic by a Bible teacher, it would be fairly easy to decipher who this mystery-man is. But before revealing his identity, what I want to know is, would it be possible to figure out the answer without the use of commentaries or the internet? Would it be possible to figure out who this man might be strictly using your Bible?
        - The answer is yes, if you stay in context and if you were to cross-reference some of Paul’s words in other parts of the Bible, or say, maybe study the Greek maybe? You could figure it out. For grins and giggles, let me show you how to figure it out. First of all, as I said, you must start by asking yourself the question, what is the context of the teaching?
        - Context is always the key. So, what is the context? Paul has been writing about this man or men who have infiltrated the Corinthian Church. Men who have (among other things) been boasting about their accomplishments to the people of the Church of Corinth. Comparing their ‘accomplishments’ in the flesh to those of Paul’s and using those accomplishments in the flesh as proof of their Apostleship and authority.
    - And so, Paul joins in and compares his hardships and sacrifice for Christ to their superficial works as a counterpoint to their point. And he continues this same theme into Chapter 12:1, where he then makes a shift (not in topic but in tactic) here in verses 2-4.
    - But then, after he shifts tactics for a few verses, he then returns in verses 5&6 and picks back up and returns to writing about boasting again. And so, what this tells us is that even though it appears Paul may be shifting topics, in reality he is not. He is shifting his tactics. Meaning, where he began by speaking about boasting in the flesh. About the things men could see outwardly. He now says in verse 1, that:

2 Cor. 12:1 **Boasting is necessary, though it is not beneficial; but I will go on to visions and revelations of the Lord.**

- In other words, I must boast in the flesh because you guys are boasting in the flesh. Because apparently, all their boasting has made an impact on this church’s trust factor. But then Paul says, “I will boast but it isn’t beneficial because it has zero spiritual value. So let me take it up a notch, and to do that, let me begin by talking about visions and revelations of the Lord”.
    - Now remember, Paul has been writing delivering counterpoints (if you will) to everything these men have been saying. Therefore, it would be safe to assume that they have been possibly citing some type of paranormal experiences they have been having. Which is why Paul shifts to talking about visions and revelations.

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        - Just a side note, these visions and revelation experiences are not new to Paul. He has a total of six of these experiences throughout the scriptures. Just so you know. Anyway, Paul shifts tactics and begins speaking about visions and revelations, and his mention of these experiences gives you a hint into who this man is, and into what this 'third heaven' business is all about.
        - And so, what we know is this; Paul is still putting forth his defense, but as I said, he changes his tactics, and we know this is a shift because he returns to talking about boasting once again in verses 5&6, which clearly tells us he has not left his original topic, but in fact he has stayed right in line with the original topic for the exact same purposes of establishing his credibility as an Apostle.
    - So, with all that said, if Paul is still making an effort to establish his credibility, but has simply changed his tactics, then who might this man be? It is himself. The only difference is he has shifted to referencing himself in the third person, which, let me say, wasn't unusual in Rabbinical writings. And Paul was a Rabbi.
    - So, this man that he knew 14 years earlier was himself, and the hint we get comes at the end of verse 1, when he says:

2 Cor. 12:1 **Boasting is necessary, though it is not beneficial; but I will go on to visions and revelations of the Lord.**

- In other words, all this boasting is getting us nowhere, so let me make a shift. Let me take it to the next level. Let me show you I am by recounting an experience I had where I was called up to the "Third Heaven". And he says:

2 Cor. 12:2 **I know a man in Christ, who fourteen years ago—whether in the body I do not know, or out of the body I do not know, God knows—such a man was caught up to the third heaven**

- What he is saying is, I don't know if I was called up into the third heaven physically, or if it was a vision while I remained on earth. But God knows. So, what is this 'third heaven' place? Well, to begin answering that question, the first question that pops into my mind is, is there a First Heaven?
    - Or, maybe even better than that, is there a Second Heaven? Anyone know? Yes, there is. The first heaven in scripture refers to the atmosphere where the birds fly, where the clouds and sky reside. And if that's the case (which it is), then where is the second heaven?
    - It's outer space, where the moon, the sun, and the stars reside. And if that's the case, then where might the third heaven be? It's the place where God dwells. The Heavens. Third Heaven is the place we refer to as Heaven. But there is another place mentioned in verse 4, a place called Paradise:

2 Cor. 12:4 **was caught up into Paradise and heard inexpressible words, which a man is not permitted to speak.**

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- So, paradise, where is that? Is it some other place? No, it's a synonym for Third Heaven or just plain Heaven as we know it. But how do I know all of this? Well, when you study the Greek and Hebrew you see Heaven mentioned many times. As a matter of fact, its mentioned over 700 times throughout the Bible, but as we have just learned, when the scriptures speak of Heaven, it is not always heaven as we think of Heaven.
    - Just listen to Isaiah 55:8-10, where Isaiah says the following:

Isaiah 55:8 **"For My thoughts are not your thoughts,**
Nor are your ways My ways," declares the LORD.
Isaiah 55:9 **"For *as* the heavens are higher than the earth,**
So are My ways higher than your ways
And My thoughts than your thoughts.
Isaiah 55:10 **"For as the rain and the snow come down from heaven,**
And do not return there without watering the earth
And making it produce and sprout,
And providing seed to the sower and bread to the eater;

- Obviously, Isaiah isn't speaking about the Heaven we've all been taught about. This heaven relates to the atmosphere. Then, in Psalm 19:1-6, David wrote this about the second Heaven – the universe:

Psalm 19:1 The heavens tell of the glory of God;
And their expanse declares the work of His hands

- This is an obvious reference to the universe (outer space). Now, in neither of these verses do we hear about the heavens being called the first heaven or the second heaven. But it's inferred because their descriptions are totally different, and when you read where Paul mentions the Third Heaven, you can assume there is a 1st & 2nd Heaven, which is an obvious reference to the Heaven that we all think of. The place where God dwells.
    - So, now that we have established that Paul is referring to himself, just in the third person, this should also give us insight into why Paul has shifted his tactic by recounting his interaction with God. He is fighting fire with fire. It's a crescendo of sorts, as further proof of who he was in comparison to who they were.
    - And one more thing. When you back up and re-read this dissertation, all the way back into Chapter 11, remember the Bible was not originally put together with verse and chapter breaks. Translators put those in, but they didn't appear until somewhere around the 14th & 15th centuries.
        - And so, if you know that, then you would know that this section of scripture here in Chapter 11 and 12 are continuous run-on sentences. Which also tells us that Paul didn't just go off script and he wasn't crazy.
        - He was still in the mode of trying to prove a point, and if you hold tight with the context and remember the point he is trying to prove, which was that he was a true Apostle and that these men were not, that they were in fact false teachers, and proof of that lies in their boasting in 'fleshly things', such as their

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appearance and their speaking ability – their defense (if you will).

- Their boasting in the flesh actually works against them. When you put all this together it will speak to you, give you insight into how the person he is talking about, the man he knew 14 years earlier, was none other than himself.

- But why does he shift to speaking in the third person? One word – humility. Because he doesn't want to boast. He doesn't want to receive credit for what happened to him and for what he saw when he was in Heaven. And how do I know that?
- I know it because that's actually what he says in verses 5 and 6. Listen to it one more time:

2 Cor. 12:5 **In behalf of such a man I will boast; but in my own behalf I will not boast, except regarding *my* weaknesses.**
2 Cor. 12:6 **For if I do wish to boast I will not be foolish, for I will be speaking the truth; but I refrain *from this,* so that no one will credit me with more than he sees *in* me or hears from me.**

In other words, he is trying to prove his point by referencing someone he knows who was called up into third heaven, which allows him to shift from talking himself, about me, me, me, to that of speaking about someone else whose experience will serve as proof of his Apostleship.

And for that reason, he references this man's spiritual experience of being called up to Third Heaven as a backup to who he is, as proof through someone else's experiences. And I will tell you that if Paul did decide to boast about his visions and revelations, he could become quite a celebrity. But he doesn't.

All because God does not honor men when they elevate themselves in the eyes of other men. Humility is the key here folks. Any time we brag or elevate ourselves, God is not in it. Which means there can only be 1 'King of the Hill' in the life of a believer, and it can never be the believer.

And I want to talk about this for just a minute because it's so important. Any time we increase in the eyes of men (in any form), the flesh increases in our lives and the spirit decreases. And I believe that God, through The Spirit, lets us know internally when we are doing that, when we are elevating ourselves.

Here's an example. Have you ever told somebody something, something you were proud of, maybe it was about a promotion or a raise, or something you bought, a house, land, vehicles, some type of possession, and then immediately you feel bad about it? What you are feeling is conviction. Conviction about elevating yourself.

This is why Paul is speaking in the third person. He is trying not to brag on himself, while at the same time defending his position.

So, the question is, how can we do this? How can we, when we are attacked or talked about, how can we defend ourselves without elevating ourselves, because our natural instinct when someone attacks us is to fight back, because an attack automatically excites our flesh,

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causes us to get angry, to lash out, and to immediately counter someone's point with our own point.

And we most often do that by highlighting everything we have done or accomplished in the flesh. Things that we think disproves what that person or persons is saying. The question is, is that what we should do? The answer is NO. But how do I know that?

Well, once again I know it because I know what the Bible tells me pertaining to this topic, along with what I see displayed in the life of Paul (among others). In other words, I know it because the overarching theme of scripture tells me that God is to be the center of our world. Not ourselves. And that in everything we do, our lives should point people back toward God. Not towards ourselves.

This is why Paul doesn't say, well guys I didn't want to have to do this, but I was called up into the Third Heaven, and I have personally interacted with God. I heard inexpressible words that no other Apostle has heard. And oh, by the way, you want to know what God told me.

Notice he doesn't tell them what God told them. Paul is so cognitive and aware of his position before God that he dares not try and elevate himself. But at the same time, he is trying to defend himself, which turns out to be a difficult position to be in. He must be humble, be direct, be truthful, but never have this church look at him as the man.

Hmmm, and this is all highlighted by what he says at the end of this section and on into the next section. And this is where we will close this morning, which by the way, leads into a very famous verse of scripture, one that theologians have debated throughout the centuries. They are still debating it today.

Let's read the end of this section and then move into the next section. One more time, follow with me verses 5&6:

5 In behalf of such a man I will boast; but in my own behalf I will not boast,
except regarding *my* weaknesses.

6 For if I do wish to boast I will not be foolish, for I will be speaking the truth; but I
refrain *from this,* so that no one will credit me with more than he sees *in* me or hears from
me.

Real quick, notice what Paul says. He will not boast except about his weakness, which is not boasting in the eyes of men. When we boast in the eyes of men, we don't boast about our weakness. We boast in our strengths. So, Paul's boasting isn't really boasting at all.

And then he says, I won't boast because I do not want anyone to credit me with more than he sees in me or hears from me. Paraphrasing here, I want my life to do the boasting about who I am.

What a powerful commentary for all of us sitting here today. Our life should be our witness. And just so you know, our life is what speaks the loudest to the world around us, not our accomplishments here on earth, rather it's the display of the Fruits of the Spirit that speak the loudest, with humility being top of the list.

And so, with all that said, let's close, which is where we will find this famous verse that has been so highly debated.

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Verses 7-10

A Thorn in the Flesh

7 Because of the extraordinary *greatness* of the revelations, for this reason, to keep me from exalting myself, there was given to me a thorn in the flesh, a messenger of
Satan to torment me—to keep me from exalting myself!

8 Concerning this I pleaded with the Lord three times that it might leave me.

9 And He has said to me, “My grace is sufficient for you, for power is perfected in weakness.”
Most gladly, therefore, I will rather boast about my weaknesses, so that the power of
Christ may dwell in me.

10 Therefore I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in distresses, in persecutions, in difficulties, in behalf of Christ; for when I am weak, then I am strong.

What a mouthful. So, Paul says, “so that I may stay humble”. God gave me a thorn in the flesh, a reminder, something that will ground me so that when I begin thinking highly of myself, I will reflect back and float back down to earth. And whatever it is (this thorn in the flesh), God placed it there through a messenger of Satan (wow), and it torments Paul, preventing him from elevating himself, or as I said, keeps him from thinking too highly of himself.

So, how about them apples, folks. God sent a messenger of Satan to torment Paul, all so that he wouldn’t become prideful and lose sight of his position before God.

What I want you to do this week is the same thing you did last week. Take these verses and go study them for yourself. And as you leave today let me give you a little insight into one of the focuses of next week’s lesson. God gave Paul a thorn in the flesh to keep him humble, and He does the same thing to us. So, how might that be?

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- Good morning and welcome back to our study of 2 Corinthians. We are in the 12th Chapter and getting close to the end of this letter.
    - Last week we spent most of our time in Chapter 12:1-6, where I highlighted a shift in Paul's approach to addressing the Church in Corinth. I noted specifically how this shift wasn't a shift in topic, but rather a shift in tactic. His tactic to convince the Church at Corinth that he was who he claimed to be, which was an Apostle of Jesus Christ.
    - A man called by God to establish and set up churches in places like Asia minor and other places. And with all that said, what we know is the Church at Corinth has lost its way and has begun listening to some man, or men who have made their way into the church and somehow established trust within this fellowship.
        - And what we've also learned is that these men have begun undermining everything Paul had established and taught them some six years prior (when he founded the church). And so, Paul is battling the nay sayers in this church, the ones who have sided with this man, or men, and his weapon of defense in fighting this battle comes by way of writing a letter, where he slowly and methodically addresses each and every thing that this faction or group is saying about him.
    - Things like how unimpressive Paul's appearance was. Highlighting the fact that he didn't speak very well. They also evidently went as far as hyping themselves up by possibly talking about how they had had some kind of paranormal experiences. Some kind of supernatural interaction with God.
        - And of course, they used all of these examples as proof of how they too were Apostles, which is what led Paul to shift tactics in verses 1-7, and this is what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 12:1 **Boasting is necessary, though it is not beneficial; but I will go on to visions and revelations of the Lord.**
2 Cor. 12:12 **I know a man in Christ, who fourteen years ago—whether in the body I do not know, or out of the body I do not know, God knows—such a man was caught up to the third heaven.**
2 Cor. 12:13 **And I know how such a man—whether in the body or apart from the body I do not know, God knows—**
2 Cor. 12:14 **was caught up into Paradise and heard inexpressible words, which a man is not permitted to speak.**
2 Cor. 12:15 **In behalf of such a man I will boast; but in my own behalf I will not boast, except regarding *my* weaknesses.**
2 Cor. 12:16 **For if I do wish to boast I will not be foolish, for I will be speaking the truth; but I refrain *from this,* so that no one will credit me with more than he sees *in* me or hears from me.**

- Last week we unveiled and unpacked a few things about this section of verses. First, we identified who this person was that Paul knew some 14 years earlier, and it turned out to be none other than Paul himself. He simply shifted from speaking in the first person to

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speaking in the third person.

- And as I taught you last week, this was not an uncommon thing to do in Rabbinical writings. And as we know, Paul was a Rabbi. But the question was why? Why did he do this? And the answer was he did it for one reason and one reason alone – boasting. He didn't want to boast about his personal interaction or experiences with God.
  - Another way to say it is, he didn't want to be the center of attention, which, let me say, I do find somewhat fascinating, especially in light of what we've all been taught, or told throughout our life in the church of the 20th and 21st Century, which is the world that many of us have grown up in.
- If you grew up in church in the past 50 years and you attended an evangelical church, meaning if you grew up in a church that was evangelistically or outreach driven, you were probably told, or maybe you weren't told, maybe you assumed or mimicked or recited or copied or simply thought to yourself that the use of your personal testimony was a means of leading people to Christ.
  - Regardless of what you thought or were told, that's not the case. And we know this because when I study Paul's manuscripts, I don't see him doing that. Nor do I see any of the other Apostles or disciples doing it either. As a matter of fact, I see a concerted effort to do the opposite of that.

- Personal testimony is not a prescribed method of leading someone to faith in the scripture. The church invented it. Not intentionally, but it evolved into that over time, and it makes sense on the surface. God saved me, my life got better. A load was lifted off my shoulders, therefore, let me tell you about "my Jesus".
  - And I get it. This makes sense because it's a natural progression to share our experience when trying to lead someone to Christ or convince someone to change their mind over a particular spiritual matter. But that begs the question, if Paul and the others didn't use their personal testimony to lead people to Christ, then how did they do it?
  - Now before answering that, I want to ask you a question, and I want you to be honest with yourself. Have you ever personally stopped and asked yourself that question? Have you ever thought or said to yourself, is the use of personal testimony the method used for leading someone to salvation in the scriptures?
    - If you were like me, the answer would probably be no. Regardless of whether you have or have not asked yourself that question, it seems to me that it would be a pretty important question to ask yourself. Wouldn't you?
    - I mean seriously. When you were saved, if you were told your next step in your walk of faith was to lead others to Christ, wouldn't you want to see how it's done by the first people to have ever done it? I would.
    - But here's the reality. I was saved in 1988-1989, and I personally never thought to ask that question until roughly, some 10-12 years later, when I began studying my Bible. It was during my studies that I noticed that Paul, nor anyone else for that matter, used (as a method) their personal testimony to lead someone to Christ. They didn't even use it as an icebreaker or conversational piece.
- Let me say something before moving forward on this topic. If this bothers you, then just

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know if you hang around here long enough it gets a lot worse, because over this past 17 years I have studied a lot of scripture and I have unpacked and ultimately questioned just about every topic you could imagine.

- And for the most part, what I've discovered is that a large majority of what we have been taught is incorrect or has been skewed or bent to fit a narrative. So much so that it is no longer identifiable in God's Word. Meaning, it doesn't exist inside God's Word. And if you attend our Wednesday night study on how to study your Bible, then you will see real life examples of what I am talking about.
- And so, misquoting scripture or taking it out of context has become a real issue. It's rampant, and after a period of time those misquotes take on a life of their own. To the point that they somehow become fixed, or 'the way it is'.
- And so, my journey of questioning everything began over 20 years ago, and once I questioned one thing and discovered it to be wrong, well then, I questioned everything (which got me in trouble with church leadership).

- So how about this whole personal testimony thing as a means of reaching someone for Christ. Is it okay to use our personal testimony as a method of leading someone to Christ, or is it wrong? Or, how about a better question. Does it really matter? I mean, does everything we do as Christians necessarily have to follow or mimic exactly what the disciples or Apostles did in the scriptures?
  - The answer is yes and no. How's that for an answer? Sounds like an attorney, doesn't it? But it's true. The answer is yes and no. Let me explain what I mean. Do I think it is wrong to share your personal testimony with someone in an effort to lead them to the cross? No, of course not.
  - But that's not the question we should be asking. The question we should be asking is, does that method actually work or produce a result? The answer is no, and how do I know that? Well, I know it because I have studied Soteriology, which is the study and process of salvation; how someone is saved.
    - And when you study Soteriology, you will learn about the *interworking* of the salvation process. Specifically, how the true God brings about salvation in someone's life. This is so important, because when you understand exactly how Salvation works, you will understand why your personal testimony isn't necessary in the process.
    - Having said that, I don't think God will be mad if we share our testimony. And I don't think it's bad to use it as an ice breaker or a conversational piece. But if we use it as a sales tool or use it to try and talk someone into salvation, then 'Houston, we have a problem'.
  - But why? Because, generally speaking, when we give our testimony, we almost always say things like, well, here is what my life looked like without God, and now here's what my life looks like with God. Look at my life, it's so much better.
    - This tends to give people a false view or sense of salvation, because the truth is, your life may get worse from a worldly sense once you accept God's free gift of salvation. It will automatically get better from a spiritual standpoint, from an internal peace standpoint. But externally it will probably get worse.
    - And so, our experience, (or as we say), our testimony, is not a catalyst in the Salvation process, which is one of the reasons why Paul doesn't use his own

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testimony as a method to lead someone to Christ.

- I find that fascinating, especially considering what most of us have been taught, right? From a strictly or purely evangelical perspective, if testimonies weren't an effective tool in leading someone to Christ, then I would say Paul's testimony would have been one of the best of all-time. But he never uses it in that way.
- As a matter of fact, he goes out of his way not to put himself at the center of the salvation process. So, what method does Paul use? Well, let's look and see. Turn with me if you will to Acts 16:25-30. Now, in the 'spirit of time' this morning, I won't explain at a high level what happens in this scene, jump in a read it.

- The situation is this. Paul and Silas were in Phillipi, and they were arrested, flogged, and imprisoned for causing a 'public nuisance'. After they were arrested, they were beaten, stripped naked, placed in stocks and chains, and shackled together.
  - The Bible says they began singing hymns to God at or around about midnight, and then suddenly there was a great earthquake, and their chains fell off and all the prison doors were opened, and they were freed. But then something interesting happened. Let me read what Luke wrote in Acts 16:25-29:

Acts 16:25 **But about midnight Paul and Silas were praying and singing hymns of praise to God, and the prisoners were listening to them;**
Acts 16:26 **and suddenly there came a great earthquake, so that the foundations of the prison house were shaken; and immediately all the doors were opened, and everyone's chains were unfastened.**
Acts 16:27 **When the jailer awoke and saw the prison doors opened, he drew his sword and was about to kill himself, supposing that the prisoners had escaped.**

- Now, let's pause here for just a moment, because what happens next is something opposite to what we might think would happen. In my opinion, I would think once they were freed they would have hit the bricks. I would think once the doors were opened, they would have immediately escaped. But that's not what happened. Listen to what happens next:

Acts 16:28 **But Paul cried out with a loud voice, saying, "Do not harm yourself, for we are all here!"**
Acts 16:29 **And he called for lights and rushed in, and trembling with fear he fell down before Paul and Silas,**

- Which then leads the jailor to say this in verse 30:

Acts 16:30 **and after he brought them out, he said, "Sirs, what must I do to be saved?**

- Now, when you study verse 30 in the Greek, it reads this way, "And having brought them

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out he was saying, Sirs, what of me is necessary to do, that I may be saved?"

- To my knowledge this is the only place in scripture where this question is asked in such a direct format. What must I do to be saved? Pretty important question, don't you think? I would say so. But what's more important is what happened next. Does the Book of Acts say, "Paul immediately sat down with the jailor and gave him and his household his personal testimony?
- Did it say he testified of what all God had done for him, how God made his life better? Is that what it says? Nope, but why not? Well, first of all, as I previously stated, from the world's standpoint, Paul's life wasn't better, it was worse.
  - I mean, the jailor himself knew Paul and Silas had been beaten and imprisoned, so I think using their testimony as a method of leading someone to salvation would have been a hard sell. Don't you? Can you hear them trying to do that?
  - Hey Mr. Jailor, if you give your life to Christ, look how your life will turn out. It's awesome being a Christ follower. So, he doesn't use his testimony. But what does he do? Well, listen to it:

Acts 16:31 They said, "Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."
Acts 16:32 And they spoke the word of the Lord to him together with all who were in his house.
Acts 16:33 And he took them that *very* hour of the night and washed their wounds, and immediately he was baptized, he and all his *household.*
Acts 16:34 And he brought them into his house and set food before them, and rejoiced greatly, having believed in God with his whole household.

- Now, the key to this section of scripture lies in verse 32, even though it may appear the key to salvation lies in verse 31, when the man asked, "What must I do to be saved?". And then Paul answers the man and says, "Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved, you and your household."
  - Yes, that's important because that is what it takes to be saved. Belief in Jesus Christ is what brings someone into Salvation. But the question is, what causes someone to believe? It's not a testimony and it's not simply reciting words, or saying, "okay, I believe".
    - And we clearly see that's not the case here with the Philippian jailor, because that's not what happened. The man didn't say, okay, I believe. No, there was a step that preceded the step of salvation itself. And what was it? Belief was brought about by the supernatural work of God, which was initiated when Paul took the man to God's Word, and they heard it.
  - The result being (not only) was this man saved, but the entire household was saved. All those who heard the Word of God. Now, what does all this have to do with today's study of 2 Corinthians?
    - Well, believe it or not, it has a lot to do with it. Because Paul's entire reasoning for hiding who this man was in verse 2, this man he said he knew 14 years earlier, revolved around boasting. How Paul did not want to elevate himself in

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the eyes of this church in any way.

- You see, if Paul told this church about the experiences he had with God, he would run the risk of he, himself becoming 'the man' in the eyes of these people. Remember, idol worship was a real problem in those days, and Paul was hypersensitive to this fact. Which was one of the reasons he doesn't give his testimony when trying to lead someone to God.
    - You see, when dealing with matters pertaining to God, we must never be the focus or the center of attention. And why? Well, first of all, that is not the method God uses to save people. His method comes by way of conviction which comes by way of His Word. God's Word convicts because God's Word is God in Word form.
    - The second reason Paul never used his personal testimony as a method to lead someone to Christ is because it leads to false conversion. If someone makes a decision for Christ outside the conviction of God by way of His Word, their decision will not hold up on their day of judgement, in God's 'Court of Law', because it wasn't of God. It was born out of the flesh, out of emotion or experience, brought about by a moment or a story of a downturn in someone's life.
        - Meaning, when the person listening to someone's testimony heard their story, it moved that individual, intrigued that person based on that individual's personal experience, which usually included God solving a problem in their life. And most the time the problem He solved wasn't salvation-related, but rather it was some everyday life or worldly issue where God made their life better.
        - Which as I said, can lead to false conversion. Because once you are saved, the problems in your life may not get better. There is really no stronger proof of this than what we read in Matthew 7:15-23, where Jesus Himself said the following:

Matt. 7:15 "Beware of the false prophets, who come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly are ravenous wolves.
Matt. 7:16 You will know them by their fruits. Grapes are not gathered from thorn *bushes,* nor figs from thistles, are they?
Matt. 7:17 So every good tree bears good fruit, but the bad tree bears bad fruit.
Matt. 7:18 A good tree cannot bear bad fruit, nor can a bad tree bear good fruit.
Matt. 7:19 Every tree that does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire.
Matt. 7:20 So then, you will know them by their fruits.
Matt. 7:21 "Not everyone who says to Me, 'Lord, Lord,' will enter the kingdom of heaven, but the one who does the will of My Father who is in heaven *will enter.*
Matt. 7:22 Many will say to Me on that day, 'Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in Your name, and in Your name cast out demons, and in Your name perform many miracles?'
Matt. 7:23 And then I will declare to them, 'I never knew you; LEAVE ME, YOU WHO PRACTICE LAWLESSNESS.'

- The key focus and intent of this passage lies in verse 22 & 23, where Jesus recounts what

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these false prophets said. Look at what they said.

- "Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in Your name?". Now, let me say, these words are really no big deal, because anyone could say they prophesied in Jesus' name and there would really be no way of verifying what they said happened. But then they said, "Did we not cast out demons in your name, and perform many miracles in your name?"
- Different story here, because it appears they actually did these things. Which brings on more talk, because if they actually did those things, and yet they were not a child of God, then how did they do it?
  - It would have to have been under the supernatural power of some other spiritual entity, and there is only one other supernatural entity capable of doing such things. And so, it must have been the enemy.

- My point being, the method for how God saves people is pretty important, and in the last days, which, let me say we are definitely living in; in the last days false conversions will be rampant according to Revelations, which tells us that the church will be full of people who aren't saved.
  - It's imperative that we as a church understand why this is the case. It's the case because the method God uses to save people has been abandoned, and in its place, we have substituted emotional experience.
    - Dr. James White said, "I fear our churches are full of people saved on music and emotion. Not the Word of God."
  - And so now you should see why Paul is so concerned about this boasting topic and why he didn't tell the church at Corinth he was the one who experienced the vision and revelation of God some 14 years earlier because he didn't want to become elevated.
  - But why is boasting such a problem? Because it's a form of pride and pride is 'Kryptonite' in the life of the believer. That's why Paul wanted to stay as far away from it as he could. And guess what? God wanted him to stay away from it as well, so to ensure Paul would never think too highly of himself, God did something to him. And what did he do? Well, let's read about it in 2 Corinthians 12:7-10:

2 Cor. 12:7 Because of the extraordinary *greatness* of the revelations, for this reason, to keep me from exalting myself, there was given to me a thorn in the flesh, a messenger of Satan to torment me—to keep me from exalting myself!
2 Cor. 12:8 Concerning this I pleaded with the Lord three times that it might leave me.
2 Cor. 12:9 And He has said to me, "My grace is sufficient for you, for power is perfected in weakness." Most gladly, therefore, I will rather boast about my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may dwell in me.
2 Cor. 12:10 Therefore I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in distresses, in persecutions, in difficulties, on behalf of Christ; for when I am weak, then I am strong.

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- Now, as I told you last week, verse 7 has been a highly talked about and debated topic throughout the centuries. So, what in the world is "Paul's thorn in the flesh"?
  - Some have said it was a woman (not me though. I didn't say it. I said some have said). Some have said it was the continual persecution and the hardships that Paul faced. Others have said it was some individual such as Alexzander the Coopersmith, a man who did a great deal of harm to Paul, which we read about in 2 Timothy 4:14.
  - Honestly, it doesn't really matter, because that's not the point. The point is God made sure Paul stayed humble. And Paul himself was so cognitive of this that he would never broach any spiritual topic where he was the center of attention. Now, what I find even most interesting about all of this is the fact that Paul himself is never described in scripture as a proud or boastful man.
    - He is actually described as right the opposite of that, and we know that to be the case when we hear the men of Corinth talk about his appearance or his speaking ability. This is also confirmed in other places of scripture as well.
- So isn't it interesting that a man who (by all accounts) doesn't seem to have an issue with bragging or boasting, because he has nothing to brag about, that God puts a little extra work in on him to ensure he doesn't become prideful. Once again, this leads me to ask why. Seem's like if God was going to focus on someone's pride issues, Peter might be the prime candidate to receive that treatment.
  - So why Paul? Because Paul had visions and revelations, like none of the others had. Six times he encountered God in that way, and with every God encounter, he ran the risk of becoming puffed up and boastful.
  - So, it's as if God said, "Paul, because you have encountered me so many times, I must do something to keep you grounded." And that's exactly what He does. But then He does something else as well. Something that speaks to all of us sitting here today. Something that educates us in the ways of the Lord, specifically, on how He operates.
    - Listen to what He says, and we will close with this. Verses 7-10 – reading it again for context:

2 Cor. 12:7 Because of the extraordinary *greatness* of the revelations, for this reason, to keep me from exalting myself, there was given to me a thorn in the flesh, a messenger of Satan to torment me—to keep me from exalting myself!
2 Cor. 12:8 Concerning this I pleaded with the Lord three times that it might leave me.
2 Cor. 12:9 And He has said to me, "My grace is sufficient for you, for power is perfected in weakness." Most gladly, therefore, I will rather boast about my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may dwell in me.
2 Cor. 12:10 Therefore I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in distresses, in persecutions, in difficulties, in behalf of Christ; for when I am weak, then I am strong.

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- Once again, in this passage we see God operate opposite of the way we would think He would operate. By the way, this is the consistent theme of scripture. God always operates opposite the way we would. The first will be last and the last will be first. The greatest of these on earth will be the least of these in heaven.
    - And so, what we have learned this morning is that if you want to access the power of God, you don't do it through some emotional experience, through some 'Hyper Spiritual Experience". You do it through weakness, and Paul believed that so much that he actually celebrated it.
        - He said, "I delight in weakness, insults, distress, persecutions, difficulties; all on behalf of Christ. For when I am weak, then I am strong."
        - Have you had a rough life? I get it, but know this. Your weakness, your hard time, if you are a believer, has purpose and meaning. It's doing something to you, and if you put those hardships into their proper perspective, you too will begin to know and experience what Paul is trying to relay.
    - God uses hardship as a tool of your development so that as you develop and mature spiritually, when you rise from the ashes, you will slowly begin to evolve into a piece of tempered steel, a tried-and-true instrument of God. And it's then, and only then, that your life will begin to bring Glory to God.
    - Which is the whole reason that God saved you in the first place. Remember, if you are a believer, your life is not your own. You have been purchased. Bought with a price. You belong to God, and He purchased you for His purposes, which ultimately culminates with Him being Glorified.
- Next week, the verses I would like for you to study are 2 Corinthians 12:11-21, as I will attempt to finish the chapter and move into Chapter 13, which will bring us to the end of this letter.

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- Welcome back folks. March is here and we are headed toward spring. Can I get an Amen on that?
    - Anyway, last week I made a statement that could be or might be considered a little controversial, especially for those of us who have attended church for many years, and it had to do with the use of our testimony. Specifically, our testimony as a method of leading someone to Christ.
    - And I used as my 'proof of concept', Paul, how he personally never used his personal testimony as a Salvation tool. As a matter of fact, I haven't personally found where a testimony is ever used a tool or method of leading someone to salvation in the Bible.
        - Which is interesting, because honestly, if anyone was going to use their personal testimony in that fashion, I would say Paul would be a pretty good candidate, wouldn't you? But he doesn't. Instead, just as we studied last week in the story of the Philippian Jailor, Paul took people to the Word of God when trying to lead someone to Christ.
        - And from there, if God was dealing with that individual, it was then that God Himself would convict them through the pages of scripture. And based on my research, that appears to be the recurring theme all throughout the Bible, at least in places where matters of salvation are concerned.
        - And as I just stated, this doesn't just apply to Paul. As far as I can tell, no other person in the scriptures uses their testimony as a method of Salvation either. Now, just so I don't appear to be setting up shop on one passage of scripture, let me take you to another place in the Bible where salvation is the topic, and use it as a proof text of what I am trying to convey.
- Turn with me if you will, to Acts 8:25-40:

Acts 8:25 So, when they had solemnly testified and spoken the word of the Lord, they started back to Jerusalem and were preaching the gospel to many villages of the Samaritans.
Acts 8:26 But an angel of the Lord spoke to Philip saying, "Get up and go south to the road that descends from Jerusalem to Gaza." (This is a desert *road.*)
Acts 8:27 So he got up and went; and there was an Ethiopian eunuch, a court official of Candace, queen of the Ethiopians, who was in charge of all her treasure; and he had come to Jerusalem to worship,
Acts 8:28 and he was returning and sitting in his chariot and was reading the prophet Isaiah.
Acts 8:29 Then the Spirit said to Philip, "Go up and join this chariot."
Acts 8:30 Philip ran up and heard him reading Isaiah the prophet, and said, "Do you understand what you are reading?"
Acts 8:31 And he said, "Well, how could I, unless someone guides me?" And he invited Philip to come up and sit with him.
Acts 8:32 Now the passage of Scripture which he was reading was this:
"HE WAS LED AS A SHEEP TO SLAUGHTER;

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AND AS A LAMB BEFORE ITS SHEARER IS SILENT,
SO HE DOES NOT OPEN HIS MOUTH.
Acts 8:33 **"IN HUMILIATION HIS JUDGMENT WAS TAKEN AWAY;**
WHO WILL RELATE HIS GENERATION?
FOR HIS LIFE IS REMOVED FROM THE EARTH."
Acts 8:34 **The eunuch answered Philip and said, "Please *tell me,* of whom does the prophet say this? Of himself or of someone else?"**
Acts 8:35 **Then Philip opened his mouth, and beginning from this Scripture he preached Jesus to him. (KEY!!)**
Acts 8:36 **As they went along the road they came to some water; and the eunuch said, "Look! Water! What prevents me from being baptized?"**
Acts 8:37 **[And Philip said, "If you believe with all your heart, you may." And he answered and said, "I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God."]**
Acts 8:38 **And he ordered the chariot to stop; and they both went down into the water, Philip as well as the eunuch, and he baptized him.**
Acts 8:39 **When they came up out of the water, the Spirit of the Lord snatched Philip away; and the eunuch no longer saw him but went on his way rejoicing.**
Acts 8:40 **But Philip found himself at Azotus, and as he passed through, he kept preaching the gospel to all the cities until he came to Caesarea.**

- And so, not only does Paul not use his personal testimony as a tool to lead someone into salvation, which was highlighted by what we read in Acts 16:25-29 with the story of the Philippian jailor. Based on the testimony of 2 Corinthians 12, he goes out of his way to do the opposite of using his testimony. And not only that, but God Himself takes great measures to ensure Paul will not be the center of His work either.
    - And how does God ensure that? Well, let's read it one more time. 2 Corinthians 12:7-10:

2 Cor. 12:7 **Because of the extraordinary *greatness* of the revelations, for this reason, to keep me from exalting myself, there was given to me a thorn in the flesh, a messenger of Satan to torment me—to keep me from exalting myself!**
2 Cor. 12:8 **Concerning this I pleaded with the Lord three times that it might leave me.**
2 Cor. 12:9 **And He has said to me, "My grace is sufficient for you, for power is perfected in weakness." Most gladly, therefore, I will rather boast about my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may dwell in me.**
2 Cor. 12:10 **Therefore I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in distresses, in persecutions, in difficulties, on behalf of Christ; for when I am weak, then I am strong.**

- So, God (to ensure Paul would never think too highly of himself) sends a messenger of

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Satan to torment him. And does that for one reason and one reason alone. To keep him grounded. To keep him from exalting himself. Pretty dramatic, don't you think?

- But having said that, what about our testimony? Am I saying we should never mention it? Nope, that's not what I am saying. Sharing your testimony has its place and purpose. It's really akin to what Abraham did when he built an alter to the Lord after God called him out of the Ur of the Chaldeans and told him to go unto a land in which He would show him.
- Once Abraham realized the blessing God had bestowed on him, he built an altar as a marker and reminder to all those who would see it. An alter to God testifying to all that God had done. And when we share our testimony, the purpose should be the same; to point people back to God.
  - Meaning, when we share our testimony, our lives should be a living Alter to God. Letting the world know who God is. How mighty and great He is. Now, someone might say, well, isn't that the same thing? I mean, if I share with people what God has done in my life, isn't that the same thing as sharing my testimony for the purposes of leading someone to Christ?
  - No, it's not. The altar Abraham built was built out of thankfulness and gratitude and, honestly, praise. It was a physical manifestation of praise unto the Lord, and by all accounts it was a form of worship.
- In other words, the altar itself had nothing to do with Abraham and everything to do with God. And proof of this concept can be found using one of the rules of Hermeneutics. Rules that we learned this past Wednesday when I took you through the second week curriculum on "How to Study your Bible as if You were Preparing to Teach it".

- The rule was that of Logic. It was rule #5:
  - The rule of LOGIC: Interpretation is merely logical reasoning.
    - It said when interpreting Scripture, the use of reason is everywhere to be assumed. Does the interpretation make sense? The Bible was given to us in the form of human language and therefore appeals to human reason. It invites investigation and it is to be interpreted as we would any other volume, applying the laws of language and grammatical analysis.
  - When we apply logic in determining the purpose of the altar that Abraham built, as the rule noted, we are using reasoning, which begins by asking yourself a simple question; why did Abraham feel the need to build the altar in the first place?
  - By applying logic and reasoning, it becomes really easy to ascertain the correct answer. Follow me here. What was the purpose of the alter? For, A – People to say, "Look, there's the alter Abraham built. What a great reminder of all that God has done for him", or B – People would say, "Look, there is an altar built to God as a reminder of who God is and of His faithfulness".
    - If the alter worked, it would convey the correct message. In other words, was the altar about Abraham or God? I'm going with B, because logically not everyone knew who Abraham was. Which means, the alter had to be a sign of God's goodness and greatness and provision, which meant it had zero to do with Abraham and everything to do with God.

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        - Which also lines up perfectly with the testimony of scripture. The scripture always makes God the focus, not us. So, when we use our testimony (even with good intention, I might add), when we use our testimony, and we use a lot of pronouns in the conversation, words like me and I, God is no longer the point of the conversation. You are.
        - And so, when we give someone our testimony, we must remember our words should point people back to the cross. It should never be about the outcome of what God did, but rather, who God is.
        - And maybe that's what you do. But for the most part, when most of us share our testimony with someone, it's generally all about us, what God did for us. And yes, God is a part of it, but He is really not the point or central focus. Generally, He as a secondary player in our story.
- Now, you may say, well, I don't necessarily agree with what you just said, and that's okay. I would just tell you to listen closely the next time someone gives their testimony, or for that matter, listen to yourself and ask yourself the question, who is the center of the discussion, you or God? If it's God, then you're okay. If it's you and God is secondary in the narrative, then you know you've got it wrong.
    - Moving on, Paul goes out of his way to divert the spotlight away from him. And, so he doesn't forget, God helps him out with that by sending a messenger of Satan to torment him. And why?
    - Well, Paul tells us in verses 8-10. It is so that he can tap into the power of the Holy Spirit, using a method by the way, that we would never use to tap into anything. A method called weakness. Listen to it one more time.

2 Cor. 12:8 **Concerning this I pleaded with the Lord three times that it might leave me.**
2 Cor. 12:9 **And He has said to me, "My grace is sufficient for you, for power is perfected in weakness." Most gladly, therefore, I will rather boast about my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may dwell in me.**
2 Cor. 12:10 **Therefore I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in distresses, in persecutions, in difficulties, in behalf of Christ; for when I am weak, then I am strong.**

- Once again guys, this is the testimony of scripture, and I want you to hear this. If you don't get anything out of what I am teaching today, hear this. If believers want to truly tap into or access the power of the Holy Spirit in our lives, it is done through weakness, of which humility and brokenness are synonyms.
    - And those are opposite of pride, and that includes any kind of pride. Pride is the issue, because it always elevates the individual, and when we increase, God automatically decreases. There is simply no way around it. And this is such a hard concept for us (as humans) to grasp and to implement into our daily lives.
    - And why? Because of sin. Sin that is so prevalent in each of our lives. With pride being at the top of the list. There is nothing our flesh delights in more than pride, which begins with our need to feel good about ourselves, to elevate ourselves.

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        - But as I said last week, unfortunately, pride is the Kryptonite in the life of the believer, and it takes extreme self-awareness to control it, control what we say, and more than that, how we say it. It requires the individual believer to stop and pause, and to think about what they are getting ready to say.
    - Essentially, it requires us to examine our heart, our motive, and then of course our tongue. The Bible even warns us about this very thing. The Prophet Jeremiah spoke about the heart in Jeremiah 17:9-10:

Jeremiah 17:9 "The heart is more deceitful than all else
And is desperately sick;
Who can understand it?

- Then we hear this about the tongue in James 3:5-6, which provides an outlet for what's in our heart:

James 3:5 So also the tongue is a small part *of the body,* and *yet* it boasts of great things. See how great a forest is set aflame by such a small fire!
James 3:6 And the tongue is a fire, the *very* world of unrighteousness; the tongue is set among our body's parts as that which defiles the whole body and sets on fire the course of *our* life, and is set on fire by hell.
James 3:7 For every species of beasts and birds, of reptiles and creatures of the sea, is tamed and has been tamed by the human race.
James 3:8 But no one *among* mankind can tame the tongue; *it is* a restless evil, full of deadly poison.
James 3:9 With it we bless *our* Lord and Father, and with it we curse people, who have been made in the likeness of God;
James 3:10 from the same mouth come *both* blessing and cursing. My brothers *and sisters,* these things should not be this way.
James 3:11 Does a spring send out from the same opening *both* fresh and bitter *water?*
James 3:12 Can a fig tree, my brothers *and sisters,* bear olives, or a vine *bear* figs? Nor *can* saltwater produce fresh.

- So, for the believer, our greatest battle takes place inside, and as I said, it requires self-awareness at a high level to win the pride battle. Which only happens when we see ourselves the way God sees us.
    - Let me say it another way, the way He saw us prior to the redeeming work of Jesus in our lives. And what was that? We were nothing more than filthy rags in the sight of a Holy and Righteous God. So, when we talk about taping into the power of God in our lives through weakness, that power is made manifest through the process of 'reflection'.
    - Meaning, when we study God's Word, it breaks us down and causes us to reflect on

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our lives. It humbles us by causing us to take a close examination of who we are, and look introspectively, which then causes us to ask ourselves a question. Am I doing what God has called me to do, which is to shine light in a dark and dying world?

- Simply put, the power of weakness is made manifest through self-reflection. Moving on.

- Let's finish Chapter 12, where Paul continues on with his defense of who he was, which was an Apostle of Jesus Christ. And, as he does that he also continues on with a sarcastic tone. Follow me if you will, 2 Corinthians 12:11-21:

2 Cor. 12:11 I have become foolish; you yourselves compelled me. Actually I should have been commended by you, since I was in no respect inferior to the most eminent apostles, even though I am a nobody.
2 Cor. 12:12 The distinguishing marks of a true apostle were performed among you with all perseverance, by signs, wonders, and miracles.
2 Cor. 12:13 For in what respect were you treated as inferior to the rest of the churches, except that I myself did not become a burden to you? Forgive me this wrong!
2 Cor. 12:14 Here for this third time I am ready to come to you, and I will not be a burden to you; for I do not seek what is yours, but you; for children are not responsible to save up for *their* parents, but parents for *their* children.
2 Cor. 12:15 I will most gladly spend and be expended for your souls. If I love you more, am I to be loved less?
2 Cor. 12:16 But be that as it may, I did not burden you myself; nevertheless, devious person that I am, I took you in by deceit.
2 Cor. 12:17 *Certainly* I have not taken advantage of you through any of those whom I have sent to you, have I?
2 Cor. 12:18 I urged Titus *to go,* and I sent the brother with him. Titus did not take any advantage of you, did he? Did we not conduct ourselves in the same spirit *and walk* in the same steps?
2 Cor. 12:19 All this time you have been thinking that we are defending ourselves to you. *Actually,* it is in the sight of God that we have been speaking in Christ; and all for building you up, beloved.
2 Cor. 12:20 For I am afraid that perhaps when I come I may find you to be not what I wish, and may be found by you to be not what you wish; that perhaps *there will be* strife, jealousy, angry tempers, selfishness, slanders, gossip, arrogance, disturbances;
2 Cor. 12:21 *I am afraid* that when I come again my God may humiliate me before you, and I may mourn over many of those who have sinned in the past and not repented of the impurity, sexual immorality, and indecent behavior which they have practiced.

- Paul begins by once again reminding his readers of his own qualifications as an Apostle.

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And he does so in a somewhat different way. In verse 11, he says he has become foolish; you yourselves compelled me. Then he says, “Actually I should have been commended by you, since I was in no respect inferior to the most eminent apostles, even though I am nobody.”

- What he is saying is, I am participating in the foolishness of comparing myself to these most eminent apostles. The most eminent apostles being these false prophets who have slipped into the church. These men who have somehow elevated themselves in the eyes of this church.
- And they have done this through outward signs of strength, which (as we’ve learned) is opposite of weakness, and weakness, brokenness, and humility are the true signs of a called man of God. So, Paul continues with a sarcastic tone by saying the Church at Corinth forced him to participate in the foolishness of these false prophets. Meaning, he didn’t want to do it.
  - At this point, Paul says this church should be confirming and commending him, but instead they are forcing him to defend himself to this critical minority inside this fellowship. Then he says, “I am doing this (defending myself), even though he was nobody”.
  - And there it is again folks. Paul speaking about himself in humility. He says he was nobody. Which is interesting because if there ever was somebody in the Bible, Paul would be it. Yet, that is not how he views himself.

- Just an FYI for all believers listening today. Paul’s description of himself should be how we describe ourselves. He was nobody and we are nobody. Humility is the key, because it’s the counterbalance to pride. Next, in verses 12-13, Paul mentions what he calls the ‘distinguishing marks’ of a true Apostle. Which were what? Signs, wonders, and miracles.
  - I won’t dwell on this too much, other than to say God created Apostles for a specific purpose and reason, and they possessed certain gifts, gifts that were unique to them. This has been a highly debated topic throughout history. Let me correct that statement. This has been a highly debated topic over the last 50 years.
  - From my studies and research, it didn’t seem to be a debate until after the turn of the 20th century, or, let me say, it didn’t seem to be as much of a debate as it is today. The gifts of the Apostles served as a unique gift to them for the purposes of authenticity.
    - Remember, at this point in church history, Jesus Christ, and the Gospel of Jesus Christ, was a new concept. The Jews had been taught that one day the Messiah would come, and He would free their people. But when Jesus arrived, He wasn’t what they expected. They wanted more. A powerful man who would slay their enemies with just a stroke of His sword.
    - But instead, God sent a meek humble man, who spoke in ways that only His sheep would be able to understand. Only His sheep could hear His voice, and once he died and rose again, the Gospel message was inaugurated on the day of Pentecost, with men disciples while in the upper room experienced the ushering in of the Holy Spirit through tongues of fire.
    - Those men were impowered by God with special gifts for a specific reason, which was to authenticate the New Covenant of Jesus Christ. And Paul (even though he wasn’t a part of that upper room experience), received the same

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power directly from God Himself on the road to Damascus.

- Those gifts were specific to the Apostles, and in my opinion based on my research, and let me say, also my experience inside the Charismatic Church, those gits died with the Apostles. Now, you may be sitting here today and saying, well, I don't believe that. That's okay. Every believer must work out these matters for themselves.

- All I can tell you is this. I tried to get right up in the middle of these miracles of God, inside churches who said the miracles were still alive and well, to no avail. I never experienced it and I never saw it, and after over a year and a half of trying, it didn't happen.
- And let me say, when you study what Paul says right here in 2 Corinthians 12, where he clearly says:

2 Cor. 12:12 The distinguishing marks of a true apostle were performed among you with all perseverance, by signs, wonders, and miracles.

- One more time: The distinguishing marks of a true Apostle were performed among you with all perseverance. If you read those words in context, Paul says these signs, wonders, and miracles were distinguishing marks of a true Apostle. I don't know about you, but it appears these supernatural giftings were specific to the Apostles.
  - Anyway, Paul's point is, even though they performed these things among this church, which proved who they were, he and the other Apostles still had to prove themselves. And then he says something else. Something that serves as further proof of his Apostleship in Verses 14-19.
  - He mentions how he, nor the other Apostles, have never been a burden to them. In this context, burden relates to money. In other words, He's saying we never took a dime from you for anything we've done.
- Now, I find this interesting, And I'll tell you why. Over these past several chapters, Paul has been combating everything these false teachers have been saying. Specifically, what they have been saying about themselves as it relates to comparing themselves to Paul and the other disciples.
  - For example, when They used Paul's appearance and speaking ability as some sort of proof that he wasn't an Apostle. The sense of Paul's writings Is that of them trying to prove who they are by and through their strengths.
  - And so, when they boast in their strength, Paul counters them by offsetting what they say by boasting in his weakness. So, it's a tit-for-tat situation. Meaning, when they make a point, Paul makes a counterpoint.
    - I find it interesting how Paul continues to mention how he hasn't been a burden to them by taking money from them for himself. And this tells me something. It tells me that these men (these false prophets) may be taking money from this church. Now let me say, the scripture doesn't say this, but if you use another rule of interpreting scripture in Hermeneutics, the rule of inference, you can infer this to be the case.
    - Meaning, Paul has consistently been combating what these men continue to

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throw out as proof of their Apostleship. And Paul counters them by saying, true Apostles don't operate in those ways.

- So, what could be concluded is that these false prophets have been taking money from this church, whereas Paul and the other Apostles have not.

- Now, I could set up shop here for days (I won't), but guys let me just say, money collected through the Saints (through tithing), should be used to fulfill the work of ministry. We are called to be good stewards for the money people give, and for the past 10-plus years, this church has made that its mission and will continue to make it our mission.
  - Money has changed the church over the last *50 years*, and I believe it has perpetuated a lot of men entering into ministry, men who were not called into Pastoral Ministry. Paul took up money when he visited a church, but not for himself. He took it to the poorer churches so he could help facilitate their basic needs.
  - That's exactly what scripture tells us. Now, once again, you don't have to listen to me, but all I am saying is take away the big salaries and see how many men are still called into ministry. You would be surprised.
- Now, last week I said we were going to finish Chapter 12 and move into 13, but apparently, I should have kept my mouth shut because we aren't going to make it. We will finish it next week by briefly touching on the last few verses.
  - And so, in anticipation of Chapter 13, I would like you to read the entire 14 verses that are left in our study of 2 Corinthians and see if you and I come up with some of the same hypothesis as it relates to those verses.

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- Good morning, everyone. Good to see you, especially given the fact that the time changed. Gaining an hour in the fall is not bad at all, but losing an hour in the spring can be a little rough.
  - Anyway, I appreciate everyone who made it this morning.
  - So, last week I attempted to finish Chapter 12, which didn't happen. And, as I stated at the end of last week's message, I want to pick back up on the last few verses of Chapter 12 before we move into Chapter 13. So, with that in mind, let's back up and re-read the final verses of Chapter 12, and use that as a segway into today's teaching.
- Beginning with verse 14 and finishing up with verse 21, here's what Paul wrote:

2 Cor. 12:14 **Here for this third time I am ready to come to you, and I will not be a burden to you; for I do not seek what is yours, but you; for children are not responsible to save up for *their* parents, but parents for *their* children.**
2 Cor. 12:15 **I will most gladly spend and be expended for your souls. If I love you more, am I to be loved less?**
2 Cor. 12:16 **But be that as it may, I did not burden you myself; nevertheless, devious person that I am, I took you in by deceit.**

- Paul, once again, is using sarcasm to drive his point home.

2 Cor. 12:17 ***Certainly* I have not taken advantage of you through any of those whom I have sent to you, have I?**
2 Cor. 12:18 **I urged Titus *to go,* and I sent the brother with him. Titus did not take any advantage of you, did he? Did we not conduct ourselves in the same spirit *and walk* in the same steps?**
2 Cor. 12:19 **All this time you have been thinking that we are defending ourselves to you. *Actually,* it is in the sight of God that we have been speaking in Christ; and all for building you up, beloved.**
2 Cor. 12:20 **For I am afraid that perhaps when I come I may find you to be not what I wish, and may be found by you to be not what you wish; that perhaps *there will be* strife, jealousy, angry tempers, selfishness, slanders, gossip, arrogance, disturbances;**
2 Cor. 12:21 ***I am afraid* that when I come again my God may humiliate me before you, and I may mourn over many of those who have sinned in the past and not repented of the impurity, sexual immorality, and indecent behavior which they have practiced.**

- In this last section of verses of Chapter 12, Paul pretty much ends with an exclamation point or "crescendo" of sorts as he defends his Apostleship. Remember, Paul has been writing to the Corinthian church for quite some time, 'rebutting & refuting' those false teachers who've have made their way into this fellowship and have been trying to

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downplay Paul and the other Apostle's position and authority.

- I say this is a crescendo moment because he makes a move from speaking about the issues (somewhat subtly) to speaking much more direct and much more sarcastically. That's where he is in the final verses of Chapter 12, and as I said, he pretty much cuts to the chase where he reminds them that neither he nor the other apostles have been a burden to this church.
- Now, when he speaks about being a burden, he's speaking specifically about taking money from the church, which I find interesting, especially in light of what we see in churches today. I'm not going expound on this too much other than to say, the Church at Corinth is wealthy. It has money.
  - Corinth was a wealthy area. It was a double seaport town. Corinth was an isthmus, a narrow strip of land which connected the Gulf of Corinth in the Ionian Sea with the Saronic Gulf in the Aegean Sea. And that entire area was a very wealthy place during that time.
  - And so, as I said, the Church at Corinth had money, and Paul urged them in his writings to take up an offering. But like I said, it wasn't for him or the other Apostles. He wanted to take up an offering for the poorer church of Jerusalem. And Paul was known for this. He wanted the wealthier churches to help provide for the basic needs of the poorer churches.
  - And so, what's that tell us, or more specifically, what is one of the examples or models we can deduct from Paul's behavior? It's a model that says churches should help one another. It also gives us a reason why God requires us to give in the first place. To help one another.
- You see, as a believer, God requires you to give. But the question is how much or what percentage should you give? Well, let's see if Paul can give us the answer to that question. Turn with me to 1 Corinthians 16:1-2:

1 Cor. 16:1 Now concerning the collection for the saints, as I directed the churches of Galatia, so you are to do as well.
1 Cor. 16:2 On the first day of every week, each of you is to put aside and save as he may prosper, so that no collections *need to* be made when I come.

- If you grew up in church, or have been in church very long, you have probably heard the 10% rule of giving or tithing your whole life. 10% is a derivative of the word "tithe" – tithe means a tenth in Hebrew, and of course the debate over the 10% rule has been a doozie over the years.
  - Do I tithe off of my gross or do I tithe off of my net? First of all, let me say, if you have ever wondered about whether you tithe off the gross or net, I can solve that debate for you right here and right now. I know it's shocking. I profess to have an answer.
  - But I promise you, I don't have the answer because I am smart or because I simply know more than other people do. That's not it at all. I have the answer because I question everything and then I go study for myself to find that these things might be true.
    - And so usually, when someone brings up a controversial topic such as giving,

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my curiosity is peaked. Especially when there is some argument or disagreement over whatever the topic may be. That's what usually makes me go dig, because truthfully, seminary or no seminary, degrees or no degrees, I simply don't trust anything preachers or so-called Bible experts say.

- And why? Because just about every topic I have ever studied has been taught from a standpoint of tradition, which then has somehow modified over the years to fit inside a church tradition box. And generally speaking, what I discover when I study is that most of what I've been taught was wrong. And this topic of giving is no different.

- Let me expound a little on this. Years ago, I was a deacon at another church, and every year, old deacons would roll off and new ones would roll on. Sometimes it would be deacons who had previously served in that role, and sometimes it would be brand-new deacons who would be serving for the first time.
  - When a new deacon was nominated by the church, the current body of deacons along with the pastor would discuss the new nominees. Specifically, whether or not they met the qualifications of deacon as laid out in the pastoral epistles – 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, and Titus.
  - Anyway, one year we were discussing a particular individual who had been nominated, and by the way, was more than qualified to be a deacon. I believe he had previously served as a deacon, and during the discussion time, the preacher brought up a concern about this candidate.
    - He said, "I have a problem with this man being a deacon because he doesn't tithe 10%". Now, at that time I was young and didn't know anything, but I remember thinking to myself, how does the preacher know what that man gives? I also remember thinking, is the preacher supposed to know what people give? That was a little unnerving.
  - Having said that, I don't specifically remember questioning the whole 10% concept at that time, primarily because I was told that 10% was the requirement. So, I believed it. But later on, as I was questioning several other church traditions, I did go study the topic of giving (in depth), and just like all the other topics I studied, I discovered that what I was being told was wrong. There was no 10% rule in the New Testament. This was an Old Testament requirement.
    - And furthermore, to be honest with you if you want to get technical with it, if you use the Old Testament standard, the 10% rule wasn't correct either, because when you study giving and sacrifice in the Old Testament, what you will discover is the percentage is more around 21%. That's if you follow the rules of sacrifice and giving to the letter of the law.
    - And so, I remember being conflicted. I would say I was disturbed. Disturbed by the fact that the preacher was looking into what people gave, because even though I didn't know for sure, I felt fairly confident that the financial oversight of the Saints was not part of his job description. Which turned out to be true. It was actually none of his business.
  - Anyway, that incident (among others) was bothersome, and it caused me to dig deeper and discover for myself. What did this man's giving habits have to do with being a deacon? I wanted to know, and so I did something crazy. I went to the place in the scripture that outlined the qualifications of deacon. You want to hear them?

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- Let me read them to you straight from the pages of God's Holy Manuscript.

1 Tim. 3:8 Deacons likewise *must be* men of dignity, not insincere, not prone to *drink* much wine, not greedy for money,
1 Tim. 3:9 *but* holding to the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience.
1 Tim. 3:10 These men must also first be tested; then have them serve as deacons if they are beyond reproach.
1 Tim. 3:11 Women *must* likewise *be* dignified, not malicious gossips, but temperate, faithful in all things.
1 Tim. 3:12 Deacons must be husbands of one wife, *and* good managers of *their* children and their own households.
1 Tim. 3:13 For those who have served well as deacons obtain for themselves a high standing and great confidence in the faith that is in Christ Jesus.

- So, there you have it. The qualifications for becoming a deacon. But did you notice what's not a qualification for becoming a deacon? Giving 10%. As a matter of fact, giving isn't mentioned at all. But should a deacon give? Of course he should but based on the requirement for every believer to give.
  - Every believer should give as they have been blessed or prospered. That's what Paul tells us in 1 Corinthians. Which means if you are a deacon, the requirement to give is assumed. But not because he's a deacon, but because that's the requirement of every believer. Having said that, that is between the individual and his Maker. Not the preacher or any other Christian. Anyway, you get my point.
  - Paul said, "I didn't burden you. I didn't ask you for money for myself or for any of the other Apostles." But that begs the question. How did Paul and the other Apostles survive if the churches didn't give them money. How did they make it? They had a job.
  - Paul was a tent maker. He worked outside the church. And just an FYI to you, that's where ministry takes place. It happens on the highways and byways of life. So, Paul had a job, but does that mean Pastors shouldn't be paid? No, it doesn't. The church is actually told to support the ministers, but Paul chose not to take any money.
    - And let me say this, if the Pastor receives support from the church, it shouldn't be ridiculously low, but it also shouldn't be extremely high either. It should be based on what the church can afford, a wage that can help take care of his basic needs along with the needs of his family.
    - In other words, the preacher shouldn't get rich on his salary. Meaning, if he can afford a mansion or a jet on his salary, I would say he is paid too much, wouldn't you? But how much is too much? I don't know, that would be a matter of prayer for the fellowship and a matter of conviction for the Pastor.
  - My point is, giving is a requirement by God for every believer. But it's not a mandated 10%. It's to give as you've been blessed.
- Let's move on. I'll digress on this topic. In verse 19, Paul writes something, something

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that I find somewhat interesting, when he says:

2 Cor. 12:19 **All this time you have been thinking that we are defending ourselves to you. *Actually,* it is in the sight of God that we have been speaking in Christ; and all for building you up, beloved.**

- Over these past several weeks, we have studied and talked about how Paul has been defending himself to this church, trying to regain their confidence and their trust. But, here in verse 19, Paul says:

2 Cor. 12:19 **All this time you have been thinking that we are defending ourselves to you. *Actually,* it is in the sight of God that we have been speaking in Christ; and all for building you up, beloved.**

- Now, in the spirit of time, I am going to paraphrase his statement for you really quick. What he is saying is, from the church's standpoint it would appear that Paul and the other apostles have been defending themselves. And that is true. But there is actually more to it than that.
    - Listen to the second part of the verse one more time, where Paul says, *Actually,* it is in the sight of God that we have been speaking in Christ; and all for building you up, beloved.
    - What he is saying is, yes, on the surface and in your eyes, we have been defending ourselves, but in reality, through my writing I have been teaching you something. I have been building you up, edifying you.
        - In other words, through my writing you have received two lessons, the one you read about and the one you don't. The one you read about is the surface message, but the one you didn't read about is the message behind the message, and that message, that secondary message, is what builds you up.
        - Hang with me for just a minute folks. Think about what Paul is saying. The life-changing power of God's Word many times comes by way of the message behind the message, and we don't have time to study all the secondary messages we have unraveled throughout Paul's writings here today.
    - But proof of this lies in what Paul himself just said in verse 19, when he said that all this time the church thought Paul was defending himself, but he was actually building them up. What you can infer from Paul's statement is that:
        - A – Yes, Paul wrote 2 Corinthians as a way of defending himself and the other apostles back against these false teachers who had slipped into this church (that was the surface message). But behind the scenes:
        - B – While defending himself, His words, His Words of Truth were building them up. In other words, the surface message accomplished one thing but the message behind the message accomplished something else. And what did it accomplish? Paul said it "built up the saints".
- Now, the logic and reasoning behind his statement is an interesting one, and we could

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study Paul's reasoning for weeks. But (once again), we don't have time. Having said that, what you can know is this. The process of building you up spiritually, based on what the Bible teaches, many times comes by way of the hidden revelations of God, which is brought about through the process of rightly dividing His Manuscript through study.

- So, this is just one example of the surface message and then the power of the message behind the message. Over this past several weeks on Wednesday night, I have been teaching you How to Study Your Bible as if you were preparing to teach it. And ultimately, what that does is it causes you to dig. It causes you to think critically.
  - And this is so important because when you do that, when you pull out those hidden messages and revelations of God, that's where the power inside God's Word lies. And let me say this, this process takes practice to learn how to do it. You must study, and as you study you must do it intentionally, starting out with prayer. Asking God to reveal Himself to you.
  - And then, slowly and methodically work your way through each verse of scripture. Notice I didn't say work through the pages of scripture, and there is a reason for that. Because if you do it correctly, for the most part you won't be able to move that fast. It's one verse at a time, and sometimes, it's just one word at a time.
  - And so, speaking of moving fast, let's finish up by focusing on Verses 20 & 21:

2 Cor. 12:20 **For I am afraid that perhaps when I come I may find you to be not what I wish, and may be found by you to be not what you wish; that perhaps *there will be* strife, jealousy, angry tempers, selfishness, slanders, gossip, arrogance, disturbances;**
2 Cor. 12:21 ***I am afraid* that when I come again my God may humiliate me before you, and I may mourn over many of those who have sinned in the past and not repented of the impurity, sexual immorality, and indecent behavior which they have practiced.**

- Paul says he is afraid that when he comes to visit them, he is going to find them in a place that neither he nor they will be proud of. And then he says, not only is he afraid of what he will find, that there will be strife, jealousy, angry tempers, selfishness, slanders, gossip, arrogance, and disturbances among them.
  - He says I am afraid when I come again my God may humiliate me before you. That's a strange statement, isn't it? It is, but not really. He is simply saying that he and they will be embarrassed as it relates to where they are as a body of believers. So much so that he may mourn over many of those who have sinned in the past.
  - But the sin is not really the issue. That's not the point. The issue is not that they sinned. The issue is they have not repented of their impurity, their sexual immorality, and indecent behavior, which they have practiced.
- Now, let's do a little exercise as it relates to Paul's writings, shall we? What would you say is the 'surface message' of these verses? It would be exactly what he is writing about. This church is in a really bad spot, so much so that Paul fears what he will find when he comes.

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- What would you hope would be the application for this church? That they would straighten up before he arrives? Correct? But, what's the message behind the message? What's the revelation inside this message, or what's the life-changing message behind the message? Another way to say it is, what's the disturbing message behind the message?
- Well, in order to extract that, you start by digging. By asking questions. And what might be a great thing to ask yourself as it relates to this church's situation? How about this – are these people even saved? Are these folks true believers, because their behavior is disturbing, and it doesn't sound like the behavior becoming of Christian men and women, does it? I wouldn't think so.
  - So, with that question in mind, I wanted to know. So, the first thing I did was study the background and history of this church, as it was at this point in time. Unfortunately, what I discovered was that these were indeed true believers. And I am not going to lie to you, I was hoping that wasn't the case, because it would be a whole lot easier to accept if they weren't believers. But they were.
  - And so, now, what do we do with that? Well, let's look at the message behind the message, which is what? Just because you are a believer, you are not immune to sin. Even sin of the highest level. And what do I mean by sin of the highest level? Right, because we would say, well, I thought all sin is the same.
- It is in the eyes of a Holy and Righteous God. It's not that one sin is worse than another, but the degree of sin in your life speaks volumes as to how far away from God you are. Remember, what is going on with these people isn't just going on in private. It has made its way into this fellowship.
- There are some pretty bad things happening inside the walls of this church, and the church has turned a blind eye to it, and the party responsible is so comfortable with it they don't even feel the need to repent over what they have done.

- So, as we close this morning, one more time, what is the message behind the message? Well, first of all know this. What is happening inside this church could happen to you. It could happen to us. That is the reality. As a matter of fact, it happens all the time in churches, and not just with church members but with church leaders as well.
  - But why? There must be a reason, and there is. It begins when we forget to keep the main thing the main thing. When we fail to spend time with God in prayer and study. When we forsake the assembling of the believers (when we don't attend church).
  - And so, if that's the case, then what shall we do to prevent such a thing? We better be vigilant and we better take it seriously. We better work on our relationship with God daily. That is the only chance we have, because according to 1 Peter 5, our enemy walks around like a roaring lion seeking whom he may devour.
  - Which means the enemy is just waiting for an opening in your life. So, we must be vigilant church, but more than that, we must follow the instructions set forth by scripture. Instructions that will ensure we can fend off the enemy. And what would that be?
- We must fill our lives with more of God and less of this world. We must spend time with God in prayer and then study His Word correctly (which is in context) by rightly dividing the truth. And just so I don't leave you with zero practical application as it relates to this issue this morning, let me read to you from Colossians 3, where Paul gives us some clear

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instruction on how to prepare ourselves. How to ward off the enemy. Listen to what he says in Colossians 3:1-17:

Col. 3:1 **Therefore if you have been raised up with Christ, keep seeking the things above (verb – action on your part), where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God.**
Col. 3:2 **Set your mind (verb – once again – action on your part) on the things above, not on the things that are on earth.**
Col. 3:3 **For you have died and your life is hidden with Christ in God.**
Col. 3:4 **When Christ, who is our life, is revealed, then you also will be revealed with Him in glory.**
Col. 3:5 **Therefore consider the members of your earthly body as dead to immorality, impurity, passion, evil desire, and greed, which amounts to idolatry.**
Col. 3:6 **For it is because of these things that the wrath of God will come upon the sons of disobedience,**
Col. 3:7 **and in them you also once walked, when you were living in them.**
Col. 3:8 **But now you also, put them all aside: (verb-action on your part) anger, wrath, malice, slander, *and* abusive speech from your mouth.**
Col. 3:9 **Do not lie to one another, since you laid aside the old self with its *evil* practices,**
Col. 3:10 **and have put on the new self who is being renewed to a true knowledge according to the image of the One who created him—**
Col. 3:11 ***a renewal* in which there is no *distinction between* Greek and Jew, circumcised and uncircumcised, barbarian, Scythian, slave and freeman, but Christ is all, and in all.**
Col. 3:12 **So, as those who have been chosen of God, holy and beloved, put on a heart of compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness and patience; (Verb – action on your part)**
Col. 3:13 **bearing with one another, and forgiving each other, whoever has a complaint against anyone; just as the Lord forgave you, so also should you.**
Col. 3:14 **Beyond all these things *put on* love, which is the perfect bond of unity.**
Col. 3:15 **Let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, to which indeed you were called in one body; and be thankful.**

- And then, here's the key folks. This is where all of this is made possible. Verse 16:

Col. 3:16 **Let the word of Christ richly dwell within you, with all wisdom teaching and admonishing (urging) one another with psalms *and* hymns *and* spiritual songs, singing with thankfulness in your hearts to God.**
Col. 3:17 **Whatever you do in word or deed, *do* all in the name of the Lord Jesus,**

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giving thanks through Him to God the Father.

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- Welcome back everyone. Today we venture into the last Chapter of 2 Corinthians – Chapter 13 (hard to believe, isn't it? But it's true).
  - We ended our teaching last week with Verses 20-21 of Chapter 12, where Paul ended with these words. Let me read it to you.

2 Cor. 12:20 **For I am afraid that perhaps when I come I may find you to be not what I wish, and may be found by you to be not what you wish; that perhaps *there will be* strife, jealousy, angry tempers, selfishness, slanders, gossip, arrogance, disturbances;**
2 Cor. 12:21 ***I am afraid* that when I come again my God may humiliate me before you, and I may mourn over many of those who have sinned in the past and not repented of the impurity, sexual immorality, and indecent behavior which they have practiced.**

- As I noted last week, Paul's words were somewhat concerning. Concerning the fact this was a church he founded and led (Pastored) for roughly two years. It's also disturbing because as I said last week, this church was made up of believers (for the most part).
  - And so, for him to have to address such things was not only disheartening for him to write, but honestly, it is somewhat disheartening for us to contemplate. I mean, how in the world could this happen? I understand how someone can sin. I have no issue with that. It happens to us all.
  - But, for some of them to have done such things and remain in an unrepentant state, it's strange. But it happens all the time, and an FYI to all of us sitting here today. The way it happened then is the same way it happens to believers now. Over time we slowly get off track. Ever so slowly. Little bit by little bit, believers allow the world to creep in.
    - And over time, slowly, the shiny things of this world begin to replace the things of God in our life. And we know better, but it just happens. It doesn't happen on purpose. It's not as if we make a conscious decision to ease away from God, and in His place move closer to things of this world.
  - It just happens and it always starts the same way. With a choice or decision where we take one small and sometimes tiny step toward the world. It's subtle. It might start with a change in our job that leads to a change in friends or environment. It could be a change in our interest (our hobbies), our curiosity.
    - Whatever it is, the enemy is always looking for a way, trying to appeal to our likes and dislikes (our flesh). Trying to lead us astray. And make no mistake about it, our enemy is patient. He is in it for the long haul. And so, no matter our current lifestyle or set of friends, he will continue to place the things of this world in our path.
- As I studied this section of scripture, I began thinking about the things that draw us away from God. And for years, preachers have correlated this process to things like drinking or the things we watch or listen to, and indeed, these are things that can draw us away from God, and even I, myself, have used these as examples throughout my ministry.
  - But the things that really cause us to veer off track are not necessarily the things we

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think about. They are not things that (on the surface) really seem to be problems at all, they are not things anyone really thinks about in the moment.

- They are subtle things, as I said, things like a job change, where you meet someone and then you develop a relationship with that person because you work with them every day, and before you know it, that relationship has taken you to a place you never intended to be.
  - I mean, think about it. If you told someone you were getting a better job, no one would ever say, be careful, you never know what might happen. No one would say, remember, our enemy walks around like a roaring lion, seeking whom he may devour.
  - And then of course there are our hobbies. Hobbies like golf and hunting. I have known many men who have fallen in love with these sports, only to find themselves (once again) in a place where they never intended to be. In a place where they have forsaken their families, their church, and their relationship with God.
  - And then there are children's sports. Nothing wrong with sports unless they rob your child of the opportunity to spend time in church. The enemy is always at work, looking for an opening, looking for ways to introduce us to new things. Things that cause us to lose our focus, influencing us in a way that garners our attention, leading us to a place where we take our eyes off the prize.

- It was true then, and it's still true today. Which means as far as humans are concerned, nothing is new. That's exactly what King Solomon testified to in Ecclesiastes 1:1-9, when he said this. Listen to what he said:

Eccl. 1:1 The words of the Preacher, the son of David, king in Jerusalem.
Eccl. 1:2 "Vanity of vanities," says the Preacher,
"Vanity of vanities! All is vanity."
Eccl. 1:3 What advantage does man have in all his work
Which he does under the sun?
Eccl. 1:4 A generation goes and a generation comes,
But the earth remains forever.
Eccl. 1:5 Also, the sun rises and the sun sets;
And hastening to its place it rises there *again.*
Eccl. 1:6 Blowing toward the south,
Then turning toward the north,
The wind continues swirling along;
And on its circular courses the wind returns.
Eccl. 1:7 All the rivers flow into the sea,
Yet the sea is not full.
To the place where the rivers flow,
There they flow again.
Eccl. 1:8 All things are *wearisome*;
Man is not able to tell *it.*

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The eye is not satisfied with seeing,
Nor is the ear filled with hearing.
Eccl. 1:9 **That which has been is that which will be,**
And that which has been done is that which will be done.
So there is nothing new under the sun.

- Remember, this was King Solomon saying this. He was the richest man to ever live, and his words were part of his summation of this world at the end of his life. He said there was nothing new under the sun. Nothing new as it relates to our problems.
  - I mean, for the most part, problems are problems, albeit maybe there is a variation in our issues, but problems are still problems, nonetheless. But, having said that, the good news is, just like there is nothing new with problems, the same holds true for solutions.
  - You see, God knew we would experience troubles and trials in life, and that we would drift from time to time. And so, as a counterbalance to those dips and downturns in our lives, He gave us the ability to take hold of our situation and do something about our plight.
    - All we have to do is recognize where we are and follow God's instructions on how to begin solving our problems. You drink too much? God's Word gives us a solution. Your marriage in shambles? God's Word gives us a solution. Your kids are out of control, you hate your job, financial problems, you're sick, and the list goes on and on. God's Word gives us a solution.
    - And so, with all that said, what might those solutions be? Well, Paul gives us some insight into the starting point for bettering your life's circumstances, and he does so in 2 Corinthians 12:21, where he says that he was afraid that when he came to them, he might find some who had previously sinned but had not yet what? REPENTED.
  - Repentance is the first step in cleaning up your situation. And why? Well, 1 John 1:9 tells us why. It says:

1 John 1:9 **If we confess our sins, He is faithful and righteous, so that He will forgive us our sins and cleanse us from all unrighteousness.**

- But then in Colossians 3:1-17, we are given further insight into the solution to our problems, which we read about last week. But I want to read it again because it's so applicable to the church at Corinth (their situation), and ours.

Col. 3:1 **Therefore if you have been raised up with Christ, keep seeking the things above (verb – action on your part), where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God.**
Col. 3:2 **Set your mind (verb – once again – action on your part) on the things above, not on the things that are on earth.**
Col. 3:3 **For you have died and your life is hidden with Christ in God.**

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Col. 3:4 When Christ, who is our life, is revealed, then you also will be revealed with Him in glory.
Col. 3:5 Therefore *consider* the members of your earthly body as dead to immorality, impurity, passion, evil desire, and greed, which amounts to idolatry.
Col. 3:6 For it is because of these things that the wrath of God will come upon the sons of disobedience,
Col. 3:7 and in them you also once walked, when you were living in them.
Col. 3:8 But now you also, put them all aside: (verb-action on your part) anger, wrath, malice, slander, *and* abusive speech from your mouth.
Col. 3:9 Do not lie to one another, since you laid aside the old self with its *evil* practices,
Col. 3:10 and have put on the new self who is being renewed to a true knowledge according to the image of the One who created him—
Col. 3:11 *a renewal* in which there is no *distinction between* Greek and Jew, circumcised and uncircumcised, barbarian, Scythian, slave and freeman, but Christ is all, and in all.
Col. 3:12 So, as those who have been chosen of God, holy and beloved, put on a heart of compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness and patience; (Verb – action on your part)
Col. 3:13 bearing with one another, and forgiving each other, whoever has a complaint against anyone; just as the Lord forgave you, so also should you.
Col. 3:14 Beyond all these things *put on* love, which is the perfect bond of unity.
Col. 3:15 Let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, to which indeed you were called in one body; and be thankful.

- And then, here is the key:

Col. 3:16 Let the word of Christ richly dwell within you, with all wisdom teaching and admonishing (urging) one another with psalms *and* hymns *and* spiritual songs, singing with thankfulness in your hearts to God.
Col. 3:17 Whatever you do in word or deed, *do* all in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks through Him to God the Father.

- Paul's words clearly tell us that we have a choice. Specifically, we have the ability to begin the process of turning our life around by grabbing hold of our situation (the church's situation) and doing something about it. Because, as we know, the Church in Corinth is in a very bad place.
    - They have allowed false teaching to permeate their fellowship. And worse than that, it appears they have begun buying into what they have been taught. And so, Paul's solution in Colossians is still the same solution for all of us sitting here today. Do you have problems?

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        - Keep seeking the things above. Set your mind on the things above, not on the things of the earth (the things of this life). And remember this, if you are saved, Paul says that you have died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God. Also, as a help, never forget our lives are on a countdown timer. Every day as we live and breathe on this earth, we are one day closer to death, to that day when we will be with Him in Glory.
- Moving on. Next, Paul went on in Verse 5 to give us the definition of what it meant to be dead to the things of this life. He said consider the members of your earthly body dead to immorality, impurity, passion, evil desire, greed, and *idol worship*.
    - By the way, I find my NASB's choice of words interesting when it says consider the members of your earthly body as dead. That's interesting to me because the Greek says, 'put to death'. I find that to be a bit more compelling than the word consider, don't you?
    - Consider seems light in comparison to put it to death. Consider seems polite, where put to death, well, not so much. But how do we do that? How do we put our earthly body to death? It's a mindset that is a biproduct of intentionally and deliberately focusing on God by way of His Word.
        - The cause and action here are that of replacing one thing with another. Meaning, if you are doing something that you know is not of God, or that God would not approve of, stop doing it and replace it with the things of God. That's in essence the process of causing your body to die to sin.
        - And so, with that introduction of sorts squarely at the top of our mind, let's enter the final Chapter of 2 Corinthians and see what Paul says next. My NASB Bible entitles this section: Examine Yourselves (Pretty Fitting Title Don't You Think?)

2 Cor. 13:1 This is the third time I am coming to you. EVERY FACT IS TO BE CONFIRMED BY THE TESTIMONY OF TWO OR THREE WITNESSES.
2 Cor. 13:2 I have previously said when present the second time, and though now absent I say in advance to those who have sinned in the past and to all the rest *as well,* that if I come again I will not spare *anyone,*
2 Cor. 13:3 since you are seeking for proof of the Christ who speaks in me, and who is not weak toward you, but mighty in you.
2 Cor. 13:4 For indeed He was crucified because of weakness, yet He lives because of the power of God. For we also are weak in Him, yet we will live with Him because of the power of God *directed* toward you.

- In verse 1, Paul says this is the third time I am coming to you, And Every FACT IS TO BE CONFIRMED BY THE TESIMONY OF TWO OR THREE WITNESSES. This will be the second time Paul warned his readers that he planned on visiting them for a 'third time' (cf. 12:14).
    - Dr. Thomas Constable said, "There are at least four possibilities about what Paul meant by the "two or three witnesses" that would confirm his credibility and his critics' guilt:

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- First, he may simply have been saying that the church would pass judgment, and, on the testimony of witnesses, they would decide who was right (Matt. 18:15-20; 1 Cor. 5:3-5).
  - Second, Paul may have viewed his three visits to Corinth as three witnesses to his innocence.
  - Third, he may have been referring to his warnings that he would not spare the Corinthians. These may be the one in 1 Corinthians 4:21, possibly a warning given during the painful visit, and the one in verse 2b.
  - Fourth, Paul may have meant the witness of his fellow workers when he returned to Corinth. He may have meant Titus for example, the brethren who accompanied him (cf. 8:23), and/or Paul's fellow travelers".
- I tend to agree with Dr. Constable. He said he favors the first possibility because it views the witnesses as people, which is the normal meaning of witnesses in the passage quoted (Deut. 19:15).
- He also said the fourth view seemed weak to him, because Paul's friends would have appeared biased to his critics. Regardless of what view you might hold to; he mentions witnesses as just another way of confirming what he is saying. It's another way for him to defend his position and authority.

- Next in verse 2, some might say Paul warns the church. Others might say he threatens the church when he says:

2 Cor. 13:2 **I have previously said when present the second time, and though now absent I say in advance to those who have sinned in the past and to all the rest *as well,* that if I come again I will not spare *anyone,***

- You see, Paul had previously warned the Corinthian Church during his second visit, also known as the "painful visit", and now he was issuing a second warning in anticipation of his return to Corinth.
  - When he says he "would not spare anyone", he meant he would personally discipline anyone in the fellowship who required correction. But that left me asking the question, what kind of discipline was he talking about? I mean, was he going to give them a spanking?
  - Well, to answer that question we must ask ourselves what type of discipline was available to him as an Apostle? There are a few theories out there, ranging from public rebuke and correction, which would include putting them out of the fellowship.
    - The severest possibility or theory was something akin to what God did when He acted decisively when holding people accountable in the early church, as He did with Ananias and Sapphira, where God took their life.
    - Similar to that story was in Acts, where "Elymas" (Eee-la-mas) the magician, where Paul said he was going to be blind, and sure enough he was. And then of course we have Paul's instruction in 1 Corinthians 5:4-5, where he tells the church to turn a man over to the devil due to his immoral acts. Regardless of what it is, they knew what he meant, and it was not going to be good.

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- Moving on. Next, in Verses 3&4, he says (one more time):

2 Cor. 13:3 **since you are seeking for proof of the Christ who speaks in me, and who is not weak toward you, but mighty in you.**
2 Cor. 13:4 **For indeed He was crucified because of weakness, yet He lives because of the power of God. For we also are weak in Him, yet we will live with Him because of the power of God *directed* toward you.**

- Paul echoes the same theme that he's continued to mention all throughout 2 Corinthians, specifically 2 Corinthians 12:10, where he said:

2 Cor. 12:10 **Therefore I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in distresses, in persecutions, in difficulties, on behalf of Christ; for when I am weak, then I am strong.**

- Weakness continues to be the theme, which is so polar opposite of how we think.
  - And wonder why? Why did God choose weakness as the means to access His power? It's because weakness is the opposite of pride, and as I have said, pride is the 'kryptonite' to the Christian. It's really that simple, and God demonstrates this very thing with Jesus' crucifixion, which was the ultimate display of weakness, at least in the eyes of those who were standing there that day.
  - Just imagine what they must have been thinking, how they could not believe that the Messiah would allow Himself to be treated this way. It made no sense whatsoever, and honestly, when we think about it, I understand why they would have thought that.
    - It would be like watching a movie, say a Clint Eastwood movie, where Clint dies in the end and his enemies win. And then the movie is over. If that happened, we would be so mad. But that's the sense here. God sent His Only Begotten Son to die for all of us. And not just any old death.
    - No, he died the most horrific death at the hands of His enemies. And in that moment, for those people standing there that day, the story ended there. Can you imagine what it must have been like for the disciples? For all those who believed that Jesus was the Messiah?
  - From a purely human perspective, there simply couldn't have been a greater show of weakness for the world to see. Can you imagine what Jesus' followers must have felt in that moment? You can almost hear them say, "Oh well, any moment now God is going to strike all these people dead".
    - But it didn't happen, and with each passing moment, with each dying breath, everyone's hope slowly faded away. They had to think to themselves, were we wrong? Was Jesus really who He said He was? Maybe He was and maybe He wasn't. No doubt these were the thoughts that plagued the disciples along with each and every one of His followers.
    - But in His weakness, God's Power was on full display. And why? Because real

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strength is displayed as anger under control. This is the Gospel of Jesus Christ folks, and I want to stop here today. I would be remised if I didn't speak into this a little bit more this morning, and honestly, this is where I would like to close this morning.

- Belief in Jesus' death is the key unto salvation, and if you are sitting here today and you have never made that profession of faith in Him, if you've never confessed that and if you feel God tugging at your heart, if you feel Him calling you to do so, then I want you to know that Salvation is free and available to you this morning.
    - I want you to know that salvation is available to anyone who believes in the story of Jesus. That is the essence of Salvation. That is the Gospel of Jesus Christ. That whosoever believes in Him should not perish but have eternal life.
    - But belief in what? In His work, in His crucifixion, in His death, His burial, and Resurrection. All those who believe will be saved. And why? Because believing in that story makes zero sense on a human level, and the only way you can believe in Jesus is when God gives you the ability to believe through the gift of faith.
    - I know most people sitting here today have probably made that profession of faith, but maybe there is someone sitting here who has not. If that's you, then I want you to do that this morning if you feel so compelled. And how do you do that?
        - Well, you pray. You tell God that you know you are a sinner, and you believe that He sent His Son, His only begotten Son, to die for you, for your sins, and then you follow that up with a public profession of faith through Baptism. That is the process of salvation, and here's how I would like for you to do this.
        - In a moment I am going to pray for you and with you, and if you pray this prayer with me, then I would like for you to take a Grow Card out of the pew in front of you and put your name on it, and simply write on the back, "I prayed that prayer this morning". From there, I will call you this week and set that up.
    - It's not hard and we are not going to make it hard. Also, I would like to offer up another invitation for anyone who may be saved but feels far away from God. If that's you then you pray as well. Repent and ask God to forgive you and He will do so.
    - And then, if you would like to write on the Grow Card, "I would like to be Baptized as a sign of renewing my faith and commitment to God", we will have a day of baptism. Who knows, maybe Easter.
        - If no one feels led to do that, that's okay. God is Sovereign and is in control of all things, so bow with me in a word of prayer.

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- Today we officially finish our journey through the book of 2 Corinthains, and it has been a long ride – to say the least.
  - How long?
  - Well – I am glad you asked – we started our journey on – drum roll please.
    - We started it on January 7th – 2023,
    - So roughly – 64 weeks ago – take out Easter, Mother's Day, Father's Day – Christmas, a snow day or two and we have completed roughly 52-54 teachings.
  - Just in case you're sad – because you missed some of the teachings – you're in luck – because you can log onto our website – and listen to the ones you missed – or re-listen to all of them if you feel as you might have missed something.
    - So, here we are – and today is the day.
- After today's teaching – we are going to partake in the Lord's supper, which – I feel is fitting at the end of a letter or book – don't you?
- Now – before we begin this morning, I want to conclude this letter – by reminding everyone why Paul wrote this letter in the first place.
  - Remember – he was the founder of this fellowship.
  - He was the leader & pastor of this group for roughly 2 years.
  - His primary purpose in writing this letter was the same purpose – or reason – he wrote most of his epistles.
    - "Except Romans"
  - He wrote them this letter – because he had received some news.
  - The church had lost its way.
  - And it wasn't just a little bad news.
  - And it wasn't ambiguous news.
- In other words, the letter he received didn't simply say:
  - Dear Paul, remember the church you started in Corinth?
    - Well – it's gotten off track.
    - You might want to reach out to them and see if you can help straighten them out.
  - That's not the way it was – it was specific to their issues, and they were very serious.
  - Paul was told that this fellowship, or better yet, he was told the "leadership" in this fellowship.
    - That they had allowed a man (at least it began with a man) - but now it consisted of men, who slipped in – an begin teaching heresy.
    - False teaching – false teaching in the form of "Asian Mysticism" and even more than that, these men were teaching a different Gospel than that of the one Paul taught – which was the Gospel of Jesus Christ.
    - These men were working hard to place doubt in the mind of these people,

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specially, about Paul – his Apostleship – and of course - his authority as an Apostle.

- Paul was also told – there was some other serious issues taking place inside this church.
  - Things such as sexual immorality – which is hard to believe.
  - But it was true, and the sad thing is no one was doing anything about it.
  - Which – (as I have stated repeatedly) – was very disturbing and disheartening to hear about, especially given the fact – that this fellowship was made up of "primarily" Christian men and women.
- We could stomach it a little bit easier if that wasn't the case.
  - If this were simply a church of lost people, then maybe it wouldn't be so disturbing – but unfortunately it was the case.
- And so, Paul wrote the letter of 2 Corinthians.
  - This wasn't the only letter he wrote to this Church.
  - Scholars believe he wrote 4 letters and some even believe he wrote 5.
  - But 4 letters for sure, but the 1st letter and 4th letter are missing.
    - Leaving us with 1st Corinthians and 2nd Corinthians as the only letters we have recorded in the Cannon of Scripture.
    - Which would mean, 1 Corinthians is 2nd Corinthians, and 2 Corinthians is 4th Corinthians.
- Anyways, my point is - this church had issues – and continued to have issues – which is why Paul wrote to them so many times.
  - Let me also say, in the beginning of our teaching of this letter, which began over a year ago, I told you that this epistle – was difficult to teach.
    - Reason being, it appears to be pieced together – maybe, from other writings.
    - Which prevented it from flowing well.
    - Causing it to be called an "amalgam"(uh-mal-gam)
    - Which simply means – *a mixture of different elements*.
  - All because it appears to be somewhat broken up – which, as I said – makes it harder to teach.
  - Primarily because – it doesn't flow well.
    - Anyways, that's a little background on this church.
- So, with that behind us, let's press on into today's teaching, and finish up 2 Corinthians.
  - Last week, we finished with verse 4 of 2 Corinthians 13 and I just want to back up a re-read verse 1-4 again, for context.
    - Here's what Paul wrote. My NASB Bible – entitles this section – (as I stated last week): Examine Yourselves

2 Cor. 13:1 This is the third time I am coming to you. EVERY FACT IS TO BE

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CONFIRMED BY THE TESTIMONY OF TWO OR THREE WITNESSES.
2 Cor. 13:2 **I have previously said when present the second time, and though now absent I say in advance to those who have sinned in the past and to all the rest *as well,* that if I come again I will not spare *anyone,***
2 Cor. 13:3 **since you are seeking for proof of the Christ who speaks in me, and who is not weak toward you, but mighty in you.**
2 Cor. 13:4 **For indeed He was crucified because of weakness, yet He lives because of the power of God. For we also are weak in Him, yet we will live with Him because of the power of God *directed* toward you.**

- So, even now - at the end of this letter, Paul is still making comments – which refers us back to the main purpose of him writing this letter in the first place.
  - Here in verses 1-4 – he still in the mode of defending his position and authority as an Apostle.
  - The 2 main themes that come out of these verses are:
    - 1 – A warning – which really shows up as a threat.
    - 2 – The topic of weakness.
  - The reason I say this warning – showed up as a threat is because of what he said in verse 2:

2 Cor. 13:2 **I have previously said when present the second time, and though now absent I say in advance to those who have sinned in the past and to all the rest *as well,* that if I come again I will not spare *anyone,***

- If we study his final words he says – I will not spare anyone.
  - And so - I don't know about you – but that sounds somewhat threatening.
  - And sure enough, as I said – when you do a little study on his statement, you could make a case for this very thing.
    - Remember, Paul is an Apostle – and he has Apostolic Powers
    - We don't know the total extent of those powers, but we do know they contain – raising people from the dead, casting out demons, and healing the sick etc.
    - They are supernatural powers.
  - What we also know is his powers seem to extend even further, from the positive to – what I would call - the negative side of life.
  - But interesting enough - no one ever talks about that.
- So – as I stated last week – this Fellowship required discipline.
  - But that left me asking the question.
    - What kind of discipline was he talking about?

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        - I mean, was he going to give them a spanking?
- Well, to answer that question (as previously stated) – we must ask ourselves – what type of discipline was available to him as an Apostle?
    - There are a few theories out there, ranging from – public rebuke and correction – which would include putting them out of the fellowship.
    - But the severest possibility or theory was something akin to what God did when He acted decisively and swiftly - in holding people accountable in the early church.
        - An example of that being – what He did with Ananias and Sapphira – when He took their life for lying.
        - Like that story – was the story in Acts – with "Elymas" "Eee-la-mas" the magician – where Paul said, he was going to be blind, and sure enough he was!
        - Then of course – we have Paul's instruction in 1 Cor. 5:4-5, where he tells the church to turn a man over to the devil – due to his immoral acts,
- Regardless of what it is, this church knew what He meant – and it was not going to be good.
    - Then we have the second theme of these verses.
        - Which was weakness.
        - Paul made it crystal clear – that weakness was the key to accessing the "Power of God",
    - Another way to say that is:
        - Humility
        - Brokenness
        - Patience
        - Kindness
        - Love
    - These are the traits required to access Gods Power.
- Which – BTW – and just on a side note, I find this fascinating, because – that is not what the church has been saying for the last 20, 30, 40 or 50 years.
    - We have been told - we can access His power – through some transcendental state – which is generally facilitated through praise and worship.
    - Or through some super spiritual phenomena, which comes by way of an amped up service, facilitated through emotion.
    - This statement will not make me very popular with some, but it's true.
- The church – has tried every avenue for accessing the "Power of God", except for the one prescribed in scripture.
    - And why?
        - Because the one prescribed in scripture isn't very appealing to us as humans.
        - And it isn't easy, or quick or instantaneous.

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        - Instead, it's a grind!
    - Just as we learned from Paul just a few weeks ago, where Paul said this in 2 Cor. 12:7-10 (A Thorn in the Flesh):

2 Cor. 12:7 Because of the extraordinary *greatness* of the revelations, for this reason, to keep me from exalting myself, there was given to me a thorn in the flesh, a messenger of Satan to torment me—to keep me from exalting myself!
2 Cor. 12:8 Concerning this I pleaded with the Lord three times that it might leave me.
2 Cor. 12:9 And He has said to me, "My grace is sufficient for you, for power is perfected in weakness." Most gladly, therefore, I will rather boast about my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may dwell in me.
2 Cor. 12:10 Therefore I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in distresses, in persecutions, in difficulties, in behalf of Christ; for when I am weak, then I am strong.

- God's power will be perfected in our lives when we become weak and humble.
    - There is no greater example - that could have been given to us then by – what Jesus endured on the Cross of Calvary.
    - Jesus – the Messiah of the world, the Son of God, lowered Himself to earth – allowed Himself to be beaten, scourged – crucified and eventually killed, and the whole time, by His own admission – He could have made one request to His Father in Heaven, and everyone standing there that day would have been wiped out an destroyed.
- But that's not what He did.
    - Instead, He endured – the most horrific punishment.
    - All so that – you and I could have an opportunity to be saved.
    - And this was the only way for us to be with God – was through the shedding of innocent blood – only then could we receive a covering for our sin – which then (as I said), could we access Heaven's gates.
- And last week – I asked you to think about that.
    - To think about how Jesus modeled for us - the ultimate display of weakness.
    - And how we through weakness could have access to the "Power of God".
- And today – at the end of the service, as we take the Lord's supper, I am going to ask you to remember and consider – this very thing once more.
    - To meditate on this very fact – as you partake of the elements.
    - And through that meditation – we should examine ourselves.
        - Thinking about who we are,
        - Where we are in our spiritual walk.

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        - And we should never ever take that lightly.
- Instead, we must be honest with ourselves.
    - Not honest with others.
    - Or others being honest with us, but honest with ourselves.
- Asking ourselves the question, where are we in our walk with Christ?
    - First off – are we saved?
    - And the second, Is God proud of what He sees in us?
    - Are we humble?
    - Are we broken?
    - Are we self-centered and selfish, self-serving, looking out for number 1?
    - Are we giving Him our best?
    - Are we simply fitting Him into our schedule – when convenient?
- To be honest with you, I don't think – God could have orchestrated todays service any better.
    - With us finishing 2 Corinthians and then parlaying into communion.
- And so – with all that said, let's finish the letter to the Corinthian Church.

2 Cor. 13:5 Test yourselves *to see* if you are in the faith; examine yourselves! Or do you not recognize this about yourselves, that Jesus Christ is in you—unless indeed you fail the test?
2 Cor. 13:6 But I trust that you will realize that we ourselves do not fail the test.
2 Cor. 13:7 Now we pray to God that you do no wrong; not that we ourselves may appear approved, but that you may do what is right, even though we may appear unapproved.
2 Cor. 13:8 For we can do nothing against the truth, but *only* for the truth.
2 Cor. 13:9 For we rejoice when we ourselves are weak, but you are strong; this we also pray for, that you be made complete.
2 Cor. 13:10 For this reason I am writing these things while absent, so that when present I *need* not use severity, in accordance with the authority which the Lord gave me for building up and not for tearing down.
2 Cor. 13:11 Finally, brethren, rejoice, be made complete, be comforted, be like-minded, live in peace; and the God of love and peace will be with you.
2 Cor. 13:12 Greet one another with a holy kiss.
2 Cor. 13:13 All the saints greet you.
2 Cor. 13:14 The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, and the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit, be with you all.

- Paul begins this section with the statement, "Test yourselves to see if you are in the

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faith",

- Then he says, "Examine yourselves or do you not recognize this about yourselves, that Jesus Christ is in you – unless indeed you fail the test?"
- I want to try something a little bit different today, with Paul's words this morning.
  - Let's personalize it a little bit.
- Let me read it again.
  - Greg, (speaking of me) test yourself to see if you are in the faith,
  - Greg, examine yourself, or do you not recognize this about yourself, that Jesus Christ is in you – unless indeed you fail the test?

- I want to encourage you to do the same. Insert your own name here.
  - If you do, I guarantee you – Paul's words – will have a much different meaning when you personalize it.
  - Test and examine yourself – Terry – Scott – Dave – Mark.
    - Big difference, isn't it?
    - But the question is - how do we do this?
- How do we test an examine ourselves, and what test is he speaking of?
  - Well, whatever it is, Paul says - he and the others have done this, and their findings have affirmed their faith.
  - And so, if that's the case, then I want to know – what test, and or examination Paul is talking about!
- Where do I access such a test?
  - Well, it's in the back of your Bible, did you know that?
  - Not really, but I had you thinking for just a second – didn't I?
- Anyways, what test is Paul speaking about?
  - Well, unfortunately – there is no such test.
    - The key to Paul's words – lie is the second half of his statement – when he says, examine yourself.
    - We must couple and tie these two words together to get our answer.
    - This test - comes by way of a thorough examination of our life.
    - Which can only be administered – when we know what we are examining our lives for.
    - Another way to say it is to ask ourselves, what does God expect out of our lives?
- Let me give you a more real-life example of what I mean.
  - If I am sick – and I don't know what's wrong, what will be the first thing the doctors will do?
  - They will do blood work,
  - From there – they will administer different types of tests.

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- Depending on the test results – coupled with where my pain is coming from, they will know – what other types of tests to run.
- From there – they will process through the possibilities based on their medical training, experience - by way of logic, and thought.
- Then after running a series of test, they begin to narrow down what might be causing the issues.
- But there first must be a basis – for the testing and examination process – a starting point.

- The same holds true with us when testing ourselves and examining ourselves as it pertains to our faith – and our salvation.
  - We must begin with a basis, and to get that basis I want jump into the Book of Matthew where Jesus – gives us a base line for this spiritual test and examination.
  - Follow with me if you will. Matt. 12:46-50.
    - In this section of scripture Jesus is addressing the crowds, when someone says something to Him:

Matt. 12:46 While He was still speaking to the crowds, behold, His mother and brothers were standing outside, seeking to speak to Him.
Matt. 12:47 Someone said to Him, "Behold, Your mother and Your brothers are standing outside seeking to speak to You."
Matt. 12:48 But Jesus answered the one who was telling Him and said, "Who is My mother and who are My brothers?"
Matt. 12:49 And stretching out His hand toward His disciples, He said, "Behold My mother and My brothers!
Matt. 12:50 "For whoever does the will of My Father who is in heaven, he is My brother and sister and mother."

- Jesus tells us that whoever does the will of My father who is heaven, these are my brothers and sisters and mothers.
  - As you sit here this morning, think about what He is saying.
  - Are you saved?
  - This will be evident by your behavior – tied back to Gods Will.
- And what is Gods Will for your life?
  - The answer to this question is complex, but not really.
  - It can be summed up by taking the sum of His word in totality –
  - Where God's Word repeats the same theme, matter a fact – it shouts the same theme.
  - Your life is not your own.
  - It's been purchased.

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- It's been ransomed.
- You have been grafted in.
- You work for the Master.
- You are not the ruler of your kingdom.
- You are not you own person.
- You belong to God.
- You are a slave – a bond servant.
- A possession of the God Most High.

- His will for your life is that you will bring Him honor and Glory!
  - That's it – there you have it and it will remain that way until the day you die!
  - So – the question is simple - how's that going for you?
    - If it were annual review time, what score would God give you?
    - Are you ready for that review?
    - Because it could be sooner than you think.
  - That is the sense of Paul's words and His words to this Church – they are the same words God places on all of us sitting here today,
  - Test yourself – Examine yourself and be honest with yourself.
  - You get the point – and so moving on,
    - And we will close with verses 11-14 this morning. Where Paul gives his final words, or his exhortation if you will.

2 Cor. 13:11 Finally, brethren, rejoice, be made complete, be comforted, be like-minded, live in peace; and the God of love and peace will be with you.
2 Cor. 13:12 Greet one another with a holy kiss.
2 Cor. 13:13 All the saints greet you.
2 Cor. 13:14 The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, and the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit, be with you all.

- Paul said, once you have tested yourselves / examined yourselves, rejoice with one another, be made complete, be complete, be like-minded, live-in peace and the God of love an (if you do that) peace will be with you.
  - And then – to top it all off, they should seal it by greeting one another with a Holy Kiss.
    - The Holy Kiss was a custom.
    - And it symbolized forgiveness.
    - Reconciliation – Unity and Fellowship.
  - And so there it is folks, 2 Corinthians – Paul's 2nd recorded letter to the church.

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- We started it over a year ago, and we are finished.
- And today we memorialize our journey with communion!

- I want to ask the men to come forward and hand out the elements this morning, and as they are handing them out, I would ask you to do exactly what Paul ask this church to do.
  - Test and examine your life,
  - Forget about this past week, yesterday – tomorrow or whatever is burdening you.
  - Clear your hearts, heads and minds and focus intently on your own life.
  - Be introspectively focused for the next few minutes.
  - Be honest with yourself and where you stand with God.
  - Use this moment as a reset – a new beginning.
  - For today is truly the first day of the rest of your life,
- Amen – Amen!

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